

In the name of God most Gracious, ever Merciful!

The Beloved and I

Volume 3: Ruth to Chronicles

Thomas McElwain

New Jubilees Version of Sacred Scripture in
Verse

With Verse Commentaries

Revised Edition

Adams & McElwain Publishers

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Preface

The New Jubilees Version is introduced more generally in the Preface to the first volume. The textual sources are given there in some detail. Aside from the printed volumes mentioned there, the Online Bible was used in preparing translation notes. As work was done from the beginning on the entire corpus, that list of sources is still valid. Nevertheless, since then the compare function on E-Sword by Rick Myers has been utilized during the process of translation. The later work also differs from the earlier in having practically no reference to the Ethiopic canon. The books of Maccabees here follow the LXX tradition.

The first volume is labelled Tawrat or Torah, and consists of the five books of Moses, Enoch, Jubilees, Joshua and Judges. These are the canonical books that have reference to Moses, either directly or by implication, but represent a tradition that does not acknowledge David, being set in an earlier time. The Torah presents the fundamentals of faith and a detailed exposition of divine law. Divine law is defined and implemented in the patriarchal system, the prophetic system, and the system of judges. At the same time the enigmatic figure of Ali is presented in three Mosaic passages and reflected in the first book of Samuel.

With the book of Ruth the reader is introduced to the figure of David. Thus the from this point on recognize the kingship of David and are presented in terms of divinely appointed kingship. These two factors distinguish the later Scriptures from those presented to this point. Thirdly, instead of focusing on the defining of divine law, there is a focus on divinely appointed royal authority in the line of David on one hand, and in grappling with issues of authority where the line of David does not apply on the other.

As the Tawrat introduces the figure of Ali, the Zabur introduces the figure of Hamda or Muhammad. The reference in Psalm 106:24 is most clearly to be seen as

a proper name, and that being the case, it is possible to interpret a number of other more ambiguous texts to refer to a proper name as well. It is thus possible to see the Tawrat as prophetic of the figure of Ali and the rest of the Hebrew Scriptures as prophetic of the figure of Muhammad. While not every individual has the faith to believe in prophecy as such, the cognate words of Ali and Muhammad in Hebrew are left untranslated where the literal meaning of the words is not clearly intended. The cognate character of the terms is a fact, no matter what one believes about their implications.

While the Torah and associated writings are largely legal in nature, the Davidic writings, if they may be broadly so called, converge on the issue of how to apply divine law in practice, under circumstances of worldly government. There are several levels of earthly government that form the parameters of these writings. The highest is the Davidic regime. This is followed by the good kings of Judah. The Northern Kingdom presents the case of a departure from Davidic rule, but one that is potentially acceptable. Bad kings are found in both regimes. The books deal with lower levels of authority: the situation of living as captives in a foreign land, under the Babylonians and Medo-Persians, and of living as vassals of the Hellenistic and later Roman rulers in and about Jerusalem. Taken altogether, the writings describe the entire gamut of circumstances under which the individual must weigh the issues and determine how to obey God and how to relate to the government. So the writings present situations, choices, values and strategies of abiding significance. The sonnet commentaries of the author illuminate the varied views of the world as faced by one making the Decalogue the rule of life and the reflector of contemplation of Reality.

Most of the attention this work has attracted in the first volume (The books of Moses) has been positive. Most readers understand it to be a work of literary art, and not specifically a work of scholarship

or apologetics for any particular religious tradition. It certainly takes stands on theological issues, but it often balances that by commenting from a diversity of human concerns. One person cannot encapsulate the entirety of human spirituality, but I attempt to go beyond my own experience to express with empathy the concerns of others as well. While this work is extremely personal, it is the hope of the author that others will benefit by it.

The bold and boisterous books of Moses now

Are set and done, creation's story, how
The serpent Watcher deceived holy pair,
And how their sons taught fratricide
beware;

The story of the ark and Flood warns all
To follow the divine appointed's call;
The family of Abraham well told
In narrative of faith and action bold

Come down to Moses who rose on the
mount

To hear the words that sprang up from the
fount

Of Your wisdom, Beloved. The golden
walls

Of inner temple follows on the stalls
Of sacrifices spent at hand of judges,
And priests and Levites where the minstrel
budes.

And now the minstrel budes. Books of
Moses

And Joshua who followed his as chose is,
And all the judges who kept to the path
That Moses showed the people beyond
wrath,

End with the word of blessedness, the peak
Of eloquence from which I turn to seek
The words of David, David, sire and sweet,
Who surpasses the lordly Moses' feet.
The books of revelation that appear

To shed light on my David and the dear
Words that he spoke in faith and song to
You

Are now the object of my loving view.
Beloved, I sing in David's tunes and rise
Up from the ashes to take hold the prize.

Beloved, as Moses in the wilderness

Built temple of gold and of blood to dress,
And brought the curtains of white linen
round

To veil the sight of glory on the ground,
So David too would build a temple sound
And filled with sacrifice and glory found.
Indeed You will have him to build with
voice

Of Psalm instead of blood of goats and
choice

Lambs from the flock. The spires of song
upraise

To make grander cathedrals for Your
praise.

The twitterings of Psalm upon the field
Where lie the sheep well pastured beneath
shield

Of arching temple of the sky above
Raise on the harp, Beloved, a song of love.

Ruth

The book of Ruth, despite its brevity, is an epic. The books of Moses and those associated with him, Joshua, the Judges, and the grand book of the sometime teacher of Moses, Enoch, have all reached their climax and become silent, waiting for the next great book of revelation, the Zabur, the revelation of David. The book of Ruth introduces the books of David.

An epic is the story of the ancestry of kings and the origins of dynasties as descended from the gods and heroes. Such grand tomes are found around the world. The book of Ruth is an epic of contrast, a unique story of origins, not in the exploits of great men of fame, but in the tenacious faithfulness of foreign women. The three foreign women in David's ancestry, who climax in the book of Ruth, are Tamar, the Canaanite wife of the sons of Judah, Rahab, the "harlot" of Jericho, and Ruth the Moabitess, the heroine of this story.

Tamar was also an object of redemption, and though undesired by the sons of Judah, she went to her own extraordinary lengths to produce a child of promise, the heir to the name of redemption. Rahab, though probably a virtuous inn-keeper rather than a harlot, was a Canaanite, one of the enemy, who

became a progenitor of David. She too was a heroine, as she saved not only her whole family, but was instrumental in opening the promised land to the people of Israel. Ruth is the last of this trinity of heroines, the divine ancestry of David, whose epic so clearly condemns human pride and the glory of human kingship.

The legislated customs mentioned in the book were already quaint and outdated when the book was written. The taking off of the sandal, the lying at the feet of the redeemer, and the night-time harvest celebration had all disappeared by the time the courtly chronicler was commissioned to produce the royal epic of the line of David.

Ruth 1

1 It came to pass now, in the days
When judges ruled, there was a phase
Of famine in the land. A man
Of Bethlehem in Judah ran
To live in Moab's land, *both* he
And his wife and his two sons *flee*.

2 The man's name was Elimelech,
Naomi his wife, *on the trek*,
And the names of his two sons were
Mahlon and Chilion, Ephrathites
Of Bethlehem in Judah-shire.
And they went up *for appetites*
To the country of Moab and
Remained there *to live in the land*.

In practice promised land's a place where
one

May live as long as there is bread and fun.
But soon as famine hits the spot the world
Of roots and promises comes all uncurled.
It's one thing to proclaim with tearful eye
"Next year Jerusalem" to satisfy
The rite of blessed night, but quite another
To stay where want threatens both child
and mother.

The earth's in flux, there are no roots to
tell,

And so genetic code comes round to dwell
Among the heathen temples, plain and dell.
Beloved, I am a stranger in the land
No matter where I go I am unclanned
To find the straightened gate, the chaff
unfanned.

3 Naomi's husband died, it seems,
Elimelech did, *in extremes*
She was left, and her two sons' *teams*.
4 Now they took wives of the women
Of Moab: the name of one then
Was Orpah, and the other's name
Was Ruth. And they lived there the same
About ten years. 5 Then both *the sons*
Mahlon and Chilion also died,
So the woman survived her sons
And her husband *also beside*.

Naomi is the name of pleasantness,
Abundances of blessing to excess.
And yet whose name gives hinting and a
guess

Of the three known abundances that You
Give in Yourself, in prophets and the crew
Of Your appointed on the earth, her fate
Was to lose at least three that in her state
Were what she loved above all on the
earth.

She was left with only daughters-in-law,
Which usually is not much better than
dearth,

At least in mother's eyes whose son's her
claw.

Bless me, Beloved, not with names'
prophecy,
Nor with the promises of future glee,
But with You in present eternity.

6 Then she arose with her daughters-
In-law that *without her own fers*
She might return from the country
Of Moab, for she'd *faithfully*
Heard in the country of Moab
That YHWH had given His folk a *dab*
Of bread. 7 Therefore she went out from
The place into which she had come,
And both her daughters-in-law too,
And they went on their way and drew
Near to the country of Judah.

8 Naomi told daughters-in-law,
"Go, return to your mother's house.
YHWH deal well with you, as with spouse
Now dead and me you both have dealt.
9 "YHWH grant that you may find *your*
rest,

Each in her husband's house *at best*."
Then she kissed them, and *as they felt*
They lifted up voices and wept.

10 And they said to her *whom they kept*,
“Surely we will return with you
To your people, *for you’ve been true.*”

This seems to be a literary license,
Dressed up and set out with fine words and
spicence.

I understand the rare case comes around
When mother-in-law finds by duty bound
A daughter-in-law that will show her face
To satisfaction of the human race.
But two in one family is stretching it
Beyond believable to my poor wit.
Beloved, I take Your word and stand
admonished

For unbelief arising when astonished.
Reality is stranger than the view
I get through many myths I think are true,
And every morning’s miracle anew
Turns dreams and visions into something
true.

11 Naomi said “Turn back, my daughters,
Why will you go *over the waters*
With me? Have I still sons in womb,
To be your husbands in their room?

12 “Turn back, my daughters, go, for I
Am too old to have by and by
A husband. If I should say I
Have hope, *if* I should have tonight
A husband and also bear *wight*
Sons, 13 “would you wait for them till they
Were grown? Would you restrain and stay
From having husbands? No, my daughters,
It grieves me much *to tears and waters*
For your sakes that the hand of YHWH
Has gone out against my *curfew!*”

In those days children were conceived it
seems
In evening just before the start of dreams.
The husband bears upon the wife when
dark
Invades the life and sets to sleep the lark.
They had not yet invented minidress
Whereby the one who wants, she will
confess,

A man in torpid afternoon before
The sun sends shadows out across the door,
Entices with a well-turned thigh instead
Of well-turned heel to get a man in bed.
So that explains Naomi’s cryptic word.

Beloved, I am a man whose heart is stirred
By reason, even in the mouth of one
Well-covered by a veil from burning sun.

14 They lifted up their voices and
Wept again, and Orpah *took hand*
And kissed her mother-in-law, but
Ruth clung to her *for which or what.*

Each morning You urge me as Naomi
Did once to her two daughters for to flee
Back to Moab and to the company
Of all the lovely gods of rock and tree.
As she did half in sorrow, half in duty,
You turn me back with the new morning’s
beauty,
Not daring to hope I might come with You,
Who offer nothing of wealth nor the view
Of happiness. And more than likely I
Give quick lip service to remembrance shy
For a moment or hour, then make my way
Into rush of gods’ and goddesses’ sway.
Beloved, let me choose now for this whole
day
To cling to Your love and cling without
pay.

15 She said “Look, your sister-in-law
Has gone back to her people’s *craw*
And to her rulers, go after
Your sister-in-law, *as it were.*”

Even the blessed and true can give advice
To return to idolatry and vice.
In fact that’s what is done in every pulpit
Where is elected grace alone for culprit,
Which is no grace at all, because it makes
So much of human sacrifice at stakes.
Grace of idolatry is that the speaker
Is free to trample on the brother weaker,
And those well trampled have the grace to
live
Above their sorrows and learn to forgive.
Beloved, let me live without idol’s share
And so have nothing to forgive or dare
To take the morsel of the one I can.
Give me the grace to be free as a man.

16 But Ruth said “Entreat me not to
Leave you, and turn back *with the few*
From following after you, for
Wherever you go on before,

There I will go, and where you live,
 There I will live, *though fugitive*,
 Your people *shall be* my folk then,
 And your rulers mine among men.
 17 Where you die, I will die, and there
 Will I be buried *for my share*.
 YHWH do so to me, more also,
 If *ought but* death part us below.”
 18 When she saw how she had decided
 To go with her whate’er betided,
 She stopped trying to change her mot.

Lovely determinedness, the thing You
 pride
 In the Suura of Patience in the Tide
 Of Time, is on the lips of Ruth, one caught
 Between her own folk and the stranger
 sought,
 As I myself in all my life and plot.
 Such stepping out has just one motive I
 Know well because of the thing that I ply,
 To freedom from the popular assent,
 And liberty alone given to repent.
 I must be free of every word beware
 To find You on my breath and everywhere.
 Who is ensnackled with both love and faith
 Despite Your presence must turn to the
 wraith.
 Beloved, I shiver in Your freshening air.

19 Now the two of them went until
 They arrived at Bethlehem’s hill.
 It happened, when they had arrived
 In Bethlehem *to where they strived*,
 That all the city was excited
 Because they had been reunited,
 And the women said “*Is this now*
 Naomi?” 20 But she said somehow
 To them, “Do not call me by name
 Naomi, *pleasantness for fame*,
 But call me Mara just the same,
 For the Almighty’s dealt with me
 In every way most bitterly.
 21 “I went out full, and YHWH has
 brought
 Me home again, and yet with naught.
 Why do you call me Naomi,
 Since YHWH testified against me,
 And the Almighty afflicts me?”

This is not high-flown philosophy’s voice
 That speaks in Naomi by word and choice.

It is the earth-bound pain of loss of love
 Of husband and of sons against the shove
 Of having fled to save life, refugee
 Who found only death in the flight to be.
 You are to us, all humankind, like mother
 Against whom we kick when we’re found
 to smother
 In pain and disappointment, Almighty.
 And yet I cannot understand her plea,
 Who went out empty, though with high
 hopes charged
 To come back without hope, and yet
 enlarged.
 There is no full but is illusion’s plate
 And there’s no empty where You set the
 rate.

22 So Naomi returned, and Ruth
 The Moabitess, who forsooth
 Was her daughter-in-law with her,
 Who came back from Moab’s land’s spur.
 And they came to Bethlehem at
 The start of barley harvest’s pat.

Ruth 2

1 A kinsman of Naomi’s late
 There was a man of great estate,
 Of family of Elimelech.
 His name *was Boaz for the beck*.
 2 So Ruth the Moabitess said
 To Naomi, “Please to find bread
 Let me go to the field, and glean
 Ears of corn after *him* who’s seen
 Me in favour.” She said to her,
 “Go then, my daughter *happier*.”
 3 So she left, went and gleaned the field
 After the reapers *of its yield*.
 And she happened to come to part
 Of the field that was Boaz’ chart,
 Who *was of* Elimelech’s shield.

Beloved, the stranger in the land, the poor
 And widow woman still has somewhat
 sure,
 The thought that friend might let her glean
 the field,
 One who might see her with favour and
 yield.

As I look out upon the wholesome past
 Of my own life in what there’s been to last,
 I see no such a patron in whose favour
 I have come to glean in the field to waver.

I thank You, my Beloved, that their is none
But You alone to succour me when done.
There is no owner of the fields about
To let me in to glean, but with a shout
I should be sent from every one I try.
I thank You that there's only You and I.

4 Now indeed, Boaz came out from
Bethlehem, and said to those come
To reap, "YHWH *be* with you!" And they
Answered him, "YHWH bless you *today!*"

Today in every favoured kind of way
The faithful say "Peace on you" or to sway
The multitude "Shalom" or then "Salaam,"
And so we hope to live in peace and calm.
But here the greeting is another thing,
"YHWH with you" is the greeting word of
king,
And the right answer is "May YHWH bless
you!"

This may be ancient practice come to view.
Though both the Bible and Qur'an make
fast

That Peace is the greeting spoken to last,
It seems another is archaic fare.
Beloved, be with me and bless everywhere,
And that's as close as peace in any case
That can be found here by the human race.

Listen, Beloved, to my scholar's instinct
To explain how the greeting that once
blinked
Has become lost to humankind and speech.
At some point readers thought Your law to
teach
That Your name must not be said in the
breach,
But respect guiding heart and tongue
would tell
Us to replace it with another spell.
This ancient greeting and its answer too
Contain the very sacred name of YHWH.
That's probably why Hebrews started out
To say peace when they came to turn
about.

And so it came into St. James's scroll,
And the Qur'an fulfilled the once set goal:
Development of respect without doubt.

5 Then Boaz said to his servant
Who was in charge of reapers' grant,

"Whose young woman *is* this, *I say?*"

6 So the servant who was in sway
Over of the reapers answered and
Said "It *is* the young Moabite
Woman who came back from the land
Of Moab with Naomi's right.

7 "And she said 'Please let me glean and
Gather after the reapers' hand
Among the sheaves.' So she came and
Has continued from dawn till now,
Though she rested a little vow
Inside the house." 8 Then Boaz said
To Ruth, "Hear me, daughter, be led,
Don't go to glean another field,
Nor go from here, but stay well heeled
Close by my young women *and steeled.*

9 "*Let* your eyes *be* upon the field
Which they reap, and go after them.
Have I not said ad hominem
Not to touch you? And when you are
Thirsty, go to the vessels' bar
And drink what the young men have
drawn."

10 So she fell on her face, upon
The ground bowed down, and said to him,
"Why have I found grace and not dim
In your eyes, that you should take note
Of me, since I'm a foreign stoat?"

The truth is simply that Boaz was not
Immune to sightly girls in human plot,
And so he raised his attention to give
The command to leave Ruth and let her
live

Without approach of young men of the soil
To distract her with sex appeal from toil.
His kindness and his justice were informed
By what he saw in beauty unbestormed
In the unique curl of a foreign race.
Many men are taken by stranger's face.
Let me too, my Beloved, ever enticed,
Follow desire to virtue intersticed
With gentleness and kindness nourished by
The hormones that boil in the loin and
thigh.

11 And Boaz answered her and said,
"I've heard all that's been reported
Of all you've done for husband's mother
Since the death of your late and brother,
And *how* you have left father and
Your mother and your birthplace' land,

And have come to a people whom
 You did not know before *from doom*.
 12 "May YHWH repay your work, and
 give
 A full reward to you to live
 By YHWH the God of Israel,
 Under whose wings you've come for cell
 Of refuge." 13 Then she said "Let me
 Find favour in your sight to be,
 My lord, for you've comforted me,
 Spoken to your servant kindly,
 Though I'm not like one of your maids."
 14 Now Boaz told her in the shades
 Of mealtime, "Come here, and eat bread,
 And dip your sop in the sour spread."
 And so she sat beside the reapers,
 And he handed her parched *corn heaps*,
 And she ate and was satisfied,
 And saved some of it *for a snack*.
 15 And when she rose up to go back
 And glean, Boaz commanded his
 Young men, saying "Let her in whiz
 Glean even among the sheaves, and
 Do not reproach her *from her stand*.
 16 "Also let *corn* from bundles fall
 On purpose for her *by the wall*,
 And leave *it* so that she may glean,
 And do not rebuke her when seen."

Ah with what jealous eye I see the path
 That Ruth takes among reapers without
 wrath.
 I too have given up my native land
 And sat among the strangers and my hand
 Has served the parents of my wife as
 planned,
 And yet no one has spoken a kind word,
 Much less given a dinner as preferred.
 When I read in Your word the sacred tale,
 I realize what miracle the veil
 Reveals, since no man is kind to the
 stranger.
 It simply is not done, though there's no
 danger.
 I'm thankful to live in peace though the
 while
 May change at any moment for a smile.
 I trust in You, Beloved, amid the guile.

17 So she gleaned in the field until
 Evening, and then beat out the till
 Of what she'd gathered, and it came

To round a barley ephah's claim.
 18 Then she took *it* up and went with
 It to the city, where her kith,
 Her mother-in-law saw what she
 Had gathered. So she brought the fee
 Out and gave to her what she'd saved
 After she'd eaten of the braved.
 19 And her mother-in-law told her,
 "Where have you gleaned today *in spur?*
 And where did you work? Blessed be he
 Who took notice of you *for free*."
 So she told her mother-in-law
 With whom she had been dealt a paw,
 And said "The man's name with whom I
 Worked today *is Boaz for why*."
 20 Naomi said to her daughter
 In law, "Blessed *be* he of YHWH's *stir*,
 Who's not forsaken His kindness
 To living and the dead's *address!*"
 And Naomi said to her, "This
 Man's kin of ours and not to miss."
 21 Ruth the Moabiteess said "He
 Also said to me, 'You shall be
 Close by my young men till they've done
 All my harvest *for work and fun*.'"
 22 And Naomi said to Ruth her
 Daughter-in-law, "*It's good infer*,
 My daughter, that you go out by
 His young women, that folk not spy
 You in another field." 23 So she
 Stayed close by the young women free
 Of Boaz, to glean till the end
 Of barley harvest to contend
 And wheat harvest, and she lived by
 Her mother-in-law *and ally*.

I've seen the women in their bright clothes
 bend
 Among the barley harvest where they
 spend
 The day and then a kindness for their toil
 Are brought back home by tractor for the
 spoil.
 A long day in the spring sun almost met
 To summer and the end of seasons wet
 Is their fate and not easy on the bone.
 Even when well treated, the weary stone
 Weighs heavy on the burdened back to
 groan.
 Still every face is covered with the joy
 Of chatting on together while employ
 Their bodies in the harvest. I raise hat

To Ruth for diligence where she was at.
The barley is a promise of the fat.

Ruth 3

1 Then Naomi her mother-in-law
Said to her, “My daughter-*in-law*,
Shall I not seek security
For you, that it may truly be
Well with you? 2 “Now Boaz, whose
 young
Women you were with, *is he* not
Our relative? In fact, he’s *flung*
To winnow barley tonight fraught
There at the threshing floor. 3 “Therefore
Wash yourself and anoint your *door*,
Put on your *best* garment and go
Down to the threshing floor, *but* show
Yourself not to the man until
He has finished eating the bill
And drinking. 4 “Then it shall be, when
He lies down, that you’ll notice then
The place where he lies, and you’ll go
In, and uncover his feet *slow*,
And lie down, and he will tell you
Whatever it is you should do.”
5 And she said to her, “All that you
Say to me I will surely do.”

Some women are not wise in how they go
About getting what’s due them in the
 show,
But place in compromising situation
Both themselves and the man who is their
 ration.
I forgive Ruth because she took advice
From Naomi, whose word was worth in
 twice
That of another for her place in being
Mother-in-law. But still they should be
 seeing
That lying at Boas’ feet could undo them
With gossip in a town ready to shrew them.
Boas may well make of the winnowing
Of barley a feast of joy on the wing,
But still he keeps his mind upon the thing
That’s best for Ruth, and not on his own
 fling.

6 So she went to the threshing floor
And did according to the score
Of what her mother-in-law said.
7 And after Boaz had well fed

And drunk, and his heart full of cheer,
He went to lie down at the *near*
End of the heap of corn, and she
Came softly, *she came quietly*,
Uncovered his feet, and lay down.
8 It came with midnight on the town
The man was startled when he turned
And found a woman *and unearned*
Was lying at his feet. 9 And he
Said “Who *are* you?” and so then she
Answered, “I’m Ruth, your maidservant.
Take your maid under your *cloak*’s slant,
For you are a close relative.”
10 Then he said “Blessed *are* you *to live*
Of YHWH, my daughter! For you give
More kindness at the end than start,
In that you did not go apart
After young men, the poor or rich.
11 “And now, my daughter, do not pitch.
I will do for you all you wish,
For all the people of this dish
Know that you *are* of good virtue,
And would not uncover a shoe.

Now days the young ladies fall for rich
 men,
But it’s not said a virtue without wen.
The young ladies who look for sugar
 daddies
Gain their respect through wealth and not
 through laddies.
Who’s to say Ruth in her total regard
For Boas did not think about the shard
Of wealth the elder man she knew
 possessed?
That is a thing left unsaid and unguessed.
Beloved, I come to You in poverty,
Forgetting that the world is Yours in fee,
Thinking our hearth together will be small
And blessed with little in the bin and stall.
But I am just as suspect as poor Ruth
Who went out looking for not wealth but
 truth.

12 “And it is true that I *am* close
In kin, but there is one more *dose*
Of relative closer than I.
13 “Stay this night, and in morning sky
It shall be *that* if he’ll perform
The duty of a close *and warm*
Relative for you, good, let him
Do it. But if he is not trim

To perform the duty for you,
Then I'll perform the duty true,
For you, *as* YHWH lives! So lie down
Until the morning *come to town*."

Take me, Beloved, to Your heart even
now,
There is no other relative to bow,
There is no closer than You to my heart,
None closer than Your Self, even my part.
Take me, Beloved, to Your tent now in
view

Of the midnight in quiet and in dew,
And I shall never leave when shade is past,
Nor flee into the town, nor cover cast.
Take me, Beloved, yet leave me in the
shove

Of timely market, and untimely love,
And I shall wait before Your purple tent
For Your awakening, and when I'm sent,
Shall find my road across Bethlehem's
stones
Untrammelled by the lichens and their
tones.

14 So she lay at his feet till morn,
And she arose before *the horn*
Before one could know one another.
Then he said "Do not let a brother
Know that the woman came down here
To the threshing floor, *gossips fear*."

15 Also he said "Bring the shawl that
Is on you and hold it *for mat*."
And when she held it, he poured out
Six measures of barley and stout,
And laid *it* on her. Then she went
Into the city, *night far spent*.

16 So when she came back to the place
Where was her mother-in-law's face,
She said "*Is* that you, my daughter?"
Then she told her all that the fer
Had done for her. 17 And then she said
"These six *ephahs* of barley *bread*
He gave me, for he said to me,
'Do not go empty-handedly
To your mother-in-law.'" 18 Then she
Said "Sit still, my daughter, until
You know how the matter fulfil,
For the man will not rest until
He's finished today the thing's bill."

Six measures of the week You give to me,

As though in favour for the harlot's fee,
Although I have not shared Your bed of
glee,

But only slept at Your feet tremblingly.
Six days You give me and a grace to spare,
Unwarranted, unearned, and as my share
The spaces to the sky, the chill of air
Above a fertile earth, and some to spare.
The seventh measure is the secret done,
The Sabbath of the love that I have won
Where I in the night work beneath Your
cloak

Breathed quietly until Your heart awoke
To find me, willing, bare, and without
claim

But that You are to me the closest name.

Ruth 4

1 Now Boaz went up to the gate
And sat down there *to stay a rate*,
And indeed, the close relative
Of whom Boaz *alternative*
Had spoken came by. So Boaz
Said "Come aside, friend, sit and razz."
So he came aside and sat down.

2 And he took ten men of the town,
Elders, and said "Sit down here too."

So they sat down *there not a few*.

3 Then he said to the relative,
"Naomi, who's come back to live
From the land of Moab, would sell
The piece of land which *belonged well*
To our brother Elimelech.

4 "And I intended then to check
With you, saying 'Now buy *it* back
Before the citizens no lack
Of elders of my folk. If you
Will redeem *it*, redeem *it true*,
But if you'll not redeem *it*, *then*
Tell me, that I may know and ken,
For no one but you will redeem
It, and I'm next after your *beam*.'" 5

Then Boaz said "On the day you buy
The field from hand of Naomi,
You must also buy *it* from Ruth
The Moabitess, wife in truth
Of the dead, to perpetuate
The name of the dead in estate."

6 And the kinsman said "I cannot
Redeem for myself *such a plot*,
Lest I spoil my own heritage.

You take my right of acreage
 In redemption and for yourself,
 For I cannot redeem *the shelf*.”
 7 Now this *was done* in former times
 In Israel concerning dimes
 Of redemption and the exchange,
 To confirm anything in range:
 One man took off his sandal and
 Gave *it* to the other *in hand*,
 And this made contract in the land
 Of Israel. 8 Therefore the kin
 Said to Boaz, “Buy *stock and bin*
 For yourself.” So he took off his
 Sandal *to give him where he is*.

Beloved, I am for sale it seems where death
 Left me to repeat frantic shibboleth
 Across bewildered borderlands of grief.
 I enter the town gate to my relief
 To find myself bartered and sold like beef.
 Beloved take off no shoe when You see me
 Return upon the banks and faithfully
 Search out Your footsteps on the dawning
 sky.
 Beloved, take off no shoe nor pass me by.
 The witnesses in turbans stroke a beard
 And furtively examine teeth with feared
 Expressions of bored lack of interest that
 Wash my raw heart into a state of flat
 Unfeeling stone. I look back where You
 sat.

9 Boaz said to the elders and
 All the people, “You *are at hand*
 To witness this day that I’ve bought
 All that was Elimelech’s lot,
 And all that *was* Chilion’s and
 Mahlon’s, and bought them from the hand
 Of Naomi. 10 “Moreover, Ruth
 The Moabitess, who in truth
 Is widow of Mahlon, I’ve taken
 As my wife, to perpetuate
 The name of the dead *not to waken*
 Through his inheritance, so that
 The name of the dead may not flat
 Be cut off from among his brothers
 And from his gate place with the others.
 And you *are* witnesses today.”

Sweet Christians talk of saviours and
 redeemers,

And here we see two such, one on the
 touch,
 The other most reluctant to do much.
 Some are redeemers, others only seemers.
 Redemption is a strange thing in the tale
 Of ages past, but down to earth and hale.
 Redeem the brother’s wife, redeem the son
 First born, the donkey too under the son,
 It’s all so clear and bright in Palestine
 Under the canopy of barley fine.
 Only the trussed theology of late
 Makes my redemption seem an obscure
 fate.

I am the first-born son, and so redeemed
 By everything that You and I have
 dreamed.

11 And all the folk who came to stay
 At the gate, and the elders, said
 “*We’re* witnesses *to what you read*.
 May YHWH make the woman who comes
 To your house like Rachel, for sums
 Like Leah, the two who have built
 The house of Israel *begit*,
 And prosper you in Ephrata
 For fame in Bethlehem *for awe*.
 12 “May your house be like the house of
 Perez, whom Tamar bore *for love*
 To Judah, because the offspring
 Which YHWH will give you from the
 spring
 Of this young woman *grows to sing*.”

You take me home, Beloved, a bride at last
 Who felt the shame of elders who had cast
 Appraising eye upon the grazing sheep
 Come up from Moab to Bethlehem’s keep.
 You take me home, Beloved, beyond the
 stares
 Of Bethlehem, whose hardened glance and
 glares
 Will find a time to fasten on the bent
 Form of Mary and on the shame she spent.
 Now on my ears are ringing all the praise
 Due to Rachel and Leah for their days
 Of faithfulness in wandering toward the
 tent
 Of Bethlehem. The joy that through me
 went
 Becomes a shiver of fear that I might
 Be empty to Your sorrow come the night.

13 Boaz took Ruth and she became
His wife, and when he made the claim
On her, YHWH gave her conception,
And then she gave birth to a son.

14 Then the women said to Naomi,
“Blessed *be* YHWH, who’s not left you
 roamy

Today without a kith or kin,
And may his name be famous in
Israel! 15 “And may he be to you
Restorer of life and a true
Nourisher of your old age too,
Because your daughter-in-law, who
Loves you, who’s better far to you
Than seven sons, and she’s borne him.”
16 Then Naomi took the child slim
And laid him on her bosom, and
Became a nurse to him at hand.

It would be interesting to know if any
Miraculous occurrence for a penny
Happened in those sweet golden days of
 yore,
When life was pastoral and folk were more
Interested in their crops than oil and war.
Did milk come from that breast Naomi
 lent?

No doubt she was still young as people
 went

In those days, though a grandmother
 unspent.

Beloved, I’ve heard of unexpected milk,
I’ve listened to whisperings of that ilk,
And I am ready to believe the thing,
Though not as action of a God or king,
But rather the result of her great love,
And that’s the miracle I’m thinking of.

17 Also the neighbour women gave
Him a name, saying “There’s a *grave*
Son born to Naomi.” And they
Called his name Obed. In the way
He *is* the father of Jesse,
The father of David *to see*.

18 This *is* the genealogy
Of Perez: for Perez begot
Hezron, 19 Hezron produced *the lot*
Of Ram, and Ram begot *a son*
Aminadab by name when done,
20 Aminadab produced Nahshon,
And then Nahshon produced Salmon,
21 Salmon produced Boaz, and he

Boaz produced Obed, 22 and see
Then Obed has produced Jesse,
And Jesse produced David wee.

Most kings hire poets to make up the grand
Legends of epic that fill every land
With pride their king descended from the
 great

Gods and heroes that once walked their
 estate.

But David’s epic tells the story of
Foreign women whose folly fed their love,
Rahab and Tamar with their hanging cord
Of scarlet to assail attacking horde,
And Ruth who clings to Naomi until
The dawn light filters through the threshing
 mill.

The weak look to the strong to bolster up
Their reign, while You and David take the
 cup

Of the weakest of weak and show the
 world

A brief and poignant epic, one impeared.

The Books of Samuel

The books of Samuel are considered by
many scholars to be drawn from very early
material, traditions going back to the
beginnings of the monarchical period of
Israel’s history. The uniqueness of the
Davidic line was introduced and
established in the book of Ruth, which
contrasts royal hero-worship, typical of
epic poetry, with the sweet, earthy
character of divinely appointed leadership.
The first book of Samuel tells the story of
the establishing of the Davidic dynasty and
the golden age of royal divine guidance.
The second book of Samuel tells the story
of that blessed reign, from the death of
Saul to near the end of David’s reign.

The importance of the books is not to be
over-estimated for both Jewish and
Christian traditions, whose messianic hope
is established in these works, already from
the magnificent prophecy of Hannah in 1
Samuel 2.

The shadowy figure of
Hemda (Hebrew cognate of the Arabic
name Muhammad), the desired one,
appears for the first time in 1 Samuel 9:20

in connexion with the dynasty of Saul, in which the hopes for the desired one were disappointed.

1 Samuel 1

1 Now there was a certain man of Ramathaim Zophim, from above The mountains of Ephraim, his name Was Elkanah of Jeroham, The son of Elihu, the son Of Tohu, the son of Zuph *done*, An Ephraimite. 2 And he had two Wives: the name of one was Hannah, The other's name was Peninnah. Peninnah had children, but Hannah Had no children *of any manner*.

3 This man went up from his city Yearly to worship and *in fee* To sacrifice to YHWH of hosts In Shiloh. Also the two *boasts*, Sons of Ali, Hophni and one Phinehas, the priests of YHWH *run*, Were there. 4 And whenever the time Was for Elkanah to make rhyme In offering, he'd give a portion To Peninnah his wife's extortion And to all her sons and daughters. 5 But to Hannah as it occurs He gave a greater portion's lot, For he loved Hannah, although YHWH Had shut up her from bearing too. 6 And her co-wife did not relent But let her know her plague was sent From YHWH to make her barren lent.

I do not imagine in darkened mind That Peninnah was enemy of kind That took advantage of the evil stroke To lay on Hannah wickedness in yoke. Peninnah was a sweet Christian and fair, The kind that exhibits exquisite care For every creature set below her state. She poured no dour reproach on Hannah's pate,

But only noted that each trial comes To teach us what the Lord has in His sums For our correction that we might repent. So sweetly did Peninnah not relent. With so many sweet Christians at my door I have no need of enemy to score.

7 As Elkanah did year by year,

So she went up to house and fear Of YHWH, and so she provoked late And early till she wept, not ate. 8 Then Elkanah her husband said To her, "Hannah, why are you led To cry, and why not eat your bread, And why is your heart grieved instead, Am I not better to you than Ten sons from baby to a man?"

It is no wonder Hannah was tear-eyed To see both Peninnah decked out in pride Of virtue since You always took her side, And Elkanah himself in irritation That Hannah was sad despite the high station

Her husband had granted her undeserved. Undeserved grace is not a thing so curved To give joy. It is not prideful I trow To be offended by paternal brow. Beloved, do not tell me You love me still Despite the fact I am a bitter pill. If You cannot love me for what I am Reflecting Your glories as though on sham, Then love not, I swear, love not for a frill.

9 So Hannah got up after they Had eaten in Shiloh to pay, And after they had drunk a stay. Now Ali the priest sat upon A seat by a post of the drawn Temple of YHWH. 10 And she was there In bitterness of soul to bear, And prayed to YHWH and cried within.

11 And she vowed a vow not in sin And said "O YHWH of hosts to win, If You will indeed look upon The affliction of handmaid drawn, And remember me, not forgetting Your handmaid, but will give in setting Your handmaid a son, then I shall Give him to YHWH all days banal Of his life, and there shall no razor Come on his head, not even laser.

12 And so it happened, as she went On praying before YHWH unspent, That Ali noticed her mouth lent.

13 Now Hannah, she spoke in her heart, Only her lips moved some apart, But her voice was not heard at all, Therefore Ali thought drunken brawl.

14 And Ali told her, "How long will

You be drunken, put away till
Of wine from you and tow the bill.”

Praise be to Hannah for she did invent
The way to pray to You in heart and tent
Without saying a word aloud and bent.
The heart remembrance is my greatest
grace,

A thing to flee to in the public race.
Praise be to Ali for his strong reproof
Of drinking at the feasts of YHWH for
spoon,

A thing that continues around the woof
And magnified today in every church.
Praise to these two, Beloved, one might
long search

For any two greater to follow suit.
The lesson is not lost on me to boot,
Who avoid each day Eucharist and root
Of liquor and remember You on perch.

15 And Hannah answered and said “No,
Sir, I’m a woman who’s brought low
In sorrow, I have neither drunk
Wine nor liquor, but I have sunk
Before YHWH pouring out my soul.

16 “Do not consider me a toll
Daughter of Belial, for out
Of great complaint and grief I pout.”

17 Then Ali answered and said “Go
In peace, and may Alohims flow
In Israel grant your petition
That you’ve asked Him in your contrition.”

18 And she said “Let your servant find
Grace in your sight and in your mind.”
And so the woman went her way,
And ate and her face became gay.

I thank You, my Beloved, that You have
given
Such power to men on earth, such as have
striven

To match Your glory with a witness born
Both to their own children and to the
sworn.

I thank You, my Beloved, that I have no
Such powers to hand out and such to
bestow

Gifts on those who about me also weep.
I have an empty hand, I lose no sleep.
I thank You, my Beloved, that there is
priest,

Though perhaps unknown to my heart at
least,

Worthy of such powers You gave in hand
Once long ago in Shiloh, Canaan’s land.
Beloved, my thanks in humble joy ascends
Before Your face that You accept such
friends.

19 And they got up at early dawn,
And prostrated themselves up drawn
Before YHWH, and then went away
Back to their home in Ramah’s bay.
Elkanah knew Hannah his wife,
And YHWH remembered her *great strife*.
20 It happened when the time arrived
After Hannah conceived contrived,
She gave birth to a son, and called
His name Samuel, saying *enthralled*,
Since I asked him from YHWH *installed*.

How many miracles in birth have You,
Beloved, brought on the ghastly human
crew.

Some miracled boys are named with the
view

Of thanking you and praising what You do.
At least one such has been caught up to be
Called God Almighty in forsaken spree,
And made the object of idolatry.
From such, Beloved, I set myself to flee.
The miracles of birth give evidence,
Not of the specialty of babies’ sense,
But of Your power alone as God above
Who gives to humankind such gifts of love.
Beloved, teach me to see the wonder here
In every birth and look on You in fear.

21 The husband Elkanah and house
All went up to offer *with spouse*
To YHWH the yearly sacrifice,
And do his vow as to suffice.

22 But Hannah did not go up then,
For she said to her husband, “I
Will not go up to there again
Until the boy is weaned, then I
Will bring him, so he may appear
Before YHWH and stay there for cheer.”

23 Her husband Elkanah told her,
“Do what you like and so prefer,
Stay till you’ve weaned him, only YHWH
Make His word at the last come true.
So the lady stayed and nursed still

Her son until she'd weaned to fill.
24 And when she'd weaned him, she took
him

Up with her, with three bullocks trim,
And one ephah of flour, and yet
A bottle of good grape-juice met,
And brought him to YHWH's house that's
in

Shiloh. The boy was young to win.
25 They killed the bull and brought the
child

To Ali, *who was reconciled*.

26 And she said "Oh sir, as your soul
Does live, my dear sir, I'm the wench
That stood before you *on the bench*
To pray to YHWH to grant my goal.

27 "I prayed for this child, and then
YHWH

Gave me what I asked for in view.

28 That's why I've lent him back to YHWH
As long as he lives he'll be lent
To YHWH." And he prostrated too
Himself in gratitude to YHWH.

I follow the practice that Ali showed
Upon the earth in actions that then glowed
With spices of obedience and grace,
To bow down in prostration at Your face.
I touch the law of Ali and I stand
Among the few and faithful of his band
And hear the childish voice of Samuel rise
In praise and prayer up to the wakened
skies.

Beloved, let me prostrate myself to you
Each day in everything I come to do,
And not just in the prayers contrived to
make

My days in punctuation to relate.
I take the faith and practice that You gave
To Ali as the leader of the brave.

1 Samuel 2

1 And Hannah *Samuel's mother* prayed
And said "My heart rejoices *stayed*
On YHWH, My horn's exalted in
YHWH. I smile at my *foes of sin*,
Since I rejoice in Your salvation.
2 "No one is holy like YHWH's *station*,
For *there* is no god besides You,
Nor *is there* any rock and true
Like our God. 3 "Talk no more so proudly,
And let no arrogance come *loudly*

From your mouth, For YHWH *is* the God
Of knowledge, and by Him are trod
And weighed doings. 4 "The bows of
mighty

Men *are* broken, and those who *flighty*
Stumbled are girded with *Your* strength.

5 "*Those who were* full have hired *at*
length

Themselves out for *new wealth and* bread,
And the hungry are served instead.

Even the barren has borne seven,
And she with many children's *heaven*
Has become feeble. 6 "YHWH kills and
Makes alive, He brings down to land
In the grave and brings up. 7 "YHWH
makes

Poor and makes rich, and *for their sakes*
He brings low and lifts up. 8 "He raises
The poor from the dust and *amazes*,
He lifts the beggar from ash heap,
To set *them* among princes' *keep*,
To inherit the throne of glory.

For pillars of the earthen *storey*
Are YHWH's, and He has set the world

Upon them. 9 "He will guard *uncurled*
The feet of His saints, but the wicked
Shall be silent in darkness brickèd.

For by strength no man shall prevail.

10 "The adversaries of YHWH *wail*,
Broken in pieces, from heaven He
Will thunder against *feeble plea*.

YHWH will judge the ends of the earth.
He will give strength to His king's *worth*,
And exalt horn of His anointed,
Promised Messiah and appointed."

A woman made the first great prophecy
Of the Messiah, promised he would be
A horn of great salvation to the free.
So Hannah was forerunner of the one
Who gave birth to the Messianic son
And had to give him up to do the work
Of his own father and as child not shirk,
But served alone within the temple shrine.
Though I am not a child of seven or
twelve,

I too trim lamps within the inner shine
Of my chamber, and in prayer I too delve
The wonders open to a little child.
I look out from my cell upon the wild
And shuttered wilderness and undefiled.

11 Then Elkanah went to his house
 At Ramah, *and he took his spouse.*
 But the child ministered to YHWH
 Before Ali the priest *to do.*
 12 Now sons of Ali *were* corrupt,
 They did not know YHWH *when they*
supped.
 13 And the priests' custom with the people
Was that when any *came to steeple*
And offered there a sacrifice,
 The priest's servant would come *to slice*
 With a three-pronged fleshhook in hand
 While the meat was boiling *and banned.*
 14 Then he would thrust *it* in the pan,
 Or kettle, caldron, pot *for span,*
 And the priest would take for himself
 All the fleshhook brought up *on shelf.*
 So they did in Shiloh to all
 The Israelites who came *by call.*
 15 Also, before they burned the fat,
 The priest's servant would come to that
 Man who sacrificed there to say,
 "Give meat for roasting *on the brae*
 To the priest, for he will not take
 Boiled meat from you, but raw *in steak.*"
 16 And *if* the man said to him, "They
 Should really burn the fat first *flay,*
Then you may take *what* heart desires,"
 He would then answer his *plaint choirs,*
 "No, you must give *it to me* now,
 And if not, I'll take *anyhow*
 By force." 17 Therefore the sin was great
 Of the young men before YHWH's *state,*
 For men abhorred YHWH's offering then.

How many priests today wield a three-
 pronged
 Fleshhook, how many folk have such
 priests wronged.
 The sharpened trinity takes on its hooks
 The taxes from each person in its books,
 And from all businesses that sell a thing
 Or make a mount to set beneath a wing,
 And pass the offering plate to take what's
 left
 To give the church's workmen of the theft.
 The church is made a handmaid of the
 state,
 And state is made vehicle of the hate
 That universal love to humankind
 Hides under three-pronged programmes of
 the mimed.

Beloved, I flee to You with empty hands,
 For sacrifices fill the contrabands.

18 But Samuel ministered then
 Before YHWH, *even as* a child,
 Wearing a linen ephod *aisled.*
 19 Moreover his mother would make
 Him a little robe, and would take
It to him year by year when she
 Came up with her husband to *see*
 And offer yearly sacrifice.
 20 And Ali would bless Elkanah
 And his wife *in basilica,*
 Saying "YHWH give you descendants
 From this woman in sufferance
 For the loan that was given to YHWH."
 Then they would go to their own *pew.*
 21 And YHWH visited Hannah, so
 That she conceived, came to bestow
 Three sons and two daughters. Meanwhile
 The child Samuel grew lank and file
 Before YHWH *in His studio.*

That Samuel served You serves to show
 the weal
 That even Rome and Canterbury deal
 In simony, yet out of all of that,
 The robbing and the taking of the fat,
 Still some child having drunk with
 mother's milk
 The Decalogue, can shine like gold and
 silk
 Though trampled by the swine of temple
 hoard.
 Although the wine of Babylon and board
 Must corrupt every hand and eye that
 comes
 Into Bel's temple to eat of the sums,
 Still there are those in even Babylon
 Who eat the pulse and drink the water gone
 Out from Your mouth to nourish all the
 race.
 I too, Beloved, look toward You and Your
 face.

22 Now Ali, he was very old,
 And heard all that his sons were bold
 To do in all of Israel's fold,
 And how they fornicated there
 With the women who came to share
 At the door of assembly tent.
 23 And he told them, "Why do you do

Such things? I hear of your consent
To do evil things in the view
Of all this people. 24 “No, my sons,
It’s no good rumour that the guns
Bring to my ears, you make the folk
Of YHWH transgress. 25 “And if one
bloke

Sins against another, the judge
Shall judge him, but if a man fudge
Against YHWH, then who shall entreat
For him?” But they did not retreat
Obeying the voice of their dad,
Because YHWH planned to kill the cad.

That’s rather far-fetched way of escaping
The responsibility not to swing,
This saying that the sons of Ali broke
Their father’s counsel because at a stroke
You planned to kill them and needed
excuse.

That concept of You lends to an abuse.
Further no doubt You will take him to task
For not correcting his sons at the mask,
And yet Ali is bold to tell them what
Is right and wrong and to convey the cut.
Beloved, I too have children on the sea
And tell them what is right and wrong to
be.

Perhaps their choices will come to agree
With what Your Decalogue says faithfully.

26 And the child Samuel grew apace
And was in favour before face
Of both YHWH and the human race.
27 And there came a man of God to
Ali, and told him, “Thus says YHWH,
‘Did I plainly appear unto
The house of your father when they
Were in Egypt’s Pharaoh’s house’ sway?
28 ‘And did I choose him out of all
The tribes of Israel to call
My priest, to offer on the flat
Of altar, to burn incense at
It, to wear an ephod before
Me? And did I give your dad’s house
All the offerings made by each spouse
By fire from Israel’s folk in store?
29 ‘Why do you then despise my thing
In sacrifice and offering,
Which I commanded in My tent,
And honour your sons above Me
To make yourselves fat with the fee

Of all the best offerings of
My people Israel above?’”
30 Therefore YHWH Israel’s Alohim
Says “I indeed said that the cream
Of your house and your father’s house
Should walk before Me man and spouse
Forever, but now YHWH has said
‘I’ve changed My mind, but those who’re
led

To honour me, I’ll honour too,
And who despise Me, curse their crew.

31 ‘Behold, the days come, that I will
Cut off your arms, and the arm still
Of your father’s house, that there shall
Not be old man dominical.

32 ‘You’ll see a foe come in my tent,
In all of which to Israel sent,
And none of your house shall grow old
Forever. 33 ‘And the man unsold
Of yours that I’ll not cut off from
My altar shall consume the sum
Of your eyes and be grief of heart
To you and all the increase part
Of your house shall die at the start.

34 ‘And this shall be a sign to you
That shall come on your two sons due,
On Hophni and on Phinehas,
On the same day they’ll die and pass.

35 ‘And I will raise me up a priest
Faithful to do what’s in the least
Of my heart and mind, and I’ll build
Him a sure house, and he well filled
Shall walk before My anointed
For ever. 36 ‘And as things shall bid,
Every one left in your house hid
Shall come and crouch to him to beg
A piece of silver and a leg
Of bread, and shall say “Put me please
In a priest’s office that in ease
I may eat piece of bread and cheese.””

I told You so. Either the sin of sons
Of Ali is their own fault on their buns
Or their father’s fault, but You take the
blame

Of them not hearing dad’s advice for
shame,
Then don’t come criticizing Ali’s style.
It’s not fair to lay blame where there’s no
guile.

If Ali is at fault because he failed
To train his sons up right and as entailed,

Then You are faultless, my Beloved, let's
not
Fall into contradiction in the plot.
Under the umbrella of sovereignty
It seems You have made mankind
somewhat free,
Or else it's not a wise thing to make fuss
As though they had free will in omnibus.

1 Samuel 3

1 And the child Samuel served YHWH
Before Ali. The word of YHWH
Was precious in those times, there was
No open vision. 2 As one does
At that time when Ali lay down
In his bed, and his eyes in crown
Began to get dim so he could
Not see, 3 and before the lamp would
Extinguish in the house of YHWH,
Where the ark of Alohim true,
And Samuel lay down to sleep,
4 That YHWH called Samuel *from his keep*
And he answered then "Here I am."
5 He ran to Ali *at the gram*,
And said "Here I am, for you called."
And he said to him, "*I'll be bald*,
I did not call you, go to sleep."
And he went and lay down *a peep*.
6 And YHWH called one more time to say
"Samuel!" Samuel got on his way
And went to Ali, and said "Here
Am I, for once more you *appear*
To have called me." He answered *clear*,
"I did not call, my son *of cheer*,
Go and lie down again, *no fear.*"
7 Now Samuel did not yet know YHWH
Nor was YHWH's word come in his view.

So rarely does one hear Your blessed word
Calling in the night, though it once
occurred
To one sleeping beside me while I slept.
It is so rare that any Your word kept.
What might amaze me more is that the
child
Thought Ali had spoken and so ran wild
To his side, when Your word re-echoed in
The priestly house and in the priestly bin.
Ali's must have been voice more choice
than any,
Which is of course an asset to the penny
For any priest. And yet I think his voice

Must have been an occasion to rejoice.
It only shows a charismatic sound
Of sweetness is no reason and no ground.

8 And YHWH called Samuel a third time.
And he got up and went to *climb*
To Ali, and said "Here I am,
For you did call me, *it's no scam.*"
And Ali noticed YHWH had called
The child *and he was not appalled*.
9 So Ali said to Samuel "Go,
Lie down and if the calling show
Again, then you must say 'Speak, YHWH,
For Your servant is hearing You.'"
So Samuel went to bed again.
10 And YHWH came and stood by the ben
And called as at the other times
"Samuel, Samuel" then in his chimes
Samuel answered, "Speak, for Your slave
Hears as always the word You gave."
Ah, my Beloved, this must be duty's start
Not to pronounce Your name but in the
heart.
For Ali told him to say YHWH but he
When he answered answering faithfully
Left out Your name. Many who read Your
book
In reverence and every time they look
At the four letters of Your name recite
Lord God instead of pronouncing it right.
If I am bold to say Your name here now
In part at least as Jah or Huu, somehow
I beg that You hear with indulgent brow
The lisping words of love I in no row
Recite to lighten my mind and my heart.
And if not, slay me with a burning dart.

11 And YHWH said to Samuel, "Behold,
I'll do a thing in Israel *cold*,
At which both ears of everyone
That hears it shall tingle *when done*.
12 "In that dark day I shall perform
Against Ali's house all *the storm*
That I have promised, when I start
I'll make an end *of that old fart*.
13 "For I have told him I will judge
His house forever for the smudge
That he knows, because his sons made
Themselves vile and he was not paid
To restrain them. 14 "And therefore I
Have sworn to the house of Ali,

That the wickedness of the house
Of Ali shall not be by grouse
Atoned in offering's sacrifice
Forever *for his own sons' vice.*"

Shame on You, my Beloved, to tell a child
A message that would make a grown man
wild,
And knowing it would tingle every ear
From Dan to Beersheba because of fear.
The lad will hardly sleep a wink the night
After hearing such a tale and of fright.
Some people have sense to turn out the
light
Of television before children's sight
When violence comes roving on the screen.
Now You Yourself bring PG rated scene.
Beloved, think of the lad alone in dark,
And pity him at least outside the park,
And comfort him lying far off from home
And mother in his new coat and new comb.

15 And Samuel lay until the morn,
And opened the doors without scorn
Of the house of YHWH, but he feared,
Did Samuel, to show *uncut version*
To Ali of the sight's *excursion*.
16 Then Ali called Samuel and said
"Samuel, my son." And he *well-bred*
Replied, "Here I am *up from bed.*"
17 And he said "What is the thing shared
With you? Please do not hide the geared
From me, Alohim do so to
You, and more also, and if you
Hide anything from me of all
The things He said to you at call."
18 And Samuel told him everything,
And hid nothing from him in spring.
And he said "It is YHWH, let him
Do what He thinks good *or what grim.*"
And Samuel grew, and YHWH was there
With him, and of his things took care
That nothing fell on the ground *bare*.
20 And all Israel even from Dan
To Beersheba knew Samuel man
Established as prophet to YHWH.
21 And YHWH appeared again in view
In Shiloh, for YHWH had revealed
Himself to Samuel in the field
Of Shiloh by the word of YHWH.

How sweetly Ali accepts punishment

As from the kind hand of YHWH and well
meant.

Perhaps his very sweetness is the tool
That his sons used to make of him a fool.
I have seen people sweet of gentle feather
Who behind the scenes even in the best
weather

Knife the oppressed and let the bully go
To rule the playground and set up the
show.

Sweetness is just as poison as the dart
Of anger, more so, by who play the part.
Beloved, save me from sweetness, from
my own

And from the sweetness of one on the
throne.

Beloved, You only are both sweet and sour
In justice, so extend Your hand of power.

1 Samuel 4

1 The matter of Samuel came to
All Israel *and in their view*.

Now Israel went out to fight battle
Against the Philistines *like cattle*,
And pitched beside the Ebenezer,
The Philistines in Aphek's *squeezer*.

2 The Philistines in war array
Set themselves against Israel's *sway*,
And Israel was struck down before
The Philistines, and they killed more
Of the army upon the field
Than four thousand of men *in yield*.

3 And when the folk came back to camp,
The elders of Israel *in stamp*
Said "Why has YHWH struck us today
Before the Philistines in sway?"

Let's fetch the ark of covenant
Of YHWH from Shiloh *from its tent*
To us, that when it's with us found
It may save us from the foe *round.*"

4 So the folk sent to Shiloh that
They might bring from there where it sat
The ark of covenant of YHWH
Of armies who dwells *twixt the view*
Of Cherubim, and so the two
Sons of Ali, Hophni *in crew*
With Phinehas were with the ark
Of covenant of God *in park*.

5 And when the ark of covenant
Of YHWH came into the camp's *plant*,
All Israel shouted with a great
Shout so the earth shook *at the rate*.

6 And when the Philistines heard that
 Noise of the shout where they were at,
 They said "What's this noise of great shout
 In the camp of Hebrews about?"
 And they understood that the ark
 Of YHWH was in the camp *to park*.
 7 And the Philistines were afraid
 For they said "Alohim *has stayed*
 In the camp." And they said "Woe be
 To us! There's never come to be
 Such a thing before this. 8 "*Now see*
 Woe to us! Who shall save us from
 The hand of these mighty Gods come?
 These are the Gods that struck *in sum*
 The Egyptians with all the sores
 In the wilderness *and in stores*.
 9 "Be strong and play the man *at last*,
 O you Philistines *in the blast*,
 That you not be servants *to cast*
 For the Hebrews, as they have been
 To you, so up and fight like men."

Ah my Beloved, how soon the weary turn
 To You when fires of war and danger burn,
 And seek the symbol of Your presence
 when

The killing starts among the sons of men.
 But what help is an ark, a crucifix,
 A chalice or a crescent or the tricks
 Of Solomon's seal on the banners flying,
 To those wounded upon the field and
 dying?

The courage they inspire comes also to
 The pagan Philistine and heathen crew.
 Beyond the faiths that fail and fall, to You
 I lift a weary eye, and in that view
 Of nothingness, my heart lights up anew
 And turns in quiet faith from all the vying.

10 Philistines fought, and Israel
 Was laid low, and they fled *a spell*
 Every man to his tent, and *well*
 There was a most great slaughter's *knell*,
 For thirty thousand footmen fell
 From *the army of Israel*.

11 And so the ark of Alohim
 Was taken, and the two sons' *gleam*
 Of Ali, Hophni and *the cream*
 Of Phinehas were killed *by scheme*.

12 A man of Benjamin ran out
 Of the army, and came about
 To Shiloh the same day with clothes

Upon him torn, and his head shows
 The dust. 13 And when he came, behold,
 Ali was sitting on a cold
 Seat by the highway waiting news,
 For his heart trembled for the use
 Of Alohim's ark. When the man
 Came to the town and told the ban,
 All the city cried out to scan.

Beloved, I may seem lazy in the streak
 I show by sitting every morning bleak
 Beside the little road above the creek
 That used to run, but now is buried sleek,
 Below the hill covered with fir and pine,
 With sometimes single birch in white to
 shine.

It may seem that my idle hand and brow
 Deserves the chiding of the day somehow.
 But my Beloved, in stillness I wait here
 To find Your word come to my eye and
 ear.

I do not wait for ark, though blessed it be
 To contain the tables eternally
 Written upon my heart. I wait *in spe*
 For You Yourself in silence to appear.

14 And when Ali heard all the noise
 Of the crying, he said "What *poise*
 Is this tumult?" The man came quick
 And told Ali. 15 Now Ali *slick*
 Was ninety-eight years old, his eyes
 Were dim, he could not see *the prize*.

16 And the man said to Ali, "I
 Came from the army fleeing high
 Today out of the army's way."
 And he said "What is done today,
 My son?" 17 The messenger replied,
 Saying "Israel has fled beside
 The Philistine, and there's also
 A great slaughter where the folk go,
 And your two sons also are dead,
 Hophni and Phinehas *both shaken*,
 And the ark of Alohim taken."

18 And it happened, when he spoke of
 The ark of Alohim *above*,
 That he fell from the seat to back
 By the side of the gate, *alack*,
 And his neck broke and so he died,
 For he was an old man, *beside*
 He was fat. And he had been judge
 Of Israel forty years *to budge*.

19 His daughter-in-law, Phinehas'

Wife, was pregnant and near the gas
 To give birth, when she heard the news
 That Alohims ark from the pews
 Was taken, and her father-in-law
 And her husband were dead and raw,
 She bowed down and went in labour,
 For her birth pangs came upon her.
 20 And about the time of her death
 The midwives said to her, "Take breath
 Without fear, for you have a son."
 But she did not reply or note.
 21 And she named the child that was done
 Ichabod, expressing her vote,
 "The glory has departed from
 Israel," because the ark in sum
 Of Alohims was captured, and
 Because of her father-in-law
 And her husband. 22 She said in awe,
 "The glory has departed from
 Israel, for Gods ark's gone and numb."

In all this story once more there is one
 Little guessed before when the thing is
 done
 Who is the victim of the plot and reign,
 The wife at home who suffered husband's
 gain.
 Perhaps she loved the meat her husband
 took
 By force from the sacrifice in the book,
 But she could hardly have enjoyed the look
 Of those women with whom the brother lay
 About the doorway of the tent in sway.
 If You told Samuel in visions at night
 About the fornication in Your sight,
 I think You were not more hurt in the
 plight
 Than was the wife of Phinehas, whose
 fight
 Remembered only Your honour and right.

1 Samuel 5

1 Then the Philistines took the ark
 Of Alohims, brought it to park
 From Ebenezer to Ashdod.
 2 Then Philistines the ark of God
 Took and brought it into the house
 Of Dagon, set by Dagon's spouse.
 3 And when the Ashdodites got up
 Early in the morning to cup,
 See, Dagon fell down on his stumps
 Upon the ground and with great bumps,

Before the ark of YHWH. And they
 Took Dagon and set in array
 Again in his place for the day.
 4 And when they got up early on
 The next day's morning, see, Dagon
 Was fallen on his face again
 On the ground before the ark's den
 Of YHWH, and Dagon's head and hands
 Were broken off upon the sands
 Of the threshold, and only left
 Was Dagon's body's stump bereft.
 5 So that's why neither priest nor folk
 Who come into Dagon's house' stroke
 To this day step upon the place
 Of the threshold in Ashdod's trace.
 6 But the hand of YHWH was hard on
 The Ashdodites and like a pawn
 He destroyed them and struck them down
 With haemorrhoids throughout the town
 Of Ashdod and its suburbs' lawn.

The reverence for threshold dates well
 back
 To Ashdod and the haemorrhoid attack.
 I've been to where they say the threshold is
 The Kaaba and build it up high to quiz
 Who enters there to lift his leg above
 The prize of noble god and in his love.
 The centuries in Anatolian heights
 Have not diminished the tradition's rights,
 So faithful are the few despite the fights
 Against their doing such things days and
 nights.
 Ah, my Beloved, let me be faithful to
 You as those are who remember the due
 Of the sea god and fish god so far from
 The scintillating sea's palladium.

7 When the men of Ashdod saw that
 It was so, they said where they sat,
 "The ark of Israel's God shall not
 Stay with us, for His hand is hot
 Upon us and on Dagon too."
 8 And so they sent and gathered all
 The lords of the Philistines' stall
 And said to them, "What shall we do
 With the ark of Israel's God's crew?"
 And they answered, "Let Israel's God's
 Ark be carried about the sods
 Of Gath." And they carried the ark
 Of Israel's God out there to park.
 9 And it was so, that after they

Had carried it about that way,
 The hand of YHWH was on that town
 With a very great falling down,
 And he struck the men of the place,
 Both small and great, and in their race
 They had haemorrhoids you know where.
 10 So they sent the ark of God bare
 To Ekron. And it came to pass,
(In Ekron too on every ass)
 The Ekronites cried out aloud,
 Saying "They have now been allowed
 To bring the ark of Israel's God
 To us to kill us by the prod
 And our folk with us to a clod."
 11 So they sent and gathered the lords
 Of all the Philistines in hordes,
 And said "Send away the ark of
 The God of Israel from above
 And let it go to its own place,
 That it not kill us to a face,
 For there was deadly destruction
 Throughout all the city for fun,
 The hand of Alohim was great
 And heavy where every ass sate.
 12 And the men there that did not die
 Were stricken on the ass with sly
 Haemorrhoids and the city's cry
 Went up to heaven in the sky.

When You, Beloved, let loose with paddle
 well
 Planted upon the backside of the swell,
 You do not do in measure halfway done.
 You smack them good who wait beneath
 the sun.
 In Ashdod and in Gath the battle's won
 Not with the sword but with the paddle set
 Upon each backside till Ekron is met.
 This may or may not be the origin
 Of scourging delinquents for minor sin,
 But it resounds like flapping in the wind.
 You are blamed for the battle against
 finned
 Dagon and for the plagues in every land.
 So why not praise You also for the planned
 In humour that arises on the strand?

1 Samuel 6

1 The ark of YHWH was in the land
 Of Philistines seven months *at hand*.
 2 The Philistines called for the priests
 And the diviners *to their feasts*,

Saying "Whatever shall we do
 About this blessed ark of YHWH?
 Tell us how to send the thing back."
 3 And they said "If you send it back,
 The ark of Israel's Alohim,
 Do not send it back empty *dream*,
 In any case give Him offering
 For trespass, then you shall be healed
 And it shall be revealed the thing
 Why His hand *on you* remains steeled."
 4 Then they said "What trespass offering
 Should we give back to Him?" And they
 Answered, "Five golden haemorrhoids,
 And five golden mice *for tabloids*,
 One for each of Philistine lords,
 For one plague has lifted its swords
 On you and on all of your lords.
 5 "That's why you'll make images of
 Your haemorrhoids, images of
 Your mice that spoil the land, and you
 Shall give glory to Alohim
 Of Israel, that as is due
 He might take off His hand from you,
 And from your gods, and your land too.
 6 "Why do you then harden your hearts,
 As the Egyptians for their parts
 And Pharaoh hardened once their hearts,
 When He did wonders among them,
 Did they not at last for *pro tem*
 Let the people go, so they left?
 7 "Therefore make a new cart and weft,
 And take two milk cows on which there
 Has never come a yoke to bear,
 And tie the cows to the cart, and
 Bring their calves home from them *in hand*.
 8 "And take the ark of YHWH and lay
 It on the cart, and put away
 The jewels of gold, which you return
 To Him a trespass offering stern,
 In a casket beside the thing,
 And send it off to go *its ring*.
 9 "And see, if it goes up by way
 Of His own lands to Beth-shemesh,
 Then He has made us this foul mesh,
 But if not, then we'll know it's not
 His hand that strikes us on the spot,
 It was mere chance then like as not."

Ah, my Beloved, how fumbling human
 minds
 Seek to fathom the motives of Your blinds!

They're sure Your actions can be wrought
upon

By magic in similarities drawn.
And so the mice in gold and haemorrhoid
Are made to sate Your greed, and once
employed,

Become the gauge divining whether You
Sit in judgement or whether a chance flew
Across their path. There is nothing that's
new.

Today men still think of You in this light,
The source of misfortune, perhaps, or
sleight

Of chance, a hazard or a will to dance.
You can be bought, we think, by gold in
stance.

O my Beloved, save us from our own
night.

10 So that's what the men did. They took
Two milk cows and tied them to hook
Of the cart, and shut up their calves
At home. 11 And they laid out the halves
Of the ark of YHWH on the cart
And casket with the mice apart
In gold and images of their
Haemorrhoids *in it for their share*.

12 And the cows took the straightest way
To Beth-shemesh, on the highway
Lowing as they went and did not
Turn to the right hand or to plot
Of the left, and the Philistine
Lords went after them to resign
As far as the Beth-shemesh line.

13 The Beth-shemites were reaping wheat
Harvest in the valley *replete*,
And raised their eyes and saw the ark,
And rejoiced to see it *come park*.

14 And the cart came into the field
Of Joshua, Beth-shemite *peeled*,
And stopped there beside a great stone,
And they broke up the cart in loan
For wood and offered up the cows
As burnt offering as YHWH allows.

I guess the sign they chose if cows went
straight
And left their calves, it meant that You
were great,
And had destroyed the Philistines of late.
Well satisfied that priest-diviners' law
Remained a thing to keep the folk in awe,

The lords returned upon their heels in
draw.

The cows met a poor fate, I think if I
Had been a cow I would have taken shy
The road between the cities on the fly
And found a refuge in meadows nearby.
But You instead lead my steps on the row,
And I find myself in the slaughter show.
Beloved, if You wish to eat my flesh so,
It would have been more tender years ago.

15 The Levites took the ark of YHWH,
And the casket beside it drew,
In which the fine things made of gold,
And placed them on the great stone's fold,
And the men of Beth-shemish came
And offered burnt offerings in claim
And sacrificed things the same day
To YHWH *to whose rule they gave way*.

16 And when the five Philistine lords
Had seen it, they turned to rewards
In Ekron the same day. 17 And these
Are the gold haemorrhoids *to please*
Which the Philistines rendered for
A trespass offering to the store
Of YHWH, for Ashdod one and for
Gaza, one for Askelon one,
For Gath one, for Ekron one *done*.

18 And the gold mice in number of
The Philistine cities *above*
Of the five lords, of fenced towns all
And country villages *in stall*,
Even to the great Abel stone
Where they set down the ark *in throne*
Of YHWH, to this day in the field
Of Joshua, Beth-shemite *peeled*.

19 And He struck the men of Beth-
shemesh

Because they searched the ark for blemish
Of YHWH, He struck down of the folk
Fifty thousand and seventy bloke,
And the people lamented, for
YHWH had struck the folk with a sore
Slaughter. 20 And the men of Beth-
shemesh

Said "Who can stand *without a blemish*
Before this holy YHWH Alohim?
To whom shall He go up to show Him?
21 And they sent messengers to those
Who lived in Kirjath-jearim's rows,
Saying "The Philistines have brought
Back the ark of YHWH *that you sought*,

Come down and fetch it to your *plot*.

Who worshipped Dagon You struck with
sore ass

And killed a few with the plague come to
pass,

But those who offered holocausts to You,
So glad again to have Your ark in view,
You struck with death upon the righteous
pew.

How do You explain that? You seem to
think

That their knowledge of sacredness at wink
Should have kept them more reverent of
Your box.

That only shows You do not know Your
flocks.

The sense of sacred itself is no proof
Of righteousness, witness Dagon aloof.
Besides, that sense is dependent upon
The temporal lobes, not glory that shone.
You've got Your rights, don't listen to my
spoof.

1 Samuel 7

1 The men of Kirjath-jearim came
And fetched the ark of YHWH for claim,
And brought it into the house of
Abinadab on hill above,
And sanctified Eleazar who
Was his son to keep ark of YHWH.

2 It happened while the ark was there
In Kirjath-jearim that the share
Of time was long, for it was twenty
Years, all Israel's house was laments
After YHWH. 3 And then Samuel spoke
To all the house of Israel *woke*,
Saying "If you return unto
YHWH with all your hearts what you do,
Then put away the strange gods *too*
And Ashtaroth from among you,
And then prepare your hearts to YHWH,
And worship Him only and He
Will deliver you from the hand
Of the Philistines *in the land*."

4 And so Israel's folk put away
Baalim and Ashtaroth from sway,
And worshipped YHWH only *each day*.

5 And Samuel said "Let all the folk
Of Israel gather at a stroke
In Mizpeh, and I'll pray for you
To YHWH. 6 Come to Mizpeh they drew

Water, and poured it before YHWH
And fasted that day and said there,
"For we have sinned against YHWH's
share."

And Samuel judged Israel's folk there
In Mizpeh. 7 When the Philistines
Heard that Israel's folk for combines
Gathered together at Mizpeh,
The lords of Philistines for fray
Went up against Israel. And when
The folk of Israel heard it, then
They were scared of Philistine men.

Note well, Beloved, how every time a
choice

Is made in Your favour to praise with voice
Repenting of the wrong done to Your law,
There's some authority plagued to the raw
To come up with police force on the draw.
There are three things allowed where
crowds may be,

And four at last may count on leniency:
The crowd to gyrate at rock music's spell,
The crowd to stampede at the sportsman's
knell,

The crowd to celebrate the choice of leader
Of the corrupt state, and the crowd that's
sent

To deal death on the armies of the spent.
Beloved, I stop to recite Your name here
Alone, crowd would be illegal, I fear.

8 So the children of Israel said
To Samuel, "Do not stop the dread
Appeal to YHWH our Alohim
On our behalf, to come on scene
And save us from the Philistine.

9 And Samuel took a suckling lamb
And offered a burnt offering's ham
Completely to YHWH, and Samuel
Cried to YHWH then for Israel,
And YHWH heard him. 10 As Samuel
Offered up the burnt offering well,
The Philistines came near to fight
Against Israel, but YHWH for spite
Thundered with a great thunder sound
On that day on Philistines round,
And frightened them and they were struck
Down before Israel to the muck.

11 And the men of Israel went out
Of Mizpeh, and pursued the rout
Of Philistines, and struck them down

Until they came to Beth-car's town.
12 Then Samuel took a stone and set
It between Mizpeh and Shen yet,
And called its name Eben-ezer,
Saying "Till now YHWH's helped us stir."

Let this be warning to the army sent
To pillage village, town, and tenement,
That such excursions for the guilt they set
Upon the mind of those out on the bet
Sometimes end in disaster when the sound
Of thunder happens to hit on the ground.
It's best to stay still at home and forget
Vengeance or plaguing others on the
round.

It may be a dream of the faithful few
Who do not raise a weapon on the crew
That You will come to rescue with ado.
But then one never knows when the
nightmare
Instead will fall upon the armies where
They blotch with blood the street, the
porch and stair.

13 So the Philistines were subdued
And came no more among the brood
Of Israel, and the hand of YHWH
Was against the Philistines' crew
All the days of Samuel. 14 *As due*
The cities the Philistines took
From Israel, *Philistines* forsook
Back to Israel, from Ekron to
Gath, as well as the suburbs *too*
Did Israel take back from the hands
Of the Philistines, *all those lands*.
And there was peace between Israel
And the Amorites *for that spell*.
15 And Samuel judged Israel all of
The days of his life *in his love*.
16 And he went around every year
To Beth-el, Gilgal *to appear*
At Mizpeh, and he judged Israel
In all those places *for a spell*.
17 And at last he returned to Ramah,
Where he had a house there *to claim her*,
And there he judged Israel and there
He built an altar to YHWH's *share*.

The circuit riding preacher first to go
Around the country was Samuel to show
Your faith and judgement to the country
folk

From Dan to Beersheba and under oak.
Perhaps not quite so far if story's true
That Samaritans tell about the rue
Of faction that arose in Ali's time
Because of his two evil sons in rhyme.
Samuel could not knit back the people
broken
In camps regarding Hophni's sins
unspoken
And Phinehas' lying in wait to rape
The women bringing sacrifice of grape
And flour and meat. Beloved, what men do
here
Creates enmity for many a year.

1 Samuel 8

1 It happened when Samuel was old
He made his sons judges and bold
Over Israel. 2 Now the name of
His eldest son was Joel for love,
And the name of his second told
Was Abiah, and they judged in
Beersheba, *but not without sin*.
3 His sons did not walk in his ways,
But turned aside for wealth and praise,
And took bribes and perverted justice.
4 Elders as numerous *as dust is*
In Israel came in a crowd,
To Samuel in Ramah *allowed*.
5 They said to him, "See, you are old,
And your sons do not act as told,
Now make us a king to judge us
Like all the nations without fuss.

Like all anarchists I too love the kings
That rule the nations round and round in
rings.
And I can understand the human way
Of escaping from injustice's day.
The judges of my city also take
Their bribes from insurance companies'
stake.
Though parliament may fight them with a
bill,
They always find a way to ignore till.
Justice does not come easy as the case
Of Samuel found to his own grief's
disgrace.

He saw what happened to Ali's sons once,
And he took lesson from it not a dunce,
And still they turned out evil. Hear my
prayer,

I discipline myself, and still foreswear.

6 But the thing displeased Samuel when
They said "Give as a king of men
To judge us." And Samuel prayed YHWH.

7 And YHWH said to Samuel, "Now do
Listen to the folk's voice in all
They tell you, for they do not stall
Rejecting you, but they in thrall
Reject Me, that I should not reign
Over them. 8 "By the works in vain
That they've done since the day I brought
Them up from Egypt to this plot,
By which they have forsaken Me
And worshipped other gods in fee,
So are they doing to you too.

9 "So listen to their voice and do,
But protest solemnly to them,
And show them kingly stratagem
In reigning as king over them."
10 And Samuel told the people what
YHWH said when they begged him to strut
A king before them. 11 And he said,
"This is how the king that is led
To rule you will do, he will take
Your sons and set them for his stake,
For chariots and his horsemen,
And run before his chariots then.
12 "And he will set him captains by
Thousands, and over fifties nigh,
And make them plant his ground with
sighs,

And reap his harvest, enterprise
Them to construct weapons of war,
And vessels of chariots in store.
13 "And he will take your daughters too
As pastry-makers and cooks too,
And bakers. 14 "And he'll take your fields,
And your vineyards, and olive yields,
The best of all to give his slaves.

15 "He'll take the tenth of your seed's
waves,
And of your vineyards, and give them
To his officers as a gem,
And to his servants at his hem.

16 "And he will take your menservants,
And your maidservants as they dance,
And your best young men and your
donkeys,

And set them to work as his honkeys.
17 "He will take the tenth of your sheep,
And you will be his servants creep.

18 "And you'll cry out in that day for
Your king which you'll have chosen tore,
And YHWH will not hear you that day,
Because you rejected His sway."

So far as I can see You took already
Their best to be Your likely servants
steady,
The priests and Levites at Your loving call,
The sheep and goats, the fatted calf in stall,
The flour and wine in sacrifice and all.
So what's a king beyond what You
required?
Rather than absolute sovereign desired,
Perhaps they thought a human king would
be
Easier to replace than what You see
In furtive fornication with the gods
And goddesses of Canaan in their pods.
Beloved, when taxes are required to set
Either a lot or little, they are met.
If You dispense with sacrifice, You're pet.

19 But the people refused to hear
The voice of Samuel, and they jeer,
"No, but we'll have a king appear,
20 "So we can be like all the rest
Of the nations, and our king best
May judge us, and go out before
Us and fight our battles in war."
21 And Samuel heard all that they said,
And he told YHWH their words instead.
22 And YHWH said to Samuel, "Hear now
Their voice and make them a king's row."
And Samuel said to Israel's men,
"Go everyone to his own glen."

The matter was not really concern for
Injustice, but the desire to restore
Conformity, to be like those around
In having the same figure and the sound.
They did not want a king to make things
just,

But rather to be like the ones they trust.
Not principle but fashion took the day.
In that the people then were like the way
People still love to have the running play.
Save me, Beloved, from my own will to be
Like neighbour in delusion for a pea.
Be my king and no other give to me,
Neither the democratic chosen fair
Nor priest nor scientist from anywhere.

1 Samuel 9

1 There was a man of Benjamin
Whose name *was* Kish the son *to win*
Of Abiel, son of Zeror,
The son of Bechorath *before*,
The son of Aphiah, who was
A Benjamite, a man who does
Great feats. 2 He had a son whose name
Was Saul, a young man of acclaim,
And fine, and there was not among
The folk of Israel a man hung
Better than he, from his shoulders
And upward taller than the fers
Of all the people. 3 And the donkeys
Of Kish Saul's father *on the tonkeys*
Were lost. And Kish said to his son
Saul, "Take now of the servants one
With you and get up and go find
The donkeys. 4 And they were *inclined*
To go through Mount Ephraim and pass
Through the land of Shalisha's *grass*,
But they did not find them, then they
Went through the land of Shalim's *way*,
Without a sight, and he passed through
The land of the Benjamite *crew*,
But they did not *find any stray*.
5 When they arrived in land of Zuph,
Saul said to his servant in proof
Who was with him, "Come, let's go back,
So my father for donkey's lack
Will not worry about our track."
6 And he answered him, "Listen, there
Is in this city a man fair
Of Alohim, and he's a great
Man, all he says will meet its fate,
So let's go there, perhaps he can
Show us our way and give a plan."

Some smile today that anyone should make
A fuss to You above for donkeys' sake.
The riotous look for the changes in
Your Word to find excuse to follow sin
Because a number comes faintly across
With the wrong addition or the wrong loss.
The rules for washing change from year to
year,

And usury brings no consistent tear,
The calendar is most imperfect here,
And mint and anis distractions appear.
But one thing like a red and golden thread

Runs through the Scriptures from the tale
to head,
And that is the concern for donkeys'
health.
Let human heart ponder in hard, cold
wealth.

7 Then Saul said to his servant man,
"But look, if we go, what shall we
Bring the man, for our bread in fee
Is used up in our packs, and there
Is not a present here to share
With the man of Alohim, what
Do we have here to fill his glut?"
8 And the servant told Saul again,
Saying "Look, I have here a yen,
The fourth part of a silver shekel,
I'll give that to the man in meckle,
To tell us our way *home again*."
9 In times past in Israel when one
Went to inquire of Alohim,
He'd say "Come let's go down for fun
To the seer." For now it would seem
That's what a prophet was times past
Called, seer. 10 Then Saul said to his man
Servant, "Well said, come let's by plan
Go." So they went into the city
Where Alohim's man sat in pity.

The oracle in every land and town
Requires a bit of silver be set down.
And every servant and each prince that
comes
Adds to the temple and the priestly sums.
You are alone, Beloved, in my country
To hold a saintly service' liturgy
Without the offering plate, without the
score
Of writing out the checks at entrance door.
I must pay dues to enter synagogue,
And give zakat to satisfy the cog
That runs the mosque, and churchly friars
seek
Remuneration for each passing week.
Beloved, You only whisper on the air
Without sending a bill for my welfare.

11 As they went up the hill before
The city, they found out of door
Young girls going out to fetch water,
And said to them, *each maid and daughter*,
"Is this the place the seer is found?"

12 They told them saying "He's around,
 And look in front of you and hurry,
 Because today he came with flurry
 To the city, and there will be
 A public sacrifice and free
 At the high place, *just come and see.*
 13 "As soon as you come in the town
 You'll find him before he goes down
 To the high place to eat, because
 The people will not turn their paws
 To food before he comes, because
 He it is who will come to bless
 The sacrifice, and then address
 The invited to come and eat.
 So get a move on, *don't retreat,*
 For about this time in the street
 You'll find him *whether sun or sleet.*"
 14 And they went up into the town
 And when they came into the town,
 See, Samuel came out to meet them
 Going up to the high place *hem.*
 15 Now YHWH had whispered in the ear
 Of Samuel just the day before
 Saul would arrive and would appear,
 Saying 16 "Tomorrow by this score
 About this same time I will send
 To you a man out of the end
 Of Benjamin's land, and you must
 Anoint him captain in the trust
 Of My folk Israel, that he may
 Save My folk out of hand and way
 Of Philistines, for I have seen
 My people, that their cry is keen."
 17 When Samuel saw Saul, then YHWH
 said
 To him, "Look at the man I led
 Speaking of him to you, this one
 Shall reign over my folk when done."
 18 Saul drew near Samuel in the gate,
 And said "Please tell me, *don't be late,*
 Where *is* the seer's house *and gate?*"
 19 And Samuel answered Saul and said
 "I *am* the seer. Go up *led*
 Before me to the high place, for
 You'll eat with me today *and more,*
 Tomorrow then I'll let you go
 And all that's in your heart I'll show.
 20 "But as for your donkeys that were
 Lost three days since, do not incur
 Anxiety for them, be sure
 They have been found. But from whom
 does

Israel expect Muhammad's *laws?*
Is it not from you and from all
 Your father's house *by divine call?*"

The longing heart awaited year on year,
 And centuries passed by in hope and fear,
 While faithful ones desired and kept alive
 The hope that he would come and he
 would strive
 In the right path. And so all Israel
 Looked for the one on whom the balance
 fell.

Did Saul believe that he would live to be
 Muhammad, the Desired, and did he see
 Beyond the hopes and dreams that he
 would fail

To lead the people from behind the veil
 And through the Scriptures into perfect
 ways?

Or did the Seer see beyond the days
 And centuries to come, Beloved, to when
 A voice inspired would cantillate again?

21 And Saul answered and said "Am not
 I Benjamite and of the lot
 The smallest of Israel's tribes and
 My family the least to stand
 Of the families in the tribe
 Of Benjamin? Why now subscribe
 To such a speech to me at hand?"

22 And Samuel took Saul and his slave
 And brought them into the lodge nave,
 And made them sit in the chief place
 Among the best invited race,
 About thirty with numbered face.

23 And Samuel told the cook, "Now bring
 The portion I put under wing,
 Of which I told you, 'Save the thing.'"

24 So the cook took the shoulder and
 The meat upon it, set at hand
 Of Saul. Samuel started to say
 "Here is what's left, take it as prey
 Before you, eat, since to this time
 Has it been saved for you in prime,
 Since I said I called folk to dine."
 So that day Saul ate with *the fine*
 Samuel, *both sacrifice and wine.*

I enter the lodge where the forty sit
 And brave the lion, guardian of it,
 And bow before the chief place, turn
 around

And whirl and whirl upon that slaughter
ground.

The elect on their sheepskins smile and
frown

To see my flying feet dusty and brown,
And how I pinch a piece of meat as I
Go past the sacrificial pot to die.
Beloved, Saul hardly knew the sacred tune,
Nor did he guess his fate beyond his boon.
So I sing with the gladness of my heart,
Not guessing any of tomorrow's part.
The sun rises and sets upon the meal
The forty enjoy with a dashing heel.

25 And when they were coming down from
The high place to the city *drum*,
He talked to Saul on the housetop.

26 They got up early *from their flop*,
It happened as the dawn arose,
Samuel called Saul to a roof pose,
Saying "Get up so I may send
You out upon your way to wend."
And Saul got up and they went out,
Both he and Samuel about.

27 As they arrived at city end
Samuel told Saul, "Tell servant friend
To go on before us," and he
Went on in front. "Now you stand free
And I'll show you God's word freely."

It seems, Beloved, that You're too shy to
speak
To more than one human upon a peak.
The prophets always claim You came to
seek

In vision or in dream where none could see
Your coming or hear Your still voice and
wee.

Even on Mount Sinai in thunder's fear
When You once before all the crowd
appear,

You still speak to the one in singular.
For You there is no shoutful crowd and
star,
But only one heart lifted to Your word.
You speak always to one heart when it's
stirred

And leave the congregation in the lurch.
You do not seem to think much of the
church
Nor of the lodge of forties on their perch.

1 Samuel 10

1 Then Samuel took a flask of oil
And poured *it* on his head *for toil*,
And kissed him and said "*Is it not*
Because YHWH's anointed your lot
To be commander of His plot?
2 "When you've left me today, you'll find
Two men by Rachel's tomb behind
The land of Benjamin at Zelzah,
And they'll say to you what compels you,
'The donkeys which you went to find
Have been found. Now your dad's resigned
Of worry for the donkeys' case
And worrying about your chase,
Saying "What shall I do about
My son?"' 3 "Then you shall go on out
From there, and come to Tabor's plain,
Where you will meet three men *in train*
Going up to Beth-el to God,
One carrying three kids in prod,
Another carrying three loaves
Of bread, the third toting *for troves*
A bottle of grape juice. 4 And they
Will greet you and give you *for pay*
Two of the loaves of bread which you
Shall receive from their hands *in due*.
5 "Afterward you'll come to the hill
Of Alohim, where is the grill
Of Philistines' fort, and it will
Happen when you come to the city
You'll meet a band of prophets giddy
Coming down from the high place with
A lute and drum, a pipe of wythe,
And harp and they shall prophesy.
6 "The spirit of YHWH shall be nigh
On you, and you shall prophesy
With them, turned to another man.
7 "Let it be when these signs in plan
Come on you, do what comes to hand,
Since Alohim is your command.

Conversion to Taoism is a thing
Not often found upon the early ring.
It is a faith or lack thereof that most
Are born into that enter on that coast.
Yet my soul quietist, Molinos' pride,
Does what comes to my hand close by my
side.

I never travel upstream with an oar
To find the grail upon a distant shore.
I find Your treasures where the lyre is
tuned

To Scripture where I always have
 communed
With Your voice on the map of psaltery.
I find the downstream flowing by decree
Is filled with notes of bird and sophistry.
I take what's in my hand and at my door.

8 "And you'll go down before Gilgal
And see I'll come to you with sal
To offer burnt offerings and make
Peace offerings, for seven days' sake
You'll wait until I come to you
To tell you what it is you'll do."
9 It happened when he turned his back
To go from Samuel, on his track
Alohim gave him a new heart,
That day all those signs played their part.
10 And when he came there to the hill,
See, a band of reciters still
Met him, and Alohim's breath came
Strongly on him and without blame
He cantillated just the same.
11 It happened when those who knew him
Before saw that he there with vim
Among the prophets sang, the folk
Said everyone to other bloke,
"What's this that happened to the son
Of Kish? Is Saul also for fun
Cantillating by prophet's *pun*?"
12 And one of them answered and said
"Who is the father who has bred
Him?" And that's why it became said
"Is Saul among the prophets fled?"
13 When he finished reciting Word
Of Scripture, to high place he stirred.

The schools of prophets in that ancient day
When Saul came out to sing and dance and
 play,
Taught young men to sing with the breath
 of God
The cryptic Scriptures in the Hebrew pod.
Saul sang the words that David later filled
With Your spirit when with the sheep he
 trilled
The songs of Moses and Miriam abroad
To find today yesterday's manna's way.
Beloved, I cantillate the words that made
Their way from Saul's parched singing
 throat and stayed
To echo on the burnt hills of the land
Of Canaan by the gold and silver sand.

The tinkling of the lyre rings in my ear
As I come singing to You without fear.

14 Saul's uncle asked him and his slave,
"Where did you go?" And they were brave
To say "To look for donkeys where
We got lost, so we made repair
To Samuel." And Saul's uncle said
"Tell me, please, what Samuel was led
To say to you." 16 And Saul replied
To his uncle, "Can be relied
On that the donkeys have been found."
But what Samuel said of the plot
Of kingdom, that thing he told not.
17 Then Samuel summoned all the folk
Before YHWH at Mizpeh by *oak*,
18 And to children of Israel spoke
"So says YHWH Israel's Alohim,
'I brought up Israel from the *stream*
Of Egypt, rescued from the hand
Of Pharaoh king of Egypt's *land*,
And from all kings oppressing you.
19 'And you've this day rejected YHWH,
Who is Himself your Saviour true
From your calamities' distresses,
And you said "No, but *it impresses*
To have a king set over us,""
Now come before YHWH's *radius*
In all your tribes and thousands *plus*."
20 So Samuel brought near all the tribes
Of Israel, and *without bribes*
The tribe of Benjamin took lot.
21 He brought Benjamite tribe in plot
By their families, and the clan
Of the Matrites rose as by plan,
And Saul the son of Kish was taken,
Though he could not be found *unshaken*
When they looked for him *unmistaken*.
22 That's why they asked YHWH once
 again,
"Will the man step up *among men*?"
And YHWH replied, "See, he is hidden
Among the stuff *when he was bidden*."

Beloved, I seek You on the faded hill,
The scrupulous pines hide no help or bill,
Your form elated by the firs is still
Invisible to me who seek Your gate.
No footprint spoils the lichen patterns
 wrought
Upon the granite boulders that have caught

The dawn light from the silver lakeside
spot
Where sun appears above the forest grate.
You shyly hide among the baggage and
The warehouses filled with cement and
sand.

Your shadow nearly gives a fleeting clue
To promise once again a divine view.
Beloved, I find You without form or state
Where I just abandoned You to be late.

23 And they ran and took him from there,
And when he stood among the fair,
He was taller than any of
The folk, head and shoulders above.

24 And Samuel said to all the folk
“Look at the one YHWH’s put in yoke,
That there is none like him among
All the people?” And every tongue
Shouted and said “Long live the king.”

25 And Samuel told the folk the thing
Of the kingdom, wrote in a book,
And set it up before YHWH’s nook.

Samuel sent all the folk away,
Each man to his own house *to stay*.
26 And Saul too went to his own house
In Gibeah, in warrior’s blouse
Went behind him the men whose hearts
God had touched *to play valiant parts*.

27 But vulgar fellows said of him,
“Who is this man to save us grim?”
And they despised him and brought no
Gifts, but he ignored wicked show.

Sons of Belial it would seem came out
To make sport of the king You set with
clout.

They thought themselves wise and without
a doubt

Loyal to You, Beloved, and King and
Lord.

Samuel with heavy heart was made accord
To crown a king for hearts of unrestored,
But once the thing was done, it seems a
show

Of fancy to refuse to make a go.
Your only word was sent on Sinai once,
And if I take another, I’m a dunce.
And yet the powers that be claim loyalty
Though I would rather live with You and
free.

Beloved, I bow to what must curse the
earth,
And yet I see that You alone are worth.

1 Samuel 11

1 Then Nahash the Ammonite came
And camped by Jabesh-gilead’s claim,
And all the Jabesh men said to
Nahash, “Make us a treaty true
And we will serve you *as our due*.”

2 Nahash the Ammonite told them,
“These are the terms of stratagem
By which I’ll make it with you, all
Your right eyes shall be struck with awl,
Reproach I’ll lay on Israel.”

3 The elders of Jabesh told him,
“Give us seven days’ respite for whim
To send messengers to the coasts
Of all of Israel if in boasts
There is none to save us, then we
Will come out *and serve you for free*.”

4 The messengers came to Saul’s place
In Gibeah, and spoke this trace
In hearing of the folk, and all
The people lifted voice in call
And wept. 5 And see, Saul came up from
The field following frolicsome
Oxen, and Saul said “What is wrong
With the people who weep *so long*?”
And they told him the words the men
Of Jabesh were speaking *again*.

6 The spirit of YHWH in its might
Came on Saul when he heard the plight
Of those words and his anger rose
Kindled greatly because of those.

7 And so he took an oxen yoke
And cut them in pieces by stroke
And sent them throughout all the lands
Of Israel by messenger hands,
Saying “The one who does not come
After Saul and Samuel’s a bum,
So shall they do his ox in sum.”
And YHWH’s dread fell on all the folk,
And they came out as in one stroke.

It seems, Beloved, that in this place of
fears,
There is no chance to escape shedding
tears.

Either the right eye must be given to
The one who holds the cannon and the
crew,

Or else one has to go out to the war
To fight with club and claw on bloody
shore.

This may or may not be result that they
Set up a king to move them to the prey.
When You alone rule on the earth, it seems
There also come up brigands from my
dreams.

Beloved, the armies still stand in array
With tanks of depleted uranium
To kill for centuries the prince and bum.
Show us, Beloved, another, better way.

8 He counted them in Bezek then
Israel's three hundred thousand men,
Judah's thirty thousand again.

9 They said to the messengers come,
"Say to Jabesh-gilead's sum,
'Tomorrow when the sun is hot
You will all be saved from the plot.'"
And the messengers came and told
The men of Jabesh glad *and bold*.

10 And the men of Jabesh then said
"Tomorrow we'll come out as led
To you, and you may do with us
What seems good to your animus."

11 It happened on the next day Saul
Divided the folk all in all
In three groups, and they came into
The middle of the camp at dew
Of morning watch, attacked the men
Of Ammon till the heat rose then
On the day, and it came to pass
The remnant were scattered *like grass*,
Till no two remained in one class.

12 The people said to Samuel, "Who
Has said that Saul shall not reign due
Over us? Bring the men so we
May slaughter them *for making free*."

13 And Saul said "None shall die today,
For on this day YHWH's given way
Delivering Israel *in the fray*."

14 And Samuel told the people, "Come,
Let's go to Gilgal *venturesome*
And there we'll renew the kingdom."

15 And all the folk went to Gilgal,
And there they made Saul king and pal,
And there they offered meat offerings
And peace offerings before YHWH's
springs,

There Saul and all the people joyed,
Rejoicing greatly *while employed*.

Septuagint doubles the number for
The warriors out to even up the score,
And adds ten thousand to Judah to boot
Before they go out to thrust and to shoot.
And after every man had slung his sling
And bound his tortured arrows on the
wing,

The lust to kill turned round to greet the
few

Who had not kept Saul king in mind and
view.

Beloved, You show Yourself
magnanimous

To wicked and to scornful among us.
The double regiment does not detract
From Your glory, nor does a king not
sacked.

I much prefer Your salvation without
An army, a battalion and a scout.

1 Samuel 12

1 Said Samuel to all Israel,
"See I have heard your voice a spell
In all you told me, and I've set
A king over you *not to fret*."

2 "Now see, the king goes before you,
And I am old, grey-headed too,
Indeed my sons are before you,
And I've gone before you from youth
Until this day, *to tell the truth*."

3 "Here I am, raise a witness up
Against me before YHWH and *tup*
Of His anointed, for whose ox
Have I taken, or donkey's *stocks*,
Or whom have I oppressed in fraud
With bribe to blind my eyes *roughshod*?
Bear witness against me *as should*,
Bear witness and I'll made it good."

4 They said to Samuel, "You have not
Defrauded us, oppressed or sought
Anything from any man's hand."

5 Samuel said to the people's band,
"YHWH's witness against you today,
And His anointed's witness say
That you have not found anything
In my hand, *store, under my wing*."
They said "He's witness *to the thing*."

6 And Samuel told the folk, and said
"YHWH's witness that made Moses led
And Aaron, who brought up instead
Your fathers from Egypt's land's bed.

7 “So now stand still that I may plead
Before YHWH for each righteous deed
Of YHWH with you which He did to
You and to your fathers *in crew*.”

If anyone stood up today and said
He would restore whatever had been bled,
I trow a thousand false witnesses could
Rise up to take his bank account and wood.
The sharks are ready to come to the spoil
And care not for the truth for wicked toil.
The ones ready to kill the opposition
Before election for royal position
Were also truthful when pressed for assent.
Beloved, if I could live in that fair tent
Instead of on the fields of lies and shows
Where law of jungle is renowned and goes
By name of survival of fittest bloke.
Beloved, archbishops join kings in the
soak.

8 “When Jacob came to Egypt’s land,
With his sons humbled by that band,
Your fathers lifted voice to YHWH,
And YHWH sent Moses *without shoe*
And Aaron, who brought out your fathers
From Egypt and from all their pothers
To live in this place *that’s in view*.

9 “They forgot YHWH their Alohim,
Who gave them over to the scheme
Of Sisera, the army’s chief
Of Hazor and *without relief*
Into the power of Philistine,
And in Moab’s king’s hand to *whine*,
Who fought against them tooth and tine.
10 “And they cried out to YHWH and said
‘We’ve sinned because we’ve not been led
By YHWH, and have served Baalim
And Ashtaroth, but now redeem
Us from the power of enemy,
And we’ll serve only You freely.’”

When shall the princes of unholy oak
Who lash upon the world atomic stroke
And poison Baghdad and Basra with dust
Of radioactivity that must
Kill for millennia, when shall they say
They’ve been worshipping Baalim every
day
And trusting in the shameful Ashtaroth
Like the vile Hun and busy Visigoth?
Beloved, when Methodists can see the light

That killing is satanic way to fight,
And repent of their sin, then I shall flee
With them to You in praise for Your
decree.

But now send Sisera with sword in hand
Without a Jael to save the contraband.

11 “YHWH sent Jerubbaal and Bedan,
And Jephthah, Samuel, save as can
You from the power of enemy
On every side to live safely.

12 “And when you saw Nahash the king
Of Ammonites come on the wing
Against you, you said to me, ‘No,
But we shall have a king for show,’
When YHWH your Alohim was king.

13 “Now see the king whom you have
chosen,

Requested *with his golden hosen*,
And see, YHWH’s made him be your king.

14 “If you’ll fear YHWH, and serve Him,
and

Obeys His voice and not in band
Rebel against YHWH and command,
Both you and also reigning king
To follow YHWH your Alohim,

15 “But if you’ll not obey the scheme
Of YHWH’s voice, but rebel and sing
Against YHWH’s commandment, then
shall

YHWH’s hand be against your corral
And against your fathers *in ring*.

16 “So stand still and see this great thing
That YHWH’ll do before your eyes sting.

17 “Is it not wheat harvest today?

I will call to YHWH that He may
Send thunder and rain, so you’ll know
And see your wickedness to grow,
That you have done before YHWH’s eye
In asking for a king to vie.”

A simple rain-maker, Samuel would stand
To use his powers to satisfy demand
Of disappointment in his savage heart.
As rain-maker, he knows to play his part.
A king you want? Then take the thunder
sound

That rises from my dancing feet on ground,
My rattle and my drum, the arrow shot
Toward the sun to see what you begot
In kings to pace the palace’s glass floor.
Beloved, I wait for rain above the roar

Of thunder on the sounds of Sinai's hill.
Send rain today, tomorrow send the bill.
The troubled, weeping sky calls once an
halt
To the unmindful rush of foot and fault.

18 And Samuel called to YHWH, and
YHWH
Sent thunder and rain on the crew
That day, and all the peopled feared
Greatly YHWH and Samuel *appeared*.
19 And all the folk told Samuel,
“Pray for your servants *and a spell*
To YHWH your Alohim, that we
Not die, for we've added to all
Our sins this wickedness in stall
In asking for a king's *decree*.
20 And Samuel told the folk, “Don't be
Afraid, despite iniquity,
Just don't turn from following YHWH,
And serve YHWH with all your heart *true*.
21 “And do not turn aside to go
After the gods of a vain show
Who cannot profit nor save you,
For they are a vain thing to view.
22 “For YHWH will not forsake His folk
For His great name's sake *at a stroke*,
Because it has pleased YHWH to make
You a people for His own sake.
23 “As for me, far be it from me
To sin against YHWH and freely
By ceasing for your *hope* to pray,
But I'll teach you the good, right way.
24 “Only fear YHWH, serve Him in truth
With all your heart, and think forsooth
What great things He's done for your
couth.
25 “But if you still do wickedly,
Then you shall be consumed debris,
Both you and your king dominie.”

The rain-maker threatens the folk with fire
To consume them before Your fragrant ire.
He begs the people to serve You in truth,
Both beggar, king, old crone and slender
youth.
He knows the human heart would rather
cry

To vanities below a leaden sky,
Than step out of illusion's veil and try
The ecstasies of divine and sweet tooth.
Beloved, illusion under which You made

Experiment in dibble stick and spade
Attaches to the vanity in bloom
And leads the soul into its dour dark doom.
Only the brave exception in the room
Is able to rise up to meet the grade.

1 Samuel 13

1 Son of a year Saul sat on throne,
Two years he reigned on Israel's *stone*.
2 And Saul chose him three thousand men
Of Israel, two thousand again
Were with Saul in Michmash and in
The mount of Beth-el, and a bin
Were with Jonathan in the place
Of Gibeath-benjamin to trace,
And the rest of the folk he sent
Every man into his own tent.
And Jonathan attacked the fort
Of Philistine in Geba's *court*,
And Philistines heard the report.
Saul blew the horn through all the land,
Saying “Let Hebrews hear *command*.”
4 All Israel heard it said that Saul
Had attacked the Philistines' stall,
And Israel had made himself stink
Before Philistines on the brink.
The folk were gathered in corral
After Saul as far as Gilgal.
5 The Philistines came up to fight
With Israel, chariots in sight
Thirty thousand, and six thousand
Horsemen, and people like the sand
Upon the seashore in their count,
And they came up and set their mount
In Michmash before Beth-aven.
6 When the sight came to Israel's men
That they were in a strait, for then
The people were distressed, the folk
Hid themselves in caves, under oak
Thickets, and in rocks and in ditch,
And in pits, *hiding at the pitch*.
7 Some of the Hebrews had gone on
Over the Jordan to the dawn
Of Gad and Gilead, but Saul,
He was still in Gilgal in stall,
And all the people followed him
Trembling *before the danger grim*.

The reason I do not hide in a cave
Or ditch and tremble like a coward slave
Is not that there's no danger here to brave,
But that I fail to understand the wave

Of evil that swells up upon my shore
 In democratic lobbying on floor
 Of parliament. I cannot believe quite
 That illusions can overcome the right.
 The wise tremble and shake before the
 gloom
 Of market prices spelling out the doom
 Of war, while I in simple gratitude
 Welcome the spring and winter in their
 feud
 For melting off or doubling up the ice
 That dangles from my roof in crystal
 splice.

8 He waited seven days, as long
 As Samuel had given song,
 But Samuel did not appear at
 Gilgal, and all the folk went scat.
 9 And Saul said "Bring the burnt offering
 And the peace offerings here to sing."
 And he offered the burnt offering.
 10 What do you know, but soon as he
 Finished burning the offering's fee,
 That Samuel arrived, and Saul went
 Out to meet him, to greet content.
 10 And Samuel said "What have you
 done?"

And Saul said "Because on the run
 The people scattered from me here,
 And you did on time appear,
 And the Philistines came to war
 At Michmash *like sand on the shore*,
 12 Therefore I said 'Now they will come,
 The Philistines down on my bum
 To Gilgal, and I've not yet done
 Entreating YHWH's favour and won,
 I forced myself therefore to do
 The burnt offering *before the crew*.'"
 13 And Samuel said to Saul, "The thing
 You did is foolish, by *the sting*
Of my command you have not done
What YHWH commanded under sun
 For you to do, for YHWH indeed
 Would have confirmed and to your seed
 The kingdom over Israel
 Forever and a longer spell.
 14 "But now your kingdom shall not stay,
 YHWH's sought a man of His own way,
 And YHWH has ordered him chief over
 His people, because you *a rover*
 Have not kept what YHWH had to say."

I wait for You, Beloved, along the days
 Of the whole week and through the
 struggling maze
 Of business on the cobbled market-place.
 I wait for You, Beloved, before Your face.
 But You do not appear, I see no trace
 Of deity above the city waste.
 There is no form where You can be
 encased,
 No likeness, no, nor light that can be flung
 Across the blackened gulf of sirens sung.
 Beloved, let me not lift a sacrifice,
 Nor say a prayer against my foe in trice,
 But wait for Your appearing on the blast
 Of silence in the treetops and aghast
 Among the crocuses spearing the ice.

15 And Samuel got up and went out
 From Gilgal to the place of rout
 In Gibeath-benjamin. And
 Saul counted the folk who made stand
 With him, about six hundred men.
 16 And Saul, and Jonathan his son,
 And the people not on the run,
 Stayed with them in the fortress town
 Of Gibeath-benjamin's frown,
 But Philistines encamped about
 Michmash *to hold the folk in rout*.
 17 And raiders came out of the camp
 Of Philistines in three groups' clamp.
 One band turned on the road that goes
 To Ophrah where Shual's land rose,
 18 The other turned Beth-horon's way,
 The third turned by the road away
 To the border that looks down on
 The valley of Zeboim drawn
 Toward the wilderness *at dawn*.
 19 Now there was no smith found
 throughout
 All the land of Israel devout,
 For the Philistines' in their fears
 Said "Lest the Hebrews make them spears
 Or swords." 20 But all the Israelites
 Went down to the Philistines' sites
 To sharpen every man his plough,
 His coulter, axe, and mattock now.
 21 The price of filing was a pim
 For mattocks, coulters, and the grim
 Forks with three teeth, and for the axe
 And to set goads *upon their backs*.
 22 And so it was the day of battle,
 There was no sword nor spear to prattle

In the hand of any of those
People that were dressed in the clothes
Of Saul and Jonathan, only
Saul and Jonathan had a spe.
23 Some from the Philistine fort went
Out to the pass of Michmash sent.

As Philistine would not let Israelite
Make iron tools for fear their blacksmiths
might
Make weapons as well to begin a fight,
So today those who claim the crown and
right
Will not let others enjoy power atomic
For fear they'll make a bomb instead of
comic.
Let such beware, Beloved, that You do not
Step in to open up the secret plot
And show Iranian and every other
How to fire up the caldron like a mother.
Beloved, the right to iron is just as much
His as mine in the single, fatal touch.
But both are condemned who would save a
small
Place for the slaughter instead of the stall.

1 Samuel 14

1 It came upon a certain day,
Jonathan, son of Saul, would say
To the young man that carried all
His armour, "Come, let's pay a call
On the Philistines' fort across
The other side *of yonder toss.*"
He told his father not a word
Of what was in his heart and stirred.
2 And Saul stayed on top of the hill
Under pomegranate tree that's still
In Migron, and the host again
With him was near six hundred men,
3 As well as Ahijah, the son
Of Ahitub, brother to *stun*
Of Ichabod, Phinehas' son,
Son of Ali, the priest of YHWH
In Shiloh, wearing ephod *new.*
And no one knew that Jonathan
Had gone off *with his armour man.*
4 And in the pass where Jonathan
Tried to go over to the camp
Of Philistines *to play the scamp*
There was a rocky crag that stuck
Out from each side, the name *for luck*
Of the one was Bozez, the name

Of the other Seneh *for fame.*
5 The one crag rose up in the front
North of Michmash, the other brunt
Was on Gibeah's southward shunt.
6 And Jonathan told the young man
Carrying his armour *by plan,*
"Come on, let's go up to the fort
Of these uncircumcised *for sport,*
Maybe YHWH will work for us too,
For YHWH saves by many or few."

Ah, my Beloved, how swell the thing
would be
If one could divide all humanity
Into the good and blessed with humble fee
And the wicked uncircumcised degree!
Although they wear their pants the thing is
not
Too difficult in most cases of plot
To find out who has and who hasn't got
A foreskin safe and wound. But that's
begun
A battle of wits by Philistine sun.
The fact is some who wear forbidden root
Upon the sword turn out an honest brute,
While the clean shaven prepuce sometimes
lies
Upon a vehicle of fraud and tries.
No use to cast names or to paint with soot.

7 His armour-bearer said to him,
"Do as your heart says, gay or grim,
See, I'm with you, my heart's as yours
To go up as ambassadors.
8 Then Jonathan said "See, we'll go
Over to the men, with a show
We'll suddenly dance a tango.
9 If they tell us, 'Wait till we come,'
Then we'll sit tight upon our bum,
And not go up to taste their rum.
10 But if they tell us, 'Come and fight,'
Then we'll go up, for YHWH *in sight*
Has put them in our hand *of right,*
And this shall be our signal *light.*"
11 And both of them stepped out in sight
In front of the Philistines' fort,
And the Philistines said "Just look,
Hebrews out of their hole and nook
Where they've been hiding, *see the sport.*"
12 And the men of the garrison
Spoke to Jonathan and the son
With him as armour-bearer, saying

“Come up to us, *don't be delaying*,
And we'll show you a thing *repaying*.”
And so Jonathan said to his
Armour-bearer, “Come *like a whiz*
Up after me, for YHWH has put
Them under Israel's hand *and foot*.”

13 And Jonathan climbed on all fours,
And his armour-bearer *with sores*,
And they fell before Jonathan,
Who struck them, and also the man,
His armour-bearer after him
Attacked them *with blows firm and grim*.
14 And that first slaughter that was made
By Jonathan and by the staid
Armour-bearer was twenty men
Within half a furrow's length's span
In an acre of land *they ran*.

Beloved, I take Your dare and climb the
hill
With stony face against lichen and rill
To sing the scrawny melody of pine
While I sip droplets of Your footy wine.
Beloved, I take Your dare against the race
Of morning clouds clearing before the face
Of lakeshore with last year's reeds frozen
fast
Along the curtained boulders set half-mast.
The day I dare is fraught with fragrant tiles
Unevenly patched on my numbered miles,
And sloping from the pathway to the well
Where summer must awaken the bluebell.
Beloved, I take Your dare and stake a
claim
On moments passing in love's outer flame.

15 And there was dismay in the camp
And in the field and in the damp,
And all the army in the fort
And all the raiders in retort
Trembled, and the earth quaked in sort,
Alohim's terror there to thwart.
16 And the watchmen of Saul's *report*
In Gibeah-benjamin saw
The army melt away *for awe*
Running hither and yon *from claw*.
17 Then Saul said to the folk with him,
“Count now and see among the trim
Who has gone out from us.” And when
They had counted up all the men,
Jonathan and his armour-bearer
Were not there *among coat and wearer*.

18 And Saul said to Ahijah, “Bring
Alohim's ark here on the wing,”
For Alohim's ark was that day
With Israel's people in the way.
19 It happened while Saul told the priest,
The Philistine camp noise increased,
Saul told the priest “Let hand released.”
20 And Saul and all his soldiers came
To do battle, and see the flame
Of every man's sword flash upon
The other in great battle drawn.

If two men only will go up to spend
Themselves against a hopeless foe to fend
For Your divine law and the word You
spoke
On Sinai to each child and wench and
bloke,
The earth will quake, the oppressor will
fall
Beneath the strokes of lightning and the
call
Of thousands to do battle against hate,
If two men only will break through the
gate.
Beloved, I bear the armour of the son
That goes upon the hilltop at a run,
Wielding the sword against vigilant flag
That scatters evil from one crag to crag.
Let me be among those who live to do
According to commandments and not pew.

21 Now the Hebrew traitors who were
Before with Philistines to purr
And go with them to camp around,
They too turned coat upon the sound
To be with Saul and Jonathan.
22 All the Israelites to a man
Hiding in mount Ephraim to scan
Also heard that Philistines fled,
And came to battle too as led,
And YHWH saved Israel on that day,
And war passed through to Bamoth's way,
And all the folk with Saul were then
About ten thousand of his men.
23 And YHWH saved Israel on that day
Fighting up to Beth-aven's way.
24 Israel's men were distressed that day
When Saul swore no one in his pay
Should be uncursed who went to feed
Before the evening, till my greed
Is avenged on enemy seed.

So no one tasted bread or mead.
 25 And all the folk came in the wood,
 And on the ground was honey good.
 26 And when the folk came in the wood,
 Out flowed the honey, but none could
 Put hand to mouth for fear of oath.
 27 But Jonathan never for troth
 Heard what his father charged the folk
 With swearing, and he reached out end
 Of the staff in his hand to fend,
 And dipped it in the honeycomb,
 And put it to mouth gastronome,
 And his eyes brightened in *their chrome*.
 28 And one of the soldiers replied
 And said "Your father swore cockeyed
 Saying 'Cursed is the man to eat
 A bit of bread today *for treat*.'
 The people were faint *on their feet*.

The soldier should have spoken up before
 Jonathan opened up the bee's sweet door.
 Ignorance of the law is no excuse
 In good old USA for my abuse.
 The arbitrary command of the prince
 And king continues to make brother wince,
 While oil flows freely from the hungry
 ground
 Upon the fertile meadow and the sound
 Of shuffling shares greets every outdoor
 mate.
 The secret to becoming, being great
 Is to fence in the populace with State.
 Who takes a roebuck or a partridge fat
 From posted property, knows where he's
 at.
 I taste the honey and bright-eyed look
 round.

29 Then Jonathan said "Dad has brought
 Trouble upon the land unsought.
 See now how my eyes became bright
 Because I tasted honey right.
 30 "Surely if the folk had this day
 Eaten freely from the foes' pay,
 Had there not been much greater slaughter
 Among Philistine son and daughter?"
 31 That day they attacked Philistines
 Michmash to Aijalon's canteens,
 And the people were very faint.
 32 And the folk flew upon the spoil,
 Took sheep and oxen and with toil
 The calves, and killed them on the ground

And ate them with the blood around.
 33 Then they told Saul, to him they said
 "See, the folk against YHWH are led
 To sin in that they eat the blood."
 And he said "You have played the dud
 Like traitors, roll a great stone here
 To me *and I shall teach to fear*."
 34 And Saul said "Scatter out among
 The folk and tell them *old and young*
 To bring everyone here his calf
 And everyone his sheep *with staff*
 And slaughter them upon this stone,
 And not to sin against YHWH's *throne*
 In eating with the blood." The folk
 Brought each one what he had *in stoke*,
 His ox with him to kill that night,
 And there they slaughtered *in his sight*.
 35 And Saul built an altar to YHWH,
 The very first he brought in view.

The verdicts of the leaders of the flock
 Are what cause people to mess up the
 stock.
 The scholars who hide in their hearts the
 book
 Of laws set out when their fathers forsook
 The simple reading of Qur'an and Psalm
 To find the nearest edge to evil palm
 Are the fault when the people would go
 wrong.
 I here accuse the mullah with his song.
 Since Saul made verdict that no one could
 eat,
 After their fasting they fell on the meat
 With blood and sank hungry tooth in the
 spoil
 Not waiting for the lawful, bloodless coil.
 Beloved, let me follow Your law alone
 And set aside the king and royal throne.

36 And Saul said "Let us go by night
 Down after the Philistine plight
 To plunder them until daybreak,
 And let us not leave single stake
 Of man among them." And they said
 "Do all that's good the way you're led,
 And the priest said "Let us draw near
 And see what God *will make appear*."
 37 And Saul enquired of God, "Shall I
 Go down on Philistines with cry?
 Will You deliver them into
 The hand of the Israelite crew?"

But He gave no answer that day.
 38 And Saul said "Come near, all you chiefs
 Of the people, and hear the briefs
 In which lie sins *and where they stay*.
 39 "For as YHWH lives who saves Israel,
 Though the lot on Jonathan fell,
 My son even shall surely die."
 None of the people gave reply.
 40 He said to all of Israel's men
 "Be you on one side, and again
 Jonathan my son and I stand
 On the other side *of the band*."
 And the folk said to Saul, "Do what
 Seems the right thing by your own gut."
 41 So Saul said to YHWH Alohim
 Of Israel, "Declare the dream."
 And Jonathan and Saul were caught
 By the lot, but the folk could trot.
 42 And Saul said "Cast now between me
 And my son Jonathan to be,
 Whomever YHWH shall cause to rise,
 That is the very one who dies."
 And the folk said to Saul, "This thing
 Is not the right verdict to bring."
 But Saul prevailed against the folk
 And Jonathan received the stroke.

The problem was the father's fatal oath
 That turned the people from Your faith and
 growth,

And yet the lot falls on the innocent.
 Am I to believe You did not prevent
 The chance set up as oracle well spent?
 Fault father for his foolish fast and fine,
 But let the son go innocent to dine.
 This story shows what comes as soon as
 kings

And presidents meet democratic wings.
 Irrational indeed, and yet the gains
 Of superstition fill Your name with stains.
 Beloved, cast lots again for Jonathan
 And let the line fall on Saul by Your plan
 And take the hazard from the floor and fan.

43 Saul said to Jonathan, "Tell me
 What you have done." And faithfully
 Jonathan told him, and said "I
 Tasted some honey on the end
 Of my staff in my hand to bend
 And see now, here I am to die."
 44 And Saul said "God do so to me

And more, but you shall not go free,
 But die, Jonathan, *you will see*."
 45 And the folk said to Saul, "Shall he,
 Jonathan die, whose hand greatly
 Brought salvation to Israel now?
 Far from it, as YHWH lives, avow
 Not one hair of his head shall fall
 To the ground, for today his brawl
 With Alohim." And so the folk
 Rescued Jonathan at a stroke.
 46 Then Saul went up from following
 The Philistines, and on the wing
 The Philistines sought their own place.
 47 So Saul took Israel's kingdom and
 Fought all his foes on every hand,
 Against Moab, and Ammon's sons,
 Against Edom, against the tons
 Of Zobah's kings, the Philistines,
 Wherever he turned in combines
 He worsted them. 48 And so he did
 Valiantly and attacked and rid
 Israel of the Amalekites
 Who spoiled them *and opposed their
 rights*.

49 And Saul's sons were first Jonathan,
 And Ishui and the last man
 Malchi-shua, and the two names
 Of his daughters were of these claims,
 The firstborn was Merab, the last
 Was Michal, *who would be outcast*.

Three boys and two girls ought to be
 enough
 To make a man wise and wealthy in stuff.
 The first and last are those who made their
 fame
 By their attachment to David's fair name.
 David married Michal, for punishment
 That she thought dancing before You was
 bent,
 David refused to share her bed. Who
 knows
 How many times beneath the crescent
 glogs
 He shared the bed of Jonathan for blows.
 The two went out to battle on the field
 And were inseparable as the sun spied.
 So two children of Saul met fame because
 They did not sleep between brave David's
 paws.
 Beloved, that is the way this knave world
 goes.

50 And Saul's wife's name, Ahinoam,
 Ahimaaz' daughter was madam,
 And the name of his army chief
 Was Abner the son for relief
 Of Ner, Saul's uncle, he was chief.
 51 Kish was Saul's father, and then Ner
 Was the fair father of Abner,
 Both sons of Abiel were there.
 52 The war against the Philistines
 Was hot and hard in Saul's designs
 For all his days, and when Saul saw
 Any mighty man, or the paw
 Of a brave man, he took him to
 Himself to fight with derring-do.

Note this, Beloved, that war increased
 apace
 As soon as the folk had a king to face.
 While You were king alone, the attack
 came
 And the people sent tribute to the claim
 Of Philistine, and had no right to make
 Tools of iron because of weapons' sake.
 But as soon as a king was set on throne,
 The peace of tribute went out like a stone.
 Beloved, is this the choice in this mad
 earth,
 To serve a heathen king for all we're
 worth,
 Or else make constant war and live from
 pit
 Of hiding place and having no life fit?
 Beloved, make room upon the bloody soil
 For me to live in peace beside my toil.

1 Samuel 15

1 And Samuel said to Saul, "Now YHWH
 Sent me to anoint you to do
 As king over Israel, His folk,
 Now therefore listen to what spoke
 The voice and words of YHWH *by oak*.
 2 So says YHWH of armies, I mind
 What Amalek did in the bind
 Against Israel, how he set down
 Himself against him in the crown
 On the way up from Egypt's town.
 3 Now go attack Amalek, and
 Utterly destroy what's in hand,
 And have no mercy, but kill all,
 Man, woman, child, and in the stall
 Ox, sheep, camel, and donkey's brawl."

4 And Saul called the folk to Telaim,
 And counted two hundred in claim
 Of thousands of infantrymen,
 Ten thousand of Judah again.
 5 Saul came to Amalekite towns
 And lay in ambush on the downs.
 6 And Saul said to the Kenites, "Go
 Out of the Amalekite show,
 Lest I destroy you with their store,
 For you showed kindness once before
 To Israelite people when they
 Came up here out of Egypt's sway."
 So the Kenites fled from among
 Amalekites *when they were hung*.
 7 And Saul attacked Amalekites
From Havilah within the sights
 Of Shur, east of Egyptian flights.

If Saul makes war, at least he lets go free
 The innocent from enemy country.
 That's more than oil diggers do on the
 shore
 Of Basrah, when they come to find the
 store
 Of black gold to invest the president
 With even more money than he has spent
 On the election, armed with sophistry.
 Beloved, save me from the elected and
 The kings by lot, although I think a band
 Of legislators not elected but
 Chosen by chance of lottery unshut
 Would be far better than what we have got:
 Rulers set up by the large lobbies' plot,
 Of those we have enough and to the glut.

8 He took Agag the king alive
 Of the Amalekites to strive,
 But completely destroyed the folk
 With mouth of sword to the last bloke.
 9 But Saul and the folk spared Agag
 The best of the sheep in a bag,
 The oxen, young of second birth,
 And all that was good and of worth,
 And did not completely destroy,
 But only what was sickly toy
 And feeble, those they slew with joy.
 10 Then came to Samuel word of YHWH
 Saying, 11 "I'm sorry that I do
 Make king of Saul, for he has turned
 Back from following Me, I'm spurned,
 And has not kept My word as learned."
 And it grieved Samuel, and he cried

To YHWH all night *till morning tide*.

12 And Samuel got up early in
The morning to meet Saul *for sin*,
And they told Samuel, "Saul has come
To Carmel to set up in sum
A monument, and turned about
To pass on down the Gilgal route.

13 And Samuel came to Saul, Saul said,
"Blessed are you of YHWH, I've been led
To do as YHWH commanded spread."

14 And Samuel said, "Then what's the
sound

Of bleating sheep I hear around
And lowing oxen *on the ground?*"

Each time I come to You, Beloved, to say
How much I have done in Your blessed
way,

You answer with a question, what to say,
"What's this bleating of sheep along the
bay,

And lowing of cattle behind your house?"

My innocence is nibbled by the mouse
Of attention to my own benefit.

Beloved, teach me to mind only what's
writ

Instead of what I stand to gain from grit.
Polite phrases conventional and smooth
Are what the priests in churches like to
truth,

And join Saul in the smiling confession
Of having kept Your law in all they've
done.

Beloved, let me turn my back on the sun.

15 And Saul said "They have brought them
out

Of Amalek what folk *devout*
Saved of the best of sheep and ox
To sacrifice to YHWH *of flocks*,
To your Alohim, and the rest
We've completely destroyed *at best*.

16 Then Samuel said to Saul, "Stay and
I'll tell you what YHWH said in hand
To me this night." And he replied
To him, "Speak on *and nothing hide*."

17 And Samuel said to Saul *again*,
"When you were little in your own
Sight, were you not set on the throne
Of Israel's tribes, and YHWH anointed
You king of Israel appointed?"

18 "And YHWH then sent you on journey,

And said 'Go destroy completely
The sinners the Amalekites,
And fight against their dames and knights
Till they're consumed.' And why did you
Not obey the clear voice of YHWH,
But flew upon the spoil with greed,
In sight of YHWH did evil deed?"

20 And Saul said to Samuel, "But I
Have obeyed YHWH's voice on the wry,
And have gone where YHWH sent me to,
And have brought Agag the king too
Of Amalek, and slaughtered all
The Amalekites *in their stall*.

21 "But the people took from the spoils
The best flocks and herds *in their coils*
Of that which was destroyed indeed
To sacrifice before YHWH's *heed*,
And to our God on Gilgal's *meed*."

Every excuse a man's heart can invent
Sounds righteous to his ear when he gives
vent.

Religion is made of the ways that men
Artistically circumventing Your pen.
Rajaraja's temples in carving stone
Relieve him from killing of flesh and bone,
And Saul's sacrifices in pious prayers
Atone for his mercy before the stares
Of the damned. My Beloved, see how I set
My face against both faith and piety.
I turn away with a disgust well met,
Not from my lust and greed and cruelty,
But from my faith and goodness and the
stand

Of beauty that comes forth from brain and
hand.

22 But Samuel said "Does YHWH delight
As greatly in burnt offerings' sight
And sacrifices as in choice
To obey when hearing YHWH's voice?
See, to obey is better far
Than sacrifice upon altar,
And doing what God says to do
Is better than rams' butter too.

In name of God both Merciful and
Gracious,

I pray do make my heart both true and
spacious.

Give me the wisdom to desire the right
As, at the office, on the road at night,

Or in the field, I come to places where
 The thing to do by everything that's fair
 And well-thought-of by friends and
 neighbourhood,
 Conflicts with what You say, Beloved, I
 should.
 Give me the courage to inflict death
 sentence
 On pregnant mother sins and unrepentance
 Before it grows from babyhood to age,
 To clean and keep clean church and
 parsonage.
 And may my sacrifice be worthy of
 Obedience to mercy, justice, love.

23 Rebellion is like witchcraft done,
 And stubbornness under the sun
 Is like idolatry as sore.
 But you've rejected what is more
 YHWH's word, and so He has as well
 Rejected you from kingship's spell."

Beloved, most merciful and gracious, hear.
 I plead for Saul the king, for whom I fear.
 Beloved, You understand what he's gone
 through,
 You know, Lord, of the pressures hitherto.
 I'm sure it's stress, not wickedness, that
 makes
 The king transgress, or maybe belly-aches.
 Does tall and handsome cut no ice with
 You,
 But that the handsome are as handsome
 do?
 Think not, Beloved, that Saul the king
 rebels.
 His heart is better than his action tells.
 I'm sure he meant to do just as You said.
 It's politics have hit him in the head.
 Forgive, by grace, I know he'll turn a leaf.
 For peace and safety, please don't fire our
 chief.

24 And Saul said to Samuel, "I've sinned
 In that I've transgressed commandment
 Of YHWH, and your words disciplined,
 Because I feared the folk for choice
 And listened rather to their voice.
 25 So now I pray forgive my sin,
 And go back with me, do consent,
 To worship YHWH *without chagrin*."
 And Samuel said to Saul, "I'll not

Turn back with you, for you have sought
 To reject YHWH's word, and so YHWH
 Has rejected you from the pew
 Of being king of Israel's crew."
 27 As Samuel turned around to go,
 He grabbed hold of the wings that show
 Upon his robe, tore calico.
 28 And Samuel said to him, "Now YHWH
 Has torn the kingdom of the crew
 Of Israel from you this day, and
 Has given it to your neighbour's hand,
 One better than you to command.
 29 Also Israel's glory will not
 Lie nor repent *of this new plot*,
 For He is not a man *like you*
 That He should repent *what to do*."

Ah, my Beloved! Just listen to this word!
 You are no man, much less a beast or bird!
 How many faiths along the wall would see
 You to be one or more in trinity
 Of flesh and feather. My Beloved, just see!
 The prophet Samuel, man I must agree
 Responsible for Your word to the free,
 Says You are not a man, not on the tree
 Nor in the manger with the oxen stirred.
 Beloved, I seek You not in stone nor gold
 Nor in the mighty hand of a man bold,
 Nor in the brilliant feats now or of old.
 I seek You in the still small voice within,
 And in the thunder of Sinai for din.

30 And Saul said "Though I've sinned
 abroad,
 Yet honour me now on the sod,
 I pray you, before elders of
 My people, and before the love
 Of Israel, and return with me,
 That I may bow to YHWH your God."
 31 So Samuel turned back after Saul,
 And he bowed to YHWH *at His call*.
 32 Then Samuel said "Bring me Agag,
 The Amalekite king in bag."
 And Agag came to him in chains.
 And Agag said "Surely I stand
 Free of death's danger *on the land*."
 33 And Samuel said to Agag then,
 "As your sword has bereaved women
 Of their children, so shall your mom
 Be made childless and *with aplomb*."
 And Samuel cut Agag in pieces
 Before YHWH in Gilgal's releases.

34 Then Samuel went to Ramah, and
 Saul too returned to his own *land*
And house in Gibeath-shaul's *band*.
 35 And Samuel never saw again
 Saul till the day of his death's *pen*,
 For Samuel mourned for Saul, and YHWH
 Repented that He'd made Saul do
 As king over Israel *and crew*.

Beloved, though I never see face of You
 No matter what I pray or fast in view,
 I do not think that You grieve for my sin
 In Ramah by the well You're buried in.
 Beloved, though Your face is a face apart,
 I know that I like everyone with heart
 Shall one day appear there with horse and
 cart
 To be judged by the law and my own mart.
 I cannot see Your face till then, until
 You stand back to judge me before the
 mill.

But now You are too near for me to see,
 Too close to jugular vein on the spree,
 Too close to eye for me to focus on
 Divinity in sunset or in dawn.

1 Samuel 16

1 YHWH said to Samuel, "How long will
 You mourn for Saul, seeing I still
 Reject him as Israel's king?
 Fill your horn up with an oil spring
 And go, I'll send you to Jesse
 The Bethlehemite, for I see
 A king among his sons for Me."
 2 And Samuel said "How can I go?
 If Saul hears it, he'll kill me sure."
 And YHWH said "Take a heifer too
 And say 'I sacrifice to YHWH.'"
 3 And call Jesse to sacrifice,
 And I'll show you what things suffice,
 And you'll anoint the one to me
 Whom I shall tell you king to be."

This is the effect of having a king
 When You alone could be lord of the
 string.
 As soon as there's a king, one has to make
 Allowances for danger at the stake.
 The king's eyes see wrong in who would
 impose
 Your rule of righteous living on his toes.
 So even prophets have to slink around

With heifers for excuse that they are found.
 The State makes honesty dishonest boot
 By being there and coming from the root.
 Beloved, I love You and I love Your
 prophet,
 But when it comes to kings I have to scoff
 at,
 And presidents are like as not to be
 Worse than the kings having their own
 lobby.

4 And Samuel did all that YHWH spoke,
 And came to Bethlehem *for broke*.
 The elders of the city came
 To meet him trembling as for blame,
 And asked "Come you in peaceful aim?"
 5 And he said "In peace, I have come
 To sacrifice to YHWH a sum,
 So sanctify yourselves and come
 With me to sacrificial hum."
 And he sanctified Jesse and
 His sons and had them be at hand.
 6 It happened when they come, that he
 Looked at Eliab, said "Surely
 YHWH's anointed now takes the stand."
 7 But YHWH said to Samuel "Don't look
 At face or height, since I forsook
 Him, for it is not like a man
 Sees things only in outward scan,
 But YHWH looks at the heart, *and can*."

Democracy fails at this very place,
 The favourite of holy populace
 Is always someone with a pretty face,
 But having heart that would not win the
 race
 In Your eyes. I suggest a lottery
 To choose our princes from the bond and
 free.
 At least then You would have a chance to
 put
 A finger in to slant the chance a-foot.
 As it is now the world goes gaily on
 Forgetting right and wrong upon the lawn,
 Defining justice by the job enhanced
 By media twisting the facts advanced.
 Beloved, reveal Yourself or then Your man
 In justice as against the present ban.

8 Then Jesse called Abinadab,
 And he passed by Samuel's confab,
 And he said "Neither has YHWH picked

This one, *because He is so strict.*"

9 Then Jesse made Shammah pass by.

And he said, "Neither is this guy
YHWH's chosen one *beneath the sky.*"

10 And Jesse made seven of his sons
Pass before Samuel *on their buns*,
And Samuel said "YHWH has not picked
Any of these *super and slicked.*"

11 And Samuel said to Jesse then,
"Are these all your children *and men?*"

And he said "There is still one more,
The youngest, see, he's out of door
Keeping the sheep." And Samuel said
"Send and fetch him and have him led
In here, for we shall not break bread
Before he comes, *nor none be fed.*"

12 And so he sent and brought him in.
Now he was red, handsome as sin
With pretty eyes. And YHWH replied
To Samuel, "Get up off your side
And anoint David, he's My pride."

13 Then Samuel took the horn of oil,
And anointed him in the coil
Of all his brothers, and then came
The spirit of YHWH on his name
From that day forward mightily.
So Samuel got up from the spree
And went back to Ramah to be.

I too have been anointed by the brick
To pray and sing before the rich and slick,
But then let out to pasture with the sheep
To live on the cold hills and vigil keep.
If any prophet comes to call me in
Who was despised as too young as a sin,
He shall not find me ruddy, no, nor fair.
He'll find me grey and balding with the
wear.

Beloved, I come before You, and alone,
Not like David with brothers to the throne,
But without any to despise or praise.
I come alone before You all my days.
And yet Your oil is sure, Your table filled
With banquets that the fattened hogs had
swilled.

14 Now the spirit of YHWH had gone
From Saul, and an evil anon
Spirit from YHWH frightened the john.
15 And Saul's servants said to him, "Now
An evil spirit anyhow
From Alohim disturbs your brow."

16 Let our lord now command your slaves
Who stand before your crown and staves,
To seek out a man skilled in tune
Of harp, and it shall be when soon
Evil spirit from Alohim
Shall come on your waking or dream,
That he'll play with his hand and you
Shall be well *comforted as due.*"

The people in those times thought they
could move
An evil spirit that came to reprove
With harp music well plucked and sung to
groove.

Since then the Middle East has seen the
rise

Of exquisite measures for healing wise
With music's power, physician's
enterprise.

But what's to be done if the evil thing
Came from Your belated, berated wing?
Unless You have mercy, no one can sing
Away the powers of darkness nor the fruit
Of having sinned against You too to boot.
Beloved, look on my exercising sting
And see how much I need the comfort of
Your harp and song, Your mercy and Your
love.

17 And Saul told his servants, "Provide
Me now a man and bona fide
Who can play well, bring to my side."

18 Then answered one of the young men,
And said "See, I have seen again
Jesse the Bethlehemite's son,
Who's skilful in playing *a run*,
A strong man of valour *when done*,
A man of war, wise in affairs,
A handsome person *without airs*,
And YHWH is with him *on the stairs*."

19 So Saul sent messengers out to
Jesse and said, "Send David who
Is your son keeping sheep *in view.*"
20 And Jesse took a donkey load
Of bread, a bottle *where he stowed*
Grape juice, and one goat kid and sent
Them with David his son who went
To Saul.

21 And David came to Saul,
And stood before him *at the wall*,
And he loved him greatly, and he
Was his armour-bearer *in fee*.

22 And Saul sent to Jesse, saying

“Let David, please, stand here *and sing*,
He pleases me in everything.”

23 It happened when the spirit came
From Alohim as if in blame
On Saul, that David took the harp,
And set his hand to play *it sharp*,
And Saul found relief, it was well
With him and the evil *to tell*
In spirit left him and its spell.

From keeper of the sheep to court musician
Is very fine to improve the position.
But I admire both prodigies when I
Remember such folk I’ve had under eye.
The skill of the musician lightens heart,
But skill of the sheep herder has its part
As I have seen them on the barren hills
Of the Hittites where Turkey’s dawn
distils.

Beloved, I have no shepherd’s task nor yet
The voice of the musician better set.
The one job I have done with pride and
well

Was cleaning toilets, till after a spell
Someone even found fault there, though
the folk

That used them came past others to
unlock.

1 Samuel 17

1 The Philistines came to wage war
And were gathered at Socoh’s shore,
Which belongs to Judah in store,
Encamping between Socoh and
Azekah, Ephes-dammim’s land.
2 And Saul and Israel’s men came out
And pitched in Elah’s vale about,
And set the battle in array
Against the Philistines *that day*.
3 The Philistines stood on the mount
On the one side, and Israel’s count
Was on the other mountain side,
The valley between them to bide.
4 Then there went out a mighty man
From the camp of Philistian,
Goliath was his name, from Gath,
His height six cubits and a span,
His heart and hand both filled with wrath.
5 He had brass helmet on his head,
And wore a breastplate, it is said,
Of chain armour, the breastplate’s weight
Was five thousand shekels, so great,

Of brass and iron. 6 He’d greaves of brass
Upon his legs, a spear to pass
As brass between his shoulder blades.
7 And the staff of his spear for raids
Was like a weaver’s beam in trades,
And his spear’s head weighed six hundred
Shekels of iron, in his stead
Went his shield-bearer *as he led*.

The heroes of this world in every time
Have three things in common where they
all climb.

They have both height and strength to beat
a dime,

They have protection of servant and rime
Of armour made of iron, brass and at last
Depleted uranium with its massed,
And weapons, last and not least
unsurpassed.

This heroes’ trinity disdains rag-assed.
Beloved, I come before the fatal fray
With nothing in my hand to meet the day.
I cantillate Your name and in its power
I look to see what rises from the hour.
The heroes rush past and leave me alone
To bow down head and heart before Your
throne.

8 And he stood shouting to the hosts
Of Israel, saying in boasts,
“Why do you come out to the fray
To set your battle in array?
Am I not a Philistine, and
You are servants at Saul’s command?
Choose you a man for you to stand
And send him down to meet my *hand*.
9 If he can fight with me and kill,
Then we shall fill your servants’ bill,
But if I win against him and
Kill the bugger, then you shall stand
As our slaves to serve foot and hand.
10 And the Philistine said “I do
Taunt Israel’s hosts this day in view,
Give me a man so we can fight.”
11 And when Saul and all Israel’s wight
Heard those words of the Philistine,
They were scared to death *of the swine*.

Some taunt their enemies as they go out
Into the desert where they flag and flout
Justice for oil and politics and shout

Down Your law that requires to live in
 peace.
 But behind taunting brute come out to
 fleece
 The poor and poison water without cease
 Is the parade of power set up in walls
 Of marble and laid out in velvet halls.
 Beloved, it does not finish the offence
 To slay Goliaths giving pounds for pence.
 When he is dead the awful presidents
 Still breathe injustice at the world's
 expense.
 Beloved, let giants come and go but still
 The corrupt voice and hand set on the hill.

12 Now David son of one of them
 Ephrathites come from Bethlehem
 In Judah, whose name was Jesse,
 And he had eight sons, whereas he
 Was old in Saul's time and feebly.
 13 And the three eldest sons of Jesse
 Had gone after Saul to the gussy
 Battle, and the names of his three
 Sons that went to the battle, *see*,
 Were Eliab the first born and next
 Abinadab *the unperplexed*,
 And third Shammah, *all faithfully*.
 14 And David was the youngest son,
 The three eldest followed *the run*
 Of Saul. 15 Now David went back and
 Returned to feed the sheep at hand
 Of his father at Bethlehem.
 16 And the Philistine drew near them
 Morning and evening presenting
 Himself forty days *on the sting*.
 17 And Jesse told David his son,
 "Take now for your brothers on run
 An ephah of this parched corn *done*,
 And these ten loaves, and carry them
 Quickly to your brothers' camp's *hem*.
 18 "And bring these ten cheeses here to
 The captain of their thousand crew,
 And to your brothers bring my peace
 And take from them their news release."
 19 Now Saul and they and all the men
 Of Israel in the vale again
 Of Elah fought the Philistines.
 20 And David got up *with the pines*
 Early in the morning, and left
 The sheep with a keeper *as deft*,
 And went as Jesse told him to,
 And he came to the barricade

As the host which was going through
 To the fight shouted in parade.
 21 And Israel and the Philistines
 Put the battle under ensigns
 Army against army arrayed.

Look, my Beloved, upon the battle plan
 And see the place where stands each man
 for man.

Your one anointed is the one who goes
 Along the road wriggling in dust his toes,
 The one even the Philistines let pass
 With bread and cheesed loaded upon an
 ass.

Your fine appointed don't drive limousines
 Or find their mugs in front of magazines.
 Instead, Beloved, they trek on dusty feet
 Carrying bread for others, and their meat.
 Beloved, I look at all the spread of men,
 The great and humble, and guess once
 again

Who is Your one appointed in the way
 Of tank and ox cart shunted from the fray.

22 And David left his baggage in
 The brace of baggage keeper's bin,
 And ran to the army and came
 And gave peace to his brothers' name.
 23 And as he talked with them, behold,
 Out came the champion and the bold
 Philistine of Gath, one whose name
 Was Goliath, out of the claim
 Of the Philistines, and he spoke
 According to the same words' cloak,
 And David heard them *to his shame*.
 24 And all the men of Israel, when
 They saw the man, fled back again
 In great fear *of the denizen*.
 25 And Israel's men said "Have you seen
 This man that's come up? It's his scene
 To taunt Israel, and it shall be
 That the one who kills him surely
 The king will give him store and gear
 As well as his daughter to steer,
 And make his father's house free in
 Israel." 26 And David in chagrin
 Spoke to the men that stood by him,
 Saying "What shall be done the grim
 Man that kills this Philistine, and
 Takes away the taunt from the land
 Of Israel? For who is this one
 Uncircumcised man under sun

Of Philistines, that he should taunt
 The hosts of Alohim and daunt
 The living God?" 27 And the folk said
 To him in answer, "So instead
 Shall it be done to the man bred
 That kills him." 28 And Eliab his
 Eldest brother heard what a whiz
 He spoke to the men, and the wrath
 Of Eliab flamed in the path
 Of David, and he said "Why did
 You come down? And where have you hid
 Those few sheep in the desert rid?
 I know your pride and naughtiness
 In your heart, for you came no less
 Than to look at the war's address."

Elder brothers remain forever so.
 They never learn a thing from David's
 show.

Respect of personage is given while
 The recipient is filled with the vile,
 But where the innocence of divine power
 Rests on the soul, it makes his brother
 glower.

Familiarity breeding contempt
 Makes every hardened heart and soul
 exempt

From visions of Your glory. That is why
 The sound of Your voice speaking from the
 sky

Is rarely heard. You speak, but those who
 hear

Turn in anger and bend a deafened ear
 Because Your pedigree is one unknown
 And You sit on an invisible throne.

29 And David said "What have I done?
 Is there no cause here under sun?"

30 And he turned from him to another
 And spoke the same way to the brother,
 And the folk answered him again.

31 And when the words were heard by men
 That David spoke, they told the thing
 To Saul, and brought him to the king.

32 And David said to Saul, "Let not
 The heart of my lord king be brought
 To sorrow, your servant will go
 And fight this Philistine below.

33 And Saul said to David, "You can
 Not go against Philistine man
 To fight with him, for you're a youth
 And he a man of war in truth."

34 And David said to Saul, "Your slave
 Tended his father's flock as grave
 When a lion came and she-bear
 And took a lamb from the flock's care.
 35 "Then I went after it and struck
 It and saved the lamb from its muck,
 And when it rose against me, I
 Caught it by the beard and that's why
 I struck it and killed it, no lie.

The secret of David is that he made
 Transfer of knowledge that he had waylaid
 Following sheep across the desert sand.
 The best tool is the tool that is to hand.
 What kills a lion, it can kill a bear,
 And what kills bears can be found
 anywhere

To break the power of Philistine as soon.
 I gaze in rapture at the frozen noon,
 Beloved, and see that arm of peace and
 boon

Of bounty that in morning fed and grave
 May in the afternoon rise up as brave
 To crush the tottering tyrant and to save.
 I crush the bigot first in my own soul
 And open up the gates to find the goal.

36 "Your servant struck both lion and bear,
 And this uncircumcised one there,
 This Philistine shall be like them,
 Since he's taunted the host and hem
 Of the living God Alohim."

37 And David said "YHWH that saved me
 From lion's paw and the claw *free*
 Of the bear, He'll deliver me
 From this Philistine's hand again."

And Saul said to David, "Go then,
 And YHWH shall be with you *amen*."

38 And Saul dressed David in his clothes,
 And put brass helmet *for trousseaux*
 Upon his head, and decked him out
 In a coat of mail and redoubt.

39 And David buckled up his sword
 And started out the unexplored,
 For he had not proved it *ungored*.
 And David said to Saul, "I'll not
 Be able to go with these taught,
 Since I'm not used to the *store-bought*."
 So David took them off *deplored*.

40 And he took his staff in his hand,
 And chose five smooth stones from the
 sand

Of the brook, and put them into
The shepherd's bag he had in view,
Even in a scrip, and his sling
Was in his hand like anything,
And he came near the Philistine.

41 And the Philistine came on and
Approached David, and on the sand
The man bore the shield at his hand.
42 When the Philistine looked about
And saw David, he shut him out,
Because he saw that he was just
A boy with a red face robust.

I set out with doctor's degree in hand,
Appointed and hired by the mission band,
Ordained by church and by the hopeful
stand

Of prejudice and insult to command
Souls into heaven. But the coat I wore
Was too heavy for innocence I bore.
I stopped myself from ritual and prayer,
Rejected hymn and offering on the stair,
And came to You with empty hand to hear
The sound of Your voice rampant on my
ear

Tuned to the Hebrew syllables that sear
My heart with love and joy as they appear.
Beloved, I turn alone to You and see
The glories unguessed of eternity.

43 The Philistine said to David,
"Am I a dog and on the skid
That you come with sticks to unlid?"
The Philistine then cursed aloud
David by his gods *in a crowd*.

44 The Philistine said to David,
"Come here and do just as I bid,
And I'll give your flesh to the birds
Of the air, and to beasts as turds."

45 And David told the Philistine,
"You come to me with sword and fine,
And with a spear and shield, but I
Come to you in the name of YHWH
Alohim of hosts of the crew
Of Israel, the One whom you
Have mocked *day by day out in view*.

46 "This day will YHWH put you in my
Power and I'll kill you, with a cry
Cut off your head and give your limbs
And Philistine host's limbs for whims
Today to the birds of the air
And the wild beasts on earth to share,

That all the world may know that there
Is a God in Israel's affair.

47 "And all who watch here, they will
know

That YHWH saves not with sword and
show,

With spear and such, for battles go
According to the will of YHWH,
And He'll give you to us *as due*."

48 It happened that the Philistine
Got up and came near to incline
To meet David, so David ran
Quickly toward the army scan
To meet the coming Philistine.

49 And David put his hand into
His bag, found a stone and withdrew
It and slung it, and struck the man,
The Philistine on forehead's *tan*,
And the stone sank deep in his head
And he fell down on his face dead.

It's Philistine now throws the brick and
rock

Into the tank wheels with sickening shock.

But now the Philistine is not one fed
On pork nor has a foreskin left unbled.

The sons of Judah and of Abraham
Fall to the fight as at the ancient ram
Of Saul and Ekron. Now the fight lays bare
The truth that You are One shot in the air,
While answering, there comes not cry of
gods

Multiplied in Gath, but the cloud of sods
With shout that God is Great and there is
none

Other God but He left under the sun.

Beloved, in three thousand years gone and
done

We've learned, as we keep fighting, You
are One.

50 So David beat the Philistine
With sling and stone *come to combine*,
And struck the Philistine down dead,
With no sword in David's hand *red*.

51 And David ran and stood upon
The Philistine, took his sword drawn
Out of its sheath, and killed him there
And cut off his head *in the air*.

And when the Philistines saw that
Their hero was dead, they fled *flat*.

52 The men of Israel got up

Along with Judah *like a tup*
 And shouted and pursued *at length*
 The Philistines *with all their strength*
 Until you come to the valley,
 The gates of Ekron, *as they flee*
 The wounded Philistines fall down
 By Shaaraim and to *the town*
 Of Gath and to Ekron's *renown*.
 53 And the men of Israel returned
 From chasing Philistines *they spurned*,
 And spoiled their camp *for what they*
earned.

54 David took the Philistine's head,
 Brought it to Jerusalem's bed,
 But put the armour in his tent.

David is wise to save for himself those
 Iron and brass helmet and mail-clad
 clothes.

Even the hero of the day may be
 Vulnerable when the clock turns a wee.
 He gives the head to celebration's spree,
 But keeps the armour in his tent for free.
 Bless David, my Beloved, and bless his
 throne,
 Who was wiser than three other men
 grown,
 Jesus, who was caught in the garden's
 moan,
 Husseyne without water beside the stone,
 And I who leave my breast open and bare
 To find the sacrificial knife strike there.
 Beloved, the corners of the weak are sure
 To bend sometime before wicked, impure.

55 And when Saul saw David who went
 Against the Philistine, he said
 To Abner captain of his spread,
 "Abner, whose son is this youth bred?"
 And Abner said "As your soul lives,
 O king, I cannot tell what gives."
 56 And the king said "Well then, find out
 Whose son that boy is *and whose scout*."
 57 As David came back from the killing
 Of the Philistine, Abner *willing*
 Took him and brought him back to Saul
 With the Philistine's head *on wall*.
 58 And Saul said to him, "Whose son are
 You, young man?" And David *the star*
 Answered, "I am the son of your
 Slave Jesse from Bethlehem's *shore*."

The king does not recognize David's song,
 He does not know him, not knowing the
 wrong

From right, bereft of heaven's spirit and
 long

Inured to goodness and accustomed to
 Betrayal and mistrust and derring-do.
 When David acts the part of tried and true
 Warrior upon the field, then Saul awakes
 And looks about to find out what are
 stakes.

But Abner does not know the humble boy
 Whose strength is in the low, faithful
 employ

Of stone to protect flock from lion and
 bear.

Abner knows only captains of the snare.
 But Bethlehem brings forth from manger
 and

Sheepcote the small and silent of the land.

1 Samuel 18

1 It happened when he finished talking
 To Saul, Jonathan's soul was stalking
 And knit with David's soul until
 He loved him as his own soul's fill.
 2 And Saul took him that day and would
 Not let him go home more for good
 To his father's house. 3 Jonathan
 Made an agreement with his man
 David, because he loved him so,
 As his own soul. 4 And at a go
 Jonathan stripped off his own suit
 That was on him and gave to boot
 To David his clothes and his sword,
 His bow and belt *he could afford*.
 5 David went wherever Saul sent,
 Behaved wisely and competent,
 And Saul set him over the men
 Of war, and it was good again
 In the sight of all the folk and
 And in sight of Saul's servant band.
 6 As they arrived when David came
 Back from the slaughter and the claim
 Of Philistines, the women came
 Out of all Israel's cities and
 Singing and dancing on the strand
 To meet king Saul with timbrels and
 With joy of three-stringed instrument.
 7 The women began and they meant,
 "Saul struck down thousands *as he went*,
 David ten thousands *from his tent*."

Watch what the women do to divide men
 With praise lavished to jealousy again.
 As long as the soldiers were in the field
 There was no bad blood in the feud to yield
 Between Saul and David, or Jonathan.
 But when the women make a show to scan,
 Then men get on the high horse and
 compete
 For female favours after horse and heat.
 Beloved, I hear the music and the dance
 That turn Your liturgy to song and prance,
 I see the call of hip and hear the toe
 Tap on the prayer-mat where the steel
 banjo
 Replaces the voice still and small and slow
 That sings from Sinai sacred circumstance.

8 And Saul was very angry then
 And this word displeased him again,
 And he said "They have ascribed to
 David ten thousands, and then to
 Me they've only given in due
 Thousands, and so he might as well
 Have the kingdom *of Israel.*"
 9 So Saul looked suspiciously on
 David from that very day on.
 10 It happened on the next day that
 An evil spirit from God sat
 Strongly on Saul so that he raved
 In the middle of the house grave,
 And David played with hand on harp
 As he did day by day as sharp,
 And Saul had his spear in his hand.
 11 And Saul threw the spear *from his
 stand,*
 Said "I'll strike David to the wall."
 And David stepped aside *the pall*
 Out of his presence twice *in all.*
 12 And Saul feared David, because YHWH
 Was with him, but abandoned crew
 Of Saul. 13 That's why Saul put him out
 Of the court and made him a stout
 Captain of a thousand and he
 Went out to war continually.
 14 And David behaved wisely in
 All his ways, and YHWH saved his skin.

The power of music in the hand of one
 May make rejoicing for good under sun.
 But when the evil spirit from You's come,
 The same art spills in violence for sum.

Saul throws a spear, though David's
 melody
 Was rank to soothe his heart and deal
 calmly,
 And this shows how the man within may
 hide
 Even from overwhelming feelings' tide
 To perpetrate a hate already sent
 That fears the competition of the bent.
 You are One, You alone, Beloved, and I
 Am Your reflection under every sky,
 And in each heart made by Your sovereign
 will,
 And so I come and come back to You still.

15 So when Saul saw his great success,
 He was afraid of his address.
 16 But all Israel and Judah loved
 David, because he pushed and shoved
 For them. 17 Then Saul told David, "Here
 Is my older daughter to steer,
 Merab, I'll give you her as wife.
 Only be valiant in the strife,
 And fight YHWH's battles." For Saul said
 To himself, "Let not my hand led
 Be against him, but Philistine
 Hand be against him *come to dine.*"
 18 But David said to Saul, "Who am
 I, and what is my life in sham,
 Or my father's clan in Israel,
 For me to be son-in-law well
 To the king?" 19 Then it happened when
 Merab Saul's daughter should have been
 Given to David, that she was
 Given to Adriel's *applause*
 The Meholathite to be wife.
 20 But Michal Saul's daughter loved him,
 Loved David, they told Saul *the whim,*
 And the thing certainly pleased him.
 21 And Saul said "I'll give her to him
 And she will be his stumbling-block,
 While the Philistines run amok."
 So Saul told David, "You shall be
 My son-in-law today *for free*
 By one of the two *faithfully.*"

The court intrigue sets women out to breed,
 Even the princess of the royal seed,
 For motives of politics and of greed.
 How rarely does one ask the girl's desire
 When marriages are made from fatal fire.

But Michal loved David, be that her
 choice,
 And yet I wonder, despite her own voice,
 Whether her love's requited by the same.
 A woman's destiny, sometimes to shame,
 Is rarely happy, even when her own
 Desires come home to roost upon the
 throne.
 Beloved, my soul is set on You alone,
 And my love reaches out to touch Your
 face,
 Even where I find fleeting in this place.

22 Saul charged his servants, "Tell the ear
 Of David saying 'Do not fear,
 The king delights in you, and all
 His servants love you in the hall,
 So now be the king's son-in-law.'"

23 And Saul's servants spoke those words
 clear

In David's ear. And David said
 "To you people does it appear
 A light thing to become the wed
 Son-in-law to the king, when I
 Am a poor man, no royal guy?"

24 And Saul's servants reported back
 To him what David said *for smack*.

25 And Saul said "The king wants no gift
 In dowry, but a hundred lift
 In foreskins from the Philistines
 In vengeance for vituperines."

26 And when his servants told these words
 To David, it pleased him in herds
 To be the king's own son-in-law.

And the days had not passed by law,

27 Till David got up with his men
 And killed of the Philistines then
 Two hundred men, and David brought
 Their foreskins, and with them he bought
 Full dowry that the king had sought.

So Saul gave him Michal as wife,
 His daughter *in reward for life*.

28 Saul saw YHWH with David and too
 Michal Saul's daughter loved his view.

My question is whether David first caught
 The Philistines and cut them live when
 brought,

Or if his soldiers desecrated men
 Dead on the field with flint and feathered
 pen.

If he baptized them in their own blood,
 then

He gave example to Ferdinand when
 They baptized Mexico before the fire
 Of martyrdom so that Indian in pyre
 Could go to Paradise while Spaniards came
 To enjoy all the wealth lying in claim.
 But if they only took the prize away
 From dead bodies, that's par in any fray.
 Beloved, David's a man of Your own
 heart,

While I am just driver of horse and cart.

29 And Saul was even more afraid
 Of David. So Saul made parade
 Against David as foe first grade.

30 The princes of the Philistines
 Went out to battle, as combines,
 As soon as they went out, David
 Behaved more wisely than the bid
 Of all Saul's servants, so his name
 Was much set by to his acclaim.

Diplomacy was what a man must get
 Who leaves his sheep and goes to court to
 set.

The courts of kings and presidents are met
 To deprive men of worthiness and let
 Depraved desires create ambitions wild
 To spoil and warp the sincere heart of
 child.

David's humility and wisdom here
 Is just the courtly magic of the fear
 That guides any man through the run of
 State.

It's not for this David is truly great.
 Beloved, David is Yours not only for
 The oil once poured upon him for the store,
 But for the heart You only see behind
 The veils of illusion and undivined.

1 Samuel 19

1 And Saul told Jonathan his son
 And all his servants on the run
 To kill David. 2 And Jonathan
 Told David, "Saul my father's ban
 Is on you to kill you, therefore
 Be on your guard till morning's door,
 And stay hidden in secret place.
 3 "And I'll go out and stand beside
 My father in field you reside,
 And I'll talk with Dad about you,

And what I find out, I'll tell you."
 4 And Jonathan spoke well of him
 David to Saul his father grim,
 And said to him, "Let not the king
 Sin against his slave in this thing,
 Against David, because he's not
 Sinned against you, because his plot
 Towards you is as good *as ought*.
 5 "For he put his life in his hand
 And attacked the Philistine band,
 And YHWH made a great victory
 For Israel, as you did see,
 And did rejoice, now why will you
 Sin against innocent and true
 Blood to kill David without due?"
 6 Saul listened to Jonathan's voice,
 And Saul swore saying at the choice,
 "He shall not die, and so lives YHWH."
 7 And Jonathan called David out
 And told him all those things with clout.
 And Jonathan brought David to
 Saul and he stood there in his view
 As he did before *all the hue*.

To survive in the courts of kings and high
 One must have a protector by and by.
 One day the coast is clear, the table piled
 With fruits and nuts and sweetmeats tame
 and wild,
 The next day favour's turned the other
 cheek
 And there's nothing but to play hide and
 seek.
 The only way to avoid nastiness
 In court is to leave off the power and guess
 And hold court alone above all the mess.
 Beloved, I seek the gold paved polished
 floor
 That lies beyond Your secret throne room's
 door,
 And wait without the gate till summoned in
 Where there are none to stand for show and
 sin.
 I hold court all alone, and need no more.

8 War broke out once again and went
 David against Philistines sent
 And killed them with great slaughter, and
 They fled before him *in a band*.
 9 An evil spirit from YHWH came
 On Saul as he sat in his claim
 At home with spear in hand, and there

David was playing with his bare
 Hand. 10 And Saul tried to strike David
 With the spear, but he went and hid
 From Saul's presence, and so he struck
 The spear into the wall, with pluck
 David fled and escaped that night.
 11 And Saul sent messengers back to
 David's house to keep him in view
 And kill him in the morning dew,
 But Michal David's wife was true
 And told him, saying, "If you do
 Not save your life tonight, in vain
 Tomorrow's light you'll be once slain."
 12 So Michal let David down through
 A window, and he left and fled
 Escaping *to where he was led*.
 13 And Michal took a doll and put
 It in the bed and then she put
 A goats' hair cover head *and foot*,
 And covered it all with a sheet.
 14 When Saul sent messengers to treat
 Of David, she said "He is sick."

If father is a king and mother queen,
 The situation's so, as always seen,
 The daughter must tell lies to save her life
 From threat to spouse and child by witness
 knife.
 If father is a king, the daughter knows
 Soon what to tell aloud to friends and foes.
 If mother is a queen, the cat is out
 To catch mice by her chair by tail or snout.
 Beloved, I too live under queen and king
 Whose hand of power extends like
 anything
 Through laws that foster thinking
 loopholes bring
 Justice, and wearing suits and ties make
 one
 A prodigy of honour under sun.
 Beloved, look on the world and have it
 done.

15 Then Saul returned them to David
 Saying "Bring him with bed and lid
 That I may kill him where he hid."
 16 See, when the messengers came back,
 There was the doll in the bed *stack*
 And a goat hair for head, *alack*.
 17 And Saul said to Michal, "Why now
 Have you deceived me *like a cow*
 And let my enemy escape?"

And Michal said to Saul *agape*,
 “He said ‘Let me go, if you don’t,
 I will kill you, see if I won’t.’”
 18 So David fled, escaped and came
 To Samuel at Ramah *for blame*,
 And he and Samuel went to dwell
 In Naioth *and stayed there a spell*.
 19 And it was told to Saul, saying
 “See David’s in Naioth *to bring*
Rebels from Ramah *against king*.”
 20 And Saul sent messengers to take
 David, and when they saw the stake
 Of prophets prophesying, and
 Samuel standing as head of band,
 Then they too prophesied full-manned.
 21 And when it was told Saul, he sent
 Other messengers, and they bent
 Also to prophesy *assent*.

The stratagem of Samuel is what
 I also do when opening door shut.
 To my hill there come day by day and
 week

The stragglers of police intent to seek
 My life and soul for being against state
 Of lawlessness toward Your heavenly gate.
 Some come to mock, some come to fight,
 some come

To drink my spring water and eat my
 crumb.

But all must stand to hear the prophesy
 From my lips and my daughter’s flowing
 free

As we cantillate from Your word in song
 Drawn out in Hebrew letters for the throng.
 Beloved, they fall before the flaming sword
 And flee when they get up from being
 bored.

22 Then he himself got up to go
 To Ramah, came where waters flow,
 And asked, “Where are, for friend or foe,
 Samuel and David on the go?”
 And then one told him, “See they are
 Both at Naioth and at Ramah.”

23 And he went there to Naioth in
 Ramah, and came *to his chagrin*
 The spirit of Alohim on
 Him also and he too went on
 Prophesying till he came to
 Naioth of Ramah *and in view*.

24 And he also stripped off his clothes,

And prophesied as Samuel rose,
 And lay down naked all that day
 And all that night, that’s why they say
 “Is Saul also in prophets’ sway?”

Who come to my door with or without
 sling

Must stay to hear the cantillation’s ring,
 And all must take off shoes and coats and
 put

Them in the closet, and have upon foot
 A woollen sock to keep them warm to root.
 If Saul lay naked or if in full view
 As vulnerable rather than in pew
 Of Adamite or nudist, to say true,
 My visitor may keep his underwear
 To cover shame or blame or ill or fair.
 Beloved, naked upon the earth I came
 To whirl in sacrifice to You, in flame
 Of love to You and Your commandments’
 sound.

And naked I before You am still found.

1 Samuel 20

1 And David fled from Naioth in
 Ramah and came and said before
 Jonathan, “What have I for sin
 Done? And what is my wicked store?
 What is my fault before your dad
 That he tries to kill me *like cad*?”

2 And he said to him, “Not at all!
 You will not die at my dad’s call,
 He does nothing, nor great nor small,
 Without telling me, and now why
 Should my dad hide this from my spy?
 It is not true.”

3 And David swore
 An oath and said “Your father’s core
 Knows I have found grace in your sight,
 So he says to himself *in spite*

‘Let not Jonathan know this thing
 Lest he be grieved,’ but sure as sting
 And YHWH lives, and as your soul lives,
 There’s only one step now *that gives*
 Between me and death.”

4 Jonathan
 Said to David, “What do you think
 I can do for you on the brink?”

5 And David said to Jonathan,
 “See now, tomorrow is the ban
 Of the first day of the month’s scan,
 When I should sit down with the king
 To eat, but let me go on wing
 To hide in the field till evening.

6 If your father misses me, say
 David earnestly asked the day
 Off to run down to Bethlehem
 His city to his family's hem
 For yearly sacrifice. 7 If he
 Says 'That's fine,' it's then safe for me,
 But if he answers angrily,
 Then be sure he meant to kill me.
 8 But be kind with your servant, for
 You have brought your servant before
 YHWH in agreement with you, but
 If there's any wickedness shut
 In me, then kill me yourself, why
 Hand over to your dad to die?"

Beloved, search my heart and my hand and
 see

If there is in either iniquity,
 Then slay that wicked one that hides in me
 And I shall be one to eternity
 With You, Beloved, and so with soul set
 free.

Beloved, come searching every heart and
 mind

And crush oppression of poor and resigned,
 And free the soul deluded and well wined
 To find You all in all above the blind,
 Search and crush, my Beloved, search
 faithfully.

The soul of David willingly revealed
 Its deepest nakedness to a friend sealed,
 Ready to sacrifice both head and heart.
 Beloved, search and slay me from end to
 start.

9 And Jonathan said "Don't say that!
 If I knew my dad planned out flat
 To attack you, I would say so."

10 Then David said to Jonathan,
 "Who'll tell me of your father's plan,
 If he should answer mad as can?"

11 And Jonathan said to David,
 "Let's go to the field where you hid."
 And they both went out at the bid.

12 And Jonathan said to David,
 "Witness YHWH Israel's Alohim,
 When I've found out my father's dream,
 This time tomorrow, three o'clock,
 See, if there's good towards David's stock,
 I'll send to you and tell your jock.

13 "Alohim do to Jonathan
 And more also, as much as can,

If my dad would do you an ill
 And I do not tell you to fill
 And send you away that you may
 Go in peace, and so may YHWH stay
 With you as He's been with my dad.
 14 "You must show me mercy that's had
 From YHWH while I live and not die.
 15 "You'll not take your kindness away
 From my house for ever to stay,
 Not even when YHWH cuts off all
 The foes of David from the pall
 Of the earth." 16 So Jonathan made
 Agreement with David's house stayed,
 "Let YHWH require it even laid
 At David's enemies' parade."

Court intrigue was invented by the love
 Of two friends who protected hand in glove
 Each other from the weather and despair
 That is found in governments everywhere.
 If governments are not today as then,
 Why does Mordechai still sit at gate
 To greet both just and unjust knight and
 men?

If the world were now simply free for mate
 As claim the riders on both ship and air,
 Then Mordechai would go free to speak
 In any land and not wait at the peek.
 Give every man a partner in the shame
 To save him from the arrow and the flame,
 Beloved, and then I too will remain meek.

17 Jonathan caused David to vow
 Because he loved him anyhow
 As his own soul *and his own brow*.

18 Jonathan said to David, "Now
 Tomorrow's the month's first day, and
 You will be missed from seat and stand.

19 "Day after tomorrow hide well,
 Come to the place where you did dwell
 Hiding yourself that day a spell
 And then stand by the stone Ezel.

20 "And I'll shoot three arrows aside
 As though I shot a target wide,
 21 "And see, I shall then send the lad,
 'Go find the arrows on the pad.'

If I say to the boy, 'See there,
 The arrows are this side of stair,
 Take them and come,' then as YHWH
 lives,
 There's peace for you and no harm gives.
 22 "But if I say to the young man,

'Look here, the arrows are a span
Beyond you,' go away in peace,
For YHWH has sent you with release.
23 "And of the matter which we two
Have spoken of, see now that YHWH
Is between us forever true."

I stand beside the stone of Ezel now
To wait Your arrow flying and somehow
Determine whether I should fly or stay
To dine with You, Beloved, another day.
The weeks and months go by, my exile still
Ties me to pine and fir, to Puijo hill,
And yet You meet me on the frozen sod
And teach me in each face to find my God.
Beloved, the sparkling granite at my hand
Speaks of a harsh and cold, yet friendly
land.
The mica shines, amphibolites glow rare
In black lust and lustre and also share
Quartz and feldspar my searching eyes
with care.
Beloved, by stone of Ezel I still stand.

24 David hid himself in the field,
And when the month's first day in yield
Arrived, the king sat down to meat.
25 As always he sat on his seat
Beside the wall, and Jonathan
Stood up and Abner by the side
Of Saul, but David's place to bide
Was empty. 26 Saul said naught that day,
Thinking, "Something came up to stay,
He's unclean, surely unclean way."
27 It happened on the second day
Of the month that David's seat still
Was empty, and Saul said to grill
Jonathan his son, "Why has not
The son of Jesse come to pot,
Neither today nor yesterday?"
28 And Jonathan answered Saul thus,
"David earnestly asked not worse
Than to go down to Bethlehem
To spend the day in family's hem.
29 And he said 'Let me go, I pray,
It's family sacrifice today
In the city, my brother has
Commanded me, and now whereas
I've found favour before your sight,
Let me get away *before night*
And see my brothers. And that's why
He's not at the king's table's rye.'"

30 Then Saul's wrath flamed at Jonathan
And he said to the gentleman,
"Son of a bitch, I know that you
Choose son of Jesse over crew,
To your own shame and to the shame
Of your naked mother for blame.
31 "As long as Jesse's son's alive
Upon the earth, I do not jive,
You'll not be set upon your throne.
Now therefore send and fetch him here
To me to die, *upon my ear.*"

Beloved, I don't approve of Saul's bad
speech,
Profanity is something I don't preach,
And that alone is quite enough to teach
Your hand to set the man off throne and
power.
To his own son no less he said that word.
Nothing in the world that ever occurred
Justifies saying such, even heart stirred.
My sympathy with Saul has just gone sour.
But that is just the problem with such
kings.
They must commit violent acts and things
To stay in power, and violence breeds lack
Of respect for the rest of Your law's track.
Beloved, keep me from violence and flame
Of bad language, let respect be my claim.

32 And Jonathan said to his dad
Saul, "What has he done that's so bad
To be put to a death *so sad?*"
33 And then Saul lifted up his spear
Against Jonathan for his fear
To kill him, so Jonathan knew
His dad had decided in view
To kill David. 34 And Jonathan
Got up from the table *and ran*
In anger, and he did not eat
Food the month's second day *for treat*,
As he was grieved for David's sake
That his father shamed him *at stake*.
35 On the next day Jonathan went
Out in the field at the time meant,
Agreed upon with David and
A little lad went *at his hand*.

I'm glad to see that Jonathan is just
Like every other child of air and dust.
When things go wrong between dad and
himself

He goes to pout or gloat upon his shelf
Refusing to eat anything prepared
By parent in love or duty ensnared.
The greatest barricade to holiness
In faith or any endeavour for mess
Is family quarrels, that's the testing
ground.

Many the prophets and the seers are found
Great in the public eye, but turn around
And see how wife and child fit in the
frame.

That is the acid test of any claim.
Beloved, that's why You're Father as one
name.

36 Then he said to the lad, "Now run
And find the arrows from my gun."
And as the lad ran out, he shot
An arrow further than he'd got.

37 And when the lad came to the place
Where the arrow fell from the race
Of Jonathan, Jonathan cried
Out after the lad, saying "Bide
Not there, has not the arrow gone
Further and lies there on the lawn?"

38 Jonathan shouted to the lad,
"Hurry up now, run and be glad,"

And Jonathan's boy gathered all
The arrow and came at the call
Of his master. 39 And the boy did
Not know a thing, only where hid
David knew and Jonathan did.

40 And Jonathan gave to the boy
His weapons and told him "Ahoy,
Go back to the city *now, kid.*"

41 As soon as the boy had returned,
David got up from where he learned,
And fell on his face to the ground,
And bowed three times, and then they
kissed

One another, and wept dismissed
A great while. 42 And Jonathan said
To David, "Go in peace, we're led
Both to have sworn in name of YHWH,
Saying 'YHWH be between us two,
Me and you, and between my seed
And your seed for ever indeed.'"
And he got up and went his way,
But Jonathan to town to stay.

My question is, if David was so dear,
Why did not Jonathan join David's gear

And travel with David's men in the race
Of desert and mountain and rocky place?
Why did he return to the palace gate
To swarm with Saul the king and meet his
fate?

Was not the choice his own? He could
have gone

With David and lent his influence drawn
For David's sake and thus precipitate
The coming of the Messianic State.
Instead he was loyal to clan and dad,
And that will result in a fate as bad
As dying with the king rejected, sad
End to a friendship that still glitters great.

1 Samuel 21

1 Then David came to Nob and to
Ahimelech the priest in view,
And Ahimelech came to meet
David with fear of some deceit,
And said to him, "Why have you come
Alone without a single chum?"

And David told Ahimelech
The priest, "The king has given spec
To me a matter and told me,
'Let no one know anything, see,
Of the business I send you on,
Or what I told in pentagon.'

And I have sent my servants where
They will abide and will take care.

3 "Now then, what do you have on hand?
Give me five loaves of bread in brand
Or whatever's found in the land."

4 And the priest answered David and
Said "There's no common bread on hand,
But only holy bread, but if

The servants have kept from the stiff
With women." 5 And David replied
To the priest and told him aside,

"Truly women have been kept from
Us about three days *worrisome*,

And when I came out the young men
Had holy vessels under pen,

And though it was a common trip,
How much more then today to sip,
When they the holy bread shall dip?"

6 So the priest gave him holy things,
For there were no others for springs
But the showbread taken up from
Before YHWH, to replace in sum
With hot bread when he took the crumb.

7 There was that day one of Saul's men

Detained before YHWH once again,
Doeg the Edomite, he was
Tending the herds of Saul *abuzz*.

The story of the holy bread is told
Again after a thousand years have fed
The gates of Jerusalem and the fold.
David and his once ate the holy bread.
Before the eye of Edomite and crown,
Before the high priest, a man of renown,
David the fleeing shepherd and strong man
Ate bread in flight from the leviathan.
Beloved, I read David's words and the
words

Of Thomas Hobbes sitting upon the sherds
And think them both too optimistic for
The rate of government and fate of state.
Beloved, David does not yet know the eye
Of Doeg is a fatal one to spy.

8 And David asked Ahimelech,
"Do you have on hand spear or sword?
For I went fast at the king's beck,
And left behind my weapons stored."

9 And the priest said, "Goliath's sword,
The Philistine's, the one you gored
In vale of Elah, see, it's here
Wrapped in a cloth behind the gear
Of ephod, if you want that one,
Then take it, since no other one
Is here." And David said "There's none
Like that, give me that *and have done*."

10 And David got up and he fled
That day for fear of Saul and led
He went to Achish king of Gath.

11 And Achish' servants *on the path*
Told him, "Is this not David king
Of the land? And did they not sing
One to another about him
In dances, saying 'Saul was grim
To kill his thousands and David
His ten thousands *when come to bid?*'"

12 And David ruminated on
These words in his heart and was drawn
To fear Achish the king of Gath.

13 And so he changed his act *and math*
Before them, and pretended he
Was insane in their hands for fee,
And pounded on the entrance gate,
And slobbered his beard *to a state*.

14 Then Achish told his servants, "See,
You find a mad man and *in glee*

Why have you brought him here to me?
15 "Do I have lack of madmen that
You've brought this one to shoot the fat
Before me? Indeed, he shall not
Come in my house *for being sot*.

A pretty picture's that David now wears
As he goes down to Gath to look for mares.
He carries sword raised by Goliath's hand,
And stretches for peace to Philistine land,
Expecting to find friends where foes once
stood

Merely because his friends no longer
could.

If friends look out to kill, then never should
One seek faith from the enemy once down.
David had better find another town.
Beloved, I too am mad, I lift a sword
Too heavy to swing by me or my lord.
My beard is wet and tangled by the board
Where I consume grapes quartered once
and gored.

Whirl me once more, Beloved, who are
adored.

1 Samuel 22

1 So David left that place and fled
To the cave of Adullam led,
And when his brothers and all his
Father's house heard it, like a whiz
They came down to him there for biz.

2 And everyone who was distressed,
And everyone by debt unblessed,
And everyone in discontent,
Gathered to him there where he went,
And he became their own captain,
In all about four hundred men.

I hope David was not discouraged by
The humble numbers of his army's pie.
When Gideon went out to fight the foe
He gave them what for with three
hundred's blow.

Four hundred is too many for the fight
That lets Your glory take the place of right.
Even the Guided one will hardly spend
Much more than three hundred once come
to send.

Beloved, I gaze upon the morning sky
And realize with me not armies' cry,
Not three or four hundred, but three or four

At most join me to pound on heaven's
door.
Besides my spouse and spawn there's only
I,
And yet there is no I but You, not more.

3 David went from there to Mizpeh
And told the king of Moab's way,
"Please let my dad and mom here stay
With you till I know what God will
Do for me *and to foot the bill.*"
4 And he brought them to Moab's king,
And they lived with him there to sing
While David hid in fortified wing.
5 The prophet Gad said to David,
"Do not stay in the stronghold hid,
Get out and go to Judah's land"
Then David left and came in hand
Of Hereth's forest *with his band.*"

It's a good thing Gad's book of prophecy
Has been lost to all his posterity.
He sends David back into lion's jaw,
And he would send us today to the maw
Of Judah or some other enemy
From Rome to Shushan's silken canopy.
Ah no! Beloved, not every prophet's book
Is one into which I desire to look!
Your Decalogue seems sometimes more
than I

Am able to acquire without a sigh,
And as I struggle with the Hebrew verb
To say nothing of Greek aspect superb
And cantillate in monotone each verse
Muhammad taught against the heathen
curse,
I find there's book enough, so let Gad go
And remain safe in my own dungeon crow
In Your presence alone behind stone's
glow.

6 And Saul heard that David was found,
And his men with him on the ground,
Now Saul was sitting on the hill
Under a tamarisk tree's sill
In Ramah, with his spear in hand,
And all his servants stood in band.
7 And Saul said to his servants who
Stood all about him, "Hear now, you
Sons of Benjamin, will the son
Of Jesse indeed under sun
Give all of you the fields and vine,

And make you captains in the shrine
Of hundreds and of thousands' wine?
8 "Yet all of you conspire for wrong
Against me, and none sang the song
To me when my son made a pact
With Jesse's son so soon to act,
And there is none of you whose face
Is set in sorrow at my place,
Or tells me that my son has stirred
Up my servant against my word
For enemy, as now occurred?"

Poor Saul, he thought all men conspired to
keep
Faith with Jonathan and David, nor weep
When Saul felt betrayed awake or asleep.
This is the way of presidents and kings.
They always expect loyalty, not rings
Of justice, truth, or support of the poor.
Love of the king's the only thing that's
sure.

And so Saul points out how he has made
rich
Every man there who's grovelling in the
ditch.
Beloved, wealth and security alone
Are found before the glory of Your throne,
Not in obedience to flesh and bone.
I rush to You for refuge, though I know
Doeg still waits beyond faith's even glow.

9 And Edomite Doeg then said
In answer, who was set and led
The servants of Saul, "I saw son
Of Jesse coming to Nob's *run*,
To Ahimelech who is son
Of Ahitub, 10 And *it was done*
The priest inquired of YHWH for him,
And gave him victuals and the *grim*
Sword of Goliath, Philistine."

11 The king then called Ahimelech
The priest, son at Ahitub's *beck*,
And all his father's house, the priests
That were in Nob, *both men and beasts*,
And they all came to the king's *deck*.

12 And Saul said "Hear now, you son of
Ahitub." And he said *for love*,

"See, *here I am*, speak, *my lord king*."

13 And Saul said to him, "Say what thing
Made you and Jesse's son conspire
Against me, in that you gave him
Bread and a sword, and went in trim

To enquire of Alohim grim
 On his behalf, and raise him up
 Against me, lie in wait like tup
 As is today?" 14 Ahimelech
 Answered the king to *save his neck*,
 "Who among all your servants is
 So faithful as David, *the whiz*,
 Who is the king's son-in-law, and
 Who goes at your *word and* command,
 Honoured in your house *and the land*?
 15 "Have I begun today to seek
 Of Alohim for him and peek?
 Be it far from me, let not king
 Impute to his servant this thing,
 Nor to all of my father's house,
 For your servant knows not a louse
 Of all of this *in treasoning*."
 16 And king Saul said "You'll surely die,
 Abimelech, you and *the spy*
In all your father's house to cry."

Watch this, Beloved, the king You
 Yourself chose
 Is more evil than any could suppose.
 He condemns the innocent one who knows
 To hold him lord and master head to toes.
 Who wield the sceptre never fail to give
 Even to those who serve them drink from
 sieve.
 If Your own king is so unjust as Saul,
 Then what can be said of the ones in stall
 Today to grant life and death under pall?
 Beloved, keep me from bowing to the
 pope,
 The priest, the senator, in state of hope,
 The prime minister with his sandy rope.
 Beloved, I flee to You from justice here
 And choose rather Your punishment
 severe.

17 And the king said to Doeg, "Turn
 And fall upon the priests to *spurn*."
 And Doeg the Edomite went
 And fell upon the priests *unspent*
 And killed that day eighty-five men
 Who wore the linen ephod *then*.
 19 *He destroyed* Nob, the priests' own
 town
 With the mouth of the sword and down
 Both men and women, children, babes,
 Oxen, donkeys *for astrolabes*,

And sheep with the sword's mouth's
renown.

Who are not afraid with their own red
 hands
 To kill, still have their mercenary bands
 Of Syrian or Edomite in lands
 Where they can persecute innocent men.
 The airport in New York's a place again
 Dangerous to the innocent who stand
 To be taken to Damascus to find
 The rack and dungeon are no evil blind
 Of Middle Ages for a time confined.
 Beloved, the mercenary still awaits
 With shock and prod before the silly gates
 Of proud democracy. I seek Your own
 Rule and the mercy of Your throne.
 Beloved, save me from goddesses of stone.

20 And one son of Ahimelech
 The son of Ahitub in peck,
 Whose name was Abiathar, he
 Escaped to David gone to flee.
 21 Abiathar told David that
 Saul had killed all the priests that sat
 In presence of YHWH. 22 David said
 To Abiathar, "With what dread
 I knew it that day, Edomite
 That Doeg is would tell for spite
 Saul, I have brought about the death
 Of all your dad's house *that drew breath*.
 23 "Stay with me then, and do not fear
 For the one that like grenadier
 Seeks my life also seeks your own.
 With me you will be safe alone.

Protection is a thing rare to behold,
 And few there be who can have it and gold.
 The mass of rag-ass men have to be told
 By barons where things can be bought and
 sold.
 Whether Abiathar loved David or
 Saul better, the thing plain upon the shore
 Was he had no choice in his flight in store.
 Not right but safety informs who is bold.
 Beloved, I live and learn and yet I speak
 Out for the bleakness of the rulers' sneak.
 Who love You still stand where chance
 places each
 And silently they hear what others preach.
 The common enemy makes friend of
 friend,

And justice is the product of their end.

1 Samuel 23

1 They told David, "See, Philistines
Are fighting in Keilah's designs,
And robbing there the threshing floors."

2 And David enquired on those scores
Of YHWH, saying "Shall I attack
These Philistines *on front or back?*"
And YHWH said to David, "Yes, go
Attack the Philistines a blow
And save Keilah *and its chateau.*"

3 And David's men said to him, "See
How scared we are in Judah's *lea*,
How much more then if we go down
To Keilah against Philistines?"

4 Then David inquired *without frown*
Of YHWH once more. And YHWH
answered

Him saying "Get up and be stirred
To go down to Keilah's *designs*,
For I'll deliver Philistines
Into your hands." 5 So David and
His men went down to Keilah's land
And killed them with a slaughter grand.
So David saved all Keilah's folk.

6 It happened Abiathar woke,
The son of Ahimelech fled
To David in Keilah, and he
Came down with an ephod in fee.

7 But someone told Saul David had
Come to Keilah, and Saul was glad
To say "God's given him into
My hand, for he's shut in *for view*
By going in a town with gates
And bars *to shut him in with mates*.

Whatever David or his like may do,
There's someone telling Saul or some such
crew

The secret of his passing. Let him strike
A blow for justice and against the shriek,
Lift off the chains of robbery that bind
The poor in the oppression of the kind,
And someone will whisper the word in stall
Of Pentagon or some senator's hall.
Beloved, You Yourself told the man to go
And save the folk of Keilah from the show,
And put David in jeopardy to row.
Say a word to the king and the informer
Before they raise an army to the stormer,
Make prophets of the killer and good Joe.

8 And Saul called all the folk to war,
To go on down to Keilah's shore,
To besiege David and his men.

9 And David knew that Saul again
Devised mischief against his den.

And he said to Abiathar
The priest, "Bring here the ephod star."
10 Then David said "O YHWH the God
Of Israel, Your servant clod

Has surely heard that Saul now seeks
To come to Keilah where he wreaks
Destruction of the city for
My sake *and on Your servant's score*.

11 "Will the men of Keilah give me
Into his hand, will Saul come free
As Your servant has heard decree?
O YHWH and Israel's Alohim,
I pray You tell Your servant scheme."
And YHWH said "He'll come down I
deem."

12 Then David said "Will Keilah's men
Give me into Saul's hand again?"
And YHWH said "They'll do that, I ken."

13 And David got up with his men
Four hundred in number and they
Went out of Keilah in the way
They could. And someone told Saul that
David escaped from Keilah's fat,
And so he remained where he sat.

14 David stayed in the wilderness
Fastnesses, in the hills to bless,
In Wilderness of Ziph. And Saul
Looked for him each day to appal,
But Alohim did not give him
Into his hand *reckless and grim*.

Will Keilah's men give David to the king,
Despite the fact he saved them from the
wing

Of Philistine? You bet your bottom shekel.
The saved are always there to jeer and
heckle.

They did it in Keilah, and once again
They did it on Golgotha as free men.
They do it in the streets of Washington,
They do it in New York and in London.
Beloved, when any man sticks out his neck
To do a good deed, let him know the peck
Of cock and hen will soon fall on his head.
Atonement is the churchly lamb that bled,
Not gratitude nor free meals in the stalls

Of the Prytaneum or some such halls.

15 And David saw Saul did not come
Out to kill him. And so in sum
David stayed in the desert hold
Of Ziph and in the forest cold.

16 And Jonathan Saul's son got up
And went to David *for a scup*
In the forest and strengthened hand
In Alohim *and in his band*.

17 And he said to him, "Do not fear,
For Saul my father's hand and ear
Will not find you, and you will be
King over Israel and free,
And I shall be next to you there,
Of that also he is aware,
Saul my father." 18 So they both made
A promise before YHWH. He stayed,
Did David in the wood, but then
Jonathan went back to his den.

Oh Jonathan, my Jonathan, how oft
Have I wept at his fatal choice aloft
To return to his house and father's fame
When he might have stayed there in
David's claim.

I doubt not any crevice or cold wood
Grieved his body so much when he
withstood

The temptation to bide in David's tent.
He came to weep and promise, then he
went.

Beloved, I too come to Your holy place
And seek the tears of love upon Your face,
And after comforting my heart a while
I turn to bend the city with my guile.
Let me learn from Jonathan's careless way
Not only to find You, but then to stay.

19 The Ziphites then came up to Saul
At Gibeah, and said withal,
"Does not David hide in the wood
In the strongholds *as best he could*
With us in the hill of Hachilah,
On Jeshimon's south side *and stiller?*"

20 "Therefore, O king, come down and do
According to your will and view,
And our part shall be to give him
Up into the king's hand *and grim.*"

21 And Saul said "Blessed are you of
YHWH,
Who have compassion on my lieu.

See how fast killers glorify Your name
And feed on compassion they find in
blame!

Who killed the priests of Nob without a
qualm

Is ready to appeal to You in psalm.
Who threw the spear at his own son at hand
Is ready to join with the angel band.
Who spread plutonium throughout the land
Of Basrah now comes to the church to
stand

And sing Fanny Crosby's words of praise
to

You who look on what human beings do.
Beloved, save me from the hypocrisy
Of globalised faith that makes justice free.
Beloved, keep my mind, heart and tongue
well put

On Your ten words to guide my hand and
foot.

22 "Go and make sure his hiding place
And his haunt, and who's seen his face,
I've heard he's a crafty scapegrace.

23 "Take notice, knowledge of the holes
Where he hides, and come back with
scrolls,

And I'll go with you, if he's there,
I'll find him out from all the fair
Of Judah's families in care."

24 And they got up and went to Ziph
Before Saul, and David with skiff
Was in desert Maon with his men,
On plain south of Jeshamon's glen.

25 And Saul and his men went to seek
Him, but someone told David meek,
So he came down beside the rock
To live there on the desert stock
Of Maon, and Saul heard and he came
Following after David's name
To the desert of Maon *with flock*.

26 Saul went on one side of the hill,
And David and his men to fill
The mountain's other side, and he,
David hurried and made to flee
For fear of Saul, for Saul and crew
Surrounded David and *in view*
His men to take them *under screw*.

27 But then a messenger came to
Saul saying "Hurry now, please do,
The Philistines have made a raid

Upon the land *and all who stayed.*"
 28 So Saul turned back from his pursuit
 Of David, and went on the route
 Against the Philistines, that's why
 They called that place for alibi
 Sela-hammahlekoth, the rock
 Of the escape *from the king's squawk.*
 29 And David went up from that place
 And lived in the strongholds *of grace*
Of En-gedi, goat's well, a space.

Saved by the Philistine, once more the land
 Is free before David's face on the sand.
 The rock of the escape like any chair
 Between two boys at play to race and share
 Tag with mutual advance and retreat
 Saved David and his men from Saul's
 complete
 Rout. You, Beloved, my cunning mind
 would doubt
 Looked on with hardly intervention's spout
 Unless the Philistines obey Your call.
 They're not the ones who softly in the stall
 Await their master's voice. The proof that
 lot
 Of luck or providence that I have sought,
 Though still faded, threadbare, remains
 aloof.
 You are invisible beneath my roof.

1 Samuel 24

1 Now it happened, when Saul returned
 From after the Philistines *spurned*,
 That it was told him, saying "Take
 Note! David's in the desert wake
 Of En Gedi." 2 Then Saul took three
 Thousand chosen men from all *free*
 Israel, and went to seek *his man*,
 David and his men on the span
 Of rocks of the wild goats. 3 So he
 Came to the sheepfolds by the lee
 Road, where there *was* a cave, and Saul
 Went in to attend his needs' *call*.
 David and his men were there staying
 In the back of the cave's outlaying.
 4 And David's men said to him then,
 "This is the day of which YHWH then
 Said to you, 'Indeed, I will give
 Your foe into your hand *to live*,
 That you may do to him as it
 Seems good to you, *and as seems fit.*'"
 And David rose and secretly

Cut off a wing of Saul's robe, *see.*
 5 After that David's conscience hurt
 Him because he'd cut off Saul's skirt.
 6 And he said to his men, "May YHWH
 Forbid that I should such things do
 To my master and YHWH's messiah,
 To stretch hand against him pariah,
 Seeing that he is YHWH's messiah."
 7 So David persuaded his men
 With words and did not let them then
 Rise against Saul. And Saul arose
 From the cave and went from his doze.

See here, Beloved, result of having kings.
 Though all Israel knew Saul had broken
 wings
 Of hundreds of innocent priests and killed
 The righteous ones before You and
 unstilled,
 They follow Saul against the pure in heart,
 The shepherd boy, the driver of ox-cart,
 The faithful servant of the king, because
 The king calls them to fight against all
 laws.
 Who fight today are blinded by the glare
 Of government command, and timely stare
 At bodies thrown against the street and
 wall
 Before they go back to their whiskey stall
 And jerk to Baal's band music with no
 taint
 Of conscience, still believing each a saint.

8 And David got up too and went
 Out of the cave *at Saul's descent*,
 And shouted after Saul and said
 "My lord the king." And Saul instead
 Looked back, and David bowed his face
 Down to the ground and to abase.
 9 And David said to Saul, "Why do
 You listen to men's words, those who
 Say 'Listen, David's out for you?'"
 10 "See now, your very eyes see how
 Today YHWH set you at my mow
 In the cave, and I would not kill
 You, but spared you, and said 'I will
 Not lift up my hand on my lord,
 For he's YHWH's messiah *restored*.
 11 "Moreover, my father, see here,
 The skirt of your robe from the rear
 Is in my hand, for it was I
 Cut off the skirt of your robe sly,

But did not kill you, so you know
And see there's no evil for show
In my hand, and I've done no wrong
Against you, though you have been long
Lying in wait to break my gong.

12 "Let YHWH judge between me and
you,

YHWH avenge me of what you do,
But my hand shall not be on you.

13 "As says the word of ancient time,
'From wicked ones comes out the crime,'
But my hand shall not touch your prime.

14 "After whom is Israel's king come?
Whom does he pursue with such hum?
After a dead dog, flea *and bum*.

15 "YHWH therefore be judge and say
right

Between me and you, see and fight
For my cause and rescue me out
Of your hand *royal and redoubt*."

Note, my Beloved, how well David has
learned

To flatter kings and forget all the spurned.
What about Abiathar's dad and boys
All killed by Saul to enhance David's joys?
Instead of grovelling upon the sand
David should demand justice for the
manned.

Instead of speaking sweet words to the
king,

David should be lifting oppression's wing.
The institution of the state no matter
How small and good becomes at last the
fatter

In injustice and in oppression's wheel.
If there are kings then some are under heel.
All is usurped authority except
Submission to You only and such kept.

16 It happened when David had stopped
Speaking these words not overtopped,
That Saul said "Is this your own voice,
David my son?" *To give invoice*
Saul lifted voice and wept *for choice*.

17 And he said to David, "You're more
Righteous than I, for you keep store
Of good to me, whereas I gave
You evil and wrong. 18 "At this cave
You have declared today how you
Have dealt well with me *and my crew*,
Since I was in your power by YHWH,

You did not kill me *when in view*.

19 "For any man who finds his foe
Will he let him escape and go?
May YHWH reward you for the good
You did to me today as should.

20 "And now see I know you will be
Certainly king of Israel's fee,
And that Israel's kingdom will be
Established by your hand's decree.

21 "Swear now therefore by YHWH to me
That you will not destroy freely
My descendants come after me,
And not blot out my name at all
From the house of my dad and stall."

22 So David swore to Saul and Saul
Went home, but David and his men
Got into the stronghold again.

The men of David did not go to Saul
To sleep again beneath his bin and stall.
They went back to the stronghold with
their chief

So that the treaty with Saul, though relief,
Was not a thing to trust with life and limb.
A king may promise, but who trust in him
Lose safety of the desert cave and rock.
I look around me also and take stock.
The stillness of the morning on the trees
Brings me with birch and fir down to my
knees,

Not to a king or president to please,
But before You alone, Beloved, to stay.
I make my peace with killers in the way,
And stand in Your word only for today.

1 Samuel 25

1 Then Samuel died, and all Israel
Gathered themselves to weep a while,
And bury him at his house at
Ramah. David from where he sat
Got up, went to the wilderness
Of Paran. 2 There a man from Maon
Had all his wealth in Carmel's town,
And he was a very great man,
And had three thousand sheep to scan,
A thousand goats, and he was there
In Carmel shearing his sheep's *hair*.
3 And the name of the man was Nabal,
And the name of his wife at table
Was Abigail, the woman was
Of good understanding as does,
And had a figure beautiful,

But the man was a cad and churl,
Evil in his doings like earl.
4 David heard in the wilderness
That Nabal sheared his sheep *of dress*.
5 And David sent ten young men, and
David told the young men at hand,
“Get up to Carmel, Nabal’s land
And greet him in my name and stand.

The death of Samuel barely gets a note,
While Nabal is a man that many quote.
I too am guilty, guilty as You are
In shunting aside righteous man for star.
I too complain about the wicked set
In every sonnet or ghazel I let
Flow from my keyboard. Still like You I
find

My silent and my constant joys that bind
Those small conceits to moments pearl-
entwined

In weathers marching with stealthy fox feet
Across the birchen sky of my retreat.
My calm is rarely ruffled by the sleet.
Instead I hum it simple hymns of grey
Along the gold and silver of my day.

6 “And say ‘May you and all your house
Prosper and be in peace *like grouse*.
7 ‘Now see, I’ve heard your shepherds who
Were with us in the wilderness
And whom we did not hurt nor was
There anything missing from claws
All the while they were in Carmel,
8 ‘Ask your servants and they will tell,
They’re shearing now. Let the young men
Find favour in your eyes again,
For we come here on a good day,
Give what you have in hand, we pray,
To your son David.’” 9 David’s men
Arrived and spoke these words again
To Nabal, as David had said,
All of his words as they were led.
10 And Nabal answered David’s boys,
And said, “Who’s David who employs,
And who the son of Jesse, too?
These days there are plenty in view
Who forsake their own master’s crew.
11 “Shall I then take water and bread
And flesh of my beasts that I’ve fed
And killed for my shearers and give
To men I don’t know where they live?”

Grant this, Beloved, if Saul had come
along

Looking for donkeys time of evensong,
And asked a boon of Nabal for himself
Or for his servant, or for even elf,
Nabal would have kicked him outside and
shut

Fast against him bowels of mercy and butt.
It’s not a grief in personal that makes
The crass of men unmerciful for shakes.
It’s rather their applauding of the great
That inspires stepping on the meek in state.
David’s rebellious proletariat
And nothing more, a servant out of step,
And that’s why Nabal’s churlish to his rep,
And answers haughtily and with such pep.

12 So David’s young men turned around
And went back and told what they’d found.

13 And David told his men “Gird on
Every man his sword *and be gone*.”

And every man put on his sword
And David too put on his sword,
And there went after David just
About four hundred men *in lust*,
And two hundred stayed behind to
Take care of the baggage *in crew*.

14 But one young man came out and told
Abigail, Nabal’s wife, “Behold,
David sent messengers out from
The desert, to our lord to come
And greet him, but he turned away
And spurned request *for drink and hay*.

15 “But the men were so good to us,
Did not hurt us or demand ruse
As long as we were with them there.

16 “When we were in the field with care,
They were like a wall to us both
Night and day, every day *of growth*
In feeding the flock. 17 “Now just wait
And see what they will do to fate,
For evil is determined *late*
Against our master and his gate,
For he is such a churlish man
That no one speaks to him or can.”

18 And Abigail hurried and took
Two hundred loaves and *in a rook*
Two bottles of wine, and five sheep
Ready dressed and five more *to keep*
Measures of parched corn, and five score
Clusters of raisins, and two *more*
Hundred cakes of figs and put them

On donkeys' backs *in stratagem*.

Two bottles of wine for six hundred men
Will not go far for song and drink again.
O my Beloved, the lady did not think
Bottles of wine should be used for their
drink.

O my Beloved, what can six hundred do,
Two bottles of wine when they're brought
in view?

The wine in such amount could only stay
Lesions and such in a medicine's way.
Enough of wine there's not for even sip,
So let each drunkard give a finger dip.
With such tales of winebibbers all along
In David's army, I sing my own song.
No wine to drink, but only for the few,
Enough for medicine in desert dew.

19 And she said to her servants, "Go
Before me and I shall come slow
After you." But she did not tell
Her husband Nabal *of the spell*.

20 It happened as she rode her ass
And came down by the mountain pass,
That there came David and his men
Towards her, met her in the glen.

21 And David said, "Surely I've kept
Safe in the desert while he slept
All this fellow's possession so
Nothing was lacking on the go,
And he's paid my good with the show
Of evil. 22 "So God do to foe
Of David and do more also,
If I leave of what's in his glow
Of morning light one male to stow."

See here, Beloved, the origin of state.
Where herders face the robber band and
wait

To find their protection from rival mate,
There is born the unspoken contract's
plate.

Who have the power to wrong, when they
refrain,

Consider that a debt's incurred for pain.
The only proper way to meet the wain
Is to bow and scrap to the robber's stain.
When it's in a man to be king, a man
After Your own heart, still when'er he
can,
He'll be king even of six hundred band,

And against every shepherd make a stand.
Beloved, You lie behind the mark and
stew,
Giving and retrieving strength as You do.

23 When Abigail saw David's face,
She hurried and got down with grace
From her donkey and fell before
David upon her face and corps
Prostrating to the ground and floor.

24 And she fell at his feet and said
"On me, my lord, and on my head
Be the iniquity and let
Your handmaid, I pray, one word get
In your ear, hear your handmaid yet.

25 "Let not my lord, I pray, regard
This base fellow, Nabal, blackguard,
For as his name, so is his shame,
Nabal means scoundrel, that's his game,
But I your handmaid did not see
The servants of my lord's decree.

26 "Now therefore, my lord, as YHWH
lives,

And as your soul lives and grace gives,
Seeing YHWH's stopped you in the path
Of blood guiltiness born of wrath
To take vengeance for yourself from
Your own hand, so now therefore come
And let your enemies and those
That seek evil to my lord's hose
Become as Nabal, *withered rose*.

27 "And so accept this token which
Your servant brought my lord in pitch,
Let it be given to the men
That follow my lord *back again*.

28 "Forgive, I pray, your handmaid's sin,
For YHWH will surely make the bin
Of my lord a firm house, because
My lord fights YHWH's battles sans pause,
And evil is not found in you
In all the days you *drink the dew*.

29 "And though a man may rise to seek
Your death, my lord's soul is not weak
To be bound in bundle of life
With YHWH your Alohim, while strife
Shall sling the souls of your foes out
As from a hollow sling in rout.

30 "And it shall come to pass when
YHWH

Shall have done to my lord and crew
According to all the good He
Has promised to do in your fee,

And shall have set you Israel's prince,
31 "That this shall be no stumbling wince
To you, nor offence of heart to
My lord, either that you would do
Such shedding of blood without cause,
Or that my lord should be in claws
Of vengeance. And when YHWH shall
deal
Well with my lord, hold then my weal."

See, my Beloved, the mix of motives here
That play on Abigail come out with fear
Before David to bow and beg a cheer.
She recognizes robber band's employ
And the right of protector to enjoy
The benefits of labour to the boy
Who slinks among the desert rocks in ploy.
She recognizes David's coming reign
And bets her life against the former pain.
In all this she finds only selfish need.
There's nothing here of righteousness
indeed.
And yet she notes that David's hand is just
And that no wickedness yet mars his dust.
For that her faith's greater than mustard
seed.

32 And David said to Abigail,
"Blessed be YHWH and of Israel
Alohim, who sent you today
To meet me here *upon the way*.
33 "And blessed be your discretion and
Blessed be you that you held my hand
To day from shedding blood on land
And finding vengeance for my stand.
34 "For indeed as YHWH Israel's God
Lives, who has kept me with His prod
From hurting you, except you had
Hurried and come to meet my lad,
Surely there had not been left one
Male to Nabal at morning sun."
35 So David took from her hand what
She had brought him *to fill his gut*,
And he told her, "Go up in peace
To your house, see, I've heard your lease,
Accepted your person's *increase*."

Noon or night, my Beloved, hear my
appeal
Out of chill avenging desire I feel
Over the quest to seek Your face alone.
No satisfaction can beat Your bright steel.

Eternally, it seems, the human bone
Lingers along the cutting sword and stone,
Eternally a light comes to console
Fathoms above the pain beside Your
throne.
The hope of vengeance turns to love in
soul,
Now flickering, now burning at the heart
Across the shadows, dimming them with
light.
Before the sting of hurt through skin and
scroll,
Above the storm calmed by the sacred part,
Love rises to illuminate the night.

36 And Abigail came to Nabal,
And see he held a feast to hail
A king, and the heart of Nabal
Was merry in him, he was drunk.
And she said nothing till night sunk
In dawn. 37 It happened in the morn,
When Nabal woke up from wine's scorn,
His wife told him of all these things,
And his heart died before the stings
And became as stone *without wings*.
38 It so happened after ten days
YHWH struck down Nabal *from his ways*.
So he died. 39 And when David heard
Nabal was dead, he said a word,
"Blessed be YHWH that pleaded the cause
Of my reproach from Nabal's claws,
And kept back His own servant's paws
From the hand of evil, and yet
The wickedness of Nabal set
YHWH on his own head." David sent
And spoke of Abigail and meant
To take her to him as wife *lent*.
40 And when David's servants had come
To Abigail on Carmel's *plum*,
And spoke to her saying "David
Has sent us to you and to bid
You come to him to be his wife."
41 And she got up and bowed her face
Down to the earth and then gave place
To speech, "See, your handmaid is but
A servant to wash feet that jut
From your slaves." 42 And Abigail fast
Got up and rode and finely assed,
With five damsels of hers that came
After her, and she went in claim
After David's messenger band
And became his own wife in hand.

43 David also took from Jezreel
Ahinoam, and they both deal
To become his wives *and to heel*.
44 For Saul had given Michal his own
Daughter and David's wife alone
To Phalti son of Laish grown,
Who was of Gallim, *flesh and bone*.

Like Abigail, who pretended to be
Shy and demure, I stay the world to see
Your face that beckons promising to wed
My soul to Yours and in love to be fed.
Who would have washed the feet of slave
instead
Of being bride to David, when she fled
Towards him she did not take lower road.
She took the fastest donkey and a goad.
Beloved, though I pretend that I am small,
Beneath your notice and beneath Your call,
As soon as You send but a breath of wind,
A ray of sunlight through a cloud, I've
sinned
To find Your presence at my heart and
door.
My donkey pants and wheezes what is
more.

1 Samuel 26

The Ziphites came to Saul who sat
In Gibeah, a hill not flat,
And said "Is David not here hiding
In the hill of Hachilah biding,
Across from Jeshimon *we're guiding?*"
2 So Saul got up and went down to
The wilderness of Ziph with crew
Of three thousand in chosen men
Of Israel with him again,
To Seek David in wilderness
Of Ziph. 3 Saul pitched at the aggress
Of Hachilah's hill opposite
Jeshimon. But David saw fit
To stay in the desert and he
Saw Saul came after him in spree
Into the desert. 4 David sent
Out spies and found out Saul's advent.
5 David got up, came to the place
Where Saul had pitched his tent in space,
And David saw where Saul lay down
And Abner son of Ner no clown
But captain of his army, and
Saul lay inside the barricade
The folk pitched round on every hand.

6 Then David answered and he said
To Ahimelech, Hittite paid
And to Abishai who was son
Of Zeruiah, brother won
To Joab, saying "Who will go
Down with me to Saul's camp to show?"
And Abishai said "I will go."
7 So David and Abishai came
To the folk at night to their shame
And Saul lay sleeping there inside
The barricade with spear to ride
Stuck in the ground beside his head,
And Abner and the folk he led
Lay round about him all out-spread.

Beloved, I creep about the camp of Saul,
The anointed who disappointed call,
Ordained the vicar of Christ but to fall
Denies Your law in word and deed and
stall.

I creep about the golden altars and
Look on the images on every hand
And see the marbled pillars where they
stand

And see the sacrificed lifted up high.
The worshippers in eager lust of eye
Turn to the flesh and blood of saviour's
cry.

Back, back I creep before the sleeping
guards
And find my place among the dusty shards
Where in my poverty I seek and find
The veils of daily cup and bread resigned.

8 Then Abishai said to David,
"Alohim delivered He did
Your enemy into your hand
Today, now therefore let me stand
To strike him, please with spear in hand
Down to the earth and at one stroke,
And I will strike again the bloke."
9 And David said to Abishai,
"Do not destroy him though he's nigh,
For who can lay a hand upon
YHWH's anointed and guiltless drawn?"
10 And David said "As YHWH lives, no,
But YHWH shall strike him down not
slow,
Or his day shall come once to die,
Or he'll go down with battle cry
And perish. 11 "YHWH forbid that I
Should put forth hand against messiah

Of YHWH, but now take the pariah,
The spear that's at his head and yet
The water bottle and let's get."
12 So David took the spear and jar
Of water from Saul's head then far
Away they went and no man saw
Nor knew it, nor did any jaw
Wake up, for they were all asleep,
Because a trance sent down from YHWH
Had fallen on all of Saul's crew.

The tardemah once fell on Adam and
The female side was taken from his hand,
And since that day a man has left his mom
And rushed to wear his wife's ring and
pompom.

The trance that fell on men of old was full
Of blessings and of revelation's pull.
But by the time the sons of men had come
To Saul's day, trances were more often
rum

Than revelation. My Beloved, let me
Face day and night with eyes as clear to see
The glories and weights of reality.
I need no trance to find the wicked gleam
Of injustice, nor yet the steady stream
Of beauty and grace from Your unity.

13 Then David took the other side
And stood on the hill to deride,
A great space between them to bide.

14 And David shouted to the folk
And to Abner, Ner's son, the bloke,
And said "Abner, don't you reply?"
And Abner answered at a stroke,
"Who's shouting at the king and why?"

15 And David said to Abner, "You
Are a brave man, isn't that true?
Who in Israel's like you, now who?
Why don't you guard your lord the king?
Someone came in to snatch his wing.
16 "This thing's not good that you have
done.

As YHWH lives you deserve the gun,
And death because you did not guard
Your lord, YHWH's messiah, your pard.
And now see where the king's spear's led
And water bottle by his head."

17 And Saul knew David's voice and said
"Is that your voice, David my son?"
And David said *like paragon*,
And David said "I'm your servant,

O lord king." 18 And *not arrogant*,
He said "Why does my lord pursue
His servant? And what do I do?
What evil's in my hand in view?
19 "Now therefore, please, let my lord king
Hear his servant's words in a string.
If YHWH has stirred you against me,
Let Him accept offering in fee,
But if the sons of men, cursed be
Such ones before YHWH, for they drive
Me out today out of the hive
Of YHWH's inheritance and say
'Go serve other gods *in the way*.'
20 "Now therefore, do not let my blood
Fall to the earth away like flood
From YHWH's presence, for Israel's king
Has come out after one flea's wing
As when one hunts bird on the wing
In the mountains *above the spring*."

Ah, my Beloved, like David I am sent
From every temple, church and gospel tent
To serve as it were other gods and be
The guest of Bedouin, Hindu, Parsee.
Who claims Your own anointing in the see
Of Peter and of John has cast me out
Despite my love confessing without doubt
That You are God alone and Your
command

Is ever at my ear and eye and hand.
Like David I give offering as I stand
If I have sinned against You in the land,
But curse the bishop and the mufti grand
Who thrusts me out to hermitage
unmanned.
Beloved, You only hear my prayers
devout.

21 And Saul said "I have sinned indeed,
Turn now, son David, and give heed,
For I will never more harm you,
Because my life in precious view
Today you saw, and see, I've played
The fool and erred greatly waylaid."
22 David answered and said "See now,
The king's spear, one servant allow
To come over and take the bough.
23 "And YHWH will render every man
According to his deeds as can
In righteousness and faithfulness,
Since YHWH gave you to my address
Today, and I would not lift hand

Against YHWH's messiah to stand.

24 "And see, as your life here today
Was precious so that I'd not slay,
So let my life before YHWH be
Precious, and may He protect me
From all the troubles that I see."

25 And Saul said to David, "Blessed be
You, my son David, valiantly
You shall do and prevail, I see."
And David turned and went his way,
And Saul went to his place to stay.

Even though Saul repented and confessed
His sin, David did not trust in his vest,
But let a servant be the go between.
Willing to stand up, willing to be seen,
David was not willing to set aside
The arms and distance protecting his ride,
But kept his safety and security
And went back to the fastnesses still free.
The Christian people who wronged me and
sent

Me to die of hunger if things so bent
Unlike Saul then do not relent, repent.
That's why, Beloved, I place no trust in
them

Who sully Your messiah's seamless hem,
While I lift up Your word as ensign's gem.

1 Samuel 27

1 And David said to himself, "I
Shall be killed one day by and by
By the hand of Saul, there is naught
Better for me than that I sought
Escape in the Philistines' land,
Till Saul despair of me at hand
To seek me any more along
The borders of Israel for wrong,
So I shall escape from his hand.

2 So David got up and passed over,
He and the six hundred men *rover*
That were with him to Achish son
Of Maoch, king of Gath *when done*.

3 And David stayed with Achish there
At Gath, he and his men to share
Each with his household, David and
His two wives, Ahinoam bland
The Jezreelitess, Abigail

The Carmelitess, Nabal's grail.

4 And it was told to Saul that he
David had fled to Gath to be,
And so he sought no more *in spe*.

5 And David said to Achish, "If
Now I have found favour *and stiff*
In your eyes, let them give me place
In one of the cities for space
In the country, for why should I
Live with you in the royal sty?"

I too live in a strange land from my prime
Until this day of grace and woeful time.
Beloved, I know the kings out to repair
The wealth of the oppressor with a care,
And how my heart is but a ball to kick
Out of the way to pick up Sabbath stick.
I dwell in Gath and bow down to the king,
And smile and pay taxes and everything,
But in my heart I know Your law above
Is true despite the dagger in his glove.
I close my doors about me and I sing
The cadence of commandments on the
wing
Across the tough twigs that soon as the
spring
Will burst in bird cherry blossom and
swing.

6 So Achish gave him Ziklag then,
Which is why Ziklag with its men
To this day still belongs to kings
Of Judah. 7 And the days in strings
David stayed in Philistine land
Was four months. 8 And David in hand
With his men went up to attack
All the Geshurites and the back
Of Gizrites and Amelekites,
Since they lived in the land and sites
From ancient time as one enshipped
Might go toward Shur up to Egypt.
9 And David struck the land and left
Nor man nor woman live in cleft,
And they took flocks and herds and
donkeys

And camels and clothing of honkeys,
And went to Achish with the heft.

10 And Achish said "Where have you
made

A raid today?" And David said
Against the south of Judah and
Against south Jerahmeelites' land,
And against south of Kenites band."

11 And David left nor man to gal
Alive to bring them to Gath's sal,
Saying "Lest they should tell on us,

Saying ‘So did David and thus
Has been his manner all the while
He’s lived in Philistines’ land’s stile.”
12 And Achish believed David and
Said “He has made his people’s band
Of Israel utterly abhor
Him, therefore he’ll serve me the more.”

What desert is this world where honest
men
Must lie and cheat to survive in the fen!
David could stay in Judah and in time
Be executed for a trumped up crime,
Or go to strange gods and their kings
pretending
To help them in heathen temples
defending.
David was taught to walk deceitful line
Living about the court of kings and swine.
I too see profit consume all the wine
Of human mercy and justice divine.
Beloved, I strut out to defend the way
And barter with Your word by night and
day,
And cantillate the quaver still and low.
Beloved invisible, this for the show.

1 Samuel 28

1 It happened in those days they came
The Philistines did as in blame
To go out to fight Israel’s flame,
And Achish said to David, “You
Know certainly you’ll go to do
Battle with me, your men and you.”
2 And David said to Achish, “True
You know what your servant can do.”
And Achish said to David then,
“Therefore I’ll treat you as your due
One of the chiefs of my chief men.”
3 Now Samuel was dead and mourned by
All Israel, and buried by
Ramah his own city. And Saul
Had put away those that by call
Divined by ghost in spirit’s thrall
Out of the land *and house and stall*.
5 But when Saul saw the Philistine
Armies, he was afraid *to whine*,
And his heart trembled *on the vine*.
6 And Saul inquired of YHWH and
YHWH
Did not answer for what he’d do,
Neither by dreams by Urim nor

By prophets *called up from the door*.
7 Then Saul said to his servants, “Seek
For me a woman that can speak
Divining by a spirit, that
I may go to her *where she sat*
And inquire of her.” And his men
Said to him, “See there is *again*
A woman that divines by ghost
At Endor, *somewhere in that coast*.”
8 And Saul disguised himself and put
On other clothing, hand and foot,
And went, he and two men with him,
And they came to the woman dim
By night, and he said “Divine me,
Please by the spirit and bring me
Up whom I name to you in fee.”
9 And the woman told him, “Now see,
You know what Saul has done, how he
Has cut off those who divine by
A ghost or spirit known or shy
Out of the land, so then say why
You set a trap to snare my life
And cause my death *with whetted knife?*”
10 But Saul swore to her by YHWH’s
name,
And said “As YHWH lives, there’s no
blame
Will fall on you for this thing’s shame.”
11 Then the woman said “Whom shall I
Bring up to you?” And he said “Why
Bring up Samuel for me *or try*.”
12 When the woman saw Samuel, she
Shouted with a loud voice freely
And said to Saul, “Why deceive me?
For you are Saul *sure as can be*.”
13 And the king told her, “Do not fear,
Tell me whom you have seen appear.”
The woman said to Saul, “I see
Alohim coming from earth’s ley.”
And he said to her, “Of what form?”
And she said to him, “An old man
Coming up and with mantle scan.”
And Saul recognized Samuel’s norm,
And he bowed down there with his face
To the ground prostrate *in that place*.
15 And Samuel said to Saul, “Now why
Have you disturbed me on the sly
To bring me up?” And Saul’s reply
Was, “I am greatly distressed by
The Philistine war against me,
And God has departed from me,
And answers me no more, not by

Prophets nor dreams, so therefore I
Have called you to say what and why.”

16 And Samuel said “Why do you ask
Me, seeing that YHWH wears a mask
And’s taken up enemy’s task?

17 “And YHWH has done Him as He
spoke

By me, and YHWH tore up and broke
The kingdom from your power to give
It to your neighbour fugitive,
David, 18 “because you’re a foul bloke
Not to hear voice of YHWH that spoke,
And did not execute His wrath
In fierceness on Amalek’s path,
That’s why YHWH’s done this thing to
you

Today *just giving you your due*.

19 “Moreover YHWH shall give you up
And Israel to Philistine cup,

And tomorrow you and your sons
Will be with me *upon your buns*,
YHWH will deliver Israel’s host
Into the Philistines’ hands’ *boast*.”

20 And right away Saul fell full length
Upon the earth and lost his strength
For fear because of Samuel’s words,
For he’d put no food in his girds
All that day or night *from his herds*.

21 And the woman came up to Saul
And saw him afraid of the pall
And said to him, “See, your handmaid
Listened to your voice and obeyed,
And I’ve put my life in my hand
And obeyed your voice by command
That you spoke to me *as I stand*.

22 “Now listen, please, to the voice of
You handmaid, and I’ll set with love
Before you a morsel of bread,
And eat and so you shall be fed,
For it’s a long way you are led.”

23 But he refused, said “I’ll not eat.”
But his servants came to entreat
Along with the woman, till he
Obeyed their voice and got slowly
Up from the earth, sat on a bed.

24 The woman had a fatted calf
In the house, hurried on behalf
Of it and took some meal to knead,
And made unleavened cakes to feed.

25 She brought it and set before Saul
And his servants, and at the call
They ate and got up and went out

Departing in the night about.

The witch and medium today that sits
In trance and glory to compose her fits
Is like to offer a delicious feast
For everyone who ignores Christian priest
To come to her door seeking the released.
The New-Age power is not a thing that’s
new

Upon the hard packed earth for earthy
crew,

But longs to spread its wings above the
view

Of centuries of human history.

The witch and medium are aye in fee.

Beloved, I follow neither moral feet

To find the answers to my bread and meat,

But stake my trust in the unknown retreat,

And sit with You in Your eternity.

1 Samuel 29

1 And so the Philistines and all
Their armies gathered *at the call*

To Aphek, and the Israelites
Encamped beside the spring’s *delights*
That’s found nearby Jezreel’s *heights*.

2 And the lords of the Philistines
Passed in hundreds and thousand’s *signs*,
And David and his men passed on
Behind with Achish *and his spawn*.

3 And so said the Philistine chiefs,
“Why are these Hebrews here *in reefs*?”

And Achish told the Philistine
Princes, “Is not this David fine,
The servant of Saul Israel’s king,
Who’s been with me days and years’ *swing*
And I have found no fault in him
Since he fell away on the rim

To this day.” 4 And the princes of
The Philistines and without love
Were angry with him and they said,
The princes of Philistines did,
“Make this fellow go back as led
To place appointed *where he hid*,
And let him not go down with us
To fight, lest in the blunderbuss
Of battle he turn enemy,

For how should he make himself free
To his master unless it be

With the heads of these men *in fee*?

5 “Is this not David whom they praised
In songs to one another raised

And dances saying ‘Saul has killed
 His thousands and David has spilled
 His ten thousands *when others tilled?*’”
 6 Then Achish called David and said
 To him, “Surely as YHWH’s not dead,
 You have been upright and your going
 Out and your coming without slowing
 With me in the army is good
 In my sight, for I’ve found there stood
 No wickedness in you since when
 You came to me to this day’s glen,
 Yet the chiefs don’t like you, *your men*.
 7 “So now return and go in peace,
 Not to displease the chiefs *in lease*
 Of the Philistines *to increase*. ”

The innocent and honest Achish spent
 His wisdom to reconcile armies lent
 And make peace between David and the
 lords
 Of Philistines come out bearing their
 swords.
 His words are calm and kind and show
 with grace
 The faith in You, Beloved, that grew in
 trace
 Through his association with the one
 You had anointed under Samuel’s sun.
 But of the two, the lords on one hand and
 The sweet Achish upon the other stand,
 The wicked Philistine lords are the ones
 Who see reality behind the tonnes
 Of masks. Beloved, let me share in both
 peace
 And in the cunning before my release.

8 And David asked Achish, “But what
 Have I done *to deserve the shut?*
 And what have you found in your servant
 As long as I’ve been with you fervent
 Until this day, that I may not
 Go out to fight against the lot
 Of my lord the king’s enemies?”
 9 And Achish answered *by degrees*
 And said to David, “I know that
 You’re good before me where you sat,
 Like an angel of Alohim,
 And yet the princes, *it would seem*,
 Of the Philistines have said ‘He
 Shall not go out with us *to see*
 The battle.’ 10 “Now then rise up early
 In the morning with servants burly

Of your master who’ve come with you,
 And as soon as the light’s in view
 In early morning take your leave.”
 11 David and his men to relieve
 Got up early to go their way
 In the morning to go as may
 Back to the land of Philistines.
 The Philistines went to Jezreel.

I like to think that Achish mentions here
 Not gods of common lands that all men
 fear,

But intends to speak Your name in the ear
 Of David as he sees his angel face.
 Beloved, as I look on the come and trace
 Of men and women in this sacred place
 Of earth, I pray to find in all I see
 Reflection from the bright angelic tree.
 All human faces are angels once sent
 From You, Beloved, from You to represent
 The one divine vision to all men lent.
 No matter what David’s secret intent,
 The message of Your oneness opens clear
 To human hearts bowed at Your throne or
 near.

1 Samuel 30

1 It happened when David and crew
 Arrived in Ziklag where they drew
 On the third day, Amalekites
 Had made a raid upon the sites
 Of the south and on Ziklag’s shore,
 Attacking Ziklag, what is more
 Burning it with a blaze *of lights*.
 2 Had taken women captive all
 Who were there, killed them not at all,
 Neither the great nor yet the small,
 But carried them off in their thrall.
 3 David and his men came into
 The city and saw *what was true*,
 How it was burned with fire and all
 Their wives, sons, daughters were in thrall.
 4 Then David and the folk with him
 Raised their voices and wept not dim
 Until they had no power to weep.
 5 And David’s two wives were in deep
 As captives, Ahinoam who
 Was from Jezreel, and the wife too
 Of Nabal Carmelite whose name
 Was Abigail *and beyond blame*.
 6 And David was greatly distressed,
 Because the folk had left unguessed

Their intention of stoning him,
Because all the people were grim
With grief, and every man for sons
And daughters, but David *for guns*
Heartened himself in his God YHWH.

It should be heartening to me to see
That David suffered more than I to be
A king in Israel, so no complaint
Should mar my efforts to become a saint.
I've never lost a wife or two to fire
Nor grieve for stolen child, yet I retire
To lick my scratches while the good and
great
Stitch up their broken bones to match their
fate.

But seeing suffering just does not create
In me joy for my unsuffered estate.
Yet I follow suite and come to relate
My joy in You, Beloved, though eye is
clear
To see how much suffering there is and
fear.
Hearten me now before both clod and ire.

7 David said to Abiathar
The priest, Ahimelech's son, star,
Please bring the ephod here to me.
Abiathar brought David, see,
The ephod to enquire freely.
8 And David enquired of YHWH saying
"Shall I pursue this troop repaying?
Shall I overtake them?" And He
Answered him, "Pursue them freely
For you shall surely overtake
And without fail take back *the cake*."
9 So David went, he and the six
Hundred men with him and with tricks
Came to the brook Besor, where those
Left behind stayed *with gear and clothes*.
10 But David pursued, he and four
Hundred men, for two stayed in store
Who were so faint they could not go
Over the brook Besor *in stow*.
11 They found Egyptian in the field
And brought him to David for yield,
And gave him bread and he did eat,
And made him drink water for treat,
12 And they gave him some of a cake
Of figs, and two of raisin stake,
And when he'd eaten, he revived,
For he'd had no bread and survived

Without water three days and nights.
13 And David asked him, "To whom do
You belong?" And he said "I'm true
A young man of Egypt in crew
As servant to Amalekite,
And my master left me in site
Because three days ago I fell
Sick, *so he let me go to hell*.
14 "We made invasion on the south
Of Cherethites and on the mouth
Of Judah, and on Caleb's south
And burned Ziklag with fire *for drouth*."
15 And David asked him, "Can you bring
Me down to where these people sing?"
And he said "Swear by Alohim
To me that you'll not kill or seem
To give me to my master's hand,
And I'll bring you down to this band."

Beloved, I've been abandoned by the hand
Of cruel masters come to ravage land
With the oppression of consumer band
And the free dealing of petroleum
And tinsel silver and uranium.
I've been abandoned with no drought to
drink
That's unpolluted lying on the brink
Of starvation beside the well-filled stores,
To die alone outside locked and closed
doors.
Beloved, there's only You, and yet You are
Greater than fame and wealth of John and
star.
Take me up and with raisin cakes restore
My breath and I will give You secrets
more,
If there is anything You wish in bar.

16 And when he'd brought him down,
behold,
They were spread out on the earth cold,
Eating and drinking, dancing bold,
Because of all the spoil in state
They had removed in volumes great
From Philistine's land and the land
Of Judah. 17 David led attack
From between evenings till the stack
Of evening of the next day come.
And not one man from out their sum
Escaped except four hundred young
Men on camels fleeing the dung.
18 And David got back all that they

The Amalekites took away,
And David rescued his two wives.
19 Nothing was lacking from their hives,
Neither small nor great, neither sons
Nor daughters neither spoil in tonnes
Nor anything they took to them.
David took back all things in hem.
20 David took all the flocks and herds
Driven before the cattle's turds
And said "This is David's spoil's curds."

The hero's fit is no longer the plough
Since human beings lost the way somehow.
A brave man on a horse or camel once
Could smack the proud and lay in dust the
dunce.

But now the proud and stupid have the
guns
And bullets made of hard pellet that stuns
With depleted uranium in tonnes.
Where is the justice of brawn and the bow
That once saved sons, wives, and daughters
in tow?

Democracy only creates a band
Big enough to consolidate the land
And produce weapons to eliminate
The good and brave from every sprawling
state.
Arise, Beloved, intervene, don't be late.

21 And David came back to the two
Hundred men who were a faint crew
Not able to follow David,
Whom they made stay there where they hid
Beside the brook Besor, and they
Went out to meet David a way
And the people with him that day,
And when David came near the folk
He greeted them *to the last bloke*.
22 Then all the wicked men and those
Of Belial whom David chose
To go with him said "Because they
Did not go with us, we'll not lay
Out for them from the spoil that we
Have taken back, except in fee
To every man his wife and child,
And let them take them to the wild."
23 Then David said "You'll not do so,
My brothers, with what we've in tow
That YHWH has given us, who has
Preserved us *from the rock and jazz*
And given the band that came outright

Against us into our hands' might.
24 "And who will listen to your words?
For as his share that stirs the curds
In battle, so shall be the share
Of those who stay beside the ware,
Their share shall be the same in there."
25 And it was so that from that day
Forward that he made it a stay
And statute for Israel to keep
Until this very day *in heap*.
26 And when David came to Ziklag,
He sent of the spoil *as a gag*
To the elders of Judah, to
His friends, saying "See here a true
Gift for you of the spoil of those
Who rose up against YHWH as foes."
27 To those who lived in Bethel and
To those who were in Ramoth's band
To southward, and to those who dwelt
In Jattir, and to those the svelte
In Aroer, and to those who
Lived in Siphmoth, and to the crew
Who were in Eshtemoa's view.
29 And to them who lived in Rachal,
And to those who made city hall
Of the Jerahmeelites, and all
Who lived by the Kenites' towns' call.
30 And to those who were in Hormah,
And to those living by the law
Of Chorashan, and to those which
Were in Atach *to make a switch*.
31 And to those who were in Hebron,
And all the places where the run
Of David and his men begun.

Beloved, no doubt I might have been of
those
Who stayed beside the brook, not faint, but
chose
To feint faintness because my coward's
pose
Would be too visible through my fine
clothes.
No doubt I'd be one to let other men
More comely and more diligent again
And more ready to battle fight my wars
While I stayed safely behind closed, locked
doors.
Beloved, I thank You that You made Your
prince,
The brave and tender David not to wince
Before the tale of brave knaves, but to give

To such as me a corner where to live.
Beloved, I make peace with You and the
lot
That parades in perennial complot.

1 Samuel 31

1 Now the Philistines would prevail
In their battle against Israel,
And Israel's men fled from before
The Philistines and fell like spoor
Slain upon Mount Gilboa's *floor*.
2 The Philistines came hard on Saul
And on his sons, and to appal
The Philistines killed Jonathan,
Abinadab, and every son
Of Saul, also Malchishua.
3 The battle went badly for Saul,
And archers struck him at the draw,
And he was wounded under rib.
4 Then Saul said to his armourbearer,
"Take out your sword, and like a terror
Ram it through me, lest those who come
Uncircumcised hack off my bum
And abuse me. But he who held
His armour would not take the knelled,
Because he was afraid, and so
Saul took sword and fell on its blow.
5 When his armourbearer saw that
Saul was dead, he also fell flat
On his sword and died where he sat.
So Saul died, and his three sons, and
His armourbearer, and his band
On the same day to make a stand.
7 And the men of Israel that
On the valley's other side sat,
And those on Jordan's other side,
Saw that Israel fled and Saul died
With his sons, they forsook the towns
And fled, and the Philistine clowns
Came and lived in them *with their pride*.

The principle, it seems, of putting out
Of misery the sufferer in rout
Is Saul's invention, while the servant's
note

To add his own life is a line of rote.
As I am no sweet Christian, I shall not
Sacrifice myself on the sacred plot,
As I have neither gift nor breath I own
To give as all I have is Yours alone.
Beloved, I live from breath to breath as
You

Restore me with the kiss of life and dew.
Put me out of the misery of love,
Or let me stay in Your breast as Your dove.
I am Your own, and there's no other way.
I flee to You by night, I come by day.

8 It happened on the next day, when
The Philistines came to the pen
To strip the slain, that they found Saul
And his three sons where they did fall
In Mount Gilboa *by the wall*.

9 And they cut off his head and took
His armour and sent for a look
Into the land of Philistines
All round about in their designs
To tell it in their idols' shed
Among all the people instead.
They put his armour in the room
Of Ashtaroth and raised in gloom
His body to the wall to stay
In Bethshan *on that fatal day*.

11 When Jabish Gilead's folk heard
What the Philistines did in word
To Saul, 12 they rose up every man
Of might and went all night in span
And took Saul's body and the ones
From Bethshan's wall, even his sons,
And came to Jabesh, burnt them there.
13 And they took their bones for their
share

And buried them under a tree
At Jabesh, fasting faithfully
For seven days *their grief to bear*.

This frail example of cremation makes
Possible a verdict for burnings sakes.
Still I recoil at ovens and their fame
And tend to cast on cremators some blame.
Why did they cremate Saul and Jonathan?
Perhaps they did because the sacks in van
Contained the mutilated remains of
Saul and his three sons, sons the people
love,
Who could not bear to think the severed
heads

Should be forever witness in their beds.
Beloved I burn in longing love for You
Even before my death in morning dew
And in the evening fires of setting sun.
I burn and rise a spark for what I've won.

2 Samuel 1

1 It happened after that Saul died
When David returned from the side
Of slaughtering Amalekites,
And David for two days and nights
Had been in Ziklag, 2 it occurred
On the next day that is the third,
Behold a man came from the camp
From Saul with his clothes torn in stamp
And dust upon his head, and when
He came to David, he fell then
To the earth in prostration's clasp.
3 And David asked him, "Where have you
Come from?" He said without ado,
"Out of Israel's camp so I flew."
4 And David asked him, "What's the
news?
Tell me please about all your views."

The worse the news, the more the human
heart
Yearns for the voice to recite in its part
The gores and shames that do not fail to
send
Hundreds of men into Hades to spend
Their innocence in agonies that cry
Up to You, my Beloved, because they die.
So David eagerly asks for the news
When he had better go back to tattoos.
A moment more of ignorance is best,
And let the dying world take up the rest.
Beloved, I do not stray into the fray,
I do not seek the bloody awful way,
And yet I find a moment when I pray
For news of what has happened to today.

He answered, "The folk have all fled
From the battle, and many dead
There where they fell, and Saul and son
Jonathan are dead, gone and done."
5 Said David to the young man who
Brought him the news, "Now how do you
Know that Saul and Jonathan who
Is his son are dead *to be true*?"
6 And the young man who told the tale
Said to him, "I happened to sail
On Mount Gilboa, and indeed,
There Saul leaned on his spear in need
And hard pressed by the chariots' speed
And horsemen pressing him *in greed*.
7 "And as he looked behind him he
Saw me there, then he called to me

And I said 'Behold, here I be.'
8 "He asked me, 'Who are you?' And I
Said 'I'm an Amalekite *sly*.'

Ah, what mistake and fatal that he said
That he was an Amalekite who fed
As a stranger among the good folk bred
As Israelite and chosen and well led!
It might not ring untrue to spill the beans
That make one a good servant behind
scenes,
But the young man does not know David's
hand
Is unwashed from the slaying of the band
Of Amalekite brigands in the land
Who took his wives and children at a stand.
Take no pride in a heritage, I say,
Lest it turn and snap at the heels for pay,
And in the battle, unbeknownst, return
And take an enemy, no time to learn.

9 "And he said to me, 'Stand, please do,
Over me and without ado
Kill me and set my body free
From my wound and the agony.'
10 "So I stood by him and I made
To kill him, since I was afraid
He could not live once he was struck,
And I took the crown *from the truck*,
That had been on his head and yet
The bracelet on his arm, *you bet*,
And brought them here where we have
met."

11 And David took hold of his clothes
And tore them, and all those who rose
With him, they also tore their clothes.
12 And they lamented, and they wept
And fasted till the evening *swept*
Upon them, for Saul and for his
Son Jonathan, for the sad biz
Of Judah's people, and the tent
Of Israel slain by the sword leant.

I wonder what the wives who must repair
The torn up clothing thought under the
glare
Of male lament, I wonder if they share
The sorrow of the men in the same
measure.
They cannot take their sadness in their
leisure,

When handspun clothing has been so ill
 used
 By dust and ash and rending and abused
 With tears and poundings on the chest. Oh
 no,
 I think the women's sorrow is no show,
 But true tears for the work the sad display
 Uselessly casts up in the women's way.
 Beloved, customs of men are foolish
 things,
 Their carpeting, their gilding, and their
 kings.
 Take me to rest empty beneath Your
 wings.

13 Then David asked the young man who
 Brought the news to him, "Where are you
 From?" And he said in answer, "I
 Am son of an Amaleki
 Sojourner *in Israel, am I.*"
 14 Then David asked him, "How was it
 You were not afraid then to hit
 With your hand YHWH's anointed *kit?*"
 15 David called one of his young men
 And said "Go over there again
 And attack him." And so he did
 And he died. 16 And then said David
 To him, "Your blood be on your own
 Head, since your mouth witnessed alone
 Against you, saying 'I have killed
 YHWH's anointed one, *though*
unskilled.'"

Who joins the folk to live in peace awhile
 Must abide by not only law but style
 Of the host company and not revile
 Authority, but submit to its guile.
 The young man thought to take reward by
 lie
 That he had killed David's foe on the sly.
 He did not realize or think the man
 Was Your anointed, and that foiled his
 plan.
 To survive I must think as do the grand
 Who rule by deceit and stealth every land,
 Now that the sword is laid up on the wall,
 And only pistols and rifles appal
 The shopper in the street. I do not flee
 Nor dare to turn my back on killing spree.

17 And David in lament set out
 This lamentation, one about

Saul and his son Jonathan *dead*.
 18 And he commanded to teach it
 To the sons of Judah *and fit*,
 In the Book of Jasher it's writ.
 19 Set up memorial for those,
 O Israel, who on your heights
 Were killed, and how the mighty chose
 To fall! 20 Tell it not in *the sites*
Of Gath, publish it not in streets
 Of Ashkelon, lest in deceits
 The daughters of the Philistines
 Rejoice, the uncircumcised *swine's*
 Daughters triumph. 21 Gilboa's hills,
 Let not rain nor dew that distils
 Descend on you, nor fruitful field,
 For there was cast the mighty shield,
 The shield of Saul all gone unholed.
 22 From the blood of the slain unsoiled,
 From the fat of the mighty coiled,
 Jonathan's bow did not turn back,
 The sword of Saul returned not slack.
 23 Saul and Jonathan, the beloved
 And beautiful, they were not shoved
 Apart, pleasant in life were they,
 And in their death they did not stray,
 Swifter than eagles to the prey,
 Stronger than lions *in the way*.
 24 Daughters of Israel, weep for Saul
 Who clothed you in the scarlet caul,
 And with adorning ornaments
 On your apparel *with incense*.
 25 How are the mighty fallen here
 In midst of battle *they appear!*
 O Jonathan, even the slain
 On your high places in *bloodstain!*
 26 My grief for you, my brother Jon,
 Is great, you were lovely and wan,
 Your love to me was better than
 Even the love of a woman.
 27 How are the mighty fallen down,
 Perished weapons of war *and crown!*

I have no Jonathan for whom to weep,
 Nor king who made my fleeing footsteps
 keep
 To the wilderness holes to hide and seek.
 I'm well-provided for Your harsh critique.
 Lament, I tell my soul, and still the buds
 Of spring raise joy in me along with floods
 Of melted ice that beckons by the road.
 The literary critic lays the load
 Of blame on me, that I fail to take note

Of post-modern despair and worse for vote
The cynical hedonism that claims
To be a new thing since its bloody flames
Address the net computers foot the sill.
Beloved, I cannot lament to my fill.

2 Samuel 2

1 It happened after this that he,
David enquired of YHWH to see,
Saying "Shall I go up into
One of Judah's cities to view?"
And YHWH said to him, "Go up then"
And David said "Go where *and when?*"
And He said "To Hebron *again.*"
2 So David went up to Hebron,
And both his wives, Ahinoam
The Jezreelitess, Abigail
The wife of Carmelite Nabal.
3 And the men who were with him, each
One and his family to reach
And live on Hebron's cities' *beach.*
4 So Judah's men came to anoint
David there to reign and appoint
Over the house of Judah, and
They told David, saying "The manned
Of Jabesh-Gilead were they
Who buried Saul *on that sad day.*"
5 And David sent messengers to
The men of Jabesh Gilead's crew,
And said to them, "Blessèd are you
Of YHWH, that you have shown this good
To your lord Saul, *just as you should,*
And buried him. 6 "And now may YHWH
Show kindness and truth to you too,
And I shall also for my part
Repay this kindness of your heart.
7 "But now let your hands be made strong,
And be valiant, though Saul through wrong
Is dead, your master all along,
And yet the house of Judah came
And anointed me in their name
As king *after Saul in his claim.*"

What could David say, my Beloved, that
would

Ingratiate him when a people stood
In favour of the last king on the block?
Was not his claim illegal in its stock?
Is not the king's son better far the one
To rule a country if a king must run?
Kingship itself breeds violence and greed
Even when loyalty goes up in need.

Behind the machinations of the hand
Of David and Abner, I see the stand
Invisible of Your own will not late
To favour good among the evil state.
Today as well as then, as men recall
The hand to power, I see Your judgement
fall.

8 But Abner son of Ner, captain
Of Saul's army, took *hand to win*
Ishbosheth son of Saul and brought
Him to Mahanaim *as taught,*
9 And made him king in Gilead,
And over the Ashurites pad,
And over Jezreel and on
Ephraim and over all the spawn
Of Benjamin and over all
Israel. 10 Ishbosheth Saul's son tall
Was forty years old when he started
To reign over Israel and parted
After he reigned two years. But all
Judah followed on David's call.
11 The space that David was the king
In Hebron over Judah's thing
Was seven years and six months' time.
12 And Abner son of Ner and all
The servants of Ishbosheth's stall,
The son he was went out from Saul,
They came from Mahanaim when done
To sit down flat in Gibeon.
13 And Joab son of Zeruiah,
And servants of David *messiah,*
Went out and met them by the pool
Of Gibeon, sat down to cool,
The one on one side of the pool,
The other across it *like fool.*
As soon as confrontation is set out
Beside the pool, even of Kauthar, doubt
Not that the end will be in violence
Instead of wisdom and appeal to sense.
Olympic game or warfare outright makes
But little difference for human sakes,
But only the awareness that You hold
The key to knowledge will make truth be
bold.

There is no I but You, Beloved, to share
The power and goodness on an earth made
bare.

Who see the I shine in the other's face
Alone is able to make peace apace.
Let no I rise in myth to take the throne,
Be You the king and judge, be You alone.

14 And Abner said to Joab, "Let
 The young men rise, I pray, well met,
 And joust before us." Joab said
 "Let them get up, *not go to bed.*"
 15 So twelve got up and came across
 Of Benjamin's folk from their boss
 Ishbosheth son of Saul and twelve
 Of David's servants *come to delve.*
 And each one grasped him by the head
 And drove the sword in side *instead*
 So that each pair fell down *apiece.*
 So that place was named *for caprice*
 The portion of treachery's *fleece.*
 17 The battle was bloody that day,
 And Abner beaten in the way
 Along with Israel before
 The servants of David *in store.*
 18 And the three sons of Zeruiah
 Were there, Joab and Abishaia
 And Asahel, and Asahel
 Was swift of foot like a gazelle.
 19 And Asahel pursued Abner
 And turned not right nor left *to spur*
 From following after Abner.
 20 And Abner looked back and said "Are
 You Asahel?" "I am that star,"
 He answered. 21 And Abner then told
 Him, "Turn aside and don't be bold,
 To left or right and lay you hold
 On one of the young men, and take
 His armour." But he'd not forsake,
 Would not Asahel to turn back
 From following him *in the slack.*
 22 And Abner said once more unto
 Asahel, "Turn aside, please do,
 From following me, why should I
 Strike you to the ground, how should I
 Lift up my face to Joab's why?"
 23 But he refused to turn aside,
 And so Abner his spear end plied
 Against his abdomen, the spear
 Came out behind him, and the dear
 Fell down and died in the same place.
 It happened those who arrived there
 Where Asahel fell down to spare,
 They all remained and stood still there.

A general is loathe to raise a spear
 Against a young lad, though the man
 appear
 To run like a gazelle in joy of youth.

Even a general has times of truth.
 But such let pass occasion to repair
 The violence left on the head and hair,
 And live to strike again, and not to spare.
 Beloved, look on officers everywhere.
 The blood of Asahel, no matter what
 Revenge his brother Joab can in glut
 Is still an innocent voice from the sod
 That cried to You, Beloved, yes, cries to
 God.

Beloved, receive the life that was snuffed
 out,
 While officer and brother live in doubt.

24 But Joab and Abashai came
 Pursuing Abner *as in blame*
 And the sun went down *on the same*
 When they had come to Ammah's hill
 That lies before Giah and still
 By the road of the wilderness
 Of Gibeon *in its address.*

25 The sons of Benjamin came to
 Gather after Abner in crew
 Standing atop a hill *in view.*
 26 Then Abner called Joab and said
 "Shall the sword always eat like bread?
 Do you not know what bitterness
 Will be the end of this address?
 When will you make the people turn
 From following brother to spurn?"

27 And Joab said "As Alohim
 Lives, if you had not spoken scheme,
 Then surely by the morning come
 All the folk had gone wearisome,
 Each from following quarrelsome."
 28 So Joab blew the horn and all
 The fold stood still to hear the call,
 And followed Israel no more,
 Nor fought again to even score.

29 And Abner and his men went all
 That night through the plain to the fall
 To cross Jordan and went through all
 Bithron, and they came to the stall
 In Mahanaim. 30 And Joab turned
 From following Abner concerned,
 And when he gathered all the folk
 There lacked of David's men the stroke
 Of nineteen servants and the youth
 Asahel, *whom Abner gave tooth.*

32 And they took Asahel in hand
 And buried him in his dad's tomb.
 And Joab went all night in band,

And when the dawn rose *in its bloom*
It found them in Hebron *for room*.

Abner is hard, but like the army now
Is not willing to kill in wanton row.
That is prerogative of youth and fire
And politician set out to conspire.
And so he wants to stop the battle when
There is still hope of saving his own men.
Ah my Beloved, what battles rage about
The soul for merely plying play and shout!
I too for pride awoken at the call
Demanding conflict over the truth's wall.
Beloved, let me like stone remain to seal
The fate of blood and soul with help and
heal.

Beloved, let me remain beside the pool
Of Kauthar where the warrior is the rule.

2 Samuel 3

1 And so there was long war between
The house of Saul and the house keen
Of David, and David's house grew
Stronger, but house of Saul and crew
Grew ever weaker. 2 Then were born
To David sons in Hebron's *thorn*,
And his first-born boy-child was of
Ahinoam, Jezreelite *love*,
Amnon *his name, of the above*.
3 And his second, Chileab of
Abigail who was the wife of
Nabal the Carmelite, the third
Was Absalom son of Maacah
Daughter of Talmai king in awe
Of Geshur, 4 and the fourth to come
Was Adonijah who in sum
Was son of Haggith, and number
Five was Shephatiah the fer
Of Abital, 5 and then number
Six was Ithream of Eglah
David's wife. These were born to draw
For David in Hebron. 6 It came
To pass while there was war and blame
Between the house of Saul for shame
And David's house, that Abner's claim
In Saul's house strengthened on amain.

David seems to be a good shot indeed,
With six sons of six wives to preserve seed
Without a double, twin or even daughter.
The man gets right along and does not
potter.

Their names are taught in puns for one or
two

Beyond counsellor of peace in his pew.
For Adonijah, Jah is my Lord, read
A railway sleeper not yet gone with greed.
For Ithream, remainder of the folk,
Read he became enangered at a stroke.
Six sons appear in residue at last
To make a work week that has not yet
passed.

May David and I enter in that rest
That You reserve to both lowly and best.

7 And Saul had a concubine whose
Name was Rizpah, daughter to choose
Of Aiah, and Ishbosheth's bane
Was to say to Abner, "Why did
You go into my father's bid
To sleep where his concubine hid?"

8 But Abner raged at Ishbosheth
And at his words, and so he saith
"Am I a dog's head that belongs
To Judah? And I do no wrongs
Today, but kindness to Saul's house,
Your father, brothers, friends and mouse,
And have not given you up to
The house of David *with your crew*,
And do you seek cause of offence
Against me for a wench's sense?

9 "God do so to Abner and more,
If as YHWH once to David swore
I do not do for him before
10 "To take away the kingdom from
The house of Saul to raise *in sum*
The throne of David over *all*
Israel and over Judah's *stall*
From Dan to Beersheba *a wall*."

11 And he could not answer Abner
Another word, he feared to stir.
12 Then Abner sent messengers to
David straight off, saying then, "Who
Rules the land?" And he also said
"Agree with me, and see I've led
All Israel to you instead."

13 And he said "Fine, I'll make a league,
In one thing only I'll renege,
That is you shall not see my face
Except you bring into the place
Michal Saul's daughter when you come
To see my face." 14 David was rum
To send messengers on the run
To Ishbosheth who was Saul's son

Saying "Give me my wife Michal
Whom I betrothed to me for all
Of a hundred foreskins I took
From Philistines *beyond the brook.*"

15 And Ishbosheth sent for and took
Her from her husband Paltiel
The son of Laish *for a spell.*

16 And her husband went with her weeping
As far as Bahurim in keeping,
Until Abner told him, "Go back."
Then he returned *and hit the sack.*

Look, my Beloved, at all this scandal done
In name of heroes and in kingdoms won.
The wickedness of Saul and David bore
Ill fruit in not only Philistine gore,
But in the trading off of daughters like
Cattle sent to market upon a spike.
Michal is sent to David for the sum
Of one hundred foreskins cut off the bum.
And then she's taken from the man by
force

And given to another man, of course,
And soon as she is loved and in return
Loves him, David steps in again to spurn.
Beloved, Your kings are scandalous, I see,
While You look on, what's Your word
faithfully?

17 And Abner confided among
The elders of Israel and sung,
"In days past you sought David to
Reign as a regent over you,
18 "And now perform it, for now YHWH
Has spoken of David to say
'By My servant David's hand's sway
I'll save Israel from the foe's way.'"

19 And Abner also spoke in ear
Of Benjamin, and Abner's clear
Went to the ear of David in
Hebron of all that seemed to win
In Israel and to the whole
House of Benjamin *in the poll.*
20 Then Abner came to David in
Hebron and twenty men in bin.
And David made for Abner there
And his men a feast for their share.
21 And Abner said to David, "I
Will rise and go and gather by
All Israel to my lord the king,
That they may make a treaty thing
With you, and you shall reign on all

Your soul desires to keep in stall."
And David sent Abner away,
And in peace he went on his way.

The man Abner, officer of the great,
Was a man for sale to the strongest mate.
When David was small he came out not
late
To fight him and take prisoner of state
Or kill him in the field, whatever Saul
Wished was Abner's command and
doubtless call.

When house of Saul was weak, he found
the gate

To the hareem, and then fat in the stall
Cursed son of the king who had fed his
plate.

With such a man David is ready to
Make covenant to get what he thinks due
Because of what You promised him in rate.
If this is after Your own heart and will,
Beloved, let me live outside on the hill.

22 See David's servants and the man
Joab arrived from caravan
And brought great spoil with them *in can,*
But Abner was not with *the man*
David in Hebron, because he
Had sent him away *in his fee*
And in peace he went *gratefully.*

23 When Joab and his army came,
All of them, they heard the acclaim
To Joab, saying "Abner came,
The son of Ner to David, and
David has let him leave the land,
And he has gone in peaceful brand."
24 Then Joab came before the king,
And said "What, have you done this thing?
See Abner came to you, why did
You let him go, and now he hid?

25 "You know the mischief of that man,
Abner son of Ner, what he can
Do to deceive you, and to know
Your going out and come to show,
And finding out to where you go."

26 Joab came out from David's view
And sent messengers out to do
Abner, bring him from Sirah's well,
But David did not know *the spell.*

27 And when Abner came back to *where*
David was in Hebron, with care
Joab took him aside quite near

The gate to speak into his ear,
And struck him in the abdomen,
And so he died a specimen
For the blood of Asahel who
Was Joab's brother *and was true*.
28 And afterwards when David heard,
He said "I and my kingdom shirred
Are guiltless before YHWH ever
From Abner's blood, the son of Ner.

See, my Beloved, how wisely Joab speaks
To tell the king what secrets Abner seeks.
And yet his word's informed by lust to kill
In vengeance for his brother on the hill.
How many sweet things I myself have said
That seemed the right thing in the ear well-
bred,
And yet served only deceit of the heart.
Beloved, keep me from that deceitful part.
Deceit tends toward the lying down in wait
To snuff out lives evil enough in state.
Let me leave vengeance to Your name and
throne,
Since You keep record written as on stone.
Forgive who come to You in penitence,
Judge those who wait the coming just
sentence.

29 Let it fall on to Joab's head,
And all his father's house instead,
And let not be lacking within
Joab's house one that has a spin,
A leper or leans on a staff,
Or falls by sword or eats the chaff."
30 For Joab and Abashai his
Brother killed Abner for the quiz
Of him killing their brother late
Asahel in the battle rate
At Gibeon *with their rage great*.
31 And David said to Joab and
To all the people at a stand,
"Rend clothes and dress you in sackcloth,
And wail for Abner *and his wrath*."
And king David followed the bier.
32 In Hebron they buried Abner,
And the king lifted voice to stir,
And wept at Abner's grave and all
The people wept *to hear the call*.
33 The king lamented for Abner,
And said "Should it ever occur
That Abner die death of a churl,
And not the death of knight and earl?

34 "Your hands were untied, and your feet
Were not in fetters, as one meet
The sons of wickedness you fell."
And still the people wept a spell.

Your servant David always comes in grief,
Lamenting more his foes, robber and thief
Than child and friend. It only goes to show
How much he regarded the people's woe,
And the opinion of the folk to be
His vassals. So it is eternally
With presidents and kings. Hypocrisy
Is the best face of our diplomacy.
But David is sincere, I wot, in what
He says to praise Abner for what he got.
He recognizes statesmanship and skill
In harbouring the court life to its fill.
Beloved, safe-guard both prophet, yes, and
king
From the sin of the folk and following.

35 And all the people came to make
David eat bread *for his health's sake*
While it was still day *at the wake*.
But David swore and said "God do
So to me and more also too,
If I eat bread or anything
Before the sun goes down a ring.
36 And all the folk took notice and
All that the king did in the land
Before the folk pleased them at hand.
37 All the folk and Israel all saw
That day that is was not the law
Of the king to kill Abner son
Of Ner *before that day was done*.
38 And the king told his servants, "Do
You not know that a great prince drew
His death today in Israel?
39 "And I am weak today *to tell*
I have just been anointed king,
And these men sons of Zeruiah
Are too hard for me *in pariah*,
May YHWH reward the wicked one
According to the deed he's done."

I too fast, my Beloved, upon the day
I see the wicked fall upon the prey.
I too fast to find that the innocent
Is deprived of the bread and wealth once
meant
For them in righteousness and
nourishment.

Beloved, the sun is slow upon the sky
 To sink toward the wine and apple pie.
 The rumbling of my tummy sets apace
 The hope the funeral will win the race.
 Even a king may not reach out a hand
 To the avenger come in rightful band.
 In violence all things come to a stand.
 Too late I weep for what was evil planned,
 Such things must be snipped out in early
 grace.

2 Samuel 4

1 When Saul's son heard Abner was dead
 In Hebron, his hand turned to lead,
 And Israel's folk were filled with dread.
 2 And Saul's son had two men that were
 Captains of bands, the first one's slur
 Was Baanah, and the other's name
 Was Rechab, sons of Rimmon's claim,
 The Beerothith of Benjamin
 In tribe, for Beeroth was in fame
 Considered Benjamite *to win*.
 3 The Beerothites fled to Gittaim
 And lived in that place to this frame.
 4 And Jonathan, Saul's son, was sire
 To a son lame in his feet's hire.
 He was five years old when the news
 Of Saul and Jonathan in views
 Came from Jezreel, and his nurse took
 Him up and fled, and so mistook
 As she made haste, that he fell down
 And became crippled *around town*,
 And his name was Mephibosheth.
 5 The sons of Rimmon Beerothite,
 Rechab and Baanah, came in sight
 In the heat of the day up to
 The house of Ishbosheth to view
 Him sleeping on a bed at noon.
 6 And they came into the house *soon*
 Pretending to fetch wheat, and they
 Stuck him in the stomach, and then
 Rechab and Baanah fled *the den*,
 Both brothers *got away again*.

Though I am not a king, I sleep at night,
 And on occasion perhaps in the light
 Of noon, though where I live it isn't hot.
 So I like every man am in the pot
 Of those who lie and vulnerable on
 The bed to sleep at evening and at dawn.
 The wicked rove the cities where I spend
 My time between sojourning on the bend

Of peninsula where the woodlands start
 And all the islands sprinkle on the chart.
 Beloved, keep me in safety from the men
 Who claim to be my foes or friends again.
 I wander whirling through my dreams of
 sky
 And lay my fate down with blueberry pie.

7 And when they came into the house,
 As he lay on his bed in drowse
 Inside his bedroom, they struck him
 And killed him and beheaded him,
 And took his head, went away grim,
 By way of the plain all that night.
 8 And they brought the head of the wight
 Ishbosheth to Hebron and to
 The hand of David, in their due
 They said to the king, "See, the head
 Of Ishbosheth, Saul's son, is dead
 Your enemy who sought your life,
 And YHWH avenged all of the strife
 Against my lord the king today
 On his enemies *in the way*,
 Even on Saul your enemy,
 And on his seed *and family*."
 9 And David answered Rechab and
 Baanah his brother, of the band
 Of Rimmon the Beerothite and
 Said to them, "As YHWH lives to stand
 Redeeming me from sorrow's land,
 10 "The one who brought the news that
 Saul
 Was dead and hoped in glad recall,
 I seized that one and killed him in
 Ziklag instead of giving win
 And reward for his news. 11 "And now
 When wicked men have struck the brow
 Of a righteous man in his tent
 And on his bed, shall I not vent
 On you for his blood and take you
 Away from the earth *and its view*?"
 12 So David commanded his youth,
 And they killed them and without ruth
 Cut off their hands and feet to hang
 Them up beside the pool *to clang*
 In Hebron, and they buried that
 Head of Ishbosheth in the vat
 Of Hebron where Abner too sat.

David is not to trust, those who return
 With good news for his kingdom, often
 burn.

He lies between the knowledge of Your heart
 And the expediency of polished art.
 That is the rate of good men everywhere.
 Sometimes they act upon the golden stair
 And sometimes by the worldly rate of fair.
 They're not to be trusted, their acts of hate
 Rise up as unexpected in the state.
 The wicked are predictable to share
 Whatever's in their interest on the plate.
 But not the righteous. My Beloved, let me
 Be as consistent as the wicked flea
 And sit in time as in eternity.

2 Samuel 5

1 Then Israel's tribes all came to where
 David was in Hebron to share
 Saying "See, we are your bone and
 Your flesh. 2 "In times past when the king
 Was Saul, it was you did the thing
 In leading out and bringing in
 Israel *to war*, and YHWH told you,
 'You'll feed My people Israel, too,
 And you will be leader to win
 My people Israel.'" 3 So all
 The elders of Israel *in call*
 Came to Hebron to see the king,
 And King David made treatying
 With them in Hebron before YHWH,
 And they anointed David *too*
 King over Israel *as due*.

Beloved, note this. You chose the worthy
 man
 To be a king. But nothing in Your plan
 Could take place unless fickle elders came
 And anointed the one who had the flame.
 You chose me too to preach Your flaming
 word,
 And gave me grace and taught to see
 unblurred
 The sense and meaning of the sacred text.
 You anointed me, but left me perplexed.
 The church and mosque refused to foot the
 bill,
 Refused to hear the word I proclaim still,
 And thus turn to rebellion and to sin.
 Beloved, though I am not a chosen king,
 I am one chosen to reveal a thing.
 Judge who reject Your word from off my
 chin.

4 David was thirty years old when
 He began to reign, and reigned then
 For forty years. 5 For seven years
 And six months he in Hebron's cheers
 Reigned over Judah, and then in
 Jerusalem he reigned with din
 Over all Israel and all
 Judah. 6 And David followed call
 With his men to Jerusalem
 Against the Jebusites in hem
 Who lived in the land, and they said
 To David, "You will not be led
 To come here, for the lame and blind
 Suffice to repel all your kind."
 For they said to themselves "He'll not
 Succeed in entering our plot."

I too see scorn, Beloved, when I step out
 Into the limelight to give word about
 The glories of Your oneness and the claim
 You have on humankind to play the game.
 You insist that we see in every face
 Reflection of Your creative retrace.
 I must see Your Self in the foe who starts
 To destroy that message with evil darts.
 I have no weapon to deter the thing
 But Your own name in everything I sing.
 I have no love, no rhetoric, no power,
 And the opposing faction hits me sour.
 When I refuse to accept faction then
 The evil breaks out once more among men.

7 But David took the stronghold first,
 This is David's city, *not worst*.
 8 But David said that day, "Each one
 That strikes the Jebusite or son,
 Let him put dagger in the lame
 And in the blind who hated name
 Of David," and that's why they say
 "Let no lame and blind come the way
 To enter YHWH's house *or to stay*."

The empty word of wrathful pride, disdain
 Comes rolling on the hills and back again.
 It never stops, it seems, and yet Your way
 Takes up the stronghold, bears and saves
 the day.
 I take hold of David's strong words and
 play,
 Crush trinity and sect and hold the sway
 That I am nothing but Your own to be
 Proof that You only hold divinity,

But that divinity is every man's
And woman's that is revealed in Your
plans.

Beloved, I hold the universe in hand,
And see it crumbling at the edges planned,
And build the dykes and patch the broken
wall,
And stand to hear Your summons and Your
call.

9 And David stayed in the stronghold,
And it was called David's house *told*,
And David built it all around
From Millo inward *on the ground*.

Beloved, though I am put out from the
church
And left with burning message in the lurch,
I still hold fast to that stronghold that You
Bring in the Decalogue before my view.
Though I am stricken, I shall not strike
back
In anger and deceit for what they lack.
Instead I strike with the whip from Your
hand,
The message that You are One in the land,
And have no partner, and while You still
stand,
Humanity is also one united
Without sect or without strife yet ignited.
Beyond the strident traditions that seek
Both to honour You and at start of week
To destroy unity, I see You lighted.

10 And David became greater still,
For YHWH Alohim of hosts will
Was with him *and to foot the bill*.

Beloved, I too become great, though no
king,
And though few hear me praise Your name
and sing.
Some say all faiths are right and good and
true,
Some say only one sect of all may do,
And in those sayings all rebel and fail,
I shall not leave the wall, but shall prevail.
My greatness is in knowing You are One,
And that humankind set out under sun
Is one in their reflection of Creator,
Within the image along with the satyr.

All things proclaim Your sovereignty and
yet

Illusion blinds my fellows where I get
The greatness of Kauthar where I lose self
In the greatness You set up beyond elf.

11 And Hiram king of Tyre sent some
Messenger to David a-run,
And cedar trees and carpenters,
And masons, and they built *with whirs*
A house for David. 12 David saw
That YHWH established him in awe
As king over Israel and that
He exalted his kingdom flat
For His folk Israel's sake *at bat*.

13 And David took more concubines
And wives from Jerusalem's *lines*
After he came from Hebron, and
More sons and daughters *to his hand*
Were born to David *in the land*.

14 And these are the names of those that
Were born to him in caveat
Of Jerusalem, Shammua and
Shobab, and Nathan and *well-manned*
Solomon, 15 And Ibhar and yet
Elishua and Nepheg set,
And Japhia, 16 Elishama,
And Eliada, Eliphelet,
(Naged, Naphec, Janathan's paw,
Leasamys, Baalimath,
And finally Eliphaath.)

Beloved, the eastern king sent me the
things
To build my house and give Your message
wings.
He set to work both mason with his jewels
And carpenter with sweet woods under
tools.
The proclamation that You are one and
None shares with You the throne of Your
command,
But prophets You have sent and here they
stand,
And divine guides still lurk on silver sand,
All these I set forth with the notice that
You hold men countable for where they
sat.

That's why I rejoice in oppression's vale
And take up with courage the broken sail.
Beloved, the eastern king from arid land
Is more than just a far off cunning tale.

17 And when the Philistines heard that
 David was anointed king at
 Israel, all the Philistines went
 Up searching for what David meant,
 And David heard of it and went
 Down to the stronghold *in cement*.
 18 And the Philistines came and spread
 Themselves in the valley *as led*
 Of Rephaim. 19 Then David asked
 YHWH saying “*Shall I go unmasked*
 Against the Philistines, will You
 Give them into my hands *a few?*”
 And YHWH said to David, “Go now
 Up, for I’ll give them anyhow,
 The Philistines into your hands.”
 20 David came to Baal-perazim,
 And there attacked them *in their bands*,
 And said “YHWH has broken with vim
 My enemies before my face,
 Just like the breach of waters’ *trace*.”
 And that’s why the name of the place
 Was called Baal-perazim *a space*.
 21 And they abandoned their gods there
 And David and his men in share
 Carried them all away from there.
 22 The Philistines came up again
 And spread themselves and all their men
 Across Rephaim’s valley’s *glen*.
 23 When David asked of YHWH, He said
 “Do not go up, but go behind
 And come against them from the blind
 Of mulberry trees *fruited and vined*.
 24 “And when it happens that you hear
 The sound of marching as of fear
 In the tops of the mulberry trees,
 Then stir yourself up in the breeze,
 For then YHWH has gone out before
 You to battle Philistine gore.”
 25 And David did as YHWH told him
 And struck the Philistines with vim
 From Giba as far as the land
 Of Gezer *by the Lord’s command*.

I ask You, my Beloved, if I shall go
 Out before the Philistine cart and show
 To defy all the whelps that flaunt Your
 worth

With pagan trinities upon the earth.
 Shall I gather up idols from the path
 And take them hence before Your garnered
 wrath?

Beloved, the better part is that I speak,
 And failing speech to write the words I
 seek,

That conscience might awaken to the heat
 Of what is true and what is right and meet.
 Beloved, I hear Your spirit move the trees
 And pass before me in the rocking breeze,
 And so I cantillate Your name once more
 To even up the fragile, fragment score.

2 Samuel 6

1 Again David gathered the men
 All chosen from Israel, *in yen*
 About thirty thousand *again*.
 2 David got up and went with all
 The people with him from the stall
 Of Baal-judah, to bring up
 From there the ark of God *to sup*,
Upon which is recited name,
 The name of YHWH of hosts, the same
 Sits on the cherubim *in flame*.
 3 They put the ark of Alohim
 On a new wagon, it would seem,
 Took it from Aminadab’s place,
 Who lived upon the hill *in trace*,
 And Uzzah and Ahio, sons
 Of Abinadab *beat their buns*
 To drive the new cart *in its runs*.
 4 They brought it from Abinadab’s
 House, which was on the hill *for grabs*,
 Along with ark of Alohim,
 And Ahio led the whole team.
 5 David and all Israel’s house played
 Before YHWH with all kinds of made
 Instruments of cypress wood and
 With harps and psalteries in hand
 And timbrels and with sistra, and
 On cymbals as David *had planned*.
 6 When they came to the threshing floor
 Of Nachon, Uzzah reached to shore
 The ark of Alohim and took
 Hold of it for the oxen shook
 It stumbling. 7 And the anger rose
 From YHWH kindled against his pose,
 And Alohim struck Uzzah there
 For his error, and so that’s where
 He died by God’s ark *without prayer*.

Familiarity with Your presence
 From childhood onward in his father’s
 tents

Made Uzzah careless of the ark that
seemed
To him a common thing, or so he deemed.
The wagon shifted, and without a thought,
He reached out hand irreverent and caught
The golden space where glory sat untaught.
Death hid behind the careless veil
unsought.

Beloved, I took walk by the common train,
Along the green and golden path in vain
Perhaps to see each day the glories turn
Again and once again to make heart burn
With exaltation. It's not always so.
Sometimes I lean on You as common
show.

If my hand in Your own, and my heart
grown
Entwined in Yours, forget Your glory's
throne,
And so spring me in death as I reach out
To touch Your presence near me like a
shout,
I make complaint of love, no more than
that,
Well satisfied to live where You are at
Or die in the place where Your glory sat.
Beloved, irreverent angel and bird song
Also coils on the roadway all along
My journey, still I feel no ill or wrong.
The blessed shekinah veiled beside my part
Shifts and balances, and gives me a start.
I raise my hand and die against Your heart.

9 And David was afraid of YHWH
That day, saying "How shall I do
To bring to me the ark of YHWH?"

10 So David would not move the ark
Of YHWH to him into the park
Of David's city, but David
Carried it aside, David did,
Into the house of the Gittite,
Obed-edom *and out of sight*.

11 And YHWH's ark stayed there in the
house
Of Obed-edom the Gittite
For three months and YHWH blessed the
site
Of Obed-edom, all his house.

Fortuitous it may seem that You came

To stay within the chamber where the
flame
Of my heart recalls all Your pomp and
fame.

You were a passer-by and stumbled here
To live beneath my roof and camp with
gear.

I welcome You to my stone walls and bare,
To the small flame of faith and love I share
With nightingale and hedgehog on the
shore

Of grass and thicket grown about my door.
Beloved, bless my three months of
unlooked for

Happiness when Your journey was cut off.
Bless all my house, my children and the
trough,

The granite threshold, lilac and the bud
Of cherry and of apple by well's flood.

12 They told King David, saying "YHWH
Has blessed Obed-edom's house too,
And all he has, because the ark
Of Alohim came there to park."

And David went and brought the ark
Of Alohim up from the dark
House of Obed-edom to stay
In David's city with glad sway.

13 It happened when they who bore it,
The ark of YHWH, had gone a bit,
About six paces, then they stopped
To sacrifice an ox untopped
And fattened sheep, *as they saw fit*.

14 And David danced before YHWH with
All *his* strength, and David forthwith
Was wearing a linen ephod,
As he stepped out upon the sod.

Beloved, let me too dance as David did,
And let me also dance with all my might.
I turn toward Your house as David did,
I cover my left foot beneath my right
And enter in the place of sacrifice
To give my head to You in sacrifice.
My throat is cut, my skin is torn away.
My self is wounded sore and flies away.
A spark up from the altar I shall fly,
And whirling, whirling upward as I die,
I dance before You in the gathering night,
And dance before Your face in whirling
flight.

And so I shall return and be as One

With You, Belovèd, when my dance is
done.

15 And David and all Israel's house
Brought up the ark of YHWH with *dowse*
Of shouting and with trumpet sound.

16 It happened when the ark arrived
At David's city, she contrived,
Did Michal Saul's daughter to look
Out at the window, and she shook
To see King David leaping and
Dancing before YHWH *and the band*,
And she despised him in her heart.
They brought YHWH's ark and set it in
Its place, in the tent and the bin
That David pitched for it, and there
David offered burnt-offerings' share,
And peace-offerings to YHWH, *no spare*.

18 When David finished offering
Burnt-offerings and peace-offerings' *sting*,
He blessed the people in the name
Of YHWH of hosts *and in His claim*.

19 He gave out to all the folk there,
To the whole multitude to share
In Israel both men and wench,
To everyone a loaf of bread,
Also a cake made in a trench,
As well as a slice of sweetbread,
So all the folk departed fed
Each one to his own house *and bench*.

I taste the whirl and dance before Your
throne,
Belovèd, and see the patterns overgrown
That twist and turn into the universe
Of fire and smoke and veils if nothing
worse

To rise and bless, to rise and never curse.
I taste the bread and meat and fill my craw
With raisins of delight from Your own law
And bless my soul that I may stand in awe
With starling at the wing and with
jackdaw.

I taste the turn and cake and then I make
My way back to the stronghold of my stake
And my own post along the further wall.
I taste and wake, Belovèd, to hear Your
call.

I taste and whirl, Belovèd, I taste and
wake.

20 David came back to bless his house.

And Michal Saul's daughter like mouse
Came out to meet David and grouse,
And said "How now did Israel's king
Act to honour himself on wing
Today before the servant girls
Of his servants, and like the churls
Uncover and make himself known
To all and sundry open shown!"

21 And David said to Michal, "Now
Before YHWH that chose me somehow
Above your father and all his
Household appointing me the biz
Of being prince to all the folk
Of YHWH, over both wench and bloke
Of Israel, so before YHWH
I will make merry, that I'll do.

22 "And I'll uncover me to be
Even more vile than you now see
And in my own sight, with handmaids
You spoke about and with their *blades*
I'll get more honour *faithfully*."
So Michal Saul's daughter had no
Children as long as she did go
Upon the earth up to death's *row*.

Some are too fine, I know, to take their lot
Among the dancers of Your garden plot.
The posts are empty, and the dergah floor
Deserted of the ones who danced before.
I see the ancient fires, I hear the calls,
I see the fleeting shadows on the walls,
But memory is faith to know the true,
And in the end and now, there's none but
You.

Belovèd, You are my partner in the reel,
Although You have no partner in the seal,
And I seem to whirl all alone and keel.
Belovèd, though we are one and single
spent,

There is a breach in the veil and a rent,
And You and I breathe as one at the vent.

2 Samuel 7

1 The king lived safely in his house
When YHWH had given him rest *from*
mouse

And every other enemy,
It happened 2 that the king spoke free
To Nathan the prophet, "Now see,
I'm living in a cedar palace,
While YHWH's ark's in a tent *for malice*."

3 And Nathan told the king, "Go, do

According to your heart's review,
And seeing that YHWH is with you."

Even King David took council from men
Who were known to be prophets in the
glen.

He did not trust his own council in all
He thought of doing in the royal hall.
That spirit is what calls forth from the
tongue

Of prophet the blessing to climb the rung.
Let me, Beloved, be humble in my right
To learn from those below me in the fight.
Although I'm not a king, there may be
some

Somewhere who have a slighter premium.
There is no face but holds Your face to
mine

To see reflected exquisite divine.
What if the vision of the night reverse
The blessing of the day? It is no curse.

4 It happened *sudden* in the night
That the word of YHWH came to light
To Nathan, saying 5 "Go and tell
My servant David, 'Here's the spell
That YHWH says, "Will you be the one
To build for Me a house begun
Where I may live *for benison*?"

6 "For I have not lived under roof
From the day I brought up *in proof*
From Egypt Israel's folk until
This very day, but have walked *still*
Beneath a tent and tabernacle.

7 "In every place and without shackle
I've walked by Israel's folk, have I
Spoken a word to any nigh
Of Israel's tribes whom I commanded
To feed My people Israel *branded*,
To say 'Why have you not built me
A palace house of cedar tree?"

So say now to David My servant,
'This is what YHWH of hosts *and fervent*
Says, "I took you from the sheepfold,
From following sheep *in the cold*,
To be a prince over My folk,
Over Israel *and at a stroke*,

9 "And I have been with you wherever
You went, and before you I sever
Off all your enemies, and I
Will make you a great name foreby,
Like the name of the great ones here

That on the earth *come to appear*.

10 "And I'll appoint a place for My
People Israel and also I
Will plant them, so they may stay in
Their own place undisturbed *by sin*
Nor shall the sons of wickedness
Afflict them with any duress,
As from the first, 11 and in the days
That I commanded judges' sways
Over My people Israel,
And I'll give you rest from the spell
Of all your foes, and truth to tell
YHWH says that YHWH will make a
castle

For you *to stay without the hassle*.

12 "When your days are fulfilled and you
Shall sleep with your fathers *in crew*,
I'll set you your seed after you,
Who'll come from your body, and I
Shall set your kingdom and for aye.

13 "He shall build a house for My name,
And I'll establish for the same
The throne of his kingdom for ever.

14 "I'll be to him a father *clever*,
And he shall be to me a son.

If he commit iniquity,
I'll chasten him with men's rod free,
And with stripes of children of men.

15 "But My mercy shall not again
Depart from him, as I took it
From Saul, as I put out unfit.

16 "Your house and your kingdom shall be
Made sure for ever where you see,
Your throne shall be established for
All the days *that come on the shore*.""

The son of David on the throne is called
By God Himself also the Son of God.
This is the promise eternal and walled,
And by the story coming, royal prod
Of biological descent plays free
With virtue in conceiving mastery.
In fine, Solomon, while he is God's Son,
Is also born of David having done
A stroke with Bathsheba after his tears.
To be the Son of God, it now appears
Does not mean to be God Almighty, but
The valid ruler on David's throne shut.
The man remains a man, and no God yet,
On that a man can lay down his last bet.

17 According to all these words, and

According to this vision's stand,
 Nathan spoke to David *in hand*.
 18 Then King David went in, and sat
 Before YHWH, and he said thereat,
 "Who am I, O Lord YHWH, and what
 Is my house You so far have brought
 Me? 19 "Since I was small before You
 O Lord YHWH, but You've spoken too
 Of Your servant's house for a great
 Time to come and by the estate
 Of great men, O Lord YHWH. 20 "And
 what
 Can David say more to You sought?
 For You know Your servant, Lord YHWH.
 21 "For You have spoken for the sake
 Of Your servant, and in the wake
 Of Your heart You have made this great,
 And Your servant to know *his state*.
 22 "Therefore You're great, YHWH
 Alohim,
 For there's none like You *in a dream*,
 Nor is there any God but You,
 By all that our ears hear *is true*.
 23 "And who is like Your people too,
 Like Israel, a nation one
 In the earth, whom Alohim won
 To redeem to Himself a folk,
 And to make Him a name in stroke,
 To do mighty, tremendous things
 For Your land, *driving out the kings*
 Before Your people to redeem
 For Yourself from Egyptian *stream*,
 From nations and their gods' *esteem*.

The king David sees clearly You are One
 Alone and have no equal under sun.
 How few see that today, and how few then,
 As heathen trinities have claim on men.
 Not only did he see that You alone
 Are God, but that also the earthly throne
 Is given under sovereign will divine
 To make one nation holy by design.
 That nation is no ethnic folk, but those
 Who acclaim You alone in divine pose
 And thus become the ummah that arose
 From desert and from city at the close.
 The third great truth on unity is found
 That David's throne is still upon the
 ground.

24 "And You have established for You
 Your people Israel in due

To be a folk to You for aye,
 And You, YHWH, became Alohim
 To them. 25 "And now, YHWH Alohim,
 The word You've spoken of Your slave,
 And of his house *after the grave*,
 Confirm it now forever, and
 Do as You've spoken *by command*.
 26 "And let Your name be magnified,
 'Allahu akbar' be said *wide*,
 'YHWH of hosts is the Alohim
 Of Israel, and so *the theme*
 Of David's house, Your servant's, too,
 Shall be established before You.
 27 "Almighty YHWH and Alohim
 Of armies and of Israel,
 You have revealed Your servant well,
 Saying 'I'll build your house to gleam,'
 That's why Your servant's taken heart
 To pray this prayer and for Your *part*.
 28 "And now, O Lord YHWH, You alone
 Are Alohim, a God and Your
 Words are truth, and You do outpour
 This good thing at Your servant's door.
 29 "So therefore let it please to bless
 Your servant's house and his address,
 That it may stay forever here
 Before You, for You, Lord YHWH dear,
 Have spoken it, and as You bless,
 Let Your servant's house not digress
 Forever from Your blessing *near*."

Again David affirms that You are God
 Alone, and never any image clod
 Made up of stone or gold, concept or flesh
 Can take a place on Your throne and be
 fresh.

My being in illusion's here as proof
 That there is nowhere a diviner roof
 Than Your heart chambered where in
 refuge flee
 The humble and the wise eternally.
 Belovèd, You are One, and never three,
 And yet the splinters of creation see
 The manifold and many on the crest
 Of everyone's perception of the best.
 Belovèd, You make Your image multiplied
 Wherein Your oneness rises on the tide.

2 Samuel 8

1 And after this it came to pass,
 David attacked Philistines' ass,
 And put them under his domain,

Then David took tribute in gain
 From the hand of Philistines' *mass*.
 2 He then attacked Moab and set
 Lines of them on the ground to get
 Two rows of them to put to death
 And one full row to keep in breath
 As servants, and the Moabites
 Came to serve David with delights.
 3 David attacked Hadadezer
 Also, the son of Rehob, fer
 As king of Zobah, as he went
 To set his rule upon the spent
 River Euphrates *where it bent*.
 4 And David took from him in all
 A thousand horsemen at the call
 And seven hundred more to be
 Companion to the footmen, see,
 Who numbered twenty thousand men.
 And David hamstrung every beast,
 The chariot horses, but at least
 He spared of them sufficient to
 A hundred chariots *in view*.
 5 And when the Syrians came down
 From Damascus to help the town
 Of Hadadezer, Jobah's king,
 David struck down like anything
 Twenty-two thousand of the men
 Of the Syrians *once again*.
 6 In Syria of Damascus
 David set up forts *for the fuss*,
 And Syrians brought presents to
 David and were his servants too.
 And YHWH gave David victory
 In every place he went to be.
 7 And David took the shields of gold
 The men of Hadadezer hold,
 Brought them to Jerusalem's *fold*.
 And from Betah and Berothai
 Cities of Hadadezer's vie,
 King David took a large amount
 Of brass, *more than any could count*.

The wars of David were not just defence.
 He went against the stranger in their tents.
 Of course the kings of those were not so
 kind,
 Nor were they pure, but probably well-
 wined.
 They bound their servants to the awful
 grind,
 And when David arrived, he cut them
 down

And put them out of misery in town.
 He also hamstrung horses, those that drew
 The chariots of war, and yet he knew
 Your pleasure, that the most part of those
 killed
 Were innocent of anything but tilled
 Gardens and their obeying the command
 Of their leaders in warfare on the land.
 Who obey to the death deserve the stand.

9 When Toi, king of Hamath heard that
 David had attacked all them at
 The army of Hadadezer,
 10 Toi sent Joran his son and fer
 To King David, and to confer
 About his welfare and to say
 Congratulations on the way
 He'd fought against Hadadezer
 And struck him down because the fer
 Had wars with Toi, and brought with him
 Vessels of silver, gold undim,
 And vessels of brass. 11 These also
 Did King David consecrate to
 YHWH, with the silver and the gold
 That he dedicated unsold
 From all the nations he subdued,
 12 From Syria, from Moab spewed,
 The folk of Ammon, and the *rude*
 Philistines, and of Amalek,
 And of the spoil taken back from
 Hadadezer, son of *the bum*
 Rehob, the king of Zobah *come*.
 13 And David made himself a name
 When he came back from killing's fame,
 The slaughter of eighteen thousand
 Syrians in Salt Valley's land.
 14 He set up forts in Edom's land,
 Throughout all Edom he put forts,
 And all the Edomites for sports
 Became servants to David. And
 YHWH gave David the victory
 Wherever David came to be.

My role is to see in the face of all
 Men and all women, even child in stall,
 The face divine that You created when
 You bent to earth to find Your Self again.
 My role is not to slay the brave, the lot
 That destroys earth to make a pinch and
 dot.
 My role is not to take on tongue the word
 Of violence against man, beast or bird.

That is reserved to You and to the one
Anointed to fulfil destruction done.
Beloved, although I do not share the bow,
The sword, the rifle, bomb, nor stand in
glow
Of military glory, mine the show
To applaud David and his on the go.

15 And David reigned over the folk
Of all Israel, and David's stroke
Of justice and righteousness came
To all his people *in God's name*.
16 And Joab son of Zeruiah
Was army general, and crier
And scribe was Jehoshaphat son
Of Ahilud, 17 And Zadok son
Of Ahitub, Ahimelech
Son of Abiathar ran neck
And neck as priests, Seraiah was
The scribe, 18 Benaiah son who was
Of Jehoiada was set over
The Cherethites as well as rover
Pelethites, and David's sons were
Chief ministers *one would infer*.

Jehoshaphat was David's record keeper
For army and nation, overt and peeper.
Mazkir, rememberer, is what the name
Intends, and yet I do not know its fame.
Did David have a man whose function was
To keep zikr as each righteous king does?
I like to think so, here among the rest,
The heroes and the wardens, and the best,
The sons and socialites, the businessmen,
There is a place for such as me again.
Not that I have prodigious memory,
But that I bow to the great mystery,
Remembering to cantillate Your word,
Your name, Your glory, until my heart's
stirred.

2 Samuel 9

1 And David said "Is any left
Of Saul's house, that for the bereft
I may show kindness for the sake
Of Jonathan?" 2 Now of Saul's house
There was a servant *like a mouse*
Whose name was Ziba, and they called
Him to David, and *unappalled*
The king said to him "Are you Ziba?"
And he said "Here in your gazebo."
3 And the king said "Is any left

Of the house of Saul *unbereft*,
That I may show God's kindness to?"
And Ziba told the king *for true*,
"There is a son of Jonathan,
Whose feet are lame, as lame as can."
4 And the king said to him, "Where's he?"
And Ziba answered the king free,
"See, he is in the house of one
Machir of Ammiel the son,
In Lo-debar." 5 King David sent
And fetched him from the house *as lent*
From Machir son of Ammiel,
From Lo-debar. 6 And so *the swell*
Mephibosheth, Jonathan's son
The son of Saul, *when all is done*,
Came to David, fell on his face
Prostrating himself there a space.
And David said "Mephibosheth!"
And he answered *in the same breath*,
See, here your servant!" 7 David said
"Don't be afraid, for I am led
To show you kindness for the sake
Of Jonathan, your father's *stake*,
And will restore you all the land
Of Saul your father *in your hand*,
And you shall eat bread at my side
And at my table aye abide."
8 And he bowed down and said "What is
Your servant, that you favour his
Life, which is but a dead dog *here*,
And before the king I appear."

The mix of mercy and the weight of kings
Is something that stirs heart as well as
wings
In flight from court and its hypocrisy.
What is the motive in giving freely?
Perhaps the friends of Saul still smell the
blood
Of David and would try to hit the mud,
And David thinks to keep the man in sight.
With my dealings in oriental might
I'd think that likely. But, Beloved, Your
hand
Lies on David, Your chosen, in the land.
Your mercy is the better part and grand
Of valour, as the courtly proverbs stand.
Let me see lowly space and righteousness
Unsullied by courtly charms and address.

9 Then the king called to Ziba, who
Was Saul's servant, said to him true,

“Now everything that was Saul’s own
 And of his house, I’ve given alone
 To Your master’s son *from the throne*.
 10 “And you shall work the land for him,
 You and your sons and servants trim,
 And you shall bring in all the fruit,
 So your master’s son head to boot
 May have bread to eat, but the son
 Of your master, Mephibosheth,
 Shall eat bread long as he has breath
 At my table. 11 So Ziba said
 To the king, “As your word is spread
 By all my lord the king commands
 His servant, so shall both my hands
 Do.” “But Mephiboseth shall eat
 At my table as king’s sons treat.”
 12 Now Mephiboseth had a young
 Son, whose name was Micha *unsung*.
 And all who lived in Ziba’s house
 Were servants to Mephibosheth.
 13 Mephibosheth lived *like a mouse*
 In Jerusalem, for he ate
 Always at the king’s place and plate,
 And he was lame, both feet *in fate*.

If not in flesh, in spirit I may be
 Grandson of wicked king and misery,
 But look on me, Beloved, as David looked
 Upon the son of Jonathan, and booked
 A table in his dining room to see
 Him come to eat there and continually.
 I take from Your broad table all I need
 In dandelion, in wood-nettle, in greed
 Pick the sweet cicely and spike my soup
 With onion, garlic, and at last a scoop
 Of light soy textured protein to set off
 The rice that forms the staple at the trough.
 Beloved, I taste with You the days and
 rights
 That spring up from the soil for acolytes.

2 Samuel 10

1 It happened after this, the king
 Of Ammon’s children died *in spring*,
 And Hanun his son reigned instead.
 2 And David said “I shall be led
 To show kindness to Hanun son
 Of Nahash, as his father’s done
 In showing kindness to me.” And
 David sent by the hand of his
 Servants condolences, that is,
 Concerning his father, and then

They came to land of Ammon’s men,
 David’s servants did. 3 But the princes
 Of Ammon’s folk said, *as for winces*,
 To Hanun their lord, “Do you think
 David has sent comforters’ wink
 To you? Has not David rather
 Sent his servants to you to stir
 The city, and to spy it out,
 And overthrow it in the rout?”
 4 So Hanun took David’s servants,
 And shaved off one half of their beard,
 And cut off the half of their pants,
 Even up to their butts to dance.
 5 And they brought David word of weird
 And shameful things done to the men,
 So he sent to meet them. The king
 Said “Stay in Jericho till your
 Beards have grown back and more,
 And then return *to your living*.”

Except when dealing with the king and
 court,
 It’s usually best to take face value short.
 The problem with David as king is that
 He too often says straight and where it’s at.
 The world is ready for conniving kings,
 And so they’re forced to do their devious
 things.
 Bless me, Beloved, to understand when I
 Meet suspicion for motives when I try
 To do good things for others, that the trial
 Ascribes to me a kingly, royal guile.
 Bless me, Beloved, despite the strike of
 state,
 To renew always my attempts to rate
 Through compassion and mercy to the raw
 Who stand by instinct instead of Your law.

6 And when the folk of Ammon saw
 They were disgusting in the crow
 Of David, then Ammon’s folk sent
 And hired Syrians resident
 In Beth-rehob, and Syrians
 Of Zobah, twenty thousand fans
 On foot, and the king of Maacah
 With a thousand men, and *the raw*
 Men of Tob twelve thousand *in awe*.
 7 When David heard of it, he sent
 Joab, and all the army lent
 Of mighty men *and to present*.
 8 And Ammon’s men went out to fight
 All in array by the gate’s light,

And the Syrians of Zobah and
 Of Rehob, and Tob's men to stand
 With Maacah by themselves together
 In the field *to follow the weather*.
 9 Now when Joab saw that the fight
 Was pitched against him from the right
 And left, he chose out of all those
 Young men in Israel to oppose
 The Syrians in battle spread.
 10 The rest of the folk he put by
 Command of brother Abishai,
 That he might set them to the fray
 Against the folk of Ammon's way.
 11 And he said "If the Syrians
 Are too strong for me in my plans,
 Then you shall help me, but if those
 Sons of Ammon strongly oppose
 You, I'll bring help against your foes.
 12 Be of good courage, let us prove
 Strong for our people, and *let's move*
 For the cities of Alohim
 Our God, and YHWH do what shall seem
 Good in His sight." 13 So Joab and
 The people with him drew in band
 Near for the battle at the hand
 Of Syrians, and they fled out
 Before him. 14 And they saw the rout
 Of Syrians, Ammon's folk did,
 Fled before Abishai and hid
 In the city, and Joab came
 Back from Ammon's folk *and their shame*
 Entered Jerusalem *in fame*.

I see the way that men follow their suit
 When they take notice that their crimes to
 boot
 Were misplaced and mistaken on the route.
 They hire a gunman to assassinate
 The one they falsely thought against their
 plate.
 For doing well one raises head above
 The parapet, becomes a target's love.
 Let me, Beloved, remain unseen by those
 To whom I do a good turn quid-pro-quo.
 When Jesus said "Don't let the left hand
 see
 What the right does," it was not modesty
 But self-preserving informed of his fee.
 Beloved, though I am modest, preserve me
 From gratitude of both my friends and
 foes.

15 The Syrians saw they were beaten
 Before Israel, and tried *to sweeten*
 By gathering themselves together.
 16 And Hadadezer sent *with tether*
 And brought out Syrians on the other
 Side of the river to help brother
 They came to Helam with Shobach
 The captain of the host *not slack*
 Of Hadadezer at their head.
 17 But it was told David *instead*.
 And he gathered all Israel out,
 And passed over Jordan in route,
 And came to Helam. *Without doubt*,
 The Syrians set in array
 Against David to join the fray.
 18 And Syria fled before Israel,
 And David killed captain *in style*
 Of their army, so he died there.
 19 When all the kings that were servants
 To Hadadezer saw the chance
 That they were beaten by Israel,
 Then they made their peace with Israel,
 And gave them tribute *for a while*.
 And so the Syrians feared to give
 Aid any longer to help live
 In Ammon's folk, *in Ammon's style*.

Once enemies, it seems the fate of man
 Is to fight as long as he ever can.
 He does not stop to think of time or cost.
 As soon as he's in battle, he is lost.
 So Syria had to move on Israel's land
 Because they were paid once to lend a
 hand
 To Ammon, and they made an enemy
 In their own right in perpetuity.
 They did not think that Israel could have
 spent
 A penny and make them their friend well
 bent
 On fighting Ammon. So slight is the
 motive
 For violence in sacrificial votive.
 Beloved, make in my heart a golden link
 That loves humanity upon the brink.

2 Samuel 11

1 It happened at the time of year
 When kings do battle *without fear*,
 David sent Joab and his men
 With him and all Israel *again*,
 And they destroyed Ammon's folk, and

Besieged Rabbath, but David's stand
Was still in Jerusalem's land.

2 It happened toward the eventide,
That David got up from the side
Of his couch, and walked on the roof
Of the king's house, and from the roof
He saw a woman bathing there,
And the woman was very fair
To look at. 3 And David sent to
Inquire after the woman's due.
And one said "Is not this the lady
Bathsheba, daughter of *unshady*
Eliam, who's engaged as wife
To Uriah Hittite *for strife*."

4 And David sent messengers, and
Took her, she came in to him planned,
He lay with her, since she was pure
From her uncleanness, that is sure,
And she returned to her own house.
5 And the woman conceived *by spouse*,
And she sent David word and said
"I am with child, for I have bred."

How is it David thought he had the right
To marry another's chosen in sight?
Simply, Beloved, because You sent a law
To Moses that was always held in awe,
That states outright a man must lose
fiancée

If during that year he joins in the fray.
Uriah chose to further his career
And that made Bathsheba free volunteer.
David saw her in the miqwe and thought
Her the morsel that he had always sought,
And since Uriah had abandoned her
By law he had a right to skin the fur.
All things are lawful, says Apostle Paul,
But not expedient, if I recall.

6 And David said to Joab, "Send
Me Uriah the Hittite, send."

And Joab sent Uriah to
David to see *what he would do*.

7 And when Uriah came to him
David asked him what kind of trim
Joab was in and how the folk,
And how the war went stroke by stroke.

8 And David told Uriah, "Go
Down to your house to rest from foe
And wash your feet." Uriah went
Out of the king's house as was sent,
And with him followed generous

Portions of food from the king's mess.

9 But Uriah slept at the door
Of the king's house with all the store
Of servants of his lord and did
Not go down to his house, *but hid*.
10 And when they told David the thing,
"Uriah did not go to sing
At his own house," then David said
To Uriah, "Were you not led
On a journey, why did you not
Go down to your house and your plot?"

11 Uriah said to David then,
"The ark, Israel and Judah's men
Live in tents, and my lord Joab
And my lord's servants, gay and drab,
Are camping in the open field,
Shall I go to my house and yield,
To eat and drink and sleep with wife?
As you live and your soul has life,
I'll not do this thing, *though for strife*."
12 And David told Uriah then,
"Stay here tomorrow and again
I'll let you go." Uriah stayed
In Jerusalem *taxes paid*

That day and the next *unafraid*.
13 And David called him and he ate
And drank before him and was late
As he made him drunk, and at eve
He went out to lie in reprieve
On his bed with the servant staff
Of his lord, but went not to quaff
At his own *well and house for leave*.

So David and Bathsheba had a fight
Which of them should tell Uriah the light
That their engagement ended, David had
Taken her as his wife. The thing looked
bad.

Neither could bring themselves to say the
word,
Which makes one wonder how much heart
was stirred

In innocence for having followed law
To its letter, while Uriah made awe
Of a career in military state.
Beloved, I have no ambitions like he
For leaving fiancée for the army,
Nor have I lust to take another wife,
Nor have I any message cut like knife.
I have only desire to find Your tree.

14 And morning came, and David wrote

A letter to Joab by note
 And sent it by Uriah's hand.
 15 He wrote in the letter command,
 Saying "Put Uriah in front
 To bear the hottest battle's brunt,
 And then retreat from him that he
 May be smitten and die *sadly*."
 16 It happened when Joab kept watch
 Upon the city, he set notch
 To Uriah to keep the place
 Where he knew valiant men would face.
 17 The men of the city went out
 And fought with Joab to some rout
 And there fell some of the folk there
 Even of David's servants square,
 Uriah the Hittite died there.
 18 Then Joab sent and told the king
 David all of the war and thing,
 19 He told the messenger to say
 "When you have finished the relay
 Of all the things about the war
 To the king and the battle's score,
 20 "If it happens the king becomes
 Angry and says 'Why for your sums
 Were you so close to city wall
 To fight, did you not know at all
 That they would shoot down from the
 wall?
 21 "'Who struck down Abimelech son
 Of Jerubbesheth? Did not one
 Woman throw down an upper stone
 Of the mill on him from the zone,
 So he died in Thebez alone?
 Why did you go so near the wall?'
 Then you shall say 'our servant tall,
 Uriah the Hittite also
 Is dead *in the battle and show*.'"

Your ways, Beloved, devious though they
 seem,
 Are not in plot and thought as those in
 scheme
 Around the court and battle field on earth.
 Life here is harsh in intrigue and in worth.
 I see the stubborn Hittite make his fate
 Yearning for fame in battle over mate
 And shirking his God-given time to be
 Married to his engaged wife, unwisely.
 Until the scandal forced his hand the king
 Had no legal blemish to mar his ring.
 And now two men are guilty of one death.

My sorrow, my Beloved, my song and
 breath
 Arise to You still to remember how
 Doing things for ambition can harm now.

22 So the messenger went and came
 And told David all of the same
 That Joab had sent him to tell.
 23 The messenger told David this,
 "The men beat us back *with a hiss*,
 Came out against us in the field,
 And we came up to them as well
 To the door of the gate *and sealed*.
 24 "And archers shot at your servants
 From off the wall, of those servants
 Of the king some are dead and your
 Servant Uriah the Hittite
 Is also dead *beside the door*."
 25 Then David in messenger's sight
 Said "You shall say to Joab so,
 'Don't let this sadden you to go,
 For the sword consumes as it will,
 Sometimes one way, sometimes to fill,
 Be strong against the city now
 And overthrow it anyhow,'
 And so encourage him with will."
 26 When Uriah's fiancée heard
 That Uriah her man uncured
 Was dead, she mourned for her ex-man.
 27 And when the mourning time was past
 David sent and took her by plan
 Home to his house and she at last
 Was his wife and bore him a son.
 But the thing that David had done
 Displeased YHWH and left Him aghast.

Uriah chose the warrior's fame instead
 Of staying home to wife and hearth and
 bed
 As demanded by Torah law for those
 Who affianced a wife, any he chose.
 He ran the risk and took the chance of war,
 And gained the fame that he was fighting
 for.
 If David helped his course to his
 destruction,
 It was wrong indeed, but the whole
 production
 Took both men in their own ambitious
 greed.
 Beloved, let me plant only lowly seed,

The seeds of flowers, of dill, and parsley
green.

Let me not seek the finer, higher scene.
And I shall be content to praise Your name
Here where I am not king or guard for
fame.

2 Samuel 12

1 YHWH sent the prophet Nathan to
David, and he came into view
And said to him "Once there were two
Men in one city, one rich and
The other poor, *nothing in hand*.

2 "And the rich one had lots of flocks
And herds. 3 "But the poor man for stocks
Had nothing but one little ewe,
A lamb that he brought up and reared
Like one of his children appeared,
It ate the morsel of his bread,
And drank from his cup *when it fed*,
And slept on his breast like a *true*
Daughter. 4 "A traveller came in view
To the rich man, who did not wish
To slay his own flocks for a dish,
Nor touch his herds to dress a meal
For the traveller *who was genteel*,
So he took the poor man's one lamb,
And dressed it for the man like ham
Who had come *in to make a deal*."

The prophet Nathan comes not with the
word

Of law before which every heart is stirred,
But with the fable to rouse up emotion
And inform David of another notion.
His action was made by letter of law.
The woman was fair game to royal paw
Since her husband went off to war instead
Of finishing the marriage in the bed.
He did not kill the man with his own hand.
By letter of the law, David was grand.
It was a matter of the heart and will
To do the righteous thing and not the ill.
So many who obey today are still
Of evil heart and wash the hand in swill.

5 And David's anger greatly roused
Against the man, and David groused
To Nathan, "As YHWH is alive,
The man who did this thing to jive
Deserves to die. 6 "And he'll give back
The lamb fourfold for his attack

Without pity." 7 Then Nathan said
To David, "You're the man so led.
So says YHWH Israel's Alohim,
'I anointed you *from the stream*
As king of Israel, and saved
You from the hand of Saul *enslaved*,
8 'And I gave you your master's house,
And master's wives to be your grouse,
And gave you house of Israel
And of Judah, and if that spell
Were too small, then I would give more.
9 'Why have you despised YHWH's word
sore

To do what's evil in My sight?
Your sword struck Uriah Hittite,
And his fiancée you have taken
To be your wife, and him forsaken
To Ammonite folk's sword *mistaken*.
That's why the sword shall never leave
Your house, since you came to aggrieve
Myself and took the fiancée
Of Uriah the Hittite's prey
To be your wife *and in one day*.'

11 "So says YHWH, 'See, I shall raise up
Adversity from your own cup,
And I will take your wives before
Your eyes and give them at the door
To your neighbour, and he shall lie
With your wives under the sun's eye.

12 "For what you did in secret I
Shall do in all of Israel's sight,
And out under the sun *for light*.' "

13 So David said to Nathan, "I
Have sinned against YHWH, *that is why*."
And Nathan said to David, "YHWH
Has also forgiven to you
Your sin, you shall not die *for stew*.

Ah my Beloved, how soon the good and
great

Turn to desire and sin and face their fate,
For sin is to transgress Your law divine
And fail to live according to design.

Ah my Beloved, how soon the great and
good

The king and prophet David, as he should,
Heeds Your call to repent and with a word
Confessed his fault and then in faith he
heard

That You, without a sacrifice beyond
The heart repenting, in Your grace respond
Assuring of forgiveness for his sin.

Ah my Beloved, I also come within
Your arms of grace to crave Your mercy's
power
From day to day even from hour to hour.

14 'But by this deed you've given cause
For YHWH's foes to blaspheme His laws,
And so the child also that's born
To you shall surely die *forlorn*.'"

Beloved, I understand the leader set
By You on David's throne was one to get
The blame when he acted with selfish heart
To twist law to fit his pocket and part.
All understand injustice when it comes
From any hand but their own when they're
bums.

But what I do not understand is how
You lay the punishment on infant's brow.
Had I been born to Bathsheba and king
Even in that cruel and wanton thing,
I should have wanted to live and to love,
To feel the wind, to see the flight of dove,
To know the thrill of lightning and of
sound,
To sit hard and fulfilled upon the ground.

15 So Nathan went back to his house.
And YHWH struck down the little *mouse*
Of child that Uriah's fiancée
Bore to David upon that day,
And he was very sick. 16 David
Prayed to Alohim when He hid,
And David fasted, and went in
Lying on earth all night *for sin*.
17 The elders of his house arose
And stood beside him as they chose
To raise him from the earth, but he
Would not, and would not eat with them.
18 It happened on seventh day's *hem*,
That the child died. And David's men
Were afraid to tell him again
That the child had died, for they said
"See, while the child lived *in the bed*,
We spoke to him, and he heard not,
Then how can we tell him *the plot*
Of his child's death, he'd slay his knot."
19 And David saw his servants near
And whispering in common fear,
And so David knew that the child
Was dead, David *irreconciled*
Said to his servants, "Is the child

Dead?" And they answered, "He is dead."

The sorrow I see all around is not
Always what I think in my heart and plot.
Some weep to see some suffer, others cry
Because they were caught doing on the sly.
Some weep for Your forgiveness, some for
grace,
Some weep because they do not see Your
face,
And others weep before the vision's light.
Some weep to break the spear and some to
fight.
Beloved, who knows what hearts hide
behind tears?
Who knows whether the cry is one of fears
Or one of bliss. I come to You to find
Whatever sorrows and joys fill the mind
That is submitted to Your sovereign will,
That walks the plain and does not cart the
hill.

20 Then David got up from the bed
Of earth, washed and anointed head,
And changed his clothes and came into
The house of YHWH and worshipped true,
And then he went to his own place,
And when he asked for food with grace
They brought it to him and he ate.
21 His servants asked him, "Why this rate?
You fasted and wept for the child
While he lived, but then when the child
Was dead, you rose and did eat bread."
22 And he said, "While the child yet lived
I fasted and wept negatively.
For I said 'Who knows if YHWH may
Pity me and let the child stay?'
23 "But now he is dead, why should I
Fast? Can I bring him on the sly
Back once more? I shall go to him,
But he'll not return from the dim."
24 And David comforted his wife
Bathsheba and went in for life
To her and lay with her and she
Bore a son and called him namely
Solomon. And YHWH loved the wee.
25 And by the hand of Nathan sent
As prophet, he was called as bent,
Jedidiah, because of YHWH,
The One who loved the boy who grew.

The story shows it obvious that You,

Beloved, willed that the boy should be
 born too.
 You may have even willed the death of
 brother
 So that Solomon should be first his mother
 Brought into royal line to be a king.
 Your will is such a darkly mannered thing.
 So You loved Solomon, what of the child
 Who died within the week? Though I am
 wild,
 I think to live a week in this world's all
 One needs to benefit the Sabbath call.
 The boy died, yes, but not before his wait
 Brought him alive though ill through
 Sabbath's gate.
 Beloved, I too in anguish or in joy
 Await the Sabbath day in Your employ.

26 Now Joab fought against Rabbah
 Of Ammon's folk and took élat
 Of royal city *in his paw*.

27 Then Joab sent his messengers
 To David and said by the fers,
 "I have fought with Rabbah, I took
 The town of waters *from the crook*.

28 "So gather all the rest to come,
 All of the people and in sum
 Encamp against the city and
 Take it, lest I conquer the land
 And town and it be called by name
 After me and for my own fame."

29 And David gathered all the folk
 Together and went up at stroke
 Against Rabbah, and fought them there
 And took *the city for his share*.

30 And he took the crown of their king
 Molchom from off his head with string,
 And it weighed a talent of gold
 With precious stones, and it was sold
 Upon the head of David, and
 He brought much spoil from that town's
 land.

31 And he brought up the folk from there
 And put them under saws for share,
 And under iron harrows' wear,
 And under iron axes, and
 Made them pass through the brick kiln, and
 So he did to all cities in
 The places of Ammon's children.

When David struts about with crown on
 head

Stolen from some monkey of kingly dread,
 No one today says any word's mistrust.
 Instead they have Muhammad and the dust
 They throw on him for robbery and strife
 As some would try to read the prophet's
 life.

There may have been men in the past
 whose fame
 And Your appointment made them not to
 blame

For the atrocity of warfare meant
 To cleanse earth from its wickedness and
 vent.

There may have been, but I am sure that
 now

Those who make sword and bomb of
 peaceful plough

Have no such mandate. No, not any one.
 Their mandate is the booty and the fun.

2 Samuel 13

1 After this Absalom who was
 The son of David taken pause
 Had a sister lovely to tell
 Whose name was Tamar, and her spell
 Upon David's son Amnon fell.
 2 Amnon was so distressed that he
 Fell ill because his sister's fee,
 Tamar's, was of virginity,
 And it seemed hard for Amnon to
 Do anything for her to woo.
 3 And Amnon had a friend whose name
 Was Jonadab, the son to blame
 Of Samaa, David's brother, and
 Jonadab was a cunning brand.
 4 And he said to him "Why, O son
 Of the king, do you leave your fun
 And food to lose weight day by day?
 Why don't you tell me what gives way?"
 And Amnon said to him, "I love
 Tamar, brother Absalom's dove."
 5 And Jonadab said to him, "Lie
 Down on your bed and be so sly
 As to pretend that you are sick.
 And when your father sees the trick,
 Tell him, 'Let my sister Tamar
 Come, please, and give me caviar,
 And cook a meal here in my sight
 And feed me with her own hand light.'"
 6 So Amnon lay down and pretended
 That he was sick, and when the fended
 King came to see him Amnon said

To the king, "Let my sister led,
Let Tamar come, please and make me
A couple of cakes where I see,
And I shall eat from her hand free."
7 Then David sent home to Tamar,
Saying "Now go *with your guitar*
To you brother Amnon's house and
Roust him a meal *and feed by hand.*"

Those days it seems princesses knew the
trade
Of cooking and confections sweetly made.
In that they are like present royalty
Who go to the same schools as the needy.
It was but century or so ago
The royals spent their time on glit and
glow
And let the servants learn to bake the
dough.

Even the king of Sweden has the show
Of annually making in family
His own sausages for the Christmas spree.
Beloved, David is not too wise when he
Lets out the dove to tiger in the grass.
Wait but a moment for the lust to pass,
And see how many stick in the morass.

8 Went Tamar to her brother's house,
And he was lying sick *like mouse*,
And she took dough and kneaded it,
And made cakes in his sight and fit,
And baked the cakes *on brazier lit.*

9 And so she took the frying pan
And poured them out before his scan,
But he would not eat. Amnon said
"Send every man out from my bed."
And every man went out as led.

10 And Amnon said to Tamar, "Bring
The food into the chamber wing,
And I will eat it from your hand.
And Tamar took the cakes she'd made,
And brought them in the chamber planned
To brother Amnon unafraid.

11 And when she'd brought them near to
him

To eat, he caught her in his vim,
And told her, "Come and lie with me,
My sister." 12 And she said freely,
"No, my brother, do not force me,
For no such thing now ought to be
Done in Israel, so do not do
This wanton deed, *but please stand true.*

13 "And I, how shall I bear the shame,
And you will be as one to blame
In Israel. Now therefore please
Speak to the king, and he'll give ease
Not to withhold me from your pleas."
14 But Amnon would not hear her voice,
But overpowered her by choice
And humbled her without invoice.

A half brother is capable I see
Of incest even on the royal tee.
What surprises perhaps is that she thought
The king would let him have the suit he
sought.

There are coxcombs about this living day
Who do not wish to marry lawful prey,
But prefer to force one or all to take
A sip of their nectar for sweetness' sake
And leave the scene of prime to find again
Another on another day and when.
Beloved, I too feel passion in the vein
And hear the calling of the virgin rain.
But keep me from incestuous refrain,
Unlike the house of David in their train.

15 Then Amnon hated her with such
Very great hatred, hate as much,
No more than the love by which he
Had loved her. Amnon said *freely*
To her, "Get up, get out, *banshee.*"

16 And she said to him "Let it not
Be so, because this wrong unsought
In putting me out is worse than
The other evil done by plan."
But he would not listen to her.

17 Then he called for his servant fer
That waited on him, and he said
"Now put this woman from my bed,
Lock the door after her instead."

18 Now she was wearing a robe made
Of varied colours as displayed
By the king's virgin daughters then,
And his servant led her parade
Outside and locked the door again.

19 And Tamar put ash on her head,
And tore her coloured robe *when led*,
And put her hands up on her head,
And went crying and weeping *sped.*

20 And Absalom her brother said
To her, "Did brother Amnon stay
With you? Just keep still on the way,
My sister, he's your brother, so

Don't take to heart the thing or show."

21 But when David heard all these things,

He was angry *to bellows*.

22 And Absalom spoke to Amnon

Neither good nor bad as sun shone,

But Absalom hated Amnon,

Because he forced his sister's *shame*,

And Tamar *was his sister's name*.

Amnon it seems was unaccustomed to

The lassitude that comes to each on cue

After ejaculation, it would seem

That he had never gone beyond wet dream.

And so he blamed Tamar after the fit

When he was too tired to keep up his wit.

It's typical a man will blame his wife

For what he himself fails to do in strife.

A father's role's to rage and keep his hand

From doing any outrage by command.

A brother's role is to keep silent word

And pretend no offence has yet occurred.

Beloved, Yours is the vengeance of the just

To fall upon all men possessed of lust.

23 It happened after two full years,

That Absalom with his sheep shears

Was in Baal Hazor, which is near

Ephraim, so Absalom's cheer

Was to invite each royal son.

24 And Absalom came on the run

To the king and said "See now, your

Servant has sheep shearers at door,

Let the king, please and his servants

Go with your servant *down to dance*."

25 And the king said to Absalom,

"No, my son, let's not all in sum

Go, lest we be burden to you."

He urged him but he would not go,

But only blessed him *for the show*.

26 Then Absalom said "If not, then

Please let Amnon my brother's yen

Go with us." And the king told him,

"Why should he go? *It's a thing dim*."

But Absalom urged him, so he

Let Amnon go and all that be

King's sons *to keep him company*.

28 Absalom commanded his men,

Saying "Now take notice and when

Amnon's heart's merry with his drink,

And when I tell you at the brink,

'Strike Amnon down and kill the man,'

Have no fear, since it is my plan.

Be of courage and valiant *link*.

I understand the anger in the breast

Of Absalom and how he got no rest

For what had happened to his favoured girl

And sister at the actions of the churl.

I also understand that he could not

Raise his own hand on brother in the plot,

But rather gave command a servant might

Strike down the valiant Amnon and the

wight.

But what I do not fathom is the wake

Of crass obedience the servants make.

If anyone is worse than Hitler and

The group of tyrants of last century's stand

It is the little man who will obey

The orders given to him with a bray.

29 And Absalom's servants did what

Absalom told them to and sought

To kill Amnon, and all the sons

Of the king got up from their buns

And everyone got on his mule

And took to heel *as though from school*.

30 It happened while they travelled on,

The news came to David anon

That Absalom had killed them all,

All the king's sons, none left in stall."

31 Then up the king got and he tore

His clothing and lay on the earth,

And all his servants stood before

With their clothing torn without mirth.

32 But Jonadab, son of Shimeah

David's brother, answered gainsayer,

And said "Let not my lord suppose

That they have killed in all their rose

The young men the king's sons, but just

Amnon is dear, for by the lust

Of Absalom's vengeance this thing

Is determined today to ring

Because he forced his sister Tamar.

33 "So now don't fret at the disclaimer,

My lord the king to say in heart,

'All the king's sons lie dead in cart,'

For only Amnon of them all

Is dead *and lying in the stall*."

34 But Absalom escaped and fled.

And the young man who kept the head

Of the guard lifted up his eyes

And saw beholding in this wise,

That many people by descent

Around about the hillside went.

And the watchman came told the king,
 And said "See, I have seen a thing,
 Men arriving upon the road,
 And on the mountainside they strode."
 35 And Jonadab said to the king,
 "See now, the king's sons in a ring,
 Just as I told you, see the thing."

Well might the man Jonadab have his say
 And appear to divine before the sway
 Of David's throne, since he was behind all
 The plot to rape the girl and then to call
 The moves as he delighted to address
 The world behind the scenes in power to
 guess.

The weeping and the quailing is for show
 In every court of king and gigolo,
 The praying and the singing are a round
 That hide the lust to kill that must abound
 Where Your law is unloved though once
 confessed.

The honesty that's seen is window dressed.
 Beloved, curse Jonadab and everyone
 That's like him living here under the sun.

36 It happened as soon as he'd done,
 See in came each and every son
 Of the king, and lifted up voice
 And wept, the king as well as choice
 Of all his servants was to weep.
 37 But Absalom fled and went to
 Talmai the son of you know who
 Ammihud king of Geshur's crew.
 And David mourned each day for that
 Son. 38 But Absalom fled and sat
 In Geshur three years, 39 till the king
 David ceased to go out to bring
 Absalom to justice. For he
 Had been comforted for the spree
 Against Amnon's mortality.

If David had treated Amnon by law
 Of incest and rape there would be no claw
 To cause such violence upon the land.
 Absalom would have remained out of hand
 In innocence and Tamar satisfied.
 David and his brother, both side by side,
 One wielding outward power, the other's
 hand
 Mixing in all affairs with sly command,
 These are the guilty ones. Amnon's a
 pawn,

And so is Absalom risen by dawn.
 Beloved, I see the flight, and spy the tears
 Of refugee today before their fears,
 And what the kings and presidents relay,
 And know that Jonadab will have his way.

2 Samuel 14

1 Now Joab son of Zeruiah
 Noticed the king's heart in latria
 Towards Absalom. 2 And Joab sent
 To Tekoa's apportionment,
 And fetched from there a woman wise,
 And said to her, "Mourn in disguise,
 And put on mourning weeds and yet
 Do not put oil upon the set,
 And be as widow mourning one
 That is many days dead and done.
 3 "And you shall go before the king,
 And speak to him and according
 To this word." And Joab put words
 In her mouth *as though from the birds*.
 4 When the woman from Tekoa
 Spoke to the king, she fell in awe
 On her face to the ground and thus
 Prostrated herself's animus,
 And said *to him*, "Help, O king, us."
 5 And the king said to her, "What is
 The matter with you?" She took his
 Word answering, "I am indeed
 A widow woman and in need
 For my husband is of death's breed.
 6 "And your handmaid had two sons, and
 They fought together at a stand
 And in the field there was no one
 To part them, but the other son
 Struck down the one killed by his hand.
 7 "And see the whole family arose
 Against your handmaid and they chose
 To say 'Give up the one who killed
 His brother, so we may be filled
 In vengeance for his brother's life,'
 And so destroy the heir in strife.
 And so they'll quench my coal that's left,
 And leave to my husband bereft
 Neither name nor remainder on
 The face of the earth *at the dawn*."

The office of wise woman is not known
 In Torah, Psalm, Gospel or Qur'an's own,
 But is the secret left remaining in
 The Book of Samuel underneath the din
 Of male authority to show the old

The ancient living matriarchate bold.
The woman's leadership was set up once
In Paradise, which is why never dunce
The serpent watcher addressed Eve instead
Of the man with her. Here in David's
spread,

Though he is king, there are such women
still

Who rule the quiet ways beyond the hill.
The wise woman thus comes to king with
word

Better than those that have the prophets
stirred.

9 And Tekoa's woman then said
To the king, "On me, my lord, spread,
O King, and on my father's house
Be the iniquity *like mouse*,
And the king and his throne be free
Of the guilt and iniquity."

10 And the king said "Who spoke to you?
Bring him to me, and in my view
He shall not touch you any more."

11 And she said "I pray on that score,
Let the king remember, mind YHWH
Your Alohim, that on his cue
The blood avenger not destroy
Any more, lest they kill my boy."
And he said "As YHWH lives, there shall
Not one hair of the prodigal
Fall to the earth." 12 The woman said
"Let your handmaid, please, have word
spread

Before my lord the king." And he
Said "*Speak your message faithfully.*"

13 And the woman said "Why have you
Devised this thing against God's crew?
For in this word the king is met
As one that's of the guilty set,
In that the king does not bring home
Again his banished one *Salome*.

The Torah trick of the avenger's plot
Is mitigated here when Joab sought
To bring back Absalom. It seems the turn
Of feuding was against the crown to spurn
The judgement powers of the king
appointed.

And so Joab thought to strengthen anointed
King at the same time as increase the
peace.

The point's to abrogate the sure release

Of slayer in the city of refuge,
And make the king an arbitration's stooge.
Blood vengeance is a dirty row to hoe
And often gets out of hand at the show.
But so does judgement of the court and
state.

Corruption falls on every sceptred pate.

14 "For we shall surely die and be
As water poured on earth from sea
Which cannot be gathered again,
Nor does God respect any men,
But let him devise means that he
Who's banished not an outcast be.

15 "And now whereas I came to speak
This word to my lord the king, meek,
It is because the folk made me
Afraid, and so said your handmaid

16 "For surely the king will hear you,
To save his servant from the crew
Of men who would destroy me and
My son together from the land
Given us by Alohim's hand."

18 And the king answered, and he said
To the woman, "Don't hide the spread
From me, please, nor the matter which
I ask of you yourself in switch."

And the woman said "Let my lord
The king by all means speak a word."

19 And the king said "Is not the hand
Of Joab with you by command?"

And the woman answered and said
"As you soul lives, my lord king led,
None can turn to the right or left
But that my lord the king is deft,
For your servant Joab, he told
Me, and he put all these words bold
In the mouth of your handmaid *old*,
20 To change this state of how things are
Done has your servant Joab, star,
Done his thing, but my lord is wise,
According to great wisdom's size
To know all thing on earth that rise."

David is Your appointed one to rule
And apply Your laws in the swimming
pool,

And yet the ways of taking care of mate
That slays another when he meets his fate
Are changed not through a revelation made
Through him or through his conscience to
be stayed,

But through a general in army paid
And through a woman wise whose role was
found

In days when matriarchy still had ground.
Beloved, the world is open in Your will
To surprises like peacocks on the hill,
Or snow in summer, or in winter's night
A burnished branch of carded candlelight.
Beloved, I listen for Your speeches still.

21 And the king said to Joab, "See,
I have done now accordingly,
Go and bring back the young man *called*
Absalom, *though I am appalled*.

22 And Joab fell down on his face
To the ground and prostrated place,
And blessed the king, and Joab said
"Today your servant knows as led
That I have found grace in your sight,
My lord, O king, who did me right
In your servant's request *and plight*."

23 And Joab got up and went to
Geshur, and brought Absalom to
Jerusalem. 24 And the king said
"Let him turn to his own house, but
Let him not see my face unshut."
So Absalom turned to his house
And did not see king's face *or mouse*.

25 Now in all Israel there was none
To be so much praised *under sun*
As Absalom for his beauty,
From the sole of his foot *to knee*
And to the crown of his head there
Was no blemish, not anywhere.
26 And when he polled his head, that is,
When he cut off his hair in whiz
At the end of the year, because
It was so heavy on his paws,
He weighted the hair from his head,
Two hundred shekels by the bled
Royal shekel by royal laws.

The rite of shaving head at the year's end
Is something no Scriptures come to defend
Or give the prohibition, but the thing
Was done at least by one son of a king
Who stands as divine guide and divine
proof.

And so I do not come to stand aloof
From doing so. I take the proven track
From Makkah to Mina and turn my back
On where I started in Mount Arafat

To find a barber who will shave my mat
And so remind me of where the king led
In submission to You, Beloved, instead
Of sun or moon or any gods that glow
In heaven above or in waters below.

27 And to Absalom there were born
Three sons and one daughter *to warn*
Whose name was Tamar, and she was
A woman fair *as beauty does*.

Note well, Beloved, that Absalom did not
Vent merely wicked vengeance in a plot,
But made positive sign of righteousness,
A tribute to his sister in address
Who had been shamed, by naming his own
girl

After her even though she scorned the
churl.

There's always something positive to do
In face of evil, and to name a few
With names well measured in their
message true

Is recourse men as well has women follow.
One need not stumble and lie down to
wallow.

One can grow up like Tamar year be year
Like the date-palm and facing without fear
The generations, wipe away the tear.

28 And Absalom lived two full years
In Jerusalem, it appears
He did not see king face to face.

29 Then Absalom sent to the place
Of Joab, to send him the grace
To come to the king, but he would
Not come to him *for ill or good*.

30 Therefore he said to his servants,
"See, Joab's field, one where he plants
His barley, go set it on fire."

And Absalom's servants *in choir*
Set the field alight. 31 Joab rose
And came to Absalom to pose
To him the question, "Why have your
Servants lit up my field *for war?*"

32 And Absalom answered Joab,
"See I sent to you at a jab,
Saying 'Come here that I may send
You to the king to say "Why tend
To bring me from Geshur? If I
Have sinned, then judge me now to die."'"

33 So Joab came before the king

And told him, and when he had called
For Absalom, he came enthralled
To the king, and bowed on his face
To the ground before the king's grace,
And the king kissed Absalom's face.

It sounds to me that in the reconciling
Of Absalom to David the one styling
For loss was only Joab in his field.
No one replaced the loss in barley yield.
The king is happy and also the son,
But Joab's under catastrophic dun.
He might have left the well enough alone
In Gershur where Absalom had his throne.
Beloved, let me not intercede for king
And estranged child in any kind of thing.
My business is alone with You to set
Your names to melodies I've not yet met.
Human relations are a waste of time,
At least to those who have to spend the
dime.

2 Samuel 15

1 It happened after this prepared
Absalom chariots and spared
No means acquiring horses too
And fifty men to run in crew
Before him. 2 And Absalom would
Get up early and stand as good
Beside the way to the king's gate,
And when anyone came in state
With a suit of judgement to take
To the king, then Absalom's ache
Was to call him and say "Of which
City are you?" And he would hitch
To inform him, "Your servant's one
From the tribes of Israel a son."
3 Then Absalom would say to him,
"See, your case is one just, not dim,
But there's no man set by the king
To hear you and correct the thing."
4 And Absalom would answer then,
"Oh that I were made judge to sit
In the land, that every man fit
Who had a suit or cause might come
To me, and I'd do justice' sum."
5 And it was so that when a man
Came near to bow down where he ran,
That he stretched out his hand and took
Hold of him and he kissed *the crook*.
6 And in this way did Absalom
Act toward judgement, so Absalom

Stole the hearts of Israel's men.

Here Absalom, inventor of the rate
Of modern politics of lobby fate
And flattering the folk disconsolate,
Foil's justice while praising with tender
heart

Justice that could be wrought with horse
and cart

If he were given rein. I see the part
Replayed in every election and grade.
Beloved, Your way is best, the lottery
That gives You chance to choose among
the free.

God grant futile, costly democracy
Be replaced with the falling numbered
balls,

And fortunes rather given at the calls
Of merit for things done in work and
rhyme.

Beloved, inflict a change in space and time.

7 It happened when forty years came
To an end *in Davidic fame*,
That Absalom said to the king,
"Please let me go by vow and sing
What I have vows to YHWH to bring
In Hebron. 8 For your servant vowed
A vow while I lived when allowed
In Geshur in Aram, saying
"If YHWH shall indeed truly bring
Me back to Jerusalem, then
I will there serve YHWH once again."
9 And the king told him "Go in peace."

See this, Beloved, the king's son calls
himself

The servant of the king, not waif or elf.
Then why do simple folk insist Your word
Is stinking like corruption of a turd
Because in one You call a man Your son,
And in the other, the same man when done,
A servant? If Absalom can say so
With king's impunity, why all the show
To criticize You, my Beloved, who speak
To say every son of Your hand is weak
And human, yet revealing of Your face
Throughout creation's form, colour and
grace?

I am a son and more of You who made
Me to serve You with pen and cart and
spade.

10 But Absalom sent spies all through
 The tribes of Israel to give cue,
 "As soon as you hear the horn's sound,
 Then you shall say the word around,
 "Absalom's king on Hebron's ground!"
 11 Two hundred men with Absalom,
 They went out of Jerusalem,
 In their hearts' full simplicity,
 And did not know *the treachery*.
 12 And Absalom sent for the man
 Ahithophel Gilonite's plan,
 David's counsellor from his town,
 Even from Giloh, *without frown*,
 While he offered the sacrifice.
 And the conspiracy's device
 Was strong, for the folk came along
 Always after Absalom's *song*.
 13 And there came messengers at last
 To David, saying "The full cast
 Of Israel's men is for the reign
 Of Absalom." 14 David would fain
 Say to all his servants that were
 With him at Jerusalem's spur,
 "Get up, let's go, lest he come fast
 To attack us and the town's *mast*
 With the mouth of the sword *up cast*."
 15 And the king's servants told the king,
 "In all our lord king chooses, see
 We are your servants loyally."
 16 And the king went out and with all
 His household after him to crawl,
 And the king left ten women who
 Were concubines to keep the crew
 Of the house. 17 And the king went out
 And all the folk after his route
 And stopped at the outskirts *to scout*.

King David trusted his son in the thing
 Regarding the court ladies remaining.
 He could not think that harm should come
 to them
 From one who was so full of stratagem
 To rake vengeance of brother for the crime
 Of abuse of his sister for a dime.
 He knew the colour of the man and so
 Predicted righteousness even in show
 Of cold conspiracy. Beloved, I know
 That human hearts may reckon good a
 while,
 But when faced with ambition and in style,

The good is thrown out with intentions
 made
 When justice was set out and on parade.
 David's mistake is trusting human guile.

18 And all his servants passed beside
 Him, and all the Cherethites' *tide*,
 And all the Pelethites and all
 The Gittites, six hundred *at call*
 That came after him from Gath, passed
 On before the king *at the mast*.
 19 Then said the king to Ittai who
 Was of the Gittites and their crew,
 "Why are you going with us too?
 Return and remain with the king,
 For you're a foreigner *to swing*
 And an exile *and refugee*
 From your own place *and your city*.
 Since you just came here yesterday,
 Should I drag you about today
 Considering I go where may?
 Go back then you and all of yours
 And may YHWH deal with you *for scores*
 In truth and *in His mercy's stores*."
 21 Ittai answered the king and said
 "As YHWH lives and my lord *is led*,
 As the king lives, where he will be,
 In death or life's *serenity*,
 There shall also your servant be."
 22 And David said to Ittai then,
 "Go and pass over *with the men*."
 And Ittai the Gittite passed over,
 And all his men and every rover,
 And all the little ones with him.
 23 And all the land wept loud and grim,
 As all the people passed the rim,
 And as the king crossed brook Kidron,
 All the folk passed over and drawn
 Toward the way of the wilderness,
There to find needed new address.

Though prophet is unknown in his own
 land,
 And son of peace may turn a traitor's hand,
 It still is rare a stranger on the prow
 Is such a friend as Ittai with a growl.
 When one is down, the worthy thing to do
 In this brave city is to join the crew
 Of those who throw stones at the fallen
 view.
 Every foundation's made of stone and
 sand.

The hard heart and the fickle take a stand,
Beloved, where I too raise an eye to see.
I look about wilderness and country
To find a fleeing king and Ittai's band.
Beloved I only see the rush to find
A place among the shadows of the blind.

24 And see, Zadok was also there,
And all the Levites he could spare,
Bearing the ark of Alohim
In covenant, in their esteem
They set down ark of Alohim,
But Abiathar went up till
All the town folk had crossed the hill.
25 And the king said to Zadok then,
"Carry Alohim's ark to den
Of the city, and if I find
Favour in YHWH's eyes, I'm resigned
He'll bring me back and show me it
As well as His dwelling and fit.
26 But if He says 'I've no delight
In You', I am not here to fight,
Let Him do to me as seems best
To Him *and in Him I find rest.*"
27 The king also said to Zadok
The priest, "See here, you should go back
To the city in peace or lack,
And your two sons with you, your son
Ahimaaz, the other one
Jonathan son of Abiathar.
28 "See, I will stay upon the plains
Of wilderness, as long detains
Word from you and what it contains."

The humble treaty of David is not
So innocent of political plot.
He has his spies and sends them with an
eye
Of what he wants to know for them to spy.
A priest is a good choice, since many think
The priest is neutral on politics' brink.
But such is never so: the innocent
Are not priests but the good in heart when
sent.
Beloved, I send my spies into Your den,
And meet Your spies come out to me
again.
I send my doves with white wing to
abound
And find where Your ark rests upon the
ground
And take it to my heart that I may be

One with You, my Beloved, eternally.

29 So Zadok and Abiathar
Brought back the ark of YHWH and star
To Jerusalem, where they are.
30 And David went up by ascent
Of mount of Olives, and he lent
His voice to weeping as he went,
Covered his head and trod barefoot,
And all the people with him put
A cover on their heads and rose
Up weeping as their sorrow shows.
31 And one told David, and he said
"Ahithophel is also led
Among conspirators to be
With Absalom." And David's plea
Was, "O YHWH, I pray You to turn
Ahithophel's counsel to spurn."
32 It happened that when David came
To the top of the hill where claim
Of worship to Alohim's name
Took place, see Hushai the Archite
Came to meet him, his coat a sight,
And torn, and earth upon his head.
33 And David told him "If you go
With me, you'll be a burden so.
34 "But if you return to the town
And tell Absalom without frown,
'I shall be your servant, O king,
As I've done for your father's ring
In times past, so I shall now be
Your servant,' then will you make free
To defeat Ahithophel's word
Of counsel for me *when he's stirred.*
35 "And see, with you there are Zadok,
Abiathar the priests in stock,
And it shall be that everything
You hear out of the counselling
Of the king's house, such shall you bring
To Zadok and Abiathar
The priests *who are my guiding star.*
36 "See, they have with them their two
sons,
Ahimaaz Zadok's son who stuns,
Jonathan Abiathar's son,
By them you'll tell me what is done."
37 So Hushai, David's friend came to
The city, and Absalom too
Came to Jerusalem *and won.*

You may wonder, Beloved, if the plan will
Amount to anything on Zion's hill.

Many distrust the friend of enemy,
 Until he shows his worth in battle spree.
 Hushai is known as David's loyal friend
 And thus is unreliable to tend
 Matters for David's son and valiant foe,
 Absalom. My experience has taught
 Duty is something that is always bought.
 You alone are true to the righteous weight
 Along the centuries of power and state.
 Alone You can be trusted, yet men still
 Linger about the court for good or ill.
 I flee to You, Beloved, from every mate.

2 Samuel 16

1 When David was a little past
 The top, Ziba, slave of the last
 Mephibosheth, met him with two
 Donkeys saddled, and on those two
 Hundred loaves of bread, and a store
 Of one hundred clusters not more
 Of raisins, and of summer fruits
 A hundred, and grape juice as suits
 In a bottle. 2 And the king said
 To Ziba, "Why have you been led
 To bring these things?" And Ziba said
 "The donkeys are for the king's house
 To ride on, and the bread to douse
 With summer fruit for the young men
 To eat, and the grape juice again
 For such as are faint in the glen
 To drink." 3 And the king said *again*,
 "Where is your master's son?" and he
 Ziba said to the king freely,
 "See, he is in Jerusalem,
 For he said "Today will the *hem*
Of Israel's house be once restored
To me and kingdom of my lord."
 4 Then said the king to Ziba, "See,
 Yours is all that belonged *in fee*
 To Mephibosheth." Then said he,
 Ziba, "I bow down, let me find
 Grace in your sight, lord king *assigned.*"
 5 When king David saw Bahurim,
 See, there came out one from regime
 Of Saul's family, one who was called
 Shimei the son of Gera stalled,
 And he came cursing unappalled.

Beloved, I too come cursing kings a while
 And follow their parade a second mile
 And throw stones at their entourage and
 smile

To see them muddied and sullied for guile.
 There's nothing sweeter on earth than the
 curse

One mouths against prime ministers and
 worse.

Though I'm a man of peace and no stone
 from

My hand will attain mark to beat the sum
 Or draw blood from the royal brow, yet I
 Still curse the head of state when passing
 by.

I once came without warning on the street
 In London and whom should I sudden meet
 But Prince Edward, eye to eye, face to
 face.

I failed to lift my hat, still feel disgrace.

6 And he threw stones at David, and
 At all the servants at the hand
 Of king David, and all the folk
 And all the mighty men awoke
 On the right and left of the king.

7 And so Shimei went on cursing
 Him saying "Begone, begone, you
 Man of blood, and base bloke and crew,
 8 "YHWH's taken vengeance on you due
 For all the blood of house of Saul,
 In whose place you have reigned to pall,
 And see, you're caught in your own net
 Of mischief, because you're one set
 In blood." Then Abishai the son
 Of Zeruiah said when done
 To the king, "Why should this dead dog
 Curse my lord king? Let me unclog
 His head." 10 And the king said "What do
 I have to do with this thing, you
 Sons of Zeruiah? So let

Him curse, because YHWH once has set
 Him saying 'Curse David,' then who
 Shall say 'Why have you come to do?'"

11 And David said to Abishai,
 And all his servants, "See here, my
 Own son, who came out from my own
 Body, would kill me for the throne,
 How much more this Benjamite now?
 Let him alone and let him curse,
 Since YHWH has commanded him terse.
 12 "It may be that YHWH will look on

My eye, and that YHWH's benison
 Will reward me good for the wrong
 Of his cursing me this day long."

13 So David and his men went by

The road, and Shimei long the hill
Throwing stones at him on the sly
And casting dust upon him still.
14 And the king and all the folk there
With him were weary with the care
And so he refreshed himself there.

I join the House of David and attach
My lowly self to be servant for scratch
In David's court to cantillate his Psalms
Week by week beneath firs instead of
palms,

And know the Sufic character that he
Projects upon both servant and the free
Is still a word of power and hope to be
Fulfilled on me who now persistently
Beyond his centuries before his throne
Wait in faith and in hope that You alone
May grant reward and vengeance on the
pate
Of those who are rebellious in their hate
Of You, Beloved, and invent modern state
To defy Decalogue, the insensate.

15 But Absalom and all the folk
The men of Israel to a bloke
Came to Jerusalem, also
Ahitophel came with the show.
16 It happened when Hushai Archite,
David's friend had come in the sight
Of Absalom, that Hushai said
To Absalom, "Long live king led,
Long live the king," so Hushai said.
17 And Absalom said to Hushai,
"Is this your kindness to the guy
Who was your friend? Now tell me why
You did not join your friend to die?"

18 And Hushai said to Absalom,
"No, but whom YHWH and this folk's
sum,
And all Israel have chosen, his
Will I be and dwell where he is.
19 "And again, whom should I serve then?
Should I not serve as denizen
Before his son, as I have served
In your father's presence unswerved,
So I'll be to you, as I've served."

I too, Beloved, bow before rules of state
And pay my taxes, though careless and
late,
And give robber and merchant each his due

And do not fail to kiss the mighty crew
Demolishing the palaces and true
Of David's tabernacle set in song.

I bow and smirk before those who do
wrong

But wield the sword and claim to bear
Your name
Before the world for their oppression's
claim.

But I'm no spy like Hushai in the court.
I'm just a leprechaun with finger wart,
Appearing now with bow and scrape and
zeal,

Then disappearing in the commonweal
To hide beneath the fir and forest game.

20 Absalom told Ahithophel,
"Give counsel, what we shall do well."

21 And Ahithophel then said to
Absalom, "Go you in unto
Your father's concubines that he
Has left to keep the house in fee,
And all Israel will hear the spree
And know you dishonour your dad,
So the hands of all with you, lad,
Will be strong in the strength you had."

22 So they spread Absalom a tent
On the house-top, and there he went
Into his father's concubines
Before all Israel by designs.

23 Now Ahithophel's counsel then
Which he counselled those days of men
Was as if a man asked of God,
So finely Ahithophel trod,
Both with David and with the clod
Absalom, *both in bloom and pod.*

For shame that such counsel should see the
light

Of inner sanctum of the palace night!
For shame that Israel could bear the sight!
And yet the government today is set
To close an eye to all perversion met
In pedophile and slave traffic to get
A profit from free enterprise and strong.
Lacking the funds is the only thing wrong
By the standards of worldly recompense.
Without the Decalogue, man has no sense.

Beloved, I cry fie on hypocrisy
That builds glass and steel towers to be
free

And yet sees that extortion is the way

To make the populace pay and repay.

2 Samuel 17

1 Ahithophel told Absalom,
“Let me now choose men to the sum
Of twelve thousand, and I will come
And pursue David now tonight.
2 “And I will come upon the wight
While he is weary, weak in hand,
And make him afraid *of the planned*,
And all the folk with him shall flee,
And I will smite the king only.
3 “And I will bring the people all
Back to you, when all are in stall,
Except the man you’re looking for,
All the folk will have peace *in store*.”
4 And what he said seemed right before
Absalom, and all elder’s there
Of Israel *under his care*.
5 Then said Absalom, “Now call me
Hushai the Archite too, to see
What he says of the plan *to me*.”
6 When Hushai came to Absalom,
Absalom spoke to him in sum,
Saying “Ahithophel has said
To do this way, how are you led?
If you don’t agree, speak your dread.”

I too, Beloved, have heard reality
Stated by scientist and the gentry
Of church, and thought the saying was the
truth.

The next one on the platform showed my
youth
And lack of wisdom before reason’s tale.
I bide by logic, and all men prevail
To set up falsehood under logic’s pale.
While I do not reject logic’s appeal,
Since that is what a human being’s reel
Under the universe is paid to steal,
I know it can be played against the weal.
Logic governed by law, law of Your word
Once pronounced at Sinai to beast and
bird,
Shows me the truth of glory, truth
unblurred.

7 And Hushai said to Absalom,
“Ahithophel’s advice in sum
At this time is not good *for rum*.”
8 Hushai moreover said “You do
Not know your father and his crew,

That they are mighty men and true
Embittered in their spirits too,
As a bear robbed of her own cubs
In the field, and your father rubs
A man of war, and will not stay
With the people this night till day.
9 “See, he is hid now in some pit,
Or in some place that he sees fit,
And it will happen when they fall
Upon them at the first to brawl,
Whoever hears the thing will say
There’s slaughter of folk on the way
Of those that follow Absalom.
10 “So even the valiant and rum
Whose heart is like a lion’s heart,
Will melt completely, for the part
Of all Israel knows that your dad
Is a mighty man, mean and bad,
And those with him are valiant men.
11 “But I advise all Israel
Be gathered to you from the swell
Of Dan to Beersheba, like sand
That’s by the sea on every hand,
And you shall go to battle stand
In your own person to command.
12 “So we shall come upon him there
In some place where he is found fair,
And we’ll attack him like the dew
That falls upon the ground in view,
And of him and of all the men
Who are with him in glen or den
We shall not leave one or a few.
13 “And if he takes refuge to go
Into a city, then shall show
All Israel to bring up ropes
To that city, stayed without hopes,
And we shall draw it in the vale
Until no stone’s left in its pale.”
14 And Absalom and all the men
Of Israel said “Word again
Of Husai the Archite is best,
Better than Ahithophel’s quest.”
For YHWH had ordained the defeat
Of Ahithophel’s advice meet,
So that YHWH might bring to the feet
Of Absalom a foul retreat.

Beloved, advisers all seem to relate
According to their privilege of state.
Bias and education fit the bill
To find a chair upon Capitol Hill.

One speaks for peace, or at least just to
take
Saddam alone and let the others make
A reconciliation for Your sake.
The other speaks for war in his deceit
To work toward fiend Absalom's defeat.
The hawk and dove were not invented by
Americans to rule a newborn sky,
But always had a place, one traitor and
The other a foul bane upon the land.
Beloved, preserve me from advisers' hand.

15 Then said Hushai to Zadok and
To Abiathar, priests that stand,
"Such and such is the advice of
Ahitophel who's hand in glove
With Absalom and Israel's great,
And such and such in counsel's rate
I have advised them in the state.

16 "Now therefore send quickly and tell
David, saying 'Tonight don't dwell
In the plains of the wilderness,
But in any case in duress
Cross over, lest the king be lost
And all the people with him tossed.'"

17 Now Jonathan and Ahimaaz
Stayed by En-rogel for the pause,
They might not be seen come to tell
But a girl came and told the spell,
And they to king David as well.

18 But a young man saw them and told
Absalom, and they both went bold
Quickly away and came where stood
One's house come from Bahurim's wood,
Who had a well in his courtyard,
And they went down into it hard.

19 And the woman then took and spread
The covering over the dread
Well's mouth, and spread out grain on it,
And the thing was not known a bit.

20 And Absalom's servants then came
To the woman in her own claim,
And asked, "'Where are Ahimaaz and
Jonathan?'" And the wench at hand
Said to them, "They have gone a way
Beyond the water-brook to stay."
And when they looked and could not find
They returned to Jerusalem.

21 It happened then when left behind
They came up out of the well's hem,
And went and told king David, and
They said to David, "Take command

To get up and pass quickly by
The water, for so says the spy
Ahitophel counselled to try.

To save life two men risked their own and
went

By the well and the brook and then they
sent

David and his across the waters spent.
The dark night and its flood may make the
use

Of lying and of subterfuge abuse
Or righteous deed. I think the law is clear
Only upon divinely guided ear.

Beloved, I sit me quiet in the town
And look at treachery and with a frown
Upon my senseless brow I lift no hand
Against the legal and the contraband.
I am for David and for David's son
In ancient times, but now that day is done
I wait to see You in the battle won.

22 And David got up and the folk,
All those with him to the last bloke,
And they passed over Jordan's stream
Until the morning dawn light's gleam,
And there was not one missing there
Who did not pass the Jordan fair.

23 And when Ahitophel saw that
His advice was not followed at
The court, he saddled up his ass,
And got up and went home *in class*
To his own city and he set
His house in order, and *in fret*
He strangled himself and he died,
Was buried by his father's side.

24 When David came to Mahanaim,
Absalom passed Jordan *self-same*,
He and all Israel's men of fame.

25 Absalom made Amasa chief
Of the army, and not Joab.
And Amasa was son *not drab*
Of a man whose name for relief
Was Ithra of Jezreel, who went
In to Abigail daughter sent
Of Nahash, she was sister to
Zeruiah, Joab's mom too.

26 So Israel and Absalom camped
In Gilead's land *where they revamped*.

27 It happened when David came to
Mahanaim, that Shobi son of
Nahash of Rabbah who was of

The folk of Ammon, and Machir
 Son of Amiel of Lo-debar,
 And Barzillai the Gileadite
 Come from Rogelim *and in sight*,
 28 Brought beds and basins, earthen jars,
 And wheat, barley and meal *cars*
 And parched corn, beans and lentils too
 And parched pulse, everything *in view*,
 29 And honey, cords, and sheep and cheese
 Of cows' milk for both David's ease
 And of the people with him too.
 For they said "The folk, *we can guess*,
 Are hungry in the wilderness
 And faint and thirsty *from distress*.

Beloved, I've fled the patterned and the
 grand,
 The worn street and the halls at every hand,
 And sought a refuge in the wilderness
 Where Your hand's welcome to one in
 distress.
 I've backed away, out, out Jerusalem,
 I've crossed the Jordan at the desert's hem,
 Passed Jericho where once the victory
 Lighted the sky, and Rahab was set free.
 Back, back from mountains gained with
 blood and sweat
 To find myself a wanderer and yet
 The desert of the Sinai, its bad stones
 That tumble feet and twist the ankle bones,
 Are my solace. And yet when least
 expected
 Your angels smooth my way delights
 confected.

2 Samuel 18

1 And David counted all the folk
 That were with him and set in stroke
 Over them captains of thousands,
 And captains of hundreds of hands.
 2 David sent the people to fight,
 A third under Joab's delight,
 A third under Abishai's hand,
 The son of Zeruiah and
 Joab's brother, and a third band
 By Ittai the Gittite's command.
 And David told the folk, "I too
 Will certainly go out with you."
 3 And they said "You will not go out.
 For if we flee, they will not care,
 Nor if half of us die out there,
 But you are worth ten thousand of

Us, so it's better in the shove
 For you to stay in town to help."
 4 And the king told them, "As you yelp,
 So I will do." And the king stood
 Beside the gate as the knighthood
 Went by in hundreds and in bands
 Of thousands *at the king's commands*.
 5 The king commanded Joab and
 Abishai and Ittai at hand
 Saying "Deal gently for my sake
 With the lad Absalom at stake."
 And all the folk heard when the king
 Gave the chiefs charge about the thing.
 6 And all the people went out in
 The wood against Israel to win,
 And the battle was in the wood
 Of Ephraim *where the trees stood*.
 7 And Israel's folk fell down before
 David's servants and men of war,
 And there was a great slaughter there
 That day of twenty thousand fair.

Since when is a king worth ten thousand
 men?
 Where did that thought come from to grace
 again
 The human brow with courage false and
 neat?
 Kings are not worth the lowest servant's
 feet.
 David is worth, instead, more than the race
 Of all humans born in this awful place,
 For having Your heart, my Beloved, to
 speak
 Always the counterview of those who seek.
 His worth as perfect man includes all men,
 But worth as king is below counsel then.
 The rabble always loves the purple robe
 Everywhere on the brightly diurnal globe.
 But I choose David's woollen cloak to
 wear
 As I step out to whirl in glory there.

8 The battle spread on the surface
 Of all the country and the place,
 While the forest killed more that day
 Than all the sword once drawn could slay.
 9 And Absalom chanced then to meet
 With David's servants *in the street*.
 And Absalom rode on a mule,
 And the mule came under the cool
 Of the thick branches of an oak

Or a great terebinth to choke,
And his head got entangled in
The oak, and he was hung like sin
Between the earth and sky, the mule
Rode out from under him *to school*.

Strange luck it was the forest killed more
men
Than could the sword when wielded with a
yen.

Those used to fighting in battle array
Upon a level plain in light of day
Are lost when taken to the wood to find
The daring of the trees that are not kind.
My fathers sought the forest like a fort
And fought the English drawn up as in
court

From frond and trunk and saving branch
and leaf

To bring the invaders to harm and grief.
For one the forest is a refuge tight,
The other finds its buggers in the night.
Beloved, I flee to You from arid plain
And from the darkened forest in the rain.

10 And one who saw it told Joab,
And said "Look I saw in confab
Absalom hanging in an oak."
11 And Joab told the one who saw,
"See, you saw it, why did your paw
Not strike him down there to the ground?
I'd have given you shekels sound
In number ten and a belt round."

12 And the man said to Joab then,
"Though you should give a thousand yen,
I still would not stretch out my hand
Against the king's son, for command
Of the king to you, Abishai
And Ittai rings in ear to say
'Take care not to hurt any way
The young man Absalom today.'
13 "If I had falsely acted to
Destroy my own life, and the due
Is never hidden from the king,
Then you yourself, no questioning,
Would have stood aside from my fate."

14 And Joab said "I shall be late."
And he took three darts in his hand,
And thrust them through the heart
unmanned
Of Absalom while still alive
In the midst of the oak to jive.

Though Joab saves the kingdom with a will
And three darts sharp and fit to meet the
bill,

He will need great diplomacy to save
His own life and loyalty from the grave.
Give me the loyalty of that brave man
Who refused to touch hair nor hide nor
plan

Of the king's son, and give me yet the
might

And courage of Joab to take the blight
And cast the dart through the heart that
avails

Of popularity to fill the sails
Of rebellion against Your faith and law.
Beloved, I see the battle plan with awe
And know that You stand over king and
son.

Give me obedience when all is done.

15 And ten young men who carried bound
Joab's armour gathered around
Attacked Absalom, struck him down.

16 And Joab blew the horn renown,
And the folk turned back from the spoil
Following Israel, in his coil
Joab held all the people back.

17 And they took Absalom to stack
Into the great pit in the wood,
And there erected as they could
A great pile of stone monument,
And Israel fled each to his tent.

18 Now Absalom in his life time
Had taken and set up to chime
For himself a pillar which stands
In the king's dale by his commands
When he said "I've no son to keep
My name remembered", so the heap
He called after his own name there,
To this day it remains to share
Absalom's name remembered there.

I have no monument in stone nor do
I have a monument in sons untrue,
My name is not remembered like the leaf
Of Absalom whose father came to grief.
The pillar that I set is everywhere
The stony forest floor rises to bear
The rustle and the echo of Your name:
Beloved, You and You only are my fame.

Some come to weep and sing in the king's
dale,
Some come to rejoice and some come to
wail,
But I whirl in the round of here and now
And take no pilgrimage to granite how.
Beloved, no monument is greater than
The whisper of Your name where I began.

19 Then Ahimaaz son of Zadok
Said "Let me run now with the stock
Of good news for the king, how YHWH
Has avenged him of his foe's crew."
20 And Joab said to him, "You'll not
Bear the news of this day in plot,
But bear the news another day,
But this day shall have no news' way,
Since it's the king's son dead astray."
21 And Joab said to the Cushite,
"Go tell the king what's in your sight."
And the Cushite bowed down before
Joab, and ran. 22 Ahimaaz
Son of Zadok spoke up with snazz
To Joab once more, "Come what may,
Let me run too, I beg and pray."
And Joab said "Why should you run,
My son? Hear you've no news begun,
Nor is there profit if you run?"
23 And he said "Why should I not run?"
And Joab told him, "Run *for fun*."
And Ahimaaz ran by the way
Of the plain and passed Cushite's stay.

Who has the lighter message runs with feet
Pounding upon the ground in motion fleet.
Who has the heavy word runs slower still,
And meets the flag with sorrow on the hill.
Beloved, I am at age that I find no
Pleasure in running, my feet are so slow
That Joab would have sent me as his
choice

And left David a day more to rejoice.
The bad news is the news that's never late,
And good news only comes to dissipate
With the brief mist of morning at the gate.
Beloved, give me no news at all and I
Shall be content in wilderness to lie
Where breezes whisper nothing to the sky.

24 Now David sat between two gates,
Below where on the roof awaits
The watchman of the gate and wall,

And raised his eyes, looked *toward the
brawl*,

And saw a lone man run withal.
25 And the watchman cried out to say
To the king what he saw that way,
And the king said "If he's alone,
The news he brings is good *as grown*.
And the man came and he arrived.
26 And the watchman saw there contrived
Another man to run, and so
The watchman cried at the gate's row
To say "See, there's another man
Running alone." And the king's scan
Was to say "He also brings news
Of gladness *from the army crews*."
27 And the watchman said "I think now
The first man's running is somehow
Like that of Ahimaaz the son
Of Zadok *when his running's done*."
And the king said "He's a good man,
And comes with good news *of the span*."

Wise Joab chose a stranger, man of Cush,
To bring the sad news without vim or rush.
The watcher saw Zadok's son, the young
priest,
And so the king thought the news good at
least.
The messenger embodies the news
brought,
And no one listens to foreigner's plot
With happiness, the very tongue is stiff
To say the words accented with an if.
The news was blurred by the young man's
accord
To take to David wonderings of sword.
I am a stranger to all men who stand
Upon the polished paving of this land,
And though my word is good, their ears
can hear
Only the echoes of their own dark fear.

28 And Ahimaaz called to the king
And said "All's well" and then bowing
Down before the king with his face
To the earth, said "Blessed be YHWH's
grace
And your Alohim, who has set
To destruction the men that yet
Lifted up hand against my lord
The king *and raised the fatal sword*."
29 And the king said "Does it go well

With the lad Absalom, do tell?"
 And Ahimaaz answered, "When he
 Joab sent the king's servant, see
 And me your servant, I saw there
 A great tumult up in the air
 But I did not know what it meant."
 30 And the king said "Just stand aside
 Right here, and wait." And so he tried
 And stood there. 31 And see then came up
 The Cushite, and the Cushite's cup
 Was, "Good news for my lord the king,
 For YHWH has avenged you to sing
 This day over all those who rose
 Against you *and all as such chose.*"
 32 And then the king asked the Cushite,
 "Is the young Absalom all right?"
 And the Cushite said "May the foes
 Of my lord the king in their throes
 And all who's risen up to do
 Evil against him, be in crew
 As is that young man in his due."
 33 And the king was troubled and moved,
 Went to the room above the gate,
 And wept, and as without abate
 He walked, he said as one reproved,
 "My son Absalom, O my son!
 Would I had died and you had won,
 O Absalom, my son, my son!"

David would die in place of Absalom,
 Then why did he not provide for the sum
 Before it came to battle and to pitch
 The many souls that fought him in the
 ditch?
 Even when kingdom of the world is joined
 To that of heaven, the golden mint is
 coined
 To treachery, so what can now be said
 When men who do not know You can be
 led
 Into the battle zone with screeching car?
 The world in ten thousand years has gone
 far
 To reach the same place in its wandering.
 Beloved, I may still have a voice to sing,
 But my clear eye sees that the government
 Can never be one of the ones You sent.

2 Samuel 19

1 And it was told Joab, "See here,
 The king is weeping at the bier
 Of Absalom." 2 The victory

That day was turned to tragedy
 As all the people mourned, the folk
 Heard spoken that day, "The king woke
 To grieve for his son." 3 And the folk
 Came quietly into the town
 As folk ashamed to walk the down
 When fleeing from the battle's *frown*.
 4 And the king covered up his face,
 And the king cried aloud in place,
 "O my son Absalom undone,
 O Absalom, my son, my son!"
 5 And Joab went in to the king,
 Into his house and said a thing,
 "You have today shamed every face
 Of your servants, who in the race
 Today have saved your life and those
 Lives that your sons and daughters chose,
 And the lives of your wives, the lives
 Of your concubines *in their hives*,
 6 "In that you love those who hate you,
 And hate those ones who have loved you.
 For you've declared today that all
 The princes and servants in stall
 Are nothing to you, for this day
 I notice that if in his way
 Absalom had lived and all we
 Had died today you certainly
 Would have been pleased. 7 Now get up,
 go
 And speak to the heart of your show
 Of servants, for I swear by YHWH,
 If you do not go out as true,
 Not a man will stay here with you
 This night, and that it will be worse
 To you than any other curse
 That has fallen on you from time
 Of youth till now, *I can show sign.*"

The truth is Joab's heart led to rebel,
 And he it was who ready not to quell
 Disturbance would have taken David's
 throne
 Except that You, O my Beloved, had
 known
 To stem the tide of evil in the heart.
 You came alone to take David's throne's
 part.
 Joab should soon have reigned upon the
 hill
 Of Zion with a firm and ready will.
 So every priest and general in town
 Is ready to rebel against Your crown.

That's why, Beloved, the darkened wave is
still
Looming upon horizons fit to kill.
Beloved, let crown and crosier fall before
The brightness of new heaven's open door.

8 Then the king got up and sat down
In the gate, and all in the town
Reported, saying "See, the king
Is sitting in the town gate's wing."
And all the people came before
The king. For Israel in store
Had fled each man to his own tent.
9 And all the folk about that went
Among all Israel's tribes then said
"The king saved us from enemy,
And from the Philistine's hand's spree,
But now he's fled out of the land
Before Absalom and his hand.

10 "And Absalom whom we anointed
Over us, is dead and unjointed
In battle. Now therefore why do
You not speak a word to the crew
To bring the king back in his due?"

11 And king David sent to Zadok
And to Abiathar the stock
Of priests, saying "Talk to the old
Men of Judah, saying 'Unfold
Why you are the last to bring back
The king to his house without lack?
For all of Israel speak up for
The return of the king to shore
And to his house to bring once more.

12 'You are my brothers, you're my bond
And my flesh, so why are you stoned
To be last to bring back the king?

13 'And say to Amasa, "Are you
Not my bone and my flesh to do,
God do to me and more also,
If you shall not be chief in stow
Of the army before me now
And always in Joab's first row."'"

14 He bowed the heart of Judah's men
All as one man, so they again
Sent to the king, and said "Return,
And all are your servants astern."

See here, Beloved, David himself removed
To speak in the ears of some men who
proved
Loyal to bring him back to throne and
grace.

The kingdom cannot depend on Your face.
It takes a whisper here, and word there too
To bring a king his fulsome glory due.
The stars that glitter now glitter because
They work incessantly with dirty claws
To scrape up from the rabble bold applause
And not because they follow noble laws.
Beloved, the mass and movement of
earth's woe
Is due to men and women making show,
While You stand still on silent Sinai's
brow
Without a single listener in tow.

15 And the king came back and came near
As far as Jordan. And came here
Judah to Gilgal and to meet
The king, to bring the king on feet
Over the Jordan *to his seat*.

Along the ways of wilderness and sun
Like glistening rivers shining on the run,
Against the rocky roadways single file
How do the royal parties stretch a mile!
Before the blood of Absalom is cold
I see the courtiers bowing to the bold
Royal diadem and shout their acclaim.
David is to be brought to town with fame.
Into the little lanes that laughed and cried
Yesterday before Absalom had died
Each caravan rides on the joyous tide
Revealed by sun, revealed by regal pride.
Ever the mote of power and will of man
Knows light better than love of son now
can.

16 Then Shimei son of Gera who
Was the Benjamite in the crew,
Who was of Bahurim, came too
In haste down with Judah's men to
Meet king David *and give him due*.
17 And there were a thousand men that
Came of Benjamin where he sat,
And Ziba servant of Saul's house,
And his fifteen sons and the grouse
Of twenty servants with him too.
And they ran in the Jordan there
Before the king *to show their share*.
18 And the ferry passed back and forth
To bring over the king's whole court,
And to do what he thought was good.
And Shimei son of Gera stood

And fell down before the king there
When he had crossed the Jordan's *glare*.

19 And he said to the king, "Let not
My lord hold a grudge for my lot,
Neither remember what your slave
Did in his wickedness to rave
The day my lord the king went out
Of Jerusalem with a shout,
That the king take it to his heart.
20 "For your servant knows that his part
Was sinful, and see, here today
I've come before all Israel's sway
And Joseph's house to go down and
Meet my lord the king *where I stand*."

21 But Abishai Zeruiah's son
Answered and said when he'd begun,
"Shall not Shimei be put to death
For this because with all his breath
He cursed YHWH's anointed when done?"

When the king's in the dust the rebels rise
To curse him with tongue as well as with
eyes.

When he returns in honour, then their due
Is to come to sue for forgiveness' stew.
Sin is not to condemn the man that's down,
Oh no, it's to meet with portentous frown
The one who has the power to wield the
sword.

When sword exists it defines who is lord.
Beloved, You who have no sword in Your
hand
Stand without honour in a Christian land.
But let You once appear on judgement day,
Then those who now curse shall see the
right way.

The brilliance of a heavy hand alone
Will make the rabble bow before a throne.

22 And David said "What do I do
With you, Zeruiah's sons to stew,
That you should be today as foes
To me? Shall any man of those
In Israel today lose his life?
For I do not know in my strife
If I'm the king of Israel's folk."
23 And so to Shimei the king spoke,
"You shall not die" and so he swore
The king did to him *all the more*.

I note, Beloved, that David's clemency
Depended on the fact the royal see

Was simply not well founded and he could
Not be sure that an execution would
Not stir up Israel to renewed fighting.
Virtue's dependent on one's perfect
lighting.

Shimei is safe because the throne is not,
And that is all there is to virtue's plot.
Beloved, I too bow to the brassy rate
Of circumstance before the earthly gate.
I ignore hands of power and laws of state
Not because of some justice in the mate,
But simply because Sinai's glory still
Surrounds the makings of my martyr's hill.

24 Mephibosheth Saul's son's son went
Down to meet the king from his tent,
And had not put on shoe nor trimmed
His beard, nor washed his clothes
unrimmed,

From the day that the king went out
Till the day he came back with shout
Of peace *for everyone about*.

25 It happened when he went into
Jerusalem to meet as due
The king, the king said to him true,
"Why did you not go out with me,
Mephibosheth?" 26 He answered him,
"My lord King, my servant was grim
Deceiving me, for your servant
Said 'I will saddle an ass *scant*
To ride upon and join the king'
Because your servant's lame in wing,
27 "And he has acted with deceit
With your servant to my lord's seat
And to the king, but my lord king
Is as angel of Alohim,
So do what's good in your own eyes.
28 "For all my father's house in guise
Were as dead by my lord king's hand,
Yet you set your servant in band
Of them who eat at the king's board.
What rights do I have now to hoard?
Or why should I make any plaint
Before my lord the king and saint?"

When Charles and Napoleon have returned
In triumph to the capitol once burned,
Out of the woodwork crawl the feeble mice
To tell them all along they thought them
nice.

It was deceit that carried word abroad
That they had failed in loyalty and laud.

It was deceit that turned their reputation
 To peaceful survival for occupation.
 When fighting stops and laurels can be
 won
 For mere applause and flattery begun
 Instead of bleeding underneath the sun,
 Then multitudes appear to give a hand
 To help to steer the carriage in the sand,
 And take an honoured seat above the land.

29 And the king said to him, "Why now
 Do you speak any longer how
 Your matters go? I've made the choice,
 You and Ziba both shall rejoice
 To divide up the property.
 30 "Mephibosheth spoke to make free
 With the king, 'Let him take the lot,
 It's enough for me that the king
 Has come back in peace to the spring
 Of his own house instead of not.'"

Gone are the compromises. David hopes
 Only to be left in peace, faintly gropes
 Doubtful solutions to reward the few
 Innocent for loyalty in a crew
 Sabotaged by infiltration, the cream
 Of Jerusalem out to make their dream
 Next to paradise. The true owner's lot
 Extends to bribes and promises once
 bought
 Out of the dust in mist of the unreal.
 None could foresee returning would be
 steel.
 Except them all from punishment and let
 Good people share the property once set.
 O my Beloved, I see the heart gone out,
 Doubt and unrest return from faded shout.

31 Barzillai the Gileadite
 Came down from Rogelim in sight,
 And he passed on to Jordan's stream
 With the king, to bring it would seem
 Him on the way over Jordan.
 32 And Barzillai was an old man,
 Eighty years old, and he had given
 The king nourishment when he'd striven
 In Mahanaim, for he was great,
 A wealthy man and one of state.
 33 And the king said to Barzillai,
 "Come over with me on the sly,
 And I will keep you with me in
 Jerusalem in stall and bin."

34 And Barzillai answered the king,
 "How many are my days of spring
 Left in my life, that I should go
 Now with the king to see the show
 In the town of Jerusalem?
 35 "Today I'm living on *the hem*
Of eighty years, can I distinguish
 Between the good, or bad extinguish?
 Can your servant taste any more
 What I eat or drink *of the store*?
 Can I still hear the voice of those
 Who sing of men or girls *in rows*?
 So why should your servant now be
 Any longer burden in fee
 To my lord the king *on his toes*?
 36 "Your servant will just go a way
 Over the Jordan in the sway
 Of the king, and why should the king
 Reward me for so small a thing?
 37 "Let your servant please turn back then
 So I may die among the men
 Of my own town, beside the tomb
 Of my father, in mother's *room*.
 But here's your servant Chimham who
 Shall go over with my lord *true*
 The king, so do for him as you
 Think best *that a king ought to do*."

I too have reached the age when laurels
 mean
 Nothing or almost nothing on my scene.
 I may have striven for applause of men
 In callow youth (who does avoid it then?),
 But see death looming close upon my sky,
 And understand that praise can never vie
 With peace and quiet where I wait to die.
 I speak with Barzillai. Let younger make
 Their mark and set a banner at the stake
 Of tent, and build a pillar set in stone.
 I find my glory in Your name alone.
 I die from breath to breath, and with each
 huu
 That cools my tongue I turn towards Your
 throne
 And glorify with my brief being You.

38 And the king answered, "Chimham
 shall
 Go over the alluvial
 With me, and I'll do for him what
 My eye finds good *to grow his gut*,
 But whatever you want from me

I'll do it for you *faithfully*."

39 And all the folk went over Jordan,
And the king went over at fording,
And the king kissed Barzillai and
Blessed him, he returned to his land.

As I turn back from Your kingdom,
Beloved,
Before the rise beyond the Jordan-gloved
Cascade, to go back to my every-day
Duties in work and rhyme along the way,
Expecting with an upturned face my due,
Frank kisses from Your lips, please bless
me too.

Guise of Barzillai and David does not
Have any meaning for our passion caught.
I still expect the royal treatment here
Just as David kissed Barzillai on ear.
Known to all men is Your beloved name,
Like cloud in sunny sky shines out Your
fame,
More need I not come to Zion and throne,
Now find You at my exile's fir and stone.

40 So the king went on to Gilgal
And Chimham went along *for sal*,
And all the folk of Judah went
Along with the king and half spent
Of the folk of Israel's consent.

41 And see, all the men of Israel
Came to the king and for a while
Said to the king, "Why have the men
Our brothers of Judah *in den*
Stolen you away and to bring
The king and his house, everything,
Over the Jordan, and the men
All of David *into the glen*?"

42 And all Judah's men answered then
The men of Israel, "Since the king
Is a near relative in wing
And feather to us, why then are
You angry for this singular?
Have we eaten from the king's store?
Or has he given us something more?"

43 And Israel's men answered the men
Of Judah, and said *once again*,
"We have ten parts of the king, and
We are your seniors in the land,
Our portion in David is more
Than yours, and so why do you pour
Insult on us, that our advice
Should not be first in the device

To bring back David to be king?"
But the words of Judah's men were
Fiercer than Israel's men *to stir*.

Manipulation of the parts of king
Is a new trend in political ring.
Ten parts are more than one indeed, yet
blood
Sings in the ears of all men in the mud
Of power. I think that too is but the tool
Of those who know whom to play at the
fool.

The king with German accent on the throne
Of Britain is a thing one can't condone,
And yet the market may require the switch
From Latin, French to German at the pitch.
Now all are speaking English with a
vengeance
As though no other fuel could run their
engines.

Even I turn to tongue and relative
As I speak to You, Beloved, where I live.

2 Samuel 20

1 And there happened to be a base
Fellow called Sheba in the place,
The son of Bichri, Benjamite,
And he blew the horn, said for spite,
"We have no portion in the plot
Of David, nor have we a lot
Inherited in Jesse's son,
Every Israel's man to his gun."

That's what I just said, my Beloved, and
see

The Benjamite arises to be free
Of Bethlehem and those born in the plot
Of Jesse for the common human lot.
For Jesse has a closet full of bones,
Those foreign women that appeared like
drones.

The international is secret fate,
But those who grasp the reins will not be
late.

Beloved, I am no son of Bich or Ben,
I have no race to run, I have no yen,
But I look up to Sheba as the pact
At the well where You once came down to
act.

That prophecy of water in the load
Of kingly machinations is my goad.

2 So all the men of Israel went
Up from following David's tent,
And followed Sheba, Bichri's son,
But Judah's men were loyal still
To David their king from the hill
Of Jerusalem to the run
Of Jordan *flowing under sun*.

David, unlike my Moses, has a bent
To charisma, and attracts men who went
In loyalty after him to the spade
And to the ditch when robber had waylaid.
But even charisma cannot last long
When there are other interests in the
throng.

All power on earth must meet the breaking
point
And that comes sooner than the smoking
joint.

Beloved, all men follow Sheba to find
The Vatican where he sits is not blind,
Nor Canterbury hardly off the map,
And so they rush to wallow in his lap.
I run to You alone, Beloved, to get
Acquittal from Your judgement hardly set.

In days of David some men were inclined
To follow Bichri's son after they'd dined
In David's tents to enjoy life and health
And benefit by the king's greater wealth.
In days of Ali some men found the way
To fair apostasy under the sway
Of Bichri's father, while the family crew
Anointed the sent one with tears and dew.
Beloved, keep me from both father and son
Of Bichri as I lay my prayers undone,
And though I may not curse here anyone
For policy of inclination taught,
I bless the name of Ali in my plot,
Forgetting camel kin as like as not.

3 And David came into his house
At Jerusalem *not the grouse*,
And the king took the ten women,
His concubines left in the den
To keep the house when he had gone,
And put them in ward and upon
Provisions from him, but did not
Go in to them. So they were got
Shut up till the day of their death
In widowhood *by Ashtoreth*.

The punishment for female uncleanness
Is hard, and that's a thing I do confess.
The same goes on today in Arab court
When a man finds his wife too short of
sport.

She's shut up in a pen without relief
Of light and hope to die quickly in brief.
David Your king once instituted this
And so the practice has become abyss.
Beloved, I wonder that You do not come
To intervene when Your appointed bum
Establishes atrocious things from hell.
You hardly seem to hear the ringing bell
Of women's prayers arising from the heat
Or cold that weighs upon inactive feet.

4 Then said the king to Amasa,
"Call me all the men of Judah
In three days, and come here yourself."

5 And Amasa went *like an elf*
To call Judah's men in a group,
But he stayed longer than the scoop
Appointed for him. 6 David said
To Abishai, "Will we be led
Into more trouble by the hand
Of Sheba Bichri's son than stand
In harm from Absalom? Take your
Lord's servants and ambassador
Pursue him, lest he get him in
Fortified cities and in bin
Escape from us and out of sight."

7 And there went with him Joab's men,
The Cherethites and in the glen
The Pelethites, and all the men
Of might, and all of them went out
Of Jerusalem with a shout
To pursue Sheba, Bichri's son.

Pre-emptive force was not invented late
To say a word on the Iraqis fate.
It's been around at least since Sheba's rate
On plains of Palestine and took the road
To refuge in fortified town's abode.
So Abishai receives the king's command
To cut him off from gaining upper hand
Before he causes grief more in that land
Than Absalom did with his hair in band.
Beloved, I hear the kingly word and song,
I see the man ride out among the strong,
And yet I cling to Your ten words alone
And call the democratic day a throne

That comes to rest on all men without
stone.

8 When they came to the great stone won
In Gibeon, Amasa came
To meet them. And Joab *for blame*
Was dressed for battle with a sword
Fastened on a belt and a cord
Around his waist and in its sheath,
As he went out it fell beneath.
9 And Joab said to Amasa,
“How are you, brother, in the way?”
And Joab took Amasa by
The beard with his right hand apply
To kiss him. 10 But Amasa took
No heed of the sword in *the crook*
Of Joab’s hand, so he struck him
There in the groin, and spilled out *grim*
His guts on the ground, but he did
Not strike him again *on the lid*,
And so he died there *on the skid*.
11 And there stood by him a young man
Of Joab’s servants, and *by plan*
He said “Whoever is in hand
Of Joab, and in David’s band,
Follow Joab!” 12 And Amasa
Lay wallowing in his blood’s clay,
In the middle of the highway.
One saw that all the folk stood still,
And he took Amasa from grill
Out of the path into a field,
And covered with a coat for shield,
Because he saw that every man
That came up to him for a scan
Stood still. 13 When he was taken off
The highway, all the folk *with scoff*
Went on after Joab to find
Sheba, son of Bichri, in blind.

The Bible’s just the story of how all
Men in the past tried or tried not to fall
Beneath the simple command of Your law
Once promised on Mount Sinai and in awe.
The bloody way of men takes little from
The way You once presented and in sum.
The competition of great men will find
Outlet in some abuse and in some kind
Will surely kill the other rather than
Stand aside in the field as husbandman.
Beloved, few follow on the righteous way
Because the interest of kings holds the
sway.

Relieve me of such hopes and feeble fear
And let me humbly walk where You may
steer.

14 And he went through all Israel’s tribes
To Abel, to Beth-maacah’s ribes,
And all the Berites, and they came
Together and went without shame
In also after him the same.
15 They came and laid siege on him there
In Abel of Bethmaacah’s share,
And they threw up a mound of earth
Against the city in its girth
Standing in the moat, all the folk
That were with Joab gave a poke
To the wall there to throw it down.
16 A wise woman cried from the town,
“Hear, hear, say, I beg you, to say
To Joab, ‘Come near here, I pray,
So I can have a word with you.’ ”

The churches and the synagogues that trace
The way to faith as well as mosques in race
With every heathen temple in the place
Today set women back seat without mace.
Indeed, the priestess may sometimes arise
In Baptist, Anglican and Luther’s guise,
But where a woman wields the crosier
now,
It shows the church lost power anyhow.
In ancient times there may have been the
priest
As male upon the sacrificial beast,
But there was also the wise woman’s state,
The office long forgotten in the rate.
Note generals bow to her wisdom’s word,
Too bad such people now are a rare bird.

18 And she spoke saying “In old time
They used to say ‘They’ll take a rhyme
Of counsel in Abel as due’
And so end the matter in crew.
19 “We are of peaceful folk and yet
Faithful in Israel, and set
You about to destroy a town
And mother in Israel’s renown?
Why will you swallow up the lot
Of YHWH’s inheritance and plot?”
20 And Joab answered and he said
“Far be it, far be from me led,
That I should swallow or destroy.
21 “It is not so, but one’s employ

Is a man of Ephraim hill land,
Sheba, Bichri's son, by name scanned,
This one has lifted up his hand
Against the king David. Give me
Only him, I'll leave the city."
And so the woman told Joab,
"See, his head shall be *with confab*
Thrown to you over the wall's slab."

Ah where there's power, even in a
woman's hand
There is the right to sever head and hand.
One does not flee from violence when one
Flees from the male to female sceptre's
fun.
She promises what hardly man would dare
To do in handing up the good and fair.
And without batting long eyelash or care
She folds the hero in his shrouding share.
She saved the city from the gushing blood
That was in Joab's hand and in the bud.
Who knows but what she saved the seed at
last
That will put all things right once the die's
cast.
Beloved, behind the killing and the craze
I see You still the Sovereign over days.

22 So the woman went in to all
The people with her wisdom's call,
And they cut off Sheba's head, son's
Of Bichri, and threw out what stuns
To Joab, and he blew the horn,
And they dispersed from the town torn
And went each one to his own tent.
Joab to Jerusalem went
Back to the king *who was content*.

It is expedient that one man die
To save the nation or a world awry.
The voice of Mary Magdalene or yet
Some other Mary sufficed not to set
Your Christ at liberty. In ancient time
A woman had a voice a man could climb.
Beloved, I watch the people in dispersion
Each to his tent, none looking with
aversion
At bloody bodies fallen by the wall.
The fattened calf is still safe in the stall,
Why worry if a man with vision's caught
And quartered to save the town's wealth
and plot?

I have a vision too, but I sit tight
Beneath my mountain without woman's
fright.

23 And Joab was the chief of all
The army at Israel's call,
Benaiah Jehoiada's son
Was over the Cherethites' gun
And over Pelethites *when done*.
24 And Adoram was tribute's chief,
Jehoshaphat son for relief
Of Ahilud recorder's leaf.
25 And Sheva was the scribe, the men
Zadok and Abiathar then
Were priests, 26 and Ira the Jairite
Also was prime minister right
To David, *all in David's ken*.

The ministers of David all in state,
I wonder how many are innocent.
Joab has killed in war, but also sent
In peace with cunning many to their fate.
Adoram, was he honest in the rate
Of tribute and taxes the people lent
To David and the realm, in where he went
Did he not have his favoured soon and
late?

Beloved, like scribe and priest, I hear the
call
To write a note to You, my love and praise,
And give account for my unloving heart.
With pen paused, I lift soul against the wall
And question her on how she spent her
days
And whether peace or venom's on the dart.

2 Samuel 21

1 And there was famine in the days
Of David three years through their ways,
And David sought the face of YHWH.
And YHWH said "It is for Saul's due,
And for his bloody house, because
He killed the Gibeonites *for straws*."

Whether the sin was treachery or murder,
How do You, my Beloved, find sense in
this
Confirming that the fault of famine's kiss
Is in what Saul did in the land to herd her?
How does the fact the lovely rain's not
stirred her
To production of corn on the abyss

Of hunger depend on the hit or miss
Of king or prince or worker on the girder?
So Saul killed Gibeonites, that act indeed
Was tragic and misplaced from where he
sat.

The cause-effect relation in the brain
Of humankind grows and blooms like a
weed.

My human, existentialist fiat
Suspects David heard voices from the
strain.

2 The king called the Gibeonites and
Said to them, (now Gibeonite band
Were not of Israel's folk, but they
Were remnants of Amorite day,
And Israel's folk had sworn to them,
And Saul tried to kill all of them
In his zeal for Israel's folk's band
And for Judah upon the land.)

3 And David said to Gibeonites,
"What shall I do to set your rights?
And how shall I make atonement,
So you may bless YHWH's lot unspent?"

4 The Gibeonites told him, "It is
No matter of silver or fizz
Of gold between us and twist Saul,
Or his house, neither have we call
To put any man to death in
Israel." And he said "To begin
What should I do for you *for sin*?"

5 And they said to the king, "The man
That destroyed us, devised the plan,
So that we've been kept from the land
Of Israel, 6 let seven men
Of his sons be delivered to
Us, and we'll hang them up to YHWH
In Gibeah of Saul anointed
Of YHWH." And the king said appointed
I will deliver them up *too*."

Some say atonement for another's sin
Escapes the law if innocence is slain.
Vain was not death of Christ, indeed not
vain,
Even if in his innocence he's thin.
None can say Saul's sons were then
lacking in

A grand display of wickedness or stain
To be the victims of atoning cane
Or stand before avenging carbine.

Now, my Beloved, I doubt the whipping
post
Enough to restore Gibeonite lives lost
Along the bloody Jordan's running sand.
Somehow I doubt effect of Hitler's boast
In prowling out with heinous holocaust,
Nor that Christ bleeding lends a helping
hand.

7 But the king spared Mephibosheth
The son of Jonathan the son
Of Saul, because of the oath done
Between them, between David and
Jonathan son of Saul at hand.

Who knows if David spared Mephibosheth
For love of Jonathan or love of vow?
I think the many years that passed in row
Stripped David of the love and of the
breath
Of an oath made before Jonathan's death.
Too much greed for the corn and oil and
cow
Has passed beneath the stomach anyhow.
It's politics that forms the shibboleth.
Time's here to tell, Beloved, if You spare
me

For love or treaty or the grace to show
A bright and burning lamp about the town.
It's far more like I'll meet mistrustingly
The lone death-bed where many people go
Without a word remembering or crown.

8 The king took two sons of Rizpah
The daughter of *the wife* Aiah,
Whom she bore to Saul, Armoni
And Mephibosheth, to deploy
Five sons of Michal daughter of
Saul, whom she bore as though for love
To Adriel who was the son
Of Barzillai Meholathite,

9 And he gave them when he'd begun
Into the hand of Gibeonite,
And they hanged them upon the hill
Before YHWH, and they fell until
All seven fell together, and
They were killed in the harvest days
In the first day and in the ways
Of the start of the barley harvest.

10 And Rizpah *as quickly as starvest*,
Daughter of Aiah took sackcloth,
And spread it for her on the rock

From start of harvest till the *wroth*
Of rain poured from the sky *in stock*,
 And did not let the birds that fly
 Rest on them as the days went by,
 Nor any beast of field by night.
 11 And it was told David what sight
 Rizpah daughter of Aiah did.
 12 And David went to where they hid
 The bones of Saul and took them all
 With Jonathan's bones, Saul's son's *tall*,
 From men of Jabesh-gilead,
 Who stole them from the plaza had
 In Beth-shan, where the Philistines
 Had hanged them in the day's declines
 When Philistines killed Saul upon
 Gilboa. 13 He brought from there drawn
 The bones of Saul as well as bones
 Of Jonathan his son with groans
 And they gathered the bones of them
 That were hanged *all up in the hem*.
 14 And they buried the bones of Saul
 And Jonathan his son from all
 The country of Benjamin in
 Zela, in sepulchre of kin,
 Of Kish his father, and they did
 All the king commanded for bid.

Perhaps it takes seven men to do right
 In sacrifice vicarious in the light
 Of ancient times, just as it took seven dips
 To heal Naaman and make worth all his
 trips.
 Now baptism is often done with just
 One dip in water running over dust
 Or in a quiet cistern, while it takes
 Just one Galgothan sacrifice that makes
 The cultic rite of atonement one square.
 Of course there were three on the cross that
 night,
 Just as some use the trine electrolyte.
 It seems the victims get more than their
 share.
 Beloved, I do not approve of the flight
 Into superstitious cosmopolite.

I haven't said enough, Beloved, on this
 Fatal tale, I bear yet a grudge amiss.
 The whole idea that one death or another
 Can set right any death of son of mother
 Is stupid, stupid, stupid on the brain.
 If You speak to humankind, say word sane.
 If You would atone for the loss, make gain

And raise up from the dead the noble slain.
 But don't mumble and curse and lay the
 blame
 On innocent witch in Salem or where
 The sons of Saul take shelter from the
 share
 Their father set to wrong in Gibeon's air.
 Beloved, open the eyes of faithful men
 To see reason instead of halogen.

15 And the Philistines warred again
 With Israel, and David's men
 Went down with him to fight the foe,
 The Philistines, David was slow.
 16 And Ishbibenob of the sons
 Of the giant upon his buns,
 The wight of whose spear done in tonnes
 Was three hundred shekels of brass
 In weight, and protecting his ass
 New armour, he intended thus
 To kill David *and make a fuss*.
 17 But Abishai Zeruiah's
 Son helped him and as such help does
 Struck down the Philistine for dead.
 Then David's men swore to him, said
 "You shall go out no more when led
 To battle lest you quench the lamp
 Of Israel in battle's damp."

There came a day when David was too old,
 Decrepit and could not do battle bold
 Without the risk of dying at the hand
 Of Philistine uncircumcised fire-brand.
 That's why his captains and his men
 allowed
 They would not see him more come out
 with crowd,
 But he should sit in palace on the throne
 And let the younger men risk life and bone.
 Beloved, I too approach the golden years
 When hair no longer brown it so appears
 Turns silver with the turning of the sun.
 My fighting days are now forever done.
 But I still bear the Philistine a grudge
 While I sit on my throne though do not
 budge.

18 And after this it happened so,
 That there was again war with foe
 Of Philistines at Gob, and there
 Sibbecai the Hushathite fair
 Killed Saph, who was one of the sons

Of the giant. 19 And *like the Huns*
 There was a fight with Philistines
 At Gob, and Elhanan the son
 Of Jaare-oregim whose signs
 Were Bethlehemite killed with done
 Goliath the Gittite, the staff
 Of whose spear was like a distaff,
 A weaver's beam. 20 And yet to laugh
 There was a battle pitched in Gath,
 Where there was a man tall in wrath,
 Who had six fingers on each hand,
 And six toes that both his feet spanned,
 Twenty-four in all, and he too
 Was born and of the giant's crew.
 21 And when he taunted Israel,
 Jonathan son of Shimea well
 David's brother killed him as well.
 22 These four were born to giants in
 Gath, and died and were put in bin
 By David's hand, and by the hand
 Of his servants *by his command*.

Beloved, I've killed no giants on the run
 Up from Gath under setting of the sun.
 I've set no dart upon the beating heart
 Of enemy, and yet I've done my part.
 Grave Milton said they also serve who
 stand,
 And while I often sit, I've not been canned
 From scribbling praises to Your name that
 sends
 The Philistine to judgement round the
 bends.
 Beloved, I rise to shout when all is lost
 To the uncircumcised and to their cost,
 I clap my hands in pleasure when the rude
 Are swept off aircraft carriers with the
 brood
 Of scorpions that lash out on poor, unwary.
 Beloved, when You succeed I'm the one
 merry.

2 Samuel 22 see Psalm 18

1 And David spoke to YHWH the word
 Of this song in the day occurred
 YHWH's salvation from every hand
 Of enemy and from Saul's *stand*.

Beloved, save me too from the hand of
 king
 And priest and pope and mullah on the
 string

Of those who lord the heart and mind and
 find
 Time to help greedy wardens in a bind.
 Beloved, save me from hand of looking
 glass
 That flatters idle lookers-on that pass
 For my own image where should only be
 The image of Creator and not me.
 Beloved save me from look and thought
 and love
 That short-change buyers on the mask and
 glove
 To fill the raucous air with promise of
 The coming satisfaction for the fleet.
 Beloved, save me from nothing in the
 street
 But rush to find me waiting where We
 meet.

2 And he said "YHWH's my rock and my
 Fortress and my Saviour when nigh.

Some say the word that David uses here
 When he calls You a rock and Saviour
 dear,
 Means that You are one and the same as
 Christ
 As though the human and divine when
 spliced
 Form God Almighty in a single dream.
 Beloved, though there's no I but You I
 deem
 That Creator and created are not
 To be confused no matter what the plot
 Of salvation or redemption I sought.
 Beloved, the heart is human on the vine
 And none can read the inner thought and
 sign.
 The lamp is flickering on the dampened
 stones
 That form the inner temple and the thrones,
 But dark corners are always filled with
 bones.

3 "The Alohim of my rock and
 In Him will I trust *where I stand*,
 My shield and my salvation's horn,
 My high tower and my refuge *sworn*,
 And my deliverer from *all*
 Violent *hand against the brawl*.

4 "I'll call to YHWH, worthy of praise,
 So be saved from my foes *ablaze*.

The image of the horn invented by
 The mother of Samuel before the try
 Of David ever came to seek the throne.
 The images of safety in the stone
 And horn and shield are not enough alone.
 Neither can tower fill my fearing breast
 With satisfaction when I am at rest.
 Beloved, do You indeed deliver me
 From every violent hand that I see?
 I trust You not when faced with sword and
 gun.
 I see my hammered heart has battles done
 And done again before the war is won.
 Beloved, I trust You in the warmth and
 dark,
 But not yet where the tanks and airplanes
 park.

5 "When waves of death come around me,
 Floods of ungodly ones in spree.
 6 "The cords of Sheol bind me round,
 The snares of death face me aground.
 7 "In my affliction I will call
 On YHWH and cry to Alohim,
 And He'll hear my voice from the wall
 Of His temple and my cries seem
 On His ears *everywhere to fall*.

The Red Sea still faces Egyptian shore
 And that of Araby, and I see more
 Water as far as Aqaba and down
 To where the Indian Ocean wears the
 crown.

But there's no break in all the shining sea
 To set foot on dry sand like on the lea.
 The cords of Sheol still there softly lap
 The pebbles on the beaches of the gap,
 And bright fishes swim by the coral reef
 To send a message up to unbelief.
 Beloved, while I sit by the Red sea wave,
 Do you not tell me I sit by the grave?
 Beloved, the Red Sea still faces the flight,
 The courage, and the day and the starlight.

8 "And then the earth trembled and shook,
 The bars of heaven moved at His look
 Of anger. 9 "There went up a smoke
 From His nostrils, and a fire broke
 From His mouth in devouring stroke
 To kindle coals *of ash and oak*.
 10 "He bowed the heavens also and came

Down and dark was neath His feet's *claim*.
 11 "He rode on a cherub and flew,
 Seen on the wings where the wind blew.
 12 "He made the dark His hiding place,
 His tent around Him was dark race
 Of waters and thick clouds in sky.
 13 "Through the brightness before His eye
 Were coals of fire lit bright and high.
 14 "YHWH thundered from the sky, Most
 High
 Gave forth His voice *and lifted cry*.
 15 "And He shot arrows, scattered them
 In lightning and despoiling them.

The work of Sinai was not done in dream,
 Not in the visions of the night to seem
 A strange reality beyond the bright
 Days of the common life and the sunlight.
 The work of Sinai was done in the fear
 Of thunder and of lightning to appear
 Across the flaming, smoking mountainside,
 With arrow and with cherubim to ride.
 Beloved, though I was not standing to see
 The lightning flash and thunder's
 symmetry,
 I have seen in my lifetime lightning bare
 And heard the thunder quake to lift its
 share,
 And seeing and hearing I know Your word
 Is greater than anything that occurred.

16 The channels of the sea appeared,
 Foundations of the world unreamed,
 At the rebuke of YHWH, the blast
 Of His nostrils' breath that He cast.
 17 "He sent from above, He took me
 He pulled me from the waters' *glee*.
 He saved me from strong enemy,
 And from the ones who hated me,
 For they were *all* too strong for me.

Pharaoh rides on again and once again
 In the form of the great and evil men
 Who wage war on the continents anew
 And chase the poor and refugee in view.
 The waters rise from Bombay to the coast
 Of far Alaska to float in the boast
 Of oil and death as long as Pharaoh rides.
 And yet, Beloved, Your hand's the one that
 guides.
 Beloved, I see the chariots in a row
 And hear the battle trumpets, see the glow

Of fire and bomb to break the people's
will.

I see the pestilence on every hill
That wears the benefactor's mask to fill
The earth with violence and evil still.

19 "They came before me on the day
Of my loss, but YHWH was my stay.
20 "He also brought me to a wide
Place, He saved me, because in stride
He set His delight at my side.

Where is that blessed hiding place now that
The heat detectors searched out where they
sat

The hidden poor in desert wilderness?
Where is their safety but within the dress
Of Your divine heart's bleeding and caress
Of saint beneath a blood-red moon and star
That falls from out its place at noise of car?
Beloved, they came before me on the day
Of my loss, but You were my strength and
stay.

And yet I pray for the tons facing ill,
The tons of dying children on the hill
Of the Sudan, of Iraq and the plain
That boasts freedom and liberty in vain.
Someday the violent will foot the bill.

21 "YHWH rewarded me according
To my righteousness *as I sing*,
According to the purity
Of my hands has He enriched me.

Rabbinicals wash hands before they eat
And pray Your blessing as they do the feat.
Samaritans and Muslims wash them too
Before they pray in morning or night's
dew.

No doubt men of all faiths who wash their
hands

Do so while soul bows on the heavenly
sands

To beg of You innocence in the way
They use their hands from day to tempting
day.

Beloved, though I wash my hands when I
take

The bread upon my teeth or at least make
Them clean somehow after relieving's
wake,

I pray to keep my hands clean from the
task

That breaks Your loved commandment, so
I ask

You guard me in both real life and the
masque.

22 "For I have kept the ways of YHWH
And not done as the wicked do
Who depart from my Alohim.

23 "For all His judgements *like a dream*
Were before me, and His laws too,
I did not depart from their *view*.

24 "I was upright before Him too,
And kept myself from wicked rue.

25 "Therefore YHWH has rewarded me
According to my righteous fee,
According to the purity
Of His eye *and His sight to see*.

Your seeing, my Beloved, is not alone
To evaluate what I cut in stone,
But when You see You stand up to create
A newness in the thing that was of late.
Creative sight of Sovereign and Creator
Makes turns and swirls in steps of every
skater

That go beyond the practice of the score.
Your sight alone opens up freedom's door.
Beloved, as You see me upon the stairs
And hear the humble offering of my
prayers,

See my steps stumbling, let Your seeing
make

My ways a skilful skipping for Your sake.
And so I shall keep myself from the ill
Until I enter on Your temple's hill.

26 "To those who live by their mercy
You show Yourself always to be
Merciful, with the upright man
You show Yourself upright *in plan*.

27 "With the pure You'll show Yourself
pure,
And with the wicked You are sure
To show to them Your ways perverse.

When You inspired Muhammad once to
quote

This verse in holy Qur'an, not by rote,
You made it sound as though You knew
the way

To heckle hecklers with witty dismay.
Your raucous and disdainful words fall on
The air about the good and evil spawn
Of humankind to prevent the excuse
That wicked ways were not the last abuse.
Beloved, I do not hear deriding voice
To intervene upon the wicked choice,
And yet I know that Your Reality
Sets judgement on all things that I can see
And finds the hidden way beyond my ken
Whereby You speak in silence to all men.

28 “And the afflicted folk You’ll save,
But Your eyes on the proud and knave
Flash out to bring them to the grave.
29 “For You’re my lamp, YHWH and so
YHWH

Will lighten me my darkness through.
30 “For by You I’ve run through a troop,
By my Alohim I’ll take *hoop*
And jump over a wall *with whoop*.

31 “El El God, His way’s perfect,
YHWH’s

Word is tried, He’s a shield in views
Of all those who trust in His *crews*.

32 “For who is El a God but YHWH,
And who a rock but our God *true*?

33 “And El God is my strength and power,
He makes my way perfect *an hour*.

The four letters that make up Your brief
Name,
Beloved, are sacred in order they came,
And though I refer to them here and say
Huu, I do not come near the holy way
That Your Name sounds, for my lips are
impure

To say the holy syllables for sure,
And my heart rises in respect and honour
Before Your Name to lay a blessing on her.
Shield me, Beloved, from idols men may
choose,

Conditions and preferments in their views,
And be a rock where I may stand to know
That other names, though spoken, come
and go.

Beloved, Your word is tried and becomes
power

To such as me who cantillate an hour.

34 “He makes my feet like those of deer
And sets me on high places’ *cheer*.

35 “He teaches my hands to make war,
So that a steel bow meteor
Is broken by my arms *in score*.

36 “You’ve given me salvation’s shield
Your gentleness makes great my *field*.
You have enlarged my steps beneath
Me, so my feet did not find teeth.

38 “I have pursued my foes, destroyed
Them and not turned back from employed
Until I had consumed them all.

39 “And I’ve consumed them, wounded
tall

So that they could not rise again.
Indeed, under my feet they’ve lain.

Your gentleness, Beloved, may well teach
me

To make war on the vile humanity
That would rise up in violence of hope.
Your gentleness may well tie hangman’s
rope.

That You stand by to see the wickedness
That freights my world when You could
come to bless

May well teach my hands and my feet to
war

Until the waiting world is filled with gore.
Beloved, I rise up in ungentle ire
And slay the enemy of my desire
And gate the plague that would cast me in
fire.

I cannot cleanse a universe from stain,
Nor make the clouds shine with the sun or
rain,

But I make clean of violence my brain.

40 “You strengthen me to battle’s song,
Subduing under me the wrong
Who rose up against me *for long*.

41 “You’ve given me also the necks
Of my foes, that I may their checks
Destroy because they hate *and vex*.

42 “They looked, but there was none to
save,

Even to YHWH, but He *was grave*
And did not answer them *or wave*.

43 “Then did I beat them small as dust
Of the earth, stamp them as I trust
In the mud of the street and spread
Them out abroad *where they were led*.

These words alas do not apply to me.

All my enemies strike and then go free.
 I do not live in such society
 Where I have recourse to the law or court,
 Both prejudiced against me and my sort.
 Nor do I have the inclination roused
 To beat to dust the one's I have aroused
 For marching to the sound of other drums,
 Specifically Your Decalogue that comes
 To conflict with the hue and cry abroad
 In this world of no seed but more the pod.
 And yet most holy people do relent
 To more than half of what they represent
 As divine law in ten commandments sent.

44 "You also have delivered me
 From my folk's striving and kept me
 Head of the heathen, so a folk
 Who did not know me at a stroke
 Shall serve me *under fir and oak*.
 45 "The sons of stranger bow to me,
 Soon as they hear they obey me.
 46 "Strangers shall fade away and they
 Shall fear in closet where they stay.

I'm more the one fearing in closet where
 I sit in stillness while the world out there
 Goes berserk on its violence in spree.
 But perhaps David's fortune here to see
 Is better than my path in wilderness.
 And yet I've seen him also in the press,
 And fleeing from the sword and lying
 tongue.
 I have been old and once I too was young,
 I have been honoured too, and I've been
 flung
 Out from the congregation with a curse.
 In all no heathen come to deal me worse
 In their obedience. Instead they cry
 That I must obey their majority.
 I flee the stranger, in the desert sigh.

47 "YHWH lives and blessed be my rock,
 High Alohim, my safety's rock.
 48 "To El is my vengeance who brings
 Under me the folk *from their springs*.
 49 "And He brings me out from my foes,
 You also lift me high who chose
 Me above them against me rose,
 You saved me from violent throes.
 50 "Therefore I will give thanks to You,
 O YHWH, among the heathen due,
 And I'll sing praises to Your name,

51 "The tower of His king's safety's claim,
 He shows mercy to His anointed,
 To David and his seed appointed
 For ever and ever *in fame*."

Though I live in the vale of fatal woes
 Where every priest and king here living
 chose

To ignore Your Sabbath and unity,
 I know that You're the Rock to which I
 flee.

I know not what vengeance is best to fall
 Upon the ruler and upon the small
 Who berate me for following Your word.
 I know not indeed, but my heart is stirred
 To give to You the violence and strain
 And pray that You rain on them the best
 rain

In justice and in mercy till the way
 Of earth is void of evil every day.
 Beloved, be vengeance in Your arm and
 face

When You return toward my dwelling
 place.

2 Samuel 23

1 And these *are* David's last words *spoken*,
 Saying of Jesse's son in token,
 David, and the man raised on high,
 Anointed by Alohim, by
The God of Jacob, and the sweet
 Singer of Israel for treat.

2 The spirit of YHWH spoke by me,
 And His word on my tongue *was free*.

3 Israel's Alohim said "The Rock
 Of Israel spoke to me in stock,
 He that rules over men is just,
 Ruling in Alohim's fear's *trust*.
 4 As morning light at the sunrise,
 A morning caught in cloudless skies,
 Like tender grass sprung from the earth
 Clear shining after rain *on dearth*.

5 Is not my house with Alohim
 Set for eternal pact to seem
 Made with me ordered in all things
 And certain, for deliverings
 And my desire on everything,
 Will He not make increase my ring?

6 But the ungodly, they're as thorns
 Thrust out, all of them from their bourns,
 Not to be touched with naked hand.

7 But the man that touches their stand

Must be armed with a coat of mail
And staff of spear, and without fail
They shall be burned upon the flame
In their own place *and in their claim.*”

Beloved, I see the last words David spoke
Were quoted from Your own as writ in
oak.

His dying day saw him relinquish all
That called his heart against the heathen
pall

And greed that covered earth in cloak of
sin

To turn to You alone instead of kin.

Beloved, I hear the last words David knew
Fresh from Your lips as on the garden dew,
And find that no desire is true or great
But that which follows in Your love and
hate.

Beloved, let me take on my last breath
token

Of Your name in the tongue of David
spoken

To find the syllables rise on the air
To greet the everlasting golden share.

8 These are David’s great heroes’ names:
Josheb-Basshebeth, Tachmonite,
Chief among captains without blames.
The same was Adino Eznite,
Who killed eight hundred in one fight.

Beloved, I have not killed a single soul.
For me that has just not been my life’s
goal.

A hero I am not, I see, with arm
Raised up to do anyone at all harm.
Not called by inclination or Your law
To keep the heathen hordes down and in
awe,

I make my way through wilderness and
street

Of city not to kill any I meet.
Beloved, the hero of David of old
Was fine and surely a great man, and bold,
But those who step out on this day and
time

Are not worth peck, penny or pilfered
dime,

From warrior to the mercenary crime,
Protecting interests of wolf in sheepfold.

9 And after him was Eleazar
Son of Dodo the son and star
Of an Ahothite, one of three
Mighty men with David in spree
To risk their lives against the hand
Of Philistines gathered in band
To battle when Israel’s men failed.

10 And he stood firm and never quailed,
But struck the Philistines until
His hand was weary of the kill,
And fingers stuck fast to the sword,
And YHWH gained great victory’s accord
That day, and the folk then returned
After him to spoil the foe spurned.

The Philistine was civilized beyond
Compared with Israelite come to abscond.
The Philistine was merchant of the sea,
Well-schooled in ships, markets and
industry.

The Philistine was great in science too,
And knew the things that any had to do
Applying eugenics to birth control
And breeding giants when to take a toll.
The Israelite, Beloved, was one to lose
Even the skills he had begun to choose.
So why did You make lesser folk become
Your chosen when You started out to hum?
Why not choose of the great and not the
small?

The great can also hear and follow call.

11 And after him was Shammah son
Of Age Ararite when done.

The Philistine in troop arrived
In lentil field, the folk survived
By fleeing them *under the sun.*

12 He stood in middle of the field
Defending it and would not yield
But killed the Philistines, and YHWH
Made a great victory’s ado.

If I’d only lentil field to defend,
And stood alone against the powers that
bend

Against me in a troop of Philistines
Wise in their cunningness and wicked
lines,

I think I would have joined the fleeing
crowd

And let the Philistines rejoice aloud
Among the lentils for their spoil and rate.

I'd leave those sorry lentils to their fate.
But I'm no hero in the battlefront.
The battle is not longer, and the brunt
Is rather felt by those who stand astride
The oil pipelines or have organs to hide
From butchers selling on behalf of state
And other wealthy members come in late.

13 And three of thirty chiefs went down
And came to David's harvest brown
Into Adullam's cave, the troop
Of Philistines encamped to stoop
In the valley of Rephaim.

14 And David in the stronghold stayed,
The Philistines' fort was waylaid
In Bethlehem. 15 And David longed
And said "Who will give me *unwronged*
Water to drink out of the well
That is in Bethlehem's gate *fell*?"
And the Philistine army camped
In Bethlehem *and there revamped*.

16 And the three mighty men broke
through
The Philistine lines whence they drew
Water out of Bethlehem's well
That was by the gate, took a spell
And brought it to David, but he
Would not drink of it but simply
Poured it out to YHWH *in the dell*.
17 And he said "Be it far from me,
O YHWH, that I should drink in fee
The blood of men in jeopardy
Of their lives?" And so therefore he
Would not drink it. These things did three
Mighty men, *heroes faithfully*.

The thing is questionable, truly so.
If David was so gracious on the go,
Then why did he express desire and show
The men he wanted water from the flow
Of Bethlehem? It was a dirty deed.
But was it grateful of him in his need
To pour the water out upon the seed
Of rocky thistle and the sturdy weed?
I think not, my Beloved, and did You ask
For the oblation of unholy task?
A bunch of thugs they seem to me from
here,
Who show off bragging that they have no
fear.
Beloved, keep me from Bethlehem's old
well,

And satisfied with what water I smell.

18 And Abishai the brother of
Joab, son of Zeruiah,
Was the chief of the three *above*.
And he lifted up his spear and
Killed three hundred upon the sand,
And gained fame among three *in awe*.
19 Of those three most in honour held
He became chief of those unquelled,
But attained not to the first three.
20 And Benaiah Jehoiada's
Son, and son of a valiant buzz
Of Kabzeel, who did mighty deeds,
He struck the altar hearths to seeds
In Moab, he went down also
And killed a lion in the tow
Of a pit in the time of snow.
21 And he killed an Egyptian, one
Great it appears, the Egyptian
Had in his hand a spear as great
As the side of a ladder, mate,
And he went to him with a staff,
And grabbed the spear, and with a laugh,
He killed him with his own spear's gaff.
22 These things did Benaiah the son
Of Jehoiada, and he won
A name among three heroes done.
23 More honoured than the thirty, he
Did not attain to the first three.
David set him guard faithfully.

The mighty deeds of ancient time require
The furnishings of ancient heart desire.
Three hundred slain upon the field still lie
With bones to bleach against the shining
sky.

The sword of the Egyptian like the side
Of a ladder may long since be applied
To some campfire of Bedouin or lost
Beneath the staff that David's hero tossed.
The only thing left of the slaughter done
Is in the praise the poet gave the gun.
The memory is made of nothing soft,
But dust in air once thrown in word aloft.
I sip those words for what hero's begun
Has long since disappeared beneath the
sun.

24 Asahel Joab's brother was
One of the thirty *as one does*:
Elhanan Dodo's son who came

From Bethlehem, *city of fame*,
 25 Shammah the Harodite and yet
 Elika, Harodite *you bet*,
 26 Helez the Paltite, Ira son
 Of Ikkeshe Tekoite who won,
 27 Abiezer Anathothite,
 And Mebunnai the Hushathite,
 27 Abiezer the Anothite,
 Of the sons of the Anothite.
 28 Zalmon the Ahohite and more
 Maharai Netophathite's score,
 29 Heleb the son of Baanah who
 Was also Netophathite true,
 Ittai the son of Ribai who
 Was from Gibeah of the sons
 Of Benjamin *come in their tons*,
 30 And Benaiah Pirathonite,
 Hiddai of Gaash in the brooks' sight,
 31 Abi-albon the Arbathite,
 And Azmaveth the Barhumite,
 32 Eliahba the Shaalbonite,
 Of the sons of Jashen by right,
 Jonathan, Shammah Hararite,
 Ahiam son of Sharar who
 Was Ararite, Eliphelet
 The son of Ahasbai in due,
 The son of the Maacathite too,
 Eliam Ahithophel the
 The son, the Gilonite *in fee*,
 35 Hezrai the Carmelite, Paarai
 The Arbite, 36 Igal son *not sly*
 Of Nathan of Zobah, Bani
 The Gadite, 37 Zelek Ammonite,
 Naharai who was Beerothite,
 And armour-bearer of Joab
 The son of Zeruiah's *scab*,
 38 Ira the Ithrite, Gareb too
 An Ithrite *from his father's due*,
 39 Uriah the Hittite, in crew
 Thirty-seven of heroes *true*.

Every prophet and divine guide is met
 Among the forties whirling on the floor
 Of heaven and earth before the open door
 That lead up to Your throne and where it's
 set.
 The threes, the fours, the sevens come to
 get
 The twelves, the sixteen, and the twenty-
 four
 To fly among the righteous to find more
 Than hides beneath the altar's burning net.

Beloved, the secret heroes of the world
 That follow unseen, unheard on the path
 Of brightness by the lion and the steed
 Are gathered by Your banner once
 unfurled
 To be both instruments of divine wrath
 As well as of peace before shameless
 greed.

2 Samuel 24

1 Again the anger of YHWH flamed
 Against Israel, and He was blamed
 To move David against them saying
 "Go count Israel and Judah *playing*."

The judgment always falls on us for doing
 The thing we think we have to. Rarely is
 There choice of punishment in our
 subduing
 As David had in famine, war, and his
 First choice, the plague. He threw himself
 on mercy
 Instead of trusting in his fighting arm.
 We might consider without controversy
 His choice astute avoidance of great harm,
 Since he chose Your abuse and not his
 brother's.
 There is no mercy found with those who
 are
 Dissatisfied with their power over others.
 They sigh and wish upon a falling star.
 The trick is not to count one's might in
 numbers
 But just enjoy tomatoes and cucumbers.

2 And the king said to Joab who
 Was captain of the host in view
 With him, "Go now back and forth through
 All the tribes of Israel from Dan
 Even to Beersheba to scan
 The number of the folk that I
 May know the sum and to rely."
 3 And Joab said to the king, "How
 YHWH your Alohims add a brow
 To the folk many as they be
 A hundredfold, and may you see
 It, my lord king, but why does my
 Lord king desire this thing on sly?"
 4 Nevertheless the king's word won
 Out against Joab and when done
 Against the captains of the host.
 That's why Joab with all the boast

Of army captains went out from
The presence of the king to come
To count Israel's people in sum.

The thing that bothers me about the king
Or president or captain is the sting
They all have when it comes to doing
wrong.

Joab knew sin sat in the counting long
Before the king suggested such a deed.
He even told the king his notion's seed.
Despite his knowledge of the wrong and
right
He obeyed the king without moral fight.
Beloved, the reason so few keep the word
That You once spoke on Sinai undeterred
Is simply because, though they know
what's good
And evil, they do nothing as they should.
Instead they obey captain, king or priest
And go out with their sins fourfold
increased.

5 And they passed over Jordan and
Pitched in Araer, on right stand
Of the city in middle of
The valley of Gad and above
To Jazer, 6 then to Gilead,
And to Tahtim-Hodshi's land clad,
And came to Dan-Jaan, and around
About to Zidon, 7 came to ground
At the stronghold of Tyre and to
And cities of the Hivites' view,
And of the Canaanites, and they
Went out to south of Judah's way
At Beersheba *to end the stay*.

8 And so they went around the land
And to and fro in every stand
Until they came back to the town
Jerusalem with sword *and gown*
At end of nine months twenty days.
9 And Joab gave the sum of praise
Of the people in the king's hand,
And in Israel there were *to stand*
Eight hundred thousand valiant men
That drew the sword to fight again,
And Judah's men numbered up to
Five hundred thousand men *in crew*.

The number of the fleet had doubled since
Coming from Egypt sucking on a quince.

Doubled and more, I say, by hundred
strong
Of thousands, that was quite the mighty
throng.

Why did You want to keep the growing
score

A secret from the battle and the fore?
Quite simply, I suppose, so man would
know

That he is helpless before any foe
Unless the strength of Your arm's in his
right.

And yet, the strong and wicked in Your
sight,

Sin without retribution, while the just
Are ground into their poverty and dust.
Beloved, let numbers take their flight and
fail

While You and Your goodness come to
prevail.

10 And David's conscience hurt him when
He had counted all the folk's men.

And David said to YHWH, "I've sinned
Greatly in what I've packed and binned,
But now, O YHWH, forgive I pray
You Your servant's wickedness' way,
For I have done a foolish thing.

11 And when David rose up to sing
At dawn the word of YHWH came to
The prophet Gad, David's seer true,
Saying 12 "Go speak to David, 'This
Is what YHWH tells you not to miss,
I lay on you three things, so choose
One of the three, and so you lose
In what I will do to you too.'"

Ah my Beloved! Was not the man
bereaved,

And did he not humbly ask You aggrieved
To recognize repentance in the bill
He prayed to You after counting his fill?
So what is this? Are You not full of grace
To pardon one who stumbled on the race?
You do not say to sacrifice a bull
To make You an atonement paid in full,
Nor do You point him to a future lamb
Upon a cross to satisfy I AM.

Instead You give him choice of three
plagues in

Punishment for sorely repented sin.
Beloved, I tremble to see how You state

The path to Your favour at David's gate.

13 So Gad came to David and told
Him and said to him, "Choose *the bold*,
Shall seven years of famine come
To you in your land or in sum
Will you flee three months from your foes
While they pursue you *on their toes*,
Or shall there be three days of plague
In your land? Now think and decide
What answer I shall go provide
To Him who sent me to your side."

14 And David said to God, "I am
In a great strait, let's fall *like lamb*
Into the hand of YHWH, for He
Is great in mercy, and let me
Not fall into the hands of men.

Beloved, David's heart seems better than
Yours,

For he trusts You before men to set scores.
Despite Your stubborn punishment on him
He keeps his view of Your mercy undim,
Or else he has a clear picture of rate
Of the sadistic in the human trait.

What else is to be done, I guess, when
three

Choices are all dark set and painfully.

Beloved, I too choose You above all men
Who would punish my sins and then again
Punish my righteousness when I take You
Alone to be the ruler of my due.

Beloved, I too choose You when You seem
to

Have no mercy at all better than ten.

15 So YHWH sent a plague on the folk
Of Israel from morning's *stroke*
Even to the appointed time,
And there died from the folk *for crime*
From Dan to Beersheba again
Seventy thousand *valiant* men.

16 And when the angel stretched his hand
Toward Jerusalem as planned,
YHWH repented the evil, He
Said to the angel in the spree
Of destruction of the folk, "See,
It is enough, now stay your hand."

And the angel at YHWH's command
Was by the threshing-floor owned by
Araunah the Jebusite guy.

David was right that You would spare the
folk

Before the drenching slaughter of Your
stroke.

David was right to place himself behind
Your mercy even when You were not blind
To his sins, bent on punishment in kind.
David was right that human mercy's not
Intrinsic to the heart, but something taught
By long submission to Your throne and
share.

Beloved, I follow David's heart to be
Trusting of You alone, I've come to see
In fifty years of dealing with the throng
That trusting others always leads one
wrong.

Beloved, I follow David's prayer and find
Your justice is a mercy, core and rind.

17 And David spoke to YHWH when he
Saw the angel strike the folk free,
And said "See I have sinned and I
Have done here iniquitously,
But these sheep what have they done here?
Let Your hand, I pray, on me steer,
And on my father's house *for fear*."

One role of divine guide is intercession
Along with his own prayer and his
confession.

But let me remind You that David's sin
Is not one of the big ten in the bin.
Results seem more than he should have to
bear

To say nothing of Israel's people's share.
But that's reality: a twist of fate
A cigarette butt thrown out without hate
Results in conflagration of a state.
Beloved, have mercy on the weak ones
here

Who suffer at unthinking hand on gear.
Though I am neither divine guide nor
prophet,

The quivering world is one I do not scoff
at.

I intercede beside the casting bier.

18 And Gad came to David that day,
And said to him, "Go up, I pray,
And build an altar to YHWH in
The threshing-floor and in the bin
Of Araunah the Jebusite."

And David went up to the site
 According to Gad's word as YHWH
 Commanded him in what to do.
 20 And Araunah looked out and saw
 The king and his servants in claw
 Coming on toward him and he went,
 Araunah did, and bowed present
 Before the king face on the ground.
 21 And Araunah said "Why is found
 My lord the king come to his slave?"
 And David said "To buy the pave
 And threshing-floor from you to make
 An altar to YHWH for the sake
 Of the plague that it may stop here
 From the people *and from their fear.* "

Everything was done it would seem when
 You
 Relented from the plague and derring-do.
 And yet David will not leave well enough
 Alone by prayer and intercession rough,
 And Gad appears to prophesy and score
 By commanding an altar at the door.
 Is not enough enough? Why must faith take
 The gyrations that sacrifices make?
 The plague had stopped before David came
 out
 To buy the threshing floor, and so I doubt
 That what I and my own do in the church
 And synagogue or on the easy perch
 Of minbar is a necessary torch
 Of light here sitting on the cosmic porch.

22 And Araunah said to David,
 "Let my lord the king take the bid
 And offer up whatever he
 Thinks good for him. and now, just see,
 The oxen of the holocaust,
 And threshing-instruments not lost
 And yokes of the oxen for wood.
 23 Arauna did all that he should
 For the king giving the king all.
 And Araunah answered king's call,
 "YHWH your Alohim accept you."
 24 And the king said to Araunah,
 "No, but I'll surely buy by law
 And I'll not offer burnt offering
 To YHWH my Alohim a thing
 That costs me nothing. So David
 Bought the threshing-floor and the skid
 Of oxen for fifty silver
 Shekels. 25 And David came to stir

Up there an altar for YHWH and
 Offered holocausts on the stand
 And peace offerings, so YHWH was
 sought
 For the land, and the plague He wrought
 On Israel ceased from the distraught.

It happened once before with Abraham
 And the sons of Heth when to buy a ham
 To bury Sarah in, the other said
 To take the plot for free and make her bed.
 But Abraham insisted he must pay.
 So David also deals out coin to lay
 Upon the paunch of owner of the straw.
 It's just a form of courtesy in awe.
 Beloved, I view the lives by David's touch
 And see how human thoughts and cultures
 much
 Colour and blur the lines of right and
 wrong.

I hear how every man sings his own song
 And see Your judgement rise to lay it bare
 Before the starry heavens everywhere.

Just one more thought, Beloved, before I
 leave
 The Book of Samuel on my checkered
 sleeve,
 I say it's magic thing the angel stopped
 At the very threshing floor that was
 propped
 By Araunah the Jebusite. It seems
 That altar set by Israelite for dreams
 Was passed by in Your divine choice.
 Instead
 You chose to honour Canaanite unbred.
 Beloved, I am a Hittite dog, but I
 Offer the altar of my heart and try
 To give the place to be Your golden throne.
 I bow to Israel's God, and You alone.
 And like Araunah I ask naught for me
 But that You accept my altar in fee.

The Books of Kings

The Books of Kings begin with the final
 events of the life of David, the
 establishment of Solomon upon the throne,
 the story of the building of the temple, and
 go on through the history of the kings of

Israel and Judah up to the destruction of Jerusalem in 587 B.C.E.

The Books of Kings form a consistent whole, being structured around the twelve kings of the dynasty of David who are declared righteous. This cycle of twelve thus appears following the cycle of twelve patriarchs in Genesis and the cycle of twelve judges in the book of Judges. The twelve good kings of Judah are David, Solomon, Rehoboam, Abijah, Asa, Jehoshaphat, Jehoash, Amaziah, Uzziah, Jotham, Hezekiah, and Josiah. The established cycle of twelve is thus continued in this line of divinely appointed leaders.

The criterion for determining who is a good and who is a bad king is simple and direct. Those who adhere to the worship of the one true God alone, setting aside idolatry, are declared good. This criterion of evaluation is reaffirmed again and again in the books, and remains still the first and most important characteristic, not only of leaders, but of every individual and every religious movement representing true faith.

1 Kings 1

1 And king David was old *indeed*
Stricken in years, *an invalid*,
And they covered him with blankets,
But he could not get warm *for frets*.
2 And so his servants told him, "Let
Be found *now* for my lord the king
A young virgin, and let her get
Before the king for cherishing,
And let her lie upon your breast,
That my lord king may warmth ingest."
3 So they looked for a pretty lass
Throughout all Israel's lands and grass,
And found Abishag Shunammite,
And brought her into the king's sight.
And the lass was a pretty sort,
And cherished the king *at the court*,
And served him, but the king did not
Lay lawless leg upon her plot.

I'd think a lady of the middle age
Might do as well for heat in patronage.
Why make such issue that the girl was
pretty?
Why not as well make issue of her city

And lineage? But instead in repetition
Her beauty reads out in the fine admission.
I'd think a buxom matron would do better
For bringing heat out in kingly go-getter.
The more flesh the more heat I'd think
would be
The rule of thumb to follow by decree.
Instead they find a likely lass to flaunt
New-ripened breasts upon the royal font.
Beloved, there's no text in the sacred writ
More gaudily raunchy to cause a fit.

5 Then Adonijah Haggith's son
Exalted himself, said when done,
"I will be king," and he prepared
Himself chariots and horsemen *scared*,
And fifty men to run in front
Of him to praise *and bear the brunt*.
6 And his father had never said
A word of discipline that led
Him ever in his life, and he
Was very handsome man to see,
Born after Absalom *was fed*.

The wonder, my Beloved, is that men
choose
To lead a folk who never came to use
On self a spot of discipline and who
Were left by parents without guidance too.
Who never learned to obey father can
Never learn to rule self with cord and ban,
And who never ruled self can never rule
Another, even with years done in school.
Beloved, the ruler is the man who most
Has learned Your yoke of guidance
without boast,
Not he who at the polls gets most in votes.
Beloved, the brazen sower of wild oats
Is always people's choice. I cast my ballot
Against democracy for its spoiled palate.

7 And he conferred with Joab son
Of Zeruiah, and when done
With Abiathar priest, and they
Followed Adonijah to help.

Adonijah! How poorly chosen is
That splendid, sacred, wondered name of
his!
YHWH is my Lord. And yet if Lord is
YHWH,
Then it should be seen in the things I do.

But Adonijah denies his own name
 In his rebellion to his father's shame.
 That's the whole problem with religious
 claim
 To follow this or that famous guru.
 Beloved, in all my ways and thoughts let
 me
 Make You my Lord, and thus set my soul
 free
 Of every false usurping canopy
 That spreads its shadow on the burning
 sand
 Of Palestine or any other land.
 Let me, Beloved, take hold Your guiding
 hand.

8 But Zadok the priest and Benaiah
 Son of Jehoiada *and higher*,
 And Nathan the prophet, Shimei,
 And Rei and the heroes brought nigh
 To David, were not *with the man*
 Adonijah *in his foul plan*.

I should think not! That even the man
 chosen
 To be a prophet would rather be frozen
 Than join in rebellion against the one
 Anointed to be king of Zion's run.
 Some priests of course might well rebel, I
 know
 The way the mind of priest is like to go.
 But not a prophet, surely, very thought
 Is shocking to my senses under-wrought.
 Beloved, let me be loyal to Your name
 And to the ones You send to hold Your
 fame
 Before the maudlin crowd, before the
 weight
 Of situation and the people's fate.
 Beloved, I stand firm for Davidic throne
 And fly to You who are sovereign alone.

9 And Adonijah slaughtered sheep
 And oxen and fatlings to keep
 By the stone of Zoheleth, which
 Is beside En-rogel in pitch,
 And he called all his brothers there,
 The king's sons and also the *fair*
 Men of Judah, king's servants' *share*.

When there are gathered men of state,
 renown,

Then I am sure to follow with a frown,
 Since I know that the crowd is noted for
 Their rebellion to You at every door.
 Remember this one thing, Beloved, that
 there

Is not one single sect that takes a care
 Even to keep the ten words You declare
 On Sinai to be law and bound to last.
 Beloved, I see the time that now has passed
 Does nothing to correct the lame excuse.
 Men always find a reason for abuse.
 And so I join the party with ill-ease
 And let the neighbour taste the wine and
 cheese

While I stand back and ask the thing You
 please.

10 But Nathan the prophet and yet
 Benaiah, and the mighty set
 And Solomon his brother, he
 Did not call *to rebellious spree*.

Then Nathan spoke to Bathsheba
 Mother of Solomon *in awe*,
 11 Saying "Have you not heard that one
 Adonijah and what he's done

The son of Haggith that he might
 Reign and David our lord in sight
 Does not know of the thing not right?

12 So now then, please, let me advise
 How to save yourself from the spies
 And Solomon your son's life too,
For treachery's a prince's due.

13 Go get you in before the king
 David and say to him a thing,
 'Did you not, O my lord the king,
 Swear to your handmaid when you said,
 "Surely Solomon your son bred
 Shall reign after me, and he'll sit
 Upon my throne? Then is it fit
 That Adonijah reign to wit?"

14 "And see, while you are speaking still
 With the king, I'll come after, will
 Confirm your words to fit the bill."

I plan my words, Beloved, to save my life
 Before democracy as sharp as knife.
 In ancient times and other places it
 Was and is enough merely to be fit
 To please one man, the king, and then arise
 In freedom to pursue one's duty's prize.
 But now one has to look at every vote

And please both small as well as men of
note.
Beloved, I long to see a righteous king
Sit once more on David's throne and to
sing.
Perhaps the world will then sit down from
strife
And every man can focus on his wife
Instead of the survival of the great.
The fittest, well, they always come in late.

15 So Bathsheba went to the king
Into the chamber, and the king
Was very old and Abishag
The Shunammite served *without shag*
Before the king. 16 Bathsheba bowed
And did obeisance as allowed
Unto the king. And the king said
"What do you want *of drink or bread?*"
17 And she said to him, "My lord, you
Swore by your Alohim and YHWH
To your handmaid, 'Assuredly
Solomon your son after me
Shall reign, and he shall sit upon
My throne.' 18 "And now with horrid
brawn

See Adonijah reigns instead
And you, my lord king, don't see red.
19 "And he has slaughtered oxen and
Fat cattle and sheep lots in hand,
And has called all the king's sons there,
And Abiathar priest to *dare*,
And Joab chief of the army,
But Solomon your servant *free*
He has not called to join *the spree*.
20 "And you, my lord king, all the eyes
Of Israel are on you to prize
That you should tell them who shall sit
On the throne of my lord king fit
After him. 21 "Otherwise it may
Come to pass, when my lord king's way
Shall be to sleep in fathers' den,
That I and my son Solomon
Shall be counted offenders then."

The first queen from the cradle stings the
rest.
All earthly monarchies it is confessed
Whether of human or of beastly breast
Rely upon the killing of the crowd
Of princes waiting for their father's shroud.
I thank You, my Beloved, I am low born

Of mere retainers below courtly scorn,
And though Carrick is still a monarch's
land,
I don't pretend to give a helping hand
To lord or bailiff as my fathers did.
Instead I've learned to wander who once
hid.
So now Bathsheba, once for beauty taken,
Fears that she and her son may be forsaken.
Beloved, stand up and shout for the next
bid.

22 And see while she was talking still
With the king, Nathan, *fit to kill*,
The prophet also came to court.
23 And they said to the king *in short*
"See, here is Nathan who's the prophet."
And when he came before the soffit
To see the king, he bowed before
The king with his face to the floor.

This is one thing I hate about the kings
That do or do not submit to Your things.
Even Your prophets come before the
throne,
Or before the bed where they're not alone,
To bow and scrape, indeed to fall upon
The stony floor with ashen forehead drawn
To meet its coldness and to steel the soul
Against the body's trembling at the shoal.
Beloved, see Nathan bend before the cage
Where slumbers David's soul for
patronage.
I come before Your throne, Beloved, to
seek
A boon in answer to my witness meek
That traitors wait beside Your oaken door
To break through and melt all Your gospel
lore.

24 And Nathan said "My lord, O king,
Have you said 'Adonijah's wing
Shall reign after me, and he'll sit
Upon my throne in form and fit?'
25 "For he has gone down today and
Has sacrificed oxen on land
And fat cattle and sheep in lots
And called all the king's sons in plots,
And captains of the army too,
Abiathar the priest in view,
And they are eating, drinking too,
In front of him and shouting due,

‘God save king Adonijah’s crew.’
 26 “But me your servant and Zadok
 The priest, and Benaiah the stock
 Of Jehoiada, and your slave
 Solomon, has he not called *grave*.
 27 “Is this thing done by my lord king,
 And you have not revealed the thing
 To your servant, who should sit down
 On the throne of my lord renown
 And king after him?” 28 Then the king
 David answered and said a thing,
 “Call me Bathsheba.” And she came
 Into the king’s presence and fame,
 And stood before the king *in claim*.

Well Adonijah made fatal mistake
 When he failed to call Nathan to the wake,
 And left out Zadok from the party list.
 He should have known at least those two
 were missed.
 If Adonijah had not failed to bring
 The priest and prophet into such a thing,
 He might have succeeded in drawing off
 Support to Solomon, for all men scoff
 At those whose power has left them in the
 lurch.
 That’s so in court and country and the
 church.
 For that mistake the man may well lose all
 As lose those who attempt to beat the pall
 Of power in every place where power
 corrupts:
 The earth must shake and volcano erupts.

And the king swore and said “As YHWH
 Lives who has redeemed my soul true
 Out of all distress, 30 “even as
 I swore you by YHWH Alohim
 Of Israel, saying whereas,
 ‘In truth Solomon your son’s beam
 Shall shine after me, and he’ll sit
 Upon my throne in my stead fit,’
 Even so will I certainly
 Perform the thing today, just see.”

The king took up Your lovely Name to
 make
 An affirmation for Solomon’s sake
 And for his mother Bathsheba who won
 The king’s heart in the shaky thing she’d
 done.

Could You, Beloved, not just as well have
 made
 Adonijah a jewel instead of spade?
 Your workings are beyond the ken of man
 And even women have to stretch to scan
 Your justice and to know the heavenly
 plan.
 While I do not fill throne, nor do desire
 The provenance of stately pomp and fire,
 I fill the place perhaps that You have
 meant
 When You gave me my breath in this
 world sent.
 Beloved, look on the thing now and relent.

31 Then Bathsheba bowed with her face
 To the earth, to reverence trace
 Before the king, and said “Let my
 Lord king David live to the sky.”
 32 And king David said “Call me then
 Zadok the priest and Nathan ken
 The prophet, and Benaiah son
 Of Jehoiada, and when done
 They came before the king *to stun*.

I think Bathsheba was noted somehow
 From the first day in how she knew to bow.
 Some wives of kings have disrespectful
 tongues
 And let the evil air come from their lungs.
 Some wives of kings remember that too
 late,
 Perhaps because their husbands have full
 pate
 Of hair and are still young upon the throne.
 The wife of king must plan the decades
 grown
 If she would see her own son beat the mass
 That waits for honour to anoint the crass.
 Beloved, Bathsheba knows now when to
 lay
 Her forehead in the dust in the king’s way.

33 The king also said to them, “Take
 With you the servants for the sake
 Of your lord and cause Solomon
 My son to ride on my own dun
 Mule and bring him down to Gihon.
 34 And let Zadok the priest there and
 Nathan the prophet oil in hand
 Anoint him there king of the land
 Of Israel, and blow the horn

And say 'God save the king new-sworn,
Solomon', *do by my command.*"

My own great grandfather was prone to sit
Upon a mule because he was not fit
And felt in limb the old paralysis
That in his childhood nearly made him
miss

The right to rule the county from his farm.
He rode upon a mule to keep from harm.
But he was not anointed in his place,
Not least because he was not chosen race.
Beloved, I hear the blowing of the horn
About the ears of those You hold in scorn.
But Solomon rides with the right to see
The people bowing by royal decree.
How rare to find a king elected once
By You instead of every prairie dunce!

1 Kings 2

1 Now David's time to die came near,
He ordered Solomon in fear,
Saying 2 "I go the way of all
The earth, so be strong to the call,
And show yourself a man withal,
3 "And keep the charge of YHWH your
God

To walk in His ways on the sod,
To keep His statutes and His laws,
And his judgements and hold the clause
Of His testimonies as it

Is written in Moses' law *fit*,
That you may prosper in all that
You do and where you turn you at,

4 "That YHWH may continue His word
That He spoke about me when stirred,
Saying 'If your children take heed
To their way to do every deed
Before Me in truth with all their
Heart and with all their soul with care,
There shall not fail you one to sit
On Israel's throne *in form and fit.*'

5 "Moreover you know also what
Joab son of Zeruiah *mutt*
Did to me, and what he did to
The two captains of the hosts *true*
Of Israel, to Abner son
Of Ner and to Amasa son
Of Jether, whom he killed and shed
The blood of war in peace instead,
And put the blood of war upon
His belt around his waist once drawn,

And on his shoes upon his feet.
6 "Do therefore by your wisdom and
Let not his grey head meet the *sand*
Of the grave in peace. 7 "But be good
To Barzillai's sons from the wood
Of Gilead, and let them be
Eating at your own table free,
For they came to my aid when I
Fled from your brother *on the sly*
From Absalom *in cunning try.*

8 "And see, there is with you Shimei
The son of Gera, Benjamite
Of Bahurim, who cursed my sight
With horrid curses on the day
When I went to Mahanaim's way,
But he came down to meet me at
Jordan, and I swore where he sat
By YHWH, saying, 'I will not put
You to death with the sword *on foot.*'

9 "Now therefore hold him not guiltless,
For you are a wise man *to guess*
And know what you should do to him,
But his grey head bring down *and dim*
To the grave with the blood of him."

Although I tell my daughter and her son
To keep the laws of Moses and be done,
I do not tell them of the ones who've
cursed

My grey head and tried to do me their
worst.

It's of no use, Beloved, among the weak
And powerless to proclaim wrong and seek
The vengeance on the wicked for their
wrong.

That is for the wealthy alone as song.
It's no use, my Beloved, to stand and wait
For You to bring the wicked to their fate.
While Your grief is greater than I could
make,

Your mercy always trembles in the wake.
So there's naught left but suffer and forget
The crown of thorns and all the rogues I've
met.

10 So David slept with his fathers,
And was buried *as it occurs*
In David's city *with all stirs.*

11 And David reigned in Israel
For forty years, and seven to tell
He reigned in Hebron, and three years
And thirty in Jerusalem.

12 Then Solomon, *as it appears*,
Sat on the throne in David's *hem*
Who was his father, and his reign
Was well established *to regain*.

Beloved, I long to have lived on the soil
Where David reigned in forty years of toil.
I'd like to hear in my reality
The token of his harp in psalmistry.
Instead I find my way to where he sings
In dreams and visions when the night takes
wings

And carries me up to the brazen hill
Where his voice sounds resounding silver
still.

Beloved, I wish that I might find the throne
Upon which David sits and when I've
shown

My plaint upon the walls that bear him up,
To take to my lips alabaster cup
And drink the mead that tells the vision
grand

That You, Beloved, on shepherd boy once
planned.

13 Then Adonijah Haggith's son
Came to Bathsheba *on the run*
Who was mother of Solomon.
And she said "Do you come in peace?"
And he said "In peace *for release*."

14 He said further "I've aught to say
To you." And she said "Have your way."

15 And he said "You know that the seat
Of kingdom was mine, and the meet
Of all Israel had set the face
In my favour to reign in place,
And yet the kingdom's turned about
And become my brother's devout,
For it was his from YHWH's look-out.

16 "And now I ask of you one thing,
Do not deny me." Replying
She said "Say on." 17 And he said "Speak,
Please, to Solomon, go and seek
From him because he'll not say no
To you, that he give me a go
At having Abishag as wife,
The Shunammite with wedding fife."

Adonijah is like contemporary,
Well-fraught with self-esteem to mind the
berry.

If one kingdom is lost, no matter now,

He'll pluck the cherry from Abishag's
bough.

There's no harm in trying, such say when
they

Set aside pride and wonder for the day
And stride into the glory for a smile
And pretend all is done and without guile.
Success and not reluctance at the tower
Is for the man who grasps the fatal hour.
Beloved, I lend my hand to smaller things
That do not catch the eye of new-clad
kings.

Let Adonijah join the cheap and crass
And I shall wait for You till his times pass.

18 And Bathsheba said "Well, I'll speak
To the king for the thing you seek."

19 Bathsheba therefore went in to
The king Solomon with the view
Of speaking to him for *the thing*
Adonijah *brought to the king*.

20 Then she said "I desire one small
Petition of you at your call,
Don't tell me no." And the king said
To her, "Just ask, mom, do not read
That I will tell you no instead."

21 And she said "Then let Abishag
Be given as Adonijah's hag,
To your brother as wife *in bag*."

22 King Solomon answered and said
To his mother, "Why were you led
To ask Abishag Shunammite
For Adonijah *in my sight*?
Ask for him the kingdom also,
For he's my elder brother, so
Too for Abiathar the priest,
And for Joab *who was not least*
The son of Zeruiah's *feast*."

Which of these too is foolish in Your sight,
The mother preyed upon or the up-tight
King who is angry at a small request?
Tell me, Beloved, which of these did her
best?

How many times the rogues come to my
fame

And ask a service as though not in blame,
And I go out to foot the bill and stake?

How often do I make the same mistake
As Solomon whose anger jumped to life
Like a dog sleeping just before the strife?
Beloved, let sleeping dogs fly in the wind

And tell me quickly before I have sinned
That Adonijah's knocking at my door.
Let me not answer, though he knock a
score.

23 King Solomon swore by YHWH, said
"God do me in and more than read,
If Adonijah did not speak
This word against his own life weak.
24 "Now therefore as YHWH lives who set
Me on the throne established yet
Of David my father, and who
Has made me a house by His cue,
This very day Adonijah
Shall *swing and* meet his death *by law*.

Here's just one more occasion for the weak
Hand of a king to set his kingdom sleek
By doing in an example to stir
The hearts of subjects, let their fear incur
Disdain of those who love democracy.
No government is so outright friendly.
All have a scapegoat by which fear arises
In populace, the rag-assed jock despises.
There is no place in some society
Where soul can grow to grandeur and to
see

The hope of Your creation at its peak.
You who invented both the oak and teak
Could not polish the body nor the soul
Of humankind before the barber pole.

25 King Solomon sent by the hand
Of Benaiah son in command
Of Jehoiada, and he fell
On him so he died *at the knell*.

26 And to Abiathar the priest
The king said "Get to Anathoth,
To your own fields and their increased,
For you are worthy now of death,
But I will not now execute
You, because you carried to boot
The ark of the Lord YHWH before
David my father and the store
Of his afflictions shared the more.

All kingdoms are established in the wake
Of fratricide, the only course to take.
One can neglect it, but when one does so,
One's own brother will come to steal the
show

And lodge a dagger in the heart to last.

No, fratricide is surely never past
As long as kingdoms and nations have
those

Who rule the masses and come to dispose
Of wealth and transportation and the songs
Taught to the school children with chimes
and gongs.

The new king must have officers both new
And fresh, favourable, above all true
To the new king instead of to the old.
Who rules the nation must kill and be bold.

27 So Solomon threw out the priest
Abiathar before YHWH's feast,
That he might carry out the word
Of YHWH which He spoke as when stirred
Against the house of Ali in
Shiloh *for judgement and for sin*.

I cannot help but find here in this word
Hypocrisy for what once more occurred
In justifying what's expedient
But record to a prophecy well spent.
You might have forgiven the house that
lost

It's favour because of two sons embossed
With their corruption, such does not mean
that

Their offspring too will wickedly get fat.
Is not the visitation of the dad
And what he did for evil and for bad
Limited to generations in three
Or four at most? Here You do wonderfully.
But Solomon needs prophecy to make
Good on his kingdom and enlarge his
stake.

28 The news came to Joab, for he
Joab had turned in treachery
After Adonijah, though he
Did not turn after Absalom.
And Joab fled *ad libitum*
Into YHWH's tent and caught hold on
The horns of the altar *up drawn*.

29 And it was told king Solomon
That Joab had fled to the tent
Of YHWH, and see, *where the man went*
By the altar. Then Solomon
Sent Benaiah Jehoiada's son,
Saying "Go kill him, *have it done*."

If I've a shred of pity for the fate

Of Abiathar at the temple gate,
 And if I disdain Adonijah's way
 Of self-serving along the royal play,
 I find less pity, more disdain for this
 Captain of the guard who had gone amiss.
 Joab indeed killed two men in cold blood.
 I only ask why David when the flood
 Was fresh did not enquire upon the guilt?
 The truth is Joab knew to joust and tilt
 And was of use to David to the hilt.
 Beloved, I share the condemnation sought,
 But still doubt purity of motives bought.
 But what am I to give the song a lift?

30 And Benaiah came to the tent
 Of YHWH and said when he was sent,
 "The king says 'Come out.'" But he said
 "No, I would rather have this bed."
 And Benaiah brought back the word
 To the king and said *what occurred*,
 "So says Joab who answered me."
 31 And the king said to him, "Do what
 He wants, and fall upon his gut
 And bury him and take away
 The innocent blood from the way
 Joab killed from me and the room
 Of my father *for Joab's doom*.

How does the vengeance dealt upon the
 head
 Of the guilty gainsay the benefit
 That the crown obtained from the battle lit
 By Joab after he had made his bed?
 The heathen superstition that the spread
 Of blood in execution makes all fit
 Is awful and atrocious where I sit.
 Atonement by death makes my eyes see
 red.
 But what I think is not a care at all.
 I come to You, Beloved, and ask reprieve
 From pagan watches that would break the
 scroll.
 No sacrifice of blood can fill the wall
 Or close the breach once it has torn the
 sleeve.
 Stones, needle, thread and sweat repair the
 soul.

32 "And YHWH shall return his blood on
 His own head, who had fallen on
 Two men more righteous than he was
 And better too, and in his claws

Killed them with the sword, while my dad
 David did not know that he had,
 Abner the son of Ner and chief
 Of Israel's army to his grief
 And Amasa son of Jether,
 Chief of Judah's army *and pure*.
 33 "Their blood shall therefore return on
 The head of Joab, and upon
 The head of his seed to endure,
 But on David and on his seed
 And on his house and on indeed
 His throne shall there be peace for aye
 From YHWH for ever *by and by*."
 34 Benaiah Jehoiada's son
 Went up and fell on him when done
 And killed him, and they buried him
 In his own house in desert *dim*.

Beloved, I thank You that I have no place
 As civil servant in this year of grace.
 For civil servants obey orders now
 As they did under Solomon's grim brow.
 Beloved, I thank You that monopoly
 Of power is something I shall never see,
 For bloody hand is bloody hand's degree
 No matter who tells one to lift the sword.
 Some kill no doubt just because they are
 bored,
 And today only those and the outraged
 Are stricken for their deeds when they are
 paged.
 Those who obey their orders are applauded
 For all the bloody soaked lands they've
 marauded.
 The civil servant's faithful, ripe and aged.

1 Kings 3

1 Solomon made a treaty with
 Pharaoh king of Egypt for kith
 To take Pharaoh's daughter and brought
 Her to David's city and lot
 Until he finished building his
 Own house, also YHWH's house *to sizz*
 And the wall of Jerusalem
 Around about it *for a hem*.
 2 Only the folk sacrificed on
 The high places, since none had drawn
 A house for the name of YHWH till
 Those very days *upon the hill*.
 3 And Solomon loved YHWH and walked
 In the laws his dad David talked,
 Only he sacrificed and burnt

Incense in high places *unlearned*.
 And the king went to Gibeon
 To sacrifice there, since it's drawn
 A great high place there, and he set
 A thousand burnt offerings to get,
 Did Solomon upon the altar.
 5 In Gibeon YHWH without falter
 Appeared to Solomon who dreamed
 At night and God said "Ask me what
 I shall give you *in wealth to glut*."

Is Gibeon one of the high place sites
 Where in days past idolatry for spites
 Arose and flourished to be put to rights
 By righteous prophets and kings flying
 kites?
 So Solomon worshipped You in the place
 Where Canaanite chose to worship
 disgrace,
 And in that did not stray from the path
 chosen
 By centuries of Christians in their hosen.
 The thing is overlooked by You it seems,
 Although it no doubt led the folk to dreams
 Of Baal, yet there was precedent and holy
 In Abraham who never built place lowly
 For sacrifice. Beloved, You answer prayer
 Addressed to You anytime, anywhere.

6 And Solomon said "You have shown
 Your servant David on the throne
 Great mercy according to how
 He acted toward You in the prow
 Of truth, and in his righteousness,
 And in heart uprightness to bless
 With You, and You have kept for him
 This great kindness, that You not grim
 Have given a son to him to sit
 On his throne as this day *and fit*.
 7 "And now, YHWH my Alohim, You
 Have made Your servant king on cue
 Instead of my dad David true,
 And I'm a little child, I do
 Not know to go out or come in.
 8 "And your servant is in the bin
 Of Your people that You have chosen,
 A great folk that cannot *for hosen*
 Be numbered or counted for crew.
 9 "So give Your servant a wise heart
 To judge Your people on Your part,
 To distinguish between the good
 And the bad, for who ever could

Judge this Your so great multitude?"

You never came to me, Beloved, to ask
 What wealth I desired for my faithful task.
 And yet I think if You had given me
 The choice to own what of the world
 freely,
 I might have chosen just this square and
 place
 Where I have so heartily sought Your face.
 I might have chosen just these forest trails,
 And just these granite boulders with their
 grails,
 And just these justling crags of quartzite
 drawn
 Across the blushing countenance of dawn.
 I might have chosen just this garden well
 And this nasturtium-covered citadel.
 I might have asked the wisdom to come
 late
 To bless my hands and feet and balding
 pate.

10 And what he said pleased YHWH
 because
 Solomon asked for such in paws.
 11 And God told him, "Because you've
 asked
 This thing and have not rather basked
 In begging for yourself long life,
 Nor asked for wealth *to sound of fife*,
 Nor begged Me kill your enemies,
 But asked to understand decrees
 Of judgement, 12 "see then, I have done
 According to your words begun,
 And see, I give you in your heart
 Understanding, so no man's part
 Before you nor after you can
 Rise up to stand before your plan.
 13 "And I have also given you
 The things you didn't ask Me to,
 Both wealth and honour, so there'll not
 Be any kings like you in plot
 All the days of your life and lot.
 14 "And if you'll just walk in My ways
 To keep My statutes and the maze
 Of My commandments as your dad
 David did walking, then I'll pad
 With length *and strength* all of your days."

Is long life blessing? For some it is not.
 For those who suffer in the planting plot

Long life is burdensome, and then some
 caught
 In old-age sins had better meet the rot
 In youth and rest in righteous grave
 unsought.
 Is long life blessing? Perhaps when it runs
 Its course in the commandments and in
 tons
 Of honour to both mom and dad that stuns
 The lookers on who say that simpletons
 Must earn respect and honour with their
 guns.
 Beloved, I want no long life, but today
 The life that is led in Your guiding way
 Until I find the last field and last ray
 That takes me to the place where I shall
 stay.

15 And Solomon woke up and see
 It was a dream. And so then he
 Came to Jerusalem and stood
 Before ark of covenant *good*
 Of YHWH and offered up the burnt
 Sacrifices *as he had learnt*,
 And peace offerings, and made a feast
 For all his servants *great to least*.

Beloved, I'm not sure I would trust a
 dream.
 Why did You not appear outright in
 scheme
 To give the man assurance of the trust
 That You had in him, though made of the
 dust?
 The fact is You always leave room to
 doubt
 And cast a shadow on thinking about.
 There is no certainty, and yet men come
 To offer sacrifice to You and strum
 The harp and guitar in Your praise
 unknown.
 They come before Your great and unseen
 throne.
 Beloved, give me no dreams, for I shall fail
 To take them in the way that I'd prevail.
 If You cannot be seen, then be not seen
 And I shall struggle to maintain the mean.

16 Then there came two women, harlots
 Before the king and stood for plots.
 17 And one woman said "O my lord,
 I and this woman share one board,

And I gave birth to boy with her
 In the house. 18 "And it did occur
 On the third day after I had
 The baby, this woman unclad
 Also had a child, and we were
 Together, no stranger to stir
 With us in the house, just the two
 Of us in the house, there so few.
 19 "And this woman's child in the night
 Died because she lay on the mite.
 20 "And she got up at midnight and
 Took my son from beside my hand
 While your handmaid lay there asleep,
 And took my son from arms to keep,
 And laid him on her breast to rest
 And laid her dead son on my breast.
 21 "And in the morning when I rose
 To suckle my child, see the pose
 Was dead, but when I saw the thing
 In the morning, see regarding
 It was not my son that took wing."
 22 And the other woman said "No,
 But the living's my son and so
 The dead is your son." But she said
 "No, your son is the one that's dead,
 And the living is mine instead."
 So they spoke before the king's row.

I come to You, Beloved, and bring the
 claim
 Of children that I've born to bear my name
 And children that I've slain once in my
 sleep,
 And children that I've held up safe to keep.
 And as I join the milling throng before
 Your throne, Beloved, though pushed back
 to the door,
 I raise my voice to join the clamour that
 Cries justice, justice before where You sat.
 Beloved, though I am nothing more to
 share
 The board and bait beneath the earth's
 bright care
 Than any other harlot at the gate,
 Still I stand here and for Your justice wait.
 Beloved, in wisdom come investigate
 The truth of what I say or not relate.

23 Then said the king, "The one says 'This
 Is my son alive, and you kiss
 The dead,' and the other one says
 'No, rather your son's lived his days

While my son is one living still.””

24 Then the king spoke up with a will,
“Bring me a sword.” And so they brought
A sword before the king who sought.
25 And the king said “Divide the child
Alive in two and reconciled
Give half to the one and the half
To the other *like fattened calf.*”

Who knows who started this relation of
Wisdom in judgement as described above?
But Solomon, it seems he was the first,
And yet the verdict was never the worst,
For Ali too once brought it out to bear
When two women came to him with their
share

Of stories for his judgement in their case.
The child divided has become a race.
Beloved, let wisdom once begun in that
Fair word that people heard where the king
sat

Cover the world with comfort for the true,
Even if they are now resigned and few.
And I shall stand with sword drawn if You
will
To break down the oppression of the till.

26 Then the woman whose child it was
Spoke up to the king for the cause
That her pity yearned on her son,
And she said “O my lord, be done
To give her the live child and do
Not in any case kill curlew.”
But the other one spoke *instead*,
“Let it be neither mine nor bred
For you, but divide *limb and head.*”
27 Then the king answered and said “Give
Her the living child, let it live,
She is the mother of it.” 28 And
All Israel heard the king’s command
In judgement as he judged, and they
Feared the king, for they saw the way
God’s wisdom was in him to do
Justice to Israel and crew.

The judgement has gone stale. Beloved, the
light
Of Solomon is known in every fight.
Today the guilty are more cunning far
At demonizing innocence with tar.
The newspaper and television start
The reputation of the knave and tart

Before the evidence has come to light.
If evidence appears, by then the sight
Is too late to save any from the harm.
Beloved, lift up Your great and saving arm,
For that is all that can today prevent
The judgement by the fire and water vent.
The witch trial is the only way men know
To deal with others, the pyre and its glow.

1 Kings 4

1 So king Solomon was the king
Over all Israel reigning.
2 And these were the princes he had,
Azariah the son and lad
Of Zadok the priest, 3 Elihoreph,
And Ahiah, sons of Shisha
Scribes, and recorder and still more if
We count Jehoshaphat the son
Of Ahilud, 4 And Benaiah
The son of Jehoiada won
Over the army, and Zadok
And Abiathar of the flock
Of priests, 5 and Azariah son
Of Nathan over officers,
And Zabud Nathan’s son occurs
As principal officer and
The king’s friend *set at his right hand.*
6 And Ahishar over household,
And Adoniram the son bold
Of Abda over the tribute,
All of these great men in suite.

The son of Zadok. Well, the generations
Go in for inherited posts’ elations.
It’s safer to take on the progeny
Of civil servants to collect in fee
Than to take on an unknown quantity
In bringing farm-lads to the court to bask.
That was Saul’s real mistake, he had to ask
Whose son the stripling was who deigned
to come
Against Goliath and kill him to strum
A harp the rest of the day under sun
Beside the sheep when the foul deed was
done.

Beloved, You seem to stick with safe and
known
In letting the world go as it is prone.
I would have invented another gun.

7 Solomon had twelve officers
Over all Israel to provide

Victuals for king and all *that stirs*
 In his household, each man did
 His month in turn around *the lid*
Of one year in provision's bid.
 8 And these are their names: son of Hur
 In mount Ephraim. 9 And Ben-Dekar
 In Makaz, and in Shaalbim,
 And Bethshemesh, Elon bethhanan.
 10 Hesed's son in Aruboth, *man*
 To whom was Sochoh, and to him
 All the land of Hephher *to scan.*
 11 Son of Abinadab in all
 The region of Dor and its stall,
 Who had as wife Taphath daughter
 Of Solomon *and to confer.*

Even in Your grand lodge and church,
 Beloved,
 The hand of nepotism comes ungloved.
 The son-in-law of the king always wins
 A place beside the altar, by the bins
 Of gemstones caught and polished to a
 shine.
 The son-in-law of king always drinks wine.
 Give me no benefice of bishop's seat,
 Give me no place in parliament to greet
 The mouth of the corrupt with a word
 sweet.
 I look instead for pine-cone and wild vine.
 Beloved, though Your chosen to represent
 You on this earth cannot escape the bent
 Of favourites, I still return to You
 In anarchy to find the royal view.

12 Baana the son of Ahilud
 With Taanach and Megiddo's *crude*
 And all Bethshean by Zartanah
 Below Jezreel out from *the raw*
 Bethshean to Abelmeholah,
 To beyond Jokneam *for a straw.*

Sweet excellence or coriander luck
 Seem to be the meaning of the strange
 puck
 Of Megiddo, and yet I doubt the twain,
 And figure looking at the word is vain.
 The failing vanity goes down to be
 The railing mourning of a patient's fee
 Or sweeter meadow of her dance to rest
 On Abelmeholah's comforting breast.
 Your word, Beloved, as soon I come to
 stand

Outside the ten words of Your loved
 command,
 Is filled with bright and darkness, swirling
 mist
 To lose my way in what I found and
 kissed.

13 The son of Geber in Ramoth
 Of Gilead to him were both
 The towns of Jair who was the son
 Of Manasseh, which are begun
 In Gilead, to him the place
 Of Argob, which of Bashan's race
 There are sixty great cities there
 With *stony* wall and brazen bar.
 14 Ahinadab son of Iddo
 With Mahanaim *for the kiddo.*
 15 Ahimaaz in Naphtali, he
 Also took Basmath, daughter *see*
 Of Solomon as wife *to be.*

The question I ask now is why the king
 Solomon ever came to do the thing.
 He gave his daughter such a name to wear
 That I'd be shamed to have her in my care.
 Basmath means desolation in my book,
 And devastation everywhere I look.
 If I were the princess, I'd change my name
 And rid myself of mom's and my dad's
 shame.
 Beloved, I do not know by what thing said
 In darkness and in secret at the bed
 Of my conceiving gave me name at birth.
 I do not know what You whisper in worth
 In memory of me, and yet I know
 By what names I lift up Your power and
 glow.

16 Baanah the son of Hushai in
 Asher and in Aloth *for bin.*
 17 Jehoshaphat Paruah's son
 In Issachar *for all he won.*
 18 Shimei the son of Elah in
The populace of Benjamin.
 19 Geber the son of Uri in
 The country of Gilead's win,
 The country of Sihon the king
 Of Amorites and of Og king
 Of Bashan, and the only sting
 Who in the land was *gathering.*

In every time and place a prophet stands,

In every country held beneath his hands,
Whether as king or hidden ruler of
The hidden ones who look to You in love,
There are twelve princes decked and sealed
sweet

To witness to Your name and always greet
Both sun and cart that graces market street.
So Solomon too appoints twelve men meet.
Beloved, I search the record of the past
To find the blessed names and hold them
fast

In heart and tongue that my hand might
employ
Their counsel in my actions to my joy.
Hidden or shown, the twelve whirl on to
make
The world a better place and for Your sake.

20 Judah and Israel *were* many,
And like the sand beside the sea
For multitude, and eating and
Drinking and enjoying *the land*.
21 And Solomon reigned over all
Kingdoms from the river to pall
Of the land of the Philistines,
And to Egypt's border in vines,
And they brought tribute and they served
Solomon all his days unswerved.
22 Solomon's victuals for one day
Was thirty kors in fine flour's *way*,
And sixty kors of meal *to sway*,
23 Ten fat oxen and twenty more
Out of the pastures, so a score,
And then a hundred sheep, beside
Stags, gazelles, roebuck to abide
What fattened fowl *cackled and cried*.
24 For he reigned over all this side
Of the river from Tiphseh's *pride*
To Gaza, over all the kings
On this side of the river *wings*.
And He had peace on all sides round
About him *from the people's sound*.

The banquet never stops beneath the sun,
Despite the rivers filled with blood that run
From Basrah upstream far as Babylon.
The divine feast goes on despite the fire
That burns the innocent at wealth's desire
Before which righteous men would fain
retire.
The divine concert and the living speech

That binds the human heart each one to
each
Is never finish with or without peach.
The festival of angel and of men
Springs from the hidden forest and the glen
To dowse the cry of pain now and again.
Beloved, the reign of Solomon's increase
Continues under canopy's release.

25 And Judah and Israel safely
Lived each man under his fig tree
And under vine from Dan clear to
Beersheba all Solomon's due.
26 Solomon had forty thousand
Stall of horses for chariots' hand
And twelve thousand horsemen *to stand*.
27 And those officers did provide
Victuals for king Solomon's side,
And for all who came to the board
Of king Solomon, each man shored
In his own month, they lacked no stored.
28 Barely also and straw replete
For horses and donkeys both fleet
They brought to the place where they were,
Every man as his charge infer.

The hidden warriors of Your pomp and
train
Come out when needed to battle the vain,
And secret sentinals rise on the walls
To warn the failing traveller by their calls.
The military clout that would stand up
Before Your unseen armies like a tup
Falls down at the last moment when You
rise
Invisibly beyond both star and skies.
Beloved, the hope of centuries is cast
In the engraven footprint come to last
From the chosen one's horse as it arose
And found the secret place of heart's
repose.
From this height of seeing I look out on
A world destroyed and safe beneath the
dawn.

29 And Alohim gave Solomon
Wisdom and understanding won
And greatness of heart as the sand
That lies between the sea and land.
30 And Solomon's wisdom excelled
The wisdom of all those who dwelled
In the east country, and all *great*

Wisdom that was in Egypt *late*.

31 For he was wiser than all men,
Than Ethan the Ezrahite then
And Heman, and Chalcol, Darda,
The sons of Mahol, held in awe
Was his fame in all nations round.

The wondrous thing is that wisdom
profound

Was recognized by any folk around.
More like today the ones we think are wise
Are just the bait of vicious, buzzing flies.
The truly wise are hidden from the view
Of those whose nose is fixed upon the few
That television raises to estate.

I spit upon the wise and shining pate.
Beloved, I searched with car and bus and
train

For wisdom in the world, I searched in vain
Until I found the ink scratch of Your word
And delved into its secrets undeterred.
The gem I know is rarely taken out
Before the crowds and acclaimed with a
shout.

32 And he spoke three thousand *of sound*
Proverbs, and his songs numbered to
A thousand and five, *not a few*.

33 And he spoke all about the trees
From cedar tree that knows the breeze
Of Lebanon down to the low
Hyssop that from the wall may grow.
He also spoke of beasts and fowl,
Of creeping things, fishes *and owl*.

The wisest of all men spoke mainly of
The lowly things of nature in his love.
The voice of ant gave meaning to the ear
That followed the brief paths taught by
Your fear.

The whisper of the trees from Lebanon
Down to the fields of Beersheba anon
Gave breath to wise words written on the
soul

Of one who sought it from its truest goal.
Though I may be not wise, nor of this
world

Nor of the depth of spirit unseen furled,
I too follow the steps of Solomon
To find what wise things I seek in the drum
Of hidden songs of birch and fir that come
At the sunrise in a winter empearled.

34 From all the nations round there came
Folk to hear Solomon's great fame
Of wisdom, from all kings of earth
Who had heard of his wisdom's worth.

35 And Solomon took for himself
Pharoah's daughter as wife *and elf*,
And brought her to David's city
Until he'd finished his decree
To build the house of YHWH to be,
And his own house, and wall to see
Around Jerusalem's city.

For ages men have wondered that the king
Would take Pharoah's daughter, wife under
wing.

Some think he felt the need to make a pact
Of peace through the matrimonial act.
Some think he was attracted by the meat
Of heathen girls instead of what was sweet.
Some think the lady fought to get his smile
Attracted by his wisdom, without guile
Repented of her young idolatry
And embraced You in all Your
sovereignty.

The lovers think she loved him and when
he

Found her he also loved her for her claim
To wisdom and to beauty and the flame
Of faith in You instead of trinity.

1 Kings 5

1 And Hiram king of Tyre sent on
His servants up to Solomon,
For he'd heard they'd anointed him
King in his father's interim,
For Hiram always loved David.

2 And Solomon sent Hiram bid,
Saying 3 "You know David my dad
Could not build a house, *it was sad*,

To name of YHWH his Alohim
Because the wars came in between,
Until YHWH set them under feet,
4 "But now YHWH my Alohim's treat

To me is rest on every side,
So neither foe nor fiend abide,

5 "And see I intend now to build
A house to the *great* name instilled
Of YHWH my Alohim as spoke
YHWH to David my dad in stroke,
Saying 'Your son, whom I will set
On your throne instead of you met,

He shall build a house to My name.’
 6 “So now command them *with acclaim*
 To cut me cedar trees *of fame*
 From Lebanon, and my servants
 Shall be with your servants *to dance*,
 And I will give the price of each
 Of your servants that come in reach
 According to the price you set,
 For you know that there’s none to get
 With skill among us to cut trees
 As the Sidonians *in degrees*.”

Hiram loved David much and so he sent
 His blessings upon Solomon who lent
 The throne of David fresh blood and new
 ways.
 He probably would have had the same days
 If Adonijah had mounted the throne.
 So friendship in this world’s a thing alone
 Of chance and who gets what position
 known.
 It is not set on deep affinity
 Nor on justice or loving sanity.
 Give me no friends at all, Beloved, if they
 Are friends because of the imperial sway
 Of circumstance! Give me companions that
 Reflect to me the beauty where You’re at,
 Divinity in human eye that sat.

8 And Hiram sent to Solomon,
 Saying “I’ve considered things *done*
 Which you sent me for, I will do
 What you want in cedar wood too,
 And in fir wood *as by your due*.

Cedar and fir, not specially hard wood,
 Through fragrant for a while in cupboard
 stood,
 And flammable beyond the crackling dare
 Of briars in the sheepfold, Lord beware.
 I would have built of oak, but that’s
 because
 Of British blood and Saxon in my claws,
 And having many centuries of living
 What Appalachian mountain woods are
 giving.
 Beloved, I build my temple not of oak
 Nor cedar, but of flesh and at the stroke
 Of living blood that courses in my veins.
 Beloved, I build a weaker house for gains,
 For in my house ascends the voices of

The Psalms in praise to You and in Your
 love.

9 “My servants shall bring them down
 from
 Lebanon to the sea in sum,
 And I will transport them by sea
 In floats to the place you set me,
 And cause them to unload them there,
 And you shall get them and to spare,
 Just give my household food in share.”

Beloved, see what agreement reigns at last
 Between two kings whose friendship is one
 cast
 In commerce rather than in wars of state.
 Let that be lesson to those come of late
 Whose economic world is made for war
 And settling matters tit for tat and score.
 Who think that violence is plague of man
 Not to avoid do what we ever can
 Is plague himself, for archaeology
 Shows there has been long-term society
 Where never arm nor lock was once
 employed.
 A thousand years without weapon enjoyed
 Is possible where men barter instead
 Of hitting each other over the head.

10 So Hiram gave to Solomon
 Cedar trees and fir trees in sum.
 11 And Solomon gave Hiram kor
 To twenty thousand in wheat store
 To feed his household and on top
 Of that twenty kor of the crop
 Of beaten oil, so year by year.

A kor of oil, a kor of wheat well spent
 Suffices to make right the wear and rent
 Between humankind when the word is sent.
 So Hiram gave to Solomon what he
 Wanted to set his loving heart in glee,
 And Solomon gave Hiram food and store
 To feed his servants on the hill and shore
 Until no hand or mouth there wanted more.
 Beloved, exchange in fair exchange with
 me
 The treasures of Your giving field and tree
 As I look out upon the morning wood
 To find Your fading tracks where squirrels
 should

Be hiding what they too need for their
sport
Of mealtime instead of defending fort.

A kor of water is all that I need
To bury body like the planter's seed
In the grave of ablution to regain
The purity that You want to maintain.
Of course that also implies I have been
Circumcised or purified from the din
Of menstuous flow, whichever case may
be.

A kor of water clean to sight's decree
And without adverse taste or smell to show
Corruption of water not on the go.
Beloved, a kor of water or of wine
Is all a man needs to be feeling fine.
Beloved, a kor no more nor less to measure
To me and You the sharing of Our treasure.

12 And YHWH gave Solomon to be
Wise and He promised him in fee,
And there was peace twixt Hiram and
Solomon and they made pact stand.
13 And king Solomon raised levy
From all Israel in number's fee
To thirty thousand men's decree.
14 And he sent them to Lebanon,
Ten thousand a month by their turn,
A month they were in Lebanon,
Two months at home with what they earn,
And Adonirom ruled what's done.
15 Solomon had seventy thousand
That carried loads, eighty thousand
Cutters in the mountain, 16 Beside
The chief of Solomon's *relied*
On officers over the work,
Three thousand and three hundred lurk
Over the folk who did the work.

Administration's not something a fool
Can do without, though wielding hand and
tool.

Solomon set an army in that bid
To make up three thousand and three
hundred.
So many deans and secretaries loiter
To make things run smoothly and some
adroiter!

And yet the ratio of administration
To faculty and staff in God's own nation
Is nearly one to fifty, so let's fire

The drones that make academies desire
And companies at loss to produce what
The people need to fill the mind and gut.
Beloved, Your word is where to find
solution
To every form of hubristic pollution.

17 And the king commanded to bring
Great stones, and costly stones *in ring*,
And carved stones to lay the foundation
Of the house of *YHWH with elation*.
18 And Solomon's builders and those
Of Hiram hewed them and arose
The stonesquarers, and they prepared
Timber and stone to build the squared.

I could have given Solomon advice
Had I been there to tell him what thing nice
I saw just yesterday, a house built of
Blocks of blue spectrolite, a thing to love.
The man who owned the house owned also
quarry,
So he could afford extravagance starry,
And build his cottage of a precious stone.
Too bad that Solomon did not know where
To quarry such a stone as that and rare.
It's only to be found here under pine
And fir and birch in Finland's crystalline.
Beloved, stop roaming and stop Your vain
search:
Beauty lies under foot of Finnish birch.

1 Kings 6

It happened in the *fateful* year
Four hundred and eighty *by ear*
Since Israel's children had come out
Of land of Egypt and redoubt,
In the fourth year that graced the reign
Of Solomon to Israel's *gain*
In month of Ziv which is second
Month, that he began from the fund
To build the house of YHWH *that stunned*.

The month of Ziv is mentioned only here.
I do not know what pagan source in gear
May have provided such a name as this.
The reader says it's brightness of the bliss
Of flowers come up in the desert spring,
The month when nature chooses how to
sing.
The burdens are all carried, placed in store,
The hammerless building of temple door

Begins as flower and beast meet with the
bird

To twist a melody that's only heard
Before the Pentecost, before the rate
Of summer come upon the generate.
Beloved, enter the temple when it's done
To find a bit of shade from burning sun.

2 The house king Solomon built YHWH
Was sixty arm-lengths long and true
Twenty long and thirty high too.

The tiny temple Solomon was pleased
To build in Your honour was never eased
Between the sky scrapers that men need
now

To prove themselves the masters of the
how.

The tiny temple Solomon erected
In silence on the brow of hill elected
Would hardly make pavilion on the street
Beside a London park where new friends
meet.

Beloved, the small dimensions of the house
Reflect in home of raccoon and of mouse,
In fisher hut and in the ardent school
Of birds that nest above the freshet's pool,
In the dark chamber of my willing heart
Where You dwell in the Psalms come from
my part.

3 The foyer before the sanctum
Of the house, twenty lengths in sum
As wide as was the house in all.
4 And he made for the house in stall
Windows for light wider withal
Inwardly than outwardly tall.

5 Against the house wall he built there
Chambers all around about fair
Against the walls of the house round
The temple and oracle sound,
He made chamber round *on the ground*.

6 The lower chamber arm-lengths five
And middle six arm-lengths to thrive,
And the third seven arm-lengths in all,
For on the outside of the wall
He made narrow rest round about
So the beams when they're sticking out
Should not be stuck to the house wall.

7 While the house was under construction
Built of stone readied in production
Before it was brought to the spot,

So that there was no hammer got
Nor axe nor any iron tool
Heard in the house *by sage or fool*
While it was under works and wrought.

Throughout the world there are fond places
yet

Where buildings have with love and grace
been set

Without the sound of hammer and without
The iron tool or nail used for their clout.
The brazen cleat and wooden peg suffice
In those rare temples where divine advice
Found written in the human heart is true:
Some fail to take up arms and crushing
shoe.

The use of iron is spoiled by its abuse
In warfare and in battle to reduce
The world to tyranny. Beloved, Your king
Was son of peace and so I did this thing.
I meet You, my Beloved, without the
stroke

Of iron in blade or spear and set in oak.

8 The middle chamber door was set
In the right side of the house met,
And they went up with winding stairs
Into the middle, from which shares
They came into the third *bewares*.
9 He built the house and finished it,
And covered the house with beams fit
And boards of cedar *where they sit*.

Cover, Beloved, the stony chambers of
My heart with cedar boards carved out of
love.

Make the cold darkness of my heart's
moonscape
A shining light reflected to escape
My narrow bounds in glory where You
walk.

Finish my house in beams of cedar's share
And let the scent forever fill the air
Above the cliffs of granite and of chalk
That teach my feet to slow their pacing
there.

Beloved, seek out the middle chamber
where

I hide my treasures from the winding stair
To keep an altar met with praise to You.
Beloved, seek out the morning and its dew
In forest, lake and island come to view.

10 And built chambers by all the house
Five arm-lengths high *to keep out mouse*,
And they lay on the house wall till
Beams of cedar were there *to fill*.

11 There came a thing of YHWH to him,
To Solomon to tell him trim.

12 “As for this house that you build here,
If you will walk and walk in fear
Of My statutes and execute
My ordinances and *to boot*

Keep all My commandments to walk
According to them, *not just talk*,
Then I’ll establish with you what
I told David your dad *clear-cut*.

13 “And I will dwell among the folk
Of Israel, and not give stroke
To forsake my folk Israel.”

A man would build with pin and groove in
stone
And make for You such glories for a
throne

Set up in polished wood and crystal ware.
But You, Beloved, do not ring in them
there.

A man would cut the rock and in his sweat
Make it a shining thing of love, and yet
The work of hand and heart can never fill
The place for You to stand on Zion’s hill.
Only obedience to You can make
The house a temple fitted for Your sake.
Only obedience, Beloved, is fit
To bring the human heart to where You sit.
Only the will subjected to Your own
Makes beauty in the path where weeds
have grown.

14 So Solomon built the house well
And finished it *after a spell*.

15 He covered the walls inside it
With cedar planks *sanded and fit*,
From the floor to the ceiling ties
All the surface with wood likewise,
And covered the floor of the place
With planks of fir or cypress’ *grace*.

Today we use panels in plywood set
Instead of solid planks Solomon let
Appear from floor to ceiling in the house,
The underside of wealth nibbled by mouse.
The solid virtues of our yesteryears

Have given place to hiding notes and fears.
The solid oak and cedar from which then
Grandfather made his furnishings again
Are now cut to a thin veneer or worse
In vinyl photograph replace with curse
The stolid form that once stayed on the
shelf.

Though I may live in plastic, let myself
Be still set in the virtues that You gave
On Sinai to rebel and escaped slave.

16 He built twenty arm-lengths upon
The sides of the house, and both on
The floor and the walls cedar board,
Building for himself where it shone
A most holy place *to the Lord*.

17 And the house, holy place before
It was forty arm-lengths *in score*.

18 The cedar of the house inside
Was caved with knops and open wide
Blossoms, all cedar, there was seen
No stone at all to intervene.

No stone at all was seen in edifice
That Solomon built up in artifice
Of carvings fruitful of the land of bliss.
No hard heart showed in Solomon to hurt
The feeble plant of Israel’s poorest skirt.
The gravings of wood gaily adorned all
With hope the sun and rain would find the
call

Of sparrow still ready to joy and thrall.
Forty arm-lengths about the shining door
Sufficed to greet the world with faith and
more.

Beloved, I smell the scented wood’s
perfume

As I enter into the sacred room
Of my own heart and temple to find there
Your memory and presence still are fair.

19 And the most holy place he made
In the house where the ark arrayed
Of covenant was set before
YHWH *the only One to adore*.

There is no place most holy but the one
Where Your commandments are hidden
from sun
Who would arise in human mind and heart
To usurp Your divinity with art.
There is no place most holy but where ark

Abides within its bosom close and stark
The tables of the law in blue engraved
That once coming from Egypt people
saved.

Beloved, the most holy place that I seek
Is in the heart of self where You will speak
From day to day and night to night Your
law

To keep me ever always in Your awe.
Beloved, the most holy place that I find
I filled with glory from You and Your
mind.

20 Before it was most holy place,
Twenty arm-lengths in length to face,
And twenty arm-lengths it was wide,
And twenty arm-lengths high *in stride*,
And that he overlaid with gold
In purity, with gold he rolled
The altar made of cedar mould.

The smallest place in all the house of
prayer
Is the most holy because You are there
In the words that You spoke on Mount
Sinai,
And in the holy name that You go by.
The smallest room in all the temple court
Could not contain fraction of a cohort,
But it contains the treasures that abound
In all the universe displayed around.
Beloved, I find the smallest seat and place
Away from the vast halls of pomp and
grace,
And in that priory where wings encase
The tables of Your law, I find reprieve
From contemplation of competing sleeve
And every sorrow at which I would grieve.

21 So Solomon encased the whole
House inside with pure gold *inscroll*,
And made a partition by chains
Of gold before most holy place,
And overlaid with gold the face.

The most holy place had its walls all set
In gold before the cherubim had met
Above the signal of Your presence there.
The inside of the place was the most fair.
The bodies that are temples built today
Are clothed on the outside with all the pay
Of gem and gold set off with fabrics taught

To reveal the surface of skinly plot.
Beloved, cover the inside of my heart
With gold of the obedience and art
Of love to You alone, and I shall be
A glory for Your sight alone to see
While what is outside seen of men remains
Without attraction, without human gains.

22 And the whole house as it contains
He overlaid with gold until
He finished the whole house and still
The whole altar beside the place
Most holy he made gold in trace.
23 Inside the most holy place he
Made two cherubs of olive tree,
Each one was ten arm-lengths in height,
And so he did the temple right.

The cherubim, Beloved, are taller than
I would have thought could fit so small a
span.

They fill the room and leave hardly the
space

To contain You if You appear in grace.
I speak with folly, forgive my poor jokes.
I know no space can contain divine yokes.
But here I learn, Beloved, that humble lace
Is enough for You and for sacred place.
Beloved, inside the most holy I see
The face of cherub made of olive tree,
And all around the glory rises up
To fill the soul with praise as with a cup.
The temple spires are Psalms that gather
round

And sanctify Your footprints on the
ground.

1 Kings 7

1 And Solomon for thirteen years
Built his own house, *and it appears*
He finished all his house *veneers*.
2 He built the house of Lebanese
Wood, a hundred arm-lengths in ease,
The width of it fifty arm-lengths,
Its height thirty arm-lengths for strengths,
Upon four rows of cedar pillars,
With cedar beams upon the pillars.
3 It was panelled with cedar there
Above the side rooms in their share
Of pillars there were forty-five,
Fifteen in each row *of the hive*.
4 And windows rising in three rows

Light against light three rows it glows.
5 And all the doors and posts *were* square,
Framing light against light three share.
6 And he made a pillar porch whose
Length was fifty arm-lengths and whose
Width was thirty arm-lengths and that
Porch was before them, and there sat
The pillars and the heavy beam
Before them *all as in a team*.

The king took thirteen years to build his
house
Ornately firm against the works of mouse.
In squares and threes the style of light and
shade
Work all together handsomely repaid
With porches, pillars, every heavy beam.
The house arises as though from a dream.
Beloved, I build my house, I've just begun
With fifty years behind me in the sun.
I have the plans before me and I set
Foundations in accordance with them yet.
The porches and the altars all in view
Surround the inner temple apercü.
The walls rise up before my dreaming eyes
To spires that comb with marble morning
skies.

7 Then he made a throne-room where he
Might judge in justice, righteously,
The porch of judgement covered by
Cedar in wall to wall *outvie*.
8 And his house where he lived had yet
Another court within the porch,
Which was of the same work and set.
Solomon also made *like torch*
A house for Pharaoh's daughter whom
He'd married, one just like this room.
9 All these expensive stones well cut
In measurement of stone unshut
From saws, within, without and from
Foundation to the copingdom
As far outside as to the great
Court. 10 The foundation was ornate
With stones, large stones of arm-lengths
ten
And some eight arm-lengths *there again*.

Some stones in the foundation measure to
Ten arm-lengths till they come on border
crew
Of stones as little as eight arm-lengths do.

All of these stones are great when in my
view.

Today the marble and the granite ware
Are often placed in panels for the glare
Of sun and state, while all the people there
Pretend the architecture's residue
Is greater than the ancients could construe.
The pride of those today who shoot the
knees

Out from under the civilized trapeze
I swear brings laughter cynical to wheeze.
Beloved, I sit upon foundation stone
And see Solomon there upon his throne.

11 Above were costly stones well hewn
By stone measure and cedars *strewn*.
12 And the great court set round about
With three rows of hewn stones and stout,
A row of cedar beams, both for
The inner court of YHWH's house *store*,
And for the house's porch *encore*.
13 King Solomon sent and brought out
Hiram from Tyre, *the one he sought*.
14 He was a widow's son of tribe
Of Naphtali, his father's bribe
Was to be a man of Tyre and
A worker in brass *on the land*,
And he was filled with wisdom and
With understanding, skilled to work
All labourings in brass *and dirk*.
15 And he came to king Solomon,
Did all his work *beneath the sun*.
And he cast two pillars of brass
Each one eighteen arm-lengths to pass
In height, a line of twelve arm-lengths
Surrounded both of them in strengths.

Beloved, I see that Solomon spoke fair
To his own friends and relatives to spare.
The king of Tyre was but an Israelite
And not a heathen in Solomon's sight.
The tribe of Dan is great upon the earth,
And held in David's esteem and in worth,
So Solomon did nothing in contrary
When he fostered his father's friend and
merry.

Beloved, I find my friends and counterparts
Among the pagan blokes, unesteemed farts.
There's nothing more to choose from and
be chary,
And so I walk in idolatrous arts.
Though my hands find the granite cut to be

Idol, I still bow to no Trinity.

16 He made two molten capitals
Of brass set on the citadels
Of the pillars, the height of each
Capital was five arm-lengths' reach,
And so the height the other one
Came to was five arm-lengths *when done*.
17 And nets of checker work and wreaths
Of chain work *that looks like it breathes*,
For capitals on pillar tops,
Seven for one capital drops,
And for the other seven too.
18 And he made the pillars, and two
Rows round about upon the one
Network to cover when it's done
The capitals that were upon
The top with pomegranates, and
The other capital in hand.
19 The capitals that were on top
Of the pillars of lily fop
In the porch were four arm-lengths' band.
20 And the capitals on the two
Pillars also above, up to
The underside which was to do
With the network and the pomegranates,
Two hundred in rows, *marbles, granites*,
Round on the other capital.
21 And he set up the pillars in
The porch of the temple to win,
And he set up the pillar right,
And called the name thereof Jachin,
And he set up the pillar left,
And called its name Boaz *when cleft*.

Trying to read the meanings of those
names
Of Jachin and Boaz seem through the
flames
Of my love and my will to obey You,
Beloved, in everything I say and do,
It seems the one means the prepared while
that
Other pillar's unflinching where it sat.
Prepared, unflinching let me ever be
As those two pillars that one then could see
Crowning Your temple porch. Beloved, let
me
Be such in the small temple of my heart.
Established in strength let me do my part
In building the invisible palace
Of praise before Your ever hidden face,

Palace of grace and praise, of praise and
grace.

22 On the pillars' top lily work,
In pillars' work they did not shirk.
He made the sea of molten work
Ten arm-lengths in diameter
All round about, its height *to stir*
Was five arm-lengths, and the line of
Its circumference *as seen above*
Was thirty arm-lengths *as it were*.
24 Under its brim and all around
Were knops surrounding it and found
Ten in an arm-length, surrounding
The sea the knops were cast in ring
Of two rows when they cast the thing.
25 It stood upon twelve oxen, three
Looking toward the north to see,
And three facing toward the west,
And three looking toward south to rest,
And three facing east, and the sea
Was set above on them to be,
And all their back sides stayed beneath.
26 It was a handbreadth thick beneath,
And the brim of it was turned down
Like the brim of a cup *to crown*
With lily blossoms, and when full
It held two thousand baths *in pool*.
27 And he made ten bases of brass,
Four arm-lengths in length was the pass
Of each base, and four arm-lengths wide,
And three arm-lengths in height beside.
28 And the bases' work was like this:
They'd borders, ones that did not miss
Between the ledges. 29 And upon
The borders between ledges drawn
Were lions, oxen, cherubs, above
There was a base, and beneath of
The lions and oxen were set
More additions of thin work yet.

The lion lies down with the ox to find
The cherubim look on them, calm and
kind,
While I am busy with my churning
thoughts
That Solomon in making imaged plots
Comes too close for my taste to idol fare.
But if You are You come to wander there
Do not strike him down dead for
wanderlust,
Nor shall I grind the brazen forms to dust.

Beloved, I rather come before the pot
Of waters of a thousand measures sought
To wash me in ablutions as were taught.
If not ablutions, then I stay to touch
The lions' manes and oxen's paunch with
much
Rubbing to polish and remain for such.

30 Every base had four brazen wheels,
And plates of brass, and at the heels
Of its four corners under-set,
Beneath the laver as cast yet
With wreaths at each one's side to get.
31 And the opening of it in
The crown and above was in bin
An arm-length high, the opening
Was round after work of the thing
At the base, an arm-length and half,
And on the opening, *no gaff*,
Were carvings with their borders square
And not round like *the other share*.
32 Under the borders there were four
Wheels with axles of wheels in store
In the base, and the height of each
Wheel was arm-length and half *to reach*.
33 And the wheel design was like that
Of chariot wheel, their axles sat,
Their rims, their hubs, their spokes all cast.
34 And there were four pieces that passed
Under the corners of each base,
And the under-pieces in trace
Were of one piece there with the base.
35 And in the top of the base there
It was completely round to bear,
Of half an arm-length in its height,
And on top of the base unite
Its ledges and borders the same.
36 For on the surface of its game
And panels he carved cherubim,
Lions and palm trees it would seem
According to the space of each
With wreaths around about its reach.
37 He made the ten bases like this,
All had one casting, not to miss
One measure and one size *to kiss*.

The lions lie beneath the palms to find
Rest from their hunting after having dined.
The oxen of life have gone on the way
Of all breath to await the Judgement day.
With wreath and cherubim, digestion takes
Its course for resting lions and their sakes.

Ten bases each with four wheels that will
show
The forty degrees as descending arcs go
And those that rise up to Your throne to be
The shining steps towards eternity.
Beloved, I follow wheel on wheel to climb
The starry journey through orange
blossom, lime,
Until ablutions sink into the night
Of drowsing cherubim for trilobite.

1 Kings 8

1 Then Solomon assembled men
Elders of Israel, and then
All of the tribal heads, the chief
Of the fathers of Israel's fief,
To king Solomon in the town
Of Jerusalem, that for crown
They bring up the ark of the pact
Of YHWH out of the town intact
Of David, which is Zion's *claim*.
2 Then all the men of Israel's fame
Gathered themselves before the king
Solomon at the feast in ring
Of the month of Ethanim which
Is seventh month *without a hitch*.
3 And all Israel's elders came out,
And the priests took the ark up stout.
4 And they brought up the ark of YHWH
And the tent of the people's crew,
And all the holy vessels that
Within the tabernacle sat,
The priests and Levites brought them flat.
5 King Solomon and all the folk
Of Israel that went for broke
Gathered before him at the stroke
Before the ark, sacrificed sheep
And oxen there, that could not keep
Track of the number for the pile
That accumulated the while.
6 The priests brought in the ark of pact
With YHWH into its place in fact
The oracle of the house, to
The most holy, under the view
Of wings of cherubim *as due*.
7 The cherubim spread out both wings
Over the place where the ark *springs*,
And cherubim covered the ark
And the staves by which it *did park*.
8 And they pulled out the staves to that
The stave ends appeared from thereat,
The holy before oracle,

And they did not appear in full
Outside, and there they are until
This very day *to fit the bill*.

The staves by which the ark was born at
last

Found resting place not to be used as
passed

The centuries the temple stood its ground,
The staves were always there and to be
found.

The golden covered poles were not in view
Before the crowd and Israel's faithful crew,
And as the decades passed there were but
few

Who ever thought of those staves without
dew

Or sunshine to relent to passing time.
Beloved, here I lie in my fatal rhyme
Ready to be used in Your plan and care,
Hidden from both the plain as well as fair.
Beloved, inert and like acacia staves
I stand and wait, ready before the graves.

9 There was nothing in the ark but
The two tables of stone unshut
Which Moses placed there at the Mount
Horeb, when YHWH set to account
The children of Israel, when they
Came out of Egypt's land *to stay*.

10 It came to pass when the priests came
Out of the holy, that the flame
Of cloud filled the house of YHWH's
claim.

11 So the priests did not stand to serve
Because of the cloud on the curve,
For YHWH's glory had filled the place
Where YHWH *entered to stay in grace*.

Within my heart, Beloved, and where I
stand

Hidden from all the things that humans
planned

Under the spreading wings of cherubim
Surrounded by the golden walls and rim,
Within my heart, Beloved, there is naught
but

The tables of Your law and with that glut
My heart is filled beyond the reach of room
Where I await the glory and the doom.
Beloved, I'm shadowed by the layered tent
Of stone and cedar without hole or rent

Through which to see the depth of star-
shred sky.

My only sight is blind when You come by.
And yet the golden cover and the stone
Open to heavens beyond and to Your
throne.

12 Then Solomon spoke up to say
"YHWH said that he would come to stay
In thick darkness *as seen today*.

13 Building I've built You where to dwell,
A house, a place to abide well
Forever." 14 And the king turned round
And blessed the gathered people sound
Of Israel, and all the folk
Of Israel stood *at the stroke*.

How many in that fertile time and place
Understood how great was the present
grace

To be blessed by the wisest of all men,
By Solomon's prolific tongue and pen?
It's strange that folk look up more to the
dead

Than to the living, yet when's done and
said,

It was a mercy, grace and honour too
To hear the blessed words heard by the
few.

The other extreme is also found here,
The adoration of the glitter bier
That bears the star along the helpful pier.
Beloved, I flee to You alone and those
That You have sent though dressed in
dervish clothes

To find the dawn and in the dawn the rose.

15 And he said "Blessèd be the YHWH
Alohim of Israel to do,
Who spoke by his mouth and unto
David my father, and has done
With His hand what He has begun,
Saying 16 'Since the day that I brought
My people Israel from the plot
Of Egypt, I chose not town out
Of all the tribes of Israel stout
To build a house, that My name might
Be in it, but I chose the wight
David to be over my folk
Israel *and stand firm like an oak*.'

17 "And it was in David's heart my
Father's to build a house whereby

The name of YHWH Alohim might
 Stand for ever in Israel's sight.
 18 And YHWH said to David my dad,
 'Since it was in your heart you had
 To build My name a house and filled,
 You did well that it was in heart.
 19 'But you shall not build the house part,
 But your son that shall come from your
 Body, he shall build temple *store*
 To My name.' 20 And YHWH has fulfilled
 His thing that he spoke, and unskilled
 I rose in David my dad's place,
 And sit on Israel's throne by grace
 Of YHWH's promise, and I have built
 A house for YHWH's name *to the hilt*,
 Who is Israel's Alohim. 21 And
 I have set there a place for ark
 Wherein YHWH's covenant will park,
 Which He made with our ancestors
 When He brought them from Egypt's
 doors."

The king remembered promises once
 spoken
 To his father and given in their token
 That he should reign to rule and build and
 make
 A place for Your name and for Your sweet
 sake.
 The king planned and construed his life to
 meet
 What he knew of Your promises and
 sweet.
 And so he lived to live within the share
 That You provided for his daily care.
 Beloved, are there some prophecies that
 plan
 My life today living here as a man?
 I search the sprawling characters to see
 If paper and ink say a word to me,
 And listen to the hymn rise from the book
 To curl above my being for a look.

22 And Solomon stood there before
 YHWH's altar in the sight and store
 Of all the gathered Israel's folk,
 And stretched out hands towards heaven 23
 and spoke:
 "YHWH Israel's Alohim, there's no
 Alohim like You, not to show
 In heaven above nor earth below,
 Who keep covenant, mercy's grace

With Your servants that walk this place
 Before You with all their heart's *race*,
 24 "Who have kept with David Your slave
 My father what before the grave
 You promised him, You spoke also
 With Your mouth and have made it so
 With Your hand as today it's so.
 25 "Therefore now, YHWH Alohim of
 Israel, keep with Your servant love
 David my father what You said
 In promise to him visited,
 'There shall not lack from you a man
 In My sight to sit and by plan
 On the throne of Israel, so that
 Your children take care where they're at,
 To walk before me as you've walked
 Before me *to do, not just talked.*'
 26 "And now, O Israel's Alohim,
 Let Your word, I beg You, for scheme
 Be verified, which You spoke to
 Your servant David, my dad too.
 27 "But will Alohim truly dwell
 On the earth? See, the sky and shell
 Of skies cannot contain You, nor
 Can this house I have built in store.

Beloved, the skies above all things do not
 Have room and place to give You form and
 plot.
 The earth is too small with its myriad
 horde
 Of life and death and all events unscored
 To give You thought worthy of footstool
 sewn.
 The human mind and heart have never
 known
 The start or finish of Your being's grace.
 The heaven of heavens cannot contain
 Your face.
 And yet, Beloved, men build for You a
 room
 Of brick and merchandize, and to their
 doom
 Built of both flesh and bone and open heart
 As though You might be found in things
 apart.
 The heaven of heavens cannot contain
 Your own,
 Can heart of man sustain Your royal
 throne?

Qadiim

Beloved, You are not before time, You
bow
To nothing that comes on the human brow.
You are not in time or above somehow,
For nothing impinges on Your
quintessence.

Self-existent, if existence can be
Attributed to You who from things flee,
To whom no thingness is a canopy,
Your ancientness is not some adolescence.
Beloved, You are Creator of both time
And space and every rhythm with its
rhyme,

You are the ancient and first cause of all
That turns in whirling as ball within ball.
Beforeness, afterness, all disappear
In light of Your timelessness' engineer.

Qadir

Almighty One, omnipotent indeed,
Your might extends to all action in seed
Who can alone do or undo all things
That praise or depose paupers and their
kings.

Almighty One, Beloved, Your sovereign
will

Is matchless, incontestable, and still
Cannot like humankind come to produce
Offspring nor dwindle before world time's
use.

Beloved, beside Your might there is no
might

Nor power nor sovereignty before the light
Of day. I hide beneath omnipotence
As though within Your fast embroidered
tents,

And find wherever I turn in my need
There You reign without effort, without
greed.

'Aalim

Beloved, You're only knower of all things,
Because You have created all in rings,
And everything is from Your plan to boot,
No thing exists but has in You its root.
Beloved, You are the knower of the great,
The knower of the least, at any rate
You know all things between, and only
You

Know what is not and what is false and
true.

Beloved, I come to seek the knowledge fast

That You desire to show me in the cast
Of players on the screen of universe.
I find since You know all, there's none that

I
Can know beside, not even if I try.
Beloved, as teacher I'd surely do worse.

Mudrik

Direct perception of all things You make
Without ear or eye or feeling at stake.
You smell without the need of nose to toast
The breadcrumbs that fall from each
human boast.

You taste the universe, both salt and sweet,
Without a tongue to grant the fruit and
meat.

No medium is needed by Your bill,
Who ride in all perceiving from the hill
Of Your sovereign estate and find the light
An object in itself, not means of sight.
Beloved, I fumble in my flailing search
To know the difference of beech and birch,
While all extensions of my senses show
That I perceive nothing beneath Your
glow.

Hayy

Beloved, I see around prolific life,
I hear the humming sound as without strife
The worlds of insect, mate and leaf retreat
To swirl again in never-ending feat.

Beloved, the life I find within myself
Is like that of each fairy wing and elf:
It still depends from breath to breath on
You

Who made the creature from the soil and
dew.

Beloved, Your life is without tangent
cause,

It does not bend to worry or to laws,
But exists without need of being's might,
Beloved, You are beyond life's inner sight,
And yet without need or share You too
live,
And living You alone need naught to give.

Muriid

Master of Your own will, You unlike me
Find no impediment to do and see.
You need no matter no, nor energy
To perform Your will on the planets' ring.

Beloved, Your action needs no clay to
mold,
It needs no atom nor any sheep-fold,
But without man or lamb You still appear
To breathe into one's nostrils hope and
fear,
And lead the other without laugh or tear.
Beloved and Master of my will and Yours,
You see without a window, without doors
You come and go, and yet need neither
place
Nor time to engage in the spaceless race,
Nor clothing to find heat here in the cold.

Mutakallim

Creator of speech, attribute divine
That goes unmentioned in the Christian
vine
So presumed by scholar, also by friend,
That it remains invisible to end!
Creator of speech, You bend down to make
The tongue utter the sounds for the sound's
sake
And give the meaning that human's
mistake
For thought and knowledge at the last up-
take.
Beloved, I hear the bumblebee give birth
To messages divine, of greater worth
Than human sonnets told and retold when
The slight reflection dozes on strong men.
Return to me, Beloved, and create speech
That I may utter what You only teach.

Sadiq

The moral power that You have set in me
To strive to tell the truth eternally
Burns in Your essence which can only be
Truth, truth in its absolute purity.
Beloved, the Truthful, through all shades
of light,
Through days of gold and through
argentine night,
Your very self is found when Truth stands
clear:
In Truth You become visible to ear.
Beloved, give me the love of truth, though
I
May wander in the sweeter-smelling pie
That anchors my illusion to the sky.
Beloved, give me mercy of truth, though
time

Has given me but brief moments to climb
Into the ghosts of Your eternal rhyme.

Murakkab

Beloved, unlike creation, there is not
In You any part or compound that's
wrought
To frame Your form or give internal grace,
Or lines and features to the divine face.
The Psalmist says to taste and see that You
Are good, and yet I know from my brief
view
Of hope and help that should I taste Your
dew
You would be pure down to last honey
drop.
Beloved, forgive my little joke and stop
To show Yourself no compound in the
shop.
You are not made of things opposing or
Complementing, additional in store:
Beloved, there are no parts in You nor edge
To give place to my love as coming wedge.

Makan

Though all things that exist need You to
be,
There's nothing in You needing to be free.
You do not find accommodation's seat
When You step on the universe to greet.
Beloved, You do not shift aside Your
throne
To give place to the flesh in blood and
bone,
Nor do You say Your pardons when You
step
Aside to let a lady pass with pep.
You displace no thing by the fact that You
Are absolutely One and always true,
With neither inside nor outside to do
A dance with suns and planets in new shoe.
Beloved, accommodate no thing in me,
But be the I in all my symmetry.

Huluul

Beloved, You are eternally to be
Without limitation, infinitely.
There is no bound created that contains
Your essence of self on the autumn rains.
You do not incarnate, not because one
Body is too small for deity's run,
But because you cannot leave those behind

That would be not You in the constant bind
Of incarnation's choice to set the flood
Of deity in one man's flesh and blood.
Idols alone incarnate in specific,
But You are always present and terrific.
You do not leave bereft the cells of one
Even who denies You the race You run.

Maryii

Because you have no edge that I can see,
No limitation in the world to be,
You are invisible, Beloved, to me.
I see You not, not because You are far
And distant like the tiny blaze of star,
Nor because You are greater than my sight
Can reach beyond the days and years of
light.
I see You not, Beloved, because Your face
Is too close to my own in love's embrace,
And where the kiss of life retains the beat
Of heart and mind, there You're too close
to meet.
Beloved, You are invisible because
You are too near to me for seeing's laws.
You are nearer than self in my heart's seat.

Ihtiyaj

Beloved, I am a creature of dark needs,
I need the pleasure of the planted seeds,
The taste of water on the sprouting corn,
The smell of Your delight on sparkling
morn.
Beloved, I am created with the spark
Of needing You in both the light and dark,
Since I have no breath but what comes
from You
Who kiss me to life with the new, fresh
dew.
But You, Beloved, have no need for Your
score,
No need for love or hate, no need for more
In nourishment, in drink or sacrifice.
You have no need of wicked or the nice.
Beloved, You who have no need, descend
yet
To find me needing nothing in Your debt.

Shirkat

Beloved, You are alone God in the way
The universe created bears its sway.
There is no one associate or friend
To share divinity from start to end.

You are alone God in this marvelled place,
There is no other god before Your face.
There is no man to come in divine trace
To be another god I might adore.
You are alone, there's none other in store,
No, not the spirit nor the one born in
The barn to save the world from the first
sin.

Beloved, though You may be alone to find
That no one is associate to bind,
Yet where all things are there You are too
kind.

Without Change

In all the universe of lights and stars,
In all the cities' fraught with cattle cars,
In all the lanes that lead me to the rote
Of fir and pine and birch to hear the note
Of spheres still singing on the single air,
There is change in each thing and
everywhere.
Beloved, You are the only One to share
Not change, since You are always One and
same.
That's why even the stars sing out Your
name,
And every linnet with voice to proclaim
With changing breath tells of You without
shame.
Beloved, unchanging through the templed
nights
That burden me with hopes and hopeless
sights,
You alone remain unchanging to care.

Without Addition

Beloved, what qualifies my given name
And being is detachable in shame.
I may speak truly if it is Your will,
But I am never truth to fit the bill
Except as Your own Self becomes my
own,
Casting out my illusion to intone
Your Self only. Beloved, I share with all
Qualities You have given terrestrial ball.
But You have none of attributes to share,
What is You is always You and is bare.
You are not merely truthful, but You are
Truth itself and not just a guiding star.
Beloved, I cannot grasp Your frame and
fame,
But I can still love and repeat Your name.

28 "Yet have respect unto the prayer
 Of Your servant and to his care
 In supplication, Alohim
 YHWH, my God, to give ear in scheme
 To the cry and prayer that Your slave
 Prays before You today *for glaive*.
 29 "That Your eyes may be open toward
 This temple night and day, toward
 The place of which You've said 'My name
 Shall be there,' that You may attain
 To hearing the prayer which Your slave
 Shall make toward this place *and nave*.
 30 "And may You hear the supplication
 Of Your servant and of Your nation
 Israel, when they pray toward this place.
 Hear in heaven Your dwelling place,
 And when You hear, forgive *with grace*.

Your servants, my Beloved, have always
 prayed
 Towards Your house. In those days when it
 stayed
 A tattered tent at Shiloh and in time
 More ancient yet and in a drier clime
 It followed flocks in search of desert
 streams,
 Still all turned toward the sacred, glowing
 gleams
 Of the Shekinah where Your presence was
 Expressed in light. They turned for every
 cause
 Toward Your house. As Solomon petitions,
 Let us find grace today in all conditions.
 Forgive the church and mosque and
 synagogue
 For raising Qiblas for the demagogue.
 Let me turn toward You singly and alone,
 Confess my faults towards Your
 cornerstone.

31 "If anyone sins against his
 Neighbour, and then oath on him is
 Laid to cause him to swear, and he
 Comes to swear at Your altar free
 In this house, 32 "Then hear in the sky,
 And do and judge Your servants nigh,
 Condemning wicked ones, to bring
 His way upon his head *to ring*,
 And justifying righteous one
 To give him as righteous he's done.

Though men may swear their innocence
 abroad
 Or in the house of Zion and like clod,
 You know, Beloved, what is the true and
 what
 Is secret of iniquity and shut.
 Strike him who swears falsely against my
 race,
 But do not forget to look past my face
 To see what things are hidden in the place
 Of my heart, even what I do not know,
 And root out all the evil from the show.
 Beloved, although that temple now is gone
 That Solomon blessed on the rosy dawn,
 I pray that as I turn toward the spot
 That You will touch again my humble plot
 To give according to Your righteous glow.

33 "When Your people Israel are struck
 Down before foes *into the muck*,
 Because they've sinned against You, and
 Shall turn back to You *as You planned*
 To confess Your name and to pray
 And supplicate You *in the way*
Of this house, 34 "Then hear in the sky,
 And forgive the sin of the *spry*
 Folk of Your Israel and bring them
 Back to the land You gave *like gem*
 To their ancestors. 34 "When the sky
 Is shut and there's no rain to fly,
 Because they've sinned against You, if
 They pray, confess Your name *not stiff*
 And turn from their sin when You strike,
 36 "Then hear in heaven, forgive the spike
 Of Your servants, and of Your folk
 Israel, to teach them *at a stroke*
 The good way in which they should walk,
 And give rain on Your land *and stalk*,
 Which You gave to Your people for
 Inheritance, *basket and store*.

37 If there is famine in the land,
 If there is pestilence *at hand*,
 Blasting, mildew, locust, or if
 There are caterpillars *in griff*,
 If their foes besiege them along
 The land of their cities *in throng*,
 Whatever plague or sickness *call*,
 38 "What prayer and supplication small
 Is made by any one, or by
 All of You people in the sty
 Of Israel, which every man

Knows as the pain of his heart's ban,
And stretch out his hands toward this
house,
39 "Then hear in heaven Your place to
grouse,
And do forgive, and make and give
To everyone as he shall live,
Whose heart is known to You, for You
Alone keep all the hearts in view
Of all the sons of men, not few.

All-knowing You are said to be by all,
The Hebrew, Christian, Muslim at the call
Of prayer in every house of worship met
In Istanbul or other city's flet
Come to declare that You know
everything.
And so the human heart is not a thing
Hidden from Your knowledge. The barren
room
That is my inner chamber neath the loom
Of patterns in the ripened universe
Is not a place of worship any worse
Than those. I too come to acknowledge
You
As knowing, sounding all in, out of view.
Beloved, know that I know that You are
there
To know all things in and out of my care.

40 "That they may fear You all the days
That they live in the land for stays
Which You gave to our fathers' *praise*.
41 As well, as it concerns the one
Who's come to Israel on the run,
Your people, but is not their son,
But comes from a far land to take
Your name and for Your fortune's sake,
42 "For they shall hear of Your great name,
And of Your strong hand and *the fame*
Of Your stretched out arm, when he'll
come
And pray towards this house *in sum*,
43 "Then hear in heaven Your dwelling
place,
And do according to *Your grace*
Of all that stranger asks You for,
So all folk of the earth *in store*
May know Your name, and fear You more
As do Your folk Israel *in score*.

Beloved, I am a stranger in a land

Far from the house that Solomon in hand
Once dedicated to Your name and fame:
I am a poor Hittite that has no claim
To any blessing that You lay on sod.
Others may be the seed, but I'm the pod.
And yet I turn toward that temple square
Even today, so far in time and air
From that place sacred to the divine share.
Beloved, beneath the northern skies when
gray
Or light at midnight as the light of day,
I turn toward Jerusalem to pray
And seek the blessing Solomon once laid
For me and every stranger's accolade.

44 "If Your people go out to fight
Against their foe, and where they might
Alight as sent by You and pray
To YHWH toward the city's way
That You have chosen, and the house
I've built for Your name, *not for mouse*,
45 "Then hear in heaven their prayer and
their

Own supplication, treat them fair.
46 "If they sin against You, and there
Is no man that does not sin here
And You are angry with the peer,
And turn them over in their fear
To enemy, so that they come
And carry them away in sum
As captives to enemy land,
Either far off or near at hand,
47 "Yet if they wake up from their dream
In the land where they're carried team
Of captives, and repent and make
Supplication and for Your sake
In the land of the ones who took
Them captives, saying "We forsook
The right and have done wickedly,
We've committed impiety,
48 "And so return to You with all
Their heart and with their soul in stall,
In the land of their enemies,
Who led them out captive to please,
And pray to You toward their land,
Which You gave to their fathers' band,
The city that You've chosen out,
Then the house which I have built stout
For Your name *only without doubt*,
49 "Then hear their prayer and hear also
Their supplication in the glow
Of heaven Your dwelling place and show

Strength favouring their cause below,
50 And forgive Your folk who've done
wrong

Against You, and give them along
Side of those who carried them out
As captives, compassion about,
That they may take pity on them.
51 For they're Your people, and Your gem
That You brought out of Egypt's hem,
Up from the iron furnace' stem.

Why must there be a foe, Beloved, and
why

Must any go out to the fray and fly?
It's not a thing writ in genetic code
That man must fight instead of bearing
load,

For centuries the native people that
Along the western coast of Chile sat
Lived on in peace without the art of sword,
Without a lock or weapon on the board.
If savages can so live in Your will,
Cannot the civilized who foot the bill?
Beloved, I see that You are neither good
Or else as strong as You could be or
should.

Good, yes, perhaps, but thwarted by the
blow

The humans shower on each other's toe.

52 "So Your eyes may be open to
The supplication of Your crew
Of servants and to what they beg
Who are Your people, Israel's peg,
To listen to them when they call
To You *for help in home and stall.*

53 "For You once set them apart from
Among all the people that come
And go on earth, to be Your own
Inheritance, and You spoke known
By the hand of Your servant Moses,
When You brought our fathers and chose
us

Out of Egypt, Lord YHWH *enclose us.* "
So Solomon spoke of the house
That he'd finished building like mouse.
He showed the sun in sky above,
The Lord, said he, would dwell in love
Of darkness, so build Me a house,
A beautiful house where anew
To dwell, and see is it not true,
It's written in the book of song

And lovingly carried along.

Who knows who added or subtracted this
Expression of Solomon in his bliss.
But it describes and praises once that house
That rose for beauty that one did not dowse
Until the king of Babylon came by
To destroy what was built to honour why
You alone reign as God on earth and sky.
A beautiful house to live in, it's true
And written in the canticles to brew
The sweetness of Your presence in the dew
And lichen-covered rock waiting for snow.
Beloved, may I be in my come and go
A temple where may dwell Your presence
spent
In Psalms aspiring from my fleshly tent.

54 And so it happened Solomon
Finished his prayer under the sun,
All this prayer and supplication
To YHWH, then he arose before
The altar of YHWH, from the floor
Kneeling on his knees with his hands
Spread up to heaven *for commands.*

I see, Beloved, the king of ancient time
Prostrating on the temple floor to climb
At last to sit upon his heels and wait
Your approbation of him and his fate.
He recites supplication to his Lord,
And sets aside the plough as well as sword
To stretch his empty hands to You in
prayer.

Beloved, see that although I was not there,
I too upon the paving stones prostrate,
I too rise to stretch out my hands ingrate
To praise and petition You though my
heart

Is small to know the glories of Your part.
Paint my feeble words now in gratitude
To mind the spires and canopies unviewed.

55 And he stood there and blessed the folk,
All Israel with a loud stroke
Of voice saying 56 "Now blessed be
YHWH

That has given His rest unto
His people Israel, and by
All that He promised there has not
Failed one word of all that He taught
In good promise, which He by hand

Of His slave Moses, gave command.

Have You, Beloved, given Your rest just to
Israel alone, and left the Gentile crew
With no Sabbath at all? Surely the string
Of Rabbinical law is worth a fling.

The Rabbis would prevent obedience
To Sabbath command in the pagan tents,
And yet give hope and health to donkey
that

Fate has given a shelter where son sat
In tents of Shem. Beloved, though I am
worth

Perhaps less than a donkey on the earth
Belonging to a Hebrew, still I trow
That I shall have the Sabbath gift
somehow.

If this house Solomon built is for all,
Then I too answer at the restful call.

57 "YHWH our Alohim be with us
As He was with our fathers' muss,
Let Him not leave us nor forsake,
58 "That He may incline our hearts' wake
To Him to walk in all His ways,
And to keep His commandments' ways,
And His statutes and His judgements
Commanded on our fathers' tents.

The Anglican today perhaps still comes
To say these words with rolling of the
drums

Of organ sound among the Norman heights
That rise in cathedral might to my sights.
He still prays You might incline heart to do
According to the commands of the true
Law that You once proclaimed on Sinai's
mount.

I wonder how many such laws in count
Such worshippers intend to keep at all.
It does not seem the Sabbath day will fall
Among the number, though it makes a
third

Of the text of the Decalogue in word.
Beloved, incline my heart, incline again,
That I might obey You before all men.

59 "And let these words by which I've
made
Supplication before YHWH stayed,
Be near to YHWH our Alohim
Day and night, so He might in scheme

Maintain the right of His servant,
And the right of His people meant,
Of Israel at all times as sent.
60 "That all the earth's people might know
That YHWH is Alohim and show
There is no other *on the go*.
61 "And so may your heart wholly be
With YHWH our Alohim to see
And walk in His statues and keep
His commandments as this day's reap."

The king prays that all the world come to
know

That You alone, Beloved, are God to show
In heaven above or in the earth beneath,
And that the trinity's no god with teeth.
That knowledge alone can keep faithful in
The right path of good actions and not sin.
No doubt the preacher's right who says that
one

Cannot keep to Your law once said and
done,
When faith is anchored on the fatal sand
Of three gods bound and sheltered in one
band.

Let me, Beloved, look to You only and
Worship You as one God, not trinity,
And so I may hope that I shall be free
Of guilt before Your judgement seat and
tree.

62 Then the king and all Israel too
With him offered sacrifice due
Before YHWH. 63 And Solomon came
To offer sacrifice of peace
Offerings he offered in YHWH's name,
Twenty-two thousand bulls' *increase*,
One hundred twenty thousand sheep.
So the king and all the folk deep
Of Israel dedicated
The house of YHWH, *yes sir, they did*.

I don't know why the king was startled so
That he must offer so much as a show,
And kill so many animals that might
Have lived on under sun and in delight.
But he must have believed that You were
best

Pleased by his offering of bulls and sheep
blessed.

I rarely lift my hand to take the life
Of sheep in offering to You, despite strife,

And rarely cut a bull with a sharp knife.
And yet, Beloved, I pray my sacrifice
Is pleasing to You and You think it nice.
I have nothing in hand of blood and meat,
But myself only for a tasty treat
To set in offering by Your throne and feet.

1 Kings 9

1 It happened Solomon had done
With the building of the house won
For YHWH, and the king's house and all
That Solomon's heart had in thrall,

2 That YHWH appeared to Solomon
The second time as on the run
He'd come to him at Gibeon.

3 And YHWH said to him, "I have heard
Your prayer and supplication's word
That you made before Me, and I
Have hallowed this house *by and by*
That you have built, to put My name
On it forever, and the claim
Of My eyes and my heart shall be
There ever and perpetually.

4 And if you will walk before Me
As David Your father walked *free*
And in integrity of heart,

And in uprightness by your part
To do all I've commanded you,
And keep My statutes, judgements *true*,
5 Then I'll establish your reign's throne
On Israel for always *alone*
As I promised David your dad,
Saying 'There'll not fail any lad
Of you on Israel's throne, *be glad*.'

6 But if you all turn back from Me
From following, posterity
Or you yourselves, and will not keep
My commandments and statutes steep
That I've set before you, but go
And serve other gods and *for show*
Bow down in prayer to them *in tow*,
7 Then I'll cut off Israel out of
The land I've given them *for love*,
And this house I've made sacred to
My name I'll cast out of my view,
And Israel shall be a proverb
And byword on all peoples' curb.

The promise of the permanence of reign
Of David's descendants here in the rain
Depends on each one toeing to the line
Of Your obedience and doing fine.

If anyone goes to the pagan floor
To open heathen goddesses the door
The kingdom's forfeit. Some lived to relate
A story of indulgence of the fate
In worshipping the idols of the great.
Beloved, keep me within Your loving care
Not to worship the sprites that fill the air.
Perhaps the walking of kings is a thing
To be understood only by the king.
I've heard enough of them, enough to
spare.

8 And at this house, which is so high
Every person that passes by
Shall be astonished and will hiss,
And they shall say 'Now why is this
Done by YHWH to this land and house?'
9 "And they shall answer *by the louse*,
'Because they forsook YHWH their God,
Who brought their fathers from the sod
Of Egypt and have taken hold
On other gods, and have been bold
To worship them and serve them, so
YHWH's brought on them this evil
show.'"

Many there be who worship other gods
Who have plenty of wealth and health in
pods.

Perhaps You only mean the sacred few
Named of Israel must worship only You.
Perhaps it is Your will that demons take
Your throne of glory in the lapping wake
Of heathen temple, Christian church, in
sum,

In many of the places I might come.
Beloved, though I am not one of the
chosen,

And though I live a land where all is
frozen,

I still bow at Your throne and take Your
will

As expressed once on Sinaitic hill
To be my guide through fast arctic morass.
You're just the only God's got any class.

10 And so it happened when were done
Some twenty years, when Solomon
Had built the two houses, the house
Of YHWH as well as the king's house,
11 Hiram the king of Tyre had made
Gift to Solomon of A grade

Cedar trees and fir trees and gold,
 According to all his heart's hold,
 And so king Solomon gave to
 Hiram twenty cities with crew
 In the land of Galilee's *dew*.
 12 Hiram came out from Tyre to see
 The cities Solomon gave *free*
 To him, but they did not please him.
 13 And he said "What cities *for trim*
 Are these that you have given me,
 My brother?" And he called the fee
 The land of Cabul to this day.
 14 And Hiram sent to the king gold,
 A hundred twenty talents *cold*.

I wonder what Hiram's guess then had
 been
 When he got from Solomon's hand his kin
 In twenty towns of misery and poor.
 At least it didn't cause a war, that's sure.
 The wily Danite who ruled on the earth
 And over shipyards to see things of worth
 Was not impressed with Galilee from
 where
 His fathers had come to the coast to bear
 The weight of civilization's grand fare.
 I'd think the memory of old times there
 Would strike a cord of nostalgic acclaim.
 Nor Solomon nor Hiram is to blame.
 Beloved, give me a wicked stick once laid
 In wilderness where my ancestors played.

15 This is the reason for the tax
 Which king Solomon raised *like axe*
 To build the house of YHWH and his
 Own house, and Millo, and that is
 The wall of Jerusalem, and
 Hazor, and Megiddo, and *land*
Of Gezer. 16 Pharaoh Egypt's king
 Had gone up and then taken wing
 Of Gezer and burned it with fire
 And killed the Canaanites with ire
 That lived in the city and gave
 It as a gift to daughter *grave*
 Who was Solomon's wife, *not slave*.
 17 And Solomon built Gezer and
 Bethhoron the lower *in land*,
 18 And Baalath and Tadmor out in
 The wilderness, *Judah's land's bin*.
 19 And all the store cities that sat
 In Solomon's possession at
 The cities for his chariots, and

The cities for his horsemen's hand,
 And what Solomon wished to build
 In Jerusalem and to gild,
 And in Lebanon, and in all
 The land that was under his thrall.
 20 All the folk left of Amorites,
 Hittites, Perizzites, and Hivites,
 And Jebusites, such as were not
 Of Israel's children *and their plot*,
 21 Their descendants left after them
 In the land, whom by stratagem
 Israel's folk also were not able
 To destroy completely in stable,
 On those did Solomon lay down
 A tax of service still renown.

In early times the practice should have
 been
 To destroy Amorite with kith and kin.
 Now that the kingdom's sure there is no
 need
 To slaughter in a bloodier stampede
 A folk that can as well serve lowly deed
 And give the free-born whom to lord upon.
 I'm one of those left over from the
 slaughter
 Of native sons caught up beyond the water,
 Surviving because some of mine were wise
 Enough to be servants to the new guys
 And show them how to range the mountain
 ways.
 Their service gave me breath in later days.
 Beloved, the cycle of the human breath
 Is far more wonderful than its mere death.

22 But of the sons of Israel
 Solomon made no slave *to tell*,
 But they were men of war to serve,
 And his princes, captains *with verve*,
 And rulers of his chariots,
 And his horsemen *who called the shots*.
 23 These were the chief of officers
 That were over Solomon's stirs,
 Five hundred and fifty who bare
 Rule over the folk who worked there.
 24 But Pharaoh's daughter came up out
 Of David's city to her *stout*
 House which he had built for her, then
 He had built Millo *in the glen*.

Beloved, I wait alone in Bethlehem
 For Your call to live in Jerusalem.

I make my patient days in beauty fall
Upon the hills where shepherds their sheep
call

To wander in search of a leaf to chew.
I look upon the bright jewels of dew
That stud my mornings as I wait for You.
Beloved, I hear the tidings sent to town
From the heights of Zion come floating
down,
And in mind's eye see mansions on the
crown

Of the fortress, I see their glory's dress.
Beloved, from my window here I confess
Your lovely plans to bring me to Your
heart.

I see on the horizon Zion's start.

25 Three times a year did Solomon
Offer burnt offerings under sun
And peace offerings on altar which
He built to YHWH and burnt like pitch
Incense upon the altar too,
The altar that was before YHWH
So he finished up the house too.

26 King Solomon built a fleet too,
In Eziongeber a ships' fleet,
Which is beside Elath at feet
Of the shore of the Red sea's *beat*,
In the land of Edom's *retreat*.

27 And Hiram sent his servants in
The navy, shipmen who could win
In knowledge of the sea along
With Solomon's servant *in strong*.
28 And they came to Ophir and got
From there gold, four hundred in pot
And twenty talents and they brought
It to king Solomon *in lot*.

Beloved, I too have walked the pebbled
shore
Of Eilat and heard sounds about, the roar
Of airplanes coming in to park above
The place where Solomon's ships used to
shove.

I've swum about the limpid waters there
And looked up to the hillsides yellow bare
And wondered of the days when Solomon
Was king over all things under this sun.
Beloved, I've seen the fishes on the reef
Shine in the colours of rainbow relief,
And wisely sink to find their place and
room

While I think of time and all things in
doom.

Beloved, the king is gone, and yet there's
here

The crowd of those who still hold him in
fear.

1 Kings 10

1 Now when the queen of Sheba heard
Of Solomon's fame and the word
Concerning the name of YHWH, she
Came to test him questioningly.
2 And she came to Jerusalem
With a great caravan in stem,
With camels bearing spices and
Very much gold and *in her hand*
Precious stones, and when she had come
To Solomon, she told in sum
Everything that was in her heart.

3 And Solomon answered *with art*
All her questions, and there was not
A thing hidden from the king's *lot*
He did not tell her *on the spot*.

This is no proof of wisdom, it is not!
The fact the woman flattered whom she
sought

Shows rather hormones riding high and
full,

The Solomon I see here's just a bull
That nuzzles the cow in rut when she
comes

With caravan, camel and sugar-plums.
Speak to me not of wisdom when the gate
Of pasture's been left open and of late
The cattle's mixed and freely gone to mate.
Beloved, the wisdom here is all Your own,
Creation's wonders spread before Your
throne,

And all the coloured wings of peacock
grown

To flash a brilliant gash beneath the leaves.
In Holland Park one finds such wisdom's
sleeves.

4 And when the queen of Sheba saw
All Solomon's wisdom with awe,
And the house that he had built there,
5 And on his table the fine fare,
And all his servants sitting there,
Attendance of his ministers,
And their fine clothing, and who stirs

His cup, and the burnt offering which
He offered in YHWH's house *in pitch*,
It took her breath away *in stitch*.

I'll bet the offering took her breath away.
No wonder those who edited the way
Of Torah limited the sacrifice
In Your name to merely the once or twice
On Sabbath day for double duty's splice.
The thousands of cattle that dripped their
blood
Must have disengorged before eye in flood
Enough to blind the queen of Sheba too.
I'll bet the offering was too much for You.
David himself, when he stepped out to
bring
The ark to his city to praise and sing
Slaughtered each six paces his offering.
Beloved, though stingy Scotsman, without
sheep
I bring myself to You for You to keep.

6 She said to the king, "It was true
What I heard in my land of you,
And of your acts and wisdom due.

7 "But I did not believe the word
Until I came and saw *and heard*,
And yet it seems the half was not
Told me, the wisdom of your lot
And wealth is greater than the fame
Of what I had heard *in your name*.

8 "Blessed are your folk, blessed are the
ones

Who serve you standing there like suns
Before you to hear your wisdom.

9 "Blessed be YHWH your Alohim come
To delight in you, to set you
On the throne of Israel's crew,
Because YHWH loved Israel for aye,
He made you king and that is why
You do judgement and justice ply."

No doubt the queen of Sheba can't be
wrong

That You placed Solomon above the
throng

To reign in justice and do judgement right.
No doubt You set Solomon up in sight.
Your great desire to bring into the world
A wise and righteous rule is what unfurled
The flag of Solomon upon the shore
Of Ophir and of Tarshish what is more.

And yet if You set Solomon to reign,
And many say you depose and make sane
The rulers of the earth and others lift,
I have trouble to follow in Your drift.
Beside Solomon few have lived to share
The throne with justice, all people beware.

10 She gave the king a hundred and
Twenty talents of fine gold and
Of spices a very great store,
And precious stones, until no more
Such abundance of spice was seen
As these brought him by Sheba's queen
To give to Solomon the king.

11 Hiram's fleet too in underling
Brought gold from Ophir, and brought
from

Ophir much sandal-wood in sum,
And precious stones. 12 And the king
made

Of sandal-wood the pillars stayed
For the house of YHWH and for yet
The king's house, harps also to get
And psalteries for singers, there
Was never such sandal-wood bare
Seen ever to this day *for share*.

13 King Solomon gave to the queen
Of Sheba all she wished on scene,
Whatever she asked, besides what
Solomon gave her of his shut
Royal bounty. So she turned and
Went to her own country and land,
She and all of her servant band.

King Solomon got the greatest stud fee
Of any stallion in earth's history.
The gold does not raise my interest at all,
But sandal-wood for harps I find to call
My heart to waken, and the psalteries
sound.

Rutting is turned both civilized, profound.
The glory of king Solomon and queen
Of Sheba is brighter than any seen,
And even to the days when Italy
Ran over Cush for Christianity,
The efforts of the king and queen were still
Rampant in cave and upon holy hill.
Beloved, I smell the sandal-wood's
perfume

In psalm and proverb still to lighten gloom.

14 The weight of gold that came each year

To Solomon was six hundred
Sixty-six talents of gold spread,
15 Besides what he had in the gear
Of merchants and of traffic of
The spice merchants as well as of
All the kings of Arabia,
The rulers of the land in awe.

The Arab's kingdoms in those days of yore
Sent Solomon his tribute to the shore
Of Eilat and by camel train as far
As David's castle, donkey cart and car.
How long has desert love come down to
bear
The spices and the gold and more to share
In faith and love to You, Beloved, since
then!
Your light pours into opened hearts of men
And women from Hagar's loins and the
sweet
Isaac's hopes in the brotherly retreat.
Today as then the choice before the world
Lies glorious and fresh as just unfurled:
We might praise You in gold and costly
scent,
Or turn to blood and slaughter with heart
bent.

17 Three hundred shields of beaten gold,
In each shield three pounds of fine gold,
And the king placed them in the house
Of Lebanon's forest *to grouse*.
18 The king made a great ivory throne,
And overlaid with gold like stone.
19 The throne had six steps and the top
Of the throne round behind to stop,
And there were stays on either side,
On the place of the seat, abide
Two lions standing on stays' side.
20 Twelve lions stood there on one side
And on the other, on six steps,
There was not the like any reps
In all the kingdom *to reside*.

Beloved, who are the twelve with lions'
mane?
Who are the dear and lovely ones that reign
About the throne of Solomon to see
The cycles of despair in history?
Say not a glowing word, Beloved, to me!
I know the names and faces of the free,
I see their shadows fleeting on the cast

Of politics and murder going past,
I see them rein the bloodlust and the gore,
I see them hold the winds of strife once
more,
Though every man despair of faith and
hope
Within this kingdom of gentry and pope.
Beloved, the lovely twelve still range in
one
Guided fire glowing fiercely in the sun.

21 And all king Solomon's cups were
Vessels of gold, and all that were
Vessels of the house of the wood
Of Lebanon as pure gold could,
None were of silver, it was naught
Accounted in Solomon's plot.

To eat or drink from gold is not allowed
By the divine law that now binds the
proud,
And yet some follow sunnat of the lord
Solomon in eating if not in sword.
I've seen the golden dish and the abhorred,
I've seen the jewelled spoon upon the
board,
And still I turn away and touch the wood
And leafy clay to eat now as I should.
Let me, Beloved, drink from bejewelled
cup
The day when I arise at last, look up
To find Ali extending drought to me
From Kauthar on the shore of Eden's tree.
Better than Solomon's gold chalice and
Better than anything found in this land.
22 For the king had a fleet at sea
At Tharshish with Hiram's to be,
Every three years the navy came
From Tharshish bringing in the claim
Of gold and silver, ivory and
Apes and peacocks *on every hand*.

Hold, wait a minute, my Beloved, tell me
What need had Solomon, even on spree,
For apes? I understand the peacock's call.
But what of apes against the marbled wall?
If one ape or a family at best
Is needed for amusement and not pest,
Then why the need each year to bring the
rest?

There's something fishy that I haven't
guessed.
I've heard an ape can do a chore or two,
But I'd think slaves and servants in the
pew
Would be a better sight and for the cost
Better investment on the money lost.
Beloved, give me no apes in an advance
On wisdom, wealth and long life in my
pants.

23 King Solomon was richer far
Than all the kings of earth *in car*
Of wealth and wisdom *popular*.
24 All the world came to Solomon
To hear his wisdom which was done
By Alohim set in his heart.
25 And every man brought him his gift,
Vessels of silver and to lift
Vessels of gold and clothing and
Armour and spice as well as grand
Horses and mules year after year,
Such was Solomon's wealth and gear.

Today You planted and appointed one
Invisibly guides kingdoms that were won
By sword and deceit all spoken in fun.
The visible and righteous head of state
Drew all men to his judgement hall and
plate
To hear justice commended on the pate
Of every wanton lady and her mate.
But such things today never can be done.
Beloved, in days gone past, despite the hate
And slaughter that was rife on every hand,
Justice awakened respect in the fanned
By ancient breezes. Today it's not so.
If Your appointed dared to make a show
Elected chiefs would deal him a death
blow.

1 Kings 11

1 Now Solomon the king loved many
Foreign women besides *bright penny*
Of Pharaoh's daughter, women of
The Moabites, Ammonites' *love*,
Edomites, Zidonians' *glove*
As well as the Hittites *for shove*.
2 Of the nations of which YHWH said
To Israel's folk, "You shall not bed
Them, neither shall they come to you,
For surely they will turn away

Your heart after their gods *in sway*."
Solomon held to these in love.
3 And he had seven hundred wives,
Princesses, and for their contrives
Three hundred concubines, and his
Wives turned away his heart *from quiz*.

Why do You sport the acts of Solomon
As though he did the things he did for fun?
It was not lust alone that made him take
So many wives to bed and feed and break.
Are You, Beloved, so ignorant of how
Political systems worked in that row?
A treaty was signed not on paper then
But by exchange of wives among the men.
Solomon's choice was marry like a fool
Or be the brunt of every warrior's tool.
Peace required wives, somewhat like Islam
now
That people scramble to make difference
fast
So's not to be mistaken in the cast
Of world religions all considered cool.

4 For it happened when Solomon
Was old, his wives *under the sun*
Turned his heart after other gods,
And his heart was not firm by rods
Of YHWH his Alohim as was
The heart of David his dad's cause.
5 For Solomon went out to play
With Ashtoreth goddess in way
Of the Zidonians, and more
After Milcom the shame in store
Of Ammonites. 6 And Solomon
Did evil before YHWH to run
Not fully after YHWH as did
His father David for his bid.
7 Then Solomon built a high place
For Chemosh of Moab's disgrace,
On hill east of Jerusalem,
And for Molech in diadem
Abomination of Ammon.
8 And so he did for all his wives
Of foreign provenance and jives
To burn incense and sacrifice
To their gods, which was not too nice.

David did not have opportunity
To make alliance with heathen degree.
So why judge him so virtuous to be?
If Solomon followed Zidonian

Gods, he was just in Hiram's wake and
 span,
 As was David before. And if he went
 To bed with Ammonitess princess sent,
 It was to make an heir to Judah's throne.
 He couldn't leave the woman there alone
 To go to her own church. He made a deal
 That he would go with her, and on the
 wheel
 She would attend the temple with the king.
 So You can see, Beloved, this is a thing
 Still known in every Christian sort of ring.

9 So YHWH was mad at Solomon
 Because his heart had once begun
 To turn from YHWH the Alohim
 Of Israel, who had *in dream*
 Appeared to him twice *with a gleam*

The anger that You pour on Solomon
 Of course is justified for what he did,
 Though You forget humans under the sun,
 Untried by angel choirs and katydid
 Remain a sleepy crew after the dream.
 No vision of Your glory can quite keep
 For my awareness drowsing at the beam,
 Robbed by Your splendour of my needed
 sleep.
 Oft I have seen the star and heard the voice
 Mayhap of heaven's own choosing to my
 ear,
 Yet in a second lost my hope and help,
 Having but flesh and bone to sling as dice
 When faced by breath not to speak of my
 fear.
 Humans remain eyes closed like canine
 whelp.

10 And He commanded him about
 This thing, not to gad round and shout
 To other gods, but he did not
 Obey what YHWH's command had
 sought.

11 That's why YHWH said to Solomon,
 "Since you have done this *in the sun*
 And not kept My covenant and
 My statutes that I gave in hand,
 I'll surely take the reign from you,
 And give it to your servant *due*.
 12 Nevertheless I'll do it not
 In your days for the sake and lot
 Of David the father you've got.

Through all the generations of the kings
 How have You shown Your love of this
 one man!
 Each one has done his best in all the things
 So unexpected that came under scan,
 Always choosing what each one thought
 was best,
 Knowing that virtue alone cannot reach
 Each height that providence gives to invest
 Our world with challenges that seem to
 teach.
 From idol worship many did not flee,
 Doing what seemed needed before the
 threat
 Around the little island of Your grace.
 Vice was not really theirs in any case.
 I wonder why David was always met
 Dumbfounded in his own humility.

But I'll take it away from hand
 Of your son, *indeed half the land*.
 13 Howbeit I'll not rend away
 All the kingdom, but hold in sway
 One tribe to your son for the sake
 Of David my servant *and cake*,
 For Jerusalem I have chosen.
 14 And YHWH stirred up a foe arosen
 To Solomon, Hadad of Edom,
 He was of the king's seed in Edom.
 15 For it happened David *for freedom*
 Was in Edom, and Joab chief
 Of the army was on relief
 To bury the dead, after he
 Had killed all males in Edom's lea.
 16 For six months Joab stayed around
 With all Israel until he found
 And killed every man in Edom.
 17 But Hadad fled, he and a sum
 Of Edomites, servants that served
 His father, to go in unswerved
 To Egypt. 18 And they got up from
 Midian, came to Paran's *hum*
 And took men with them from Paran
 And came to Egypt to the man
 Pharaoh, king of Egypt, who gave
 Him a house, food and land *to save*.

David, Beloved, seems to be the aggressor
 Here as he struck down Edom's priest
 confessor

And kept his general for six months
running
In genocide of all the males and cunning.
Today the media would show the man
In the same light as, well, name as name
can

Among abundant tyrants of the race.
David would now have firm honour and
place
With Nazi, Communist, and Democrat
In every Republican place they're at.
The Pharaoh would come smelling unlike
rat
For having set asylum, board and room
To refugee: et plus ça change for gloom
The more I recognize the day of doom.

19 And Hadad before Pharaoh found
Great favour, so that he was bound
To give him as wife sister of
His own wife, sister *and the love*
Of Tahpenes the queen *above*.
20 Tahpenes' sister bore to him
His son Genubath, whom in trim
Tahpenes weaned in Pharaoh's room.
21 And when Hadad heard of the doom
Of David in Egypt, that he
Slept with his fathers and that wee
Joab the chief of his army
Was dead, Hadad said to Pharaoh,
"Let me depart, that I may go
To my own country *and my show*."
22 Then Pharaoh said to him, "But what
Have you lacked with me here in gut
That you seek to go to your land?"
And he answered, "Nothing at hand,
But anyway let me go out
And see what my country's about."

When traitor and tyrant have gone the way
Of all flesh, those who baited death's
decay
Come out of hiding to take arms again.
And they are not suspected to be men
Of cruelty and wrath, since they are those
Who suffered in the early time the throes
Of tyrants' plagues upon their shins and
toes.
It's blue-eyed pity combined with false
hope
That plays the rerun of captain and pope.
Failure to believe that the rising star

Is just as bloody as the one with scar
Is what prevents the ending of the hate
That sets the world up for the rich and
great.
We're satisfied to own a brand new car.

23 And Alohim raised up a foe,
Rezon son of Eliadah,
Who fled from his lord on the go,
Hadadezer king of Zobah.
24 And he gathered men unto him,
And became chief of a band grim,
When David killed them there they went
To Damascus, and stayed in tent
And reigned in Damascus' *ascent*.
25 And he was foe to Israel
All Solomon's days besides spell
Of mischief that Hadad did well
And he hated both Israel
And reigned over Syria a spell.

The government in exile is a thing
Created long ago by ancient king.
Besides the ones ambitious with a pile
Of land to rule upon mile upon mile
There are those who reign over memories,
And sometimes even golden jubilees
With shekels stashed away in case the
breeze
Turns once again and gives them room to
rout
And engage in the game instead of pout.
Beloved, let me be king of my own hand
To keep it from disgrace of contraband
In sinful action, nay, even in word,
And keep my very thoughts in purer herd.
My government in exile's Your demand.

1 Kings 12

1 And Rehoboam went up to
Shechem, for all Israel in crew
Had come to Shechem to make him
King. 2 And it happened *on a whim*
Nebat's son Jeroboam, who
Was still in Egypt heard *what's new*,
3 And they sent and called him up too.
And Jeroboam and the church
Of Israel came to the perch
And spoke to Rehoboam, saying
4 "Your father made our yoke in paying
A hard one, now then make the hard
Service of your dad lighter card

Than what he laid on us, and we
Will serve you *also thankfully*."

Here's the first lobby known to history.
Approach the ruler with a smile and see
If he'll leave off his gloating treachery.
Ask any king, Beloved, to set aside
A bit of the oppression and abide
In justice and see what is his response.
Just that You've interrupted royal jaunts
Suffices to make irritation bounce.
See, he'll even grimace before the pounce.
Beloved, there is no way to test Your
throne,
Because Your yoke's so light I can't atone.
Obedience to You brings only rest
And crowns with hope even the hopeless
nest.
I bow, Beloved, to You and You alone.

5 And he said to them, "Take your way
For three days, then come on a day
To me." And so the people left.
6 Rehoboam took counsel deft
With the elders that stood before
Solomon his father to score
While he still lived, and said "How do
You advise I should give this crew
An answer?" 7 And they spoke to him
Saying "If you'll cut down and trim
Yourself to serve this folk today
And answer them in good words sway,
They'll serve you always and a day."
8 But he ignored the counsel given
By the old men which they gave shriven,
And asked the young men what to do,
Who had grown up with him in view.
9 And he said to them, "What advice
Do you give to me to say nice
To this folk who have approached me
Saying 'Make the yoke which *in fee*
Your father laid on us to be
A lighter one *than what we see?*'"
10 And the young men grown up with him
Spoke to him saying a word dim,
"So shall you speak to this folk that
Spoke to you saying where you're at,
Saying your father made our yoke
Heavy, but make it *at a stroke*
Lighter for us, so shall you say
To them 'My little finger's *sway*
Shall be thicker than my dad's hip.

11""And as my dad did load your ship
With heavy loads, I'll add to it,
My dad punished you with a whip,
But I with scorpions as fit.""

It's not the age and wisdom makes the
deal,
Although the youth had never felt the heel
Of warfare and of danger in the weal.
Perhaps the aged men were wise because
They remembered David's fleeing the
claws
Of son and usurper upon the plain.
But counsel of experience is vain.
A young man too may be wise if he's
caught
Up in Your law to find celestial plot.
It's not age nor the wisdom that is taught,
But willingness to bow to Your throne's
grace
And find the joy of serving in Your place.
Beloved, give me good counsel nor let me
Be counsellor of any wickedly.

12 So Jeroboam and the folk
All came to Rehoboam *bloke*
Once more on the third day *for stroke*.
13 And the king answered harshly to
The people and forsook the due
Counsel of the elders in view.
14 And spoke to them by the advice
Of the young men saying not nice,
"My father made heavy your yoke,
And I will add to it a stroke,
My father punished you with whips,
But I'll lay on scorpions' lips."
15 So the king did not listen to
The people, because it was YHWH
That was behind it that He might
Carry out His saying for spite
Which YHWH spoke by Ahijah's word,
The Shilonite and which was heard
By Jeroboam Nebat's son
To end the reign of Solomon.

I'll bet the young men that thought up that
word
Of scorpions thought their humour
unblurred,
And considered the show of arrogance
Would scare the people out of eager prance
To gain an independence in their pants.

I'll bet the young men jiggered in their wit
 And chuckled in their beer to have a fit
 That they came up with such a fine repast
 Of rhetoric to make the kingdom last
 In the oppression they wanted as fast.
 Taxation by the king turns out to be
 More for the sycophant courtiers in fee.
 Beloved, Your court is grand enough for
 me
 With no tax on the oak or the pine tree.

16 And when all Israel saw the king
 Would not *then* listen to their thing,
 The folk answered the king and said
 "What share have we in David's *spread*?
 We've no inheritance *at all*
 In son of Jesse's *tents and stall*,
 So off to your tents, Israel,
 And look to your own house *as well*,
 David." So Israel departed
 To their tents not *at all downhearted*.

When this rebellion happened to grandson
 Of David, it must be remembered one
 Was not so blinded by his fame and fire.
 David was just a ruler and a squire
 Of the old school, a man that dad
 remembered
 Not always with the good-will he
 engendered.
 Now David is so famous he is taught
 In many faiths to be a prophet sought
 As well as king and divine guide, who
 wrought
 In iron and in faith and music fine.
 He'd be a welcome guest today to dine.
 But when these people asked the fatal
 question,
 His fame was hardly more than a
 suggestion,
 His Psalms hardly remembered for their
 shine.

17 But folk of Israel who dwelt
 In Judah's cities felt *the belt*
Of Rehoboam's rule and welt.

18 King Rehoboam sent Adoram
 Over the tribute there to floor them,
 And all Israel stoned him with stones,
 So that he died and left his bones.
 King Rehoboam in his haste
 Got in his chariot, outpaced

Back to Jerusalem *disgraced*.
 19 So Israel rebelled and went
 Against the house of David *rent*
 Up to this very day *unspent*.

No doubt the lord Jesus in parable
 Got his own story from the fate in full
 Of Adoram who as ambassador
 Was slaughtered for his taxing of the poor.
 My principles are set in heart and stone
 And include saving alive flesh and bone,
 But perhaps these folk had forgotten law
 And what happened on Sinai to their awe.
 Beloved, I grieve the sin of killing off
 Even the civil servants with a scoff
 Who are not always civil, yet I smile
 To think of Rehoboam's record mile.
 Kings and their tax collectors make a pair
 Of scallywags just about everywhere.

20 It happened when all Israel heard
 That Jeroboam had been spurred
 To come again, that they sent and
 Called him to the assembled band,
 And made him king of Israel,
 And there was none that followed well
 The house of David but the tribe
 Of Judah only *without bribe*.

I've noticed, my Beloved, the nouveau
 riche
 Are generally noisy in their niche.
 The heir of factory is blander than
 The foreman who was once a handy-man.
 If Rehoboam shows an ugly tooth
 Then Jeroboam will, to tell the truth,
 Be worse a tyrant than the spoiled brat who
 Was brought up to the throne in golden
 shoe.
 But let the people make the same mistake,
 Perennial philosophy's a fake,
 And all who bite the bit will come to know
 The power of tyranny before the show
 Of justice that they hoped would heal the
 breach
 Between the almond and the pining peach.

21 When Rehoboam had come back
 To Jerusalem, he's not slack
 To gather all of Judah's house,
 With tribe of Benjamin *to grouse*,
 A hundred and eighty thousand

Choice men and warriors in their band
 To fight against Israel's house and
 To bring the kingdom to the hand
 Again of Rehoboam, son
 Of *good and wise king* Solomon.
 22 But Alohim's word came upon
 Shemaiah, man of God at dawn,
 Saying 23 "Speak to Rehoboam
 The son of Solomon in scam
 The king of Judah, and to all
 The house of Judah and the wall
 Of Benjamin, and to the rest
 Of the people saying for best,
 24 'So says YHWH, "You shall not go up
 Nor fight against your brothers' cup,
 The folk of Israel, return
 Every man to his house and learn
 This thing is from Me.'"" So they heard
 YHWH's word and turned back in a herd
 According as YHWH said the word.

For once, Beloved, You had the wit to stay
 The mouth of sword before the break of
 day.

In most accounts the kings are out to kill
 And You are there to help them get their
 fill.

Praise to Your name, Beloved, and may
 You be

Ever ready to solve thing peaceably,
 Since there is hardly general to wage
 Peace rather than war on the worldly stage.
 Beloved, see how You sent prophetic word
 One time, and glory be, that word was
 heard,

And so ten thousand widows in the loss
 Were spared their husbands at a wing and
 toss.

If only all wars met the same dark fate
 And prophet listened then not to be late.

25 Then Jeroboam built Shechem
 In mount Ephraim and set *the stem*
 Of his dwelling there, and went out
 From there to build Penuel *stout*.

26 Then Jeroboam told himself,
 "Now the kingdom that's on my shelf
 Will go again to David's crew
 27 "If this folk travel there to do
 Sacrifice in the house of YHWH
 At Jerusalem, then the heart
 Of this folk will return in part

To their lord, to Rehoboam
 King of Judah, and *as I am*
 They'll kill me, and go back again
 To Rehoboam king of men
 In Judah's *every town and den*."

Admit, Beloved, that Jeroboam's thought
 Is cunning, shrewd and wittily true
 wrought.

The simple truth is going up to pray
 In Judah's capital was like to pay
 With Jeroboam taking second place
 Before the house of David to his face.
 The man is not a dumbbell now admit
 That what he says is true and truly fit.
 Beloved, You called the man to be the king
 In situation, impossible thing,
 So if he finds a worldly way to keep
 The kingdom You gave him, why should
 he reap

Your anger if that way's worldly and wise
 To set idolatry before Your eyes?

28 And so the king asked for advice,
 And made two calves of gold and nice,
 And told them, "It's too much for you
 To go up to Jerusalem.
 See your gods, O Israel, in view
 That brought you from Egyptian hem."

See here, Beloved, the golden calf is just
 The vehicle of deity and dust
 Of gold to represent the one true God.
 It's something once invented on the sod
 Of Egypt, the great Egypt and not by
 Jeroboam in secret on the sly.
 Everyone then knew that one god alone
 Always came as sun disc upon the throne
 Of golden calf, and only the few knew
 To question what was always held as true.
 Beloved, the heathen word's tradition's
 pen

And always right according to most men.
 If men forget You, You created them
 With mythopoeic minds for stratagem.

29 He set one in Bethel, the other
 He put in Dan to be *its brother*.

30 And this thing became for a sin
 For the folk went to worship in
 Dan the one. 31 And he made a house
 Of high places *for men and grouse*,

And made priests of the lowest folk
Who were not Levites *of the smoke*.

I'm not sure that the worse was turning
gold
Into an idol for both weak and bold.
The thing that turned the kingdom upside
down
Was all the new-come priests about the
town.
It's priest craft more than false concepts of
God
And idols flaming on the blessed sod
That makes corruption of both church and
state.
It's always priests not superstition's
weight.
The role of idols is to fool the mass
Of men to support priest craft and their
crass.
If Jeroboam made a bad mistake
In taking the Egyptian calf and rake,
He made a second when he ordained men
To be the preachers in his devil's den.

32 Jeroboam ordained a feast
In the eighth month and so increased
It on the month's fifteenth day, like
The feast that's in Judah *for hike*,
And made offerings upon the altar.
So he did in Bethel with Psalter,
Made offering to the calves he'd made,
And set in Bethel the priests staid
From the high places he'd waylaid.
33 So he offered upon the place
Of sacrifice he'd made to grace
Bethel on the month's fifteenth day,
In the month he had found in sway
Of his own heart, and made a feast
For all the folk of Israel fleeced,
He sacrificed on altar there
And burnt incense *upon the air*.

A new faith is always born of the way
Men seek to change the calendar and day.
Jeroboam made havoc and great grief
By placing the Passover on new leaf,
A month later than in Judah, and well
Because the northern slopes set back a
spell
Perhaps the harvest of the barley bell.
Pope Jeroboam and lord Constantine

Thought to change times and laws and to
demean
The Sabbath in the wake of Sunday's
sheen,
And so like Jeroboam cast a pall
Over the people and to make a wall
Of rebellion against Your law and will.
You have Your Jeroboams living still.

1 Kings 13

1 And see, a man of God went out
Of Judah by YHWH's word about
To Bethel, where Jeroboam
Stood by the altar with *a gram*
Of incense to burn it *devout*.
2 And he cried against the altar
By the word of YHWH and by gar
Said "O altar, altar, so said
YHWH, 'See, a child once more is bred
To be born to David's house and
His name's Josiah, and on you
Shall he offer the priestly crew
Of high place that burn scent on you,
And men's bones shall be burnt on you."
3 And he gave the same day a sign
Saying "This is the self-same sign
Of which YHWH's spoken, *see the place*
Of this altar shall break, *disgrace*,
The ashes poured out from its *face*."

Ali is prophesied by Moses' mouth,
And David rose from Hebron in the south
To tell of Ahmed's coming in the Psalms.
But few are mentioned by name under
palms
Of prophecy long years before their birth.
Josiah's an exception of some worth.
I note that Jesus is not in this crowd
Of the elite: one divine guide allowed,
One prophet, and one king of Judah's land.
Few if any others by name on hand.
Let this be the blessed Bible Trinity,
And may they inspire both the bond and
free
To revere You alone, Beloved, until
A fourth may come to foot the golden bill.

4 It happened when King Jeroboam
Heard what God's man said *and to stow*
him,
Which had cried against altar there
In Bethel, he stretched out his *bare*

Hand from the altar, saying "Stay Him!" And his threatening hand that way Stretched out, dried up so he could not Pull it back however he sought.

5 The altar also did break down,
And ashes poured out *on the town*
From the altar, by the sign that
The man of God gave *caveat*
By the word of YHWH *where He sat*.

6 The king responded, saying to
The man of God, "Entreat now do
The face of your Alohim YHWH,
And pray for me, my hand may be
Cured for me again." And then he,
The man of God prayed earnestly
To YHWH and the king's hand was free
To him again like formerly.

The rebel ruler of the earth today
Is just like Jeroboam in the fray.
As soon as his heart weaken on the set
He comes to pray You for cure not to fret.
The hand that persecutes the poor and good
When stricken cries out for Your healing
hood.

Who bombs the cities of the innocent
On Sundays stands to pray that You'll
relent.
Beloved, save me from that hypocrisy
That waylays generals eternally,
And show me where to make petition just
From my position on the lowly dust.
Beloved, I stretch out both hands of my
own
Will as I stand before Your sovereign
throne.

7 And the king told the man of God,
"Come home with me and rest your pod,
And I'll give you reward *for prod*.
8 And the man of God told the king,
"If you gave half of everything
In your house, I'd not go with you,
Nor eat bread or drink water new
In this place, 9 "For it so was charged
Me by the word of YHWH enlarged,
Saying 'Eat no bread, no, nor drink
Water, nor turn upon *the brink*
Of the same way you came to link.'"

Beloved, I too reject the evil word
When it is openly displayed, offered,

But what about the hidden benefit
Spoken by those who claim to be Your fit
Vicars on earth? They all proclaim what
You

Once said on Sinai was for servant crew
And not for me. But tell me in my due
What thing I need not take into my view.
May I have other gods or idols make
To share Your name? Or may I Sabbath
break
To lay on donkey load? Dishonour Dad?
Or treat my neighbour dealing bad and
sad?

It may not be easy to reject poke
From king, but prophet is another joke.

10 So he went back another way,
And did not go by the same way
He came into Bethel that day.

11 Now there was living in Bethel
An old prophet, and his sons fell
To tell him all the works that man
Of God had done that day to scan
In Bethel, the words that he spoke
To the king, they told to the bloke
Their father *resting under oak*.
12 And their father said to them, "Which
Way did he go to follow ditch?"

For his sons had seen what way *he*,
The man of God went out *to see*,
The one who came from Judah's *lea*.
13 He told his sons, "Now saddle me
The donkey." So they all made free
To saddle him the donkey and
He rode on it *out on the land*.

14 He went after the man of God,
And found him sitting *on the sod*
Under an oak, and said to him
"Are you the man of God *not dim*
Who came from Judah?" And he said
"*I am the one who was so led*."

15 Then he said to him, "Come with me
To my house and eat bread freely."

16 And he said "I may not return
With you, nor go where you intern,
Neither will I eat bread nor drink
Water with you *drawn from the sink*.

17 "For it was said to me by word
Of YHWH, 'You shall not be once stirred
To eat bread or drink water there,
Nor turn again to go back where
You came from to the same way there.'"

18 He told him, "I'm a prophet too,
As you, and an angel spoke to
Me also by the word of YHWH,
Saying 'Bring him back with you due
To your house, that he may eat bread
And drink water.'" But what he said
Was a lie *and cunningly spread*.

How can I know, Beloved, if prophet come
In Your name is a liar and a bum?
Or if the priest that shares the bread and
wine

Is not a devil invited to dine?

The rule is here: the prophet knew what
You

Had told him in Jerusalem to do.

The prophet who came to contradict that
Was liar and a fraud there where he spat.
I find, Beloved, in every church I know
A liar in the pulpit on the go,
And in the synagogue a man for show
Who says the Sabbath's only for his toe.
Beloved, there's only You who holds the
Truth

And so I turn to You in age and youth.

19 So he went back with him and ate
Bread in his house, drank water *late*.

20 It happened, as they sat at table,
The word of YHWH came to the *able*
Prophet that brought him back *to stable*.

21 And he cried to the man of God
That came from Judah, said in prod,
"So says YHWH, 'Since you disobeyed
The mouth of YHWH, and have not stayed
To keep the commandment that YHWH
Your Alohim commanded you,

22 "'But came back here and ate your
bread

And drank your water from the spread,
Your carcass shall not come back to
The sepulchre your fathers knew.'"

23 It happened after he ate bread
And after he had drunk as led,
He saddled for him the ass which
Was for the prophet in the ditch
That he had brought back at a pitch.

24 And when he left a lion met
Him by the way and killed him yet,
And his body was thrown aside
In the path, and the donkey ride
Stood by it, and the lion too

Stood by the body *that it slew*.

The prophet of the Lord went up to scold
King Jeroboam's sin, and he was bold
And cried before the king, and gave the
sign

The king's hand should be withered by
design.

By miracle he struck the altar down,
By saying just a word against the crown.
The altar split, it's ashes spilling out,
The living God worked there without a
doubt.

The prophet then obeyed the Lord's
command

And without food and drink he left the
land.

There was another prophet living near,
Who was a true and faithful one, in fear
He served the Lord alone and prayed to
Him.

He went out with the best of thoughts,
though dim,

To give God's man some hospitality.

The prophet said "I cannot go truly
To eat or drink against the Lord's
command."

The other answered "Surely as I stand,
I too am one who speaks the Word of God,
I too work miracles, I too have trod
The straight path. God commands I deal
bread to

The hungry and give drink, and so to you
God thus commands to serve you in my
place.

It was no lie, for God observes the face
Of those who give in mercy and make
haste

In service and in charity no waste.
So he turned back to hear a prophet speak,
And gladly joined in doing for the weak.

He followed love and charity instead
Of doing what the Lord Himself had said.
A lion stood and waited on the road.
It killed him, thus he reaped what he had
sowed.

Who turn to prophets true or false to find
Excuse that God's commandments do not
bind,

Will meet the lion on the path who seeks

One to devour, so with the passing weeks,
 Let us ignore the siren call and sweet
 Though in the tongue of good men that we
 meet,
 Or in the tongue of angel, prophet, Christ.
 The words of none of these ever sufficed
 To end the clear command that God has
 spoken.
 And so let no man leave his Sabbaths
 broken.

25 And see, men passed by and they saw
 The body thrown beside the maw,
 And the lion standing there by
 The body, and they came to fly
 To the city where there lived nigh
 The old prophet *who told the lie*.
 26 When the prophet who'd turned him
 back

From the way heard it from the sack,
 He said "It is the man of God
 Who disobeyed YHWH's word and prod,
 That's why YHWH's given him as meat
 To the lion, who broke the treat,
 And killed him, just as YHWH had said
 And spoke to him here *by my spread*."
 27 And he spoke to his sons and said
 "Saddle the donkey for me *fed*."
 And they saddled just as he said.
 28 And he went out and found his body
 Thrown in the ditch and on the soddy,
 And the donkey and lion there
 Standing beside the carcass bare.

The blessed trinity stands by the road,
 Unhungry lion who has slain by goad,
 The dead man lying in the ditch a load,
 Then patiently the donkey that he rode.
 The lion is the father of all men
 And of all gods that walk that path again.
 The dead man is the son in sacrifice
 After eating and drinking to be nice.
 The spirit of all flesh is in the ass
 Calmly beside the pathway eating grass.
 Beloved, I praise You that such gods in
 three
 Do not reign over Your eternity,
 But humbly I may take for God alone
 You only who sit Sovereign on Your
 throne.

29 The lion had not stopped to eat

The carcass nor broken the meat
 Of the donkey *beside the street*.

The heathen story of the resurrection
 Of vicarious sacrifice' selection
 Is easy to extract from what takes place
 Upon the world of time and seasons' race.
 The spring of things is found in God's own
 heart
 To raise the slaughtered bull to take a part
 In entering the palace for new start.
 The thunder leaves the carcass with the
 dart
 And lets the donkey graze on pastured cart.
 Beloved, I flounder with the winter's tale
 And see the visions of the shadows flail,
 And yet I ponder why the donkey finds
 So many to worship him in the blinds.
 Your word alone on Sinai is what binds.

30 The prophet picked up the dead weight
 Of the man of God, set *in state*
 Upon the donkey, and brought back
 The man, the old prophet *not slack*
 Came to the city and to mourn
 And bury him *in his own bourn*.
 30 He laid his body in the grave
 Of his own place and mourning gave
 Over him, "O my brother, *brave!*"
 31 It happened after he had done
 Burying him, he spoke to son
 And all and said "When I am dead
 Then bury me beside the spread
 In the tomb where the man of God
 Is buried, lay my bones and sod
 Beside his bones, 32 "Because he cried
 By YHWH's word against the great pride
 Of Bethel's altar, against all
 The houses of the high place call
 Which are in Samarian stall,
 That word will come to pass withal."
 33 After this Jeroboam turned
 Not from his evil way but spurned
 Not to make lowest of the folk
 Priests of the high places *to stoke*,
 Whoever would he consecrated,
 And he became a priest elated.
 34 And this thing became as a sin
 To Jeroboam's house to *win*
 Its cutting of, destruction from
 Off the face of the earth *to come*.

When the church tells me Sunday is the
rule
Just because Constantine had gone to
school
And Mithra bore a great witness of hate
To Roman soldiers storming at the gate,
I know that when the harm is done the man
Who lied will make a show by royal plan,
And decorate the tombs of those he killed
By the word of the prophet unfulfilled.
Beloved, I share the news that lying guy
Repeated of Josiah's coming by,
And I share his desire to take the blessing
From every tomb of saint about confessing,
But see hypocrisy is rampant yet
In every visitation I have met.

1 Kings 14

1 At that time Abijah the son
Of Jeroboam was undone.
2 And Jeroboam told his wife,
"Get up, please, and disguise your life,
So no one will know that you are
The wife of Jeroboam, star,
And go to Shiloh, see there lives
Ahijah the prophet who gives
The first witness that I should be
King of this people *wickedly*.
3 "And take along ten loaves of bread,
And cakes and jar of honey spread,
And go to him and he'll tell you
What fate of our child is in view."

If Jeroboam's wife had lived this day
She could have made anonymous call's
way
Or got a handle on the internet
And called herself anything she could get.
Instead of loaves of bread a credit card
Is good or better than the cash that's hard.
The wicked hide identity when they
Go to the confessional or to pray.
Beloved, let my posting to find You where
You sit behind a star and often wear
The cloak invisible that warlock's share
Be often and so often that You know
My voice before I even make a show.
Let me come before I need any care.

4 And Jeroboam's wife did so,
She got up and went to Shiloh,
And came to the house of Ahijah.

But Ahijah was blind as Niger,
For his eyes were old *from the glow*.
5 And YHWH said to Ahijah, "See,
Jeroboam's wife's come quickly
To ask you all about her son,
Because he is sick and undone,
But you shall tell her thus and so,
For it will happen in the show
When she comes in she will pretend
To be another *kind of friend*."

Blindness in this world is no fault to own,
For even dogs they say can smell the bone
Better than they can see it with their sight
So different than humans in their plight.
The sense of prophecy is equal to
The sense of smell in every canine crew,
So Ahijah knew well who came to seek
His help or Your help even without peek.
Beloved, if I were on my given way
To find Your prophet I would stop to pay
A representative to hear the word
Of scolding before the man undeterred.
But let me not pretend to be what I
Am not before prophet and Lord of sky.

6 And it happened when Ahijah
Heard the sound of her foot and claw,
As she came in the door, he said
"Come in, Jeroboam's wife led,
Why do you pretend now to be
Another, I speak heavily.
7 "Go tell Jeroboam, 'So said
YHWH Alohim of Israel's stead,
'As much as I exalted you
From among the ranks to make you
Ruler of My folk in your due,
8 "And tore the kingdom away from
The house of David, and by gum
Gave it to you, still you have not
Been like my servant David got,
Who kept my commands and who went
After Me with all his heart spent,
To do only right as I sent,
9 But you have done evil above
All that were before you in love,
For you have gone and made yourself
Other gods, molten idols' elf,
To provoke me to wrath and then
Cast me behind your back again,
10 "That's why, see, I'll bring evil on
The house of Jeroboam's *spawn*,

And cut off from Jeroboam
Who pisses against the wall *jamb*,
And him who's shut up and who's left
In Israel shall be bereft,
And I will take away what's left
Of Jeroboam's house as one
Shovels manure until it's done.

The commandment says, as does Torah
too,
That sons should not suffer what fathers
do.
And yet You cut off the poor child that's
born

To Jeroboam as though the child's scorn
Was for the father's sins. Beloved, I rant
Against such justice for the bill and cant.
Let me see like Moses before the eye
Of Enoch the purpose and reasons why
It's better that the innocent should die
Than that they should come to the throne
as kings.

I answered my own question by the by:
That death would save him from king's
wicked things.

Beloved, let me too die before my hate
Gets me in trouble with a foreign state.

11 "The one that dies there in the city
Of Jeroboam *without pity*
The dogs shall eat, and the one who
Dies in the field shall birdly crew
Eat, for the one who speaks is YHWH.
12 "Get up now then, go to your house,
And when your feet come in *like mouse*
To the city the child shall die.

13 "And all Israel shall mourn for him,
And bury him, for he *in trim*
Only of Jeroboam will
Come to the grave, for in him still
Is found some good towards YHWH the
God

Of Israel lying *in pod*
Of Jeroboam's house *for prod*.

14 "And yet YHWH shall raise up a king
Over Israel to cut the ring
Of Jeroboam in that day,
But what? It's even now, I say.

15 For YHWH shall strike Israel like reed
Is shaken in the water's speed,
And He shall root up Israel
Out of the good land, which a spell

He gave to their father and so
Shall scatter them beyond the flow
Of the river, because they've made
Their groves, and so they have waylaid
YHWH and His anger is not stayed.
16 "And He shall give up Israel
Because of Jeroboam's spell
Of sins, who sinned, made Israel
To sin *in field and citadel*. ""

The world about me grows up like a weed
To worship bowing in the wind like reed
Before the gods of wealth and stardom's
creed,

While I, Beloved, in my obscurity
Desire the wealth of Your infinity.
Beloved, I walk the groves still planted
here,

Although many are cut down in the fear
That poverty will overtake the purse
Unless the trees are sold for rags or worse.
Beloved, I walk the groves and see afar
The images engraved to every star,
And find the rites of selling to remain
As long as there are things to buy in vain.
I turn to find Your empty stall and reign.

17 And Jeroboam's wife got up
And went her way and then came up
To Tirzah: when she came up to
The threshold of the door *in view*
The child died. 18 And they buried him,
And all of Israel mourned for him,
According to the word of YHWH
Which He spoke by his servant *due*
Ahijah the prophet *in pew*.

19 The rest of Jeroboam's acts,
How he warred and by all the facts
How he reigned, see, they written down
In the book of all the enacts
Of Israel's kings *when they're in town*.
20 The days of Jeroboam's reign
Were twenty-two years *all in vain*
And he slept with his fathers and
Nadab his son ruled in the land.

So Nadab was a boy the You allowed
To sit upon the throne before the crowd
And hear his praises sung on every lip
While glory was a thing he had in grip.
His brother You let die in childhood while

The younger faced the fickle world with smile.

The former was a grace, because he met Creator with heart innocent and set.

The latter was a judgement, one that let Nadab live to commit sins to his fate.

I find myself living here also late,
Though without crown or sceptre, I relate
My sins to see if they will keep me from
Your holy day and from Your kingdom
come.

21 And Rehoboam who was son
Of Solomon reigned under sun
Of Judah. Rehoboam was
Forty-one years old when he does
Begin to reign, and he reigned just
Seventeen years upon *the dust*
Of Jerusalem, city which

YHWH had chosen out of the stitch
Of all the tribes of Israel,
To put His name down there as swell.
And his mother's name was Naamah,
An Ammonitess *with a claw*.

22 And Judah did most wickedly
Before YHWH, and provoked, you see,
Him with their sins to jealousy,
Sins they committed above all
Their fathers had done to recall.

23 For they too built them high place and
Images and groves where hills stand
And under each green tree *on land*.

24 And there were also sodomites
In the land, and they did the rites
Of wickedness that all the folk
That YHWH cast out and at a stroke
Before the people of Israel
Who finally fell by their spell.

Naamah's a common name of
Ammonitess,

One still found in Jordan's cities to bite us
When tourists look for lodgings and for
food

At the price of the locals of the brood.
A thousand Naamahs are still living there,
The name of each of them means they are
fair.

If Rehoboam's name is one to share,
Increase of the people it seems to mean,
Although when he became king on the
scene

The people decreased all about his land.
Some names are opposite to understand.
Beloved, name me in any way You choose,
But with the name do not make me to lose
My love for You alone where all abuse.

25 It came to pass in the fifth year
Of king Rehoboam's career,
That Shishak king of Egypt came
Up against Jerusalem's claim.

26 And he took away treasures from
The house of YHWH and treasures from
The king's house, he took all away,
And took all the gold shields in pay
That Solomon had made to stay.

27 King Rehoboam made instead
Shields of brass and contributed
Them to the chief of the guard who
Kept the door of the king's house *true*.

28 So it was when the king went *to*
Worship within the house of YHWH
That the guard bore them and brought back
Into the guard house *without slack*.

29 The rest of Rehoboam's acts
And all that he did *in his pacts*,
Are they not written in the book
Of Judah's kings' chronicles' *nook*?

30 And there was war between the two,
Rehoboam *ablaze anew*
Against Jeroboam as long
As they both lived *to reign for wrong*.

31 Rehoboam slept with his fathers,
And was buried there with his fathers
In David's city. And his mother's
Name was Naamah, an Ammonitess,
And Abijam his son *to spite us*
Reigned in his place *and not his brothers*.

I do not care, Beloved, for shields of gold,
I do not care for brass among the bold,
I only care that in the hidden tent
Of my heart's temple that You are present.
Let Egypt have the costly store that bound
My father to the shore and rocky ground.
Let Pharaoh take the golden store and go
Back to the Nile to fit out a ship slow
To find the burden of the sun and night.
I need no wealth but Your name in my
sight.

Beloved, I see the king go up to pray
And pity him at morn and close of day
That the public opinion spoiled his faith

And taught him to worship You and a
wraith.

1 Kings 15

1 Now in the eighteenth year of king
Jeroboam, Nebat's son's fling,
Abijam reigned on Judah's *ring*.
2 Jerusalem is where he reigned
Three years. And his mother unfeigned
Was Maachah, Abishalom's daughter.
3 And he did all the sins of *slaughter*
Of his dad done before him, and
His heart was not perfect in hand
With YHWH his Alohim, as was
David's his father's heart *and paws*.

Three years, or sixteen, does it matter now
That all are dead and gone, gone anyhow,
Though some say Arthur was also the son
Of David and such men are never done?
Anyway, three years or sixteen suffice
To live a righteous life or else to slice
Oneself a bit of devil's food cake and
Join in the celebration of the band.
Abijam, father of the sea, was named
By mother Maachah, whose name it is
claimed
Means of oppression, though she was the
daughter
Of father of peace, and he should have
taught her.
Beloved, names we give do not always
show
Reality in sun and the star glow.

4 But for David's sake then did YHWH
His Alohim give him in view
A lamp in Jerusalem, to
Set up his son after him, and
Set fast Jerusalem in land.
5 Because David did what was right
In the eyes of YHWH and turned his sight
Not aside from what He commanded
Him all his life's days, but remanded
Just in the matter of Uriah
The Hittite, *which thing was pariah*.
6 And there was war between the two,
Rehoboam who sat in view
Of Jeroboam all the days
Of his life *for abuse and praise*.
7 Now the rest of Abijam's acts,
And all he did *and all his pacts*,

Are they not written in the book
Of Judah's kings' chronicles' *hook*?
And there was war between Abijam
And Jeroboam *to oblige them*.
Abijam slept in his dad's room,
And they buried him in the tomb
City of David, and Asa
His son reigned in his place *and law*.

The lamp in its niche with the dark around
Casts light upon barren and fertile ground.
The house of David, hidden and consumed
Still brings life to the tortured and
consumed,
If only in the temple of the Psalms
That brighten chanter under pine and
palms.
The lamp of truth, the fire of faith, the light
That glitters on my pathway through the
night
And makes my night-work sweet with
cooling dews,
Is burning and eternal while I choose
To cantillate Your name, Beloved, until
The sun comes up beyond the western hill.
A lamp remains beside the temple tent
In every divine guide since then You sent.

9 In Jeroboam's twentieth year
As king of Israel *to appear*,
Asa ruled in Judah *for fear*.
10 And he reigned forty-one years in
Jerusalem, with grand-dam's grin
Whose name was Maachah, daughter of
Abishalom *as told above*.
11 And Asa did what thing was right
Before YHWH as David his wight.
12 He took away each sodomite
Out of the land, and removed site
Of idols his fathers had made,
13 And also his mom Maachah laid
Off from being queen because she
Had made an idol in the lea,
And Asa tore down her idol
And burnt it by brook Kidron's *fall*.

Good king Asa removed the sodomite
From the land. Now I wonder what the
wight
In fact did to the temple prostitutes
That ate the people leaf, stem, fruit and
roots.

It does not say he killed the wayward crew
 Of civil servants doing by the true
 Line of public opinion what was due
 To make the crops grow and the rain come
 down
 Upon the fields and villages and town.
 But he closed down the churches with their
 priests
 Who practiced sodomy with boys in feasts
 Of the dying and rising god-man's church,
 And left gullible faithful in the lurch,
 With only faith in You, God of renown.

14 While the high places were not taken
 Away, Asa's heart was unshaken
 With YHWH all his days *to awaken*.
 15 He brought in the things which his dad
 Had dedicated and the *glad*
 Things which he dedicated too,
 Into the temple-house of YHWH,
 Silver, and gold, and vessels *too*.

16 And there was war between Asa
 And Baasha king of Israel's *claw*
 All their days. 17 And Baasha the king
 Of Israel went against *the wing*
 Of Judah, and built Ramah that
 He might keep people where they sat,
 Not to go out or come in at
 Asa the king of Judah's *flat*.

18 Asa took all the silver and
 The gold that were left in his hand
 In the treasures of house of YHWH
 And the treasures of the king's due,
 And put them in his servants' hands,
 And king Asa sent them in bands
 To Benhadad, who was the son
 Of Tabrimon, of Hezion
 The son, who was Syrian king,
 Who lived in Damascus, saying
 19 "The treaty between me and you,
 Between my father and the crew
 Of your father, see, I have sent
 To you a present that is meant
 To be of silver and of gold,
 Come break your pact with Baasha bold
 The king of Israel, that he
 May get a way *from troubling me*.
 20 So Benhada obeyed the king
 Asa, and sent the captains' *sting*
 Of the army which he had to
 The cities of Israel *with crew*
 Attacking Ijon and Dan too,

And Abelsebmaachah, and all
 Cinneroth, Naphtali *in stall*.

Beloved, I take the wealth I have in hand
 And use my surplus to buy in the land
 Friends of mammon to press my innocence
 In safety though I dwell among the tents
 Of heathen and idolater. I make
 Friends of each human face that I can take
 Into the circle of my hope and trust.
 I live in an untidy world and must.
 Beloved, though I tread city street and lane
 I lift my heart to You and not in vain
 To keep me from the sinful thought and
 stain
 That would cloud my vision of You in
 train,
 Who makes from breath to breath the
 solitude
 Of briar and brake, of meadow and of
 wood.

21 It happened when Baasha heard that,
 He stopped building his Ramah flat,
 And stayed in Tirzah where he sat.
 22 Then king Asa proclaimed throughout
 All Judah, none was left in doubt,
 And they took Ramah's stones all out,
 And its timber with which Baasha
 Had built, and then built king Asa
 With them Geba of Benjamin,
 And Mizpah also *in the bin*.

The stones and timbers that my foes have
 set
 Against me, both the enemy that's met
 In the halls of the great and in the place
 Of buying and of selling without grace,
 And those foes that I meet in my own
 heart,
 I take their beams and cornerstones apart
 And from the brash attack upon my soul
 I make a fortress beyond every toll
 To rise above the tamped besiegers' grit
 Thrown up against my walls, though they
 be fit,
 To make of my walls' castle a mere plain
 Where every foot may enter and may gain
 The vision of You enthroned in my room
 Upper and inner, out of reach of doom.

23 The rest of all of Asa's acts,

And all his might with all the facts
 Of what he did, what towns he built,
 Are they not written in the *gilt*
 Book of the chronicles of kings
 Of Judah? But in old agings
 He was diseased in his feet's *springs*.
 24 Asa slept with his fathers, and
 Was buried where his fathers stand
 In the town of David his father,
 Jehoshaphat his son *then rather*
 Reigned in his place *and on his sand*.

I too have aching feet, Beloved, and I
 Awaken with their pain sometimes and cry,
 And wonder what sport or herbal
 concoction

I might find to soothe them in shop or
 auction.

They hurt when I fail to run up the hill,
 They hurt when I am outside to fulfil
 The exercises of my work and will:
 Like Asa, I know pain in cramping feet.
 Let me be like king Asa for a treat,
 Beloved, and tear down idol and the stand
 Of graven image in my heart and land.
 Let me come with Psalm to Your Sabbath
 show

And cantillate Your name where I may go.
 It can be done no matter what feet know.

25 Nadab the son of Jeroboam
 Began to reign over *and blow them*
In Israel the second year
 Of Asa Judah's king's career,
 And reigned over Israel two year.

26 And he did evil in the sight
 Of YHWH, and walked in the way light
 Of his father and in his sin
 Wherewith he made Israel to sin.

27 And Baasha the son of Ahijah,
 Of Issachar's house *to abide you*,
 Conspired against him, and Baasha
 Attacked him at Gibbethon *raw*,
 Which belonged to the Philistines,
 For Nadab and all Israel's *lines*
 Laid siege to Gibbethon's *confines*.

28 And Baasha killed him in the third
 Year Judah's king Asa *was stirred*,
 And ruled in his place. 29 It occurred.
 When he reigned he attacked all of
 The house of Jeroboam's love,
 He left not to Jeroboam

Any that breathed *or suckled dam*,
 Until he had destroyed them all,
 According as the words befall
 From YHWH, which He spoke by the call
 Of His servant Ahijah who
 Was Shilonite *as was his due*.
 30 Because of Jeroboam's sins
 Which he sinned, and which he *for wins*
 Made Israel sin, by his start
 By which he provoked to *the heart*
 YHWH Alohim of Israel
 To wrath *and anger for a spell*.
 31 The rest of Nadab's acts and all
 He did are they not on the wall
 Written in the book of the kings
 Of Israel chronicled things?

Nadab had only two years in which he
 Showed all his colours and brought forth
 fully

The wickedness of his heart's gratitude.
 He was a man in a continual feud
 Both with Asa the king of Judah and
 With every Philistine upon the land.
 Traditionalist he was nonetheless
 Who followed public opinion's caress
 As well as father's ways and to confess
 The scientific view that the sun made
 The rain by sprinkling on the clouds
 arrayed.

Why do You, my Beloved, insist that You
 Be worshipped and alone of all the crew
 Of nature? Sovereignty's a harsh word
 played.

32 And there was war between Asa
 And Baasha king of Israel's law
 All the day that they *lived by claw*.

33 In the third year of Asa king
 Of Judah began Baasha's thing,
 The son of Ahijah to reign
 Over all Israel *in vain*
 In Tirzah, twenty-four years' reign.

34 And he did evil in the sight
 Of YHWH and walked in the way *light*
 Of Jeroboam, and in that
 Sin of his where he made *the fat*
 Of Israel sin *where they were at*.

I recapitulate the sin that brought
 The downfall of Jeroboam's complot.
 He made another temple to be sought

Besides the one in David's city wrought.
He made a feast like Passover untaught
A month later than what He should have
done.

He made a calf to stand under the sun
And let the sun disc represent Your fun.
This Trinity of sins is no rare thing
Today among priest, pope, ruler and king:
Idolatry, a new calendar and
A holy city usurping to stand.
Beloved keep me from every false faith
way:

The Roman, Meccan, Genevan for pay.

1 Kings 16

1 The word of YHWH came to Jehu
The son of Hanani in view

Against Baasha, saying *to do*,

2 "Since I exalted you up from

The dust and made you prince to come
Over my folk Israel, in sum

You have acted just like that bum

Jeroboam, and make my folk

Israel to sin, and to provoke

Me to anger with their sin's stroke,

3 "See here, I'll take away the seed

Of Baasha as well as the greed

Of his house, and will make your tent

Like the house Jeroboam rent,

The son of Nebat *eminent*.

4 "Who dies of Baasha in the town

The dogs will eat, and *with a frown*

Who dies of his in the fields birds

Or the air will eat *without words*."

5 Now the rest of Baasha's acts and

What he did and his power in hand,

Are they not written in the book

Of Israel's kings' chronicles' hook?

6 And so Baasha slept with his fathers,

Was buried in Tirzah with bothers,

And Elah his son reigned instead,

Let's see how well he was bred.

7 And also by the hand of prophet

Jehu son of Hanani's soffit,

Came the word of YHWH against Baasha,

And against his house, roof and fassure,

For all the evil that he'd done

In the sight of YHWH under sun

To provoke him to wrath by what

His hands had done, just like the mutt

House of Jeroboam, also

Because he killed him *in the show*.

8 In Asa king of Judah's year

Twenty-six Elah came to rear

Over Israel, the son of Baasha

In Tirzah for two years *of fear*.

9 And his servant Zimri, the chief

Of half his chariots in relief

Conspired against him when he was

In Tirzah, drinking as one does,

Drunk in the house of Arza who

Was steward of his house and crew

In Tirzah. 10 And Zimri went in

And struck him down and did him in,

The twenty-seventh year that king

Asa of Judah reigned, so he

Ruled in his place *most wickedly*.

11 It happened when he started to

Reign, as soon as he sat in view

On his throne, it happened he slew

All the house of Haasha and crew.

He left him not a single one

That pisses on the wall when done,

Not of his kin nor of friends won.

12 So Zimri destroyed all the house

Of Baasha, according to nous

Of YHWH, that He spoke against him,

Baasha by Hehu, prophet grim.

13 For all the sins of Baasha and

The sins of Elah, son at hand,

By which they sinned and by which they

Made Israel to go astray,

In provoking YHWH Alohim

Of Israel to wrath in scheme

Of all the vanities *in dream*.

Now the rest of Elah's acts and

All that he did, do they not stand

Written in the book of the kings

Of Israel, chronicled things?

15 And in the twenty-seventh year

Of Asa king of Judah's gear

Did Zimri reign seven days in

Tirzah. And the folk set to win

Against Gibbethon Philistine.

16 The people encamped there heard say

Zimri's conspired and gone to slay

The king, therefore all Israel made

Omri, captain of the host paid,

King over Israel that day

In the camp *so he'd have his say*.

17 Omri went up from Gibbethon,

And all Israel with him *at dawn*,

And they besieged Tirzah anon.

18 It happened when Zimri saw that

The city was taken *down flat*,
 That he went in the palace, sat
 And burned the king's house over him
 With fire and so he died there *grim*.
 19 For his sins which he sinned to do
 Evil and in the sight of YHWH
 In doing Jeroboam's way,
 And in the sin he did to make
 Israel to sin, *err and mistake*.
 20 The rest of Zimri's acts and his
 Treason that he wrought there, that is,
 Are they not written in the book
 Of chronicles of Israel's rook?
 21 Then Israel's folk were split in two:
 Half of the people followed *true*
 Tibni the son of Ginath to
 Make him king, and half wanted to
 Make Omri king and ruler *due*.
 22 But the folk that followed Omri
 Won against those who were party
 To Tibni son of Ginath, so
 Tibni died, to Omri *bravo*.
 23 In the thirty-first year of king
 Asa of Judah did the ring
 Of Omri begin over folk
 Of Israel, twelve years to a stroke,
 Six years he reigned by Tirzah's *oak*.
 24 Then he bought the hill of Shemer
 Called Samaria to confer
 For two talents of silver and
 Built on the hill and called the stand
 Samaria, city he built,
 After the name and honour gilt
 Of Shemer, owner to the hilt.
 25 But Omi did the evil thing
 In the eyes of YHWH and failing
 He was worse than all in the ring.
 26 For he walked in all of the way
 Of Jeroboam the son's play
 Of Nebat and in all his sin
 By which he made Israel to sin,
 To provoke YHWH Alohims of
 Israel to wrath with their vain love.
 27 The rest of Omri's acts which he
 Did and his power worked wonderfully,
 Are they not written in the book
 Of Israel's kings' chronicles? Look!
 28 So Omri slept among his own
 Ancestors, was buried alone
 In Samaria, and Ahab
 His son reigned in his place *to stab*.
And in Omri's eleventh year

Jehoshaphat the son and dear
Of Asa began his reign at
Thirty-five years of age and sat
As king kin Jerusalem for
Twenty-five years, and on that score
His mother's name was Gazuba
Daughter of Seli and his draw
Was to walk in the way of his
Dad Asa and not turn to quiz
From it and doing what is right
In the eyes of YHWH, only they
Did not remove the high place gay,
they sacrificed and burnt incense
On the high places in their tents.
Now the engagements that were made
But Jehoshaphat with the staid
King of Israel and all his deeds
Of greatness that he did with speeds,
And the foes he attacked, see, are
They not writ in the book where star
The chronicles of Juhah's kings?
And what was left of the whoredoms
They practiced in the days tumtums
Of Asa his father he put
Out of the land. There was no foot
Of king in Syria, but viceroy.
And King Jehoshaphat for toy
Made a ship at Tarsus to go
To Ophir for gold, but in tow
It did not go, for the ship floundered
At Gasion Gaber unbounded.
The king of Israel said to him,
Jehoshaphat, "I shall send trim
Your servants and mine in the ship,
But Jehoshaphat would not grip.
Jehoshaphat slept with his fathers
And is buried there with his fathers
In the city of David spread,
And Joram his son reigned instead.
 29 And in Asa's thirty-eighth year
 As king of Judah, Ahab's gear
 As son of Omri came to reign
 Over Israel, and Ahab's train
 As son of Omri ruled over
 Folk of Israel in Samaria
 The twenty-two years of his reign.
 30 And Ahab son of Omri did
 Evil in sight of YHWH to bid
 Above all that before him did.
 31 It happened, as if it had been
 A light thing for him in the sin
 Of Jeroboam Nebat's son

To walk, so he took a wife won
Named Jezebel, daughter of king
Ethbaal of the Zinonian ring,
And went and served Baal and fell down
To worship him *like foolish clown*.

32 And he reared up an altar for
Baal in the house of Baal and store,
That he build at Samaria's *door*.

33 And Ahab made a grove, Ahab
Did more to provoke in confab
YHWH Alohim of Israel's wrath
Than all the kings in Israel's path
That were before him *on the scab*.

34 In his days Hiel the Bethelite
Built Jericho, he laid height
Of the foundation on his son
Abiram his firstborn when done
And set up the gates of it on
His youngest Segub, but the wan
Word of YHWH which he spoke by one
Jushua who was son of Nun.

1 Kings 17

1 And Elijah the Tishbite who
Who was among Gilead's crew
Said to Ahab, "As does live YHWH
Israel's Alohim, before whom
I stand, there shall not be *for doom*
Dew or rain in the years *to come*
Except by my word *wranglesome*."

2 And YHWH's word came to him and
said

3 "Get out of here and take the spread
Towards the east and hide yourself
By the brook Cherith like an elf
Before the Jordan river-bed.

4 And it shall be that you will drink
From the brook, and I've told a rink
Of ravens to bring you food there.

5 So he went and did by the share
Of YHWH's word, for he went to live
By the brook Cherith *fugitive*
Before the Jordan's *thoroughfare*.

5 The ravens brought him bread and meat
In the morning and for a treat
Bread and meat in the evening too,
And he drank from the brookly dew.

My goodness, I don't think that I could
take
That much meat in a day, for breakfast
steak

And when come supper time another slab
Or two of the same carrion ravens grab.
I wonder that the prophet can find strength
To stomach such a meal, though sure at
length

Hunger would drive the purest body's soul
To gobble rotting swine flesh on the dole.
The fact is You gave laws that can be kept
Only by those in favour with the prepped.
The truly faithful find their earthly store
Of meal and oil and safety on that score
A minimal beside the luxury
Of those who worship at Ahab's belfry.

7 And after a time it occurred
The brook dried up *for beast and bird*
Because there was not seen or heard
Rain in the land *by gallows-bird*.

8 And YHWH's word came to him and
said

9 "Get up and go to Zarephath
Which is along Zidonian path,
And live there, see, I've told a widow
There to support you *and her kiddo*.

Now this is typical, I do say here,
That widows and orphans support in gear
And oil and wine and white bread on the
table

The priest and ruler in true life and fable.
The one who barely can scrape by the
while

Her health abides is who with cheerful
smile

Gives Sunday dinner to the preacher and
Fills his pockets with something more than
sand.

Beloved, I thank You that You have kept
me

From that table and from that drunken
spreed.

Though I admit, when I have been in
trouble,

It's sometimes been the widow with burst
bubble

Who came to my rescue, the one who
needed

Herself her funds and buns, and yet
acceded.

10 So he got up and made his way
To Zarephath, without delay

He came to the gate of the town
 And see, the widow woman's gown
 There gathering sticks, and he called
 To her and said "Bring me appalled
 Please some water in a cup so
 I may have a drink of the flow.
 11 As she was leaving on that task
 He called after her then to ask,
 "Bring me, please a bite of bread too
 In your *kind* hand, *if you will do*.
 12 And she said "YHWH your Alohim
 Lives, but I have no cake *or cream*,
 But just a handful of meal left
 In the container and the cleft
 Of a drop of oil in a jar,
 And see I'm gathering here a pair
 Of sticks that I may go and cook
 It for myself and my son, look,
 That we may eat it and then die."
 13 Elijah told her, "Fear no wry,
 Do as you've said, but make me first
 A little cake of not the worst
 And bring it to me and then make
 For you and for your son's sweet sake.
 14 "For so says YHWH and Israel's God,
 'The meal box shall not lack a pod
 Nor shall the jar of oil be gone
 Until the day YHWH sends upon
 The earth the *lovely* rain *at dawn*.'"

I know how You do things, Beloved, and
 how
 Your prophets speak to man and bull and
 cow,
 Requiring faith and sacrifice to meet
 The rising sun as well as setting feet.
 So I'm surprised Elijah promised that
 The meal and oil would grace her habitat
 If she gave to the prophet first a bite.
 At least this once You gave a ray of light
 Before the act of faith. It's rarely done.
 More often than Exodus under son
 Your servant builds the pyramids and
 stores
 Of unrighteous and tyrant Pharaoh boars.
 I thank You for this prophet's words
 beyond
 Your stores of meat and bread and magic
 wand.

15 And she went and did by the word
 Of Elijah, and it occurred

That she and he and her house all
 Ate every day to the next fall.
 16 The box of meal lacked not its store,
 The jar of oil contained the more
 According to the word of YHWH
 That He spoke by Elijah's clue.

It seems to me amazing that the oil
 Did not run out but always at the toil
 Of widow and of orphan ran the more.
 The wolf always remained outside the
 door.

A year of days three people ate the scrap
 Of meal and oil cast from the widow's lap.
 I wonder how much miracle You do
 Today across a world where not a few
 Widows and orphans find their life is
 strewn.

How many secret times You come in boon.
 The tons of human flesh that die each day
 Of malnutrition might belie the way
 You act to temper evil on the score
 Of humans who hoard wealth and shut the
 door.

17 After that it occurred the son
 Of the woman of the house run,
 Got sick and was really bad off,
 Indeed he did not breathe *or cough*.
 18 And she said to Elijah then,
 "What have I in Your faith or den,
 O man of Alohim? Did you
 Come here to me to show my due
 Of sin in memory and to
 Kill my son *with nothing to do*?"
 19 And he said to her, "Give to me
 Your son." And he took him a wee
 Out of her lap and carried him
 Up to the loft the interim
 Where he himself lived and laid him
 On his own bed *there trim and prim*.

I guess there may be some in solitude
 Of their own pew and goodness once
 accrued
 Who note that punishment is always there
 For those who fail to carry out their share
 Conforming to the expectation of
 The folk and their elected leaders' love.
 The widow's son died no doubt in such
 minds

Because she gave him a room without
blinds.

Beloved, I've heard the faithful say again
Why accident occurred to wench or men,
Because they did not attend church enough
Or did not spend their tithe on holy stuff.
Beloved, I doubt the word of holy people
Gathered to gripe beneath a soaring
steeples.

20 And he cried unto YHWH and said

"O YHWH my Alohim *biped*,
Have You also brought ill upon
The widow with whom I was drawn
To stay with by killing her spawn?"

21 He stretched himself upon the child
Three times and cried unto YHWH wild
And said "O YHWH my Alohim,
I pray You, let this child's soul seem
To come to him out of the dream."

22 And YHWH heard Elijah's voice and
The soul of the child by command
Came into him again and he
Revived *from death most wonderfully*.

23 Elijah then took up the child
And brought him down from his room
styled

Into the house and gave him back
To his mother and without slack
Say "See your son's alive *on track*."

24 The woman told Elijah, "Now
By this I know that You somehow
Are a man of Alohim, that
YHWH's word as truth in your mouth sat."

It's clear this is no miracle at all,
But mouth to mouth resuscitation's pall.
They only thought Your hand was there to
call
The life and breath back into one so small.
In fact I see the miracle repeated
Each time I take a breath and undefeated.
The death that threatens me each time I let
Out my breath will no doubt catch me once
yet.

Until then miracles remain for me
Twenty times in the minute while I'm free
To deal with other things forgetting Your
Kiss of life creating my life and more.
Beloved, the child I am gets up again
To find myself alive in earthly den.

1 Kings 18

1 Many days passed and then the word
Of YHWH came to Elijah stirred
In the third year, saying "Go show
Yourself to Ahab and I'll blow
The rain upon the earth below."

2 So Elijah went to present
Himself to Ahab and there went
A great famine in every tent
Samaritan. 3 And Ahab called
Obadiah who unenthralled
Was ruler of his house installed.

4 For as Jezebel cut off such
As were prophets of YHWH as much
Obadiah took of their number
One hundred prophets and to slumber
Hid them by fifty in a cave
And fed them bread and water's wave.

5 And Ahab said to Obadiah,
"Go into the land and pariah
To all the springs of water and
To all the brooks and if off hand
We might find grass to save the horses
And mules alive that in their courses
We do not lose all in the land."

6 So they divided up the land
Between them to go through the strand.
Ahab went one way by himself
And Obadiah took the shelf
The other way and by himself.

Though Ahab was a wicked man indeed,
And selfish as the first Genevan creed,
Still he is willing to walk several mile
To save the livestock from the horsemeat
pile.

There's none but has redeeming form and
face

Or some feature of mercy and of grace.
Even Hitler they say cried when his pet
Canary bird lay cold and firmly set.
Beloved, we all remember in our way
To keep the law You spoke on Sinai's day,
But few remember to keep all ten right.
And that is what I lay before Your sight.
May I if I alone keep all ten laws
In thought and word and even deed of
paws.

7 As Obadiah's on the way,
See, Elijah *to his dismay*,
Met him, and he was recognized,

And Obadiah when surprised
 Fell on his face and said "Are you
 My lord Elijah *in the stew?*"
 8 And he answered him, "Yes, it's me,
 Go tell your master and lord, 'See,
 Elijah's here *and he's still free.*'"
 9 And he said "What have I done now
 In way of sin that you would plough
 Your servant beneath Ahab's hand
 To kill me *and mine off the land?*
 !0 "As YHWH your Alohim does live,
 There's no nation *beneath the sieve*,
 Or kingdom where my lord has not
 Sent to seek you, and when he got
 The answer no, he made them swear
 They did not find you anywhere
 In the kingdom and nation there.
 11 "And now you say 'Go tell your lord,
 See, Elijah is here and floored.'
 12 "And it will happen just as soon
 As I have turned back from your boon,
 A wind from YHWH will blow you where
 I do not know, but have a care,
 And so when I come tell Ahab,
 And he can't find you where to grab,
 Then he will kill me, but I fear
 YHWH from my youth, your servant dear.
 13 "Did no one tell my lord what I
 Did when Jezebel made a try
 At killing all YHWH's prophets, how
 I hid a hundred men somehow
 Of YHWH's prophets by fifty strong
 In a cave and fed them along
 With bread and water *and a song?*
 14 "And now you say 'Go tell your lord
 See, Elijah whom you abhorred,
 Is here, and he'll kill me *by sword.*'"

The best humour I find is with the mate
 Who doesn't realize that wicked state
 Of comic that is natural to his view.
 He's funny because he has not a clue.
 Well Obadiah's such a man, though truth
 Be told despite his size and hollow youth
 What he says of the danger in the smile
 Of Ahab is not just a funny style.
 The man's too serious for his worth, and
 yet
 His serious bone is what, when the sun set
 Of faithfulness, pushed him to save a share
 Of prophets snatched from hand of death
 and bare.

I thank You, my Beloved, for such men
 still
 In courts of Vatican, Capitol Hill.

15 Elijah said "As YHWH of hosts
 Lives, before whom I stand with boasts,
 I'll surely show myself today
 To him *and you shall live for pay.*"
 16 So Obadiah went to meet
 Ahab, and told him, what a feat,
 And Ahab went to meet Elijah,
The man he looked for to confide you.
 17 It happened when Ahab then saw
 Elijah, that Ahab *from craw*
 Said to him "Are you the one that
 Troubles Israel *without rain's spat?*"

The men in power always think the true,
 The lowly and the righteous, the such few,
 Are to blame for the evils that they do
 Themselves upon the ravages of earth.
 Such are the kings and presidents in worth,
 To say no word at all of civil servant.
 But Obadiah is a man most fervent,
 And bravely meets Ahab to tell the news,
 Who promptly blames Elijah for his dues.
 Beloved, of four types of men here are
 three:
 The armed hand who obeys the mystery
 Of wickedness and claims to rule in state,
 The hiding prophet, and the silent mate
 Who works behind the scenes for good
 rebate.

18 And he answered, "Not I, not I
 Have troubled Israel *on the sly*,
 But you and your father's house in
 That you forsook commands for sin
 Against YHWH, and followed Baalim.

Elijah is not scared of anything
 Since he knows God sent him to tell the
 king
 A straight word and a truthful one to show
 The king the evil in his come and go.
 Ahab might well have cut his throat right
 then,
 But Elijah is not afraid of men.
 The cause is cleverly wound out in books
 Of social science and in proudful looks
 Of politicians as well as the hooks
 Of priest craft garnered in irrational.

But such causes fail to measure the sal.
The reason for the evil on the land
Is simply wicked doing by the band
That serves the government and tries to
stand.

19 Now send and gather Israel,
All to me on the mount Carmel,
And the prophets of Baal *to number*
Four hundred and fifty *to slumber*,
And the prophets of the groves four
Hundred eating upon the score
Of Jezebel *not to encumber*.

20 So Ahab sent to all the folk
Of Israel, and gathered by stroke
The prophets to Mount Carmel's *oak*.

21 Elijah came to all the folk
And said "How long do you *each bloke*
Waver between two ways *of being*?

If YHWH is Alohim, *agreeing*
Then follow Him, but if Baal is,
Then follow him *in all your biz*."
But the people did not tell him
A single word *they were so grim*.

22 Elijah told the people then,
"I only I remain a prophet
Of YHWH, but Baal's prophets to scoff at
Are four hundred and fifty men.

23 "Let them therefore give us two bulls,
And let them choose for miracles
One bull for themselves and cut it
In pieces and lay on wood fit,
And set no fire, and I will dress
The other bull and then *address*
To lay it on the wood and put
No fire under it *or its foot*.

24 "Call on the name of your gods and
I'll call on the name of YHWH's hand,
And the Alohim by command
That answers by fire, let him stand
As Alohim." And all the folk
Answered and said "Good and well spoke."

25 Elijah said to Baal's prophets,
"Choose one bull for yourselves and sofits,
And dress it first, for you are many,
And call on your gods' name or any,
But do not set fire to the fenny."

26 So they took the bull given them,
And they prepared *it from cuff to hem*,
And called upon the name of Baal
From morn till noon, saying "O Baal,
Hear us!" But no voice answered them.

Then they jumped all around the place
Of sacrifice they'd made *scapegrace*.

I cast aside at last the melodies
Of heathen worship in loving frenzies,
That seem to be a way that's right to men
But are the path to darkened hearts again.
Let nothing have a hold, Beloved, on me
But words borne on Your tongue to make
me free.

Break You the binding fetters that I fail
To see because of the illusion's veil.
You sing the universe into its being,
Sing me thus into hearing, into seeing
The glories that are multiplied in You
And in Your words and everything You do.
Beloved, let there be no song but the tried
In which my soul in You comes to abide.

27 It happened when noon came Elijah
Made fun of them and said "Don't hide
you,

Yell louder, since he is a god,
Maybe he's talking for a prod,
Or hunting or on a long trip,
Or maybe he's asleep, some lip
Will wake him up, *so rant and rip*."

Though I make no bones that Elijah
mocked
The pagan priest and prophet when he
stocked

The sacrificial load on Carmel's brow,
I don't hold it a good example now.
There are too many in this fearful place
Who use their self-righteous excuse to face
The disagreeable with rant and laughter
Not caring who or what is tumbling after.
Beloved, let me be courteous and just
Even to priest and prophet of the crust
Of this world's false religions shining
where

The wealth and prestige of liar and thief
Usurp the faithful heritage and share.
Politely I go down to my own grief.

28 And they shouted louder and cut
Themselves *as they do in their rut*
With knives and daggers till the blood
Gushed out upon them in a flood.

The practice of shouting and cutting self

Was anciently practiced by satyr's elf
In every field where gods were born and
died.

The practice has not finished in the tide
Of time before the waking of the shore.
There are still those who slash the open
door.

I see the blackened journey meet the crowd
Upon Ashura for the craven shroud,
And know that pagan priesthood that once
cried

Before Elijah's still here to abide.
Beloved, the holy writ is still a sure
Source of wisdom to action for the poor
Despite the guidance of the vain to add
To tears and beaten breast something more
sad.

29 It happened when midday was past,
They prophesied until the cast
Of evening sacrifice was come,
But voice of neither god nor bum
Was heard nor any answer there
Nor anyone who seemed to care.

30 Elijah said to all the folk,
"Come near me." And all at a stroke
Came near to him. And he repaired
The altar of YHWH that was bared.

31 Elijah took twelve stones to make
As many as tribes for the sake
Of Jacob, to whom YHWH's word came,
Saying Israel shall be your name.

32 And with those stone he built an altar
In YHWH's name and he did not falter
To make a trench about the altar,
Big enough for two pokes of seed.

33 He laid wood in order of need
And cut the bulls in pieces, and
Laid it on the wood, and said "Fill
Four containers with water still
And pour it on the holocaust
And on the wood let none be lost."

Beloved, the altar of my heart is made
No doubt of stones instead of fleshly grade.
But on those stones twelve secret names
are laid

By which I enter in the holy place.

Beloved, the twelve names are Your given
grace.

The centuries may pock the sudden wave
Of people sleeping with the dog in cave

Until the light of dawn come to the brave,
And yet I know the secret number comes
With the divine guidance to meet the sums
Of life and of eternity in mace.

Beloved, upon the twelve names let me
lace

My praise to Your name till the night
reveal

The star that leads to the celestial wheel.

34 And he said "Do so once again."

And they did so. And he said then,
"Do so a third time." And they did
So a third time *and as he bid*.

35 The water ran around the altar,
He filled the trench *not a defaulter*.

36 It happened at the holocaust
Prophet Elijah would accost,
And said "YHWH Alohim of those
Abraham, Isaac and repose
Of Israel, let it be known
Today that You are God alone
In Israel, and I You servant,
I've done all this at Your word fervent.

I wondered at first where they got the
water,

Since there was nothing from the sky that
caught her.

How could Elijah insist that the folk
Pour for a drink cast water on the oak
And on the stones to fill in wasteful spoke
The trench about the altar till the time
That You should answer in both fire and
rhyme.

But I suppose that there was water still
Somewhere to dip up beyond the drought's
grill.

Someone had hoarded water for the break.
They did not yet know for Elijah's sake
The rain would come again. Some still
thought Baal

In scientific dress might yet prevail.
They had more water than oil and
cheesecake.

37 "Hear me, O YHWH, so this folk may
Know that You are YHWH God that they
May have their hearts turned back Your
way.

O my Beloved! How great a prayer is this!

How strong Elijah, prophet not to miss!
The great apostle James failed not to kiss
His memory, no doubt because this word
Lifts You in glory and every heart stirred.
See, I too come to prayer and bring petition
And praise and plaint and not without
contrition,

And yet I dare not bring the prayer that he
Prayed on mount Carmel and so
wonderfully.

I cannot pray for a whole people here,
I am a lone dervish, no more I fear.
I let the world roll on and pray that You
Somehow guide all who fumble for the
true,
But with each breath bring me back to
Your view.

38 Then YHWH's fire came and it
consumed
The holocaust and wood and doomed
Stones and the dust and licked up still
The water in the trench *for swill*.

I hear the raucous sounds that try to set
The defiled fire beneath the altar wet,
And close my ears to every human strain
Of holiness that pours out blood in vain.
I beg that I may sit in cold and dark
Without a candle and without a spark
To lighten me until You choose to send
Your fire and light to the hearth where I
bend.

Beloved, Beloved, the fire of love I find
Kindled upon my altar, though I'm blind,
Suffices in this world of winter storm,
Suffices as a fire to keep me warm
Though road I travel I still travel here
Alone and lonely with only my pir.

39 When all the people saw the thing
They bowed down on their faces' fling
And said "YHWH He is Alohim,
YHWH He is Alohim *to gleam!*"

You, my Beloved, are Alohim alone
And only You sit on the sovereign throne
Of universe, of world, of fire and stone.
You, my Beloved, are God and I declare
That I acknowledge no gods of the fair
But only You Creator do I dare
To own, and so I own You till the end

Of every church and synagogue and friend
Of mosque until like Elijah I spend
My life beside the juniper and by
The cave of Sinai where I hear the cry
Of wind and storm and fire come from the
sky

To say that You are God and only You
Unite all in one hope, being, and crew.

40 Elijah said to them, "Take now
The prophets of Baal, let none cow
Escaping." And they took them and
Elijah brought them down in hand
To the brook Kishon, killed them there.

41 Elijah said for Ahab's share
"Get up and eat and drink for there
Is sounding an abundant rain.

42 So Ahab went to eat again
And drink. And Elijah went up
To the top of Carmel to sup
And prostrated himself upon
The earth and put his face up drawn
Between his knees *upon the lawn*.

The one text of the Hebrew Masorete
That shows how long ago the prophet met
The duty to prayer with face on the ground
And knees drawn up and bended to the
sound

Is this. And yet the model prayer of him
Who still lives to see every prayer's true
trim

And tackle is prayed with the blood upon
The hands that killed the leaders that were
drawn

To mount Carmel to exercise their right
And duty as priests, prophets of the might
Of earthly glory and the same kings that
Still carry the load of wealth in their vat.
Here I still fall upon my face to pray
And draw my bent knees up in the same
way.

43 He said to his servant, "Go now
Look toward the sea." And anyhow
He went and looked and said "There's not
Anything there." He told the plot
"Go seven times again, a lot."

The cycle of my praying also comes
To seven in the days of the week's sums.

The seven daily prayers fall from my
tongue
Including the two night prayers said
unsung.
And so I send my soul to look upon
The bright sea shining in the glowing
dawn,
And hear her answer that the sky is clear.
I bow again, Beloved, in love and fear.
As evening draws near and the final prayer,
The seventh of the night and day of care,
Arises to Your sky I find the cloud
From the sea comes to me to speak aloud
And brings the torrents of the waited rain
In answer to my seven prayers not in vain.

44 It happened at the seventh time
He said "See, there goes up a prime
Cloud from the sea like a man's hand."
And he said "Go tell Ahab manned,
'Prepare and get you down, the rain
Will stop you if you here remain."
45 It happened in the meantime that
The sky was black with clouds that sat
And wind, and there was a great rain.
And Ahab rode Jezreel's domain.
46 YHWH's hand was on Elijah and
He tightened his belt with his hand
And ran before Ahab up to
The entrance of Jezreel in view.

See here, Beloved, this is the text I rate
And show to You my servant's role and
fate.

I run before the kings and presidents
And flatter them although I have good
sense.

Unless I run before the chariot bound
For bloody city and the queen there found,
I shall run risk of falling to the ground
In faintness for the meals that only come
To those who plough their furrows to their
drum.

I know You fed me once in wilderness
On carrion from the ravens' fields, to bless
The widow's jar and crib, but now confess
As soon as priest craft hits a snag I go
To eat sweetmeats before the glittering
show.

1 Kings 19

1 And Ahab told to Jezebel

Everything Elijah did well,
And how he'd killed the prophets with
A sword *instead of word and myth*.
2 Then Jezebel sent messenger
To Elijah to tell the fer,
"So let the gods do to me too,
If I do not make your life screw
Like the life of one of them by
Tomorrow about this time high.

The battle for justice is always lost
Just when the hero stops to count the cost.
So it has been, so it shall always be:
Success is proof, not of the poverty
That comes from faith in You, but of bereft
False faith that always consumes what is
left.

The king may hesitate to down the right,
May for a moment seem to see the light,
But there is always reason when he turns
To homeward to relinquish what he learns.
There's always vital interest of the state
And of the lobby to increase the rate.
But every battle lost for justice wins
The war of beauty against ugly sins.

3 And when he saw that, he got up
And fled for his life like a top,
And came to Beersheba which is
In Judah, left servant of his.

4 But he himself went on a day
Travelling in the desert way,
Came and sat under juniper,
And prayed to die for all the stir,
And said "It is enough, now, YHWH,
Take my life away for my due
Is not more than my fathers' *true*".

The fact is every life is not worth more
Than life of the fathers that went before.
That's hardly dismal thought to keep in
store

And shows no foul depression at the door.
Every man's fated once to live and die,
And each life passing on the glowing fly
Is worth its own infinities of hope
That beauty and justice may be one rope.
Beloved, You are perverse that You do not
Give to a man the very thing he sought.
Elijah prays to die, but then You send
A fiery chariot and so transcend
The veils of dark creation in the light

Of everlasting glory in Your sight.

5 And as he lay and slept beneath
A juniper tree, *see the wreath*,
An angel touched him and told him,
“Get up and eat, *you’re far too trim.*”

6 And he looked and see, there a cake
Baked on the coals, he was awake,
And a jar of water beside
His head. And he did eat and bide
To drink and laid him down again.

I too sleep in illusion’s soft entrain
Through days and nights, living as though
in vain,
And waking only to sip the delights
Of sherbet or to quench my hunger’s spites
With cakes baked on the coals of
anchorites.

I too sleep by the juniper in safe
Dreams of the gathered orphan and the
waif,
And find when I awake the present hand
Sent from Your heart into this human land
To nourish me where by the tree I stand.
Beloved, I drink the nectar secretly
Set by my head beneath evergreen tree,
And fash my face in Kauthar’s greening
brook
To find Your footprints everywhere I look.

7 The angel of YHWH came again
The second time and touched him and
Said “Get up, eat, the trip at hand
Is too hard for you *as you’ve planned.*”
And he got up and ate and drank,
And went in the strength that he sank
From that food forty days and nights
To Horeb mount of God’s *delights*.

I too have fasted forty days and nights
And sought Your holy mountain’s
crystallites
On which words of light and cerelean hue
Irradiate in gold, and red and blue.
I too have fasted and recited Psalms
Beneath the pine as well as under palms
To find Your word filling the universe
Annulling evil and the evil curse.
Beloved, as I stand at the threshold of
My days of fasting running in the love
Of desert and delight, I see the crown

Of Sinai glittering above the brown
Wastelands and hold my hope before Your
face
To find myself within this sacred place.

9 And he came there into a cave,
And stayed there and see *from that grave*
The word of YHWH came to him and
He said to him, “What have you *planned*
To do here, Elijah *unmanned?*”
10 And he said “I’ve been jealous for
YHWH Alohim of hosts before,
Because Israel’s fold did forsake
Your covenant and by mistake
Threw down Your altars, and they killed
Your prophets with the sword fulfilled,
And I, only I am still left,
And they would kill me too bereft.”

How many times have I felt just the same
As I gathered with one or two to claim
The promise of reciting Your dear name
Within the glowing words of Torah and
The Psalms, the Gospels and in golden
band
The holy Qur’an with the rise of dawn.
How many times as the prayer time was
drawn
Have I found I bowed with no other man
To share the glory of Your sky in scan.
Beloved, indeed Your altars are cast down
From every hill where anciently the frown
Of pagan vibrancy acclaimed the life
That was the growing fruit of all its strive.
I too have felt the sting of fuming ban.

11 And He said “Go out and stand on
The mountain before YHWH *at dawn*.
And see, YHWH passed by and a great
And strong wind broke the mountain’s
weight,
And tore the rocks in pieces where
YHWH went, but YHWH resided not
In the wind, and after the hot
Wind came an earthquake but then YHWH
Was not in the earthquake to-do.

I’ve seen strong winds since I was very
young
Come off the gulf and sing with roaring
tongue
Along the slash pines up to where live oaks

Are starkly emerald against the strokes
Of lightning laying bare the universe.
For earthquakes I have hardly been the
worse

To feel the ground weave to trip up my feet
Like drunken and to rattle and to greet
The plates and windows with its terror
there.

But in the wind and earthquake as my
share,
Just like Elijah on the holy mount,
I found them still a dark and empty fount
Unless Your voice inaudibly almost
Come to whisper along my lonely coast.

12 After the earthquake came a fire,
But YHWH was not there in the fire,
And after the fire one small voice.
13 And so Elijah heard the choice,
And wrapped his face up in his cloak,
And went out and stood there for broke
At the mouth of the cave. And see,
A voice to him that said "Tell Me
What you are doing here Elijah,
And what do you hope here will hide you?

Beloved, it's always You who gets to ask
The questions when You take a man to
task.

There's not a man alive, though dead ones
keep

The pews warm in the places where they
sleep,
Who has not burning questions that arise
Each time he stops to look up to the skies.
And when the chance appears to pin You
down,

You never say "Let's go out on the town
And I'll give all the answers to the claims
That are so often brought about in blames."
Oh no. The first thing You do is speak up
To ask a question of the human tup,
As though You needed answers. We're the
ones,

Beloved, without the wisdom of our buns.

14 And he said "I've been jealous for
YHWH Alohim of hosts before,
Because Israel's fold did forsake
Your covenant and by mistake
Threw down Your altars, and they killed
Your prophets with the sword fulfilled,

And I, only I am still left,
And they would kill me too bereft."

Beloved, I like Elijah's boldness here,
Who does not lie in simple, abject fear
But tells the truth of what he's done and
seen.

I like the man for both his guts and spleen.
Sometimes I think that I'm alone to find
Your will and way among the deaf and
blind,

Though I unlike Elijah have not spent
My arms in slaying prophets on the bent,
Nor calling down the fire from clouds
unrent.

With few exceptions all have found me
kind.

Nor kindness nor a proclamation gets
The word a hearing on the tv sets,
And if it did, I'd run away, I trow,
To find my granite mountain, Sinai's brow.

15 And YHWH said to him, "Go, return
On your way to Damascene burn,
And when you get there you'll anoint
Hazeal king of the Syrian joint.

16 "And Jehu son of Nimshi you
Shall anoint king of Israel's crew,
And Elisha son of Shaphat

Of Abelmeholah for that
You shall anoint prophet instead
Of you *to slumber in your bed.*

17 "And it shall happen that the one
Who escapes Hazeal's sword when done
Shall be killed by Jehu and he
That escapes Jehu's sword shall be
Killed by Elisha *though he flee.*

18 "But I have left in Israel
Seven thousand knees all who well
Have not bowed down to Baal and each
Mouth of which have not kissed his
peach."

This trinity of swords surprises me
In everything but sandwich meat to be
The bread of Syria and Elisha's fee.
Elijah has the power to set up kings
In Damascus to rate the flounderings
Of Syrian wars, that is a thing that tests
My powers of hope since others wear such
vests.

A foreign king surprises me, and yet

Elisha's sword as prophet when he's met
Is also glance of light I had not found
Before upon the golden threshing ground.
Beloved, I distrust the strange bread You
take

To sandwich in the king of Israel's lake,
But in the practice see the plan You make.

19 So he went from there and he found
Elisha son of Shaphat round
And ploughing twelve yoke on the ground
Before him, and the twelfth with him.

And Elijah passed by him grim
And threw his mantle over him.

20 He left the oxen and ran after
Elijah and said "Let with laughter
Please kiss my father, also my
Mother and I will follow by
You." And he told him, "Just go back,
For what have I done to your track?"

21 And he turned back from him and took
A yoke of oxen by the hook
And slaughtered them and boiled their
flesh

Over the oxen's wood yokes fresh,
And offered to the folk and they
Ate, then he got up on his way
After Elijah and became
His servant *and at last found fame.*

Deary! The man would honour Dad and
Mom
Before he went out at the prophet's sum
In lowly service to the man of God.
And yet Your Bible keeps the word in pod.
It does not say whether Elisha strode
Back to his dad and mom's humble abode
To say good-bye and kiss them on the
cheek.

It only says he sacrificed the bleak
Work oxen and gave meat to helpers there
Before he left to find the divine fare.
You leave the doubt and task to me and
those

Who read these words after Elisha rose
To say whether he kept the word or not
To honour Mom and Dad when he was
sought.

1 Kings 20

1 And Benhadad the Syrian king
Gathered all his army in ring,

And thirty-two kings with him, and
Horses, and chariots up to stand
In siege against Samaria's *land*,
And fought against it *with his band*.

2 And he sent messengers to king
Ahab of Israel in the wing
Of the city, and said to him,

"So says Benhadad, *a man grim*,

3 'Your silver's mine and so's your gold,
Your wives also, children as bold,
All those are mine, *you're in the cold.*'"

4 The king of Israel answered and
Said "My lord, O king, here I stand
According to your word and I
Am yours and everything you spy."

5 The messengers came back and said
"So speaks Benhadad *to your head*,

'Although I sent to you to say
"Give me silver and gold today,
And your wives and your children fey,"

6 "'Still I will send my men to you
Tomorrow at this time in crew,
And they shall search your house in view
And your servants' houses and then
Whatever is pleasant *to men*
In your eyes, they shall take in hand
And bring it back into my land.'"

That pleasant thing, Muhammad in the
word

Of holy script and mouth of beast and bird,
Is worthy that the kings of earth might
fight

To gain his jewelled treasure and his light.
Will Benhadad take Ahmed from the store
Of Ahab's treasures to bring to the door
Of his own house, the glory of his land?
The wicked kings of yore might come to
stand

And bicker for the lot of Ahmed's strength.
But as I wander this last world's sure
length

I find Muhammad's not the treasure
sought,

Although he might be justifying bought
To secure energy of stone and oil.
I find Ahmed derelict on the soil.

7 Then Israel's king called all the folk
The aged in the land of oak,
And said "Note please, see how this one
Seeks mischief, for he in summon

Sends for my wives and children and
Silver and gold, I cannot stand.”

8 And all the elders and the folk
Said to him, “Do not hear the bloke,
And don’t consent *under his stroke*.”

9 That’s why he told the messengers
Of Benhadad, “Tell my lord, fers,
The king, ‘Everything you sent for
To your servant from the first roar
I will do, but this thing I may
Not do.’” And so they went their way,
The messengers did, and they brought
To him the message they were taught.

10 Benhadad sent to him and said
“Let the gods do to me and spread
Even more also, if the dust
Of Samaria shall be as must
For handfuls for all the folk that
Come after me *to join the spat*.”

Conflict among the shadows that arise
Here in the world decked out in human
guise

Is always the product of pride once caught
In the trap that Your oneness must be
taught.

All men know that the thinking one inside
Is the one god that no one should deride,
And that secret within the breast is one
That never is uttered beneath the sun,
And yet it informs every word and act.
I am God is the knowledge and exact.
Conflict arises when that one god sees
The other man also claims the chemise
Of the divine, and since You’re one alone,
Someone must therefore be toppled from
throne.

11 The king of Israel answering
Said “Tell him, ‘When one’s harnessing
Let him not boast as when he takes
The harness off *after the cakes*.’”

12 It happened when he heard this word,
As he was drinking with the *stirred*
Kings in their tents that he said to
His servants, “Set for battle *due*.”
And so they set themselves *in siege*
Against the city *by their liege*.

13 And see, a prophet came up to
Ahab, Israel’s king, and said true,
“So says YHWH, ‘Have you seen all this
Great crowd of folk? The benefice

I give is that into your hand
I shall deliver the whole band
Today, and you will come to know
That I am YHWH *of high and low*.”

The prophet that cries benefits to me
Is not Elijah or the progeny
Of Abraham, the prophet that chirps at
My window is from my own habitat:
The pine-spread slopes, the aspen thickets
where

The summer breezes clap their mittens
there.

The chatter, twitter prophet of my hopes
Is one who knows the wild vine’s twisting
ropes

Up to the attic where to cock an eye
Black, beady, and then to take off and fly.
Kings get the messages of prophet men
And women, but such as I look again
To find the green or yellow breast is right
In its prediction of the shining light.

14 Then said Ahab, “By whom?” And he
Replied, “So says YHWH *faithfully*,
‘By youthful princes of the cities.’”

Then he said “Who shall bind the fight?”
And he answered “Yourself *in right*.”

15 He counted then the number of
The youthful princes of above
Districts to find two hundred and
Thirty-two, and the people’s band
In all the sons of Israel
Came to seven thousand *in swell*.

16 And they went out in noontime *heat*
While Benhadad drank to entreat
In the booths, he and the kings,
Thirty-two kings who pulled his strings.

17 Then went out the young princes of
The provinces fore and above,
And sent Benhadad out, and they
Told him saying “Men *in the way*
Come out from Samaria’s *sway*.”

18 He said “If they in peace come out,
Take them alive, and if in *rout*
Of battle they come out, alive
Take them *as best you can contrive*.”

19 So these then set out from the city,
The youthful princes *in committee*
Of the districts, the army *too*
Followed after them *kept in view*.

20 And they killed every one his man,

And so fled every Syrian,
 And after them pursued Israel,
 But he escaped, Benhadad royal
 Of Syria on horse along
 With horsemen *coming in the throng*.
 21 The king of Israel then went out
 And struck horse and chariot about,
 And killed the Syrians with great
 Slaughter *fallen upon their pate*.

I see that You, Beloved, strengthened the
 hand
 Of Ahab against Syrian in the land.
 Did You not notice that Ahab was just
 Or nearly as reproachable as dust
 As Benhadad? The king who wins the war
 May be your relative favourite for spoor,
 But in the end, all those that You treat well
 And give them power and reign to rule a
 spell
 Are just as evil as the ones that score
 Nothing for fear of Your condemning rod.
 After all, You alone, just You are God.
 Illusion crazes all the hills and towns
 And ends by seeking not smiles, but men's
 frowns
 Upon the rooted and the unploughed sod.

22 And then the prophet came near to
 The king of Israel in view
 And said to him, "Go fortify
 Yourself and know and see what thing
 You do, for the year's turn will bring
 The Syrian king up on your *sky*."
 23 And the Syrian king's servants said
 To him, "A God of hills is bred
 Their Alohim, that's why they came
 Stronger than we, but if we aim
 To fight them in the valley, then
 Surely we'll be the stronger men."

O my Beloved, I doubt not that You are
 The God of hills rising against the star
 And cloud and moon, towards the brighter
 sun.
 I doubt not that the battle has been won
 Along the hills where Your feet ever run.
 And yet You who live on the fairest peak
 Of mountain further than a man can seek
 Still come to tread the valleys and the
 sands

Where Syrian soldiers and kings in their
 bands
 Come stealing through the darkness of the
 year.
 Beloved, I too love hills and know that
 You
 Bless the trees on their slopes more than
 You do
 The trellises of flatlands where the show
 Of evil comes to curse the way I go.

24 "And this thing you shall do, you'll take
 The kings away for each man's sake
 And put governors in their stake.
 25 And count yourself an army out
 As much as the army in rout,
 A horse for horse and chariot
 For chariot, and we'll have fought
 Against them in the plain, surely
 We shall be stronger than the free."
 He heard their voice and did thusly.
 26 It happened at turn of the year
 That Benhadad had numbered gear
 Of Syria, and approached the plain
 Of Aphek to fight for his gain
 Against Israel *and Israel's reign*.
 27 And Israel's sons were numbered there
 All present, and they went to share
 In battle against them, and pitched
 Israel's sons against them ditched
 Like two little flocks of kids, round
 About them Syrians filled the ground.
 28 And there came near a man of God
 And said to the king *and the prod*
 Of Israel, and so he said
 "So says YHWH, 'Just because they've
 spread
 This rumour, the Syrians have done,
 That a God of the hills is YHWH,
 And not a God of plains is Huu,'
 That's why I shall *under the sun*
 Deliver all this multitude
 Into your power, and all your *brood*
 Will know that even I am YHWH."
 29 They pitched against each other *there*
 For seven days, it came to bear
 On the seventh day battle raged
 And Israel's folk *there engaged*
 Killed of the Syrians hundred *count*
 Of thousands, *and so great amount*
 Of footmen in one day *uncaged*.

If they came out upon a Sunday when
 They camped against Israel and Israel's
 men,
 Then battle drew up on the Sabbath day,
 It's very likely it happened that way.
 The wicked soon learn when to try the just
 By their distractions on the day they must
 Refrain from all tasks to return to You
 And drink the nectar of the residue
 Of blessings the week has presented them.
 The wicked always try to crush the gem
 Of Sabbath in their spite for faith and love,
 In hatred of Your sovereignty above.
 Each divine image in the breast of man
 Rules all things to the extent that it can.

30 But fled the rest into Aphek,
 Into the city *for a speck*,
 And a wall fell down on the men
 Twenty-seven thousand *again*
 That were left. And Benhadad led
 And came into the city *spread*
 Into an inner place and den.

Beloved, I too like Benhadad of old
 Flee into Your own city and am bold
 To find my inner chamber cut in stone,
 In stony heart, and their before Your throne
 I wait my fate and thank the stars above
 That I am bound up in eternal love.
 Beloved, I too like Benhadad flee from
 The battle against good and when I've
 come
 Into the city where I find my rest,
 I plead Your mercy from all sin confessed.
 Beloved, the flight of general and king
 Is always from the good and to the ring
 Of far security, but I come here
 Within my own heart where You will
 appear.

31 His servants said to him then, "See,
 We've heard Israel's house's kings be
 Merciful kings, so let us please
 Put gunny sacks from waist to knees,
 And ropes on our heads, and go out
 To Israel's king, for there's no doubt
 He'll save your life *and that with ease.*"
 32 So they put gunny sacks around
 Their waists, and then with their heads
 crowned
 With ropes they came to Israel's king

And said "Benhadad, underling
 Of yours says "Please now, let me live."
 And he said "Does the man still live?
 He is my brother, though I'm king."

I recognize myself, Beloved in this
 King of Your people Israel amiss,
 King Ahab, who did nothing of the right
 And was always a vile man in Your sight.
 My heart is merciful to all who come
 And flatter me with word or paltry sum,
 And soon as I see smiles I leave Your state
 Forgetting You, Your law, Your lovely
 gate.

As soon as civil servant deigns to be
 Civil, then I'm his friend eternally.
 Let only Your law be criterion
 Of how a relate to everyone's son,
 And I shall show a better face to all
 Who grimace or who flatter at the ball.

33 Now the men listened carefully
 And caught the word immediately
 And they said "Your brother *and bred*
 Benhadad." And so then he said
 "Go bring him." So Benhadad came
 Out to him and he raised his *flame*
 Into the chariot *ahead*.

34 And he said to him, "Cities that
 My father too from your dad flat
 I shall restore, and you shall make
 Streets in Damascus for your sake
 As my dad made Samaria."
 Then he answered, "I'll send your paw
 Away with this treaty in claw."
 So he made the treaty with him
 And sent him away *safe and prim*.

When shall I learn, Beloved, the promise
 made
 By law and statute is not justice weighed,
 But excuse for the wealthy come to rule
 And pretend they are just to every fool.
 The law applies only to those whose hand
 Is in the sugar bowl, for others sand
 Is put into the spoon to grind the teeth.
 Beloved, I give democracy a wreath
 And know that every man who does the
 right
 Depends on You alone by day and night.
 Policemen are the dupes who must obey
 The caller with the greater sum to pay,

And judges hand down verdicts to the best
Bidder who has a gold fob on his chest.

35 And one man of the prophets' sons
Said to his neighbour by the guns
Of YHWH, "Please hit me", but the man
Refused to hit him *by his plan*.

36 Then he said to him, "Because you
Did not obey the voice of YHWH,
See now as soon as you go out
From me a lion *round about*
Shall kill you." And as soon as he
Was gone from him, a lion *free*
Found him and killed him *with a shout*.

37 Then he found another man and
Said "Hit me, please." And *by command*
The man hit him so when he hit
Him he wounded *him quite a bit*.

38 So the prophet went out to wait
For the king by the pathway's *gate*
Disguising himself and his face
With ashes on him *to debase*.

39 It happened that the king passed by
And so he yelled at the king night,
And he said "Your servant went out
Into the battle and the shout,
And see a man turned to the side
And brought me a man to abide,
And said 'Keep this man, if at all
He is missing out of the stall,
Then your life for his life I'll take
Or else weigh silver for his sake.'

40 "It happened your servant had much
To do here and there until such
That he was gone." And Israel's king
Told him, "So let your judgement ring,
You yourself decided the thing."

41 Then he was quick to take away
The ashes from his eyes *and grey*,
And Israel's king then recognized
Him as one of the prophets *prized*.

42 And he said to him, "So says YHWH,
'Because you've released the man who
Was appointed by me to be
Destroyed *and destroyed* utterly,
Therefore your life is forfeit for
His life, and your folk *out of door*
For his people, *who shall go free*.'"

43 And Israel's king went to his house
Heavy and displeased *like a mouse*
And came to Samaria's *town*
Still wearing on his face a frown.

The point is not to be cunning like that
Italian princeling who knew where they sat
For intrigue and so wrote a noble book
That's still the guideline modern rulers
took.

The cynical breach of promise is not
What school of prophets cantillating
taught.

But rather mercy is not man's to take
Any more than vengeance is his to make.
All is in Your hands, and You stand to
stake

The mercy on one and another break.
Mercy without conditions is the rule
That's taught by every selfish, loving fool.
Obedience to Your command is still
The only way to rise and foot the hill.

1 Kings 21

1 It happened after these things that
Naboth Jezreelite had a *vat*
And vineyard in Jezreel near by
The palace of Ahab *the guy*
Who was king of Samarian sky.

2 And Ahab spoke to Naboth and
Said "Give me your vineyard at hand
So I may have it for a plot
Of herbs, because the place is not
Far from my house, and I will give
You a better vineyard to live
Than it, or if it better seems
To you I'll give *beyond your dreams*
Its worth in money *in a sieve*."

3 And Naboth said to Ahab then,
"YHWH forbid me, that I again
Should give my fathers' heritage
To you *for onions and for sage*."

In Israel still there were such people paid
To live by the anarchy that was weighed
Out to the tribes before a king was set,
Before the judges had in battle met
Sisera and before the rod of Moses
Brought water from the rock as well as
roses.

Beloved, I rejoice that a man could bring
Such a response to give a prince and king.
Of course I know that he will live to pay
For every proudful thing he dared to say.
But death must come to all sometime and
last

It's good to use one's death in ways to cast
A vote against establishment and cry
A prayer to You above kings in the sky.

4 And Ahab came into his house
Heavy and displeased *as a grouse*,
Because of the thing Naboth said,
The Jezreelite, to him *well-bred*,
For he had said "I shall not give
You my dad's heritage *to live*."
And he lay down upon his bed
And turned away his face *to spread*
And Ahab would not eat his bread.

5 And Jezebel his wench came in
To him and told him, "Why for jinn
Is your spirit so full of dread
That you refuse to eat your bread?"

6 And he said to her, since I said
A thing to Naboth Jezreelite,
And told him, "Give me *for my right*
Your vineyard for money *or spite*,
Or else if you like I will give
You a vineyard for it *to live*,
And he answered, 'I will not give
You my vineyard *for a long sight*.'"

Poor Ahab, so sad that his treacle can
Not tempt him off his pouting cause a man
Refused to render him what's his in due
Because he wears a crown on his cashew.
But Ahab has a wife of sympathy,
Who understands the feelings' filigree
Of sensitive souls hurt by populace
Of rogues who need to be put in their
place.

Most presidents and judges have such tarts
To posture and pose when they play at
darts

At the nearby pub or palace or house
Of legislature. Quiet as a mouse,
Such ladies come to courage their weak
men

To slaughter others and slaughter again.

7 And Jezebel his wife told him,
"Do you rule Israel with a whim?
Get up, eat bread and let your heart
Be happy, I shall give *to start*
The vineyard of Naboth *who comes*
A Jezreelite *to do his sums*."

Behind each man's success a woman
drives
The cattle to the pasture, smokes the hives
And makes the house a home, and there is
no

Exception in deserving ways that show
In Jezebel, sweet Jezebel, who takes
Care of her poor, weak husband in his
shakes.

The good a man does often is the seal
Of how good his wife is about the wheel.
The evil of a man is sure to be
Reflection of a wife's iniquity,
Unless of course the man in his own right
Is evil in what he does day and night.
Ahab and Jezebel, a power pair
Ready to rule the world with time to spare.

8 And she wrote missives in the name
Of Ahab and sealed with *the claim*
Of his seal, and sent letters to
The elders and the nobles *true*
Who where in the town living *there*
With Naboth *pretending they're fair*.

When ladies write to newspapers for fun
Sometimes they get results for what
they've done.

When they write to their congressmen to
set

Them doing wicked deeds, success is met.
It's only good that's hard to get a hearing,
And when a lady's hand is in the clearing
There's precious little to be done the while.
The elders and the nobles find a smile
Bewitching and attuned as they've become
To charms and wealthy lobbies both in rum
And firearms not to speak tobacco's name,
Methinks there's little left of any shame.
Manipulation of decision-maker
Is better than a tail of bird salt-shaker.

9 And she wrote in the missives saying
"Call a fast and set Naboth *playing*

At the head of the people *staying*."

10 And set two men, sons of Belial,
Against him to bear witness vile
Saying 'You have blasphemed the gods
And king.' Then take him out, with clods
Stone him to death *for all his guile*."

The woman told the truth, deedy she did.

She didn't say a word beyond the bid
 Of what Naboth had done in his refusing,
 She didn't tell a lie in her accusing.
 Naboth was disrespectful to the king,
 And surely did not fear the gods for sting,
 But stubbornly stayed in the ancient law
 That You, Beloved, set up against the claw
 Of usurpation and abuse of land.
 The man was clearly guilty in his stand.
 See Jezebel is surely in her rights
 To judge such folk to death and not for
 spites.

Beloved, I too live in a land well-ruled
 By Jezebels and Ahabs finely schooled.

11 So did the men of his town do,
 The elders and the nobles true,
 Who lived in his town, just and sent
 Jezebel to them and as meant
 In the missives which she had sent.
 12 They called a fast, and they set up
 Naboth in head as people's *tup*.
 13 And there came two men the sons of
 Belial and sat against love
 Of him and so they witnessed, did
 The men of Belial to skid
 Against Naboth in front of folk
 Saying "Naboth came to invoke
 Blasphemy against gods and king."
 And they took him outside the ring
 Of the town and stoned him with stones
 Until he died *among his groans*.

See here, Beloved, the way courts always
 go.

They follow according to evil show
 And never do justice unless it might
 Serve wicked hands by product on the
 slight.

All men are perjured in this vale of gears,
 And all partake of murder in the steers
 Of state, and all invoke Your name in turn
 In blasphemous contentions as they earn.
 Beloved, I flee to You from justice here
 As I flee from the nobles and the peer,
 And see the city gathered in the field
 To stone the innocent and unappealed.
 There's nothing changed since Jezebel
 went out

To do her business with whisper and shout.

14 And they sent to Jezebel saying

"Naboth is stoned and with death *paying*."

15 It happened when Jezebel heard
 That Naboth was stoned dead *as turd*
 That Jezebel said to Ahab,
 "Get up and possess it and grab
 The vineyard of the Jezreelite
 Naboth, which he refused in right
 Of silver to you, for Naboth
 Is not alive, but dead *for oath*."

16 It happened when Ahab heard that
 Naboth was dead, rose where he sat,
 Did Ahab to go down to take
 The vineyard of Naboth, the stake
 Of Jezreelite *for a keepsake*.

17 And there was the word of YHWH to
 Elijah the Tishbite in view.

18 "Get up, go down to calling of
 Ahab king of Israel above
 Who's in Samaria; see loath
 He's in the vineyard of Naboth
 Where he's gone down to take the troth.

19 "And you shall speak to him and say
 'So says YHWH, "Have you had your way
 To kill and then take up the stake?"'
 And you shall speak to him *awake*
 Saying 'So says YHWH, "In the place
 Where dogs licked Naboth's bloody face
 Shall dogs lick up your blood *a space*.'"
 ""

Beloved, I've noticed when You speak to
 men

It's never to warn them what will again
 Take place if they are fooled by summons
 to

Enjoy a place of honour with the crew
 Of wickedness that deny law and grace.
 I've noticed You speak only face to face
 To call the wicked to repentance and
 To tell them what evil they did in hand
 After the thing was done. I'd think You'd
 learn

To warn the perpetrator to be stern
 To keep the narrow way, or else at least
 To warn the victim between he is fleeced.
 But no. The only thing You seem to know
 Is blaming evil done after the show.

20 And said Ahab to Elijah,
 "Have you found me, my enemy?"
 And he said "I've found you *a straw*
 Because you've sold yourself to work
 Evil before YHWH's eyes *and smirk*."

21 "See I shall bring on you the bad
 And take away posterity
 From you and cut off from Ahab
 Who comes against the wall to pee,
 And everyone that is shut up
 And left in Israel *to sup*.
 22 "And I will make your house as that
 In which Jereboam once sat,
 The son of Nebat, and like house
 Of Baasha, Ahija's son's *louse*,
 For provocation by which you
 Have provoked Me to anger's *rue*.
 And made Israel to sin *with you*."

Oh yes, besides the accusation You
 Bring against evil-doers hitherto,
 You also mention what's their punishment
 For doing bad things to the innocent.
 Just watch what happens when You speak
 to those
 Who bear the rulership that You once
 chose:
 They'll make pretence of being sorry
 found,
 But cannot repair damage to the ground.
 And You forgive the clown and leave the
 weak
 In destitution for the things they seek.
 Beloved, I raise I cry and sing a song
 In accusation of Your way of doing wrong.
 Speak, speak to those tempted before the
 act,
 Warn, warn the victim once before the fact.

23 And also to Jezebel spoke
 YHWH saying "The dogs at a stroke
 Shall eat Jezebel by the ditch
 Of Jezreel without a hitch.
 24 "The one of Ahab that dies in
 The city will the dogs for sin
 Eat, and the one who dies out on
 The field birds of the sky impawn."
 25 None was there ever of the like
 Of Ahab, sold himself to strike
 In wickedness by eyes of YHWH,
 Whom Jezebel his wife gave clue.
 He did abominable things
 In following idols in strings
 Like all the Amorites that YHWH
 Cast out before Israel's folk's crew.
 27 It happened when Ahab heard these
 Words that he tore his clothes, with ease

Put sackcloth on his flesh and fasted,
 Lay in sackcloth and while it lasted
 Walked softly, *low profile to please*.
 28 And the word of YHWH came again
 To Elijah the Tishbite then.
 29 "See how Ahab humbles himself
 From before My face like an elf?
 Because he humbles himself now
 Before me, I will not bring *plough*
Of evil in his days, but in
 His son's days will I bring the sin
 Upon his house *for what he's been*."

What did I say, Beloved? You're taken in
 By every man that weeps for rate of sin
 That's found him out and caused him some
 chagrin.
 Be wise and look upon the human heart
 And see how far repentance plays a part.
 Repentance of a king? Don't make me
 laugh.
 Repentance of a king is not worth chaff.
 What now for Naboth? Why not use Your
 power
 To raise him up and give him back an hour
 Enjoying vineyard given to his dad?
 Repentance of Ahab just leaves me sad,
 Although I guess the angels in Your court
 Sing praises and rejoice he holds the fort.
 Beloved, if You are just You're also mad.

1 Kings 22

1 And they sat for three years without
 War between Syria *to shout*
 And between Israel *to pout*.
 2 It happened in the third year that
 Jehoshaphat the king that sat
 In Judah came down to the king
 Of Israel *once more to sing*.
 3 And said the king of Israel to
 His servants, "Do you know *it's true*
 That ours is Ramoth Gilead,
 And we are silent *as too sad*
 To take it out of the bare hand
 Of the king of Syria *to stand*.
 4 And he said to Jehoshaphat,
 "Will you go with me to make *flat*
Out battle in Ramoth Gilead?
 Jehoshaphat said to the *mad*
 King of Israel, "I'm as you are,
 My people as your people's *star*,

My horses as your horses' *pad*." □
 5 Jehoshaphat said to the king
 Of Israel, "Enquire the thing,
 Please, at the word of YHWH today."
 6 So the king of Israel called in
 The prophets four hundred in bin,
 And said to them, "Shall I go up
 Against Ramoth Gilead *like tup*
 To battle or shall I forbear?"
 And they said "Go up, *have no care*,
 For the lord shall give up the thing
 Into the hand of *lord* the king."
 7 And said Jehoshaphat, "Is there
 No other prophet anywhere
 To YHWH as yet? And that we may
 Enquire of him *also this day*."

I wonder that a king upon the throne
 Would doubt the crown's priests since they
 were full-frown.
 Jehoshaphat is blasé when it comes
 To four hundred church wardens with their
 turns.
 Perhaps it was just prejudice that made
 Him thing the northern prophets were
 waylaid.
 I'd be loath to think less of his review,
 And rather consider that in his brew
 There was a bit of common sense and light.
 Once in a generation in the night
 Of this world there is one spark of the right
 That flashes for a moment on the pool
 Where every queen's a slut and king a fool.
 Beloved, once in a lifetime good takes
 flight.

8 And said the king of Israel
 To Jehoshaphat, "There is still
 One man to enquire with YHWH from,
 But I hate him because he's dumb
 To prophesy upon me good,
 But only evil, Micaiah
 And the *blasted* son of Imlah."
 And Jehoshaphat said "You should
 Not speak so, you're a king, *not hood*."
 9 The king of Israel called a eunuch
 And said "Get going *like a Punic*
 And bring Micaiah *to me fast*
 The son of Imlah, *the outcast*.
 10 And Israel's king along with king
 Jehoshaphat of Judah's *spring*

Sat each on his throne and having
 Put on their robes, sat in the square
 By the gate of Samaria *there*,
 And all the prophets prophesied
 Before their faces *on each side*. □
 11 Zedekiah son of Chenaanah
 Made iron horns and *then like goner*
 Said "So says YHWH, with these you'll
 push
 The Syrians till they burn *like bush*."
 12 And all the prophets prophesied
 In like manner with words of pride,
 "Go up to Ramoth Gilead,
 And prosper, YHWH shall surely add
 It in the king's hand given *wide*."
 13 The messenger who went to call
 Micaiah spoke to him to bawl,
 "See now, the prophets words are good
 To the king as agreement should,
 Let your word please be like the rest
 Of them and speak what is the best."

The representatives of church and state
 In public views always come to relate
 Their cantillated spells congratulate
 The plans and powers of those who would
 make war.
 Who does not follow protocol in store
 Is not allowed to enter in the place
 Where the tv cameras focus on face.
 In ancient time the conjurors came too,
 And proclaimed magic spells to prosper
 brew.
 Who sang a sour note did an evil thing
 To spoil the spell that favoured God and
 king.
 And so the messenger is kind to tell
 The prophet protocol and to act well
 When he comes in to cantillate his spell.

14 And Micaiah said "As YHWH lives,
 What YHWH says to me when He gives,
 Is what I'll say *in narratives*."
 15 So he came to the king. The king
 Said to him, "Micaiah, what bring,
 Shall we fight Ramoth Gilead
 Or be content with what we had?"
 And he gave him answer, "Go well,
 And prosper, for YHWH shall dispel
 It in the king's hand *and be glad*."
 16 And the king said to him, "Say now

How often must I tell you how
 To tell me nothing but what's true
 In *glorious, blessed* name of YHWH?"
 17 And he said "I saw Israel all
 Scattered upon the hills to bawl
 As sheep without a shepherd, and
 YHWH said 'These have none to
 command,
 Let them return each man to his
 Own house in peace *and leave the fizz.* '"

The point is not to find out what the will
 Of Your desiring is, Beloved, when still
 The prophets stand to sing Your praise and
 fill
 Their temples with the donkey-cart and
 swill.

The point is to cast spell on small and great
 And whip up courage to die in their fate
 By proclaiming success in positive.
 Man can create his own reality,
 It seems, if he speaks loudly in his spree
 Of psychowash subservient to state.
 No one should prophesy in omen word
 The future, but just what might have
 occurred

If patron does as he himself desires.
 Put out, put out, Beloved, prophetic
 fires!□

18 And so the king of Israel said
 Unto Jehoshaphat instead,
 "Did I not tell you that he would
 Cantillate evil and no good
 About me as a prophet should?"□
 19 And he said "Hear now word of
 YHWH,

I saw YHWH sitting on His pew,
 And all the heavenly host *in view*
 Standing beside Him on His right
 Hand and on His left *hand in sight*.
 20 "And YHWH said 'Who'll persuade
 Ahab
 To go to Ramoth Gilead
 To fall there?' And one said one thing,
 Another said another thing.
 21 "And there came out a spirit and
 Stood there before YHWH *at His hand*
 And said 'I'll persuade him *to stand.* '
 22 "And YHWH said to him, 'Tell Me
 how?'

And he said 'I'll go and endow
 The mouth of all his prophets *now*
 With lying spirit.' And He said
 'By you he surely can be led.
 And so succeed, *go and be sped.* '
 23 "Now therefore, see how YHWH has
 put
 A lying spirit, mouth and foot,
 In all these prophets of yours here,
 And YHWH's told evil on your gear."
 24 Zedekiah son of Chenaanah
 Went near and hit Micaiah saner
 Upon the cheek, and said "Which way
 Went YHWH's spirit from me to say
 Such things to you *to be a gainer?*
 25 And Micaiah said "See, you'll see
 The day when to your room you'll flee."

Ah, my Beloved, if only I could find
 Such words the prophets used in days
 behind!
 Such wit and humour now I guess is found
 Among an advertiser on the ground,
 But hardly any preacher now can match
 Even the message the false prophets
 snatch.
 Beloved, here I repent the sordid way
 I write jingles in mediocre pay,
 While Baal's sons' words spoken against
 the fray
 Millennia ago are fresh as play.
 I sell my soul to You, Beloved, but yet
 I suffer that my tongue and lips are wet
 With mere truth and the ranting of the
 sweet.
 O my Beloved, hear, give to my tongue
 feet!

26 And so the king of Israel said
 "Take Micaiah and bring him led
 Back to Amon the chief of town,
 And to Joash the king's son's frown.
 27 "And say 'So says the king, "Put this
 One in the prison not to miss
 And feed him sorrow's bread and give
 To drink afflictions watered sieve
 Till I come back in peace to live.'""

See now, Beloved, how wisdom of the king
 Of Judah brought about the wicked thing
 Against Your prophet in his flesh and skin.
 No use to take half measures against sin.

To warn the sinner is no way to do.
 You have to strike him down there in his
 pew
 Or in his pulpit more the like, it's true.
 So Ahab will give bread and water while
 He's off to squander life a weary mile.
 Free board and room for every prophet
 come
 In Your name, my Beloved, is Gospel's
 sum!
 I rush to prophesy before the throne
 Of president and congress for a bone,
 But have nothing to say but what's in
 stone.

28 And Micaiah said "If you come
 Back at all in peace and in rum,
 YHWH has not spoken by me." And
 He said "Take note, folk, all your band."□
 29 So king of Israel and the king
 Of Judah, Jehoshaphat's sting
 Went up to Ramoth Gilead
 To do whatever thing they had.
 30 And so the king of Israel said
 Unto Jehoshaphat as led,
 "I will disguise myself and go
 In to the battle, but for show
 You put on robes from head to toe."
 So Israel's king disguised himself,
 Went into battle *like an elf*.□

The evil king always hopes to disguise
 Himself from his people and holy eyes,
 From friend and foe, so no one will suspect
 How much he would oppress Your own
 elect.

The king of Israel on the battle day
 Hoped to be unseen by the powers that
 slay,
 And his own machinations came to foil
 The safety that the gunners hand in toil.
 Beloved, I find You too always disguised
 In faces of the lowly and despised,
 In shy beasts that peer at me from the
 gloom
 Of fir and fern and slink into their room,
 In glimpses of the feathered round that
 wakes
 A song beyond the hewn and scribbled
 stakes.

31 And Syria's king gave the command
 To his thirty-two chiefs at hand
 Who ruled over his chariots' band,
 Saying "Don't fight with small or great,
 But only Israel's king *in state*."

32 It happened when the chariot chiefs
 Saw Jehoshaphat *in his briefs*,
 They said "Surely it is the king
 Of Israel." They turned in ring
 To fight against him, then cried out
 Jehoshaphat *as if in rout*.□

33 It happened when the chariot chiefs
 Noticed it was not by beliefs
 The king of Israel, that they turned
 Back from pursuing him *they spurned*.

34 And a man drew bow by hazard
 And struck Israel's king between hard
 Joints of his armour, so he said
 To his chariot driver, "Be led
 Away and carry me outside
 The ranks, for I'm wounded *betide*."

35 The battle then increased that day,
 And the king was held up at bay
 In his chariot against the troops
 Of Syrians, and as day droops
 He died, and the blood ran out from
 The wound into the chariot's drum.
 36 There went a proclamation through
 The army when the sun withdrew,
 Saying "Let every man go to
 His own city, and every man
 To his own country *as he can*."

Since You're in hiding now, Beloved, the
 wake

Of church and synagogue and mosque
 must make

Due with the absence of the good and true.
 They groan beneath the burden of the pew,
 The writhing of the rich, the proudful stare
 Of the unjust and those who overbear.
 Since You're in hiding now, all men
 forsake

The golden lamps, the showbread, and the
 stair.

Beloved, I meet the temple now bereft
 Of incense and of worshippers in cleft.
 I find the quiet of the empty room
 A harbinger of judgement and of doom,
 As yet I take joy in the peaceful glade
 That bounds in all the wonders I am paid.

37 So the king died, and he was brought
 Into Samaria, in lot
 They buried Samarian king *caught*.
 38 One washed the chariot in the pool
 There in Samaria, and a school
 Of dogs licked up his blood, and they
 Washed his armour in just the way
 The word of YHWH had come to say.
 39 The rest of the acts of Ahab,
 And all he did to do and grab,
 The ivory house that he had made,
 And all the towns of his parade,
 Are they not written in the book
 Of chronicles of Israel's crook?
 40 And so Ahab slept with fathers,
 And Ahaziah, son of bothers,
 Reign in his place *to count his pothers*.

Beloved, I now commend You for the way
 That You take care of dogs even today.
 You give them the blood of their kings in
 pay
 For the respect they show Your righteous
 ray.
 The dogs keep their commandments to the
 hilt
 And look disdainfully upon the silt
 Of human life surrounding them in breed.
 The dogs never relax the moral deed,
 But lap the blood left to them in their
 greed.
 Beloved, I am a dervish dog in seed,
 Although I fail to be enthusiastic
 And wag my tail at odours beyond plastic.
 I merely sleep beside the golden throne,
 And thump my tail twice when You throw
 a bone.

41 Jehoshaphat the son of Asa
 Began his ruling over Judah
 In the fourth year of Ahab king
 Of Israel *in Israel's ring*. □
 42 Jehoshaphat was thirty-five
 Years old when he began to thrive,
 And he reigned twenty-five years in
 Jerusalem. And his mom's din
 Was Azubah, daughter in fact
 Of Shilhi *and to be exact*. □
 43 He walked in all the ways of Asa
 His father, and turned not away, sir,

From doing what was right before
 The eyes of YHWH, 44 and yet the store
 Of high places were not removed,
 For the folk still burned unproved
 Offerings and incense as they wished
 Upon the high places undished.
 45 And so Jehoshaphat made peace
 With Israel's king *that did not cease*.
 46 The rest of the things that he did,
 Did old Jehoshaphat and bid,
 Are they not written in the book
 Of chronicles, just take a look,
 Of Judah's kings *and what they shook?* □
 47 And those left who served in the rites
 Of fertility on the sites
 As male prostitutes, who remained
 In the days that his father gained,
 Did Asa, he took from their rigths.

The temples built in ancient times serve as
 The place where people went to get their
 jazz.
 They had both men and women there in
 trust
 To serve the populace upon the dust.
 Disarmingly excuses that they used
 Were that the crops would fail if they
 abused
 The earth by chastity and living clean.
 Such is the faith of human hearts in bean.
 Beloved, I turn from church and multitude
 To find in Your invisible and brood
 Of temple in the melodies that sing
 Themselves across David's Psalms with a
 ping.
 The single soul arises on the wing
 And swerves away from all the bees that
 sting.

48 Then no king in Edom was there,
 A deputy took the king's share.
 49 Jehoshaphat made ships to go
 From Tarshish to Ophir for glow
 Of gold, but they did not get there,
 Because the ships were broken bare
 At the place called Eziongeber.
 50 Then Ahaziah, Ahab's son,
 Said to Jehoshaphat, "*By gun*,
 Let my servants go with your own
 In the ships." But Jehoshaphat
 Would not consent to such as that.

51 Jehoshaphat slept with his dads,
 Buried with his fathers and lads
 In his dad's town, David's own town,
 And Jehoram his son took gown
 To reign in his place *on his pads*. □
 52 Ahaziah son of Ahab
 Began to reign in Israel *sad*
 Samaria, seventeenth year
 Jehoshaphat was king *to fear*
 In Judah, and he came to reign
 Two years over Israel *as thane*.
 53 And he did evil in the sight
 Of YHWH, and walked in ways not right
 Of his father, and in the way
 Of his mother, and in the way
 Of Jeroboam, Nebat's son,
 Who made Israel to sin begun.
 54 For he served Baal, and worshipped
 him,
 Provoked to wrath YHWH Alohim
 Of Israel, according to
 All that his dad had used to do.

The king that reigned after Ahab was one
 Who tried to do the right as well as fun,
 And understood that Baal was scientific,
 Compared to You, Beloved, a god terrific.
 He was no innovator on the throne,
 But followed the traditions to a groan,
 Conservative in black suit and black tie,
 Dressed fit to kill and worthy yet to die.
 Beloved, I follow all the tracks around
 The altars of the righteous on the ground
 And find their hypocrisy does abound.
 The crowd will follow royal orders when
 The market takes a share in tax from men
 For buying idols up to make a yen.

2 Kings 1

1 Moab rebelled against the land
 Of Israel after death's hand
 Took Ahab. 2 Ahaziah fell
 Down through a lattice truth to tell
 In his upper chamber that was
 In Samaria, and for that cause
 He was ill, and sent messengers
 And said to them, "Go jingling spurs
 Enquire of Baalzebub the god
 Of Ekron whether from this pod
 Of illness I'll get well or not."
 3 The angel of YHWH on the spot

Said to Elijah the Tishbite,
 "Get up and go outside to meet
 The messengers upon their feet
 Of the king of Samaria,
 And tell them, 'Is in not because
 There's no God between Israel's paws
 That you are travelling to enquire
 Of Baalzebub of Ekron's hire?'"
 4 "That's why YHWH says the following,
 'You will not get up from that spring
 Bed you are lying on, but you
 Will surely die.'" After that too
 Elijah departed *and flew*.
 5 And when the messengers turned back
 To him, he said "Alas, alack,
 Why is it you have now turned back?"
 6 And they said to him, "There came out
 A man to meet us and to shout,
 'Go, turn back to the king who sent
 You, and tell him, "So says *unspent*
 YHWH, 'Is it not because there's not
 A God in Israel to be sought
 That you send to enquire the god
 Of Ekron Baalzebub in pod?
 That's why you will not get up from
 That bed where you are lying dumb,
 But you will surely die, *by God*.'"'"

The god of Ekron is alive and well
 And all the presidents on earth who dwell
 In the fire of sweet love and maddened
 spell
 Come to seek life at his word while the
 knell
 Of day chimes hymns ostensibly to You
 Who never shod your feet with triune shoe.
 Beloved, the god of Ekron, Beelzebub,
 Dances in every church that hears the scrub
 Of rock and country gospel, yet You are
 In every place on earth and furthest star.
 What I tell You, You know better than I,
 You have the whole view of the
 splendoured fly.
 The god of Ekron dances at the gate.
 Perhaps he knows what will be his last fate.

7 And he asked them, "What kind of man
 Was it that came to meet your scan,
 And told you these words *by his plan*?"
 8 And they answered, "A hairy man,
 And with a leather belt upon
 His waist." And he said at the drawn,

"It's Elijah the Tishbite's *ban*."

9 The king sent to him fifty's chief
With his fifty without relief,
And he went to him and see there
He sat on a hilltop to stare,
And he spoke to him, "Man of God,
The king says to come down and nod."

10 Elijah answered the chief of
Fifty and said with hand in glove,
"If I'm a man of God, then let
Fire come down from the sky and get
You and your fifty." And there came
Down from the sky consuming flame
And destroyed him and fifty's claim.

11 So once again he sent to him
Another captain fifty's grim,
And he spoke to him saying then,
"O man of God, the king again
Says to come quickly down *from den*."

12 Elijah answered telling them,
"If I'm a man of God, by gem,
Let fire come down from heaven and burn
You and your fifty." At that turn
A great fire came down from the sky
And killed him and his fifty nigh.

13 And he sent once more fifty's chief,
A third with his fifty's relief,
And the third captain of fifty
Went up and came and fell on knee
Before Elijah and begged him,
And told him, "Man of God not grim,
I beg you, let my life and that
Life of these fifty here on mat
As your servants be precious in
Your sight. 14 "See there came fire from
heaven

And burnt up two captains and leaven
Of the former fifties and their
Fifties, therefore now my life spare
As precious in your eyes *to care*."

Beloved, today it's to the wicked we
Must be humble and have a care to be
Sweet and soft lest the tanks of his army
Come push over the house where we live
free.

The day of Your Elijah is so rare,
Hardly does any man come here to share
Fear of You and Your state and Your
appointed.

No one is humble before Your anointed.
Instead the roar of bombs strikes open air

And flames come not from Your throne nor
its share,
But from the missiles and the guns of those
Who rant with evil hearts on those You
chose.

Beloved, the fires are always in the sky,
Whether from You or from others nearby.

15 The angel of YHWH said then to
Elijah, "Go down with the crew,
Don't be afraid of him." And he
Got up and went down with him, see,
To the king. 16 And he told him there
"So says YHWH, 'Since you did not spare
To send messengers to enquire
Of Baalzebub the god of fire
Of Ekron, not because there's no
God in Israel His word to show?
That's why you will not get up from
The bed you lying on in sum,
But you will surely die *like bum*.'"

17 And so he died just as the word
Of YHWH said by Elijah stirred.
And Jehoram reigned in his place
In the second year of the grace
Of Jehoshaphat Judah's king,
Because he did not have offspring.
18 The rest of what Ahaziah
Did, is it not written by paw
In the book of Chronicles of
The kings of Israel as above?
*And Jehoram as Ahab's son
Reigned over Israel under sun
Of Samaria for twelve years' run,
Starting in eighteenth year of king
Jehoshaphat of Judah's ring.
And he did what was evil in
The sight of the Lord, though for sin
Not as his brothers and his mum.*

*And he removed the pillars of
Baal which his father made for love,
And broke them in pieces, and yet
He joined the sins of the house met
Of Jeroboam, who led to sin
Israel, he did not leave that bin.
That's why YHWH was wroth with the
room
Of Ahab and led it to doom.*

I might rejoice, Beloved, to hear the news
That Ahaziah's dying in his pews,
If the same messenger brought to me that

I would live on to pray and to get fat
 Because I have not sent to Ekron's god
 To find health, wealth and a pea in the pod.
 Just because every man around I see
 Is certain that death waits at Your decree
 Or at the hand of evolution's sour,
 Does not mean that Your beloved's in its
 power.

Who knows if You will not put out a hand
 And save from death a greater faithful band
 Than just Elijah, Enoch, Jesus and
 Muhammad al-Mahdi, the four that stand?

2 Kings 2

1 It came to pass when YHWH would take
 Up Elijah into the wake
 Of a whirlwind into the sky,
 Elijah went up *on the sly*
 With Elisha from Gilgal's *stake*.

Beloved, You took Elijah to Your breast
 To find a place of fire where he might rest
 With Enoch who had long whirled on the
 flame

Of love and smoke and glory to Your
 name.

Beloved, You took the man because he had
 Not done nor thought nor spoken any bad,
 But always obeyed You in everything,
 And so You saved him from death's
 withered sting.

Beloved, as three-score years come
 crowding round

My head in my sojourning on the ground,
 I pray You might blot out the sadness that
 Deprives me of the glory where You sat,
 And when my turn arrives, send own a
 wheel

Of that same chariot to grab my heel.

2 Elijah said to Elisha,
 "Stay here, please, for YHWH *by His paw*
 Has sent me to Bethel *to bake*.

And said Elisha, "As YHWH lives,
 And as your soul also that gives,
 I shall not leave you." So they went
 Down to Bethel *as they were sent*.

3 And the sons of the prophets who
 Were at Bethel came out in crew
 To Elisha and said to him
 "Do you know that YHWH's at the rim
 Of taking your master today

From your head?" And he said "Indeed,
 I know it, but do not impede."

Elisha told the cantillators of
 Your Scriptures in their gathering of love
 To be still about coming circumstance
 Of Elijah going to make sky dance.

The reason's clear, he wanted to go out
 With Elijah and hear the heavenly shout
 When glory split the sky and fire rained
 down

To whisk the prophet out of Israel's town.
 Beloved, I whisper and hush with a frown,
 And sink into the burning prayer within,
 Petitioning the blotting out of sin
 Until Your holy temple comes to light
 Burning and purified, gloried and white,
 That You might also give to me that crown.

4 Elijah told him, "Elisha,
 Stay here, please, for YHWH *by His paw*
 Has sent me down to Jericho."

And he said "YHWH lives *and not so?*
 And as your soul lives, I shall not
 Leave you." So they came to *the plot*
 Of Jericho. 5 And the sons of

The prophets that were on the shove
 At Jericho came to Elisha,
 And said to him, "Not to entice you,
 Do you know that YHWH'll take away
 Your master from your head today?"
 And he said "I have the whole lease,
 But just be quiet, hold your peace."

6 Elijah told him, "You stay here,
 Please, for YHWH's sent me *without gear*
 To Jordan." And he said "As YHWH
 Lives and indeed as your soul too,
 I shall not leave you." And the two
 Continued on. 7 And fifty men
 Of the prophets' sons went again
 And stood to watch some way away,
 And they both stood by Jordan's *sway*.
 8 Elijah took his cloak and wrapped
 It round and hit the water snapped,
 And it divided there in two,
 And they went over with dry shoe.

If anyone could take the cloak and strike
 The waters of the Jordan with a spike
 To split the foam and pile the waves up
 high,

Then he could also rise up in the sky.

If anyone could take hold of the cloak
 Of good Elijah and hold fast like oak
 Until the chariot came down in fire,
 He could also achieve holy desire.
 Beloved I lay hand on the woollen rope
 That bound Elijah's waist and in that hope
 Strike out toward the grey-spent shore to
 take
 Your chariot by storm for Your name's
 sake,
 And cantillate the prophets' sons' bright
 lays
 As I rise up to meet You in Your praise.

9 It happened when they passed the stream
 Elijah asked Elisha "Deem,
 What shall I do for you before
 I'm taken up from your last shore?"
 Elisha said "Please give me twice
 The portion of your spirit's slice."
 10 And he said "You've asked a hard
 thing,
 But if you see me on the wing,
 Then your wish will be granted, but
 If not, then the thing will be shut."

Beloved, I seek a boon beyond the light
 Of this world's blooming flowers and
 scented night,
 Beyond the sound of Psalm and song of
 word
 That bounded on sacred Sinai and stirred
 The world to faith and power. I seek an
 hour
 And vision on deserted meadows' flower
 Where this creation cracks to find the life
 That rises up beyond both demon strife
 And machinations of the human hair
 That lines the feeble shortages in lair.
 Beloved, I seek a boon in double sight,
 A working out in my soul of the right
 Until the ages melt eternally
 Upon the shores of Your commands'
 decree.

11 It happened as they still went on
 And talked, see, in fire like the dawn
 A chariot and horses drawn
 With fire came splitting them apart,
 Elijah went up in the heart
 Of a whirlwind in a sky cart.
 12 Elisha seeing it cried out,

"My father, father, and the rout
 Of Israel's chariot and more
 The horses of it *at the door*."
 And he did not see him again.
 And he grasped his own clothes and tore
 Them in two pieces on the shore.
 13 He also took Elijah's cloak
 That fell off of him as he spoke,
 And went back and stood by the bank
 Of Jordan. 14 And he took and sank
 The mantle of Elijah that
 Fell off of him and smacked it flat
 On the water and said "Where's YHWH
 Alohim of Elijah's crew?"
 And when he'd also hit the flood
 It parted and revealed the mud,
 And Elisha went over too.

Elisha saw the vision of Your sword,
 He saw the flaming horses and adored
 The driving chariot that sweeps the sky
 Of every day since Enoch rose to spy
 The portals of the watches and the grates.
 Elisha saw the vision of Your hates
 And loves abound above the Jordan's
 stream.
 But I see only sparkling on the dream
 Of Your images wrought on nothing's
 weights.
 When Your reality breaks in the dare
 Of splinters on the rocky even stair,
 Let me see like Elisha the shine there
 And find the path on earth enough to bear
 Me up toward the golden city gates.

15 And when the prophets' sons in view
 At Jericho saw him, they said
 "The spirit of Elijah's spread
 On Elisha." And they went out
 To meet him and bowed themselves stout
 On the ground before him *as led*.
 16 And they said to him "See here now,
 We have got fifty strong men, vow
 To let them go, please, and search for
 Your master, lest YHWH's spirit bore
 Him and put him down on some mount,
 Or in to valley by a fount."
 And he said "Don't send anymore."
 17 When they insisted he was shamed
 And said "Send then." They sent *acclaimed*
 Fifty men who searched for three days
 But did not find him *in their ways*.

18 When they returned where he was at
In Jericho, he said out flat,
“Didn’t I tell you not to go?”
And that happened in Jericho.

Even the singers of Your sacred word
Are sometimes led into crafty absurd
By thinking that Your power’s a think like
bird.

Remember now, Beloved, it’s not their
fault,
Since You Yourself sent out as by default
A raven and a dove from Noah’s ark,
And on this very Jordan came to park
Your power in the form of simple dove.
Beloved, that day what were You thinking
of?

I whirl about the wadis and the trench
For three days till I find a wooden bench
To sit upon and hear the heavenly news
Of every preacher not content to choose.
Speak secrets to each lad and each lad’s
wench.

19 The men of the city said to
Elisha, “See, please, that the view
Of this city’s pleasant, as you
Sir see, but fresh, sweet water’s few,
And so the ground is barren too.”

20 And he said “Bring me a new jar
And put salt in it.” At instar
They brought it to him. 21 And he went
Out to the water spring and sent
The salt in it and said “So does
YHWH say ‘I’ve healed the spring that
was,

And there shall not be from this time
Any more death or barren *clime*.’”

22 And so the waters then were healed
To this day by the saying sealed
Elisha spoke *in song and rhyme*.

The Sufi orders of that day were wild
In working miracles for every child.
The dervishes’ main task it seems was then
To sing Your Scriptures in the ears of men
And in the hidden pastures of Your grove.
The dervishes were known to meet the
drove

With medicine and miracle to make
The world a better place for Your name’s
sake.

Instead of catching me up in the air
Each day to meet with Enoch and the fair,
Put in my hand a blessing and a care
To heal the turgid waters in the glare
Of hate and poison and drought that comes
near
The towns and cities where I keep my gear.

23 He went from there to Bethel and
As he was walking on the land,
There came a gang of youths to stand
Outside the city, making fun
Of him and told him on the run,
“Rise up, bald head, up in the sky!”
24 He turned around to ask them why,
And cursed them in YHWH’s name, and
there

Came from the woods bears in a pair
And killed forty-two young folks there.
25 He went from there to mount Carmel,
And then Samaria’s Israel.

The weakness of the dervish count today
Is simply because in their loving way
They’ve taken to the gangs’ songs in their
sway

Of rock and roll to pave the narrow clay.
If any dervish said a curse to lower
The criminal approach to reaper, sower
Along the paths of this world’s raptured
knower,

The readers of Hafiz’ and Rumi’s bin
Would rise up to condemn so gross a sin.
That’s why today the masters are confined
To repeating what’s on the loving mind
And so support the pecking order’s bind.
Beloved, I lay a curse and lay it well,
But not openly like Elisha’s spell.

2 Kings 3

1 Now Jehoram son of Ahab
Began his reign in Israel *for drab*
Samaria the eighteenth year
Of Jehoshaphat king to fear
In Judah and he reigned twelve year.
2 And he did wickedly before
YHWH, but not like his father’s crew
And like his mother, since he put
Away the image *of the root*
Of Baal his father made *for soot*.
3 And yet he stuck beside the sins
Of Jeroboam *for his wins*,

The son of Nebat, one who made
 Israel to sin, in them he stayed.
 4 And Mesha king of Moab had
 Many sheep at which he's not bad,
 And gave Israel's king tribute in
 A hundred thousand lambs, and in
 A hundred thousand woolly rams.
 5 But it happened that in time's came
 When Ahab died, king of Moab
 Rebelled against Israel's king's grab.
 6 The king Jehoram went out of
 Samaria that time of glove
 And counted all Israel above.
 7 And he went and sent to the king
 Jehoshaphat of Judah's ring,
 Saying "The king of Moab's come
 Rebellious against me, *the bum*.
 Will you go with me up to fight
 Against Moab?" And he said "Right,
 I'll go up, you and I, my folk
 Are as your folk, and every yoke
 Of my horses as your own sprite."

A hundred thousand sheep and rams are
 quite
 A booty and temptation for a wight
 Like Moab's king to set rebellion rolling.
 It's not a simple party out for bowling.
 So many sheep in tribute I would think
 Enough to feed Kuwait all at the brink.
 No wonder the kings disagreed to toe
 The line of what their fathers did in show.
 Beloved, I have no sheep at all to take,
 And not a single ram that is awake,
 But of my wealth I hardly keep a score,
 And You no doubt relieve me of the store.
 My lambs are scudding clouds above the
 shore,
 My wool is dandelion hair on lake.

8 And he said "Which way shall we go?"
 And he answered, "Through Edom's row."
 9 And so the king of Israel went,
 And the king of Judah as sent,
 And the king of Edom, and they
 Went round in journey seven day.
 And there was not enough to drink
 For the army and cattle's link.
 10 And Israel's king said "Oh alas,
 YHWH's gathered these three kings to
 pass
 Into the hand of Moab *crass!*"

11 And said Jehoshaphat, "Is there
 Not here a prophet in YHWH's care
 By whom we might enquire of YHWH?"
 And one of Israel's king's slaves said
 In answer, "Here's Elisha bred
 Of Shaphat, who poured water on
 The hands of Elijah when drawn.
 12 And so then said Jehoshaphat,
 "The word of YHWH is where he sat."
 So Israel's king, Jehoshaphat
 And Edom's king went where he's at.
 13 Elisha said to Israel's king,
 "What do I have, if anything,
 To do with you? Go to the hand
 Of your father's prophets in band
 And to your mother's prophets scanned."
 And Israel's king said to him, "No,
 For YHWH's gathered these three kings'
 show
 To give them in Moab's hand's row.
 14 Elisha said "As YHWH of hosts
 Lives, before whom I stand in boasts,
 Surely were it not that I see
 The presence of the king in fee
 Of Judah, king Jehoshaphat,
 I wound not look to where you're at.

Elisha simply is not even kind
 And polite to a king, and such I find
 Does not meet protocol or standard of
 Political correctness for a shove.
 Of course the king is first to say You made
 The three kings to come out to be afraid,
 Which does not show much confidence in
 You.
 Perhaps that's why Elisha thought words
 due.
 Beloved, I take example from the prophet
 And when I see such kings I mind to scoff
 at
 Them for their lack of grace in standing
 firm
 By Your commandments set out for the
 term.
 If any like Jehoshaphat are brave,
 I'll give such presidents a nod and wave.
 15 "But now bring me a harper. So
 It happened when the harper'd go
 To play, the hand of YHWH came on
 Him *in word of prophecy drawn*.

16 And he said "So says YHWH, 'Make
this
Valley full of ditch not to miss.'
17 "For so says YHWH, 'You'll not see
dew

Of wind nor rain, yet that valley
Shall be filled with water to be,
So you may drink, both you and your
Cattle and your beasts *on the shore.*'
18 "And that's not all that YHWH will do,
He'll give the Moabites to you.
19 "And you will strike them every town
Strengthened and every city down,
And you'll cut down every good tree
And fill up all the springs with scree,
And spoil all the good land with stones
Until Moab is filled with groans."

The fact is kings enquired of prophets then,
And even came in a band of three men
To ask the leader of a group of singers
What of the water and Your coming
stingers.

Today if any president or king
Shows interest in a spiritual thing
It's going to be muttering and peep
By medium and wizard out to creep
And not the cantillator of Your word
With harp or without for the omen stirred.
Beloved, I find my audience is where
The squirrel sits upon my window there
And peers with wonder at the glowing
room
Alive with growing spices, mint and
bloom.

21 And when all the Moabites heard
That the kings had come up like turd
To fight against them, they came out
In armour at the border stout.
22 And they got up at break of dawn
To see the sun shining upon
The water, and the Moabites
Saw the water there in their sights
As red as blood. 23 And so they said
"This is blood and the kings are dead,
And they've killed each other instead,
Now then, Moab, collect the bread."

The rosy dawn that shines at morning by
My window from the lake up to the sky
Sometimes makes lake turn to a pot of gold

And sometimes to blood colouring and
bold,
But never is the store of life and cold
Metal worth more than what the moments
hold.

So Moab erred in thinking that the dawn
Red on the fields of water and soon gone
Was death to king Jehoshaphat and those
Two kings who joined him in the warring
rows.

All that glitters is not gold, no, nor blood,
All that is red and bright's not ruby stud,
And yet I find about me everywhere
The gems that others think are only air.

24 And when they came to Israel's camp,
The Israelites got up like lamp
Attacking the Moabites so
They fled before them on the go,
But they came on to the attack
Against the Moabites in track
As far as their country *and back.*

25 And they beat down the cities there,
And on each good piece of land's share
Each man throw down his stone to fill
It and they stopped each water rill,
And cut down all the best of trees,
Only in Kirharaseth please
They left its stones, and yet they went
With slingers round it, struck and bent.

26 And when the king of Moab saw
That battle was beyond his paw,
He took with him seven hundred men
With swords in hand to break again
Up to the king of Edom, but
They could not for the way was shut.

27 Then he took his eldest son who
Should have reigned in his place as due,
And offered him burnt offering on
The wall. And a great anger's spawn
Fell against Israel, and they left
Each into his own land and cleft.

Even the lords of Philistines were shocked
When Moab's king offered his son and
rocked

The heathen world of worship with the fate
Of the firstborn as promised soon and late.
When in distress every fond head of state
Still finds a sacrifice of small or great
To distract public from his own sins' share.
And still shocked Israel disappear in air.

Beloved, the sacrifice of son and loved
 Or of the enemy and leaden gloved
 Goes on behind the closed doors where the
 fine
 Come together to drink the oil and wine.
 I find the traces of the sacrifice
 Set out in thousands of new plates of rice.

2 Kings 4

1 There cried a certain woman who
 Was wife of one of the sons crew
 Of the prophets to Elisha,
 Saying "Your servant and the pa
 Of my two sons is dead, and you
 Know that your servant had feared YHWH,
 The creditor has come to take
 My two sons bondsmen for his sake."
 2 Elisha told her, "What can I
 Do for you? Tell me what is nigh
 In your house?" And she said "Your maid
 Has nothing in the house that stayed
 Except a pot of oil." 3 Then he
 Said "Go and borrow what you see
 Of pots from all your neighbours, all
 That are empty and bring in stall
 Not few but many, *that is all*.
 4 "And when you've finished, shut the
 door
 With you and your sons, start to pour
 Out into all those pots and set
 Aside the full ones *when they're met*."
 5 So she went from him, shut the door
 Upon herself and sons in store,
 Who brought her pots for her to pour.
 6 It happened when the pots were full
 She said to her son capable,
 "Bring me one more pot," But he said
 To her "There's not a single spread."
 And so the oil came out no more.
 7 She came and told the man of God.
 And he said "Go and sell the rod
 Of oil and pay your debt and live
 You and your children with the laive."

Elisha of all prophets is exception,
 Even better than You with no surreption.
 He tells the woman exactly what he
 Hopes to accomplish now miracley.
 He does not make like Elijah and say
 Give me your last cake and then die today,
 After which in surprise he works a ray.
 No, he tells her he'll fill the pots with oil

As many as she wishes for the spoil.
 Her faith is shown in just how many pots
 She gathers for the pouring in their slots.
 She calculates enough to pay her debt,
 But greed did not come in to what she set
 Beyond that for her daily living's toil.

8 It happened when Elisha passed
 One day by Shunem a high-classed
 Woman made him stop there to eat.
 And so as often as his feet
 Went there he stopped in for a treat.
 9 And she said to her husband, "See,
 I notice what holy degree
 Is on this man of Alohim
 Who comes past us always *to team*.
 10 "Let's make a little room I beg
 On the wall and *to rest his leg*
 Set there for him a bed and chair
 And table and candlestick there,
 So when he comes by us he'll stay
 In that place *and not go his way*."

Itinerant preachers are well nigh gone,
 And those there are try to get home by
 dawn.

I've heard of such men come to get the
 cream
 Of service from the milkmaids in their
 dream.

I've heard the tale of Laestadian preacher
 Who found time in the night for fellow
 creature,
 A servant girl in every farmhouse where
 He stopped to feed his face and then to
 share

Your word with host and family, I swear
 I'm glad itinerant preachers are rare.
 Preacher or not, when I had house and fold
 In city centre, I too was one bold
 To bring the traveler in to meal and bed
 After he'd said his piece, after he'd fed.

11 It happened on a day he came
 There and turned in the room to claim
 A rest there. 12 And he told his slave
 Gehazi, "Call this Shunammite."
 And when he'd called her with a wave,
 She stood before him *in his sight*.
 13 He said to him, "Now tell her, 'See,
 You've been hospitable and free,
 So what can I do in return?"

Speak to the king or general?"

She answered, "I am pleased to dwell
Among my own folk *Israel*."

14 And he said then, "What's to be done?"

Said Gehazi, "She has no son,
And her husband's old *by the sun*."

15 And he said "Summon her again."
And when he called her, she came then
And stood in the door *of the den*."

16 And he said "Near a year from now
According to life's time somehow
You will embrace a son." And she
Said, "No, sir, please don't lie to me."

17 And the woman conceived and bore
A son the time Elisha swore
To her, according to life's score.

The tales of Hajji Bektash and the race
Of his apostles told in every place
Reveal the penchant in the dervish trace
For leaving children to be born where none
Had been seen there before under the sun.
A pregnant grain of wheat or prayer's
enough

To shake a woman up and not be gruff.
Elisha, let us say, had hand to do
The miracle and still be righteous too,
But those who follow in his wake have
ways

More devious to get a child for praise.
The wonder and the miracle that sound
In rainbows and in joys upon the ground
Are turned to crust when churches bring
their phase.

18 And when the child was grown one day
He went out to his father's way
Among the reapers. 19 And he said
To his father, "My head, my head."
And he said to a servant lad,
"Carry him to his mum, too bad."

20 When he took him and brought him
back
To his mum, he sat on her lap
Till noon, and then he died, alack.

21 And she went up and laid mayhap
Him on the bed of man of God,
And locked him in and went abroad.

22 And she called to her husband, said
"Send me please one servant and led
One of the donkeys so I can
Go out and return with God's man."

23 And he said "Why go there today?
It's not the first of month or day
Of the Sabbath." And she said "Stay."

24 She saddled up a donkey then
And said to her servant, "Drive then
As fast as you can, do not wait
For me unless I tell you late."

So folk were wont to find Elisha's seat
At first of month and for the Sabbath treat.
That's a good thing to know. I wonder if
The occasion was legal, formal, stiff
As they claim now who say the Sabbath
law
Was nailed onto the cross by Roman claw
And so we're freed from all its blessings
now
And may be oppressed by eater of sow
On each and every day in weekly round.
There is no day now when the boss is
found
To have no right to boss us to the ground.
But in those lovely days before the cross
There still were limitations on the boss.
Beloved, I hanker back from freedom's
loss.

25 So she went and came to the man
Of Alohim upon the span
Of mount Carmel. It happened when
The man of Alohim saw her
At a distance, he did aver
To Gehazi his servant, "See
That Shunammite *arrives finely*."

26 "Run now please to meet her and say
'Is all well with you and in way
Of your husband, and with the child?'
She answered "It's well" reconciled.

27 When she arrive up on the hill
To the man of Alohim still,
She caught him by the feet, then came
Gehazi to push off in blame.
Then said the man of Alohim,
"Let her alone, for it would seem
Her soul's afflicted in her, and
YHWH's hidden it from eye and hand."

The prophet knows by Your permission
what
Is in the heart of every man and shut
Within the soul of every woman that

Comes in his view, and yet at times You
make
The anguish of one soul for Your own sake
And for no other. Note that You are not
The only secretive one in the plot.
The woman does not tell the father that
The boy is dead and lying on his mat.
The tragedies that You deal with above
My unknowing, expressions of Your love,
Move out across the vast expanse of sky.
And yet I'm unconscious of who may die,
Or who may live, sitting here in Your
wake.

28 Then she said "Did I beg a son
Of my lord? Did I not when done
Say 'Don't lie to me?'" 29 Then he said
To Gehazi, "Get ready, take
My staff in your hand and then make
Your way and if you meet a man,
Do not greet him and if by plan
Any should greet you do not say
A word in answer, and then lay
My staff on the face of the child."
30 Then the mother not reconciled
Said "As YHWH lives and so your soul,
I will not leave you." He took toll
And followed her. 31 Gehazi passed
On before them and laid amassed
The staff on the face of the child,
But there was no sound nor a stir.
So he went back to meet the fer,
And told him saying "The child's not
Awakened at all from his plot."

Why did the child not respond to the wand
Of Elisha as sent by servant frond?
Perhaps he spoke a greeting on the path
And hid the matter from his master's
wrath.
Perhaps the power of healing and of faith
That is a true thing not in hand of wraith
Becomes a false and twisted evil mask
When brought in hand of those who dream
to bask.

Beloved, I take the prophet's staff and run
And feel the heat and burning of the sun
On head and back, and know that in my
lack

The child is sleeping still as in my slack
I lay upon his face the clasping wood.
Beloved, let me at least run to some good.

32 Elisha came to the house, see,
The child was dead, laid on his bed.
33 And so he went in there softly
And shut the door on both as led
And prayed to YHWH *for what should be*.
34 He went up and lay on the child
And put his mouth where his mouth
smiled,

His eyes on his eyes, and his hands
On his hands, and he stretched his bands
On the child and the child's flesh came
Warm. 35 Then he got up from the game
And walked back and forth in the room,
And went up again and stretched bloom
On him and the child sneezed seven times,
And the child opened his eyes' *dimes*.
36 He summoned Gehazi and said
"Call this Shunammite *woman bred*."
So he called her, and when she came
There to him, he said "Take your claim."
37 She went and fell down at his feet
Bowed herself to the ground to meet,
And took up her son and went out.
And that was the end of that bout.

In cases of the kind this form of help,
Mouth to mouth resuscitation of whelp,
Ought not to do a thing to bring him back.
The story's deformed, just a rumour's
crack

At something that happened in truth or yet
A miracle in fact where doubters met.
To warm the flesh already cold in death
Shows that some hours have passed and
without breath.

Beloved, I breathe and know I die each
time
I exhale from a lung filled up with rhyme,
And come to life again to feel Your kiss
Of oxygen fall once more on abyss
Of knowing and unknowing and the dark
Recedes from my eyes glowing in the park.

38 Elisha came back to Gilgal,
With a dearth in the land for sal,
And the sons of the prophets sat
Before him, and he told him pat,
His servant, "Set on the great pot
And make some soup and *make it hot*
For the sons of the prophets lot."
39 And one man went out in the field

To gather foodstuffs of its yield
And found a wild vine and he took
From it wild gourds into his hook,
And came and cut them in the pot
Of soup, because they knew them not.
40 They dished it up for all to eat.
And as they all ate of the treat,
They cried out and said "Man of God,
The pot contains a poisoned pod."
And so they could not eat *the treat*.
41 And he said "Then bring meal." He
threw

It into the pot, told the crew,
"Dish it up for the people so
They can eat it and not be slow."
And there was no harm in the pot,
And so ended that frightful plot.

My hand, Beloved, shreds pumpkin on my
gruel
With stainless steel for my best shredding
tool,
And lays the poisoned prayer upon the rate
Of my prostrations for a fatal wait.
My searching in the treasure field of song
Uncarths the gems that seem bright for the
wrong.
Each effort to avail ends in rebuke:
My life despite all effort is a spook.
Beloved, cast in Your meal of grace and
change
The good things that appear within my
range
From poison to the nourishment I need
To cantillate again Your word with greed.
Beloved, serve up the meal-bred soup
again
And I shall join my force with other men.

42 There came a man from Baalshalisha,
And brought the man of Alohim
Bread of the firstfruits it would seem,
Twenty loaves of barley to kiss you,
And ripe ears of corn in the husk.
And he said "Give the folk at dusk
So they can eat *honey and musk*."
43 The waiter said "What? Shall I set
This before a hundred men met?"
And he said again, "Give the folk,
So they can all eat at a stroke,
For so says YHWH, 'They all will eat
And leave leftovers of the treat.'"

44 So he served them and they did eat
And left some as YHWH called the feat.

It's hardly fair, Beloved, so many know
The tale of Jesus done before his woe
When he fed the five thousand on the go.
He did not tread the path alone to bring
The bread and fish upon the stones to sing.
He had example of Elisha done
To feed the multitude beneath the sun.
Beloved, Your wonders breathe and then
repeat
So often that the human heart's replete
With awe before the rushing stream to find
The ocean of Your love not out of mind.
I bring an ear in husk, I bring a groat
And find that ocean's there here where I
float
As though the earth and sky were greater
feat.

2 Kings 5

1 Now Naaman who was army chief
For the king of Syria's relief
Was a great man before the king,
And honourable as anything,
Because by him YHWH had allowed
Syria great victories in crowd,
A mighty man and surely brave,
But because of leprosy grave.
2 The Syrians gone out in band
Had brought as captive from the land
Of Israel a little lass
Who served Naaman's wife *plate and
glass*.
3 And she said to her mistress, "If
Only my master for a sniff
Were by prophet of Alohim,
He'd cure him of leprosy's *scream*."
4 And someone went and told his lord,
Saying "So said the maid here floored
That's here from Israel's land *by sword*."
5 And Syria's king said, "Go then, go,
And I'll send a letter with bow
To Israel's king." And so he left
And took along ten talents cleft
Of silver and six thousand bits
Of gold, and ten changes of fits.

A servant girl perhaps with just a word
Changed the course of earth's history. It
occurred

That kings moved and removed because
 she spoke
 A whispered sigh between her labour's
 stroke.
 If that seems strange as cog in fortune's
 wheel,
 Think of the master who would make
 appeal.
 He was one who could say a word to kings
 And risk the wrath of prophets in ravings,
 And yet he was one that inspired the love
 Of a slave maiden whose heart's sighings
 of
 Hopefulness thought of him and wished
 him well.
 How many servants now are there to tell
 Who might remember their masters that
 way?
 I've seen even good masters' anger's sway.

6 And he brought the note to the king
 Of Israel, and said a thing,
 "Now when you get this letter see,
 I've sent Naaman with leprosy,
 My servant so you'll set him free."
 7 It happened when Israel's king read
 The letter, that he tore his spread
 Of clothing and at last he said
 "Am I Alohim that I kill
 And make alive as by my will,
 That this man sends someone to me
 To cure him of his leprosy?
 Consider please what he's about
 Seeking a quarrel and a rout."

Contrast the concern of the king with that
 Of the slave maiden on her working mat.
 The one is filled with fear and quarrelling
 And ready to combat the other king
 If only arms enough provide the sting.
 The other bowed with labour and with
 care,
 Too tired to sleep sometimes is there to
 share
 The feelings and the sorrows of the wife
 And master that oppress her little life.
 Her thoughts are for her mother living still
 Perhaps somewhere upon Samarian hill,
 The comfort of the woman that she serves,
 The health and happiness of others' nerves.
 Tell me which of the two's a better thrill?

8 When Elisha the man of God
 Heard that Israel's king at the prod
 Had torn his clothes, he sent the king
 Saying "Why do you do this thing?
 Let him now come to me to know
 A prophet stands in Israel's show."
 9 Naaman went with chariot and horse,
 And he stood at the door *in course*
 Of Elisha's house. 10 And he sent,
 Elisha did, a messenger
 To him, saying what should occur,
 "Go wash in Jordan seven times,
 And your flesh shall be *from its crimes*
 Restored to you, and *you'll* be clean."

The only example in Hebrew text
 Of proselyte's baptism is perplexed
 By the number of times to make the show.
 The Chosen Vessels mission's only glow
 Was seven dips, and in that they were right
 Despite the fact they are not now in sight.
 Three dips are found in Judaism now,
 And so the German Baptists dip a frau,
 And Eastern Orthodox still know the way
 To baptize with three dips instead of spray.
 I wonder if those slobbered on or held
 Beneath the water are clean from the
 spelled.
 The Decalogue knows no dips, and Qur'an
 Says You're the best of baptizers of spawn.

11 But Naaman was mad, *on the scene*,
In anger went away and said
 "I truly told myself instead,
 'He will surely come out *to me*,
 And stand and call upon the name
 Of YHWH his Alohim, and aim
 His hand upon the place, and he
 Will heal me of my leprosy.'
 12 "Are not Abana and Pharpar,
 Rivers of Damascus now far
 Better than all of Israel's streams?
 May I not wash in them, it seems,
 And be clean?" He left in a rage.
 13 And came near him servant and page
 And spoke to him and said "My father,
 If the prophet had told you bother
 To do some great thing, would you not
 Have done the great thing on the spot?
 How much more rather then when he
 Says to you 'Wash for purity?'"
 14 Then he went down and dipped himself

Seven times in the Jordan shelf,
As he was told by man of God,
And his flesh came alive *in pod*
Like the flesh of a little child,
And was well *from the illness wild*.

The rage of men and women in this place
Of shadows and fears is to run a race
Out of the water as fast as they can
And keep their leprosy down to a man.
How many stay to dip themselves that way,
Slowly and seven times and rise to pray?
At most three times the faithful want to
come,
And that is why their sin remains. The hum
Of flight from faith is not because You
take
Only those who have been washed in the
wake
Of seven waves, but because those who
start
Up from the pool do so because their heart
Is not wholly given to You. Your grace
Though infinite, requires repentance' trace.

15 He went back to the man of God,
He and all his company's bod,
And came and stood before him and
Said "See, I know in all the land
There is no God, but Israel's God,
So now then please take from the hand
Of your servant a blessing's nod."
16 And he said "As YHWH lives before
Whom I stand, I shall take no store."
And he urged him to take it then
But he refused it *once again*.

This is the one criterion to hold
To know whether a prophet's in the cold
Or one of Your's. Of course You gave the
heel
To those who defied Sinai's law's appeal,
And those whose prophecies were made in
vain
So nothing that they spoke happened to
rain.
But prophets of Your love and word today
Who recite all Your Scriptures the right
way
Are known because they do not take
reward,
But rely on Your keeping and Your sword.

Beloved, I cantillate each Sabbath morn
Your Scriptures without pay, and as forlorn
Look out upon the wilderness of food
Enough to keep alive a hungry brood.

17 And Naaman said "Shall not your man
Servant I beg you have two span
Of mules' load of earth? For your man
Servant from now on will not make
Burnt offering nor sacrifice stake
To any other gods but to
The Alohim of Israel YHWH.
18 In this one thing may YHWH forgive
Your servant, that when my lord live
To go into Rimmon's house and
To worship there, leaned on my hand,
I bowed myself in Rimmon's room,
When I bowed down myself *for doom*
In Rimmon's house, let YHWH forgive
Your servant for this thing *and live*."
19 And he told him, "Go in Islam."
So he went a way *singing Psalm*.

I too go in Islam, having made peace
With You, Beloved, and for my sins'
release
Look to Your grace alone, not sacrifice
Beyond the small death in baptism's slice
In seven dips in Jordan's heavy flood.
I do not drink or eat or sprinkle blood
From Your sent one upon my bread and
wine.
I do not sacrifice oxen and kine.
Instead I flee to that submission dressed
From Abraham that Elisha confessed
Upon Naaman, and bow upon the sod
That he sent with the captain and his rod.
Two mules' load of earth from the
promised land
Give me place for prayerful forehead and
hand.
20 And said Gehazi to himself,
Elisha God's man's serving elf,
"See how my master spares this man
This Naaman and this Syrian,
Not taking what his hands have brought,
But as YHWH lives, I'll run till caught
And take something from him *I've*
sought."
21 Gehazi followed Naaman's band,
And when Naaman saw on the land

Running after him, he got down
 From the chariot without frown
 To meet him and asked "Is all well?"
 22 And he said "Truly all is well.
 My master's sent me saying 'See,
 Just now two young men came to me
 From mount Ephraim, of prophets' sons,
 Give them please silver for their buns
 And two changes of clothes *for free.*"
 23 And Naaman said "Rather take two
 Talents of silver (*one's so few*),"
 And he urged him and tied up two
 Talents of silver in two pokes,
 With two changes of fine new cloaks,
 And gave them to two of his men
 To carry them for him *again*.

See, my Beloved, how generous are those
 Who have received Your blessings to give
 clothes
 And silver to the dishonest who make
 A presentation for Your name and sake!
 The devout Catholic is not slack to put
 A penny in the pot, it adds a foot
 Sometimes in charity to feed the poor.
 The Protestant is less of a good doer,
 But still is frank in turning up pounds,
 pence
 Despite his not having very good sense.
 Beloved, let me give silver straight in hand
 To the one who needs it upon the land
 And not trust mongers who know how the
 get
 A profit from my love to You first met.

24 And when he came back to the tower
 He took them from their hand and power
 And hid them in the house and then
 He let the men go back again.
 25 And he went in and stood before
 His master. And Elisha swore
 To him, "Where did you come from now
 Gehazi?" He said *with a bow*,
 "I didn't go outside the door."
 26 And he said to him, "Didn't my
 Heart follow you there on the sly
 When the man turned back from his car
 To meet you? Is it a time's star
 To get money, clothes, oliveyards,
 Vineyards and sheep and oxen pards,
 And menservants and maids, by gar?
 27 "So Naaman's leprosy shall stick

To you and your children to pick
 For ever." And he went out from
 His presence a leper *in sum*
As white as the snow that has come.

Your prophet knows the secret passage
 found
 By false servants and shepherds on the
 ground.
 You show the wicked path under the sun
 To those who represent You will be done.
 It's not a time to gain silver and cloak,
 It's not a time to trace the awful oak
 To oliveyards and vineyards where the best
 Of sheep and oxen come to take a rest.
 It's time instead to proclaim You are one
 To the civil servant and captain won
 From their idolatry, who find a place
 Beside the idol-worshipper in grace
 To bow indeed in temple made of bars,
 And yet worship only You under stars.

2 Kings 6

1 The sons of the prophets said to
 Elisha, "See, the house where you
 And we live is too small *for crew*.
 2 "So let's go please to Jordan's *stream*
 And take from there each man a beam,
 And let us build us a place there
 Where we can stay *without a care.*"
 And he answered, "Go *do your share.*"
 3 And someone said, "I wish you'd go
 Down with your servants for the show."
 And he answered him, "I will go."
 4 So he went with them. When they came
 To Jordan, they cut each his claim.
 5 But as one man cut down a tree,
 The axehead slipped, fell splashingly,
 And he cried and said "Master, oh,
 It was a borrow domino."
 6 And the man of Alohim said
 "Where did it fall?" And so he spread
 His hands toward the place, then he
 Cut off a stick and threw quickly
 Into the river and the iron
 Floated up *like following siren*.
 7 So he said "Catch it." and he stretched
 Out his hand and *the axehead* fetched.

Two miracles reported here are known:
 That iron floated on the Jordan and
 That when the prophets went out in a band

They did not want to go to work alone,
 But wanted Elisha to chaperone.
 That says a lot about a man in hand
 Who had two she-bears under his
 command
 And with them killed forty young men
 unblown.
 Beloved, a greater miracle than floating
 Axehead is that other young people noting
 Excursions are more fun when baldhead
 deigns
 To grace them with his presence count
 their gains
 When bald Elisha says that he will come
 I don't think they predicted axehead's hum.

8 The king of Aram came to war
 Against Israel, and took up for
 His servants counsel, saying thus
 "In such and such a place *for worse*
 Shall be my camp." 9 The man of God
 Sent to the king of Israel prod
 Saying, "Watch out and don't go near
 Such and such a place, for the fear
 Of Syrians hiding in the rear."
 10 And Israel's king sent to the place
 That Alohims's man marked by grace
 And warned him of, and took his guard
 Not once or twice *in that regard*.

Who disregard the sermons once sent down
 To Your prophets and hear them with a
 frown
 Are often men of state and war who might
 Welcome informer prophet with delight.
 Your hidden ones today no doubt appeal
 To president and prime minister's heel
 With good advice to work the woe and
 weal
 Of such events for now that meet the sight.
 Unrecognized Your representative
 Engages politicians where they live,
 And what seems filled with only greed and
 plot
 Is often transfigured behind the sought.
 Your finger rests upon the plans of men
 To foil the evil time and time again.

11 That's why the king of Syria's heart
 Was greatly troubled for its part,
 And he called his servants and said
 To them, "Won't you reveal the spread

Of which of us is spying for
 The king of Israel *at the door?*"
 12 One of his servants said "My lord,
 None of us is a spy deplored,
 O king, but Elisha the prophet
 That's in Israel will always cough it
 Up even the word that you speak
 In your own bedroom *and with cheek*."

Even the servants of the king of greed
 Sometimes know better than the holy seed
 The workings of Your hand upon the earth.
 Sometimes a wisdom lies beneath their
 mirth.

More often, I trow with my doubting heart,
 The accusation of the divine part
 Is born of superstition and the ray
 Of New Age surmisings in iron and clay.
 Beloved, the round of human thought and
 eye
 Is fleet to find a pattern in the sky,
 And yet the world is not fast in the claw
 Of what we picture in the wakened maw.
 Your revelation penetrates the sound
 Of the earth spinning round and round and
 round.

13 And he said "Go and take a look
 Where he's at, and I'll send a hook
 And fetch him." So they told him then
 "See now, the man is in Dothan."

14 So he sent horses, chariots and
 A great army that came to stand
 Against the city in the night.
 15 And when the servant of the wight
 Man of Alohims got up bright
 And early and went out, see there,
 An army besieged the town where
 There stood both horses and a *fleet*
Of chariots ready *in the street*.

And his servant said to him, "Oh,
 My master, how shall we now go?"

16 He answered him, "Don't be afraid,
 For those with us are more arrayed
 Than those of them who came and stayed."

17 Elisha prayed and said "YHWH, I
 Beg you to open up the eye
 So he may see." And YHWH did that,
 And opened the young man's eyes flat,
 And he saw, and see on the hill
 Was full of horses and the shrill
 Of fiery chariots round about

The place where Elisha stood stout.

My eyes have been opened upon the mount
Where I came quietly to take an account,
And what I saw was not the fire and flame
Of angels bent on vengeance in Your
name,

But the same sun that comes anew at dawn
And the same colours that I thought were
gone

Forever at a stake. My eyes still make
Appearance of the heavenly cloudy wake
Of mercy strewn across a troubled sky.
My eyes have seen the angels passing by.
Beloved, as red and gold turn worsted grey,
And morning melodies settle to day,
My open eyes see in the daily round
The miracles that always can be found.

18 And when they came down to him, then
Elisha prayed YHWH, "Smite these men,
I beg, with blindness." And He struck
Them with blindness and at the cluck
Of Elisha. 19 Elisha said

To them, "This is not where you're led
The way or the city, but stay
Behind me, and I'll show the way
To the man you are looking for."
He brought them to Samaria's *door*.

20 It happened when they had arrived
Into Samaria, *he contrived*,
Elisha did, and so he said

"YHWH, open their eyes *whom I've led*,
That they may see." And so YHWH did
Open up their eyes *and eyelids*,
And they saw and see they were there
In middle of Samaria *fair*.

21 And Israel's king when he saw them,
Said to Elisha, "Father gem,
Shall I strike them, shall I strike them?"

22 He answered, "You shall not kill now,
Would you kill such as captive bow
Before your sword and arrows set?
Put bread and water till they get
Enough to eat and drink and then
Go back to their master *like men*."

23 And he prepared for them a feast,
And when they'd eat and drunk increased,
He sent them back and they went to
Their master. So the Syrian crew
Did not come back to Israel's land.

See here, Beloved, the way that prophets
climb.

They always lead blind men in merry
mime.

They never take the seeker where he's due,
And into the places of guru pew,
But lead the men in fairy chase and find
Them captive in their enemies' house
blind.

See here, Beloved, how prophets always
act,

And it's because their humour is intact,
That when the human heart in serious
mission

Is searching for the one under suspicion,
He tracks them all out of the way to go
And brings them to a feast and rowdy
show.

Send me no prophets, my Beloved, and I
Shall not have weapons in the field to spy.

24 After this it happened at hand
That Benhadad gathered his band
As king of Syria and went out
Against Samaria about.

25 Samaria was famine stricken,
And see how they besieged it thicken
Until a donkey's head was sold
For eighty silver pieces cold,
And quarter of a piece of poop
Of pigeon for five silver coup.

Some say that pigeon poop is really just
The name they gave in humour for a crust
Of garlic. I am not so good at talk
To say whether that's true in Hebrew
stock.

In any case the price of food was great
So that the poor suffered the harder fate
As always happens when the kings step out
To try their arms against each other's rout.
Beloved, a donkey's head is not my cue
For pleasant meals before which I thank
You.

A donkey's head is rather for the sound
Of blaring plunder on the village round.
I tighten belt and come to You to find
If there isught to eat when You are kind.

26 And as the king of Israel
Was walking on the wall a spell,
A woman shouted to him saying

“Help, my lord king, *from the gainsaying.*”

27 And he said “If YHWH does not help

You, how shall I give more than yelp

Out of the silo or wine cellar?”

28 And the king asked her, “Tell a fellow

What’s wrong?” She answered, “See, my mate,

This woman said to me of late,

‘Give up your son that we may eat

Him for today, and then complete

The eating of my son tomorrow.’

29 “So we boiled my son, ate in sorrow,

And I said to her the next day,

‘Give up your son and have our way

To eat him.’ But she hid her son.”

30 It happened when the king had done

Heard the words of the woman, that

He tore his clothing where he sat

Upon the wall, and the folk looked,

And there was sackcloth underhooked

Upon his body. 31 Then he said

“God do me in and more if yet

If Elisha’s head shall stay set

On Shaphat’s son on this day met.”

32 But Elisha sat in his room,

The elders with him to presume,

And the king sent a man out from

Him, but before the man could come

To him, he told the elders, “See

How this son of murder makes free

To send and take away my head?

See, when the messenger is led

In, shut the door, and hold him fast

At the door, is not the sound cast

Of his master’s feet coming last?”

33 And while he was still saying that,

The messenger came where he sat,

And then said “Truly tragedy

Like this is from YHWH, why should be

My hope in YHWH eternally?”

I understand the king. I too would fly

Off in wrath if a woman that passed by

In my kingdom brought me such a
complaint.

I too would howl against sinner and saint.

The king had seen Elisha perform things

That made the miracles of divine kings

Seem pale and flimsy. So why did

He not stop all the suffering under lid?

He might have said the word and armies
fail.

He might have touched stones and make
them avail

As bread and cake. And yet he sits among

His friends and recites Scripture, tones well
sung.

I understand the anger of the king

Better indeed, Beloved, than anything.

2 Kings 7

1 Elisha said “Now hear YHWH’s word,

So says YHWH, ‘Tomorrow’s inured

When a measure of fine flour’s price

Shall be a shekel, and then twice

That much of barley for the same

In the gate of Samaria’s fame.”

2 An officer upon whose hand

The king leaned answered sans command

The man of Alohim, and said

“See, if YHWH made windows instead

In the sky could this thing occur?”

And he said “See, you’ll see it, sir,

But not eat a bite *of the bread.*”

You try the faith of men too hard when

You

Make prophets say things that cannot be
true

By everything men know of life and
power.

You create infidelity the hour

You speak to humankind. No doubt that’s
why

You are so silent after Sinai’s try.

It is a grace that human ears hear not

The cantillations of Your heavenly plot.

The human heart cannot believe the song,

And so in unbelief turns to the wrong.

I sit in silence of the spheres and wake

My doubting heart to melodies that take

The universe by arm and ear and make

Of the great dance a tentpin and a stake.

3 Four leprous men sat at the gate,

Said to each other, “Why tempt fate

Just sitting here until we die?

4 “If we say ‘We’ll go on the sly

Into the city,” famine’s there

And death will only be our share.

And if we stay here we’ll die too.

So now then let’s be up and do,

Surrender to the Syrian host,

And if they save us, we can boast,

And if they kill us in the fray,
We'll just be dead in the same way."

No matter what we do in life for truth,
A man's condemned to die if not in youth
At least in old age. Does the argument
Then follow that I should enter the tent
Nearest the city to find bread unspent
And feast till morning? Should I tell the
crowd

Upon the wall what I have found allowed?
Death comes to all, it seems, and yet the
tale

Speaks of another time and clime and pale.
Beloved, I rise up from the gallows floor
And turn my back against the city door
To face the vanished goblins that prevent
My entry into Your feast's covenant.
I find within the famine plenty's store.

5 They got up by the evening light

To go into the camp in sight
Of Syrians, and when they came
To the edge of the camp *for shame*
Of Syria, see, none were there.

6 The Lord had made the Syrian host
Hear noise of chariots and the boast
Of horses, and the heavy sound
Of a great army, they were found
Saying to one another, "Look,
The king of Israel's played the crook
And hired against us Hittite kings
As well as the Egyptian rings
To fight against us *underlings*."

Fear flies before the reasons guessing that
Assumed seem proven truth and got down
pat.

The Syrians were sure that Israel's king
bribed

Egyptians and Hittites with gold imbibed
To fight their war. Illusion seems so safe
To strong man as to every failing waif.
It is not doubt that leads man into wrong
Paths and destruction before angel throng,
But rumours left undoubted and the tale
Told for the truth that punctures iron mail.
Beloved, teach me to doubt the sound of
men

And chariots riding on the outer fen.
Beloved, give me to doubt and doubt again
Until I see the sparkle of the sail.

7 And so they got up in the night
And left their tents and in their flight
Their horses, donkeys, all the camp
Just as it was and hit the tramp.
8 So when these lepers found the edge
Of the camp they took privilege
To go in one tent, eat and drink,
And carry from it silver clink
And gold and clothing which they hid,
And came back for another bid,
And took that too, that's what they did.

9 And then they said to one another,
"What we do's not right, *friend and
brother*,

Today's a day of good news and
We don't say a word, if we stand
Till morning, some evil will fall
On us, now then, get on the ball,
Let's go tell the king's house of all."

In fact most people are not so unselfish
here

As those three lepers who got up for fear.
Those men were used to thinking what
might be

The result of their actions to their fee.
Their grave disease is what made them
look out

For future cuffs and officers' shout.
Unselfishness created by the rough
In the subservient to me is not enough.
Unselfishness is just a vain conceit
Among those who have luxury of meat.
The city was filled with women who knew
How to boil children, how to serve and
chew.

Beloved, save me from my unselfish
thought,

And I shall meet you on the dergah spot.

10 They came and called the porter down
To tell him and inform the town,
Saying "We came into the camp
Of Syrians, and see the scamp,
No one was there and not a sound,
But horses tethered all around
With donkeys and tents on the ground."

11 He called the porters and they told
It to the king's house *and the bold*.

12 And the king got up in the night
And told his servants, "I'll make light

To you what Syrians have done
To us. They know hunger has won,
So they've left the camp now to hide
Themselves in the field and to bide,
Saying 'When they come out of town,
We'll catch them all alive and down
Into the city *when we've tried.*'"

The king of Israel, for all his weight
Of wrath at the expense of prophet great,
Is wise to the affairs of war and men
And ready to suspect the adder's den.
Harmless as dove he may or may not be,
Who sent a soldier to the prophet's fee,
But wise as serpent I show in his rate
Of watching for the Syrians at gate.
Beloved, I too come out to eat the feast
That you have set before me and increased
With watchful eye, lest human hand appear
To quash my joy with an inhuman fear.
Though I doubt not Your love and grace I
find
You have made men of quite a different
mind.

13 And one of his servants then said
"Please let us take five of the fed
Horses that we still have in town
(See, they are all Israel's renown,
Since all is consumed by the crown),
And let's go out and see the dread."

14 Two chariot horses so they took,
And the king sent to have a look
After the Syrian army, saying
"Go and see *if they're hidden slaying.*"

Indeed, two horses are enough, why bother
five,

When hardly more than that are still alive?
And yet I still ask with the king why You
Did not demand the prophet come in view
With sacred noise of warfare on the plain
Before the death of that one boy in vain.
What happiness is there in finding out
The city's safe and Syrian in rout,
Since that boy's dead and buried in the gut
Of mother and of neighbour, while friend
shut

In hiding now is playing in the street?
What comfort is there now in any treat?
Could You not have sent noises just as well
A week before the ringing of the bell?

15 They followed them to Jordan's stream,
And see all the road like a dream
Was full of clothes and pots they left,
The Syrians hastily bereft.

The messengers came back to tell
The king *what they had seen as well.*

16 And so the people all went out
And took the spoils of Syrian rout
From all their tents. And so a pound
Of wheaten flour was had at sound
Of just a shekel and the two
Of barley for a shekel due,
According to the word of YHWH.

17 The king set the lord on whose hand
He leaned to have the gate's command,
And the people trampled him down
In the gate that came *in the town,*
And he died, as Alohims man
Had said when he spoke to *the clan*
When the king came down to his *van.*

18 It happened as Alohims man
Had spoken to the king by plan,
"Two barley measures for the span
Of one shekel and wheaten flour
One measure at a shekel's power,
Shall be tomorrow at this time
In gate of Samarian *mime.*

19 And that lord answered to the man
Of Alohims and said "How can
If be, if YHWH should open up
Windows in the sky, throw a cup,
It could not happen." And he said
"Look, you will see it where you're led,
But not taste a crumb of the bread."

20 And so it turned out for his fate,
The people trampled in the gate,
And so he died *at any rate.*

I've seen the place of trampling in my day,
I visited in Mina once to pay
Respects of pebbles thrown in Satan's way,
And saw where hundred died beneath the
feet

Of others pushed on and beyond retreat.
The horror of the trampling is a thing
Not to be forgotten in the night's ring
When sleep flees from the eye and heart
beats high.

No trampling is a horror under sky.
Beloved, You've seen the tramlings
humans make

Throughout the history of the earthly cake.
Tell me what rises in Your divine heart
When You awaken to the crushing cart?
Is there a thing You can say for Your sake?

2 Kings 8

1 Now spoke Elisha to the wife
Whose son he had restored to life,
And said "Get up and go out you
And your house and stay in a crew
Wherever you can find to stay,
For YHWH has called to come this way
A famine, and it will appear
Upon the land for seven year."

2 The woman got up and obeyed
The word of Alohims man *paid*,
And she went with her household and
Stayed seven years upon the land
Of Philistines. 3 It happened when
The seven years had gone again,
The woman came back from the land
Of Philistines, and turned her hand
To the king for her house and land.

Fact is, Beloved, that refugees are not
The product of a very modern plot
Alone, but have been living off the land
Of foreigner and thief on every hand.
Despite the wars, despite the heathen track,
In times past it was possible when lack
Drove one out of one's lot to find the
knack

Even among the Philistines' command.
Beloved, if those fell primitives of late
Could take in refugees without a wait
And nourish them and cherish them until
A full seven of years had turned the mill,
Why cannot we so civilized and great
Not find a corner for the poor ingrate?

4 The king talked with Gehazi who
Was servant of Alohims' gnu,
And said "Please tell me all the things
Of greatness that Elisha brings."

5 It happened just as he was telling
The king how he had brought excelling
A dead body back to the living,
See the woman he had been giving
Back her son cried unto the king
For her house and her everything.
And Gehazi said "My lord king,
This is the woman and her son

Whom Elisha gave back and won."
6 When the king asked the wife, she told
him.

So the king set one not to scold him
As officer to her and said
"Restore all that was hers and bread
Of all the field from the day that
She left the land till where we're at."

Of course, to be a refugee entails
The loss of property and house and nails
If one tries to return to former seat
And eat the former grapes and oil and
wheat.

Some king will have taken the spoil for
His own and to increase the royal store.
But something like a resurrection from
The dead might be enough to make the
sum

Return to rightful owner if the tale
Is told at the right time in the right scale.
Beloved, I am no refugee nor yet
Land-owner threatened by famine to get
Comfort at home or abroad, I retain
Nomadic status for Your further gain.

7 Elisha came to Damascus,
And Benhadad the king *to curse*
Of Syria was sick and it
Was told him, saying "The man *fit*
Of Alohims has come here *flit*."

8 The king said to Hazael, "Now take
A gift in hand and go for sake
Of meeting Alohims man and
Enquire of YHWH by him and stand
To say 'Shall I get well as planned?'"

9 Hazael went to meet him and took
A present with him, and just look,
Every good thing Damascus makes,
Forty camel loads, no mistakes,
And stood before him saying "Your
Son Benhadad king of the run
Of Syria sent me before
You to ask 'Shall I when I'm done
Get well of this disease in store?'"

10 Elisha told him, "Go and tell
Him, 'You will certainly get well.'
But in reality YHWH showed
Me he will die *beneath the load*."

11 He tried to keep a poker face
Until he was ashamed a space,
Alohims man burst into tears.

12 Hazael then asked him it appears
 “Sir, why are you crying?” And he
 Answered, “Because the deviltry
 That you will do to Israel’s folk
 Came to my mind as I just spoke,
 How You will set fire to their forts,
 And with swords kill young men in shorts,
 And crush their children on the ground,
 Ripping up pregnant women found.”
 13 And Hazael said “Am I a dog,
 That your servant should play the hog?”
 Elisha answered, “YHWH showed me
 You’ll be king of Syrian spree.”

The evil that I do, Beloved, shocks me
 When told before the fact, I’m sure I’m
 free
 From wickedness, and pure a lamb as be,
 Until the fatal moment that my hand
 Finds justice as I see it requires stand.
 No man does wickedness for wickedness,
 But for the right the limited access
 To truth reveals in illusion at poll.
 No one does wickedly of man or troll.
 Imagination falters at the sight,
 But righteous indignation lifts the light
 And arms bear hearts into the fray and
 fight.
 Not slaughter children and the pregnant
 dam?
 Hazael thinks not, and yet, and yet I am.

14 So he left Elisha and came
 Back to his master who would aim
 To know what Elisha had said.
 And he answered, “He without dread
 Told me you would rise from your bed.”
 15 It happened the next day that he
 Took a thick cloth and let it be
 In water and spread on his face,
 So that he died, and in his place
 Reigned Hazael *as by decree*.

It is no wrong to lie to kings when told
 To do the deed by every prophet bold.
 To say the truth is for the child and fool,
 The lie is every wise man’s faithful tool.
 Lie of the future, where’s the sin in that?
 No man can know the future and out flat,
 But only guess at dim and prophecy.
 Of course Elisha’s one whose word may be
 Reliable beyond the normal weather.

Lie, lie, and find all men are of one feather.
 Beloved, I seek the love of truth and yet
 Know that truth stabs me just as well to set
 As every king and prophet of the past.
 I fly the flag of humankind half-mast.

16 In the fifth year of Joram son
 Of Ahab king of Israel won,
 Jehoshaphat when he was king
 Of Judah, Jehoram took wing,
 Jehoshaphat’s son began to
 Reign as king of Judean crew.
 17 Thirty-two years old was he when
 He started to reign over men,
 And he reigned for all of eight years
 Over Jerusalem *for tears*.
 18 He acted like all Israel’s kings
 As did the house of Ahab’s *flings*,
 For Ahab’s daughter was his wife,
 And he did evil, *he did strife*,
 Before YHWH’s eyes *and all his life*.
 19 Yet YHWH would not destroy Judah
 For David his servant in awe,
 Since He promised him to give light
 To *all* of his children *in sight*.

You promise David a light and a store
 Of power beyond the wisdom of earth’s
 gore.
 Even the heart of David, close to Yours,
 Was able to open up wicked doors
 And let in violence and greed and all
 The fateful things that are at beck and call
 Of royalty. Beloved, what promise kept
 Has been less fraught with power to the
 inept?
 Destroy no state on earth, and You will see
 That evil but extends the riot’s spree.
 Destroy them all, and You will find the
 weight
 Of suffering first lands on innocent pate.
 I flee to David’s promise for the best,
 And find reciting Your word longed-for
 rest.

20 In his days Edom made revolt
 From under Judah’s rule *like colt*,
 And made themselves for king *a dolt*.
 21 So Horam went over to Zair,
 And all his chariots with his ire,
 And he got up by night and struck
 The Edomites down in the muck,

And in their chariots their blents,
And the folk fled into their tents.
22 And still Edom revolts till now
From Judah's rule, Libnah somehow
Revolted at the same powwow.

The heathen revolt from David's appeal,
And even David's house has come to feel
The weight of Ahab's wickedness and spiel
Of Jezebel's reward for every heel.
Revolt against Jerusalem? I doubt
That revolt will find any good thing out.
The crown and crosier are corrupted now
As when the son of David set the prow
Towards the scientific, heathen rate.
And yet there's no use to disrupt the great.
The tents of David are repaired to sing
At the recital of the Psalms that ring
The pristine air with clarity of sound
And bring down heaven's kingdom to the
ground.

23 And all the rest of Joram's acts,
And all he did are written facts
In books of chronicles of kings
Of Judah *among other things*.
24 And Joram slept with his ancestors,
And buried in their fast sequesters
In David's city, and his son
Ahaziah his reign begun.
25 In the twelfth year of Joram son
Of Ahab king of Israel's bun
Did Ahaziah the son of
Jehoram king of Judah's love
Begin to reign *as said above*.
26 Ahaziah was twenty-two
Years old when he began to view
His kingdom and he reigned one year
Over Jerusalem *with fear*.
And his mother was Athaliah,
Daughter of Omri, king to tire
Israel *with his wrath and ire*.
27 And he acted as all those did
Who came from Ahab's house, and did
Evil in the eyes of YHWH and
As did the house of Ahab's band,
For he was son-in-law to stand
In Ahab's house *and at his hand*.
28 And he went with Joram the son
Of Ahab to war and to gun
Against Hazael the Syrian king
In Ramoth Gilead to bring.

The Syrians wounded Joram.
29 And king Joram went like a ham
Back to be healed in Jezreel of
The wound the Syrians above
Had given him by Ramah's glove,
When he fought against Hazael king
Of Syria. And that's the thing
That made Ahaziah the son
Of Jehoram Judah's king won
To go down to see Joram son
Of Ahab in Jezreel, because
He was sick *and ill in his claws*.

No doubt there is reward in every act
Of mercy no matter who makes the pact.
One king goes to another with a box
Of chocolates and long-stemmed roses'
stalks.
It he had stayed at home and not gone out
To fight and war and turn the chariot rout,
He might have kept his health and fitness
too.

But that is not the way that princes do.
Beloved, I too have fetched me back for
grief
Illness enough, and then begged for relief.
It is the fate of men and women too
To suffer act of virus and of You.
Let this not lay blame where it is not due:
Your innocence is beyond doubt and true.

2 Kings 9

1 Elisha the prophet called one
Of the students in the school run
To teach the cantillation of
The divine word spoken in love,
And said to him, "Put on your clothes
And take this box of oil I chose,
And go to Ramoth Gilead.
2 "And when you get there, don't be sad,
But look for Jehu who is son
Of Nimshi, and when you've begun
Go in and make him get up from
Among his fellows and to come
Apart into a secret place.
3 "Then take the vial of oil and trace
It on his head and say "So's said
YHWH, 'I've anointed you now led
To be king over Israel.'
Then open up the door and flee,
And do not stay there *openly*."

I too am cantillator of Your Word,
And so might be called son of prophet bird,
But I was never called to oil the king
Or any impostor to crown and sting.
What would they think if I burst in the
room

Where generals were planning the world's
doom

And took one aside and with horn of oil
Greased his bald spot to shine like blistered
boil?

They'd think me mad, as like, and when I
turn

The page the same thing here I can discern.
That's why You told the man to shut the
door

And flee before they figured out the score.
Beloved, nothing has changed, it seems to
me,

Since schools of cantillation took their fee.

4 So the young man, the student prophet,
Went to Ramoth Gilead *and off it.*

5 And when he got there see the chiefs

Of the army sitting for griefs,
And he said "I've an errand here
For you, captain." It would appear
Jehu said "Which of us in brief?"
And he said "To you only, chief."

6 And he got up, went in the room,
And poured the oil out like perfume
On his head and said to him, "So
Says YHWH Alohim on the go
In Israel, 'I anoint you
King over the people of YHWH,
Over Israel *to be king true.*

7 'And you'll attack your master's room,
The house of Ahab to its doom,
So I may take vengeance for blood
Of my servants, prophets, in flood,
And blood of all servants of YHWH
In the power of Jezebel's crew.

8 'For Ahab's whole house shall come
down,

And I'll cut off from Ahab's town
Every man-child, and the one hidden
And the one left at large unbidden.

9 'I'll make Ahab's house like the room
Of Jeroboam for its doom,

The son of Nebat, like the band
Of Baasha, Ahijah's son *fanned.*

10 'The dogs shall eat of Jezebel

In the plot of Jezreel to swell,
And there shall be none there to make
A grave for her and for her sake."
And then he opened up the door
And fled and was seen never more.

Beloved, I here rejoice to hear the word
That Jezebel would turn into a turd
That dogs would eat and spread upon the
field

Of Jezreel to increase the wheat yield.
The divine light in every human soul
Can be turned to both good and evil goal,
And it is but justice to find the fate
Destruction of the wicked and the great.
Beloved, I always thought the graceful dog
The pinnacle of Your creating log,
And laud Your provision of savoury meat
For every dog with wagging tail to eat.
I doubt the dogs forget to thank Your
grace,

But I thank You once more and just in
case.

11 Then Jehu came out to the band
Of his lords servants in the land,
And they asked him, "Are all things well?
What did this madman come to tell?"

And he said to them, "It looks like
You know the man and what's his spike."

12 And they said, "Not so, tell us now."
And he said "He told me like this,
And said, 'So says YHWH not to miss,
I anoint you as Israel's king.'"

14 Jehu son of Jehoshaphat
Son of Nimshi planned to raise bat
Against Joram. And Joram kept
Ramoth Gilead, and he swept
All Israel there, because the king
Of Syria Hazael's *acting.*

15 But king Joram came back to be
Healed in Jezreel of the wounds he
Received from Syrians when he
Fought with Hazael the Syrian king.
And Jehu said "Just keep the thing
In your minds and let no one go
Out or escape the town to show
The thing in Jezreel *that we know.*"

Amazing here is that Jehu went out
Immediately to carry out the rout.

He might have laughed and put it out of
mind.
What made him think anointing of that
kind
Would bring success to his rebellious fit?
Apparently he thought Elisha's wit
In sending a young Bible singer to
Anoint him was sign enough in his view.
Beloved, I see the turning of the stars,
The brush of moon, the rush of sunlit bars,
And know despite the crooning and the
shout
That you have secret messengers about.
The president, prime minister do not
Know who is coming up against their plot.

16 So Jehu rode a chariot,
And went to Jezreel where the plot
Of Joram lay. Ahaziah
Who was the king over Judah
Had come down to see Joram's lot.
17 There stood a watchman on the tower
In Jezreel who spied the power
Of Jehu coming and he said
"I see a band." And Joram said
"Take a horseman and send to meet
Them asking if it's peace their treat."
18 So one went on horse back to greet
Him saying "So says the king here,
'Are you coming in peace or fear?'"
Jehu said "What's to do with peace?
Turn in behind me for release."
The watchman told them saying then,
"The messenger came to the men,
But he's not coming back again."
19 So he sent one more on horseback,
Who came to them and said not slack,
"The king asks if you come in peace."
And Jehu answered, "Do you cease
To do with peace? Join my police."
20 The watchman spoke again and said
"He came to them but was not led
To return, and the driving's like
The driving of Jehu to strike,
The son of Nimshi, for he drives
As furiously *as with nine lives*."

The driving of Jehu's so famous that
I hardly can add something to the spat.
More than his driving, I would see the rate
Of turning peaceful messengers in fate

To fight with him against the king and
great.
He has a divine mandate. Does he not
Doubt his calling at all? It's one he got
From a mere stripling who was learning
how
To cantillate the Scriptures with clear
brow.
The stripling got it from another man,
Albeit famous prophet, still I can
See links to many in the chain. I'd doubt
The mandate till too late in rout
And foil even Your own resplendent plan.

21 And Joram said "Get ready then."
And his chariot was brought again.
And Joram king of Israel
And Ahaziah king as well
Of Judah went out, each one in
His own chariot, gone to win
Against Jehu, and came in sight
In plot of Naboth Jezreelite.
22 It happened when Joram saw Jehu,
He said "Jehu, is it peace free you?"
And he answered, "What peace is there
As long as your mother's affair,
Jezebel's mucking witchcrafts stare
The world in the face everywhere?"

The man is not just headstrong, but he
speaks
The gutter language while his angel weeps.
Methinks, Beloved, You chose him to be
king
In order to give hanging rope to bring
His reckless driving to a fatal halt.
He talked that way, I know, but was the
malt
Worthy of quoting in Scripture's assault?
We have to read the Scripture as we come
To worship You on Sabbath day in sum,
And then You let such language fill the
track
That parents hope their children turn their
back
And close their ear. Beloved, You were not
wise
To let Jehu be quoted in this guise.
Of course, he only said the truth a smack.

23 And Joram turned his hands and fled
And then to Ahaziah said

“It’s treachery, Ahaziah!”

24 And Jehu drew a bow with paw
And struck Jehoram twixt his arms,
And the arrow went with alarms
Out at his heart and he sank down
In his chariot *by the town*.

25 Then he said to Bidkar his chief,
“Take up the body for relief
And throw it in the lot and field
Of Naboth Jezreelite to yield
Remembrance how when we two rode
Together after Ahab’s load,
His father, that YHWH laid this thing
Upon him *before he was king*;

26 ‘Surely I’ve seen yesterday blood
Of Naboth and his sons in flood,’
Says YHWH, ‘and I will requite this
In this very ground *not to miss*,’
Says YHWH. Now therefore take him out
And throw him on that ground in rout
According to the word of YHWH.”

Your prophecies, Beloved, are often met
With their fulfilment when some heroes get
The nerve to carry out the things You said.
Prophecies are not all in self-fulfilment.
Some wait until the time of faster billment.
So Jehu calls to witness Bidkar and
Throws Jehoram into Naboth’s late land.
I search the Scriptures for a prophecy
Not yet fulfilled to see if I can be
A hero in the northernmost country
By carrying out what You had one say
Upon the dry hills of Israel one day.
Beloved, if nothing else, let my heart know
Fulfilment of the promises You show.

27 And Ahaziah seeing this,
The king of Judah fled to miss
The way of the garden house, while
Jehu followed him by the stile,
And said “Attack him too and in
His own chariot *in his sin*.”
On the way up to Gur they did,
Which is by Ibleam where he hid.
And he fled to Megiddo then
And there he died *beside his men*.

A frantic chase across the garden brings
To mind the chase of Adam who took
wings

When he found that his backside remained
bare

After tasting forbidden fruit to share
With spouse when hidden knowledge
tempted him

To lighten his mind with distinctions made
Between the right and wrong. So he was
paid.

Jehu was agile, more agile it seems
Than You were, my Beloved, who in my
dreams

Calls Adam with such pathos and desire.
Jehu’s is anger’s zeal, not love’s bright
fire.

The garden missed the violence. That came
Only upon the barren road for shame.
Megiddo is the place to die in mire.

28 His servant carried him back to
Jerusalem in chariot’s view,
And buried him in his own grave
With his fathers and in the brave
City of David *in his cave*.

29 Eleventh year of Joram son

Of Ahab was when had begun
Ahaziah to reign upon

The land of Judah and its dawn.

30 When Jehu came to Jezreel then
Jezebel heard, and so again
She painted her face, on her head
Put a crown, from the window shed.

31 As Jehu enter in the gate
She said “What was then Zimri’s fate
Who killed his master *for the state*?”

32 He lifted up his face to see
The window and said “Who is free
On my side, who?” And there looked out
At him two or three eunuchs *stout*.

33 And he commanded, “Throw her
down.”

So they threw her down *on her crown*.
And her blood spattered on the wall
And on the horses in her fall,
And he trampled her under foot.

34 And when he had come in he put
Himself to eat and drink and said
“Go see now this cursed hag abed,
And bury her, for she’s offspring
And daughter of a royal king.”

Four men agree without least consultation

To throw a painted queen from window's station

To be trampled by horse and men until
Her rags are covered in her blood and swill.

The fate of Jezebel is not to spoil
The appetite of new kings in their toil.
An afterthought come too late for the queen.

Men are too ready to honour the scene
With funerals and posies on a grave,
Who thought nothing of tossing one like slave

Upon the pitch. All honour's in the ditch.
There is no man sincerely lauds the great,
But all think of their own coming estate,
And bank upon the future when they come
With signal praises between nail and thumb.

35 And they went out to bury her,
But they found no more of her fur
Than the skull and the feet and yet
The palms of her hands *where they set*.

36 And so they came and told him so.
And he said "This is YHWH's word's show,

That He spoke by His servant come,
Elijah the Tishbite wherefrom
He said 'In Jezreel's plot the dogs
Shall eat Jezebel like the hogs.

37 And Jezebel's carcass shall be
Like dung on the field's surface free
In the lot of Jezreel, so they
Can't say "Here's Jezebel today."

What happens to the great is rarely fine,
Beloved, and yet all men seek heady wine
Of status and of praise before the crowd.
What happens to the great You speak aloud
Beforehand and in warning of the bit.
But rarely do the great listen to it.
Elijah the Tishbite is still alive,
They say in occultation to contrive
To see the universe from heaven and drive
The fiery chariots along the day
That dipped into the lake where my songs lay.

Beloved, did that Elijah from his perch
Approve of Jezebel's fate in the lurch?
He had his own contention by the way.

2 Kings 10

1 Ahab had seventy children in
Samaria. And Jehu wrote
Letters sent to Samaritan bin,
To Jezreel's chiefs and elders and
To those who cared for Ahab's band
Saying *to them not to misquote*,

2 "As soon as you get this epistle,
Since your master's children like thistle
Are with you and chariots and horses,
A fortified town, armour's courses,

3 "Pick out the best and finest of
The children of your master's love,
And set him on his father's throne,
Defend your master's house alone."

4 But they were very much afraid
And said "See, two kings were waylaid
Before him, how shall we be stayed?"

5 The chiefs of the house and the city,
The elders also, and with pity
The bringers up of the king's brood,
Sent to Jehu not being rude,
To say "We are your servants all,
And we shall do right by your call.

We shall not make us any king,
Just do what you think's the right thing."

6 And so he wrote again to them
And said "If you are mine, condemn
The heads of the men by my word,
Your master's children, and come stirred
To me in Jezreel by this time
Tomorrow. And the king's son's crime
Amounted to seventy men who
Were with the great men of that crew
Who brought them up *on honey-dew*.

7 It happened when the letter came
They took the king's children for shame
And killed all seventy men and put
Their heads in baskets, left the foot,
And sent to him in Jezreel's *root*.

There is no new thing set under the bun,
And Machiavelli did not strive to be
Original in what he wrote for fun.
He just noted what princes faithfully
Perform since time began under the sun.
Jehu was not just reckless in his driving.
He had a plan beneath his maddened cap,
And humour drove him more than any
striving

Perhaps because the woman in his lap

Kept body, soul and wit attuned and thriving.
The heads of tyrant's children innocent,
The bloody cabbages picked from the field,
The dripping pumpkins wherever they went,
Beloved, are harvest of the same old yield.

8 And so a messenger arrived
And told him saying "They've contrived
To bring the heads of the king's sons."
And he said "Pile them up like buns
In two piles by the city gate
Until the morning actuate."

9 It happened in the morning that
He went out and stood there where sat
All the people and so he spoke,
"Look here, all you good gentle folk,
Rebelling I rose against king,
And killed him, but who did this thing
To kill young men and each suckling?
10 "Know that no single word shall fail
Of what YHWH, YHWH spoke to avail
Concerning Ahab's house, for YHWH
Has done what He predicted by
His servant Elijah to ply."

11 So Jehu killed all who remain
Of Ahab's house on Jezreel's plain,
And all his great men, all his kin,
And all his priests, till none stayed in
The land who were of Ahab's reign.

I truly believe, my Beloved, that You
Raised up Jehu to destroy Ahab's crew,
And that idolatry and violence
Justified what went on in Jehu's tents.
Unless You limited the evil score
Upon the world and multiplied the rate
Of every good deed at the kitchen door,
The earth would soon melt down beneath
the hate.

And yet I point out, my Beloved, that all
Who wield the gored in hand come to
appall

With the disarming excuse that Your will
Is behind all their actions come to chill.
Both righteous kings and evil realize
They are wonderful before divine eyes.

12 He got up, left, and then he came
To Samaria. As his claim
Reached to the shearing house that way,

13 Jehu met the brothers of gay
Ahaziah king of Judah,
And asked them, "Who are you?" And they
Answered, "We are the brothers gay
Of Ahaziah, and we're going
Down to greet the children we're knowing
Of king and queen *there where they stay.*"
14 And he said "Take them all alive."
And they took them alive to drive
Them to the pit of shearing place,
And killed them there without a trace
All forty-two men, he did not
Leave one alive of those he got.

Forty-two royal martyrs of god Baal
Are thrown alive and dead in one dark pit.
I think of the opposite to avail
Of martyrs in the Wadi Natroun's grit
Beneath the fortress tower that's blessed
With graffiti of Ethiopic best
That no one in the monastery now
Can read at all. I took pictures somehow.
All those slain in the world are martyrs to
Some god or devil, to the wrong or true,
And all have their place in the pilgrimage
The line of humans take in sacrilege
Or in the hope of finding under dome
You at last since You were not found at
home.

15 When he had left that place he met
Jehonadab of Rechab set
As son coming to meet him there
And he greeted him for his share
Saying "Is your heart true as mine
Is with your heart without design?"
And Jehonadab answered, "Yes."
"If so, then give your hand, I guess."
And he gave him his hand and he
Pulled him into the chariot's fee.
16 And he said "Come with me and see
My zeal for YHWH." So they made free
To drive him in his chariot wee.

Jehonadab's a man I must admire,
One who does such feats to which I'd
aspire
With grave doubts. I once mounted chariot
Of an acquaintance. All things I forgot
Because they made impressions slight in
fear
Rise up once more in visions of my bier.

The man drove like a maniac ten miles
So quickly I could hardly rank my files
Reciting Al-Hamd only three times through
While he flicked past mountain and valley
too.

I could have warned Jehonadab not to
Step in the chariot of king Jehu.
Experience, Beloved, in derring do
Avoids the stepping on the crocodiles.

17 On coming to Samaria,
He killed all that were left he saw
Of Ahab, till he'd destroyed all
According to YHWH's word *and call*
That He spoke by Elijah's *pall*.

18 And Jehu summoned all the folk,
And told them saying as he spoke,
"Ahab served Baal a little, now
Jehu shall serve much anyhow.

19 "So call me all prophets of Baal,
All his servants and priests assail,
Let not be lacking, for I've got
A great sacrifice to the plot
Of Baal, and whoever is not
Here, he shall not live." But Jehu
Had his own cunning in his view
On purpose to destroy at once
Every Baal worshipper and dunce.

Deceit, deceit's the word, Beloved, I find
In Jehu and in what he had in mind.

Some are cunning as serpents, some like
doves

Remain in innocence and misplaced loves.

Beloved, I look in wonder at the way
Jehu was able to track down and bay
The prophets of Baal to destroy the lot.

I admire Jehu and his cunning plot.
Beloved, give me the sense to tell a lie
If I can throw down images thereby
And tip idolators into the sty.

Beloved, let me join in the church and song
Upon a day when it would not be wrong
To set fire to the whole destruction strong.

20 And Jehu said "Proclaim a great
And solemn gathering in state
In honour of Baal." So they did.

21 Jehu sent all Israel to bid,
And all the worshippers of Baal
Came till not one was left to sail.
And they came in the house of Baal,

Till it was filled from end to veil.

22 He told the keeper of the clothes,
"Bring out garments for all that chose
To worship Baal." And he brought out
The finest clothing thereabout.

23 Went Jehu and Jehonadab
The son esteemed of one Rechab,
Into the house of Baal and said
To the worshippers of Baal's head,
"Look out among you that there be
No worshipper of YHWH, but see
The servants of Baal only free."

There are three conditions I see of late
Permitting this action of terror's hate.
The first is king Jehu's divine mandate
(Although such can be had both soon and
late

By the imaginings of fools in state).
The second is the certainty the bomb
Will not hurt innocent folks singing Psalm.
The third is to be son of Rechabite,
The people who reject both dark and light
Drink drunk to find the fizzle and the
bright.

Only teetotallers have God-given right
To engage in terrorist act and fight.
Beloved, though I have all three reasons
here,

I shall commit no violence, I fear.

24 When they went in to sacrifice
And offer up burnt offerings nice,
Jehu set eighty men outside
And said "If anyone abide
Escaping from your hands of those
That I have brought, let his life close
For the life of the escaped rose."

25 It happened when he finished making
The burnt offering, Jehu was shaking
The guard and captains and he told
Them, "Go in, kill them all, be bold,
Let none come out." And they attacked
Them with the mouth of sword intact,
And the guard and captains threw out,
And went to the city in rout
Of the house of Baal without doubt.

26 They brought the idols from the house
Of Baal and burned them *not to dowse*.

27 They broke of Baal's idols and broke
Down Baal's temple and at a stroke
And made it a dump until now.

28 So Jehu destroyed Baal somehow
 Out from among Israelite folk.
 29 Yet the sins of Jeroboam
 The son of Nebat for a slam
 Against Israel in sin, Jehu
 Did not depart from them, in view
 The golden calves set in Bethel
 And set up there in Dan as well.

Beloved, did they not have a good excuse
 For the golden calves in the temple use?
 The temple in Jerusalem contained
 The ark with cherubim in gold unstained
 At each end with their wings outspread to
 shield
 Your presence in the shekinah's bright
 field.
 The golden calves where merely there to
 serve
 As the foundation of Your throne, not
 swerve
 Into idolatry. Do you not make
 Distinction for the golden cattle's sake?
 Indeed You do. The sin is not so much
 Idolatry as Baal and Ahab's touch.
 It is political expedience
 To keep the people from David's house'
 sense.

30 And YHWH said to Jehu, "Because
 You have done well following laws
 In my eyes and Ahab's house destroyed
 According as My heart employed,
 Your children shall sit on the throne
 Of Israel and shall there be known
 To four generations *enjoyed*."
 31 But Jehu did not take care to
 Act according to all the view
 Of the law of YHWH Alohim
 Of Israel with all his heart's dream,
 For he did not let go the sin
 Of Jeroboam who made sin
 Israel *with a cunning grin*.
 32 In those day YHWH began to cut
 Israel short, and Hazael butt
 Them all around Israel's land's *bin*.
 33 From Jordan eastward, all the land
 Of Gilead, the Gadites, and
 The Rebenites, the Nanassites,
 From Aroer by Arnon's lights
 And river, Gilead and Bashan.
 34 The rest of the acts of the man

Jehu, and all he did and all
 His strength, are they not written in
 The book of chronicles to win
 Of Israel's kings? 35 And Jehu slept
 With his fathers, and his tomb kept
 They in Samaria to stay.
 And Jehoahaz his son's sway
 Was over the land from that day.
 26 The time that Jehu reigned in all
 Samaria was to the call
 Of twenty-eight years. *That was all*.

The writer of this word thinks that the fall
 Of Israel's borders was not from the pall
 Of Hazael, but from the fact the calves
 Were in the house of prayer so that by
 halves
 The people worshipped You. Perhaps the
 view
 Is in the last analysis both true
 And relevant to me today as I
 Seek to be true to You, Beloved, though
 shy
 To worship in Bethel, Dan or the city
 Jerusalem, and more's to be the pity.
 Alone I stand before Your Sabbath throne
 To pledge obedience to You alone,
 As only my own family's to share
 The blessing of the cantillation there.

2 Kings 11

1 When Athaliah, mother of
 Ahaziah saw, *despite love*,
 That her son was deceased, she rose
 And destroyed all the royal beaux.
 2 But Jehosheba, daughter of
 King Joram, who was sister of
 Ahaziah, took Joash son
 Of Ahaziah, secret done,
 Away from among the king's sons
Who were being slain *at their runs*,
 And they hid him and his nurse too
 In the bedroom, from *the crazed stew*
 Of Athaliah, so that he
 Was not killed *at all*. 3 And so he
 Was hidden with her in the house
 Of YHWH for six years, *like a mouse*,
 While Athaliah ruled the land.

The palace intrigue as an institution
 Is just one more of kingship's contribution.
 Without the regicide there is no motive

For the intrigue at all, it's merely votive.
So those who blandly push for power's
plea

That without kings and presidents in fee
We all must die victim of anarchy
Are really saying they support the killing
Of kings and kings' sons, willing or
unwilling.

One cannot have the human power to rule
And expect things to spin out smooth as
spool.

The competition itself will create
The killing as well as the mutual hate.
Beloved, You are my only king and state.

4 The seventh year Jehoiada
Sent summoning centurions,
With captains and the guard in awe,
And brought them to him *with their guns*
Into the house of YHWH and made
A contract with them *renegade*,
And made them swear *silence and mum*
In the house of YHWH *to keep dumb*,
And showed them the king's son *had*
stayed.

5 And he commanded them and said
"This is the thing whereby you're led,
A third of you who enter in
On the Sabbath shall keep in bin
The watch on the palace royal,
6 "And a third of you at the gate
Of Sur, and a third stand in wait
At the gate behind the guard shall
Keep watch of the house and it be
Not broken down, *entered freely*.

7 "And two groups of all you that go
Out on the Sabbath, they shall show
Guard of the house of YHWH and yet
About wherever the king's met.

8 "And you must surround thus the king,
Every man with arrow on string,
And anyone that comes too close,
Let him be killed for such a dose,
And so be with the king when he
Goes out and comes in *faithfully*."

9 Centurions did all that he,
Jehoiada the priest made free
To command them, and they took each
Man his men that came within reach
On the Sabbath, with them that go
Out on the Sabbath, came to show
Jehoiada the priest *to know*.

10 The priest gave the centurions
King David's spears and shields in tons
That were in the temple of YHWH.
11 And the guard stood, every man armed
Around the king not to be harmed
From the right corner of the temple
To the left corner of the temple,
Along by the altar and temple.
12 And he brought out the king's son and
Put the crown on his head to stand
And gave him witness, and they made
Him king anointing him and stayed
To clap their hands and said a thing,
Saying again, "God save the king."

God save the king, they shouted on that
day
Of Sabbath and of rest pronounced at last;
Divine right of David's seed has not passed
South of the border; heaven still has its
way.

I see the joys the Sabbath holds in sway
Vibrate across the hearts and throats
amassed,
Eager before the temple for the glassed
Triumph to rise and walk, be where it may.
Heal my returns, Beloved, who saw the
power
Eating the mantle of the sacred tent,
Knowing the decadence of slacking rite.
I turn, Beloved, to You to buy the hour,
Nothing reserved from hope in silence
spent:
Grant me a glimpse of the king in his light.

13 When Athaliah heard the noise
Of the guard and people in joys,
She came to the folk in YHWH's house.
14 And when she looked about to grouse,
See, the king by a column stood,
As was the custom that he should,
And the princes and trumpeters
Stood by the king, and it appears
All the land's people there rejoiced,
And blew the trumpets as full-voiced,
And Athaliah tore her clothes,
And cried out, "Treason, treason's blows."

The treasures that Your Sabbaths would
bequeath,
Robbed of the tinder Athaliah yet
Escapes to find in temple with regret,

Abound despite her; silver bells still
 breathe.
 Sounds of the trumpets, shimmering to
 wreath
 Out from the stated column where is set
 None but boy king anointed without debt,
 Triggers the rage, makes wild mother's
 heart seethe.
 Recall my strategies as I retire,
 Evasive, yes, but ready as I put
 A period to willingness to concur.
 Some plans are best laid on the flashing
 pyre
 Outside the temple where unsacred foot
 Nears to the last, Beloved, what You
 prefer.

15 Jehoiada the priest commanded
 Centurions, officers handed,
 And told them "Bring her out between
 The rows and people and who's seen
 To follow her kill with the sword."
 For the priest said "All above board,
 Let her not be killed in YHWH's house."
 18 They laid hands on her *like a louse*,
 And she went by the way by which
 The horses came along the ditch
 To the king's house, there died a stitch.
 17 Jehoiada made covenant
 Between YHWH and the king present
 And the folk that they should be YHWH's
 Folk, and between the king in views
 Of all the people *in their pews*.
 18 And all the people of the land
 Went into Baal's house by command
 And broke it down, his altars and
 His images they broke by hand
 In pieces shattered, and they killed
 Mattan the priest of Baal well filled
 Before the altars. And the priest
 Appointed officers increased
 Over the house of YHWH released.
 19 And he took the centurions,
 And the captains and guard in tons,
 And all the people of the land,
 And they brought down the king in hand
 From the house of YHWH and they came
 By the way of the guard gate's claim
 To the house of the king. And he
 Sat on the kings' throne *faithfully*.
 20 All the folk in the land rejoiced,
 And the city still was unvoiced.

And they killed Athaliah there
 With the sword by the king's house *bare*.
 21 Jehoash was seven years old
 When he began to reign the fold.

Athaliah died in outrage and hate
 Towards the priest whose machinations
 found
 How to outwit her treason on the ground
 Against Judah; such women need no mate.
 Lacking both mate and sovereign of her
 state,
 I see her rushing to be crowned or bound
 Against priest crafts that forever resound,
 Have no mercy on a grandmother's pate.
 Softly I go, Beloved, to see the blood
 Drip down to wet the eager lips of earth
 Entranced to get a taste of royal share.
 Among the soldiers who join with the mud
 To rejoice, I still wonder at her worth:
 How can I at this age make my sword
 bare?

2 Kings 12

1 In the seventh year of Jehu
 Jehoash began his reign too,
 Forty years in Jerusalem
 He ruled. His mother's name and stem
 Was Zibiah of Beersheba.
 2 Jehoash acted in the awe
 Of YHWH all his days when the priest
 Jehoiada taught him policed.
 3 Yet the high places were not taken
 Away, the people'd not forsaken
 Sacrifice and burnt incense there
 In the high places *of the fair*.

There never was, it seems, society
 Where You're worshipped without
 idolatry.
 The rods are cast, the pillars set up tall,
 The groves well planted by the idol's wall,
 And every one comes to the hidden place
 To enjoy company of those who trace
 The scientific few that copulation
 Is fertility's only restoration.
 The act of love as worship's a disarming
 Rebuttal to refute me, it is charming.
 But I still say You have sent down no word
 That obedience to You is ever blurred.
 I'm still held responsible to the ten
 Commandments and I recite them again.

4 Jehoash told the priests, "The coin
Of all things dedicated join
To bring into YHWH's house, the money
Of everyone passing, the money
That everyone is set at, and
All the money without command
That comes into any man's heart
To bring into YHWH's house a part,
5 "Let the priests take it to themselves,
Every man of his own known elves,
And let them refurbish the house
Wherever there is hole of mouse."
6 But by the time the king had reigned
Twenty-three years they had not deigned,
The priests had not to finish all
The fixing the house to install.

The lesson should have been learned from
the time
This story was set down in word and
rhyme.
Anything that's entrusted to the priest
Is like to flounder in the bag at least.
More often more than flounder, one is
faced
With the dishonesty of priestly race.
This is exception. When Jehoash made
The rule the priests were honest and well-
paid
And could be trusted not to steal the rents.
It was inertia kept them in their tents
Instead of raising funds to fix the house.
All priests are merely nibblers, like a
mouse.
Beloved, give me no task with coin to
fetch,
It is enough I dig in broom and vetch.

7 Then king Jehoash called the priest
Jehoiada, and every priest,
And said to them, "Why don't you fix
The house wherein it needs the tricks?
Now then don't take money yourselves
Of your acquaintances or elves,
To bring it up to fix the house."
8 The priests consented to receive
No money at the hand and leave
Of the folk neither to repair
The breaches in the house as there.
9 But Jehoiada the priest took
A chest and bored a hole to look

In its lid and set it beside
The altar on the right abide
As one comes in the house of YHWH,
And the priests that kept the door put
In it all the money on foot
That was brought in the house of YHWH.
10 It happened when they saw that there
Was plenty of money to share
In the chest, then the king's scribe and
The high priest came up by command
And put it up in bags and counted
The money in YHWH's house amounted.

Just see, Beloved, how well things shape
up when
Responsibility is laid on men
Who have their own business and work to
do.
They take care of things better than they do
Who are established and paid for the task.
It's only those whose interest spoils the
mask
Are faithful to resort to getting done
What You intended for both work and fun.
Out with the priests! Out with the
president!
The way to do things properly well-spent
Is give it to the folk directly bound,
The people who keep their feet on the
ground
And do not have a vested interest in
The hidden black agendas of their sin.

11 They gave the counted money to
The ones who did the work in view
Of the house of YHWH, and they laid
It out to carpenters and paid
Builders that worked there all in crew
Upon the repaired house of YHWH.
12 And to the masons and stone cutters
To buy timber and hewed stone shutters
To fix the breaches in the house
Of YHWH, and for fixing the house.
13 But there were not made for the house
Of YHWH bowls of silver and such
Snuffers, basins, trumpets as much
Or any golden vessels or
Vessels of silver of the store
Of money brought into YHWH's house.
14 But they gave it all at the door
To the workmen fixing YHWH's house.
15 They did not check up on the men

Who gave the money out again
To the workmen, because they dealt
Faithfully *in all that they felt*.
16 The trespass and sin offering though
Was not brought to YHWH's house for
show,
It was the priests' own at a go.

I should not recommend this rate to keep
The records of the money in one's sleep.
The fact is in the time of Joash men
Were honest if corrupted by the den
Of the establishment, they still could work
On the said wages and forget to shirk.
Let me take my lesson from those who
were
The best of Your beloved who'd ever stir,
That money can be given into the hand
The honest workman under Your
command,
But even in the rare case that all men
Are lovers of Your truth they fail again
If set in institutions with fine names.
Let me learn, my Beloved, or take the
blames.

17 Hazael Syrian king went up
And fought against Gath like a tup
And took it, and Hazael set face
To go to Jerusalem's place.
18 Jehoash king of Judah took
All the sacred things from the nook
Of Jehoshaphat, Jehoram
And Ahaziah to a dram
As well as his own hallowed things,
And all the gold found in the wings
Of YHWH's house and the house of kings,
And sent it to Hazael the king
Of Syria, and he went away
From Jerusalem *for that pay*.

Gold is a wondrous thing, though of no
worth.

One cannot eat or drink it on the earth.
One cannot wear it nor does it make warm.
Of greater value are the bees in swarm.
And if it buys one's safety from the crook
And leaves one in peace to read in Your
book.

Beloved, give me the gold I need to buy
The freedom to live under Your fair sky.
And yet I feel the pang of those who've not

Got what it takes to turn tanks from their
plot.

The gold and oil found in the ground
attracts

The wicked rich to perpetrate their acts.
Beloved, the rich and poor both lower head
To escape the blades of the golden fed.

19 The rest of Joash's acts and
All that he did, *all at his hand*,
Are they not written in the book
Of chronicles that the kings took
In Judah? *Go and have a look*.
20 And his servants got up and made
Conspiracy and so waylaid
Joash in Millo's house when you
Go down to Silla *for the view*.
21 For Joazchar Shimeath's son,
And Jehozabad who was son
Of Shomer, his servants struck him
Down so he died, *and it was grim*.
They buried him with his own folk
In David's city at a stroke
And Amaziah his son reigned
In his place *for the throne he gained*.

To be a good king does not relieve one
Of the conspiracy of evil done.
An ordinary man sometimes can find
Agreement with the populace to bind
Him in his safety, since he does not try
To rule or steal the populace of rye.
But kings are always in the line of fire.
I contemplate them myself in my ire.
A righteous king like Joash is more like
Than wicked ones to get stuck on the pike.
Beloved, You should have intervened to
keep
Joash safe in his palace and his sleep
As well as in the house of Millo's field.
There's no explaining of the sword You
wield.

2 Kings 13

1 In the twenty-third year that reigned
Joash son of Ahaziah
King of Judah Jehoahaz
Son of Jehu started and deigned
To rule Israel in Samaria
For seventeen years *without jazz*.
2 He did the evil in the eyes
Of YHWH, and followed alibis

Of Jeroboam Nebat's son,
Who made Israel to sin *when done*,
He did not depart from that guise.
3 The wrath of YHWH enflamed and rose
Against Israel and so He chose
To give them over to the hand
Of Hazael and Syrian band,
And of Benhadad Hazael's son
All of their days *when once begun*.

The writer thinks You are the punishment
Behind every fight that comes to the tent,
Because kings of Israel did not relent,
But refused to worship in the place sent,
Jerusalem, for fear the people's hearts
Would stay in David's house and David's
carts.
Beloved, I seek the noble way today,
And though I've been in Quds and heard
the sway
Of Hebrew and of Arabic to gloss
The tongue in the old streets, I hear the
boss
And make my pilgrimage to the place
where
The prophet said to go, the place to share
According to Your Christ not in the mount
Nor yet in sweet Jerusalem's bright fount.

4 Jehoahaz prayed to YHWH and
YHWH listened to him, *understand*
He saw Israel's oppression, since
The Syrian king had made them wince.
5 YHWH sent a saviour to Israel,
So they escaped the Syrians' bell,
And Israel's folk lived in their tents
As they did before the offence.

You answer prayer, and yet the supposed
fault
That brought Your wrath leaves still room
for assault.
You sent a saviour, how many of those
Have You sent to the world in its death
throes
And how many have met those who appose
Your laws both in attacker and the bent
Ones who have formally come to present
Their vows to You to worship only You.
You sent a saviour in times false and true.
Beloved, I seek the saviour of all men
And find him hidden in the clouds again,

Unready to reveal a face apart,
Although I may reveal a loving heart
To those who hide their faith in Your own
den.

6 But still they did not depart from
The sins of house of Jeroboam,
Who made Israel sin, but instead
Acted according to that dread,
And there remained also the grove
In Samaria *for a trove*.

I've seen the groves. The Turkish Alevis
Come to the sweet groves and under the
trees
Hang up the little goats whose blood has
flowed,
To flay their skins off from the flesh in
mode
To cut the meat into the pots and play
The oboe and the drum for marriage gay.
I've seen the groves. Not every grove's a
sin.
I've heard the sweet music and hear the
din.
Sometimes the groves are made of trees
that spin
Their leaves and bark of marble and to win
The wealth of buildings fine above the sod.
Sometimes the groves are dwelling place
of God,
And sometimes places where in sensual
thrust
The hips gyrate to sounds of heathen dust.

7 Neither did He leave of the folk
To Jehoahaz but the stroke
Of fifty horsemen, chariots ten,
And ten thousand infantry men,
For Syria's king had made destruction
Like dust of threshing in reduction.
8 The rest of Jehoahaz' acts
And all he did in his contracts,
Are they not written in the book
Of chronicles to take a look
At Israel's kings *in their own nook*?
9 Jehoahaz slept with his dads,
And they buried him in the pads
Of Samaria, and Joash
His son reigned in his place *to clash*.

I'd think, Beloved, it was not punishment

To be left without army in event
 The army is a useless thing at best
 And costly when the people are at rest.
 Punish the world today, Beloved, and send
 Us an army for fifty to comment
 In cavalry, and only ten tanks that
 Support ten thousand soldiers where
 they're at,
 And that that army suffice for the world
 That in its present violence uncurled
 Goes on the impoverish every son
 Of every mother when the warring's done.
 Beloved, punish us fair as in the days
 Jehoahaz met Syrians in the blaze.

10 The thirty-seventh year Joash
 Was king of Judah, Jehoash
 The son of Jehoahaz started
 To reign over Israel charted
 In Samaria sixteen years.
 11 He did the evil it appears
 Before YHWH, he did not depart
 From all the sins come from the heart
 Of Jeroboam Nebat's son,
 Who made Israel to sin when done,
 But acted in comparison.
 12 The rest of Joash' acts and all
 He did and his power wherewithal
 He fought against Amaziah
 The king of Judah are in awe
 Written in the book of the times
 Of Israel's kings *and of their climes*.
 13 And Joash slept with his dads and
 Jeroboam sat on his stand,
 And Joash was buried with kings
 Of Israel in Samaritan rings.

Joash who reigned as Israel's king
 Was not like his namesake to sing
 Your praises in the temple taught
 Where Psalms arose and lambs were
 sought.
 Joash was just a wicked man
 Like those before him in the plan
 Of the kingdom of northern rate.
 He lived and reigned to spite his hate.
 Beloved, though I in different state
 Look back on the acts of such men
 Who held the scepter, here again
 Power tempts the soul to grant the ride
 To wealth and stealth and to abide.
 Beloved, Beloved, in You I hide.

14 Elisha fell sick with the matter
 From which he died. Joash the latter
 King of Israel come down and cried
 Over his face and said beside,
 "O my father, my father dear,
 Chariot of Israel and the steer."
 15 Elisha told him, "Take a bow
 And arrows" And he was not slow
 To take bow and arrows *for show*.
 16 And he said to Israel's king,
 "Put your hand on the bow and string."
 And he put his hand on it and
 Elisha laid hand on his hand.
 17 He told him, "Open toward the east
 The window." He did so at least.
 Then Elisha said "Shoot." And he
 Shot. And he said "the arrow free
 Of YHWH's salvation, and the arrow
 Of deliverance from the harrow
 Of Syria, for you'll attack
 The Syrians in Aphek on track
 Till you've destroyed *them front and back*.
 18 And he said "Take the arrows now."
 And he took them. He would allow
 The king of Israel, "Strike upon
 The ground." And he struck with his brawn
 Three times and then he stopped *and*
 stayed.
 19 The man of Alohim was mad
 At him and said "You should have made
 Five or six strikes, not it is sad,
 You would have attacked Syria
 Till you'd destroyed it with your paw,
 But now you'll only strike three times
 To *punish for so many crimes*."

Joash before Elisha's deathbed sought
 To comfort tears, but his face was not
 taught
 To hate the civilized and heathen plot,
 And so he only struck the ground a rate
 Of three, perhaps trinity was his fate.
 He should have struck the ground seven
 times at least
 Or better twelve as divine guides increased,
 And he might have established in that place
 Eternal kingdom for a holy race.
 The opportunity to do good fails,
 And You alone increase when good
 prevails,
 And limit the wrong to a pretty shore

To stop the evil knocking at the door.
Beloved, I come to strike before Your
grace.

20 Elisha died, they buried him.
And the bands of Moabites grim
Invaded the land at the turn
Of the year. 21 and they came to learn
As they were burying a man,
They saw a band coming as can,
And they threw the man in the grave
Of Elisha, and when the brave
Man was let down and touched the bones
Of Elisha, with shouts and groans
He came to life, stood on his feet.
22 But Hazael came to defeat
Israel, did the Syrian king
All days of Jehoahaz' ring.
23 But YHWH was gracious to them and
Had compassion on them at hand,
And respect for them because of
His covenant with Abraham,
Isaac and Jacob, and for love
Would not destroy them in the scam,
24 Then Hazael Syrian king died,
And Benhadad his son and side
Kick reigned in his place *satisfied*.
25 Jehoash Jehoahaz's son
Took back from Benhadad the son
Of Hazael the cities won
Back from Jehoahaz his dad
By war. Three times then Joash had
The victory and so he got
Back the cities in Israel's plot.

Though I have been thrown in the
prophet's grave,
And gained knew life, still I have been the
slave
Returning to the heathen dust that glows
Upon the hearth of civilized men's toes.
Yet You have been one full of grace to me
To send me out again for victory.
Beloved, I see the armies of the dead
In Palestine revealed before my head,
And how the train of happenings with
dread
Repeated on the hills and valleys spread.
Beloved, I see the armies wax and wane,
I see the days of peace, the days' refrain
Of battle and of slaughter and the gore.
I see the world turn and return once more.

2 Kings 14

1 In second year of Joash son
Jehoahaz Israel's king *done*
Reigned Amaziah who was son
Of Joash king of Judah's *bun*.
2 He was twenty-five years old when
He started to reign *over men*,
And he reigned twenty-nine years in
Jerusalem. His mother's kin
Were from Jerusalem, by clan
His mother was Jehoaddan.
3 He did the right in eyes of YHWH,
Yet not like David his dad true,
He did everything that his dad
Joash did, *both the good and bad*.
4 Still the high places were not swept
Away, and still the people kept
On them sacrifice and incense,
On the high places *for defense*.

No matter what good I may do below
The hills and fir trees and the pines on
show,
The fact remains the high places stand still
Upon the market squares and fit to kill.
The altar bears the mocking sacrifice
Of bread and wine and everything that's
nice.
The altar piece is painted with such skill
That the three die in agony of will
Upon the darkness of Golgotha's hill.
The rising sun above all this is writ
Across its face with a distortion fit
Of Your name stretched in Hebrew to
mean that
The sun still shines and shines well where
it sat.
Only the idol incense fails to grow.

5 It happened when the realm was firm
Beneath his hand, he killed like worm
The servants who had killed his dad
The king, *they had done something bad*.

I look about for throne and crown to make
Me ruthless in the ways I have in stake.
Vengeance is sweet, and sweet it is to be
A king so that one can take a hand free
With sword or else just give word of
command
And see heads roll along the bloody sand.

If anyone had killed my father I
Would have been glad to raise a hue and
cry.

But where I live such things are hardly
done.

The killer is placed in the storage bun
And kept a few years at best, then set loose
To kill again, unless he's learned his goose.
Beloved, the king is right, no doubt, to slay
The killers of his father in the way.

6 The murderers' children he did
Not kill because of the thing hid
In the book of Moses' law when
YHWH commanded saying to men,
"The fathers shall not die because
Of the children, nor children's paws
Be cut off for their fathers' sin,
But everyone shall suffer din
For what his own wickedness win."

Good man! He labours after my own heart
And after that of Your Christ for his part
Who also is a stickler for the art
Of following the Torah's horse and cart
Instead of Mercedes Benz and the row
Made by Rolls Royce and others anyhow.
Let me, Beloved, justify what I've done
Always by Your word read under the sun,
And let the light of day peer down and say
That I am right to do, to save or slay.
The Torah-true life is for man and king
And has a matter to prop everything.
Hardly a day goes by when I refer
To Torah's law for such things that occur.

7 He killed from Edom in the vale
Of salt ten thousand men in mail,
And took Selah by war and called
Its name Joktheel to this day *walled*.

8 Messengers Amaziah sent
To Jehoash Jehoahaz'
Son who was Jehu's son and bent
To be Israel's king with pizaz
Saying "Come, let us look each other
In the face *like brother to brother*."

9 Jehoash king of Israel sent
To Amaziah Judah's gent
Saying "Thistle in Lebanon
Sent to the Lebanese cedar
Saying 'Give your daughter anon
To my son as wife,' from afar

A wild beast there in Lebanon
Trod down the thistle *popular*.
10 "Because you won a victory
Over Edom, your heart goes free
In pride. Stop while you are ahead
And stay at home, why now be led
To meddle and get hurt and fall,
You and all Judah in the stall?"

11 But Amaziah would not listen.
So Jehoash king set to glisten
In Israel went up and he
And Amaziah king of free
Judah met fact to face in place
Of Bethshemesh which is the grace
Of Judah *for a plot and race*.
12 And Judah got the worst of it
Before Israel, and fled a bit
Each man to his own tent to sit.

I guess my understanding of the words
That ancient Hebrews used when they
threw turds

Is lacking. I'd not seen hostility
In Amaziah's way of speaking free
To Israel's Joash, but perhaps he meant
To call him out to battle and to tent
While he was on a roll of victory.
In any case Jehoash sent the ball
Back in his court to bounce it over wall.
Beloved, the clash of kings is never done
And nothing changes here beneath the sun.
Do not think I sent these rhymed darts to
You

To challenge in the wake of interview
With foes I've conquered before melting
dew.

13 And Jehoash Israel's king
Took Amaziah Judah's king
The son of Jehoash the son
Of Ahaziah when he won
At Bethshemesh and came up to
Jerusalem, and broke anew
The wall of Jerusalem too
From the gate of Ephraim up to
The corner gate four hundred arm
Lengths, *doing Jerusalem harm*.
14 He took all the silver and gold
And all the vessels that were told
In the house of YHWH, and in all
The treasures of the king's house stall,
And hostages and then went back

To Samaria *with the stack*.

15 The rest of Jehoash's acts
That he did and his power on facts,
And how he fought there Judah's king
Amaziah, do they not sing
In the book of chronicles well
Of the kings over Israel?

16 Jehoash slept with his ancestors,
Buried by Samaritan questers
With the kings of Israel, and then
Jeroboam his son for men
Reigned in his place *and in his den*.

Three things the victor did in ancient time
When he had joined the battle and the
clime

To open city gate and cast his spell.
The first thing he would do and do so well
Is break down half the wall, at least a
corner

Preventing their resistance back of horner.
The second thing is rob the palace and
The temple of its gold and ampersand.
The third is take some hostages as slaves
And leave the rest to wander toward their
graves.

The victor of today's another guy.
There are no walls to break down on the
sly.

But oil is more the reason for attack,
And gold is their to help in any slack.

17 And Joash Azaziah's son,
King of Judah, lived as he won
After the death of Jehoash
Son of Jehoahaz *to splash*
As king of Israel fifteen years.

18 The rest of Amaziah's acts,
Are they not written for contracts
In the book of the chronicles
Of Judah's kings *as miracles*?
19 They laid a plot against him in
Jerusalem. He fled his kin
To Lachish, but they followed him
To Lachish where they killed him *grim*.
They brought him back on horses' back
And he was buried in the sack
With his ancestors in the town
Of David, Jerusalem's *crown*.

21 And all of Judah's people took
Azariah, sixteen years old,
And made him king, those who forsook

His father Amaziah's *brook*.

22 He built Elath *as it is told*
And restored it to Judah's *fold*,
And after that the king slept with
His ancestors *and in their myth*.

I've seen the crystal water at Eilat
Filled with its coloured fish, vision for cat,
And swum about the shore and looked
abroad

To see the barren Arab hills of sod
And stone across the border. I have stood
Upon the mountainside to where I could
Clamber with joy towards a naked sky.
I thank You and the king for his good try
Restoring Eilat to Judean fold.

I look out on the Sabbath morning bold,
And visit Yemenite synagogue where
I find the kindness and sweetness to bear
The memories of centuries long past
In the bright voices that the young boys
cast.

23 In Amaziah's fifteenth year,
Who was the son of Joash' fear,
The king of Judah, came to reign
Jeroboam in the domain
Of Samaria, as the son
Of Joash king of Israel won,
For forty-one years *then was done*.

24 He did the evil in the eyes
Of YHWH, and he did not despise
All the sins of Jeroboam
The son of Nebat who like ram
Made Israel sin *by the calves' scam*.
25 He gained back all of Israel's lands
From Hamath's entrance to the sands
Of the sea of the plain, as taught
By the word of YHWH Alohim
Of Israel, the word He brought
By the hand of Jonah His trot,
The son of Amittai, prophet
From Gathhepher *when he was met*.

26 For YHWH saw Israel's oppression
Was very bitter, few with gun,
Poor and in want, nor was there found
A saviour anywhere around.

27 And YHWH said He would surely not
Blot out the name of Israel's plot
From under heaven, but He saved
Them by the hand of *the engraved*
Jeroboam son of Joash.

28 The rest of Jeroboam's acts,
 And all he did and his extracts,
 How he warred, how he overcame
 Damascus and Hamath of fame
 Which had belonged to Judah to
 Take to Israel's possession too,
 Are they not written in the book
 Of chronicles of kings in nook
 Of Israel? *Just take a look.*
 29 And Jeroboam slept along
 With his ancestors, with the *strong*
 Kings of Israel, and Zachariah
 His son reigned instead *of pariah*.

When evil befalls any nation that
 Has made a covenant and turned and spat,
 Your prophet says that evil's at Your hand,
 Because of the folk's sins in wicked band.
 And yet the king does evil here to stand
 In his namesake's beguiled and fashioned
 fate.
 And yet You do not turn upon his gate,
 But in Your mercy grant respite and wait
 To see enlargement of Israel's estate.
 The truth is not that evil is the score
 Of Your wrath only sitting at the door,
 Nor that You have mercy on whom You
 will.
 The truth is faith always can fit the bill.
 Do not see me a cynic on my sill.

2 Kings 15

1 Then in the twenty-seventh year
 Of Jeroboam Israel's peer,
 Azariah who was the son
 Of Amaziah started *fun*
Of reigning king of Judah *won*.
 2 Sixteen years old was he when he
 Began to reign, and he reigned free
 Fifty-two years in the city
 Jerusalem. His mother's name
 Was Jecholiah of the same
 Jerusalem, *city of fame*.
 3 He did the right in eyes of YHWH,
 All that he saw his father do,
 Amaziah, *true-hearted too*.
 4 But only that the high places
 Were not removed, for the races
 Of people sacrificed and burnt
 Incense still where they once had learnt
 On the high places *for their daces*.
 5 YHWH struck the king with leprosy

Till the day of his death, and he
 Lived in a house apart. And then
 Jotham the king's son judged the men
 Of the land over house and den.
 6 The rest of Azariah's acts
 And all he did, are they not facts
 Written down in the chronicles
 Of Judah's kings' conventicles?

No doubt in Your prophet's writing and
 view
 It was Your hand that rewarded the true
 Righteousness of Azariah's life too.
 And it was Your hand that struck the king
 down
 With leprosy, because he set no frown
 Upon the high places but let the folk
 Sacrifice and burn incense on the stoke.
 So faith perceives that every consequence
 Is the punishment or reward in pence
 Of what men do. I think that faith is weak
 To see reality upon the peak
 Of those who are both righteous and who
 share
 In suffering in a world of do and dare.
 The question's always one that human's
 speak.

7 So Azariah slept among
 His ancestors, and then they strung
 Him out in his ancestors' tomb
 In David's city, in his room
 Jotham his son reigned *without gloom*.
 8 The thirty-eighth year of the king
 Azariah of Judah's sting,
 Then Zachariah who was son
 Of Jeroboam joined the fun
 To reign over Israel in town
 Of Samaria, six month's crown.
 9 And he did evil in the eyes
 Of YHWH, by his ancestor's lies,
 Departing not for the sins of
 Jeroboam Nebat's son's glove,
 Who made Israel sin *though unwise*.
 10 And Shallum son of Jabesh plotted
 Against him and attacked him *spotted*
 Before the people, and killed him
 And reigned in his place. *He was grim*.
 11 The rest of Zachariah's acts,
 See they are written in contracts
 Of the book of chronicles of
 The kings of Israel above.

12 This was the word of YHWH that He
Spoke to Jehu saying, "To *three*
And four generations shall sit
Your sons on Israel's throne as fit."
And so it happened *and was lit*.

Sometimes Your prophet sees the events
swell
As by prophetic word that none can quell,
As though fate lay on every man and all
He might try to do could not weather
squall.

Punishment, fate and mercy all combine
To explain both the sweet and bitter wine,
While I in condescending view look down
On all the faithful and sinners in town.
Beloved, the fact is none of us can know
The why and wherefore of the ways things
go.

Philosophy leaves much to tail and toe,
And those thoughtful on earth are satisfied
With no explaining reason why they died.
The man did evil. But the omens tried.

13 Shallum son of Jabesh began
To reign in the year that was *scan*
Thirty-nine of Uzziah king
Of Judah, and he reigned *full swing*
Of a month in Samaria's *wing*.

14 For Menahem son of Gadi
Went up from Tirzah, and then he
Came to Samaria to strike
Shallum son of Jabesh *with spike*,

And killed him and reigned in his place.
15 The rest of Shallum's acts and race
And his conspiracy to face,
See, they're written down in the book
Of chronicles of Israel's crook.

The way to keep from being king, it seems,
Is to have assassin break in your dreams.
Assassination's not gone out of style,
Although the means have improved with
men's guile.

To be assassin's shortest way and trick
To become king, not democratic pick.
Inheriting the throne is dangerous
Unless the prince has learned of
blunderbuss.

Beloved, I seek no throne, and so I find
No reason to assassinate the kind

Of people who compete for what's not
theirs,
And people who're always putting on airs.
Instead I seek invisibly gold stairs
Toward celestial secrets out of mind.

16 Then Menahem attacked Tiphseh
And everything in it he saw,
And all the lands around up from
Tirzah, because they did not come
Out to him, so he attack all
With pregnant women to appall
He ripped up *killing in the stall*.

Each culture area has its own style
Of warfare actions to adjust the dial,
And in each place such acts are evident
And found inevitable in the bent
Of human constitution though they be
Unheard of in another place and fee.
Eurasians always rape the female sex
When they go out to battle and to vex.
The native culture of Americas
Rather raped men caught in their raiding
claws.

The ancient Middle East is so concerned
That war without splitting the pregnant
burned
Is not a war at all, that they would go
Out planning for the naked, avid show.

17 In year thirty-nine of the king
Azariah of Judah's sting
Menahem Gadi's son began
To reign over Israel *and fan*
Ten years in Samaria *by plan*.
18 And he did evil in the eyes
Of YHWH, he did not turn *his prize*
In all his days from the sins of
Jeroboam Nebat's son's *glove*
Who made Israel to sin *in guise*.

19 Then Pul the Assyrian king
Came up to the land's attacking,
And Menahem gave Pul a bag
Of one thousand pieces of *rag*
Silver, so he would then affirm
To him the kingdom *not to squirm*.
20 And Menahem taxed all the men
Of Israel, all the mighty men
Of wealth, from each man to account
Fifty silver shekels' amount,
To give to the Assyrian king.

So the Assyrian king turned back
And did not stay in the land's track.

Chilean hordes reveal the truth at last.
War's not inevitable thing that passed
For hope or wail in every land and time.
It's an effect of choices in the rhyme.
Fair trade between communities suffices
To stop war so as not to disturb prices.
It's barbarity alone in taking taxes,
Or greed to acquire other people's faxes
That allows wrathful excuses to win
And throw out peace with carrots in the
bin.
Beloved, I come to join You in Your perch
On high to observe people in the lurch.

21 The rest of Menahem's acts and
All that he did are writ by hand
In the book of the chronicles
Of the kings of Israel's *numskulls*.
22 Menahem slept with his ancestors,
And Pekahiah, no molestors,
His son reigned in his place *for nesters*.
23 The fiftieth year of the king
Azariah of Judah's spring
Pekahiah who was the son
Of Menahem began to run
Israel in Samaria and
Reigned there two years *as he had
planned*.
24 And he did evil in the eyes
Of YHWH, he did not leave the guise
Of Jeroboam's sins, the son
Of Nebat, who made Israel run
To sin. 25 But Pekah who was son
Of Remaliah, a chief *Hun*
Of his conspired against him and
Attacked him on Samarian *sand*
In the palace of the king's house,
With Argob and Arie'h's *grouse*,
And with him fifty men among
The Gileadites come *unstrung*
To kill him, and reigned in his place.
26 The rest of Pekahiah's acts,
And all he did *in his contracts*,
See, they are written in the book
Of Israel's kings' chronicles, *look*.

Pekahiah is an example of
The kind of king who inherited glove
And found assassins waiting in the wings

Of the stage that sets and deposes kings.
All that's irrelevant, I trow, to fact
The king was evil in the way to act.
It does not seem to make a difference
whether
The father keeps the son on righteous
tether
Or lets him run free in sins of his choice.
None listen to mom and dad's warning
voice.
The son of righteous king may be a bum.
The wicked king may bring forth one to
hum
Your praises with good deeds around the
earth.
Each king and man himself decides his
worth.

27 In the fifty-second year of
Azariah who was king of
Judah, Pekah who was the son
Of Remaliah went to run
Israel in Samarian *sun*,
And reigned there twenty years when done.
28 And he did evil in the eyes
Of YHWH, not learning to despise
The sins of Jeroboam son
Of Nebat, who made Israel run
To sin. 29 In the days of the king
Pekah of Israel came to sing
Tiglathpileser who was king
Of Assyria, and he took
Ijon as well as every nook
Of Abelbethmaachah, as well
As Janoah and Kedesh tell,
And Hazor and Gilead to keep,
And Galilee, for all to weep
In the country of Naphtali,
And took them captive on the fly
Into Assyria *to sweep*.
30 Hoshea son of Ela made
A plot against Pekah betrayed
The son of Remaliah and
Attacked him and killed him with band
And reigned in his place in the year
Twenty of Jotham son to fear
Of Uzziah *without a tear*.
31 The rest of Pekah's acts and all
He did, see, they are in the stall
Of the book of the chronicles
Of Israel's kings *for tentacles*.

One king takes back the cities lost and then
 As time goes on the empire finds new men
 To turn the tide and push the border back.
 I truly doubt, Beloved, the cause is lack
 Of love and obedience to You in one
 Case or the faithfulness by which was done
 The worship due to You instead of fun
 In grove of Baal and Ashtoreth. I doubt.
 It seems that folk push each other about
 According to the level of their strength.
 They did so then, they do so now at length
 Bombs are run by atomic force to make
 The enemy inside out crispy steak.
 At least in those days steak was rare a
 shake.

32 In the second year of Pekah
 Who was son of Remaliah
 The king of Israel, began
 Jotham son of Uzziah man
 To rule Judah. 33 Twenty-five years
 Old was he when despite his fears
 He started to rule, and he reigned
 Sixteen years in Jerusalem.
 And his mother's name undisdained
 Was Jerusha daughter of Zadok.
 34 And he did *with both pick and haddock*
 The right thing in YHWH's eyes, he did
 According to all that he bid,
 His father Uzziah *cool-brained*.
 35 But still the high places were not
 Removed, the fold sacrificed lot
 And burned incense in the high places.
 He built the higher gate for traces
 Of the house of YHWH *in its graces*.
 36 The rest of Jotham's acts and all
 That he did are they not withal
 Writ in the book of chronicles
 Of Judah's kings *like barnacles*?
 37 In those days YHWH began to send
 Against Judah Rezin to wend,
 The king of Syria as well
 As Pekah Remaliah's spell.
 38 And Jotham slept with his ancestors
 And was buried with his ancestors
 In the city of David who
 Was his ancestor, Ahaz too
 His son reigned in his place *and pew*.

I see the higher gates built up to hide
 The high place and the grove concealed
 inside

The church and churchly heart. The famous
 build
 The higher gates and with that stop-gap
 filled
 Content themselves they've done great
 deeds to make
 Humanity a better one and stake
 Their fortune on the profits of the wake.
 The sweet Christian fold's different from
 the one
 The Middle East produces on the run.
 The tripartite system's at Roman root
 And even Celt desires to lick the boot.
 Beloved, I break down my heart's higher
 gate
 Raze the high place, the grove annihilate,
 And find Your worship's not a culture.

2 Kings 16

1 The seventeenth year of Pekah
 Who was son of Remaliah,
 Ahaz the son of Jotham king
 Of Judah began to take wing.
 2 Twenty years old was Ahaz when
 He began to reign over men,
 And reigned sixteen years in the town
 Jerusalem, and to his crown
 Did the right in the eyes of YHWH
 His Alohim, like David too.
 3 And he acted like Israel's kings,
 Even made his son pass the stings
 Of fire by the abominations
 Of the heathen, whom YHWH from
 stations
 Expelled from before Israel's folk.
 4 He sacrificed and came to stoke
 Incense in the high places, and
 On the hills and *about the land*
 Under every green tree to *stand*.

The pagan sacrifice of the first-born
 In Molech's burning arms, from mother
 torn,
 Was considered by civilized estate
 Essential to success of farm and rate
 Of city. To neglect the sacrifice
 Of one soul for the nation would suffice
 To bring catastrophe on everyone.
 It was expedient to have the thing done.
 Today fathers still sacrifice a son
 To business, education or defense

As fighting's called. Not all killing's good
sense
Is focused on the first-born and the free.
Sometimes an execution's solvency
Is what saves people from catastrophe.

5 Then Rezin king of Syria
And Pekah of Remaliah
King of Israel came to *the town*
Jerusalem to war *with frown*,
And they besieged Ahaz but could
Not conquer him *for bad or good*.

Judah and Israel were supposed to seek
Your face alone on Sabbaths week to
week,
And face the world of pagan wealth and
power
To hold Your honour up to eyes an hour.
But what do I see here? Expected fate
Of brother against brother and the state
Cooperating with idolatry
To smash the other with velocity.
Beloved, I have not brother, and thanks be,
If that's the way a brother would treat me.
I'd rather take my fortified soul and see
Alone the world go by, and give my hand
To one in need rather in blood to stand
Pockets full of the Syrian contraband.

6 At that time Rezin Syria's king
Recovered Elath to the wing
Of Syria and drove out the Jews
From Elath, and the Syrians choose
To come to Elath and live there
Until this very day *a share*.

The Arab and the Jew share to this day
The town of Elath, the Arab holds sway
Upon the east, and on the western bay
The Jewish state sets up its verdant way.
The borderland between the two is caught
Up in the thread of quarrels that were
sought
In new markets, and not the troubled toil
Of Syrian in ancient times for oil.
When we learn to burn hydrogen, I guess,
Every country will be the prey and mess
The Middle East is today for address.
Beloved, I see the blue sky in reflection
Of the Red Sea beside the loud confection
Of the airport in the town of selection.

7 So Ahaz sent messengers to
Tiglathpileser who was due
King of Assyria to say
"I am your servant and in pay
Of you, come up and save me out
Of the power of the Syrian clout,
And out of the might of the king
Of Israel, risen to sting."

If Israel can pay Syria for a bit
Of armour and a fight among the fit,
Then Judah too can play that single game
And send Assyria payment for her shame.
Ahaz is wise as Israel in his part
To ally himself with Assyrian heart,
And be a servant instead of a king.
Exchange of wealth accomplishes the
thing.
Beloved, I send word to Your empire's
throne
To tell You that I have been left alone
To face the arms of church, factory and
state,
And so depend on You to turn my fate
From such submission to true Islam's rate,
Without Umayyad or Abbasid pate.

8 And Ahaz took silver and gold
Found in the house of YHWH and told
In the king's house's treasury
And sent a gift in hope to see
The king of Assyria *for fee*.

9 Assyrian king listened to him,
For the king of Assyria grim
Went off against Damascus' rim,
And took it and carried captive
To Kir, did not let Rezin live.
10 And king Ahaz went to Damascus
To meet Tiglathpileser's maskus
The king of Assyria and
Saw an altar that was at hand
In Damascus, and king Ahaz
Sent to Urijah priest he has
The pattern of the altar and
How it was made by craftsman's hand.

11 And Urijah the priest built all
The altar according to all
That king Ahaz had sent in call
From Damascus, and so he made
Urijah the priest while he stayed
Did king Ahaz in Damascus

Before he came up with the bus.

The strong distinction that today I'd make
Between the cult of YHWH and what's in
stake

In heathen cult is probably all wrong.

Ahaz took pattern from the Syrian song

And raised it in Jerusalem as strong

As in Damascus. I see even in

The wilderness tent Moses' came to win

With the Egyptian architecture and

Their taste in colours in alternate band

Of blue and red and purple every hand.

Beloved, You state in ten commandments
what

Is needed to fulfil the golden but.

The rest is the free choice of cultured mind

That sees beauty of form, colours in kind.

12 When the king came from Damascus,

The king saw the altar not worse,

And the king came near the place of

Sacrifice and offered *for love*.

13 He burnt his burnt offering and meat

Offering, and poured drink offering neat,

And sprinkled the blood of his peace

Offerings on the altar's release.

14 He also brought altar of brass

That was before YHWH from the grass

In front of the house, from between

The altar and YHWH's house as seen,

And put it on the north side of

The *new* altar of Ahaz' love.

15 And king Ahaz commanded then

Urijah the priest saying then,

"On the great altar burn the offering

At morning and evening meat proffering,

And the king's burnt sacrifice and

His meat offering, and for the land

The burnt offering of all the folk,

And their meat offering *at a stroke*

And their drink offerings and then take

And sprinkle on it all the stake

Of blood of the burnt offering and

The blood of sacrifices, and

The brass altar shall be for me

To enquire by *and privately*."

16 So Urijah the priest did as

Had commanded his king Ahaz.

17 And king Ahaz cut off the sides

Of the bases, removed the tides

Of the laver from them and took

Down the sea from the brass ox crook

That was under it and he put

It on a stone pavement *for foot*.

18 The Sabbath covered placed they'd built

And the king's entry outside stilt,

He turned outside the house of YHWH

On account of Assyrian crew.

19 The rest of Ahaz' acts which he

Did, are they not written in fee

In the book of chronicles set

For *all* the kings of Judah yet?

20 And Ahaz slept with his ancestors,

And was buried within sequesters

With his ancestors in the town

Of David, and then took the crown

Hezekiah his son instead,

So Judah was by a king led.

I see the oecumenical in place.

Ahaz made place of sacrifice and grace

Outside the sacred temple but in view

On the north side providing for the crew

Of the uncircumcised who battled for

The king Ahaz in strength to keep his store.

The wisdom of his choice is clear to see.

He could not bring heathen impurity

Into Your house, but he could bring the

prayer

Of Your house out to hear and stand there

where

The heathen was allowed. Beloved, I bring

Petition sacred to my soul and fling

My pearls before the swine and feel the

sting

Of trampling without sight or

knowledging.

2 Kings 17

1 In the twelfth year of Ahaz king

Of Judah Hoshea the son

Of Elah started out to bring

His rule over Samarian gun

In Israel to reign nine years.

2 And he did evil it appears

Before the eyes of YHWH, but not

As Israel's kings before his slot.

3 Against him rose up in attack

Shalmaneser king front and back

Assyrian, and Hoshea

Became his servant and in awe

Gave him presents, *tribute in paw*.

4 And the Assyrian king found out

Hoshea had plotted his rout,
 For he had sent messengers down
 To So king of Egyptian town,
 And brought no tribute to the king
 Of Assyria the which thing
 He had done year by year before.
 That's why Assyrian king in store
 Shut him up behind prison door.

Hoshea bought stock in Egyptian wear
 Which was a mistake for the spiteful care
 That Shalmaneser had to keep account
 Of his clients in dutiful amount.
 Hoshea's mistake was one of perception
 And not simply a matter of ineption.
 It's easy now to see Egypt's decline,
 But from Hoshea's slope that land was fine
 For centuries. The new stock come of late
 Is always seen as a risk from the state
 Of Wall Street. My Beloved, that's why I
 put
 Stock in trust in Your sacred name and foot
 Set on earth and invisible to those
 Who walk around in fashionable clothes.

5 And then king of Assyria
 Came up through all the land with claw
 And went up to Samaria,
 And besieged it for three years' time.
 6 In the ninth year of Hoshea
 The *dread* king of Assyria
 Took Samaria *in its prime*
 And carried Israel away
 Into Assyria *to play*,
 And put them in Halah and in
 Habor by river Gozan's bin,
 And in the cities of the Medes.
 7 The sin of Israel exceeds
 Against YHWH their Alohim, who
 Had brought them from Egyptian crew,
 From under the power of Pharaoh,
 King of Egypt, and they let go
 To fear other gods *in chapeau*,
 8 And acted by their pagan laws,
 Which heathen YHWH threw out like
 straws
 Before Israel's folk and the kings
 Of Israel, which they made *in strings*.
 9 And Israel's folk did secretly
 What was not right against YHWH, see,
 Their Alohim, and they built high
 Places in all their cities by

The watchmen's tower to fortified
 City *and every place beside*.
 10 They set up images and groves
 On every high hill *to dispose*
 And under every green tree's *rose*.
 11 And there they burnt incense in all
 The high places as by the call
 Of the heathen whom YHWH threw out
 Before them, and in wicked flout
 Provoked YHWH to anger about.

Political theory that's based on what
 Idols may be set up in temple shut
 Or in the open hill-top groves it seems
 Is just naïveté and stands on dreams.
 The truth is Hoshea made a mistake
 In trusting in Egypt and in its wake,
 And that's why Shalmaneser came to take
 The people all away in three years' shake.
 Causality and explanation fail,
 Beloved, beneath the overwhelming pale
 Of intervention by the divine guide,
 Of armies set aghast before the slide
 Of Your approach. I wait the true and find
 The glories of eternity in mind.

12 For they served idols, that's why
 YHWH
 Had said to them, "You shall not do
 This thing." 13 Yet YHWH had testified
 Against Israel and Judah's pride
 By all the prophets, all the seers,
 Saying "Turn from your evil fears,
 And keep My commandments and My
 Statutes according to the ply
 Of all the law I commanded
 Your fathers and which I would bid
 You by My servants, prophets *high*.
 14 And still they would not listen, but
 Hardened their necks like the necks shut
 Of their ancestors, who did not
 Believe YHWH their Alohim's *plot*.
 15 And they rejected His statutes,
 His covenant made with recruits
 Of their ancestors, His witness
 That He witnessed against their mess,
 And they followed vain idols and
 Became vain, and followed the band
 Of heathen round about their land
 Of whom YHWH had warned them not to
 Be like them in the things they do.

It's not so much attraction of the gods
And goddesses of Grecian temples' prods
That still attracts the human heart and
mind.

It's not so much the spirit and divined.
It's more the pull of what the neighbour
does

And what the neighbour has for fur and
claws.

The simian approach to everything
Is imitation of the neighbour's ring.
But from a spectator's view that seems
rough:

There's no function in fact for jewels on
muff.

It's monkeyish and crowish to be caught
In glitter of the neighbour's fancy lot.
Beloved, though sunken in the monkey
row,

I look to You, depart from glitter show.

16 They left all the commandments of
YHWH their Alohims and made love
To molten images, two calves,
And made a grove, worshipped by halves
All the stars of the sky and served
Baal *a false god and undeserved.*

Not only glitter seduces the paws
And eyes of humankind, rather than laws
Of idols on the waste of gold and stone.
There's something else that itches to the
bone.

The worship of idols is made to fit
The hormones of the simian lack of wit
To enjoy sex instead of time of rut
Each and every day one can crack a nut.
The sexy worship of Baal, Ashtoreth
Once penetrated every shibboleth
Of ancient Israel, and now it seems
To be the fount of what a Christian dreams,
Blessed by the music and the crowd and
sure

That what he feels is from a Spirit pure.

17 They caused their sons and daughters
too

To pass through the fire, used askew
Divination and enchantments,
And sold themselves of common sense
To do evil before the eyes
Of YHWH, provoking His reprise.

Glitter and sex are only two of three
Things that seduce pagan humanity
Dressed in a Christian fashion to be free.
The third is a successful life drawn on
The education of illicit dawn.
Israel once sacrificed the first-born child
In fiery arms of Molech and the wild
Din of contemporary Christian rock.
Now sacrifice is made upon the stock
Of sacrifice of all to gain success.
Nothing more can Creator give to bless.
The divination of the future comes
When the soul makes calculation of sums.
Beloved, I trust in You and fail to guess.

18 That's why YHWH was exceeding
wroth

With Israel and threw their broth
Out of His sight till none was left
But only Judah's tribe bereft.

19 Neither did Judah keep the law
From YHWH their Alohims's fair paw,
But acted like Israel *for straw.*

20 And YHWH rejected all the seed
Of Israel, and oppressed their creed,
And gave them up to spoilers' greed,
Till He had thrown them out before
His face *and so settled the score.*

21 He tore Israel from David's rule
And they made Jeroboam fool
The son of Nebat king and he,
Jeroboam drove Israel free
From following YHWH, made them sin
A very great and awful sin.

22 For Israel's folk acted by all
The sins of Jeroboam's fall
That he did, they did not depart
From them *not in deed nor in heart,*
23 Until YHWH cast Israel out from
Before His face *for rascaldom*
As stated by all His servants
The prophets. *For extravagance*
Israel was carried from their land
To Assyria where they stand
Until this day. 24 Assyrian king
Brought from Babylon and Cuthah,
And from Ava and from the *spring*
Of Hamath and from Sepharvaim,
And settled towns of Samaria,
And they lived in its cities' *clime.*

Effect of seduction of glitter and
 Sex and success is to fail in the land
 And be swept up before the rushing flood
 Of market, hardly noticing the blood
 Upon which the economy is built,
 The controlled violence of pick and stilt.
 So Israel was taken out to live
 In peaceful slumber that the idols give.
 Beloved, I turn away from haste and search
 To find the right cathedral and the church.
 I turn to You alone and take no god
 Or goddess from the singing of the rod.
 I bow in silence toward the marbled room
 That is reflected in my heart till doom.

25 As soon's they started living there,
 They did not fear YHWH for their share,
 So YHWH sent lions among them
 And they also killed some of them.

26 That's why they brought it to the king
 Of Assyria, and saying

"The nations you removed and placed
 In the towns of Samaria's waste
 Do not know how the land's God must
 Be worshiped, that's why *in disgust*
 He's sent lions among them and
 See they are killing them *at hand*
 Because they do not know how to
 Worship the God of the land due."

27 The king of Assyria commanded,
 Saying "Take there one of high-handed
 Priests that you brought from there and let
 Them go and live there to revet
 Them in the worship of the God
 Of the *said* land *and of its sod*."

28 Then one of the priests they had taken
 Away from Samaria forsaken
 Came and lived in Bethel and taught
 Them how to fear YHWH as they ought.
 29 Nevertheless each nation made
 Gods of their own and on parade
 Put them in houses of high places
 Which the Samaritans' disgraces
 Had made, each nation in the towns
 Wherever they lived *in their gowns*.

The lions that came out to eat the crowd
 Of people that replaced the folk allowed
 To be deported from the land were sent
 The prophet says by You in anger bent
 Because they did not honour You as god
 Of Israel's hills and rivers and its sod.

That explanation's heathen of its sort,
 The idea every land has god in sport
 That must be worshipped by the passing
 crew.

That faith was trounced by Abram and his
 few

Who traveled everywhere, but worship
 You.

Your prophet does not say if the plan
 worked

To bring a priest to help them in the
 quirked.

I doubt the prospect fits like a new shoe.

30 The men of Babylon then made
 Succothbenoth, the men waylaid
 From Cuth made Nergal and the men
 Of Hamath made Ashima's den,

31 And the Avites made Niblaz and
 Tartak, and the Sepharvites hand
 Was turned to burn their children in
 Fire to Adrammelech *in bin*

And Anammelech, who were gods
 Of the Sepharvaim *men and clods*.

32 So they feared YHWH and made
 themselves

Priests of high places lowest elves
 Who sacrificed for them disgraces
 In the houses of the high places.

33 They feared YHWH and served their
 own gods

According to the custom'd prods
 Of the nations whom they took out
 Away from there and on the route.

34 Unto this day they act by those
 Former customs *their fathers chose*,
 They do not fear YHWH, neither do
 They act according as is due
 By their statutes and ordinance,
 Or after the law's commandance
 That YHWH commanded Jacob's crew
 Whom He named Israel *to be true*,

35 With whom YHWH made a covenant,
 And charged them saying "Don't consent
 To worship other gods and bow
 Down to them to serve them, endow
 Them with sacrifices *and vow*.

Prophetic word here has appearance of
 Political explaining of the shove
 Between Jew and Samaritan that late
 Under the Persians came to divide rate.

The Persians invented the Jewish state
To balance out Samaritan with hate
And so to rule the land of Palestine
With cunning and with their own planned
design.

Far-reaching were the effects of the plan
The Persians made for woman, child and
man.

Diplomacy and not raw force is their
Best attribute, and they come out to share
The surface of the load of power, but bear
Their secrets in wise wonder and clear
care.

36 "But YHWH who brought you from the
land

Of Egypt with great power and hand
Stretched out, Him shall you fear and Him
Shall you worship, also to Him
Shall you bring sacrifices *trim*.

37 "And the statutes and ordinance,
And the law and its commandance,
Which He wrote for you, you shall keep
For ever and not come to weep
For other gods *in wicked heap*.

38 "And the covenant I have made
With you, you shall not leave waylaid,
Neither shall you worship at hand
Other gods *come from any land*.

39 But YHWH your Alohim you'll fear
And He shall save you from the gear
Of all your foes *when they appear*."

40 And yet they did not listen, they
Acted in just their former way.

41 So these nations feared YHWH and
served

Their graven images unswerved,
Both their children and children's sons,
As did their ancestors by tons,
So they do to this day. *It stuns*.

Though I was never brought out from the
state

Of Egypt, nor did I live under fate
Of slavery by the Nile, but only kept
A memory of kindly folk who wept
To meet and greet me by the pyramid,
Still I pray, My Beloved, that where You
hid

Your great salvation is a secret shown
To me also before Your righteous throne.
Beloved, let me not take Egyptian god

Nor any other on the famous sod
Of market and of temple sent from Rome
Or Babylon, Geneva, or the dome
Even of St. Paul's where the quire is thick
With beauty of sound and the oaken stick.

2 Kings 18

1 Now it came to pass in the third
Year of Hoshea son of *bird*
Elah king of Israel, the son
Of Ahaz who was king of Judah,
Hezekiah started to brood her.
2 Twenty-five years old was he when
He started to rule over men,
And he reigned twenty-nine years in
Jerusalem. His mother's *kin*
Name also was Abi, daughter
Of Zachariah *to infer*.

3 And he did what was right in eyes
Of YHWH, according to the guise
Of all that David his dad did.

4 He took away high place forbid
And broke the idols, cut down groves,
And broke in pieces what in troves
Moses had made, serpent of brass,
Since till those days Israel en masse
Had burnt incense to it, and he
Called it Nehushtan, *brazen scree*.

Hezekiah was a ruler who saw
Beyond the law of jungle, law of claw,
And broke down the high places and their
groves
Where people came to orgies in their
droves.

A king or president today like him
Would take a view of churches low and
dim
And smash them all to pieces, like as not,
Since that is where sex orgies still are
taught

With trap-set and with swaying arms and
hips.

Let me not take their name upon my lips.
He'd also break down banks because they
draw

Their usury called interest from the craw
Of everyone, and so cause violence
To fall on modern Israel and her tents.

5 He trusted in YHWH Alohim
Of Israel, after his scheme

There was none like him of all kings
 Of Judah, nor before *in springs*.
 6 Because he stuck to YHWH and did
 Not stop following Him, but hid
 In keeping His commandments which
 YHWH gave to Moses *without hitch*.
 7 And YHWH was with him and he won
 The victory in all he'd done,
 And he rebelled against the king
 Of Assyria, served not a *ping*.
 8 And he attacked the Philistines
 As far as Gaza and combines
 Of borders from its signal tower
 To the fortification's power.

King Hezekiah would not stand to be
 Subjected to a foreign king in fee,
 And so he rebelled from establishment
 The UN had accepted as the bent
 Way that officially one ought to go.
 He did not accept the Assyrian show.
 Unfortunately there were soldiers none
 The UN could send in to stop the fun.
 And so he attacked peaceful Philistine
 And then went home victorious to dine.
 Beloved, I should have lived in those days
 rare
 When politicians still knew what was fair,
 And when Your temple was raised in the
 air
 To celebrate Your worship once with care.

9 It happened in the fourth year of
 King Hezekiah, which above
 Was the seventh year of the son
 Of Elah king of Israel won,
 Hoshea, that Shalmaneser
 King of Assyria came to stir
 Against Samaria in blockade.
 10 At the end of three years they stayed
 To take it, then in the sixth year
 Of Hezekiah, to appear
 In the ninth year of Hoshea
 King of Israel, Samaria
 Was taken. 11 The Assyrian king
 Carried away Israel to sing
 In Assyria, and put them in
 Halah and in Habor in bin
 By the river of Gozan and
 In the cities of the Medes' *land*.
 12 Since they did not obey the voice
 Of YHWH their Alohim for choice,

But broke His covenant and all
 That Moses YHWH's servant in call
 Commanded, and would not listen
 And would not do those things *again*.

Success of Hezekiah seems to prove
 The theory that obedience to the groove
 Of Your law in breaking grove and high
 place,
 The heathen churches of a heathen race,
 Was the best weapon to establish throne
 And rulership over Judean groan.
 Perhaps the insight that gave the king right
 In his religion also improved sight
 In how to defend the kingdom and get
 Its independence from the power set.
 I too have here my temple where I come
 To inner chamber to worship and hum,
 But do not break down idols with my axes,
 Nor fail to give the Caesar all my taxes.

13 In the fourteenth year of the king
 Hezekiah Sennacherib
 King of Assyria to sting
 Came against the fortified jib
 Of all the towns of Judah and
 Took them, *every one in the land*.
 14 And Hezekiah king of Judah
 Sent to Assyrian king the feuder
 At Lachish, saying "I've offended,
 Back off from me, what you've intended
 I'll pay." And the Assyrian king
 Set tax on Hezekiah king
 Of Judah three hundred talents
 Of silver and thirty talents
 Of gold. 15 And Hezekiah gave
 Him all the silver in the cave
 Of YHWH's house and the treasures
 Of the king's house *as if to please*.
 16 Then Hezekiah cut the doors
 Of the temple of YHWH and scores
 Of the pillars which Hezekiah
 King of Judah had set up by her
 Overlay, and then gave it to
 The king of Assyria *as due*.

The time came when it was not enough to
 Cut down the groves and destroy high
 place crew
 In order to get safety from the brew
 Established in the world for false or true.
 So Hezekiah also had to pay

Taxes to be left alone in his sway.
 That is a comfort to me in my way
 Of failure to cut down the groves and stay
 Idolatrous flood of oppression's day
 In the state church and in the far worse
 play
 Of Pentecostal orgies that abound
 Wherever Christ is mention or is found.
 Beloved, forgive me that I pay my tax
 Supporting the established mics and macs.

17 And the king of Assyria sent
 Tartan and Rabaris and lent
 Rabshakeh from Lachish to king
 Hezekiah with a great wing
 To strike against Jerusalem.
 And they went up, came to the hem
 Of Jerusalem. And when they
 Had come up, they stood by the way
 Of the canal to the high pool,
 By the way of the fullers' field.
 18 When they to the king had appealed,
 There came out to them stocked and
 steeled

Eliakim son of Hilkiah,
 Who was over household and by her,
 And Shebna the scribe and Joah
 Son of Asaph, recording paw.
 19 And Rabshakeh said to them, "Speak
 Now to Hezekiah, he's weak,
 So says the great king, who is king
 Of Assyria, 'What faith you bring?
 20 "You speak vainly to have a plan
 And strength to battle as you can.
 In whom do you trust and rebel
 Against me, *think now and do tell?*
 21 "See now, you trust in the lone staff
 Of this bruised reed at which they laugh,
 In Egypt, on which if a man
 Leans, it will surely, spick and span,
 Go in his hand and pierce it through.
 So is Pharaoh of Egypt to
 All who trust him. 22 "But if you say
 To me, "We trust in YHWH today
 Our Alohim," is that not He
 Whose high places and altars' fee
 Hezekiah's taken away,
 And told Judah in all their sway,
 Jerusalem 'You'll worship here,
 Jerusalem's altar with fear?'"

Attackers of Jerusalem knew well

How to cast up theological spell
 And muddy waters and create the doubt
 That Hezekiah knew what he's about.
 The argument that he broke down Your
 churches
 And so left Your worshippers in their
 lurches
 Is just the argument sweet Christian now
 Will find to support heathen talk and
 plough.
 They call You by the name of Trinity
 And pretend all faiths are one to the free,
 And blind souls to Your law and to Your
 love
 When You refuse to work both hand in
 glove
 And in the name of idols in their glee.
 Beloved, though I'm alone, look down on
 me.

23 "Now then, I pray, give pledges to
 My lord the Assyrian king due,
 And I'll give you two thousand horse,
 If you can set riders in course.
 24 "How then will you turn back the face
 Of even one captain in chase
 Of the least of my master's men,
 And put your trust on Egypt then
 For chariots and for horsemen?
 25 "Have I now come to the attack
 Without YHWH's aid against the back
 Of this place to destroy it now?
 YHWH said to me 'Go up and plough
 This land to its destruction now.'"

Assyrian to the attack is now
 Ready to say that You held up his brow
 And brought destruction on Jerusalem
 By his hand in theological gem.
 He also bellows in pride at the state
 Comprised of so few who stand armed and
 wait.
 I too, Beloved, hear the same argument,
 That You back only those who enter tent
 Of Trinity, that blasphemous belief,
 Are protected by You from robbing thief.
 I also hear that numbers create truth,
 And since the band is small and without
 ruth
 That keeps Your ten commandments as
 they're writ,
 My faith is one to fail since it's not fit.

26 Then said Eliakim the son
 Of Holkiah and Shebna won,
 And Joah to Rabshakeh, "Speak
 Please to your servants in the reek
 Of Syrian language, for we know
 It and do not talk with the show
 Of the Jews' language in the ears
 Of the people that mind the tiers."
 27 But Rabshakeh said to them, "Did
 My master send me to the bid
 Of your master and to you here
 To speak these words? Should I appear
 To the men on the wall so they
 May eat their own shit and then stay
 To drink their own piss in your way?"

Beloved, speak now to Rabshekeh and
 those
 Who echo his message in refined prose,
 Where rhetoric hides the abysmal thought
 Of shit and piss for good doctrine that's
 brought
 On golden platters of the Christian church
 And even to the synagogue and perch
 Of Mulla, speak, Beloved, and show Your
 arm
 To protect the slight faithful from their
 harm,
 And lay a curse upon the furthest rung
 Of heathen rhetoric that has been sung
 In sensual lays and rhythms on the tongue
 Of priest and cantor, drumbeat flying fast,
 While the parishioners not to be last
 Wail and prevail to shake their hips
 halfmast.

28 Then Rabshakeh stood up and cried
 With a loud voice on the Jews' side
 And spoke in the Jews' tongue and said
 "Hear the word of the great king spread
 Over Assyria, be led.
 29 "So says the king, 'Do not believe
 Hezekiah, he'll not relieve
 You and save you out of his hand.
 30 "Neither let Hezekiah stand
 To make you trust in YHWH, and say
 "YHWH will deliver us today,
 And this town shall not under sway
 Of the king of Assyria."
 31 "Do not listen to Hezekiah,
 For so says the king and pariah

Of Assyria, 'Make with me
 A treaty by a present, see,
 And come out to me, and then eat
 Every man of his own vine's treat,
 And every one of his fig tree,
 And drink every one of the sea
 Of his own cisterns *at his feet*,
 32 "Until I come and I take you
 Away to a land like your view,
 A land of corn and wine and dew,
 A land of bread and vineyards too,
 A land of oil, olive and honey,
 Where you may live with house and money
 And not die, and take not heed now
 To Hezekiah when his brow
 Persuades you saying "YHWH will save."

The heathen church seduces on the hill
 Of Jerusalem, I can hear it still
 Calling men to the favourite water hole
 And lifting up the oil and gold in bowl.
 Wealth is enducement enough for the most
 Of men, both those submitting and who
 boast.
 Sex and cents bring the world to heal and
 bind
 All men in one faith and one heart to find
 Rebellion against You, against Your law
 In what is best to favour gun and claw.
 Beloved, I hear the ringing words and plot,
 I see the advertisement for the lot,
 And turn toward the gold of dawn to sing
 A single song to You, my Lord and King.

33 "Have any gods of nations down
 Saved their lands from beneath the frown
 Of the Assyrian king? 34 "Where are
 The gods of Hamath and *the star*
 Of Arpad? And where are the gods
 Of Sepharvaim, *flung to the clods*,
 Hena and Ivah? Did they come
 Deliver Samaria *and hum*?
 35 "What gods are their among all gods
 Of all countries that with their prods
 Saved their country out of my hand,
 That YHWH should deliver the land
 Jerusalem out of my hand?"
 36 But the people said not a word,
 They held their peace *as though not*
stirred,
 For the king's command was to say
 Nothing in answer to his *spray*.

37 Then came Eliakim the son
Of Hilkiah of the housedom,
And Shebna the scribe and Joah
The son of Asaph in whose paw
Was the recording, with clothes torn
To Hezekiah, told the *scorn*
Of Rabshakeh in what *he'd sworn*.

The argument is thrown out with both spite
And disdain for the faith I hold with might.
Have You saved me, Beloved, from
poverty
And pest and plague blown on humanity?
Have You put forth a hand against the rot
Of holocaust and genocide that's wrought
Destruction of those who have kept Your
word
And Sabbaths despite all and still
unspurred?

Beloved, the argument falls on my ears
And falls upon the waking of my fears,
And yet I meet the argument that springs
Eternally it seems from mouths of kings
With silence. And with silence I take wings
To find my refuge in You without tears.

2 Kings 19

1 It happened when king Hezekiah
Heard it, he tore his clothes to sigh it,
And dressed himself up in sackcloth,
And went into YHWH's house of *wrath*.

2 He sent Eliakim who was
Over the household and the claws
Of Shebna the scribe and the elders
Of the priests clothed in sackcloth felders
To prophet Isaiah the son
Of Amoz, *who was worth a ton*.

3 They told him, "So says Hezekiah,
'Today's a day of great pariah,
And of rebuke and blasphemy,
Because the time of birthing be,
And there's not strength to birth a flea.

4 "It may be YHWH your Alohim
Will hear all the words sans esteem
Of Rabshakeh Assyria's king
His master has sent with a thing
Of reproach to the living God,
And will reprove those words of clod
YHWH your Alohim has heard, so
Pray for the ones left in the show."

Beloved, I could pray Hezekiah's prayer.

Such words I hear from Christians
everywhere

As Rahshakeh proclaim upon the wall.
Such blasphemy I hear to greet Your call.
The reproach of the living God I hear
Is shouted from the pulpit loud and clear
Of every place where priest craft come to
stand

In paid positions in every green land,
Or in the cloistered, monkish rates that cost
So little to support celibates bossed.
Beloved, Your glory stands above the hate
That humans spread about the earth and
wait
For healing from Your wings of golden
state
To fall on heads of hair and balding pate.

5 King Hezekiah's servants came
To Isaiah, *prophet by name*.

6 And Isaiah said to them, "So
Shall you say to your master, 'So
Says the blest YHWH, "Don't be afraid
Of the words which you have heard laid
By the servants Assyrian king
Has sent to blaspheme Me *a thing*.
7 "See, I'll send upon him a blast,
And he will hear a rumour cast,
And will return to his own land,
And I will cause him not to stand
Before the sword in his own land."'"

Beloved, the words Isaiah brought still
bring

A comfort to the lonely heart and sting
Of blasphemy that builds the city streets
That I must walk to find my food and
treats.

I clutch the promise and believe the word
That casts out power of cursing like a turd
And re-enlivens me to faith I've heard
Since Sinai rang with the bells of Your
voice

And I in Israel made eternal choice.
Beloved, I wait fulfilling of the stroke,
And rejoice in the death-throes of the folk
Who curse me in polite response to my
Fostering Your commandments on the sly.
I hear already rumours for to croak.

8 And Rabshakeh returned and found
The king of Assyria bound

In battle against Libnah round,
 Though he had heard that he had gone
 Up from Lachish *before the dawn*.
 9 And when he heard say of the king
 Of Ethiopia a thing,
 And of Tirhakah, "See now he
 Has come out to fight against you,"
 He sent messengers back to see
 Hezekiah saying in view,
 10 "So you shall speak to Hezekiah
 King of Judah and all that's nigh her,
 Saying 'Let not your God in whom
 You trust deceive you of your doom,
 Saying "Jerusalem shall not
 Be delivered into the plot
 Of the king of Assyria."
 11 "See, you have heard and heard with
 awe
 What the kings of Assyria
 Have done to all lands by destroying
 Them wholly, shall you be enjoying
 Deliverance? 12 "Have nations' gods
 Delivered them from any prods
 Of my ancestors destroying,
 As Gozen, Haran, and the spring
 Of Rezech, and folk of Eden
 Who were in Thelasar like men?
 13 "Where is the king of Hamath and
 The king of Arpad, and the land
 Of the king of Sepharvaim's town,
 Of Hena and Ivah *for crown? "*

Look, my Beloved! Even when You have
 thwarted
 The wizardly way of the hog-toed, warted,
 And sent the king off packing with his
 wares,
 He still raises the tumult of his dares.
 His words are lost on me as mine on those
 Who in rebellion have come here and
 chose
 To defy You in Your oneness and tried
 To make of You a triad to confide
 Like every heathen rate, like those who
 mind
 No Sabbath but the sun's day and designed
 To support the imperial in state
 And raise the arm and favour of the great.
 Beloved, I rant to see the stubborn rate
 Of those who rush into the fiery fate.

14 And Hezekiah got the brief

From the messengers in relief
 And read it. Hezekiah went
 Up to YHWH's house and spread the sent
 Before YHWH. 15 Hezekiah prayed
 Before YHWH and said where he stayed,
 "O YHWH Israel's Alohim, who
 Stays between cherubim in crew,
 You are the Alohim and You
 Alone, of all kingdoms of earth,
 And You have made both heaven and
 earth.
 16 "YHWH, bow down Your ear now, and
 hear,
 Open, YHWH, Your eyes, see and hear
 The words Sennacherib has sent
 The living God reproach to vent.
 17 "Truly, YHWH, the Assyrian kings
 Have destroyed nations and their things.
 18 "They have thrown their idols in fire,
 For they were not gods to desire,
 But the work of men's hands, and wood
 And stone, that's why destruction could.
 19 "So that's why, YHWH our Alohim,
 I pray to You, save from the scheme
 Of his hand, so all earthly kings
 May know that You above all things
 Are YHWH Alohim, only You.
To You alone worship is due "

Let me, Beloved, join once more in the
 prayer
 Of Hezekiah, who in temple bare
 Bowed down before You, spreading out the
 brief
 Of blasphemy and praying for the chief.
 May all men know. Beloved, that You
 alone
 Are worthy of worship who sit on throne
 Of universe above both tide of time
 And place, above both prose and craven
 rhyme.
 I pray to You alone, Beloved, though I
 May be the only one left under sky.
 I care not for the numbers of the great,
 I care not for establishments of state
 And church and mosque and synagogue, I
 rate
 All but as trash before Your grand
 mandate.

20 Isaiah the son of Amoz
 Sent to Hezekiah what shows,

Saying "So says YHWH Alohim
Of Israel, 'What you would deem
To pray to Me against the king
Sennacherib of Assyria,
I've truly listened to the thing.'

21 "This is the thing that YHWH for awe
Has spoken about him: 'Virgin
Daughter of Zion despised your skin,
Laughed you to scorn, the daughter of
Jerusalem shakes head *and glove*.

22 "Whom have you reproached and
blasphemed?

Against whom have you cast and beamed
Your voice and lifted up your eyes
Up high? Against the holy rise
Of Israel. 23 "By messenger

Have you reproached the Lord to stir
Saying 'With crowds of chariots
I have come up the mountain lots,
To the sides of Lebanon, and
Will cut down the tall and the grand
Cedar trees from it and the choice
Fir trees from it, and I'll rejoice
To enter in his borders' place,
The forest of his Carmel's grace.

24 "I've dug and drunk strange waters and
With the sole of my feet I've fanned
Dry all the rivers of the manned.'

25 "Have you not heard how long ago
I accomplished *great things of woe*,
And formed it all in ancient time?

Now I have brought to pass *the crime*
That you should be here to lay waste
Fortified cities *for a taste*.

26 "That's why their people lacked the
power,

Dismayed and confounded an hour,
They were like the grass of the field,
And as the green herb without yield,
The grass on the housetops to wilt
Before the wind *and the wind's silt*.

27 "Yet I know where you're coming from,
Your advance and your retreat's sum
And your rage against Me *like bum*.

28 "Because your rage against Me and
Your tumult has come up to stand
In My ears, therefore I'll put hook
In your nose and bridle to brook
Your lips and I will turn you back
In the way you came up to track.

29 "And this shall be a sign to you,
You'll eat this year such things as grew

Of themselves, in the second year
The same such things as so appear,
And in the third year you shall sow
And reap and plant vineyards to grow
And eat the fruit of what *you know*.
30 "What has escaped of Judah's house
Shall once again take root and spouse,
And bear fruit upward once to grow.

Did You, Beloved, promise by the hand
sent

Of Your prophet to hear the prayer that
rent

The heart of Hezekiah at the sight
Of blasphemy to shadow all that's right?
Indeed, if You promised to hear that
prayer,

I beg of You to enter in the dare
Also petitions that I raise to You
Against the modern rack and heathen crew.
Beloved, I raise a tender voice and true
To the support of Your law which the few
Maintain as it reads in the clutter word.
I raise a voice and grasp the promise stirred
To Hezekiah as I rant and rave
That such be sent forever to the grave.

31 "Out of Jerusalem shall go
A remnant, and those who escape
Out of the mountain fortress shape
Up in the zeal of YHWH agape."

32 "Therefore so says YHWH of the king
Of Assyria, 'He'll not bring
Himself to this city, nor shoot
An arrow there, neither shall boot
Or his shield come, not throw a mound
Of earthworks against it on ground.

33 "By the way which he comes, he'll go
Back and shall not enter the row,'
Says YHWH. 34 'For I'll defend this town
To save it for My own renown,
And for my servant David's sake.'"

Beloved, Your servant David raised a voice
So broad and unflinching, the church of
choice

That even sings his Psalms will not rejoice
In the curses he lays on pagan stone
When he accepts that You are God alone.
A remnant, yes, a remnant let me see
Marching beneath the banners flowing free

Emblazoned with the words of Your law
 given
 And taking those words of Yours for to
 live in.
 Beloved, I hope above the tattered loss
 That is Christendom with its hopeless cross
 That You will step down once more and
 return
 The remnant of obedience to learn
 That You are God alone, all else is dross.

35 It happened that night that came out
 The angel of YHWH, put to rout
 The camp of the Assyrians
 And killed as many in their cans
 As hundred eighty-five thousand,
 So when they got up dawn at hand,
 See, all dead bodies *on the sand*.
 36 Sennacherib Assyrian king
 Turned back and left and then took wing
 Back to live by Nineveh's *spring*.
 37 It happened as he bowed before
 Nisroch his god in temple store,
 That Adrammelech and Sharezer
 His sons attacked and killed the geezer
 With a sword, and they both escaped
 Into Armenia's land well graped.
 And Esarhaddon his son reigned
 In his place *since he was unfaned*.

I have a task for You, Beloved, tonight
 And for Your angels as they're kept from
 sight.
 The camp of the Assyrian is still
 Around the hope of Zion and its hill.
 The churches may be empty and the till
 Of Pentecostal fervor lost in fog,
 But there is still a lot cast out to dog.
 The grand establishments throughout the
 earth
 That pretend to Your service for their
 worth
 Are waiting for an angel hand in dearth
 To uproot them and cast them in the ditch.
 My fever and my zeal have reached a pitch.
 Beloved, send angels now upon the town
 And restore to Yourself the golden crown.

2 Kings 20

1 In those times Hezekiah fell
 Ill like to die. And come to tell
 Him was the prophet Isaiah

The son of Amoz, with éclat
 Said to him, "So says YHWH, 'Set now
 Your house in order, and your brow,
 For you'll die, not live *anyhow*.'" 2
 Then he turned his face to the wall,
 And prayed to YHWH, began to bawl,
 3 "I pray You, YHWH, remember now
 How I have acted by Your face
 In truth and with a perfect race
 Of heart and have done good before
 Your eyes." Hezekiah wept sore.

Who would not act as Hezekiah did
 When he prayed that where his darling life
 hid
 Might be spared the stroke that attends
 each man
 That breathes on earth? There are but few
 who can
 Accept with equanimity the span
 Of life provided in this dark world's poke
 And not beg for a moment more at least
 To finish up repentance more increased.
 Beloved, I do not look askance at him,
 Nor do I think his prayer and actions dim.
 Instead I mind how he tore down the
 groves
 And flattened the high places of their
 stoves
 And altars whereon children met their fate.
 I do not despise Hezekiah's pate.

4 It happened, before Isaiah
 Had gone out to the middle draw,
 That word came from YHWH to him
 saying
 5 "Turn back and tell the man who's
 praying,
 And Hezekiah captain of
 The people I uphold and love,
 'So says YHWH, the Alohim of
 David your ancestor, 'I've heard
 Your prayer and seen your tears up-stirred,
 See I will heal you, on the third
 Day you shall go up to the house
 Of YHWH whole and well as a grouse.
 6 "And I will add unto your days
 Fifteen years, and I will upraise
 You and this city from the hand
 Of the Assyrian king and band,
 And I will defend this town for
 My own sake and upon the score

Of My servant David before.””””

Hezekiah I think jumped from the pan
Into the flames, courageous, fearless man.
It's one thing to know one is dying now,
Another to know fifteen years in trow
Separate the soul from its death in row.
The fact is secretly the soul declines
To believe less than twenty years in fines
Are left to breathe on earth, and so the
whines

Of only fifteen years prey on one's days
Like cattle set out to pasture to graze.
Beloved, You do not realize how we
Who are mortal view our mortality.
You sit upon the throne forever fit
And never have to wonder without wit.

7 Isaiah said “Now take a lump
Of figs.” And they took off a stump
And laid it on the boil and he
Recovered from his illness' spree.

Folk remedies were known in ancient times
And are still valid now in other climes.
I'd think it might be better now sometimes
To place a fig upon the boil instead
Of rushing to the doctor to be fed.
Folk remedies are life along the way,
The fig, the date, the olive oil, the ray
Of charcoal, egg and grape juice, all give
life.

The doctor is the last resort in strife
Before the body gives up and retires
Into the grave when every soul expires.
Beloved, I take Your folk cures and be
done

With quacks that try to get my money won,
And so I live and enjoy the warm sun.

8 And Hezekiah said unto
Isaiah, “What sign shall accrue
That YHWH will heal me, and that I
Shall go up to YHWH's house to spy
On the third day? *Now show me why.*”

9 Isaiah said “This sign shall you
Have from YHWH, and the thing that
YHWH

Will do He has spoken. Now say
Shall the sundial go in the way
Forward ten degrees or go back
The same amount and be in lack?”

10 And Hezekiah answered well,
“It is an easy thing to spell

For the shadow to pass on by
Ten more degrees, no let it fly
Back on its path ten steps *or try.*”

11 And Isaiah the prophet cried
To YHWH and He brought it to bide,
The shadow stepped back ten degrees
By which it had gone down to freeze
On the dial of Ahaz' *decrees.*

I'd hate to be a prophet, Beloved, when
The people and the kings of Your own men
Cry for a sign and miracle to show
That You are there to bless what I may
know.

And yet I do know something from the
days

That I have contemplated You in praise,
A moment of reprieve from the dark haze
That covers the soul and mind in illusion
And leaves humanity in stark confusion.
I bide the time and let the signs remain
In Your hand and upon the brightened
plain

Where ride the lark to dive again in song
Along the righteous meadows without
wrong.

Beloved, more than signs I would remain
sane.

12 At that time Berodachbaladan
Babylon's king, son of Baladan,
Sent letters and a present to
Hezekiah, because he knew
Hezekiah was sick a few.

13 And Hezekiah received them,
And showed them all things in his hem,
The precious things in his house and
The silver and the gold in hand,
The spices and fine ointment store,
And the house of all his armour,
And everything in his treasure,
There was nothing in his house sure
Nor in all his domain, that he,
Hezekiah failed to let see.

14 And Isaiah the prophet came
To king Hezekiah in blame
And said to him, “What did these men
Say? And where did they come from
then?”

And Hezekiah said “They came

From a far country, Babylon.”
 15 And he said “What have they begun
 To see in your house and for fun?”
 And Hezekiah answered spun,
 “Everything in my house they’ve seen,
 There’s nothing of my treasures keen
 That I did not show on the scene.”
 16 Isaiah said to Hezekiah,
 “Hear the word of YHWH in pariah.
 17 ““See the days come when everything
 In your house and ancestor king
 Had laid in store up to this day
 Shall all be carried once away
 To Babylon, till nothing’s left,’
 Says YHWH. And so you’ll be bereft.
 18 “Of your sons that you beget now
 Shall be carried before the plough
 To be eunuchs of the king won
 In palaces of Babylon.””
 19 Then said Hezekiah unto
 Isaiah, “Good’s the word of YHWH
 That you have spoken.” And he said
 “Is it not good if peace be led
 And truth in all the days I’m fed?”
 20 The rest of Hezekiah’s acts
 And all his power and his contracts
 To make a pool and canal to
 Bring water in the city’s lieu,
 Are they not written in the book
 Of chronicles, just take a look,
 Of Judah’s kings *and not a few?*
 21 And Hezekiah went to sleep
 With his ancestors’ watch to keep,
 And Manasseh his son instead
 Reigned *and he also reigned for dread.*

See now, Beloved, results of what You did
 Revealing to the king what should be hid.
 No man should know the day of his own
 death
 While he still labours under weight of
 breath.
 Now Hezekiah’s learned to meet his days
 With knowledge and with everlasting
 praise.
 It is not natural for man to know
 That his is not eternity in show.
 King Hezekiah’s satisfied to grow
 Fifteen years and then let the kingdom go
 In fires of catastrophic mael and rope.
 He is a man no longer lives in hope.

With knowledge, my Beloved, You destroy
 that
 Hope that makes a human of democrat.

2 Kings 21

1 Manasseh was twelve years old when
 He began to reign, and like hen
 Reigned fifty-five years in the town
 Jerusalem. His mother’s crown
 Was Hephzibah. 2 And he did that
 Which was evil from where he sat
 Before the eyes of YHWH, and by
 Abominations of the sly
 Heathen whom YHWH threw out before
 The folk of Israel *at the door.*

King Hezekiah died at fifty-four
 Having reigned just nine years over a score
 And did what’s right more than all those
 before
 Or after, and yet had to beg for life
 Aged thirty-nine when You had put the
 knife
 To his throat. My Beloved, You are a bore
 To let evil Manasseh reign one more
 Year longer than the whole life of the just
 King Hezekiah, man who bit the dust.
 You are unjust, Beloved, unjust, I say
 To have put Hezekiah on his way
 And let Manasseh reign. I’ve seen as much
 In other rulers. Evil gets the touch,
 While righteousness runs afoul of Your
 clutch.

3 For he rebuilt up the high places
 That Hezekiah in his graces
 His father had destroyed, and he
 Raised up altars for Baal to see
 And made a grove as did the king
 Ahab of Israel on the wing
 And worshipped all the starry host
 And served them, *and such was his boast.*

If You did not want those high places built
 You might have thought before giving the
 jilt
 To Hezekiah. If the people come
 To worship Baal and Ashtoreth and hum
 Hymns to the stars, let You take of the
 blame.
 It stands here to Your everlasting shame.
 If You care not a whit that idols stand

And prosper even in the holy land,
Then You've no right to judge the humans
lax
Who turn away their eyes as well as backs
And let the heathen range go on as free
Under the tolerance of ear and e'e.
Am I the only voice raised up to sell
Manasseh's idol and throw them in hell?

4 And he built altars in YHWH's house
Of which YHWH said to *man and spouse*
"Jerusalem is where I'll put
My name to *see on hand and foot*."

5 And he built altars for the stars
Of heaven in the two courts of *bars*
In the *very* house *built* for YHWH.
5 He made his son pass through the fire
And observed times, and did admire
Enchantments, and dealt in the calling
Of some familiar spirits stalling,
And wizards, and he did much wrong
Before the eyes of YHWH for strong
Provoking him to wrath appalling.

I'd like to see Your brash appalling wrath.
All I see's how the heathen in their path
Increase in wealth and in oppressing of
The poor and righteous whom You say
You love.

Get Your arse off the throne and do a job
In wetting and controlling of the mob.
Familiar spirits still whisper and peek
And all the world has wizards where they
seek

To know the future dictated by stars,
But few remember in their fancy cars,
Observing rather times of luck and fate,
The populace bows to the rich and great,
And leaves Your worship in the humble
dust

Where I find all Your glories gone to rust.

7 And he set up a graven image
Of the grove that he made in scrimmage
In the house of which YHWH had said
To David and to his son fed
Solomon, "In this house and in
Jerusalem I've chosen bin
Out of all Israel's tribes where I
Will put my name for ever, aye.
8 "Neither will I set Israel's feet
Again out of place in retreat,

From land I gave their fathers if
Only they will obey, be stiff
To observe all that I command
Them and according to the law
That my servant Moses in paw
Brought them, *yes, by all of that law.*"

An image set up in Your sacred house!
Such wickedness was never done by mouse
Or rat upon the stink hill in the yard.
Truly Manasseh is a king ill-starred,
Since stars are what he worships, and the
sun

Of Baal and mother Ashtoreth when done.
Mother earth herself as an idol set
Must vomit out the drivel that we get
Inherited from Manasseh's last word
Destroying everything his father heard.
Beloved, methinks You've gone and left
the lot
To their own evil, and have found a spot
Where You can be in peace enjoying rest
While without guidance humans still
invest.

9 But they did not listen and still
Manasseh enticed them to swill,
To do more evil than the nations
Whom YHWH destroyed before the
stations

Of Israel's folk. 10 And so YHWH spoke
By His servants the prophets' yoke,
Saying 11 "Because Manasseh king
Of Judah has done wicked thing,

Abominations above all
The Amorites did on the ball
Before him, and has made to sin
Judah also with idols' din,
12 "Therefore, so says YHWH Alohim
Of Israel, 'See, now I deem

To bring such evil on the town
Jerusalem and with a frown
On Judah, that whoever hears
Of it shall tingle in his ears.

13 "And I'll stretch on Jerusalem
The line of Samaritan hem,
And the plummet of Ahab's house,
And I will wipe Jerusalem

As one wipes off a dish to douse,
Wiping it and turning on hem.

14 "And I'll forsake the remnant left
Of My inheritance bereft

And give them up into the hand
Of their foes, and they'll be a band
In prey and spoil to all their foes,
15 "Because they've done what evil *chose*
In My eyes, and provoked to wrath
Since the day of their fathers' path
Out of Egypt to this day's *close*."

Truly the raw in heathendom is not
As evil as the people who have got
The divine guidance that they never sought
And so rejected without even thought.
The one who once saw light and turned
away

Is dazzled in the darkness from the day,
While he who sits forever in the dark
Sees something of the shadows of the park
And lets his feet go sweetly to the mark.
Beloved, I keep my eye upon the light
That guides me to the good and to the
right,
As I know that the clinging of the flame
Blinds with greater illusion and with
blame,
And with its light impression fails the
night.

16 Besides that Manasseh had shed
Very much innocent blood bled,
Till he had filled Jerusalem
From end to end *for requiem*
Besides the sin by which he made
Judah to sin and in parade
Doing evil before the eyes
Of YHWH. 17 Now the rest of the acts
Of Manasseh, all his contracts,
And his sin that he sinned, are they
Not written in the book and way
Of kings chronicled in Judah?
18 Manasseh slept with his ancestors,
And was buried in the sequesters
Of his own house, in Uzza's garden,
And Amon his son *without pardon*
Reigned in his place, *one of his besters*.

Note this, Beloved, idolatry is free
To corner love in a monopoly
And call sex and good feeling the right
way

To true religion for the keen and sway
Of lips and hips and fellowship to pray,
But when it raises love above the bold

Obedience to Your law, it is cold
To any who in faith look up to You.
Such heathen love, for all its pleasant view
Learns best to shed blood of the good and
true.

Love is the source of holocaust, that's why
Such genocide recurs under the sky.
One searches for the cause in human hate
And misses the true culprit for the bait.

19 Amon was twenty-two years old
When he began to reign as bold,
And he reigned two years in the town
Jerusalem *without a frown*.
And his mother *who caught her breath*
Had for a name Meshullemeth.
She was the daughter of Haruz,
Of Jotbah, *Amon's mother was*.
20 And he did evil in the eyes
Of YHWH, and by his father's guise,
As Mannasseh did, *both unwise*.

21 He acted in every way as
His father had before his jazz,
And served the idols that had served
His father, and worshipped unswerved.
22 And he forsook YHWH Alohim
Of his ancestors as a dream,
And did not walk in YHWH's esteem.
23 The servants of Amon conspired
Against him and killed the *bemired*
King in his own house *it transpired*.
24 The people of the land killed all
Of those who had come to make fall
King Amon, and the people of
The land made Josiah *in love*
His son king in his place *above*.
25 The rest of the acts Amon did,
Are they not written and on bid
In the book of the chronicles
Of the kings of Judah *in lulls*?
26 And he was buried in his tomb
In Uzza's garden from his doom,
Josiah his son took his room.

King Amon was a pea in a pod with
His own dad, and the story's not a myth.
They both did evil at the temple door
To worship what was not a god and more,
And yet they both pretended on that score
To worship You, Beloved, whose throne
was set
Behind the idol that their vision met.

By turning in the right direction they
 Were sure that they would get from You
 their pay.
 The many temples that grace earth today
 Are filled with Your thrones and the idols'
 sway,
 And many think they worship You astray.
 Beloved, lead me from heathen paths
 away,
 From white and black as well as from the
 grey.

2 Kings 22

1 Josiah was eight years old when
 He began to reign and he then
 Reigned thirty-one years in the town
 Jerusalem. His mother's gown
 Held the name Jedidah, her path
 Was from Adaiah of Boscath.
 2 And he did right before the eyes
 Of YHWH and walked in all the guise
 Of David his ancestor and
 Did not turn aside to right hand
 Nor to the left *but made a stand*.

See here, Beloved, both father and his dad
 Had always done only what things were
 bad,

But when Josiah sat upon the throne
 He turned his heart to You and You alone.
 It is not education hits the mark,
 It is not the genetic glowing spark,
 It is not anything beyond the choice
 Of every soul to rise beyond the voice
 Of the environment as well as heart
 To obey You and play the noble part.
 Beloved, I wonder at the loving lad
 Who had the courage that Josiah had.

3 It happened in the eighteenth year
 Of king Josiah, he sent gear
 To Shaphan son of Azaliah,
 The son of Meshullam to cry a
 Scribe to the house of YHWH, saying,
 4 "Go up to Hilkiah high priest
 That he may count without delaying
 The silver brought to house of YHWH
 That keepers of the door in view
 Have gathered from the people due.

5 "And let them give it in the hand
 Of the workers who in their band
 Have oversight of house of YHWH,

And let them give it to the ones
 Who do the work and rush their buns
 In the house of YHWH to repair
 The house of breaches that are there.
 6 "To carpenters, and builders and
 To masons and to buy in hand
 Timber and cut stone to repair
 The house *of YHWH and make it fair.*"

How is it that the hope of every king
 Who loves You above all must take a fling
 At building You a temple or if not
 The building then repairing of the lot?
 The temple's just one more place where
 men can

Come to blaspheme Your name by deed
 and plan

As well as word. Beloved, I see the rate
 Of money poured into the building late
 Sent out again repeatedly to state
 Human desire to build in honour's way
 Until the night unfold and take the day.
 Beloved, the hand of man is never tired
 Of doing either for honour inspired
 Or for the shamefulness of the conspired.

7 But there was no need of account
 Of the money in what amount
 Was given in their hand because
 They dealt with honesty *of paws*.

The way that Christians work today's so
 full

Of accounting the thing's a miracle,
 Perhaps the only true in signs of late
 Since people do not speak in tongues to
 rate

Nor heal their brothers fallen from the roof
 Or window once asleep after the goof
 Of sermon much too long. They don't
 preach those

Either now that worship's in finer clothes.
 But what I meant to say, Beloved, is that
 It is unusual to find holy fat
 Not in the fire but in the storage vat.
 I'm down to faith so grassroots in my way
 That I need neither money for the pay,
 But only get up from my bed to pray.

8 And Hilkiah the high priest said
 To Shaphan the scribe, "I was led
 To find the book of the law in

The house of YHWH.” And to begin
 Hilkiah gave Shaphan the book,
 And so Shaphan then took a look.
 9 Shaphan the scribe came to the king
 And brought the king again the thing
 And said “You servants gathered up
 The money delivered in cup
 In the hand of the one’s who work
 And have oversight without shirk
 In the house of YHWH *for a kirk.*”
 10 And Shaphan the scribe showed the
 king
 Saying “Hilkiah priest a thing
 Deliver up to me, a book.”
 And Shaphan read it at a look
 Before *Josiah who was king.*

Notice, Beloved, that reading of the book
 Was specialty of scribe and priestly crook
 And king could not decipher what it said
 But had to depend on what the scribe read.
 I thank You that in this dark evil time
 I have the right to write the book in rhyme
 And read it in square Hebrew at a glance
 As well as join in kingly, priestly dance.
 The book is hidden in my dusty heart
 All broken down, needing repairer’s art,
 And found each morning as I wake and
 start
 To read forgotten words and love their lay.
 Beloved, I take them with me on my way
 Through thoroughfares of noon and
 brighter day.

11 It happened when the king had heard
 The words of the law book, *was stirred*
 And tore his clothes *for what he heard.*

When I hear the words of the sacred book
 Read in the strains of Hebrew in my nook
 And wafted by the rays of morning sun,
 I too often find that my soul’s undone.
 I do not rend my clothes, my wife would
 say
 A word against a faith so run away,
 But I suppose the king had servant that
 Sewed up his garments when broken by
 fat.
 It makes me think of Ahmed whom his
 wife
 Said in his domestic and homely life
 The prophet did what all men do alone

With wife, that is take needle, steel or bone
 To mend his clothes and shoes, not sit on
 throne.
 Beloved, I read and watch, I sing and
 groan.

12 And the king commanded Hilkiah
 The priest and Ahikam the son
 Of Shaphan, Achbor of Michaiah
 A son, and Shaphan the scribe and
 Asahiah from servant band
 Of the king saying out of hand,
 13 “Go and enquire of YHWH for me,
 And for the people of degree
 Of all Judah, about the words
 Of this book that was found, the girds
 OF YHWH’s wrath are great against us
 Because our ancestors’ mad fuss
 Not to listen to this book’s words
 To do according to all that
 Is written about where we sat.”

How wise is this Josiah who was king
 To send to enquire of You for the thing
 That was of life and death. He knew the
 way
 Of generations had led all astray,
 But did not try to defend priest or gore,
 But bowed in sure repentance at Your
 door.
 It’s rare that You find clients with their
 staff
 Waiting in waiting room, indeed I laugh
 To realize the king of Universe
 Has plenty of time to read all my verse
 Since the division of humans who come
 To worship You is very small in sum.
 Others are bowing down to baals while
 bird
 Voice makes up most choirs where Your
 praise is heard.

14 So Hilkiah the priest as well
 As Ahikam and Achbor fell
 With Shaphan and Asahiah
 To go to prophetess Huldah
 The wife of Shallum of Tikvah
 The son, the son of Harhas who
 Was keeper of the wardrobe too,
 And she lived in Jerusalem
 In the college and by the hem
 Of the second quarter, and they

Spoke with her *on that very day*.

They went to Huldah to enquire of You
No doubt because just then prophets were
few

Of the male sort, and I will tell You why.
I've also seen churches come on the sly
And ordain women to the pulpit's seat.
It's always when priestly power's in retreat
That women get that chance. Position that
Holds true power's always one where men
have sat.

And so when kings went in apostasy
The status fell in all Your prophecy
And women filled the vacuum that came
out

When men no longer sought prophetic
clout.

But Huldah is a great name in my mind,
A woman prophet living with the blind.

15 And she said to them, "So says YHWH
Alohim of Israelite crew,

'Tell the man that sent you to me,
16 "So says YHWH *speaking faithfully*,

'See, I will bring destruction on
The place and its dwellers of dawn,
All the things in the book the king
Of Judah's read, *yes, everything*.

17 "Because they have forsaken me,
And burned incense to other gods,
Provoking My anger with prods
Of all the works of their hands done,
That's why My anger has begun
To flame against this place and it
Shall not be quenched, *not by a fit*.'"

18 "But to the king of Judah who
Sent you to enquire now of YHWH,
So shall you say to him, 'So YHWH
Alohim of Israel says to

You, "The words that you heard are true,

19 "But because your heart was in view
And you have humbled yourself here
Before YHWH, when it hit your ear
What I spoke against this place and
Against the dwellers in the land,
That they should be desolate, cursed,
And have torn your clothes and have burst
In tears before Me, I have heard
You also," says YHWH *now He's stirred*.

20 "So see that's why I'll gather you
To your ancestors and from view

In the grave in peace and your eyes
Shall not see all the bad demise
That I will bring upon this place.'"

They brought the thing to the king's face.

Not even the repentance of the king
Could now save Judah from destroying
wing,

But only put the moment off in grace
Because Josiah humbly sought Your face.
Beloved, I too live in a wicked place
That holds Your commandments in such
disdain

That few think of their words, they think in
vain

Who do remember them upon the pain
Of catechetical camps now on the wane.
The light of truth burns in the temple yet
Which is the heart of many people set
In quiet homes, invisible to me,
But bright and loving to Your eye to see.
I wait the day when You'll gather the met.

2 Kings 23

1 The king summoned the people and
They gathered to him like the sand
All the elders of Judah and
Jerusalem. 2 And the king went
Up to the house of YHWH and sent
All the men of Judah and all
Those living in Jerusalem
With him, and the priests from their stall
And the prophets and people all,
Both small and great, and then he read
In their hearing all the words spread
Out in the book of covenant
That was found in YHWH's house *and
tent*.

3 The king stood by a pillar and
Made covenant before YHWH's hand
To follow YHWH's every command
And His testimonies as well
As His statutes *to Israel*
With all the heart and all the soul,
To do the words set out in goal
Written in this book. All the folk
Stood to the covenant *he spoke*.

4 The king commanded Hilkiah
The high priest and priests in the draw
Of second order, and door keepers,
To bring out of YHWH's temple sleepers
All the vessels once made for Baal,

And for the grove and for the trail
Of heavenly hosts, and these he burned
Outside Jerusalem unearned
In the fields of Kidron and then
Brought their ash to Bethel again.

I stand and look towards Kidron from the
way
Of the great city and recall the day
That they brought out the vessels sacred to
The god and goddess to burn in the view
Of the folk who still in their heart of hearts
Could not relinquish idolatrous arts.
Beloved, the smoke of the fire still goes up
Towards the dome of blue, the drinking
cup
And vessels that caught human blood to
make
The fields and wombs fertile and for Your
sake.
Today there be those still who think the
blood
Of human sacrifice poured out in flood
Establishes the church and state and all
Things that grow and that prosper in the
stall.

5 He put down idolatrous priest
Whom the kings of Judah increased
To burn incense in the high places
In Judah's cities *for disgraces*,
And in the places round about
Jerusalem *with din and shout*,
Those also who burned such incense
To Baal, the sun, the moon, immense
Planets, to all the heavenly host.
6 And he brought out the grove to boast
From YHWH's house and out of the town
Jerusalem, to brook Kidron,
And burned it at the brook Kidron,
And trampled it to powder and
Threw the powder upon the graves
Of the folk *who were idols' slaves*.
He plundered the holy whores' homes,
Male prostitutes in catacombs,
Set by the house of YHWH, and where
Women wove hangings to repair
To the grove. 8 He brought every priest
Out of Judah's towns and released
Defilement upon the high places
Where the priests had burned incense
traces,

From Geba to Beersheba and
Broke down the high places that stand
In the gates at the coming in
Of the gate of Joshua *thin*
Governor of the city which
Were on the town gate's left-hand *ditch*.

Just think, Beloved, the warehouses were
found
Upon the temple walls and all around
The altars that Solomon had set up
To be to Your honour in drinking cup.
Belief that human sex in tenderness
Brings crops and prosperity in the mess
Of chaos on earth springs deep in the mind
Of human beings thinking they're not blind
To scientific explanation of
The universe and justice and of love.
Such pseudoscience reigns where priests
now fill
The temples with the sensuous din and
thrill
Of sacred music made to fit the bill
Of sacred fornication rising still.

9 However the high places' priests
Did not come up to altar's feasts
Of YHWH in Jerusalem, they
Ate yeastless bread in their own way.
10 He defiled Topheth in the vale
Of Hinnom's children to avail
That no one might make his son pass
Or daughter either through morass
Of fire to Molech, *burnt like grass*.
11 He took away the horses that
The kings of Judah gave out flat
To the sun at the entrance of
The house of YHWH and just above
The chamber of Nathanmelech
The chamberlain at call and beck,
And burned the sun's chariots with fire.
12 The altars on top of the spire
Of Ahaz which the kings of Judah
Had made as well as altars cruder
Which Manasseh set in both courts
Of the house of YHWH for his sports
The king beat down and broke them too
And threw their dust out and to strew
In the brook Kidron *like the dew*.

Even horse offerings to the sun are found
In the great city once to You clear bound.

It seems that every form of blasphemy
Was brought into the temple there to see
The place where once ark of testimony
Sat enthroned by Your presence under
cloud.

All things at last were adopted, allowed,
As later in loved Mecca where the stone
Walls of the Kaaba sounded with the groan
Of every idol known to humankind.
It's in Your very house men are most blind.
Beloved, grant me the purity of faith
That does not bow to stone or gold or
wraith,
But worships with both pure heart and pure
mind.

13 And the high places there before
Jerusalem, there right in store
Of the mount of corruption which
Solomon Israel's king did stitch
For Ashtoreth abomination
Of the Zidonian creation,
And for Chemosh abomination
Of Moabites and for Milcom
Abomination of Ammon,
The king defiled *before first dawn*.
14 He broke completely idol stand,
And cut down the groves from the land
And filled their places with the bones
Of men *who once had worshipped stones*.

The friendship of David and Solomon
With Hiram king of Tyre's where was
begun
Affection for Ashtoreth and the sight
Of Baal as a god of the sun and might.
The economic bloom that pact once made
In ships and cedar trees, gold on parade
Was not worth the effect on faith and deed
That accompanied the market in seed.
Trade in goods is foundation of world
peace
Without war and without the gross increase
Of violence, and yet with trade there comes
Communication of gods and their hums.
Beloved, I buy the wheat and flour and
meat,
But leave the idol in its foreign seat.

15 The altar that was at Bethel,
And the high place which was as well
From Jeroboam Nebat's son,

Who made Israel to sin a ton,
Both that altar and the high place
He broke up and burned without trace,
And trampled it to powder dust
And burned the grove *down to a crust*.
16 As Josiah turned round he saw
The sepulchres in the mount's claw,
And sent and took the bones out from
The sepulchres and burned them some
Upon the altar and defiled
It, according to YHWH's word wild
That the man of Alohim spoke
Who proclaimed these words *at a stroke*.
17 He said "What mound is that I see?"
And the men of the city said
"The grave of the man of God dead,
Who came from Judah and proclaimed
These things that you have done unblamed
Against Bethel's altar *enflamed*."
18 So he said "Leave that one alone,
Let no man move or touch a bone."
So they let his bones there alone
With the bones of the prophet who
Came out of Samaria *true*.

The prophet who was disobedient
To Your Word and came back to eat when
sent
And drink with Your own righteous man
who lied
And turned his hospitality aside
Is honoured now after all these years spent
In his disgrace. He knew what Your words
meant.
Touch not the grave of prophets nor
destroy,
But leave such graves for others to enjoy.
They are reminders that Your word is fast
To purify the hearth and bring at last
The soul to You in judgement for reward,
While those who do not pray there meet
Your sword.
Beloved, I've stood beside the prophet's
grave
And learned again that I'm only Your
slave.

19 And all the houses also of
The high places that were above
In the towns of Samaria,
Which the kings of Israel to draw
Had made provoking wrathful fate,

Josiah took away with hate
And did to them according to
All the actions he would accrue
In Bethel, *so the word was true.*
20 And he killed every high place priest
Upon the altars and increased
Defilement burning men's bones there,
Then went to Jerusalem's care.

Josiah killed the lovely priests that made
Oblations in the high places and paid
Attention to the sensitive and meet,
The civilized tastes that raised to a treat
The poetry and thought that grew up in
A world of chaos turned to scale and fin.
The pagan thought that organized the dross
Of Your creation ended once in loss.
The sweet and tender lives that boldly met
Your fragmented creation with a set
Of axioms and laws to understand
Went down the drain at Josiah's command.
The intricate and complex ways to see
The world by art sank from Reality.

21 And the king commanded the folk
All saying "Keep Passover's stroke
To YHWH your Alohim as writ
In the book of covenant fit."
22 Surely there was not observed such
A Passover from the days' touch
Of the judges of Israel,
Nor in all the days of the fell
Kings of Israel nor of the kings
Of Judah *for such wondered things.*
23 But in the eighteenth year of king
Josiah this Passover ring
Came to YHWH in Jerusalem.

Passover that Josiah made that week
Once long ago Jerusalem had peek
Of pageant and of prayer, thanksgiving
meek
In memory of the one time You came
To interfere with government to blame.
Though all of history is just one blast
Of evil against those who came to last
In Your command and mercy, still that one
Day when You sent angel to kill the son
Of president and prime minister still
Resounds not only on the sacred hill
Jerusalem, but also in my heart

That prays You might once again do Your
part.

24 Besides all those with stratagem
Having familiar spirits and
The wizards and the idols grand
And pillars and vain things they found
In the land of Judah and round
Jerusalem, Josiah put
Away and out and under foot
So he might act by the words of
The law written in book above
That Hilkiah the priest had found
In the house of YHWH *on the ground.*

I too have stoned pillars that represent
The Satan gods that used to mind the tent
Of people in the Middle Eastern vent.
Like good Josiah, I have lifted hand
Against idolatry upon the sand
Of the desert in far Arabia
And stood to smite down sin with stone
and awe.

Beloved, I too have read the golden law
In the book found by the priest Hilkiah
And cast my vote and lot among the poor
Who look to no other thing here as sure
Except Your word and Your command. I
wait
The welcome of Your open heart and gate.

25 Like him there was no other king
That turned to YHWH with everything,
His heart and soul and all his might
To do all Moses' law for right,
Neither came after him the like,
Only kings like Alibi Ike.

26 Yet YHWH did not turn away from
The fierceness of His great wrath come
Against Judah because of all
The provocations that the call
Of Manasseh had stirred withal.

Why did you not let Judah stay and live
A righteous witness in front of the sieve
Of human empires without ever flagging
From Your law and Your blessing of their
bragging?

If I had been You, my Beloved, I would
Have made the kingdom of Josiah good
For two millennia and then bring more
Kings of the like and set them up a score.

Beloved, Your ways are secret and design
Of righteousness is hidden by the vine
Of the deceit of human righteousness
And the ways of government that I guess
Were made in hell but get the right impress
Of justice in looks if not in address.

27 And YHWH said "I'll remove Judah
Also out of my sight and paw
As I've removed Israel, and will
Throw off this town into the swill,
Jerusalem the one I chose,
And the house of which I suppose
I said "My name's set where it grows."
28 So the rest of Josiah's acts
And all he did *in cataracts*,
Are they not written in the book
Of chronicles of the kings, *look*,
Of Judah? 29 Pharaoh Nechoh king
Of Egypt went up *on the wing*
In his days to attack the king
Of Assyria to the flood
Of Euphrates, and king Josiah
Went up to battle *and pariah*.
He killed him at Megiddo when
He had seen him there *with his men*.
30 His servants brought him dead up from
Megiddo in a chariot's *hum*,
Took him into Jerusalem
And buried him *with diadem*
In his own grave. And the land's folk
Took Jehoahaz son *awoke*
Of Josiah, anointed him
And made him to be a king *trim*
In his father's own room *and rim*.

I weep for king Josiah, for the brave
And good who was forever a true slave
Of You, Beloved, and followed with his
might
Every command You gave men for the
right.
I weep for king Josiah and the good
Who followed him in martyrdom and
should
Be written in letters of gold for all
To see the reward of Your flash and call.
Beloved, though I weep for the great, good
king,
I know that You control here everything
Behind the scenes of evil and of craft.

Though men have rejoiced, You alone have
laughed.

Megiddo is still there to see and those
Who see it know forever whom You chose.

31 Jehoahaz was twenty-three
Years old when he began to be
Ruler, and he reigned three months in
Jerusalem. His mother's *kin*
For name was Hamutal, the doll
Of Jeremiah, Libnah's poll.
32 He did the wrong before the eyes
Of YHWH according to the guise
Of all his ancestors had done.
33 Pharaoh Nechoh put him in bands
At Riblah in the Hamath lands,
So he might not rule *in the town*
Jerusalem, and then set down
A tribute on the land out *cold*
A hundred silver, one of gold.
34 And Pharaoh Nechoh came to make
Eliakim the son and sake
Of Josiah king in the room
Of Josiah after the doom
Of his father, and changed his name
To Jehoiakim, took the claim
Of Jehoahaz and he came
To Egypt where he died *in shame*.

It only took Jehoahaz twelve weeks
To undo the good that his father seeks
To instil in the hearts of Judah's folk.
The evil always runs and goes for broke.
Your hand is seen in Pharaoh for the stroke
He laid upon Jehoahaz to stoke
The way of righteousness before the sky
Jerusalem still looked upon as nigh.
Replacing a bad king with one his brother
Born of the same wickedness and same
mother
Can do nothing to change the way the
world
Looks on his deeds to emulate uncurled.

Beloved, it hardly helps to change a name.
Reality remains always the same.
The king with wicked heart and action
proves
That wickedness will always find its
grooves.
It might have worked a miracle to change
The name of the boy to bring in his range

The goal of righteous action. But the
thought

Is overcome by what the boy's been taught.
The father may well have taught him the
good,

But his own heart and people in the wood
Seduce him to the pagan altar and
Corrupt what could have been a righteous
hand.

Beloved, change not my name, but change
my heart

Always to know and do the better part.

35 Jehoiakim gave silver, gold
To Pharaoh, but he taxed the bold
Land to give the money as due
By the command of Pharaoh's crew,
He charged the silver and the gold
To the folk of the land and told
Each one according to taxation
To give it up *and with vexation*
To Pharaoh Nechoh *and his nation*.

35 Jehoiakim was twenty-five
Years old when he began alive
To reign, he reigned eleven years
In Jerusalem. *It appears*

His mother's name was Zebudah,
Who was daughter of Pedaiiah
Who came from the town of Rumah.

37 And he did evil in the eyes
Of YHWH according to unwise
Things of his ancestors' demise.

You might have raised according to the
name

Jehoiakim the people from their shame.

You might have raised, Beloved, the king
to do

The commandments, the merciful, the true.
You might have raised the sights of all the
folk

To truth and justice at a kingly stroke,
If Jehoiakim had lived up to fame
Implied in his name to Your gracious
claim.

Beloved, Your name when hidden in the
heart

Of men's names ought to grace them with
the art

And blessing of Your presence, but I see
Jehoiakim worked out iniquity.
That failure is a human tragedy:

Before us always possibility.

2 Kings 24

1 In his days king of Babylon,
Nebuchadnezzar came upon
Jehoiakim who then became
His servant three years for disame
Before he rebelled *at the claim*.

When Hezekiah rebelled You stood firm
To give the patient early bird the worm.
How was Jehoiakim to know that now
It was too late to put on kingly brow
And take an independent stand somehow?
Two ways of dealing with idolatry:
The one sets out to crush the vanity,
The other quietly submits to gold
But keeps the inner chamber bright and
bold

And unseen by the tyrant. Here I find
The two ways lie before me, though I'm
blind,

The Master of the Age must give the call
Before I break the barrier and wall.
My acquiescence is my sword and mall.

2 And YHWH sent against him in bands
Chaldees, as well as Syrian bands,
And bands of Moabites and bands
Of the folk of Ammon *like sands*,
And set them against Judah to
Destroy it and according to
The word that was spoken by YHWH
Through His servants the prophets' *crew*.

3 Truly at the command of YHWH
This came on Judah to remove
Them from before His face and prove
The sins of Manasseh for groove,
4 And also for innocent blood
That he poured out to fill like flood
Jerusalem, innocent blood,
Which YHWH would not pardon *a bud*.

5 The rest of Jehoiakim's acts,
And what he did *and what distracts*,
Are they not written in the books
Of chronicles of Judah's crooks?

6 Jehoiakim slept with his dads
And Jehoiachin *last of cads*
And his son reigned there in his place.

It's Manasseh whose sins set fatal mark
Upon Jerusalem and every park

From Kidron up to David's tower to lay
 The mighty walls of the town in the sway
 Of Babylon. Fair Babylon the great
 Who never had nor shall equal or mate.
 The sins of one dictator come to haunt
 The sunny days and make them also gaunt.
 Beloved, though I live in the aftermath
 Of tyranny as well as in the gaff
 Of so-called democratic psychopath,
 I turn not to Egyptian arms nor go
 Into Babylonian power show,
 But stay within the chambered way I know.

7 The king of Egypt showed no face
 Any more from his land to race,
 Because the king of Babylon
 Had taken up for possession
 From the river of Egypt to
 The river Euphrates the crew
 Of all that belonged to the king
 Of Egypt, *he took everything*.
 8 Jehoiachin was eighteen years
 Old when he started, it appears,
 To reign, and he reigned in the town
 Jerusalem three months *to frown*.
 Nehushta was his mother's name
 Daughter of Elnathan who came
 From Jerusalem, *town of fame*.
 9 He did the evil in the sight
 Of YHWH according to the spite
 That his father had done *not right*.

Three months was all it took to show the
 man
 A base fellow as base as any can.
 At eighteen years the geezer knew his mind
 And lay a path toward destruction's rind.
 The actions of these kings called wicked is
 But the expected action in the fizz
 Of the culture where they are found with
 biz.
 None could or would blame them, but
 rather call
 Them up for leadership prize in the hall.
 Beloved, it's only You and one you sent
 In a prophetic bent who'll not relent,
 Insisting the idolatrous is bent
 Against the culture heritage that's meant
 In all the lands around there where he
 went.

10 At that time Nebuchadnezzar's

Servants, king of Babylon's gars,
 Came to attack Jerusalem,
 Besieging the town *like a hem*.
 11 And Nebuchadnezzar the king
 Of Babylon came in a ring
 Against the city and his slaves
 Besieged it *down into its graves*.
 12 Jehoiachin king of Judah
 Went out to Babylon's king's *claw*,
 He and his mother and his slaves,
 His princes and officers' *waves*,
 And the king of Babylon took
 Him in the eighth year of his rook.
 13 He brought all the treasures from there,
 From the house of YHWH and the share
 Of treasures from the king's house and
 Cut in pieces all the gold stand
 That Solomon then Israel's king
 Had made in YHWH's temple *to spring*,
 And YHWH had said, *so was the thing*.
 14 He brought all Jerusalem out,
 And all the princes, and the stout
 Men of war, ten thousand captives,
 And each craftsman and smith that lives,
 Till none remained except the poor
 Sort of folk *at the country's door*.
 15 He brought away Jehoiachin
 To Babylon, and the king's kin:
 His mother and the king's wives too,
 His officers and mighty crew
 Of the land, he brought in to serve
 Captive from Jerusalem's *curve*
 To Babylon, *just see what nerve*.
 16 And all the men who knew to fight
 Even seven thousand of might,
 And craftsmen and smiths to the number
 Of a thousand, not to encumber,
 But strong and apt for war, all such
 The king of Babylon would touch
 As captives in Babylon's clutch.

The many looking on would praise the
 work
 Jehoiaquin did for town not to shirk,
 Because he tried to keep the kingdom still
 Running for independence of the bill
 Of Babylon. The many watchers would.
 How is one to know the way that one
 should
 If not to follow desire and the track
 Of popular opinion at one's back?
 Beloved, You gave the king a book to read

That very few of Judah's kings would
 heed,
And so he is without excuse to stand
Before You in the judgement on the sand
Of Babylon with mother and with wife
After the bloodshed and the horrid strife.

17 The king of Babylon then made
Mattaniah his dad's unpaid
Brother to be king in his place,
And changed his name though not his race
To Zedekiah *for a space*.

18 Zedekiah was twenty-one
Years old it was when he'd begun
To reign, he reigned eleven years
In Jerusalem it appears.

His mother's name was Hamutal,
Daughter of Jeremiah tall
Of Libnah, *a good town and stall*.

19 He did the evil in the eyes
Of YHWH according to the guise
Of what Jehoiakim unwise
Had done *before him to despise*.

20 For through the angry wrath of YHWH
It happened in Jerusalem,
It happened so in Judah too,
Until He had thrown out the stem
From his presence, and so rebelled
Zedekiah *and all withheld*
From Babylon's king *till he quelled*.

Now Zedekiah was a piece, I swear,
As brave and firm as any anywhere
To hold the fort and rise up strong and true
To the ideals of Canaan, Tyre and crew
To trust in Baal and Ashtoreth to do
The wicked thing that everyone felt right
Before the king of Babylon in sight.
Beloved, the acres of Your presence find
But little response in the human mind,
And yet the soul's but an illusion blind
Where You're reflected in the slow refined.
I whirled about the haze and clear and
 grow

To see there is no other in the show
But You before illusion must bow low.

2 Kings 25

1 It happened in the ninth year that
He reigned, in the tenth month and flat
On the tenth day of the month came
Nebuchadnezzar as in blame,

The king of Babylon and all
His army to attack, enthrall
Jerusalem, and so they pitched
Against it and built forts *bewitched*.
2 And the town was besieged until
The eleventh year of the still
King Zedekiah. 3 On the day
Number nine of the fourth month's sway
The famine covered all the city
Without bread for the land's folk's pity.
4 The town was broken down and all
The soldiers fled between the wall
By way of the gate and at night
Beside the king's garden to light.
And the Chaldees attacking there
Were all around, but the king's share
Went by the road toward the plain
As fast as can and hoped for gain.
5 The army of the Chaldees went
After the king and found him spent
In the plains of Jericho, and
All his army scattered like sand.
6 And so they took the king and brought
Him up to the king who had sought,
The king of Babylon who stood
In Riblah, and judged as they could.
7 They killed Zedekiah's sons there
Before his eyes, and did not spare
To put out Zedekiah's eyes,
And bound him in brass chains to bear
Him up to Babylon *as prize*.

Compared to predecessor Zedekiah
Was long-lived though he became a pariah.
Before the tyranny of empire he stood out
Eleven years with diplomatic rout
To make what he could of his name and
 fame.

There ought to be few to rise up in blame.
The evil that he did was nothing but
The same evil the populace was shut
On doing on the high place and the hill.
Idolatry is popular now still.
Beloved, king Zedekiah's hero here
With Papa Doc, Saddam, Stalin and fear
As long as what's appropriate is kept
Conformable to palaces well swept.

8 And in the fifth month, on the day
Number seven in the month's sway,
In the nineteenth year of the king
Nebuchadnezzar who was king

Of Babylon, came captain of
 The guard, Nebuzaradan, glove
 In service to Babylon's king
 Up to Jerusalem *on wing*.
 9 He burnt the house of YHWH as well
 As the king's house, and truth to tell
 All the houses left in the town
 Jerusalem, and every crown
 House he burnt with fire *and tore down*.
 10 And all the army of Chaldees
 That were with the guard's captain's
 wheeze

Broke down the walls around the town
 Jerusalem *and left them brown*.

11 The rest of the folk that were left
 In the city and those bereft
 That fell away before the king
 Of Babylon, and everything
 Of all that crowd that there remained
 Nebuzaradan the retained
 Captain of the guard brought away.
 12 But the captain of the guard left
 The poor of the land there bereft
 Vinedressers and farmers to stay.

The captain of the king came to the land
 Of Judah and Jerusalem to stand
 As a destroyer on the fateful sand.
 The blades cut down the temples and the
 great
 Houses and left them flattened that had late
 Been wonders of the world. Beloved, I see
 The desolation and the poverty
 And realize that there is one salvation
 From tyranny in this world of elation,
 And that is blooming in humility
 Beneath the blades of war in charity
 As vinedresser and farmer who remain
 To worship You upon a desert plain.
 Today, though, farmers are striving in vain

13 The brazen pillars in YHWH's house
 And the bases and the sea's dowse
 That was in YHWH's house, the Chaldees
 Broken in blocks, carried like cheese
 All their brass back to Babylon.
 14 And the pots and the shovels and
 The snuffers and the spoons on hand
 And all the brazen vessels by
 Which they served, they took *on the sly*.
 15 The firepans, bowls, such things of
 gold,

Of gold and silver, silver told,
 The captain of the guard was bold
 To take them *all without reply*.
 16 Both pillars, the sea and the bases
 That Solomon had made for traces
 In YHWH's house, the brass of these
 things
 Was too much to weigh *in farthings*.
 17 The height of each pillar in all
 Was eighteen cubits and so tall
 The caption on it was brass too,
 And the height of the caption due
 Was three arm-lengths, and wreathen work
 And pomegranates for the kirk
 Around it, all of brass and like
 These also on the second spike,
 With wreathen work *too high to strike*.

The fall of Solomon seems here at last
 To come as the pillars that once were cast
 And wrought for beauty fall into the hands
 Of spoilers of Chaldeans in their bands.
 The truth is Solomon fell from his place
 When he went beyond what the Torah's
 trace

For royal mandate gave, not to retain
 Too many wives and horses on the plain.
 Whatever record's right in horse's count,
 Solomon went beyond the right amount.
 A foreign wife implies a treaty with
 The royal heathen father and his myth.
 Beloved, the fall of Solomon preceded
 The cutting of the pillars that he needed.

18 The captain of the guard then took
 Seraiah the chief priest *and cook*
 And Zephaniah, second priest,
 And the three door keepers *at least*.
 19 Out of the town he took a man
 Set over the army *and clan*,
 And five men from before the king,
 Found in the city, and writing
 The first scribe of the army who
 Mustered the folk of the land's few,
 And sixty men of the land's folk
 Still found in the town *at a stroke*.
 20 And Nebuzaradan the chief
 Of the guard took these for relief
 And brought them to Babylon's king
 To Riblah *so he'd see the thing*.
 21 The king of Babylon struck down
 And killed the men brought from the town

At Riblah there in Hamath's land.
 So Judah failed out of their land.
 22 The folk that remain in the land
 Of Judah, whom Babylon's king
 Nebuchadnezzar left to sing,
 Over them he made ruler one
 Gedaliah who was the son
 Of Ahikam, and Shaphan's son.
 23 When all the army chiefs, they and
 Their men heard that the king's command
 Made Gadaliah governor,
 There came to Gedaliah's door
 In Mizpah, even Ishmael son
 Of Nethaniah, Johanan
 The son of Careah as well
 As Seraiah the son of *fell*
 Tanhumeth the Netophathite,
 Jaazaniah a Maachathite,
 They and their men *after the fight*.
 24 And Gedaliah swore to them
 And to their men by diadem,
 And told them, "Do not be afraid
 To be servants though still unpaid
 Of the Chaldees, live in the land,
 Serve king of Babylon's command,
 And you will prosper *by my hand*.

See, my Beloved, how Gedaliah swore
 In true allegiance to the kingly score
 And promised wealth and health before the
 door
 Of Judah, if and only if the man
 Would submit to the royal crown and ban.
 It's possible, I see, to live a life
 True to You, my Beloved, amidst the strife
 Of competition to be king and leader.
 But to do so one must be bottom feeder
 And find joy in the wild plant and the grass
 Instead of temple built of gold and brass.
 The gold of my temple, Beloved, is here
 As buttercup and dandelion's tear,
 A song for just a day, and then to pass.

25 It happened the seventh month that
 Ishmael Nethaniah's son *fat*,
 The son of Elishama who
 Were of the royal family too,
 Came with ten men and stuck the man
 Gedaliah, who died by plan,
 And the Jews and Chaldees with him
 At Mizpah, *it was action grim*.
 26 All the folk then both small and great,

The army chiefs too, got up late
 And came to Egypt, for they feared
 The Chaldees *after what appeared*.

Who represents the king in loyalty
 And fearing You, Beloved, may come to
 see
 Assassination as fast as the free
 King on the throne who does things
 wickedly.
 So Gedaliah, though he tried to be
 Faithful to all, was killed and cast aside.
 Fear comes, Beloved, before the morning
 ride
 As refugees in Egypt to abide.
 You promised that no one need take that
 road,
 And yet fear laid upon the hearts such load
 That trusting not in what You might
 provide
 The people fled to find the Nile a home.
 Beloved, I do believe Your providence
 Enough for Roman or Chaldean tents.

27 It happened then upon the year
 Thirty-seven in prison gear
 Of Jehoiachin Judah's king,
 In the twelfth month and on *the ring*
Of the twenty-seventh day of
 The month as mentioned there above,
 That Evilmerodach the king
 Of Babylon then did a thing
 In the year he began to rule,
 He lifted up the head of *fool*
 Jehoiachin the king of Judah
 Out of the prison *though a feuder*.
 28 And he spoke kindly to the man,
 And set his throne upon a span
 Above the throne of the kings that
 There with him in Babylon sat.
 29 He changed his prison clothing too,
 And he ate bread always in view
 Of him all the days he lived too.
 30 His pension came from the king daily
 As long as he was living *gaily*.

The empire is benign when one is set
 In prison long enough and to forget.
 Events pass quickly, opportunity
 Is but a single breath, it then sets free
 The one called for a moment's destiny.
 The ragged remnants of a burning flame

Are black and cold and dressed as though
in shame
And morning for the lost chance to be
great.
And so the ghosts of other times in state
Dine at the tables of the enemy
Who can afford to set his prisoner free.
Beloved, though my flame may be small
and spent,
Though I may have failed in what this
world lent,
I dine at Your full table and content.

The Books of Chronicles

The Books of Chronicles are considered to be of much later date than the Books of Samuel and Kings. Aside from an introductory portion going back to Adam, they cover the same period, however. They present some complications for the scholar and believer in the fact that there are some factual inconsistencies between the Chronicles and the Books of Kings. Much of the argumentation for the invalidity of the Bible is drawn from a comparison of these two distinct traditions. The assumptions of those arguments are mainly two: 1) factual inconsistency implies corruption of the text or a non-divine inspiration; 2) the inclusion of a weak text in the Bible discredits the entire Bible, even those portions produced by different people hundreds of years earlier or later than the text in question, and even in a different language. The thoughtful reader will note that the criterion of factual consistency can itself be questioned on one hand, and the argument of invalidity based on canonical composition, on the other, is irrational to the point of insanity.

The figure of Hemda, introduced in Samuel, is developed in the Chronicles, with the underlying belief that the coming of the desired one is immanent, and any king may turn out to be the Hemda for whom the world, or at least Israel, was awaiting. The figure is overtly mentioned in 2 Chronicles 22:20; 32:27; and 36:10. I have taken the liberty of transcribing the word Hemda as Muhammad. The words

are exactly the same in Hebrew and Arabic, and only the vocalization, a meaningless convention, obscures the fact. Whether or not the texts are prophetic of the Prophet of Islam born in Arabia ca. 570 C.E. is a matter of opinion or belief, but the fact of the name itself appearing in the text is incontrovertible. It is simply there. It is not a tenuous etymology, but an exact and undeniable cognate.

1 Chronicles 1

1 Adam, Seth, Enosh, 2 Cainan, and Mahalalel, Jared *in hand*,
3 Enoch, Methuselah, Lamech,
4 Noah, Shem, Ham, *and neck in neck*
Japheth. 5 The sons of Japheth *are*
Gomer, Magog, Madai, *so far*
Javan, Tubal, Meshech, and Tiras,
All heroes, all and none to fear us.

Ten generations make up Noah's span,
While Japheth is wide-spreading to a man
With seven sons, five continents, a wake
Upon completion in twelfth, Gomer's sake.
Madai is not the middle, Javan is,
And though Meshech is tall, no secret's
his.

The seven sons with enigmatic names
Are easier to crack than all the claims
Of seven veils that fall without a word
Beyond the heart alone by one name
stirred.

Beloved, I here recite the secret notes
That sail beyond the jumping, painted
boats
Out where the froth gives way, the dragon
floats,
And phoenix finds a flame once and
inured.

6 The sons of Gomer: Ashkenaz,
Diphath, and Togarmah *for laws*.

The twelfth and perfect generation stayed
In Japheth's family and on parade
To divide into three names secretly
Without a meaning on the placid lee.
No doubt those names are meant to stretch
a line
Beyond the borders of Middle East fine
Into the northern countries where they bear

No more meaning than chirping on the air.
 If Germans, Danes and Finns here find
 their share,
 The thirteenth generation's everywhere,
 And nothing relents from its beer and wine.
 And still I penetrate the pallid tree
 And settle with dark firs all around me
 Into the quiet and the holy glade.

7 The sons of Javan: Elishah,
 Tarshishah, Kittim, and *the raw*
 Rodanim. 8 The sons of Ham: Cush,
 Mizraim, Put, and Canaan's *push*.

I doubt the children of this further year
 Can recognize a face beyond the tear
 That claims to represent the Grecian book,
 The pyramid Egyptian and the look
 Of Abyssinia and the Sudan.
 I doubt that any living children can
 Find prophecies here from their early roots.
 The Canaanite is thrown on with his boots.
 Elishah only has a name to claim
 The fame of great salvation in the game.
 If God is my salvation from what cause
 Gives me, Beloved, beneath my trees some
 pause,
 Then it's enough for me that they were
 born.
 I hold no blistered heat nor sand in scorn.

9 The sons of Cush *were* Seba, and
 Havilah, Sabta, *by command*,
 Raama, and Sabtecha. The sons
 Of Raama *were* Sheba *who runs*
 And Dedan. 10 Cush produced Nimrod,
 Mighty on earth *and before God*.

The secrets of glad Seba win the race:
 I see the golden thread drawn on the trace
 Of revelation to Your divine face,
 A monument to mercy and to grace.
 If Yemen and Axum still bear the seat
 Of Decalogue in mind and heart and treat
 Commandments with the tongue and hand
 to make
 A witness to Your name, Beloved, I take
 That secret on my breath and live to bring
 It to fruition in the things I sing
 If not in what I do with a weak hand
 That stretches out no farther than I stand.
 Beloved, I see the golden thread drawn fast

In Bible and Qur'an, in heart to last.

11 Mizraim produced Ludim and
 Anamim, Lehabim *to stand*,
 Naphtuhim, 12 Pathrusim, Casluhim
 (From whom came Philistines, Caphtorim).
 13 Canaan produced Sidon, his firstborn,
 And Heth *by no means among worst born*,
 14 The Jebusite, the Amorite,
 And the Girgashite, 15 the Hivite,
 The Arkite, Sinite, 16 Arvadite,
 The Zemarite, and Hamathite.

If Hittites are the sons of Ham, I swear,
 Beloved, I shall not accept anywhere
 The epithet and curse, I'll move my rate
 To some religion far beyond Your state!
 And yet, Your Christ despised no dog that
 sat

Beneath the Jewish table on a mat,
 But gave the woman back her son and then
 Compared her faith beyond that of some
 men.

A dervish dog I be, no doubt, and wait
 Beside Your table for the bone and plate,
 Eyes bright, ears at alert, and eager tongue
 Ready to sing the howling songs I've sung.
 Beloved, though Canaanite and Celtic
 flash,

I hide beneath the cover of Your sash.

17 The sons of Shem *were* Elam, and
 Asshur, Arphaxad, Lud's *command*,
 Aram, Uz, Hul, Gether, Meshech.
 18 Arphaxad produced Shelah's *neck*,
 And Shelah had Eber *as son*.

19 To Eber were born *on the run*
 Two sons: the name of one Peleg,
 For in his time the earth *by peg*
 Was measured, and his brother's name
 Was Joktan. 20 Joktan *had in claim*
 Almodad, Sheleph, Hazarmaveth,
 Jerah, 21 Hadoram, and engraveth
 Uzal and Diklah, 22 Ebal, and
 Abimael, Sheba *in hand*,
 23 Ophir, Havilah, and Jobab.
 All these sons of Joktan's *confab*.
 24 Shem, Arphaxad, Shelah, and yet
 25 Eber, Peleg, Reu, 26 Serug, set
 And Nahor, Terah, 27 and Abram,
 Who *is also called* Abraham.
 28 The sons of Abraham, Isaac

And Ishmael. 29 These *in their pack*
Are their genealogies' stack:
 And the firstborn of Ishmael
 Nebajoth, then Kedar, Adbeel,
 Mibsam, 30 Mishma, Dumah, Massa,
 Hadad, Tema, 31 Jetur, Naphish,
 And last and finally Kedemah.
 These *were* the children Ishmaelish.
 32 Now the sons born to Keturah,
 Abraham's concubine *by law*,
Were Zimran, Jokshan, Medan, and
 Midian, Ishbak, and Shuah's *band*.
 The sons of Jokshan *were* Sheba
 And Dedan. 33 Sons of Midian's *law*
Were Ephah, Ephher, Hanoch, and
 Abida, and Eldaah. All these
 Were children at Keturah's hand.
 34 And Abraham produced *to please*
 Isaac. The sons of Isaac *were*
 Esau and Israel *astir*.

The Book of Chronicles has come out late
 To comment on the Genesis, relate
 The generations that arose to rate
 The world from the beginning of its fate.
 The universal view arises here
 To make the conquest of all hearts in fear
 Of heathen gods that You, Beloved, are
 near
 To all men and all generations' gear.
 There is no land nor clime beyond the hand
 That guides the universe from the
 unscanned
 Watches of night and day. Beloved,
 unbanned
 The kings and followers join what You've
 planned.
 I find the calling to Your unity
 Vibrant and vital in the living tree.

35 The sons of Esau: Eliphaz,
 Reuel, Jeush, Jaalam, whereas
 The last is Korah. 36 And the sons
 Of Eliphaz: Teman *for puns*,
 Omar, Zephi, Gatam, Kenaz,
 And Timna, and last Amalek.
 37 The sons of Reuel *were* Nahath,
 Zerah, Shammah, and Mizzah's *path*.
 38 The sons of Seir *were* Lotan, and
 Shobal, Zibeon, Anah's *hand*,
 Dishon, Ezer, and Dishan. 39 And
 The sons of Lotan *were* Hori

And Homam, Lotan's *alibi*
Was his sister Timna ally.
 40 The sons of Shobal: Alian,
 Manahath, *and where* Ebal *ran*,
 Shephi, and Onam. The sons of
 Zibeon *were* Ajah *for love*
 And Anah. 41 The son of Anah
Was Dishon. The sons *by the law*
 Of Dishon *were* Hamran, Eshban,
 Ithran, and *the last was* Cheran.
 42 The sons of Ezer *were* Bilhan,
 Zaavan, *and finally* Jaakan.
 The sons of Dishan: Uz and Aran.
 43 Now these *were* the kings who reigned
 in
 The land of Edom *without sin*
 Before a king reigned of the folk
 Of Israel: Bela a bloke
 The son of Beor, and the name
 Of his city was *in its fame*
 Dinhabah. 44 And when Bela died,
 Jobab the son of Zerah's *pride*
 Of Bozrah reigned there in his place.
 45 When Jobab died *within God's grace*,
 Husham of the Temanites' land
 Reigned in his place *as he had planned*.
 46 And when Husham died, Hadad son
 Of Bedad, who attacked Midian
 In Moab's field, reigned in his stead.
 The name of his city's Avith.
 47 When Hadad died *with all his teeth*,
 Samlah of Masrekah reigned then
 In his place. 48 And when Samlah's yen
 Was to die, Saul of Rehoboth
 Beside the river took the oath
 To reign in his stead. 49 When Saul died,
 Lord Hanan son of Achbor's pride
 Reigned in his place. 50 And when the lord
 Hanan died, Hadad took his sword,
 Whose city's name was Pai. His wife's
 Name was Mehetabel *whose strifes*
The Lord made good, the daughter of
 Matred, who was the daughter of
 Mezahab. 51 Hadad died also.
 And the chiefs of Edom *to show*
 Were Chief Timnah, Chief Aliah,
 Chiefs Jetheth, 52 Aholibamah,
 Chief Elah, Chief Pinon, 53 and Chief
 Kenaz, Chief Teman, *for relief*
 Chief Mibzar, 54 Chief Magdiel, and
 Chief Iram, chiefs of Edom's *land*.

Edom and Moab also have a place
Beside the tribe of Israel in Your grace.
All stand before You with an equal choice
To follow the commandments of Your
voice.
The nations wake each morning to receive
The new day and the dawn of Your
reprieve
With a new slate to write the words in
score
According to the Decalogue in store.
The choice is made each day by everyone
Until the setting of the worldly sun
And all stand to be judged for what they've
done
And not for what they've lost or what
they've won.
Beloved, I praise You for Your mercy and
Your justice on a gloried, teeming land.

1 Chronicles 2

1 These *were* the sons of Israel:
Reuben, Simeon, Levi as well,
And Judah, Issachar and yet
Zebulun *where Jacob was set*.
2 Dan, Joseph, Benjamin up to
Naphtali, Gad and Asher too.
3 The sons of Judah: Er, Onan,
And Shelah, three born *to the man*
By Shua the Canaanitess,
A wife he had but not to bless.
And Er Judah's eldest was bad
In YHWH's eyes, so He killed the lad.
4 And Tamar his daughter-in-law
Bore him Pharez and then Zerah.
And so in all then Judah had
Five sons *although the two were bad*.
5 The sons of Pharez: Hezron and
Hamul, *beginning of the band*.
6 The sons of Zerah: Zimri and
Ethan and Heman, Calcol and
Dara, five of them in a band.
7 The sons of Carmi: Achar who
Was troubler of the retinue
Of Israel, who transgressed in what
Was forbidden *among the shut*.
8 The son of Ethan: Azariah.
9 The son too of Hezron's *latria*
That were born to him, Jerahmeel,
And ram and Chelubai *at heel*.
10 And so Ram sired Amminadab,
Amminadab got son to grab

In Nahshon, prince of Judah's folk.
11 And Nahshon sire Salma *the bloke*
Who sired Boaz *when gone for broke*.
12 And Boaz sire Obed and he
Obed's the one who sired Jesse.
13 And Jesse's firstborn was Eliab,
And the second Abinadab,
And Shimma the third one *to grab*.
14 Nethaneel the fourth, and Raddai
The fifth, 15 Ozem the sixth to fly
To the seventh, David *the guy*.

The plot of the Torah points to a man,
Moses, who was central to all Your plan.
The Torah books are supplemented by
The Jubilees, Enoch and the strong cry
Of Joshua and Judges as they ran.
The rest of Hebrew Scriptures find their
way

Around the figure of David to sway
The hearts of men, as Moses' light of day
Illuminated right actions in play.
So Moses and David at once began.
Two more books of revealing will come
next
To answer the questions of the perplexed:
The Gospel and Qur'an revitalize
Your revelation before human eyes.

16 The sisters of David were two:
Zeruiah, Abigail in crew.
The sons of Zeruiah were these:
Abishai and Joab *to please*,
And Asahel, like as three *peas*.
17 And Abigail bore Amasa,
And Amasa's father by Jah
Was Jether, Ishmeelite *for paw*.

Even the sisters of David arise
To get their honour here beneath the skies
Of books surrounding David's family.
Their children too are bright as they can be.
Some will complain that one married a
man
Coming it seems from Arabian clan.
But Canaanite and Moabite remain
As well as ancestresses not inane.
Beloved, David is prophet and a king
Forever on the throne of Israel's wing,
And yet he's multinational in view
Because he looks only toward the true.
Other kings wait for gods and men to make

Renown. David's for foreign women's
sake.

18 And Caleb son of Hezron had
Sons by Azubah, wife not bad,
And by Jerioth, whose sons spun
Were Jeshur, Shobab and Ardon.
18 And after Azubah had died,
Caleb took a wife to his side,
Ephrath, who bore him Hur *in pride*.
20 And Hur sired Uri and Uri
Sired Bezaleel *among the free*.
21 And afterward Hezron went in
To Machir's daughter without sin
Since he had married her when he
Was sixty years old, and so she
Bore him Segub, *Johnny lately*.

If Caleb can have three wives and the first
Two simultaneously, and what is worst
In that he replaced one on death as due
With another, as though old men require
Two wives to quench their fine lustly
desire.

Example of his father made Hezron
Take a new wife at sixty, though the run
Of the Septuagint would set the date
At sixty-five, not to settle too late.
Beloved, the duty first of humankind
Is propagation of the fed and wined,
And then to rule the world. That's why the
great

Are never reticent to find a mate.
So different, Beloved, is Your estate.

22 And Segub sired Jair, who had
Twenty-three cities in not bad
Country renowned as Gilead.
23 And he took Geshur and Aram
With the towns of Jair in clam
Away from them, with Kenath and
Its suburbs, sixty cities' band.
All these pertained to Machir's sons
The father of Gilead's *runs*.
24 After Hezron died in the town
Of Calebephatah's renown,
Then Abiah Hezron's wife bore
Him Ashur Tekoa's dad *sore*.
25 And so the sons of Jerahmeel
The firstborn of Hezron to feel
Were Ram the firstborn and Bunah,
Oren, Ozem and Ahijah.

My view of revelation is such that
Come what may where the cunning critic
sat

Enunciating origins got pat,
Launching theories as truth historical
Without doubt for reason, empirical,
And come what may of fundamentalist,
I hear a different drummer in the mist
Noting that human subterfuge that rises
To sink Your revelation in disguises
Has merit in the broader view to get
Only the surface of the fact and set
My heart to dialogue from self to Self
And know You better than the elf on shelf
Sufficient to the arguments all met.

26 Had Jerahmeel a second wife
Whose name was Atarah for life,
She was the mother of Onam.
27 And the sons who were born to Ram
The first born of Jerahmeel here:
Maaz and Jamin and last Eker.
28 And the sons of Onam: Shammai,
And Jada. And sons of Shammai:
Nadab and Abishur *to spy*.
29 And the name of Abishur's wife
Was Abihail and *without strife*
She bore him Ahban and Molid.
30 And the sons of Nadab *for bid*
Were Seled and Appaim, but died
Seled without children *by side*.
31 And the sons of Appaim: Ishi.
And the sons if Ishi *in sty*:
Sheshan. And the sons of Sheshan:
Ahlai *as far as one can scan*.
32 And the sons of Jada the frère
Of Shammai: Jether and *in care*
Jonathan, and Jether too died
Without any sons *at his side*.
33 The sons of Jonathan: Peleth
And Zaza. These were of the breath
Of Jerahmeel *after his death*.
34 Now Sheshan had not sons at all
But only daughters in the stall.
And Sheshan had Egyptian slave
Named Jarha *from cradle to grave*.
35 And Sheshan gave his daughter to
Jarha his servant as wife due
And she bore him Attai *in view*.

The system of slavery in Palestine

Among the Hebrews may have not been
 fine,
 But hardly fits the picture that arises
 From the word in this day and page
 surprises.
 To be a slave of Sheshan was to know
 The pleasures of both son and brother's
 glow
 And then to mount the home hearth
 princess till
 An heir was born to sit on throne and hill.
 Who criticize Your word, Beloved,
 because
 It uses the word slave in statute clause
 Redeem the will to doubt both faith and
 laws
 For excuse to set free men to repeat
 Oppression without slavery on their beat.
 Hypocrisy's the name I give with cause.

36 And Attai sired Nathan, the lad
 Nathan sired and begat Zabad.
 37 And Zabad sired Ephlal, Ephlal
 Sired Obed *and not prodigal*.
 38 And Obed sired Jehu whose paw
 At last begat Azariah.
 39 And Azariah sired Helez,
 And Helez begat Eleasah.
 40 And Eleasah *just as one says*
 Sired Sisamai, and Sisamai
 Sired Shallum *since he was not shy*.
 41 And Shallum sired Jekamiah,
 Jekamiah Elishama.
 42 The sons of Caleb who was brother
 Of Jerahmeel *of the same mother*
 Were Mesha the firstborn who was
 The father of Ziph, and the *buzz*
Of sons of Mareshah the dad
 Of Hebron, *a lad not too sad*.
 43 And the sons of Hebron: Korah
 And Tappuah, Rekem, Shema.
 44 And Shema sired Raham, the dad
 Of Jorkoam, and Rekem had
 For son Shammai *and a good lad*.
 45 And the son of Shammai was Maon,
 And Maon was Bethzur's dad to stay on.
 46 And Ephah, Caleb's concubine
 Bore Haran and Moza and *fine*
 Gazez, and Haran sired Gazez.
 47 And the sons of Jahdai *in fez*:
 Regem, Jotham, Geshan, Pelet
 And Ephah and Shaaph *in a set*.

48 Maachah Caleb's concubine bore
 Sheber and Tirhanah, *no more*
 49 *Except* also Shaaph who was dad
 Of Madmannah, Sheva the dad
 Of Machbenah, who was the dad
 Of Gibeah, and Caleb's daughter
 Was Achsah *who demanded water*.
 50 These were the sons of Caleb son
 Of Hur, Ephratah's firstborn won,
 Shobal, Kirjathjearim's dad.
 51 Salma who was Bethlehem's dad,
 Hareph father of Bethgader.
 52 And Shobal Kirjathjearim's dad
 Had children: Haroeh and *glad*
 Half of the Manabethites' *pad*.
 53 Kirjathjearim's families' gear:
 The Ithrites, Puhites, without fear
 The Shumathites and Mishraitites,
 Of them came the Zareathites,
 And *finally* the Eshtaulites.
 54 The sons of Salma: Bethlehem,
 The Netophathites and the hem
 Of Ataroth of Joab's sites,
 And half of the Manabethites,
Or Joab's crowns, and the Zorites.
 55 And the families of the scribes
 Who lived at Jabez *with the bribes*
 Of Tirathites, Shimeathites,
 Suchathites, these are the Kenites
 That came from Hemath, father of
 The house of Rechab, *hand in glove*.

Caleb was famous in the Bible story
 That's told to children, both the one of
 glory
 As well as those that get a bit too gory,
 But never do we tell our sons the man
 Had concubines as though by divine plan.
 The holy line engages in the sin
 (As we more highly developed to win
 Would see today) of having slave and more
 Slave wives to open and to shut the door.
 The Bible's here to tell the story how
 Men lived to circumvent Your law, allow
 And write the inspiration of the plot
 They think arises in vision to clot
 With complications Your simple shalt not.

1 Chronicles 3

1 Now these were the sons of David
 Born in Hebron *after he hid*:
 The firstborn was Amnon, by her

Named Ahinoam, Jezreelitess,
The second Daniel to offer
From Abigail the Carmelitess.

The prophet Daniel was named for the one
Son of David that never jumped the gun,
Was never one rebellious, let the star
Of younger brother be king popular
While he lived in obscurity as far
As divine write spells out the benison.
If Daniel waits for You, Beloved, to judge,
And leaves not on his life a smear or
smudge,

But only lives Your love in faithful dress,
I take his firm example and address.
The line of kings goes left and right and
finds

Its way in righteous and in wicked minds,
But the line that looks back to Daniel's fare
Is straight and righteous living everywhere.

2 The third was Absalom son of
Maachah who was the daughter of
Talmi king of Geshur, the fourth
Adonijah the son come forth
From Haggith. 3 The fifth, Shephatiah
Of Abital, the sixth *pariah*
Ithream of Eglah his wife *by her*.
4 Six were born to him in Hebron,
And there he reigned seven years once
drawn

And six months, in Jerusalem
He reigned thirty-three years *pro tem*.

5 And those born in Jerusalem
Were Shimea, Shobab, Nathan
And Solomon, four as he can
From Bathshua the daughter of
Ammiel *that he took for love*.

6 Ibhar too, and Elishama,
And Eliphelet, 7 and Nogah
And Nepheg, also Jephia,
8 And Elishama, Eliada,
And Eliphelet, nine *in paw*.

9 All sons of David besides those
Born of concubines *that he chose*
And Tamar their sister *who rose*.

The fifteen sons of David and the daughter
Who fended off the brother come and
fought her
With slight success, are stated here in line

With mother's mentioned, at least the
benign.

I think my favourite of the female lot
Is Abigail who once had husband caught
In drunken disrespect for man and beast.
And so the sons line up from great to least.
Beloved, the group is not better than any
That gathers round the market for a penny.
I wonder why you promise royal due
To such awkward and motley uncouth crew.
But then, Beloved, You grace me with the
sun

Though I deride the universe with pun.

10 Solomon's son Rehoboam
Sired Abia a son *like ram*
Who sired Asa his son and who
Sired Jehoshaphat in his crew.
11 Joram in line, then Ahaziah,
Joash his son and *not pariah*,
12 The next in line was Amaziah
Followed by his son Azariah,
Jotham his son, 13 and then Ahaz
His son and then to come with snazz
Hezekiah his son and then
Manasseh his son *to rule men*.
14 Amon his son was followed by
Josiah his son, who was sly
To have children, the firstborn being
Johanan and the second seeing
Jehoiakim, third Zedekiah,
The fourth Shallum *who was loud crier*.
16 Jehoiakim's sons: Jeconiah
His son, Zedekiah his son.

The line of kings appears here for a treat
Full in its glory and final defeat.
David's line comes to faith and sin to mind
Twelve righteous of the kings once they're
defined.

Four kings in all stand out above the
crowd:

King David and fair Solomon allowed,
And last king Hezekiah and the proud
And lovely king Josiah who once forged
The book of law most beautiful and gorged
The Torah with its pinnacle of great
And fine curses and blessings that came
late.

Or so the story goes the scholars tell
In superficial tones and somber bell.

I find in You, Beloved, both words and
spell.

17 And Jeconiah's sons appear
Assir, Shealtiel with gear,
18 Machiram also, and Pedaiah,
And Shenazar and Jecamiah,
And Hoshama and Nedabiah.
19 And the sons of Pedaiah were
Zerubbabel and Shimei *fer*.
And the sons of Zerubbabel:
Meshullam, Hananiah well
And Shelomith their sister *gel*,
20 And Hashubah and then Ohel,
And Berechiah *man alive*,
Hasadjah, Jushabheshed, five.
21 And the sons of Hananiah:
Pelatiah and Jesaiah.
The sons of Rephaiah, the sons
Of Arnan, sons of Obadiah,
As well as sons of Shechaniah.
22 And the sons of Shechaniah:
Shemaiah; and Shemaiah's sons:
Hattush, Igeal and Bariah,
And Neariah and Shaphat, six.
23 And the sons *with a bag of tricks*
Of Neariah: Elioenai,
And Hezekiah *on the sly*
And Azrikam, three *for reply*.
24 And the sons of Elioenai:
Hodaiah and Eliashib,
Pelaiah as well as Akkub,
And Johanan, Dalaiah and
Anani, seven *in a band*.

So many sons are listed in the word
Of who was born and who sired such a
herd,
But only Zerubbabel's daughter's stirred
To be mentioned, no doubt because her
name
Was one of glory and to better claim.
Shelomith, daughter of peace, were that
she
Still lived upon earth and among the free.
Too many sons of war meet at the gate
Of temple and of palace to instate
The violence controlled that keeps the quo
In quid and status for the hum and ho.
The sons of war pretend necessity
Sends them out treading on the poverty
Created by their fathers in the spree.

1 Chronicles 4

1 The sons of Judah were Pharez,
Hezron and Carmi *as he says*,
And Hur and Shobal. 2 And begat
Reaiah Shobal's son Jahath,
And Jahath sired Ahumai and
Lahad. These are Zorathite band.

Pharez corrects the breach of shameful
birth
By Hezron, an enclosure's noble worth.
All men are born to shame and hope and all
Act to correct the breach and fill the stall
Or else to further ruckus by the sense
Of injury in generations' pence.
Fourth generation sees forgetfulness
Of what was so important in address
To those before. The simple vineyard
shows
That humankind, though tortured by the
throes
Of artifice in miscontent, yet knows
Survival is the better part of strife.
Beloved, I come to simplify my life
Among child and grandchild as well as
wife.

3 These were sons of father of Etam:
Jezreel, and Ishma, *none could beat them*,
And Idbash, and their sister's name
Was Hazlelponi *for her fame*.
4 And Penuel, who's Gedor's dad,
And Ezer, who is Hushah's dad.
These are the sons of Hur, the first
Born of Ephratah, *not the worst*,
The father of Bethlehem *glad*.
5 Ashur, Tekoa's father, had
Two wives, Helah and Naarah too.
6 And Naarah brought forth in his view
Ahuzam, Hephher, Temeni,
And finally Haahashtari.
These were the sons of Naarah's crew.
7 And the sons of Helah were Zereth,
Jezoar and Ethnan, *who careth*.
8 Coz sired Anub and Zobebah,
And clans of Aharhel *in awe*
Of the son of *blessed* Harum *too*.
9 And Jabez was of honour greater
Than his brothers, congratulate her,
His mother called him Jabez, saying
"Because I bore him sorrow laying."

10 Jabez called Israel's Alohim,
Saying "Oh that You would esteem
To bless me and enlarge my land,
And lay upon me mighty hand
To keep me from the wicked band
So that it might not bring me grief!"
And Alohim gave him relief.

Jabez is hardly known among the score
Of men and women always brought to fore
By the religious and those who love gore.
Though enigmatic for his mother's word,
He's simple and direct in what occurred
To him to ask of You, and You alone.
Three blessings if not four before Your
throne

He brings in accents sweet there to entone.
He asks for blessing on body and soul,
He asks for more land to till on the dole,
He asks You keep him from the cart and
bowl

Of wicked people so he might not share
Their deeds and bring grief on himself to
bear.

Beloved, methinks there is no better
prayer.

11 And Chelub Shuah's brother sired
Mehir, Eshton's dad *as required*.

12 And Eshton sired Bethrapha and
Paseah and Tehinnah's hand,
The father of Irnahash *grand*.

These are the men of Rechah's band.

13 The sons of Kenaz: Othniel
And Seraiah, the sons that fell
To Othniel: Hathath alone.

14 And Meonothai sired *with groan*
Ophrah: and sired Seraiah Joab,
The father of valley *not Moab*
But Charashim, for they were craftsmen,
In those days there were not yet draftsmen.

15 Caleb's sons, son of Jephunneh:
Iru, Elah, Naam *come what may*,
And the sons of Elah: Kenaz
To bring the family up to snazz.

16 The sons of Jehaleleel: Ziph
And Ziphah, Tiria and *stiff*
Asareel. 17 And Ezra's sons were
Jether and Mered and Ephraim,
And Jalon. And she bore the glad
Miriam, Shammai and Ishbah dad
Of Eshtemoa. 18 And his wife

Jehudijah gave Jered life,
The father of Gedor, and then
Heber Socho's father again,
And Jekuthiel Zanoah's dad.
And these are the sons that were had
Of Bithiah daughter of Pharaoh,
Whom Mered married *quick as arrow*.

In every church today I know the one
Who married a princess would have the fun
Of being amongst great and famous, while
The righteous poor are left to walk their
mile.

That's why, no doubt, Bithiah and the great
Mered are talked about so much of late
And featured in the press and eloquent
Talk shows and followed everywhere they
went

By paparazzi camera-bound and bent
On flame and fortune in the wings and
street.

Beloved, the cry of fame is truly sweet,
And see how immortality in treat
Remains with pharaoh's daughter and the
meet

Husband. What was his name now? Don't
defeat.

19 And the sons of his wife Hodiah,
The sister of Naham to ply her,
The father of Keilah Garmite
And Eshtemoa Maachathite.

20 And the sons of Shimon were Amnon
And Rinnah, Enhanan and Tilon.
And the sons of Ishi were Zoheth
And finally also Benzoheth.

21 The sons of Shelah son of Judah
Were Er who was father of Lecah,
And Laadah father of Mareshah,
And the families of the clan making
Fine linen of Ashbea's taking.

The Huguenots in England made fine
clothes

Of silk and not mere linen, and so those
Go down in history with Shelah the great
Who sired a son called Er because the fate
Of Onan was so evil for estate.

Few now remember that Shelah was clad
With bearing son to brother's name whose
sad

Demise was token of his evil part

In Tamar's distress and anguish of heart.
 Few now remember that the Huguenots,
 Whose very name's conundrum in the
 shows,
 Fled for their faith, and in their fleeing rose
 To prominence on foreign shores and
 market,
 Only to disappear with Cutty Sarkit.

22 And Jokin and men of Chozeba,
 Joash and Saraph *in gazeba*
 Over Moab, Jashubilehem,
 And ancient *are these things in hem*.
 23 These were the potters and those who
 Lived among plants and hedges too,
 There they lived with the king to do.
 24 The sons of Simeon: Nemuel,
 Jamin, Jarib, Zerah, Shaul.
 25 Shallum his son, who sired Mibsam,
 Who in his turn sired Mishma *lamb*.
 26 And the sons of Mishma: Hamuel
 His son, Zacchur his son *for gruel*
 And Shimei his son *on his stool*.
 27 And Shimei had sixteen sons and
 Six daughters, but his brothers' band
 Did not have many children, nor
 Did all their family *in store*
 Increase like Judah's folk *in score*.
 28 And they lived at Beersheba and
 Moladah, and Hazarshual's *strand*,
 29 And at Bilhah and at Ezem,
 And at Tolad, 30 Bethuel's *hem*,
 And at Hormah and at Ziklag,
 31 At Bethmarcaboth *raised a flag*,
 And Hazarsusim, Bethbirei,
 And at Shaaraim *making hay*.
 These were their cities to the reign
 Of David *the king without stain*.
 32 And their villages: Etam and
 Ain, Rimmon and Tochen and *land*
Of Asham, five towns *in a band*.
 33 And all their villages around
 About the same cities as found
 As far as Baal. These were their places
 Of dwelling and their families' races.

The sons of Shimei were sixteen and left
 A crowd of their descendants unbereft
 To fill so many cities right and left
 Till David came to reign after the theft
 Of throne of Saul. The brother of the man
 Had few descendants as if by the plan

Of fate or fortune or the universe
 Or You Yourself, I don't know which is
 worse.
 What tracks we leave beneath the burning
 sun!
 What tides come to cover them when
 we've done!
 Beloved, I follow all the lives of earth,
 Both those lifted to glory for their birth
 And those left behind as of little worth,
 And find but little difference in long run.

34 And Meshobab and Jamlech and
 Joshah Amaziah's son *grand*,
 35 And Joel and Jehu who was son
 Of Josibiah, who was son
 Of Seraiah, Asiel's son.
 36 And Elioenai, Jaakobah,
 And Jeshohaiah, Asaiah,
 And Adiel, Jesimiel,
 And Benaiah *to cast a spell*.
 37 And Ziza the son of Shiphi,
 The son of Allon, for a try
 The son of Jedaiah, the son
 Of Shimri of Shemaiah *done*.
 38 These mentioned by name were the
 chiefs
 In their families *for reliefs*,
 And their ancestors' house increased
 Abundantly *in hold and feast*.
 39 And they went to the going in
 Of Gedor on the eastern fin
 Of the valley to find a place
 To pasture their flocks *for a space*.
 40 And they found fat pasture and good,
 And the land was broad and as should
 Be quiet, in peace, for Ham's folk
 Had lived there once *beneath the oak*.
 41 And these written by name came by
 In days of Hezekiah's try
 As king of Judah, struck their tents
 And the houses found in presence
 Destroying them full to this day,
 And lived in their place, for the way
 There was pasture there for their flocks
Despite the desert sand and rocks.
 42 Of them, such as were Simeon's sons,
 Five hundred men went to *the runs*
Of Mount Seir under captains' voice
Of Pelatiah and the choice
 Neariah, and Rephaiah,
 And Uzziel, Ishi's sons' claw.

43 And they attacked *as well as raped*
Amelekites' rest who escaped
And stayed to live there *in that town*
To this *very day of renown*.

The sons of Simeon are like the father,
Full of attacking and give hardly bother
To perpetrate broad genocide on those
Who fill the land with idols in repose.
Shechem is gone, Amelekites as well
Fail before the cloud of fell Israel.
And even Judith in her fame and rights
Was counted once among the Simeonites.
Beloved, if I too have inherited
The tendencies of what my fathers did,
Let me too take no blame for when they
 slid,
But praise their worth when they remained
 to say
A gloried witness to Your oneness' way,
And so make place in fame a human day.

1 Chronicles 5

1 And the sons of Reuben firstborn
Of Israel, for he was firstborn,
But since he defiled father's bed,
His birthright was given when fled
To the sons of Joseph *who sped*
From Israel, so the family
Is not reckoned by birth's *degree*.
2 For Judah prevailed over his
Brothers, and from him *for his quiz*
Came he who is the prince, but still
The birthright was Joseph's *to fill*.
3 The sons of Reuben the first born
Of Israel: Hanoch *without scorn*,
And Pallu, Hezron and Carmi.

Four sons of Reuben, the one cast out for
Lurking behind his father's tent and door,
To take the prize in lust, still came to sire
Four sons with names of the gates to
 inquire.
Hanoch instructed in the law of God
Is brother to delight upon the sod
Of marvels set to find the third gate where
The walls enclose the fields of promised
 share
Until my vineyard, my grapeyard there set
Behind the sun-quenched stones in secret
 met
The gate of truth beyond the parapet

Of awareness in the mount's stony glare.
Reciting Reuben's sons' names brings me
 round
The secret glories found on sacred ground.

4 The sons of Joel where Shemaiah
His son, Gog his son, *not pariah*,
Shimei his son *above degree*,
5 Micah his son, Reaia his
Son, Baal his son, and *the whiz*
6 Beerah his son whom as captive
Tilgathpilneser come *to live*
As Assyrian king took *in fright*.
He was prince of the Reubenite.
7 His brothers by their families,
Generations' genealogies
Counted, the chief Jeiel, and
Zechariah, to fill the band
8 Bela son of Azaz, the son
Of Shema, son of Joel, who
Lived in Aroer, and up to
Nebo and Baalmeon *in view*.
9 And he lived eastward till you come
To the desert from river's hum
Of the Euphrates, since their cattle
Increased on land of Gilead's *rattle*.
10 And in the days of Saul they made
War on the Hagarites who stayed
Fallen beneath their hand, and they
Lived in their tents through all the sway
Of the east of Gilead's *way*.

Despite the Talmud I presume these must
Be Hagarites, Ishmaelites laid to dust.
I never thought so well of Saul that I
Expected but atrocities to buy
His time, despite excuse not to comply
With killing all when given commandment.
The Hagarite tents served king David well
When there was no place left for him to
 dwell
In all the land of frozen Israel.
Beloved, I plead for Hagarites, and yet
Deplore the sword and shield come out to
 get
Glories from murder on erected set.
In days of Saul or David, let me find
Peace and peace only on the divine mind.

11 And Gad's people lived close by them
In Bashan's land to Salchah's hem.
12 Joel the chief, and Shapham the next,

Jaanaï, Shaphat in Bashan flexed.
13 Their brothers from their fathers' house
Were Michael, Meshullam *and spouse*,
13 And Sheba and Jorai and Jachan,
Zia and Heber, seven *taken*.

The seven veils of pagan fame and blame
Are but the shadows of the real flame
That blinds the eye upon the screen
allowed
By which You guide in cinders and in
cloud.

The seven names retreat and then return
And find a place upon my breast to burn,
While days of light and dark meet sun and
moon

Where I peer from my windows after noon.
Beloved, I recite seven names and find
That I am still within the veils and blind,
But have at least the knowing that the kind
And gentle fruit that sways above the earth
Has something for my seeking and its
worth.

I turn returning and fall asleep soon.

14 These are the sons of Abihail
The son of Huri *without fail*
The son of Jaroah, the son
Of Gilead, *who was* the son
Of Micael, son of Jeshishai,
Son of Jahdo, Buz's son's *tie*.

15 Ahi the son of Abdiel,
The son of Guni *for a spell*
The chief of their ancestors' *well*.

16 And they lived in Gilead in
Bashan, and in its towns, and in
All the suburbs of Sharon round
Upon their borders *where they're found*.

I too live in the fatted Bashan's land
With Gilead about on every hand,
Looking down on fair Sharon with an eye
To see the ancestors fail to comply.
I too live in the lean and green land of
Bashan where all the cattle low with love,
Looking up to the racing heaven above,
And searching in the light with scarce a
sigh.

Beloved, when Bashan lights with
reticence
And wealth beside my poverty in pence
To find me living in last season's tents,

I turn to You once more and find the face
That hides from rush and practiced
marketplace.

I turn to You once more beneath the sky.

17 Their numberings all took place when
Jotham was king of Judah's men,
And in the days Jeroboam
Was king of Israel *and a ham*.

18 The sons of Reuben, the Gadites,
And half the tribe Manasseh *lights*
Of valiant men, men who could bear
Both shield and sword and shoot in air
With bow, and were skilful in war,
Forty-four thousand and three score
Above seven hundred out to war.

19 They made war on the Hagarites,
With Jetur, Nephish, Nodab's wights.
20 And they prevailed against them and
The Hagarites fell in their hand,
And all that were with them, for they
Cried to Alohîm in the way
Of battle, and He heard their call
Since they put trust in Him *and all*.

21 They took away their cattle and
Fifty thousand camels in band,
Two hundred fifty thousand sheep,
Two thousand donkeys, *hear them weep*,
A hundred thousand men *to stand*.
22 Many fell down dead since the battle
Was of Alohîm *and His rattle*,
And they lived in their place instead
Until the captivity *spread*.

The conflict between Jew and Arab started
Before the Balfour declaration parted.
Perhaps the battle went well because those
Who fought fought bravely and with good
plans chose

Their strategy and remained on their toes.
Why say that victory came from Allah?
Does Allah defend one against the claw
Of other, while both shout that He is one?
Just say they put the fellows on the run.
Too often men see Your hand in success
When You would rather seek the right
address

And tell the wights to obey Your command
Not to kill or steal from the barren land.
I trow the place continues in a mess.

23 The folk of Manasseh's half tribe

Lived in the land *without a bribe*
 And increased from Bashan as far
 As Baalhermon and Senir's *bar*
 And Mount Hermon *to go by car*.
 24 These were the heads of every house
 Of their ancestors, *pant and blouse*,
 Ephraim and Ishi, Eliel,
 And Azriel and Jeremiah,
 And Hodaviah, Jahdiel,
 Great men courageous, men of fame,
 Heads of their fathers' house *by name*.
 25 They sinned against the Alohim
 Of their ancestors, *it would seem*,
 And went to spend on prostitutes
 Of other gods in the land's suits
 Whom Alohim slew before them.
 26 The Alohim of Israel
 Stirred up the intent of the fell
 Pul king of Assyria and
 The mind of Tilgathpileser
 King of Assyria's *broad land*,
 And he took them away, the band
 Of Reubenites as well as *fair*
 Gadites and half the tribe of *where*
 The Manassites *lived*, brought them to
 Halah and Habor and *the view*
 Of Hara and River Gozan
 Unto this day *and to a man*.

See what I mean? Why pretend Hagarite
 Is given by the hand of God and might
 To tribes to possess their tent and their
 right,
 When the possessor himself fails to light
 A witness against gross idolatry,
 But goes out in the heathen pageantry
 To lust and luff beneath the sacred tree?
 Why bring Pul in the plot when Ishmaelite
 Is sitting wounded from the horrid fight?
 Beloved, I turn from every explanation
 Of warfare given from the divine station
 And see it as a heathen expiation.
 I turn me from the great ungodly sight.

1 Chronicles 6

1 The sons of Levi: Gershon and
 Kohath and Merari in band.
 2 The sons of Kohath: Amram and
 Izhar, Hebron, Uzziel's stand.
 3 The offspring children of Amram:
 Aaron, and Moses, and Miriam.

If ever there was holy trinity,
 Aaron, Moses and Miriam make three.
 Let no one take a favorite and leave
 The other two beside the well to grieve,
 But love all three like Ahmed and Ali
 And love still more each divine guide set
 free.
 The holy hope of Aaron was not lost
 On Miriam as a child who came and
 bossed,
 Nor was the cry of Moses once drawn out
 In vain in hear of Pharaoh's daughter's
 clout.
 Beloved, I love the running feet in sand
 That warn of Miriam's approach at hand,
 The laughing call of growing Aaron's
 voice
 To make of Moses at last divine choice.

The sons also of Aaron are
 Nadab, Abihu, Eleazar,
 And finally one Ithamar.
 4 Eleazar sired Phinehas, who
 Sired Abishua, 5 Abishu
 Sired Bukki, and Bukki sired Uzzi,
 6 Zerariah was son of Uzzi,
 And father to one Meraioth,
 7 Meraioth fathered Amariah,
 And Amariah without oath
 Begat Ahitub *as one higher*.
 And Ahitub fathered Zadok,
 And Zadok Ahimaaz in stock.
 9 And Ahimaaz sired Azariah,
 And Azariah sired Johanan.
 10 And Johanan began *the canon*
 By siring Azariah who
 Was the priest in the temple *crew*
 That Solomon built *in the view*
 Jerusalem *springs up on cue*.

From Aaron fourteen generations' stroke
 Come down to Solomon whose temple
 woke
 The wonder and the love of humankind
 More awed by architecture and the rind
 Than by Your still small voice in temple
 set
 Of time alone within Sabbath once met.
 From Aaron fourteen generations make
 A pathway through the narrow earthly
 stake
 To set the desert once behind in wake

And see the spires Jerusalem can rake.
Beloved, twice seven in perfection rise
From Aaron to serve You beneath the skies
Until the temple fail of gold and pot
And generations return to the rot.

11 And Azariah sired one higher
Amariah, and Amariah
Fathered Ahitub at a walk.
12 And Ahitub fathered Zadok,
And Zadok fathered Shallum's stock.
13 And Shallum begat one Hilkiah
And Hilkiah sired Azariah.
14 And Azariah sired Seraiah,
Seraiyah begat Jehozadak.
15 Jehozadak then lost his track
When YHWH took Judah and *the star*
Jerusalem by hand *not slack*
Of *the grim* Nebuchadnezzar.

From Solomon to Nebuchadnezzar
Is only nine in priestly gaze and star,
While kings fall thicker by the scythe of
time.

Priest or king, I prefer merely to rhyme.
Yet priest is more like to live in his fame
Than king so often murdered as in blame.
The hierarchy and dynasty fall fast
Beneath the wailing stars in autumn cast.
Beloved, I count the generations down
To dusty Zion and put off the crown
To pray beneath the domes set in renown
Where Solomon built temple for the gear
And for the worship of the rounding year
Until Nebuchadnezzar came in fear.

16 The sons of Levi: Gershom and
Kohath and Merari *in band*.
17 These are the names of Gershom's sons:
Libni and Shimei *on their buns*.
18 And the sons of Kohath: Amram,
And Izhar and Hebron and ham
Uzziel. 19 The sons of Merari:
Mahli and Mushi, *no Ferrari*.
And these are the families *in song*
Of the Levites to run along
By their ancestors *without wrong*.
20 Of Gershom: Libni was his son,
And Jahath came as next son won,
Then Zimmah was his son *for third*
Generation after the word.
21 Joah was his son, *who then sired*

Iddo his son, *who was not fired*
Before begetting Zerah who
Was his son, to increase the crew
Jeaterai his son *was born*.

The seven generations that come down
From Gershom set Friday night on the
town.

Libni come out from clarity and bright,
And casts a ray that penetrates with light
The silken covering that makes the world
A place of shadows when the cloak's
unfurled.

The seven generations that release
The flood of knowledge to the world in
peace

Rend all the curtains that from my cocoon
I spin for death trap of the slivered moon.
Beloved, the seven followed paths return
And all find faith upon the earthen burn
Where lady's mantle, shaken with the dew
Remembers and remembers YHWH and
YHWH.

22 The sons of Kohath: his son *came*
Amminadab *was chosen name*,
Korah his son, Assir his son,
23 Elkanah his son, *once begun*
Came Ebiasaph his son *too*
And then Assir his son *in view*,
24 Tahath his son, Uriel his
Son, Uziah his son *to quiz*,
And Shaul his son, *the end of biz*.

Ten generations meet the Decalogue
In every turn I take from bird and frog
Of Genesis, and now I see them rate
In generations ten before the gate
Of law and love and knowing to the state
Of truth Yourself where there's no longer
mate.

The sons of Kohath in their running stream
Take up the song of sun and moon and
beam

Until the whirling dance returns to dawn
And I awaken at the hope of spawn.
Ten generations and ten words be true
That lead me through the winding ways to
view

The lake and islands that awaken dream
And fill my soul and self with Alohim.

25 The sons of Elkanah *where both*
Amasai and *then* Ahimoth.

26 Elkanah, sons of Elkanah,
Zophai his son, who *by due law*
Begot Nahath, 27 who *in his turn*
Sired Eliab, whose son *I learn*
Was Jeroham, whose son as well
Was Elkanah. 28 And Samuel
Had sons: the firstborn was Vashni,
And then Abiah *by and by*.

Vashni and Abiah, two sons of fame
Are written here as though they bore no
blame.

But Samuel strode the path that Ali swore
Should never be trodden down anymore
And saw his sons like mirrors of that priest
Who left the halls of justice once increased
In witness that no alcohol should smell
Upon the lips of any who prayed well.
Beloved, Vashni and Abiah were born
With hope and yet they lived to find their
scorn.

Let me die, my Beloved, before my name
Is told with Abiah to Vashni's shame,
And I shall live to raise a gentle spark
In sacrifice at gate of Eden's park.

29 And then the sons of Merari:
Mahli, who had a son Libni,
Whose son was Shimei, who begat
Uzza, 30 whose son Shimea *sat*
And had a son Haggai who
Begot Asaiah *before through*.

So many names of priests and Levites sit
Upon my tongue, and yet even more fit
From Adam, Noah, Abraham and one
Drawn from the river, Moses, not yet done
Till David, Jesus, Muhammad have run.
The divine guides from Ali and Hasan
To Husayn, Zaynul Abideen the man
To sire Baqir, then Sadiq, Musa and
Ridha, Taqi, Naqi up to the hand
Of Askeri until the Mahdi stand.
May Hajji Bektash with his glowing brand
Show me the congregation and the band
Who come to raise the soul and heart and
eye

Before Your throne, Beloved, of earth and
sky.

31 These are the ones that David set
Over the music service met
In YHWH's house after the ark came
To have rest *in YHWH's blessed name*.

32 They ministered before the place
Of dwelling tent assembling face
With singing until Solomon
Had built the house of YHWH and won
Jerusalem, and then they waited
At their post by their cycles stated.

33 And these are those that waited by
Their families. Of offspring nigh
To Kohathites, Heman a singer,
The son of Joel *for a swinger*,
The son of Shemuel, 34 the son
Of Elkanah, who was *when done*
The son of Jeroham, the son
Of Eliel, the son of Toah.

35 The son of Zuph *then came to show her*
The son of Elkanah, the son
Of Mahath, who *then won*
Being of Amasai the son,

36 Who was the son of Elkanah,
The son of Joel, *who by law*
Was son of Azariah, son
Of Zephaniah *on the run*,

37 The son of Tahath, Assir's son,
The son of Ebiasaph who
Was son of Korah *in his due*,

38 The son of Ishar, Kohath's son,
The son of Levi who was son
Of Israel, *that's Jacob done*.

Is music such a thing of genes and fruit
Of family that all must hit the boot
Who are named Bach or Heman or
Kohath?

Surely, Beloved, You protract no such
wrath.

I too am a descendant of the ways
Who played the fiddle in their roundelays
As long as fiddles have been of account.
It's hidden German ancestry in fount,
Though not the very family, I trow,
Of Bach beneath the sullen sky and plough.
I lift a family voice to praise Your name
In Hebrew and in Arabic for shame
Not to have all the skill my name implies
Beneath a thousand greys of rain-soaked
skies.

39 And his brother Asaph who stood

On his right hand, Asaph the good
 Son of Berachiah the son
 Of Shimea, 40 who was the son
 Of Michael, son of Baaseiah,
 Who himself was son of Malchiah,
 41 The son of Ethni, son of Zerah,
 The son of Adaiah *to bear her*,
 42 The son of Ethan, Zimmah's boy
 The son of Shimei *come for joy*,
 43 The son of Jahath, Gersom's lad,
 The son of Levi, *not too bad*.
 44 And their brothers, Merari's sons
 On the left hand *stood on their buns*:
 Ethan the son of Kishi who
 Was Abdi's son, the heir in due
 Of Malluch, 45 son of Hashabiah,
 Who was the son of Amaziah,
 Who was the son of one Hilkiyah,
 46 Who was himself son of Amzi,
 The male offspring on one Bani,
 Son of Shamer, 47 son of Mahli,
 Son of Mushi, son of Merari,
 The son of Levi not contrary.
 48 Their brothers also the Levites
 Appointed to all kinds of rites
 In service of the tent's *espouse*
That finally was Alohim's house.

There are more singers with their harps
 than names
 Of other sons to perform other frames.
 Let there be singers more to cite Your
 word
 In cantillation before hearts that stirred!
 And yet I look upon the craven sea
 In its commotion out of every lea,
 And find that priests and bishops sacrifice
 The blood and flesh while singers are not
 nice.
 The hand drum and the organ all conspire
 To praise human ambition and retire
 The simple lays of psalm upon my breast.
 Beloved, I search in vain to hear the best
 Except in my own bowing to repeat
 The Hebrew melodies before Your feet.

49 And Aaron and his sons were proffering
 Upon the altar of burnt offering
 And on the altar of incense
 For all the work in recompense
 Most holy, to make atonement
 For Israel by all that went

From Moses slave of Alohim
 By his command *and in his scheme*.

Do offerings truly make atonement now,
 The burning flesh, the flowing blood
 somehow?
 The dying sun-god in his crimson vest
 Painting the sky of both the east and west,
 The resurrecting son returning to
 The queen of heaven with naked breast in
 view,
 The bread up-crossed and lanced, the
 dripping cup,
 The gallant gushing blood of sheep and
 tup,
 Do these atone, Beloved? Does sacrifice
 Of divine sons on crosses in a trice
 Turn wickedness to sainthood, tell the
 truth?
 Beloved, I rely on such things uncouth
 As cantillating psalms and bowing down
 In my repenting soul before the crown.

50 And these the sons of Aaron be:
 Eleazar his son faithfully,
 And his son Phinehas whose son
 Was Abishua, and when done
 51 His son was Bukki, Uzzi his
 Son, Zerahiah his son's whiz,
 52 Meraioth his son, Amariah,
 Ahitub his son, one on fire,
 53 Zadok his son, Ahimaaz
 His son, and that is all he has.
 54 And these are places where they lived
 By their encampments chosen, sieved,
 Of Aaron's sons and families
 Of Kohathites, their lots to please.
 55 And they gave them Hebron there in
 The land of Judah's kith and kin,
 And all the suburbs round its din.
 56 But the fields of the city and
 Its villages they gave in hand
 To Caleb the son of Jephunneh.
 57 To Aaron's sons they gave then sooner
 The towns of Judah, Hebron which
 Was a town of refuge from ditch,
 And Libnah with its villages,
 Jattir, Eshtemoa, that is,
 Also with all their villages,
 58 And Hilen with its suburbs and
 Debir with the surrounding land,
 59 And Ashan with its villages,

Bethshemesh with its villages,
60 And out of Benjamin's tribe, Geba
With open land about zareba,
And Alemeth with alentours.
All their towns and all their allures
Throughout their *many* families
Were thirteen cities *fit to please*.

Caleb sits in the middle of the priests
And prophets as a warrior brave in feasts.
He did not fear the sons of Anak nor
The locusts and grasshoppers on the shore.
He did not fear the grape two men could
grasp
And carry down the mountain with a gasp.
He did not fear his own heart nor the hand
Of his own people risen up in band
To stone him for his faith that You would
go

Before the fleeing sons of Israel's show.
Beloved, the tent of Caleb and his tower
Stand in the middle of the priestly power
To show that faith alone at such an hour
Is all a man can ever need to know.

61 And to the sons of Kohath left
Of that tribe's family unbereft
Out of the half tribe, the half left
Of Manasseh by lot they cleft
Ten cities *both the warp and weft*.
62 And to the sons of Gershom through
All their families set in due
Out of the tribe of Issachar,
Out of the family of Asher,
Out of the clans of Naphtali,
Out of Manasseh's Bashan's pie
Thirteen cities *to dignify*.
63 To Merari's sons by lot through
Their families given in crew
Out of the tribe of Reuben and
Out of the tribe of Gad to stand,
And from the tribe of Zebulun,
Twelve cities *rich and full of fun*.
64 The children of Israel gave to
The Levites cities with their crew.
65 They gave by lot out of the tribe
Of Judah's children *as for bribe*,
And out of Simeon's offspring's tribe,
And out of the tribe of the sons
Of Benjamin, cities *by tons*,
Each called by name *and benisons*.

The tribe of Simeon has left the town
For shame of every father and his frown
Because of violence once sitting down
In Shechem with Levi to take the crown.
Now Levi's own descendants come to take
A place and plot in Simeon's last stake
As though in comfort for the sighs they
make
To give the downcast mind and heart a
shake.
Beloved, send some sweet singer to my
nest
And give my aching throat a time to rest
From singing Psalms in Hebrew at my
best.
Beloved, send some child of Levi to bring
Fresh courage to my heart and let it sing
Again of Kauthar in the heavening spring.

66 The families of Kohath's sons had
Cities to border on the glad
Tribe of Ephraim *solid and plaid*.
67 They gave them refuge cities too,
Shechem in mount Ephraim with crew,
And Gezer with its suburbs too,
68 And Jokmeam with land about,
And Bethhoron and suburbs stout,
69 And Aijalon with villages,
And Gathrimmon with froth and fizz,
70 And out of half tribe Manasseh,
Aner with its surrounding brae,
And Bileam with its suburbs,
For the clan left of Kohath's burbs.
71 To Gershom's sons out of the clan
Of Manasseh's half tribe *to scan*,
Golan in Bashan with its fields,
And Ashtaroth with its lands' yields.
72 Out of the tribe of Issachar,
Kedesh with its surroundings far,
Daberath with village *and car*.
73 And Ramoth with its lands about
And Anem with suburbs in route.
74 And out of Asher's tribe, Mashal
With its surroundings prodigial,
And Abdon with its villages,
75 And Hukok with privileges,
And Rehob with its suburbs *set*.
76 And out of Naphtali's tribe *met*
Kedesh in Galilee *and wet*,
And Hammon with her lands about,
And Kirjathaim with fields *and shout*.

I seek the cities given to the horde
For refuge from the bright avenging sword,
For refuge from the threat of rising dawn
That speaks across the lakes and islands on
My waking and my dream of faithful
spawn.

I seek the cities fortified from attack
Of wrathful ones come out to steel my
back,
For refuge from the hope of the daylight,
For refuge from the softness of the night
That covers wickedness from my last sight.
Beloved, the villages upon the shore
Of Kadesh and Ramoth attract me more
Than Rome and Athens, more than Paris
too,
Despite the Notre Dame that breaks the
view.

77 To what's left of Merari's sons
Out of the tribe of Zebulun's,
Rimmon with its surrounding lands,
Tabor with villages and stands,
78 And on the other side where flows
Jordan that runs by Jericho's
East side, of Jordan, out of the
Tribe of Reuben, Bezer to see
In the desert with lands about,
And Jahzah with village in route,
79 Kedemoth also with its lands,
And Mephaath with views and commands.
80 Out of the tribe of Gad, Ramoth
In Gilead, outlying growth,
And Mahanaim with angel stairs,
81 And Heshbon with its hidden lairs,
And Jazer *where the green field bears*.

Merari's sons remain to sing the praise
Of Jordan and of Jericho in ways
That join the reapers in their swing of arms
And sickle lent to keep from all the harms
Of famine that would raise children's
alarms.

Merari's sons stay where the river flows
Beside the plain of Jericho and goes
Past En Gedi beneath the hopeless rows
Of salty sea and bloom-embossed clift
stones.

Merari's sons have songs instead of
thrones.

Let me, Beloved, join with Merari's folk
To lift with song the heavy, wooden yoke

That leads the plough around the stretching
oak
And unearths on its way lost human bones.

1 Chronicles 7

1 The sons of Issachar were Tola
And Puah, Jashub, Shimron, four.
2 And finally the sons of Tola
Were Uzzi and Rephaiah's store,
And Jeriel and Jahmai and
Jibsam and Shemuel in band
Heads of their father's house and land,
Of Tola, mighty men and bold
In all the stories that are told,
Whose number in David's fair day
Was two and twenty thousand sway
And six hundred *soldiers in pay*.
3 And the sons of Uzzi are next,
Izrahiah, the sons perplexed
Of Izrahiah: Michael and
Obadiah, and Joel and
Ishaiah, five, all of them chief
Men of the people for relief.
4 And with them, by their generations,
After the house of fathers' stations,
Their soldier bands for war six and
Thirty thousand, and in their band
Were many wives and children grand.
5 Their brother of the families
Of Issachar mighty ferlies,
Counted by genealogies,
Eighty-seven thousand to please.

Issachar has his thousands of fine men,
But not a soul of woman's named again
Of all the band of many wives and more,
The children sitting by the flocked tent-
door.

Issachar has his thousands on the field
And in the villages now long since healed
From battle with the Amoritic host
Who came out with their own flash and
their boast.

Beloved, I read the silver names and hear
Michael and Joel falling on my ear
From times long past to live again, I fear,
Within the cabined stretch of northern lake
And fir above the pine, and birch to wake.
Let them not think that there is some
mistake.

6 Of Benjamin: Bela, Becher,

And Jediael, the three to share.
 7 The sons of Bela, Ezbon and
 Uzzi, Uzziel and the grand
 Jerimoth and Iri, all five
 Heads of their fathers' house alive,
 Great men of courage, counted by
 Their genealogies not shy
 Of twenty-two thousand and thirty-
 Four men armoured, panted and shirty.
 8 The sons of Becher: Zemira,
 And Joash and Eliezer,
 And Elioenai, Omri,
 And Jerimoth as well to be
 Abiah and Anathoth and
 Alameth: all Becher's sons grand.
 9 Number by genealogy
 By generations of the free
 Heads of their fathers' house, great men
 Of courage, twenty thousand then
 And two hundred *to ride again*.

Becher the young camel, or in the weight
 Of Islam camel's father, nine sons late
 With meanings all: the pruning, trimming
 psalm,
 And Jah has given, and God help the balm,
 Toward God are my eyes, and Jah gives
 out,
 The Heights, Jah is a father, without doubt
 The Answers are found where the Hidden
 one
 Lies, such are the names of Becher's each
 son.
 Beloved, the cycle shares the secret spent
 Of Becher's love and life, and where he
 went.

I follow that fair faith of hymn to find
 You giving, helping, at my eyes unblind,
 Apportioning the heights, a father's care
 To give the hidden answers as my share.

10 The sons of Jediael too:
 Bilhan to mention just a few;
 The sons of Bilhan: Jeush and
 Benjamin and Ehud to stand
 With Chenaanah and Zethan and
 Tharshish and Ahishahar's band.
 11 All these sons of Jediael
 By chiefs of their fathers and well
 Great men of courage, seventeen
 Thousand and two hundred and keen
 For war and battle on the scene.

12 Shuppim also and the Huppim,
 The children of Ir and Hushim,
 The sons of Aher and the cream.
 13 The sons of Naphtali: Jahziel,
 Guni and Jezer and appeal
 To Shallum, the sons of Bilhah,
Name for both foolishness by law.
 14 The sons of Manasseh, Ashriel
 Whom she bore, but his concubelle
 The Aramitess bore Machir
 The father of Gilead's fear.
 15 And Machir took a wife in awe
 Of Huppim and Shuppim by claw
 Whose sister's name, it was Maacah,
 The name of the second was glad
 To be at last Zelophehad,
 Zelophehad sired daughters sad.

It always comes out with a jubilee
 Of shout that Zelophehad's daughters' fee
 Was to inherit with the men their plot
 So that their father's name not be forgot.
 I too, Beloved, raise single voice to show
 The justice of the way You chose to go,
 But make complaint again that You did not
 Defend them till they themselves fired a
 shot.

The hope of Gilead is one to reign
 Even when dearth appears upon the plain,
 And all seems lost if not because the sons
 Failed from the hearth, but because in its
 tons
 Troubles arise on every hand to spark
 A fearsome twinkle in the land of dark.

16 And Maachah wife of Machir bore
 A son and called his name to score
 Peresh, and the name of his brother
 Was Shersh to rhyme with the other,
 And his sons were Ulam, Rakem.
 17 And the sons of Ulam, ahem,
 Were just one and only Bedan.
 There were the sons down to a man
 Of Gilead, the son by plan
 Of Machir, Manasseh's son's fan.
 18 and his sister Hammoleketh
 Bore Ishod, Abiezer's breath
 And Mahalah *before her death*.
 19 And the sons of Shemida were
 Ahian and Shechem to stir
 And Likhi and Aniam fer.
 20 And the sons of Ephraim came,

Shuthelah, and Bered by name
 His son, and then Tahath his son,
 And Eladah his son begun,
 And then again Tahath his son,
 21 And Zabad his son and again
 Shuthelah his son in his den
 And Ezer and Elead then,
 Whom the Gathites born in the land
 Killed because they came down in band
 To steal their cattle from their hand.
 22 Their father Ephraim stayed to mourn
 For many days and his forlorn
 Brothers came down to comfort him.
 23 When he went to his wife in trim,
 She conceived and bore a son and
 He named him Beriah to stand
 For the plague on his house and grim.
 24 And his daughter was Sherah who
 Built Bethhoron the lower too,
 As well as upper, Uzzensherah.

The ear of Sherah heard the call to build
 Bethhoron and Uzzensherah by skilled
 Labour across the laden valley filled
 With harvest of grape, barley, olive, wheat.
 The ear of Sherah, why so named a treat?
 The upper town is called by such a name
 That makes me wonder till I feel my
 shame.
 My shame's not only that I don't recall
 Why such a name show grace a fine town
 hall,
 But also that it seems in all the years
 That Christians have named children in
 their fears
 And hopes that Bible names will bless their
 young,
 Sherah is not a name on any tongue.
 Perhaps somewhere that blessed name
 appears.

25 And Rephah was his son as well,
 Also Resheph and Telah's tell
 His son, Tahan his son as well.
 26 And Laadan his son, Ammihud
 His son, Elishama the good
 His son, Nun his son, Jehoshua,
 His son *the famous one, no fewer.*

Ammihud ben Laadan could never guess
 That his name would one day fit the
 address

Of those who bless and curse because of
 mess
 Upon the native shore that once was sold
 For beads of brass and glass instead of
 gold.

Ammihud ben Laadan is just a name
 Among the genealogies of fame
 Lost in the Scriptures that are never read
 Upon the Sabbath day for those who're fed
 On cantillation of the sacred key.
 Few but myself turn to its melody
 And sing forgotten names as I return
 To bow before the throne for what I earn
 On lichen-covered granite under tree.

1 Chronicles 8

1 Now Benjamin produced Bela
 His firstborn, Ashbel a fellow
 To be the second, Aharah
 The third, 2 Nohah the fourth, and then
 Rapha the fifth. 3 The sons *again*
 Of Bela *were* Addar, Gera,
 Abihud, 4 Abishua, and
 Naaman, Ahoah, 5 Gera's stand,
 Shephuphan, and Hiram in hand.
 6 These *are* the sons of Ehud, who
 Were chiefs of the fathers' clans by
 The dwellers of Geba and nigh,
 And who forced them to move away
 To Manahath *on one sad day*:
 7 Naaman, Ahijah, and Gera
 Aho forced to move *outside law*.
 He produced Uzza, Ahihud.
 8 And Shaharaim had *when he could*
 Children in Moab's land, after
 He'd sent away Hushim and *her*
Companion Baara, his *two* wives.
 9 By Hodesh his wife he *contrives*
 To produce Jobab, Zibia, *and*
 Mesha, Malcam, 10 Jeuz *to stand*,
 Sachiah, and Mirmah. These *were*
 His sons, chiefs of their fathers' *stir*.

My plaint is for Hushim and Baara who
 Were wives together and made up the two
 Who first gave Shaharaim a place in view.
 The failure of good men in gratitude
 To women who give them both love and
 brood
 Is credible, yes, but I don't approve
 Of men who tire of wives and make a
 move.

My plaint is for Hushim and Baara when
They were rejected from the world of men
And left sequestered who knows where to
wait

For death since life had passed them by in
fate.

Beloved, my plaint goes up today to You
Despite the fact the principles are dead,
I still hold up their case to fountain-head.

11 And by Hushim he had produced
Abitub and Elpaal *reduced*.

12 The sons of Elpaal *were* Eber,
Misham, and Shemed, ones who were
To build Ono and Lod along
With its towns, 13 and Beriah *strong*
And Shema, who *were* chiefs of their
Fathers' *clans* of the dwellers, *fair*
Of Aijalon, who drove out from
Gath its inhabitants to come.

Elpaal means God has wrought and so I
find

No fault with the name. I am disinclined
To love the name Abitub, which I think
May mean my father's good, if my own
link

To understanding Hebrew fails me not.
It was a disappointment in the plot.
My dad is good? And yet he left the mother
And went off to bed and breed with
another.

Did Shaharaim himself pick out the name?
Or was the mother's hopefulness to blame?
I do not know, and yet I think the claim
Less than the truth, considering that he
Left two wives empty and went on the
spree.

Beloved, judge now between these folks
and me.

14 As well as Ahio, Shashak,
And Jeremoth to lead the pack,
15 And Zebadiah, and Arad,
And Ader, 16 Michael *not half bad*,
And Ispah, Joha, and the sons
Of Beriah, 17 And Zebadiah,
And Meshullam a hardy flier,
And Hezeki, and Heber too,
18 Ishmerai also, and the crew
Of Jezliah, Jobab, the sons
Of Elpaal come in their tons,

19 And Jakim, Zichri, and Zabdi,

20 And Elienai and the free
Zilthai and Eliel 21 and still
Adaiah, Beraiah to fill

The list with Shimrath, the sons all
Of Shimhi, 22 And Ishpan to call

Heber and Eliel, 23 Abdon,
Zichri, Hanan, and before run
Hananaiah and Elam and

Antothijah to make a stand,

25 And Iphedeiah, Penuel,
The sons of Shashak for a spell.

26 And Shamsherai, and Shehariah,

Coming all up to Athaliah,
27 And Jaresiah, and Eliah,
And Zichri, sons of Jeroham.

28 These were the heads of fathers' scam
By generations and the chief,
Lived in Jerusalem's relief.

Zichri may be my male or souvenir,
As I climb off my well-washed Sabbath
bier

To dance with the momento that I fear
To face throughout the week in labour
clear.

Zichri reminds me with a virile arm
To stop after six days of doing harm
Or gathering the wheat in bin and coil
To eat from my own and from others' toil.
Beloved, remind me every hour to come
Back to Your keeping and to count the sum
Of my days male and minding while the
week

Sinks into memories that I may seek
As old age looks to You to mind the way
That You are the bright light of every day.

29 At Gibeon there lived and dwelt
The father of Gibeon svelt,
Whose wife's name was Maachah, 30 and
his

Firstborn son Abdon was a whiz,
And Zur and Kish and Baal, Nadab,
31 And Gedor *with the gift of gab*,
And Ahio and Zacher's *flab*.

32 And Mikloth sired Shimeah, and
These also lived there in the land
Of Jerusalem with the band
Of their brothers, near by at hand.

33 And Ner begot Kish, Kish begot
Saul and Saul Jonathan *in slot*,

Machishua, Abinadab,
And Eshbaal *to win a crab*.

With Ner and Kish and Saul I find
The genealogy of good and kind
The favourite, my Jonathan who sees
That David's the one above all to please.
I wonder what I would have done with
those

Two lovers if I'd live among and chose
To find them panting on the arrowed field.
Instead I live among the brightly steeled.
At least warfare is something we have got
In common with that ancient loving lot.
The battle and the song are of one plot,
The harp and javelin sing at the ear
Though David and his Jonathan, no fear,
Rest in their genealogies now healed.

34 The son of Jonathan to come
Was Meribbaal, and *at a hum*
Meribbaal sired Micah *first*.
35 The sons of Micah *were not worst*:
Pithon, Melech, Tarea and
Ahaz. 36 And Ahaz sired first-hand
Jehoadah, Jehoadah
Sired Alemeth by hook or claw
And Azmaveth and Zimri too,
And Zimri sired Moza *and crew*,
37 And Moza sired Binea too,
Rapha was his son and the next
Eleasah his son *unvexed*,
And Azel his son *least perplexed*.

The last of four was Ahaz, but the first
And only to be listed with the burst
Of genealogy and siring sport.
I see the spires of Moza's dark-lanced fort.
So Moza is the lineage and a find
Upon the plain of sires and sons to bind
The strong perhaps in Binea, since the
weak
Is found in Rapha as lineages seek.
Beloved, my right hand and my left are
strong
To do the right and sometimes do the
wrong,
And yet I too look to the younger son
When my path of blessing on earth is done,
And take Jacob, Rapha and the left hand
And turn upon the dizzied floor to stand.

38 And Azel had six sons in all
Whose names are these *writ on the wall*:
Azrikam, Bocheru, Ishmael,
And Sheariah *for a spell*,
And Obadiah and Hanan.
All these the sons of Azel *man*.
39 And the sons of Eshek his brother:
Ulam his firstborn and another
Jehush, the third Eliphelet.
40 The sons of Ulam don't forget
Were great men of courage to shoot
With bows and arrows and astute,
And they had many sons and sons'
Sons, hundred and fifty, *it stuns*.
All these are Benjamin's *bright* sons.

He set aside a shade next to the wall
Of six sons born to battle and to call
To life and birth and courage for the fall
Until Ulam's offspring learned how to
shoot
And every foe fell down dead in his boot.
Why not a seventh son to meet the tall
And full measure of hope in number's
game?
I should not stop at six, Beloved, for
shame,
But go on to the seventh in the flame
Of love and heat and light until the name
Of seven stood against the dead of night.
Beloved, I look about with pen to write
The names of six or seven of the right
And find only One and yet out of sight.

1 Chronicles 9

1 All Israel were accounted for
By genealogical score,
And inscribed in the book of kings
Of Israel and Judah, till things
Got bad and they were carried off
To Babylon for wicked scoff.
2 The first inhabitants that sat
In their own lots in their towns' flat
Where Israelites, the priests, Levites,
The Nethinim *in their own rights*.

My promise is to lack to meet the twelves
Come out to dance with demons and with
elves
Even if ten commandments do not make
Length and width enough for my harried
stake.

When with one more I fill the ninth room
 here
 Along the battlement of namely gear,
 I sink my teeth in roasted meat and try
 Not to gloat over every passer-by.
 Some love the word and some would rather
 die
 For faith or quaint belief about the gum.
 Only a slight harmony or a hum
 Likes to return to honey on the sty.
 Long have I tried to meet my promises,
 Yet criticism strikes both hers and his.

3 And in Jerusalem their lived
 Of Judah's folk and the folk sieved
 Of Benjamin, and Ephraim
 And Manasseh *all safe and trim*.
 4 Uthai the son of Ammihud,
 The son of Omri and the bud
 Of Imri, the son of Bani,
 Of Pharez' children *on a spree*
 The son of Judah *and grand prix*.

Uthai may be a foreign name, who knows?
 At least I find no meaning where it shows.
 Ammihud may have tired of the weight
 Of splendour to carry a name so great.
 If my folk were so glorious, I think
 I should have no complaint upon the brink,
 But would give lovely names to all my
 brood
 To keep them off the ways and words of
 crude.
 But to each be his own, I fry my wealth
 In words without, without meaning in
 stealth,
 Until I find that all words lead to one
 And all lay down the crown when they
 have done.
 Beloved, I search Uthai for meaning till
 The last lamp goes extinguished on the hill.

5 And from the Shilonites: Asaiah
 The first born and his sons *and crier*.
 6 And of the sons of Zerah *feinty*,
 Jeuel and co. six hundred ninety.
 7 And from the sons of Benjamin,
 Sallu the son of Meshullam,
 The son *and crew* of Hodaviah,
 Who was the son of Hasenuah,
 8 And Ibneiah the *faithful* son
 Of Jeroham, and Elah son

Of Uzzi, the son of Michri,
 And Meshullam in son's degree
 Of Shephathiah who was son
 Of Reuel Ibnijah's son *done*,
 9 And their brothers in generations,
 Nine hundred fifty-six in stations.
 All these men *were* chief of the fathers
 In the house *and land* of their fathers.

Four lacking from a thousand, I relate.
 I know the feeling of not being great.
 Four lacking of the thousand at the gate
 Until the brothers rise in a new state,
 The world whirls on while on the floor
 The soul seems to give style to nothing
 more
 Than being and in silence makes a break
 For yonder timber and the crystal stake.
 Beloved I wander in the four gates too,
 And search out many lovely things to do
 As long as mischief is not of my pew.
 I wander in the four until I find
 Nine hundred ninety-six to make me blind
 To forty whirling in the unrefined.

10 And of the priests: Jedaiah and
 Jehoiarib and Jachin's hand,
 11 Azariah son of Hilkiah,
 Meshullam's son and first desire,
 The son of Zadok, Meraioth's
 Son, son of Ahitub in growths
 The ruler of the house of God.
 12 And Adaiah Jeroham's son,
 The son of Pashur, who was son
 Of Malchijah and Maasiai,
 The son of Adiel, the guy
 Was son of Jahzerah, the son
 Of Meshullam, who was the son
 Of Meshillemith, *who when done*
Was son of Immer *on the run*.
 13 And their brothers, the heads of house
 Of their fathers *both cock and grouse*,
 A thousand seven hundred and
 Sixty and very ably manned
 For the work of worship within
 The house of Alohim with din.

To her the jewel of eternity,
 Adaiah sits alone beneath the tree
 And shares with lists of sons his golden
 store
 Of promises and wishes at the door.

To her the jewel of eternity,
 What name is that that lets my soul go free
 To wander stony paths till every shore
 Appears to go on and for evermore?
 Let me, Beloved, try for the thousand
 manned
 And seven hundred of courageous band
 To find the sixty waiting at the stand.
 Let me, Beloved, whirl on the whitened
 sand
 Until the work of worship rises up
 In sounds of lowing oxen and of tup.

14 And from the Levites: Shemaiah
 The son of Hasshub, sin-in-claw
 Of Azrikam, Hashabiah's
 Son, of sons of Merari's *laws*.
 15 And Bakbakkar, Herish, Galal,
 And Mattaniah, *worth his sal*,
 Son of Micah, son of Zichri,
 The son of Asaph *by degree*.
 16 And Obadiah, Shemaiah's
 Son, son of Galal, the son's *paws*
 Of Jeduthun, and Berechiah
 The son of Asa, *no pariah*,
 The son of Elkanah, who lived
 In Netophathite towns *unsieved*.

Though El Qanah's a jealous God who
 knows
 To speak to Israel at the mount and shows
 If not a face, a voice that comes to blows,
 I think the images beneath the toes
 Of earth and cloud are nought to take in
 fame
 As representatives of Your bright name.
 Though El Qanah's a jealous God for grief
 To generations saved from ill belief,
 I find in El Qanah my last relief
 Before the coming of heirloom and fief.
 Beloved, the best name comes to bite my
 ear
 When I recite Your Decalogue in fear,
 And find the darkness and the cloud a
 place
 Where I stand nude without shame of Your
 face.

17 The porters were Shallum, Akkub,
 And Talmon and Ahiman's dub,
 And their brothers, Shallum was chief,
 18 Who up till then stayed in relief

In the king's gate toward the east,
 They were the porters and increased
 In the bands of folk of Levi.
 19 And Shallum, Kore's son, *a guy*
 The son of Ebiasaph, the son
 Of Korah and his brothers *won*,
 Of his father's house, Korahites,
 Over the work of worship sites,
 Keepers of tabernacle gates,
 And their fathers, over the states
 Of YHWH to keep the entry rates.
 20 And Phinehas, Eleazar's son
 Ruled over them in times now done,
 And YHWH was with him *on the run*.

Well, Phinehas. He is a man for fame
 To piece with javelin the crying shame
 That Balaam inspired Balak in his claim
 Against the folk of Israel on the shore
 Of Jordan before knocking at the door
 Of Jericho. Sweet Jericho still lies
 Under the tranquil blue of mounting skies
 Above the ragged mountains that were set
 To view the feast and dancing that were
 met
 Upon a day when Phinehas came out
 And set the pagan gods all in a rout.
 Beloved, I am no man of war myself,
 And yet I love Phinehas beyond elf
 As I sit quietly upon my shelf.

21 And Zechariah who was son
 Of Meshelemiah begun
 As porter of the door in tent
 Of the assembly *where it went*.
 22 All these elected there to be
 Porters in the gates of the free
 Were two hundred and twelve, these be
 Counted by their genealogy
 In their places, which David and
 Samuel the seer did command
 In their established posts to stand.
 23 They and their children oversaw
 The gates of YHWH's house from the raw,
 That is the tabernacle house
From dangers of both foe and mouse.

Two hundred twelve is quite a number set,
 One hundred and one more is all that's met
 Beside the Qaaba never to get wet
 Unless a season's cloudburst come delight

The Meccan moon, the Meccan star and
 night.
 Two hundred twelve men all in places
 found
 And ready to bow head and hand to ground
 To serve You, my Beloved, and David
 round
 The fortress and the tabernacle door.
 The seer in Samuel stands upon the shore
 Still watching and still waiting for the
 score
 Of righteousness to rise up to the post
 And make the deeds of men worthy of
 boast,
 The gates of Your house, my Beloved, and
 host.

24 On four sides were the porters' mouth,
 Toward east and west, the north and south.
 25 There brothers in their places came
 After seven days timed in their claim.
 26 For these Levites, chief porters four
 Were set in their posts and their store
 Of treasures in the house of God.
 27 They lived around about the sod
 Of house of Alohim, because
 It was their duty there by laws
 To open every morning's draws.
 28 Some of them had the keep of pots
 Of service, transporting in lots.
 29 Some took care of the furniture,
 And holy vessels *of the pure*,
 And fine flour, grape juice and the oil
 And frankincense and spices' *coil*.
 30 And from the sons of priests some made
 The perfumes of spices *allayed*.

Some made from spices their own rare
 perfumes
 Such as no secular man in his rooms
 Dare make unless he would combat his
 dooms.
 Some took the furniture in care and
 brought
 The holy pots full of fine flour and taught
 The grape juice not to spoil in jar and place
 Of darkness and of coolness from the trace
 Of oil upon the threshold for a mace.
 Some came at morn to open up the door
 And let the sunlight filtered on the floor
 Rejoice a moment till the time for more
 Had rounded on the day and left a chore.

Beloved, some come and go, some do and
 praise,
 But I am only here for days and days.

30 And Mattithaiah, the Levite,
 Who was firstborn of Shallum's right
 The Korahite, established post
 Over things made in the pans' boast.
 32 And from their brothers, of the sons
 Of Kohathites, over the buns
 Of showbread for each Sabbath *day*.

The Kohathites made showbread for the
 day
 Of Sabbath and brought the fresh loaves in
 pay
 Each week to set upon a table rare,
 To gleam behind the veil and simmer there.
 The Kohathites did nothing else in view,
 At least those set for this brave task, to do
 Your will in tent and temple. Every hand
 Has some small labour to fulfil command.
 Beloved, there are no Kohathites that live
 And bake in my time and place, none to
 give
 The fragrant, holy loaf on Sabbath eve.
 I pine for those lost moments of reprieve,
 And make do with the now and here and
 find
 My rye bread just as succulent and vined.

33 And these are singers in their way,
 Chief of the Levites' fathers' *sway*,
 In chambers free, for it was they
 Who served in that both night and day.
 34 These chief fathers of the Levites,
 Chief through their generations' *rights*,
 These lived on Jerusalem's *heights*.
 35 In Gibeon lived the father of
 Gibeon, Jehiel, whose wife's *love*
In name was Maachah for her fame.
 36 And his firstborn son Abdon, then
 Zur, Kish and Baal and Ner in den
 And Nadab, 37 Gedor, and Ahio,
 And Zechariah, Mikloth *low*.

Gedor's a name reminds me of Ghadir,
 The enclosed oasis that without fear
 Proclaims the name that I still must revere
 As I climb up the mountain like the seer.
 Gedor's a name that brings to mind the
 clear

Waters and the green pastures where the
flock
And herd take refuge from the burning
rock.
Gedor's a name that hardly is heard now
After the purpose prophetic somehow
Unfolded after pilgrimage was late
To remind everyone of prophet's fate.
Beloved, name some man still Gedor to
mind
Of that day when half of the world went
blind.

38 Mikloth sired Shimeam. And they
Also lived in their brothers' way
There in Jerusalem and near
Their brothers *where they all appear*.

Mikloth sired Shimeam. The rods lightly
Come to the mouth of womb if there to see
Escape in from everlasting ennui.
Love of sons and why not daughters too
makes
Woman and man abide the tricks and
shakes
Along the living of both night and day.
I rise up and walk to the shop to pay
No more than what I must to eat my bread.
Some find a place to rest when all is said,
For nothing is greater than that thing
spread
Out on the human wounds of heart and
skin.
Low bends the head and knee as though for
sin,
Lovingly calls at open door come in.
Young and old gather at the fountain-head.

39 And Ner sired Kish, and Kish begat
Saul, and Saul sired Jonathan *fat*,
And Malchishua and *the rat*
Abinadab, and Eshbaal's *cat*.
40 The son of Jonathan *to come*
Was Meribbaal, and *he with hum*,
Meribbaal sired Micah *in sum*.
41 The sons of Micah were Pithon,
Melech and Tahrea, *one gone*
Was Ahaz in the spring of dawn.
42 And Ahaz sired Jarah, and *he*,
Jarah begat Alemeth *free*,
And Azmaveth and then Zimri,
And Zirmri sired Moza *with glee*.

43 And Moza sired Binea and
Rephaiah his son came *to stand*,
Eneasah his son, Azel
His son *came to bless Israel*.
44 And Azel had six sons, whose names
Are these, Azrikam Bocheru's *fames*,
And Ishmael, and Sheariah's *claims*,
And Obadiah and Hanan,
These sons of Azel *to a man*.

More names that are repeated in the fund
Create confusion of the moribund.
Enough I say without the repetition
Longing to fill the book with ammunition.
Why not repeat a name if by its glow
Another sigh and song may sound below?
I cantillate the names again, again
Number the sacred sounds vouchsafed to
men.
Some bask in light and sound of mass and
noise
From the rock stage brighter than battle
boys,
Or sit upon the wall and watch the game,
Lovely as fruit upon the evil shame
Languishing in the garden with the snake.
You might be glad about the songs I make.

1 Chronicles 10

1 The Philistines attacked the folk
Of Israel, and every bloke
Of Israel fled from before
The Philistines, and score on score
Fell dead on Gilboa by stroke.
2 The Philistines pursued hard after
Saul and his sons, *no count for laughter*,
The Philistines killed Jonathan,
Abinadab, and before done
Malchishua, the sons of Saul.
3 The battle went hard against Saul,
The bowmen struck him and *for gall*
He staggered at the bowmen's *call*.

I guess a prophet would say that You sped
The heels of Philistines against the red
And bloody hands of Saul. But I remind
You that David Your chosen in a bind
Spared more than once Saul's life. So give
in kind.
Saul did consult a witch, but so do most
Of those in government today that boast.
Saul did throw javelins against the wall,

But so do most princes and have a ball.
Saul was the king of unified estate
And for the most part sanctified Your gate.
Think in the relative. David's own sons
Were more than half worse people in their
runs
Than Saul. And yet the archer's arrow
Struck Your anointed in the tight and
narrow.

4 Then said Saul to the one who bore
His armour, "Draw your sword before
And stab me through with it, so these
Uncircumcised come not *like fleas*
To torture me." But that man who
Bore his armour just would not do,
For he feared *the anointed true*.
So Saul took sword, fell on its *rue*.
5 When he who bore his armour saw
That Saul was dead *by his own claw*,
He also fell on sword and died.
5 Saul died and his three sons beside,
His whole house together there died.

The way of honour in the greater grief
Is suicide, that boon of great relief
When all is lost and in despair no hope
Gleams up beyond the unsheathed sword
and rope.

The way of honour is unkind when met.
It throws the soul and body in the net.
Beloved, I flee among the hurtling trees
And search out refuge from the taunting
breeze

Until I find the barren hill where Saul
Fell on his sword and at the great appal
His armour-bearing drank the bitter gall.
With Jonathan dead too, then what was left
I ask that was not dark, bereft?
Reality forces man to his knees.

7 When all the men of Israel there
In the valley saw evil share,
They fled, and that Saul and his sons
Were dead, they left their cities' *guns*
And fled away and Philistines
Came and lived in their cities' *scenes*.
8 It chanced upon the next day when
The Philistines came out of den
To spoil the slain, that they found Saul
And his sons fallen *in the brawl*
Upon mount Gilboa *to sprawl*.

9 When they had spoiled him then they
took
His head and armour he forsook
And sent to the land's every nook
Of Philistines to bring the news
To their idols and folk *in pews*.
10 They put his armour in the house
Of their gods and tied up the grouse
Of his head in Dagon's *bright* house.

If only Saul were taken in the spoil
Perhaps I might be reconciled to toil.
But I see ever truth upon the scaf
And Philistine on golden chair to laugh,
And it is not original in me
To note the sinking stars' eternity.
Gilboa is a continent at least
And spreads around the world in gaunt
feast.

Beloved, I weep not only for the soul
Of Saul and Jonathan upon the mole,
But for the millions yet unnamed that fall
Each day beneath the cutting and the maul
Until my eyes are sore with salt and tears,
Until my eyes are opened to my fears.

11 And when all Jabeshgilead
Heard all that the Philistines had
Done to Saul *when they had run mad*,

12 They got up all the valiant men
And took away the corpse again
Of Saul and bodies of his sons,
And brought them to Jabesh with guns
And buried their bones by the oak
In Jabesh and fasted a stroke
For seven day *before they spoke*.

13 So Saul died for his sins that he
Committed against YHWH freely,
Against the word of YHWH that he
Did not obey, and also for
Consulting a jinn's common whore
To enquire of the future's store.

14 And did not ask of YHWH, therefore
He killed him and gave the kingdom
To David Jesse's son *for plum*.

What man is perfect in Your chosen place?
How many could stand better in the race
Than Saul, and yet the writer of Your word
Considers him no better than a turd.
The modesty and honour of the man
Inspires me still no matter what I scan.

My heart's the heart of David so by plan
 I praise Saul for his hopes and acts and
 heat
 Against the evil on Philistine beat.
 Beloved, I praise Saul still without retreat,
 And ask You, is it not so that his arm
 Had done more good on earth than it did
 harm?
 Not You but Philistine, I trow came by
 With sword and ploughing to see King
 Saul die.

1 Chronicles 11

1 Then all Israel came to David
 At Hebron *after David hid*,
 Saying "Indeed we *are* your bone
 And your flesh. 2 "Also, in time gone,
 Even when Saul was king, you *were*
 Leading Israel out to *incur*
Wrath on the enemy and brought
 Them in, and YHWH your God *has taught*
 You saying 'You shall shepherd My
 People Israel, and *by and by*
 Be ruler of Israel My folk.'"

When one hero dies on the frozen sod
 Of Gilboa forsaken by his God,
 The people are quick to return and find
 Another to lead them like cowed and
 kined.
 When one hero dies with the hand on
 sword,
 Having given in sacrifice adored
 Hopes of peaceful domesticity and life
 To save his people from impending strife,
 The folk are fast to turn toward relief
 From sorrowing, a few feed on a grief.
 Beloved, my hero's dead and so I turn
 To find a David on the heathered burn
 And raise a lyre to sing aloud his praise
 While one is still warm on the puzzled
 craze.

3 Therefore all Israel's elders spoke
 To the king at Hebron, and made
 A covenant where David stayed
 At Hebron before YHWH. Then they
 Anointed David Israel's king
 For what YHWH said by Samuel's thing,
And then arose and went their way.
 4 And David and all Israel went
 To Jerusalem, *as one sent*,

Which is Jebus, where Jebusite
 Was dwelling on the very site.
 5 The dwellers of Jebus said to
 David, "You shall not come here too!"
 But David took the stronghold of
 The fortress, (Town of David's *love*).
 6 And David said, "The one who goes
 Against the Jebusites first knows
 He shall be chief and captain." And
 Joab son at Zeruiah's hand
 Went up first, and became the chief.
 7 David lived in the stronghold's *fief*,
 That's why they called it David's City.
 8 And he built around it the city,
 From the Millo to all around.
 Joab made the rest safe and sound.
 9 Then David went on and was great,
 And YHWH of hosts *was* with his fate.

Beloved, You once established Your own
 man,
 David, king of Israel by Your plan,
 And gave him the stronghold of fortress
 fast

To reign in as long as Zion shall last.
 The caravan of human power goes on
 Controlling Quds the city dawn to dawn,
 But David's throne in mystic beauty still
 Stands with the hidden ruler and the thrill
 Of Your sweet guidance and the divine
 will.

Find every Jebusite still in my heart
 And throw him out to feel the stinging dart,
 And let no such come in the stronghold of
 My fortress, rather my cold chamber fill
 With spirits that know only of Your love,
 Whispering to the stones of flesh and art.

10 These *are* the heads of mighty men
 Whom David had, who strengthened then
 Themselves with him in his kingdom,
 With all Israel, to make *in sum*
 Him king, according to the word
 Of YHWH about Israel *inferred*.
 11 This is the register of men
 Of courage David had again,
 Jashobeam a Hachmonite,
 The chief of captains *in his sight*,
 With spear uplifted he attacked
 Three hundred at a time *unslacked*
 And killed all of them *snicker-snacked*.

There is a time and place, I warrant such,
 Where giftedness in killing is the touch
 To be praised and adored. The battlefield
 Finds many on both teams who in the yield
 Might be tooted for murders of the mealed.
 There is a time and place, no doubt in
 mind,
 Where killing is the greated talent find
 To be had by the king and president.
 Few harpists have the medals when they're
 spent.
 There is a rhyme and race for readers of
 The saving of the many for their love
 By slaying the armed with the iron and
 core
 Of fallout on the last embattled shore.
 Beloved, I mime and pace, but do no more.

12 And after him Eleazar
 The son of Dodo and a star
 Ahohite, of a trinity
Of men accounted all mighty.
 13 With David at Pasdammim he
 Was and there Philistines *greatly*
 Gathered together for the fight,
 Where a plot of ground at the site
 Was full of barley, and the folk
 Fled before the Philistine *yoke*.
 14 They set themselves within that field
 And saved it, killing to make yield
 The Philistines, and YHWH saved there
 By a great delivering's *share*.

The barley field is always cheaper than
 The wheaten flour to every hungry man.
 And yet the barley field is worth a life
 Or two struck down and fallen on the strife.
 The life of the invader is so small
 That half a pound of barley at the mall
 Suffices to bring out the sword and call
 And lay it low with barred and bloody
 knife.
 Beloved, I eat with thanks the barely done
 In flour and baked in over under sun,
 And think no thought of who was beaten
 where,
 And why the barley now's become my
 share.
 What use to those once fallen is the praise,
 The wreaths, the honours, and the hallowed
 days?

15 Three of the thirty captains went
 Down to the rock to David spent,
 Into the cave of Adullam,
 And the band of Philistine ham
 Camped in valley of Rephaim.
 16 And David was then in the hold,
 While Philistine's fort *and all told*
Were then at Bethlehem *and bold*.
 17 And David longing spoke and sighed,
 "If only one would give to drink
 Of the water that's on the side
 Of Bethlehem and on the brink
 Of the gate *there where all men ride*."
 18 And so the three broke through the band
 Of Philistines to try their hand
 At drawing water from the well
 Of Bethlehem by citadel
 Of the gate, took and brought to quell
 The thirst of David, but David
 Would not drink it, and what he did
 Was pour it out to YHWH amid.
 19 He said "May Alohim forbid
 Me doing such a thing as this,
 Shall I drink blood with avarice
 Of these men who risked life for whim?
 For at the risk of lives and grim
 They brought it. That's why he would not
 Drink it. These things three mighties
 wrought.

The story of the well of Bethlehem
 May make the foolish heart with pride and
 hem
 Rise and swell to think that the mighty men
 So loved their leader they would die again
 If such were possible. Such worthies then!
 Surely it is no virtue to go round
 And risk one's life to satisfy the ground.
 Moses could never have inspired as much.
 He could not raise the loyal heart to touch
 The rock with gratitude for water brought
 When it was needed by the frankly sot.
 Beloved, give me a clear eye beside heart,
 A reason as well as doing my part
 For the bare feeling of David and dart.
 Beloved, I too pour out libation filled
 With the resentment of Philistine killed
 In history and fire upon the grilled
 Fat flanks of sister of Yazid. I pray
 A curse upon them all who see the day
 And touch the blessed of the Lord for pay.

David's commandment was not just to
 show
 The bravery of his stalwarts on the go.
 It was a prophecy beneath the sky
 And on the parched earth where we come
 to die
 That there would be a time when faithful
 men
 Would pour out water on the ground again
 With every drought and exclaim at that
 breath
 A curse upon Yazid, the man of death.

20 Abishai brother of Joab,
 He was the chief of three for grab,
 For lifting up his spear to slay
 Three hundred, and slew them that way
 And had his fame among the three.
 21 Of the three he was than the two
 More honourable, for he as due
 Was their captain, but yet did not
 Attain to the *first* three *in plot*.

The brother of Joab, for all his fame,
 Raises hope that, despite his lesser show
 In chronicles of the great in the know,
 Need not seek every form of slighter claim.
 I read the loving man beyond the name
 To know his hopeful guise is but the glow
 Around the portalled town stretched out to
 blow
 So bright a star that none need pretend
 shame.

A cross or crown engulfs the god to lend
 Taut hope on small sums that at last must
 be
 Trinity of man and goddess to pass
 Alone almighty through the mind to bend
 In hope what shadows come about to see
 Now in dark blasphemy the mirrored glass.

22 Benaiah Jehoiada's son,
 The son of a bold man in run
 Of Kabzeel, who'd done many acts,
 He killed two lion-men in pacts
 With Moab, also he went down
 And killed a lion *of renown*
 In a pit on a snowy day,
And so he showed courageous way.

I find, Beloved, the snowy days increase
 About my muffled ears and the lights cease

Upon the mornings and the evenings'
 share.
 I find the snow but never lions there.
 The firs have long since marched out of the
 east
 And touched the Finnish landscape with
 the priest
 And censer on the icon of the world.
 A bear perhaps but never lion curled.
 The silence of the tree-, frost-covered hill
 Provides hardly of sight of beast to kill,
 And I am left with only my heart's will
 To overcome with snow and silence fill.
 Beloved, let Moab be a memory
 And my own frozen patch eternity.

23 He killed an Egyptian, a man
 Of height five arm-lengths if a span,
 And he attacked him with a staff,
 And snatched the spear out *with a laugh*
 From the Egyptian's hand and then
 With his own spear struck him again.
 24 These things did Benaiah the son
 Of Jehoiada and he won
 Fame among the three mighties *done*.
 25 See, he was honourable among
 The thirty, but attained no rung
 Among the *first* three, David set
 Him over his guard, *no regret*.

I never plucked a spear out of the hand
 Of any Egyptian under command.
 But I have plucked a pen with coloured
 face
 Of pharaoh's and the hieroglyphic trace
 From seller in the hotel with the muse
 That he should sell it as another choose
 For less. I did not bear in mind that he
 Had all the rent of the hotel in fee
 To pay, while in the central market place
 No doubt the overhead was greater grace.
 Beloved, the heroism of my days
 Is now the slightness of my words of
 praise,
 Is now the hopeful watching of the sky
 Where lately in the red clouds You pass by.

26 The bold men of the armies too,
 Asahel, Joab's brother due,
 Elhanan the son of Dodo
 Come up from Bethlehem to show.
 27 Shammoth the Harorite, Helez

The Pelonite, Ira as says
 The son of Ikkeshe Tekoite,
 Abiezer the Antothite,
 29 Sibbecai who was Hushathite,
 Ilai who was an Ahohite,
 30 Maharai the Netophathite,
 He led the son of Baanah *too*
 A Netophathite *come in view*.
 31 Ithai the son of Ribai of
 Gibeah, which was of the love
 Of Benjamin's folk in the sight
 Of Benaiah Pirathonite.

The brothers of Joab show up and fair
 With all the heroes found and everywhere.
 Then as now catered armies still provide
 Careers by which the young men to abide
 In memory bring up the sword and side.
 The brothers of Joab, the one and two
 Rise to their fame for brawn and fighting
 crew

Among the men of every claim and race
 Brought in the council of David to trace.
 I am no brother of Joab by right,
 Nor Tekoite, Antothite, Hushathite,
 Nor even Netophathite, yet I'm true
 To David's men, Beloved, as well as You,
 To David's men, Beloved, a motley brew.

32 Hurai of the brooks of Gaash and
 Abiel the Arbathite grand,
 33 Azmaveth the Baharumite,
 Eliahba the Shaalbonite,
 34 The sons of Hashem Gizonite,
 Jonathan of Shage Hararite,
 35 Ahiam son of Sacar too
 Hararite, Eliphal in view
 The son of Ur *along with crew*.
 36 Hephher the Mecherathite too,
 Ahija the Pelonite and
 37 Hezro the Camelite *on hand*,
 Naarai son of Ezbai *to stand*.
 38 Joel the brother of Mathan,
 Mibhar Haggeri's son and man,
 39 Zelek the Ammonite and yet
 Naharai the Berothite's bet,
 The armourbearer of Joab,
 The son of Zeruiah's gab.

Hurai I guess has the same root in name
 As the Qur'anic Houris have in fame,
 And both tongues are ambiguous to blame,

Both trying with their whiteness to reclaim
 Either the white grape or the cloth of game.
 A nobleman the name would seem to ride
 For white nobility on every tide,
 Though Hurai comes from Gaash, a raging
 stream

If by its name it is what it would seem.
 Beloved, my raging stream is torrent less
 In summer and in winter's white address,
 But spring freshets fulfil the tidal wave,
 And autumn rains belie the dawning grave.
 And yet upon the bank I stop to guess.

40 Ira the Ithrite and Gareb
 The Ithrite, 41 and *the Johnny reb*
 Uriah the Hittite, Zabab
 The son of Ahlai *to be glad*.
 42 Adina the son of Shiza
 The Reubenite, a captain's *paw*
 Of the Reubenites, and *in a* '
 Thirty with him *by hook and claw*.
 43 Hanan the son of Maachah and
 Joshaphat Mithnite to stand,
 44 Uzzia the Ashterathite,
 Shama and Jehiel of might
 The sons of Hothan Aroerite.
 45 Jediel the son of Shimri,
 And Joha his brother the free
 Tizite. 47 Eliel the Mahavite,
 Jeribai, Joshaviah,
 The sons of Elnaam, and Ithmah
 Who was after all Moabite.
 47 Eliel, Obed, Jasiel
 The Mesobaite bold and fell.

Uriah the Hittite was foreign man
 Among the stalwarts of David in scan,
 And three j's top the mast as Moabites
 To join with David in his many fights.
 The nations gather one by one to greet
 Your one anointed and fall at his feet,
 And never is there such a sound so sweet
 As harping in the ancient city's street.
 Beloved, I come to You in cities fair
 Strung out like mist-grey pearls and
 everywhere
 Touched by the finger of Your chosen one
 That justice in the guard may aye be done.
 Yet holiness is not seen by the eye,
 Nor does the city rise up at the cry.

1 Chronicles 12

1 Now these are the ones that had come
To David in Ziklag *for fun*
While he was still far off from Saul
The son of Kish, *one to appal*.
And they were among mighty men,
Helpers in the war *once again*.

2 Armed with bows, they could use both
right

And left hands *in battle and fight*
With stones and arrows from a bow,
Saul's brothers from Benjamin's *row*.

3 The chief was Ahiezer, then
Joash, Shemaah's sons among men
Of Gibeah, and Jeziel,

And Pelet and the sons as well
Of Azmaveth, and Berachah,
And Jehu the Antothite's paw.

4 And Ismaiah the Gibeonite,
A mighty man in thirty's sight,
And over thirty, Jeremiah,

And Jahaziel, Johanan's *crier*,
And Josabad Gederathite.

5 Eluzai and Jerimoth wight,
Bealiah and Shemariah,
The Haruphite called Shephathiah.

6 Elkanah, and Jesiah, and
Azareel, Joezer, and
Jashobeam, the Korahites.

7 And Joelah, and Zebadiah
Jeroham of Gedor's sons' wights.

Gedor, Ghadir, words sacred to the feat
Of marking of the pleasures and the treat
Of pastured and oasis'd plots of land
By walls of guardianship and of command,
Bring to the heart a rush of recognition.
My flight in Hebrew finds with no
contrition

The wall shuts out with hopeful stone and
bright.

My flight in Arabic's another sight,
And one from the inside, where all is done
And what was hoped for on the road is
won.

Beloved, I am no son of Gedor or
Ghadir, and yet I find that enclosed shore
Where life gleams green beyond the desert
stone

And I find You at last upon Your throne.

8 And of the Gadites there were set
Apart for David to be met

In desert fortress, men of might,
And men of war fit for the fight,
To wield the shield and buckler, whose
Faces were lions' ones to choose,
And fast as roes on mountain views.

9 Ezer the first, the second came
As Obadiah man of fame,
And Eliab the third in claim.

10 Mishmannah fourth, the fifth to come
Jeremiah, 11 Attai had won
Sixth place, the seventh Eliel,

12 Johanan eighth in Israel,
The ninth Elzabad, 13 tenth *at last*
To Jeremiah, *no outcast*,

Eleventh Machbanai, 14 These were
The sons of Gad, captains *each fer*
Of the army, one of the least
Was over a hundred, the beast
Of them over thousand *increased*.

Eleven men of fame in David's court
Were sent to serve in first and last resort,
Victorious in everything they did,
And skilful with the sword, the shield and
lid.

Eleven men, my faith, it's generally
Twelve men that make the sacred
company.

Are there not twelve imams to follow in
The path of David, though without the sin?
Beloved, I singly come, no skill to show,
No lovely voice, no weapon, and no glow,
But ready to fill the last place and be
A watchman at the door, a servant free
Until the number's made, I take my place
In David's foremost ranks before Your
face.

15 These are the ones who went across
Jordan in the first month in toss
When it had overflowed its banks,
And they put to flight all in ranks
Of the valleys toward the east
And toward the west *all foes increased*.

16 There came of Benjamin's folk and
Of Judah to David to stand.

17 And David went to meet them and
Answered and told them, "If you've come
In peace to me to help in sum,
My heart shall be knit unto you,
But if you come to me in view
Of your betrayal to my foes,

Since there is nothing wrong that grows
 In my hand, our dads' Alohim
 Look and rebuke what is unseen."
 18 So clothed the spirit Amasai,
 Who was chief of the captains by,
 "We're yours, David, and on your side,
 You son of Jesse, peace and pride,
 Peace be to you and peace be to
 Your helpers, for your God helps you."
 Accepted then David them and
 Made them all captains of the band.

Beloved, I do not shirk my faith in You
 When I make myself one of David's crew.
 I meet him on the Jordan's stormy bank
 And take the lowest terms in army rank.
 Let others be the captains and stand tall.
 My under six feet stretches at the wall.
 And yet I say peace to the king in flood,
 And walk the narrow passageway of blood
 Beneath the gallows of the earthly mud.
 I take the spirit of Amasai dear
 And step out before I have time to fear
 Upon the sinking planks with heart sincere.
 Beloved, the son of Jesse is my guide
 As I return returning to Your side.

19 And some of Manasseh came out
 To David, when he came with shout
 Of Philistine to fight with Saul,
 But they did not help them at all,
 Because the Philistine chiefs said
 To send him packing, he'd be led,
 They said, to help his former master
 Saul to our loss of heads *and faster*.
 20 As he went down to Ziklag's town,
 There came to him some of renown
 Of Manasseh, Adnah and yet
 Jozabad and Jedaiel set,
 And Michael, Jozabad and more
 Elihu and Zilthai the core
 Captains of thousand *of the fleet*
 Of Manasseh *to be complete*.
 21 They helped David against the band,
 For they were all great men to stand,
 And army captains *to command*.
 22 For at that time and day by day
 There came folk into David's way
 To help him, till a great army
Was gathered such as God's *to see*.

Prophetic is the coming of the men

In secret and so quietly in fen
 That hardly anyone takes task or note
 That David is now filling up his boat.
 The great establishments meet in conflict,
 The Philistine meet Saul with armies
 picked,
 Just as the mosques and synagogues today
 Join with the church a march into the fray.
 Behind, above the din of constant war
 There is a hidden band just at the door
 With David, my sweet David, gone before.
 Beloved, let me sing with David a song
 As I join in the hidden, secret throng,
 And so keep my soul from the seething
 wrong.

23 These are the numbers of the bands
 Ready armed to the battle stands,
 Come to David in Hebron for
 To turn Saul's kingdom to his door,
 According to YHWH's word, what's more.
 24 The sons of Judah wielding shield
 And spear where six thousand to yield
 And eight hundred and armed to fight.
 25 Of Simeon's children, men of might
 And brave in battle, to the spread
 Of seven thousand one hundred.
 26 Of Levi's sons four thousand and
 Six hundred *strong upon the land*.
 27 Jehoiada was leader to
 The Aaronites, with him in view
 Were three thousand seven hundred true.
 28 And Zadok, a young man of might
 And brave, and of his father's right
 With twenty-two captains in sight.
 29 And of the sons of Benjamin,
 The kin of Saul, three thousand kin,
 For up to now the greater part
 Had stayed with Saul's house *and Saul's*
cart.
 30 And of the sons of Ephraim
 Twenty thousand and eight hundred,
 Brave men of valour, might and dread,
 Renowned throughout their fathers' spread.
 31 And of Manasseh's half tribe sent
 Eighteen thousand by name *and lent*
 To come and make David king *meant*.
 32 And of the sons of Issachar
 Who understood the times *and star*
 To know what Israel ought to do,
 The chiefs of the numbered to two
 Hundred, and all their brothers stood

To hear their commandment *as should*.
33 Of Zebulun, such as went out
To battle, fit in war *and shout*,
With weapons all, fifty thousand
Able to keep rank *on the land*,
Not double-hearted they *but true*.

Fifty thousand men all in rank go out
From little Zebulun, men frank and stout
And ready for the battle and the show.
It's hard so many years after the go
To see the difference between this and that,
How this is not rebellion laid out flat.
To me it looks like treachery for gold
Or honour to send out anointed cold.
Perspective on events runs always true
To life, no matter when or where or who:
God's with us and is never with the foe.
No man is ever wrong, it's vertigo
Alone that makes the battlelines seem
straight.
Let me go out to fight and not be late.

34 Of Naphtali a thousand chiefs,
And with them with shield and *reliefs*
Of spear thirty-seven thousand.
35 And of the Danites in the land
Expert in battle twenty grand
And eight thousand and six hundred.
36 And of Asher such as were led
Out to the fray, fit for the fight,
Forty thousand *to come in sight*.
37 And on the Jordan's other side,
Of Reubenites and Gadites' *pride*,
And half the tribe of Manasseh,
With weapons of all kinds in fray,
A hundred twenty thousand's *sway*.
38 All these men of war who could keep
Rank came with a perfect heart to *reap*
Hebron and there make David king
Over all Israel, everything,
And all the rest of Israel *too*
Were of one mind to make *the true*
King David *over all in view*.
39 They stayed with David there three
days,
Eating and drinking in their ways
What their brothers had fixed *in praise*.
40 Besides that those that lived nearby
In Issachar and on the high
Zebulun and in Naphtali,
Brought bread on donkeys, camels too,

On mules and oxen for the crew,
And food and flour and cakes of figs,
And bunches of raisins and swigs
Of grape juice and of oil and yet
Of oxen and sheep and well met,
For there was joy in Israel set.

Beloved, I am one that lives here nearby,
And so I bring my donkeys on the sly,
All laden down with bread and cakes of
figs,
And food and flour not to throw out to
pigs.

I come to make David my king and find
A better throne than the one at the grind
Of humanist and marketer well dined,
And priest and bishop dressed up out of
mind.

I come to make David my king and see
A better throne than on the desert lea
Where oil springs up to fill the coffers with
Something more useful than their gold and
myth.

Beloved, I come a donkey, camel spent
To find Your David reigning where he
went.

1 Chronicles 13

1 David took council with the chiefs
Of thousands and hundreds' *reliefs*,
And every leader *in beliefs*.
2 David told all the assembly
Of Israel, "If good it may be
Good to you and of YHWH our God,
Let's send to our brothers abroad
And everywhere, those that are left
In all the land of Israel's feoffed,
And the priests and Levites in their
Cities and villages to share
Together with us *if they dare*.
3 "And let us bring again the ark
Of our Alohim to our park,
For we did not enquire of it
At all during Saul's days *of fit*."

My heart's the heart of David and I send
To all the crowd of Yours if they will bend
To bring the ark of covenant into
The temple of the human heart to view
The tables of the law set out in dew
And written with Your finger on the crew.
My heart's the heart of David and I run

To find Your Decalogue for song and fun,
 To bring the cherubed ark of gold and fine
 Acacia wood to glisten in its line,
 To sparkle with the joy of sunly fire
 And lustfully fill my heart with desire.
 Beloved, my heart's the heart of David
 while
 Your ark is both my pleasure and my guile.

4 And all the congregation said
 That they would do the thing instead,
 For the affair was good and right
 In the sight of the folk *contrite*.

5 Then David gathered in one place
 All Israel from Shihor's *trace*
 In Egypt even to the gate
 Of Hemath to bring and instate
 The ark of Alohim from where
 It sat in Kirjathjearim's *share*.

6 And David went up with the folk
 All to Baalah, which is in stroke
 Of Kirjathjearim in Judah
 To bring from there Alohim's ark
 And that of YHWH as held in awe
 To stay within secluded park
 Of cherubim, whose name's in mark.

7 They carried up Alohim's ark
 In a new cart out of the room
 Of Abinadab, and for doom
 Uzza and Ahio drove the cart.
 8 And David and all Israel start
 To dance before Alohim in
 All strength and with their singing's *din*,
 With harps and psalteries and *more*
 With timbrels, cymbals and *in store*
 With trumpets *as never before*.

9 And when they reached the
 threshingfloor
 Of Chidon, Uzza shot forth hand
 To hold the ark before *the stand*
Of stumbling oxen on the land.
 10 The wrath of YHWH then flamed up
 right

Against Uzza, and smote with might,
 Because he laid his hand upon
 The ark, and there he died *as drawn*
 Before Alohim *in His sight*.

11 And David was displeased because
 YHWH has struck Uzza for his paws,
 Which is why to this very day
 That place is called Perez-Uzza.

12 David feared Alohim that day,

Saying "How shall I bring away
 The ark of Alohim to me?"

13 So David did not bring the ark
 To himself and to his city,
 But carried it aside to park
 In the house of Obededom
 The Gittite. 14 and so then in sum
 Alohim's ark stayed with the folk
 Of Obededom and to stoke
 His house for three months. And so
 YHWH

Blessed house of Obededom's crew.

The ark wherein Your Decalogue now rests
 Within the chamber of my templed vests
 Is three months begging blessing from
 Your room,
 Twelve weeks of divine guidance without
 doom.

With Obed-Edom, servant of the red,
 I fill my table with sweetmeats and fed
 With nectar of the gods to hear Your word.
 My swollen heart is humbled while it's
 stirred.

Beloved, the king's heart may be empty
 now,

The curtained tabernacle beneath plough,
 But my house is blessed with the sounding
 note

Of Your voice that once gave the blessed
 rote

On Sinai to the waiting, hoping crowd.
 I joy to hear commandments sung aloud.

1 Chronicles 14

1 Now Hiram king of Tyre sent to
 David messengers and a crew
 With timber of cedars, with men
 As masons and carpenters then
 To build him a house *strong and true*.

2 And David saw YHWH had confirmed
 Him king over Israel *affirmed*,
 For his kingdom was raised up high,
 Because of his folk Israel's *try*.

3 And David took more wives when he
 Lived at Jerusalem, *you see*,
 And David sired more sons and daughters.

4 And these are the names of the blotters,
 His spawn that filled Jerusalem,
 Shammua, Shobab, and *the gem*
 Nathan, and at last Solomon,

5 And Ibhar, and Elishua,

And Elpalet, 6 and then Nogah,
Nepheg, and Japhia, when done,
7 And Elishama, Beeliada,
And Eliphalet, *thirteen paw*.

David did not need Hiram for his help
To build himself a house of common
 whelp,
But with new wives accrued in city span
He sired them more and more and man to
 man.

If Ishmael is a hero for the sum
Of twelve, and Jacob follows on his tum,
Then David scores one above all of them
As he relaxes in Jerusalem.
Beloved, is thirteen not a number chosen
For warning to the heated and the frozen?
I'd rather take the twelve, but then I find,
Messiah makes the thirteenth and resigned.
I'd rather take the twelve as Ishmael taught
And Jacob followed in the well-set plot.

8 And when the Philistines heard that
David was anointed king *flat*
Over all Israel, then went
All the Philistines to tent
Of David. David heard *the news*,
And went out against them to cruise.
9 The Philistines came and spread out
In the valley of Rephaim's route.
10 And David asked Alohim, saying,
"Shall I attack Philistine slaying?
And will You put them in my hand?"
And YHWH said to him, "Get and go,
For I'll put them in your hand's show."
11 They came up to Baalperazim;
And David attacked there with vim.
Then David said, "Alohim's broken
Down my foes by my hand in token
Like gushing forth of streams awoken."
That's why they called that place by name
Of Baalperazim *for its fame*.

Lord of the breach indeed. Let my faith
 stand
Like David's on the gushing brink of land
To see the living water spill about
Myself unwilling for the march and rout.
Beloved, break down my foes in self and
 other
And make all born my sister or my brother,

So gushing streams may wash away the
 guilt
Of ground up golden calves and desert silt.
When David spoke to You in questioning,
You gave response in clarity to king.
Though I am not a king upon my throne
Of fir-beams and of lilac bushes grown,
I still speak in the morning silence asking
Which foe to send You breaking while I'm
 basking.

12 They abandoned their idols there
And David commanded their share
Be burned with fire *and burned with care*.
13 The Philistines once more spread out
In the valley. 14 So without doubt
David once more asked the advice
Of Alohim, and in a trice
Alohim told him, "Do not go
Up after them, but turn the show
Away from them and then attack
By mulberry trees *and at their back*.
15 "And it shall be then when you hear
A noise in the mulberry trees' gear,
Then you shall go out to the fight,
For Alohim's gone there to smite
Before you the whole of the host
Of men the Philistines can boast.
16 So David did what Alohim
Told him to do, and like a dream
They slaughtered Philistine army
From Gibeon to Gazer *to flee*.
17 And David's fame filled the country,
And YHWH caused all lands to fear him,
Although he was not very grim.

Ah, there is where the voice divine
 appears!
A rushing in the mulberry trees for fears!
I thought that You spoke Hebrew to the lad
And ringing in his ears it was not sad.
Instead I find Your syllables awake
With wind in ambiguity to take
As any human heart will in the musk.
My disappointment hides beneath the dusk.
Beloved, speak clearly in this land for
 shame
And at You clear word I shall take the
 blame,
Or whisper in the aspens what You will,
And I shall find Your voice though I am
 still.

Wherever Your voice is not heard aloud
I turn my face away from praying crowd.

1 Chronicles 15

1 He built houses in David's city
And readied a place without pity
For Alohims ark and there pitched
For it a tent and one well-stitched.
2 And David said "Nobody ought
To lift up Alohims ark wrought
But the Levites: for YHWH has chosen
Them to carry God's ark unfrozen
And serve before Him all their lot.
3 And David gathered all the folk
Of Israel together in poke
Unto Jerusalem, to bring
Up the ark of YHWH under wing
Where he'd made ready everything.
4 And David gathered Aaron's folk
And the Levites *all at a stroke*.
5 Of Kohath's sons Uriel chief,
And his brothers *for his relief*
A hundred and twenty *in brief*.
6 Of the sons of Merari *yet*
Asaiah the chief, and his *set*
Brothers two hundred twenty *met*.
7 Of the sons of Gershom Joel
The chief, and his brothers *set well*
A hundred and thirty *for spell*.

Beloved, I think that I should like to see
The day when David, master of the free,
Brought up the sacred ark from resting
place
To make Jerusalem Your throne of grace.
And yet I know the thing was foreign to
My heart and eye, the language, although
true,
Despite my knowledge of the square
Hebrew,
Accustomed in no way to mind and ear.
And I imagine and as well I fear
The slaughter of the sacrifices there
Would have betrayed my wholesomeness
of air.
But still, Beloved, Your tables of
commands
Lay hidden under all the strange ribands,
And these speak to my heart directly now
Despite the centuries that hide my brow.
Beloved, You and Your law are always
fair.

8 Of the sons of Elizaphan
Shemaiah the chief, and his *span*
Of brothers two hundred *in clan*.
9 Of the sons of Hebron Eliel
The chief, his brothers without guile
Eighty *in all with none to spoil*.
10 Of the sons of Uzziel too,
Aminadab the chief of crew,
And his brothers, one hundred twelve,
All active men and none to shelve.
11 And David called for Zadok and
Abiathar the priests *on hand*,
And for the Levites, for Uriel,
Asaiah, Joel, Shemaiah, Eliel,
Aminadab, *and with a smile*
12 He said to them, "You are the chief
Of the fathers of Levites' *leaf*,
Make yourselves holy, you and your
Brothers to bring up to the door
The ark of YHWH Alohims of
Israel up to the place above
That I've prepared for it *to shove*.
13 "Because you did not do so then
At the first time *as faithful men*,
YHWH our Alohims struck us down
For our not seeking Him with frown
Appropriate to His renown."
14 The priests and Levites sanctified
Themselves to bring up *on the tide*
The ark of YHWH the Alohims
Of Israel *in wake and dream*.

Unless the Cohens are a holy crowd
I doubt there are any longer allowed
Holy men on the street of Jericho
Or in Jerusalem for sacred show.
The waving banner of the vast elite
That once trod on the cobbles of the street
Is gone, long gone, and even Jesus sweet
Has disappeared in clouds of heaven's
way.
I only see today the day to day.
All things disintegrate while opulent
Theories suggest each year a better tent.
I know the truth for living and for spent
That golden ages are the hope of men,
And eschatologies come back again.

15 The children of the Levites bore
The ark of God upon *the core*
Of their shoulders with staves set in

As Moses commanded by *din*
 Of the word of YHWH *without sin*.
 16 And David spoke to Levites' chief
 To set up their brothers in brief
 As singers with instrument of
 Music, and psalteries and love
 Of harps and cymbals sounding by
 The lifting up of voice with joy.
 17 The Levites set up Heman son
 Of Jel and his brothers in run,
 Asaph the son of Berechiah,
 Sons of Merari, brothers won,
 And Ethan the son of Kushaiah.
 18 Their brothers too of second row,
 Zechariah, Ben on the go,
 And Jaaziel, Shemiramoth,
 And Jehiel and Unni both,
 Eliab and Benaiah and
 Maaseiah and Mattithiah,
 Elipheleh and Mikneiah,
 Obedom, Jeiel and those
 Who carried things *in rows and rows*.
 19 The singers Heman, Asaph and
 Ethan to sound brass cymbals grand.
 20 And Zechariah, Aziel,
 And Shemiramoth, Jehiel,
 And Unni and Eliab and
 Maaseiah and Benaiah's hand
 With psalteries on Alamoth
To praise and promise higher growth.
 21 And Mattithiah, Elipheleh,
 And Mikneiah, another fellow
 Obedom, and Jeiel and
 Azariah with harps to stand
 With excellence on Sheminit.

I bear the table of Your law in part
 Upon my fleshly shoulders and my heart,
 And like the Levites of that ancient time
 Lift up my soul in melody and rhyme.
 I sing the Hebrew songs that cast Your
 word
 Upon the air to vie with beast and bird
 In voices lifted up to praise Your name
 Along the rime of wood and lake in flame.
 Beloved, I bear the stony share until
 I hear the echo of Your law on hill
 And granite crystalline and quartzite rill.
 Beloved I speak the cantillated sound
 Of ark-bound commandments above the
 ground
 Rejoicing in the faith that I have found.

22 And Chenaniah, Levites' chief
 Was for song, he instructed brief
 About the singing because he
 Was skilful *in such harmony*.
 23 And Berechiah, Elkanah
 Guarded the ark *with tooth and claw*.
 24 Shebaniah, Jehoshaphat,
 Nethaneel, Amasai fat,
 And Zechariah and Benaiah,
 And Eliezer, the priests nigh her,
 Blew on trumpets before the ark
 Of Alohim, and the wight stark
 Obedom and Jehiah
 Guarded the ark *with tooth and claw*.
 25 So David and the elders of
 Israel along with captains of
 Thousands went to bring up the ark
 Of YHWH's covenant out of park
 Of Obedom with great joy.
 26 It happened when Alohim came
 To help the Levites without blame
 Carry the ark of covenant
 Of YHWH, that they came to present
 Seven bullocks and seven rams.
 27 And David was clothed with a stole
 Of fine linen, the Levites' whole
 Gang that carried the ark and those
 Who sang wore one too as they chose
 And Chenaniah chief of song
 With the singers. It wasn't long
 But David also had on him
 Another ephod of linen.
 28 So Israel all brought up the ark
 Of YHWH's covenant with the mark
 Of shouting and the cornet's voice,
 And with trumpets and cymbals' choice,
 Making a sound with psalteries
 And harps *upon the hills and breeze*.
 29 It happened when the ark of YHWH's
 Covenant came into the views
 Of David's city, Michal who's
 The daughter of Saul looked out of
 A window and saw her own love
 King David dancing for his part,
 And she despised him in her heart.

The trumpets sound within my heart and
 mind
 Despite the lack of trumpets I could find
 Upon the street to fill my waiting ear.
 The cornet's voice, the cymbals that I hear

Are only those within, the harps that range
With psalteries my neighbours would find
strange.

And yet the sound You cantillate in me
Is one that echoes on eternity,
And one that shuts out every failing voice
And every tinkle that would call my choice
Away from rejoicing in Your command
And promise to the blooming desert land.
Beloved, I dance with David from the heart
And despise all the watchers where they
start.

1 Chronicles 16

1 So they brought up Alohim's ark
Into the tent for place to park
That David set, and offered burned
Sacrifices and peace gifts earned
Before Alohim *for a lark*.
2 When David finished offering
Each burnt offering and peace offering,
He blessed the folk in name of YHWH.
3 He gave to each of Israel's crew,
Both man and woman, to each one
A loaf of bread and for good fun,
A fine piece of meat and carafe
Of grape juice to have a good laugh.
4 And he appointed the Levites
To minister before the lights
Of YHWH's ark, to record, to thank
And praise YHWH Alohim *in rank*
The God of Israel *by rights*.
5 Asaph the chief and next to him
Zechariah, Jeiel *grim*,
And Shemiramath, and Jehiel,
And Mattithaiah *without guile*,
And Eliab, and Benaiah,
And Obededom *with his claw*,
And Jeiel with psalteries and harp,
While Asaph made the cymbals carp.
6 Benaiah also among priests
With Jahaziel on the feasts
Of sounding trumpets stayed before
The ark of Alohim's pact sore.
7 On that day David handed out
This first psalm to thank YHWH devout
By the hand of Asaph and crew.

David creates new psalms for those in store
To eat their gifted bread by all the more
And drink each man his sweet fruit juice in
cup

And sing aloud Your praises and look up.
I tremble with excitement now that I
Am about to sing that psalm to the sky,
And take part with the crowd upon the day
When each had his own basket and to sway
His own carafe of grape juice to Your
praise.

I tremble at the threshold of the maze
And trip out in the sun to joy beneath
Jerusalem's clear sky and lay a wreath
Of love upon the place the ark once stood,
At least within my heart if there I could.

8 Give thanks to YHWH, call on His name,
Show to the folk His deeds of fame.

The very core of faith and worship's here
To give thanks to You and call without fear
Upon Your name, and praise before all
men

The works that You have done and done
again.

Salvation from the enemy of old
Was often the theme of the song and bold.
Today the gas fires of the holocaust
Have barely been extinguished, barely
tossed

Out of the heart and mind. I face a shore
Of tanks and calling on Your name once
more

In hope of deeds to come, in silence or
In trumpeting of justice in a world
Where once again salvation's flag's
unfurled.

I wait a moment looking from my door.

9 Sing to Him, sing psalms to Him, talk
Of all His wondrous works and walk.

I sing to You, Beloved, the melodies
I find struck on the Hebrew words to
please

In little dots and lines, in circles wrought
To show the rise and fall of voice in plot.
I sing to You, Beloved, I sing and find
The voice that seemed dark, singularly
blind,

Awakens with the hope of harmony
To contemplate throughout eternity.
I sing to You, Beloved, sings psalms at last
Heard in their faith original and blast
Of trumpet and the tinkle of the harp

To call the sparrow and the bear and carp.
I sing to You, Beloved, and of Your deeds
Of wonder to provide for all my needs.

10 And glory in His holy name,
Let their heart rejoice *without shame*
Who seek YHWH *without sin or blame*.

The law of Sinai gave command to show
Your name the honour due it in the glow
Of Your creatorship and sovereignty.
The glory of that statute comes to me
In daily sips as I seek to lift up
Your name in sincere seeking of the cup
Of grace from You to make my heart
rejoice.

I lift Your name with my unworthy voice,
And yet trust that its glory will abide
To hold me guiltless by Your sceptre's
side.

A name alone is power and glory when
It can refer to You above the den
Of hopeful tryings to set up a reign
On earth, let Your rule guide instead my
fain.

11 Seek YHWH and His strength, seek His
face
Continually *in every place*.

I seek Your face, Beloved, in all my days
In every place I turn, I find the rays
Of glory shining on the dust and mote,
And yet I do not see Your face afloat.
Who see You and Your power and then to
see

Your face seek like the moth eternally
The flame to unmake body and set soul
At once before the final hope and goal.
As all return to You, I turn again
And seek Your face, Beloved among all
men,
And find in each Your face, but not Your
power,
Reflection of eternity an hour,
And then the bright engulfed that turns
back time
And mixes splinters with metre and rhyme.

12 Remember His great works He's done,
His miracles *beneath the sun*,
The judgements *that* His mouth *has won*.

The miracles of light and flight in air,
The coming of all things and everywhere
With buzz of bug and sleight of wing and
song

Of coyote and yapping of the strong,
The shape of stone, the fire of life, the feel
Of firm earth at the heart and by the heel,
Show power of Your creation at the sight.
And yet I falter at the coming night.
The miracle of word, the cantillation
Of Hebrew text, the statute, the elation,
These are the miracles above the scent
Of perfumed night and hovered desert tent.
The shape and shadow of Your sign alight
To find my soul waiting and my heart
right.

13 Descendants of Israel, His slave,
You children of Jacob in wave,
His chosen ones, *the good, the brave*.

I do not doubt the choice of Israel,
Nor even of the wilder Ishmael,
I do not doubt the heritage in lot
Of Ammon and of Moab in their plot,
But still I joy in my own ethnic creed,
The mix of every race on earth and seed.
I may not be among the chosen folk,
But I am of all peoples at a stroke,
The bearer and the sharer of Your all
That lies upon the screen of creatures' hall.
Beloved, I hail the chosen tribes and give
Them all the credit for the way they live,
And yet I join the party not invited
And keep the rendez-vous of the required.

14 He's YHWH our Alohim, His *ways*
Of judgement are to all earth's *praise*.

See, did I not speak right, when I availed
Myself of choice to join the holy veiled?
Your judgements are to all the earth and so
They are for me also among the slow.
Though I am neither Israelite nor yet
The Arab prophet's progeny, I'm kept
By love and judgement at Your harvest
gate.

You are my God as well, though I am late.
Beloved, all earth sings of Your blessed
day
And flings its melodies in every way

That locust hops and swallow darts to find
A hollow in the stony, harkened mind.
I too dart in the hope and joy to know
That You are God of all the earthly glow.

15 Always remember His promise,
The word He commanded for bliss
To a thousand generations.

16 What he made to the benisons
Of Abraham and His oath to
Isaac *son of Abraham true*.

I see and hear, Beloved, the golden ring
Of the commandments in their glorying,
And know indeed that what may seem
command

Is also promise in the things that stand.
The Hebrew words are in a form that can
Be understood as promise as I scan
As well as some imperative to naught.
The ten words are a fruitful field for
thought.

A thousand generations feel the power
Of that one promise given in an hour,
That You will multiply effects of good
Beyond the limits that normally would.
Beloved, I thank You for the promise
spoken
And for the command given out in token.

17 He has confirmed it for a law
To Jacob, and to Israel's maw
For everlasting covenant.
18 Saying "To you I shall present
The land of Canaan for your lot
Inherited *in glorious plot*,
19 When you were only few, a few
And strangers in the land *and pew*."

The promises were given when the just
Were few and single rather than like dust
Of earth or like the shining stars of heaven.
Promises were given when twelve lacked
eleven.

The seed of Abraham throughout the globe
Spreads out beyond ken of the astrolabe,
And fills the world with fear and gracious
deeds

As well as evil on some noxious weeds.
I too turn to the promises, though I
Am not of Abraham's seed on the sly,
But am of heathen stock despite the worth

Of circumcision on the barren earth.
I too turn to the promises as one
Like Abraham did on the day he'd done.

20 They went from nation, land to land,
From kingdom to another band,
21 He let no one do any wrong
To them, even the kings *and strong*
He reproved for their sakes *along*.

The seed of Abraham wandered out wide
As far as tortured Gobi and the side
Of the Yang-tse to find a place to hide
Beneath a brazen sky and on iron earth
To bow in prayer and seek Your name of
worth.

Kings even You reproved to let them live,
And everywhere they spread they have to
give

The blessings of the civilized and true
To every folk they have to come in view.
Beloved, I benefit from that throng set
Among the nations with a message met,
And grasp the noble teaching and the song
And hear it echo in my soul along
Until I find returning night from wrong.

22 "Touch not my anointed and do
My prophets no harm *or pursue*."

King David himself knew the gross
temptation
To touch with evil for the sake of nation
Anointed of Your land, and yet forbore
On every chance he had upon the shore.
King David so established by his hand
And deed untouchable as by command
Every anointed of the Lord to stand.
I hear and obey where I count the score.
Beloved, I peer out from the open door
And see invisibly that You have set
Again anoint ones though rarely met
And hidden from the sight of king and
court.
You jest perhaps in secret, jostling sport,
Protecting divine guides from what they'd
get.

23 Sing to YHWH, all the earth and show
His salvation in each day's glow.

Your chosen folk may be an elite class

And separated from the crazy mass,
But still the whole earth sings to You Your
praise

And raises up Your name on nights and
days,

On silver walks along the frozen shore,
On golden steps above the jewelled door,
In hidden pathways where the little mite
Of squirrel or chipmunk trades the acorn's
right.

Beloved, I too join in the faithful song
Of nature that can never know the wrong,
And add my timid voice in Psalm and
prayer

Upon the dry and dusty desert air.
And thus my pilgrimage from clime to
clime

Is seasoned with Your praise in prose and
rhyme.

24 Declare His glory among men
Of heathen provenance and then
His marvellous works among all
Nations *on earth to rise and fall.*

If glory must be declared among men
Of heathen provenance, then I again
Am one of those, and give thanks that I
find

Both promise and command among the
blind.

You choose a nation no doubt for the best,
But all Your marvels speak that You invest
In every nation, heathen and the rest,
To give the opportunity to know
The dawn to share in work and life and
show

Obedience is possible to go
For even heathens like myself who choose
To live in love and walking in the shoes
Of Your commandments in the right and
good,
In living life as every person should.

25 For YHWH's great, greatly to be
praised
And feared above all others raised.

Is it the greatness that is You that makes
You to be feared instead of all the stakes
Of neighbour and henchmen that offer all
Their services in church and city-hall?

I fear You not for hell or tide or flood,
Nor for the falling on the sword for blood,
I fear You only for the blinding rent
In universe that tells me I am sent
To fill the empty spaces of divine.
I fear that what You offer is the wine.
I fear to fail to praise where praise is due,
I fear to acknowledge the You of You.
And in my fear I rise to praise again
That You are and are not among all men.

26 For all the elevated ones
Among the people's benisons
Are idols, but YHWH made the skies.
27 Glory, honour before His eyes,
Might with joy before His place lies.

The one who sits in power in every place
Is but an idol come before Your face,
And yet it is an idol that reflects
The one true soul, the self the world
neglects.

Idolatry is to fail to see You
In every face, instead of human rue.
There may be one who claims he's made
the skies,

But even in the smaller claim he lies.
There is no self at all but You alone,
Glory, honour and might before Your
throne.

Beloved, I set aside the idol set
In my own heart, and turn out all men met
Except as they reveal Your holy part
And raise Your law and love within the
heart.

28 Give to YHWH, families of the folk,
Give to YHWH glory, power *like oak.*
29 Give to YHWH glory to His name,
Bring gift and come before His claim
To bow down to YHWH in the beauty
Of holiness, *it is your duty.*

I have no beauty here in what I do,
Nor in the face I show to all men's view.
I have no beauty on the strength of mind
Or in the strength of hand to bend and
bind.

I have no beauty here in what I see,
I have no grace in being and to be,
Nor do I show the skill of right and will
Beneath the beauty of the nearest hill.

The only beauty I bring as my gift
Before Your claim is that I come to lift
What You Yourself give in setting apart
Myself in holiness within Your heart.
My beauty is that You stretch out a hand
To touch me in the hope of Your
command.

30 Fear before him, all in the earth,
The world shall stand unmoved *in girth*.

The proof that I should fear You only
stands
That earth will not be moved on seas or
lands.
But the fact is not long ago there came
A tidal wave that slaughtered men and
game.
Beyond that with dull regularity
The earth convulses in some tragedy,
And You still give as evidence that I
Should fear You only, that the world must
lie

At rest beneath a leaden or clear sky.
Beloved, I join with all the graven earth
To fear You only and for just Your worth,
Creator and my Sovereign till I die,
The maker of all things in earth and sea,
The gauge of faith and love eternally.

31 Let the skies be glad, earth rejoice,
And say among the nations' choice,
"YHWH reigns." 32 Let the sea roar and
all
That fills the ocean's beck and call,
Let fields rejoice, all in their stall.

The gates of wonder fill my faith and eye
As I reveal my whirling to the sky.
Let the first gate be air and so be glad
That the last gate is earth not to be sad.
The nations in their gross idolatry
Still must admit You reign eternally.
The third gate, gate of water meets the sea
With roar and ocean's pounding, cleansing
shore.
All turn to the third gate in secret store,
The fields rejoicing in the burning life
That secretly smoulders beneath the knife
Of joy and hope beneath the hopeful sound
Of gourd and grain both springing from the
ground.

Beloved, I touch the barley and leave strife.

33 Then shall the forest trees sing out
At YHWH's presence *as with a shout*
He comes to judge the earth *in rout*.

Beloved, the heart of man is focused on
His own words and his song at summit's
dawn,
And yet the song of forest tree springs
higher
And even katydid drowns out the crier.
All nature and creation have a voice
In Your presence and all things here rejoice
To see that You come down to judge the
earth,
Mayhap it still contains something of
worth,
Though something may not be of human
call
Or made of human flesh and blood at all.
Beloved, I lift a lone voice among men
To signal that I too would once again
Join with the trees in their disparagement
Of human skills as they sing in Your tent.

34 Give thanks to YHWH, for He is good,
His mercy's for all time withstood.

Your mercy, my Beloved, fails not, it's
sure,
For if it did, long since earth would be pure
Of wickedness by human hand and gate.
You had mercy on humankind to rate
Of the ark's number, even up to eight.
Yes, You Beloved, are merciful and good,
If not wise and destructive as You should.
I think I could quickly find out sin's cure.
Beloved, though You are good and
merciful,
Look on Your servant this day at the pull,
And destroy from my heart the false desire,
And from my mind the false light and false
fire,
And from my hand the sword and gold and
oil,
And from my feet the outward, downward
toil.

35 And say "Save us, O Alohim
Of our salvation, and redeem
Together and save from the scheme

Of the heathen, so we may give
Thanks to Your holy name and live
To glory in Your praise *active*.

There is a scheme about me in the way
Set up by wicked men in selfish pay,
So save me, my Beloved, from every task
That they set out to trap and trip and ask.
There is an evil crunch about the dew
As soon as I meet with the common few,
And there's a plan to destroy all in view
That is pure, good, and noble, bright and
gay.

But turn, Beloved, and find that scheme
and plan

That lurks in my own heart and hand and
span,

And break it before dust creeps out to
choke

The breath beneath Your light and easy
yoke.

Then I shall give thanks to Your holy name
And live to glory in Your praise and fame.

36 Blessed be YHWH Israel's Alohim
For ever and ever supreme.
And all the people said "Amen"
And praised YHWH *again and again*.

If all the people could once more repeat
The amen from the heart and hand and feet
In doing and in following the treat
Of Your bright Decalogue before the seat
Of judgement and of glory here replete,
I should find You blessed truly by all those
Who now in dire hypocrisy arose
To pretend to justice while making do
With business interests and of those not
few.

Beloved, I bow and say amen among
A crowd of people who Your name have
sung,

And yet I doubt the cunning and the right
That still appear on left as well as fight.

Five thousand knees have not bent, yes I
know,

And so I bend too at Medina's glow.

37 So he left there before the ark
Of YHWH's covenant the wight stark
Asaph and his brothers to work
Before the ark and not to shirk

As required every day to park.
38 And Obededom with their kin
To sixty-eight *numbered in bin*,
Obededom also the son

Of Jeduthun and Hosah won
To be porters *and carry in*.

39 And Zadok the priest and his kin
The priests before YHWH's tent go in
The high place there at Gibeon,

40 To offer burnt sacrifice to
YHWH on the altar of burnt crew
Always morning and evening, do
According to all that is writ
In the law of YHWH which He fit
Commanded Israel to commit.

Leave me here, my Beloved, before the ark
In whose bosom of gold there shines the
stark

And wondered letters of the Decalogue
Enough to lead and call a dervish dog.

Leave me here, my Beloved, to sing the
song

With Asaph and his brothers in the throng
Of fair musician who no nothing wrong,
A member of the choir, if but a cog.

Leave me here, my Beloved, a priest to
bring

The sacrifice of living and whirling
Before the holy ark, and so to keep
The step in Decalogue's fast dance or
weep.

Leave me here on the altar to arise
A burning spark to You upon the skies.

41 And with them Heman, Jeduthun,
And the rest chosen on the run,
Marked down by name to give thanks to
YHWH, since His mercy's always due.

42 Along with Heman Jeduthun
With trumpets and cymbals' bassoon
For those to make a sound with God's
Musical instruments *and rods*.
Jeduthun's sons carried the lot.

43 And all the people left and got
Each to his own house, and David
Came back to bless his house *and lid*.

Some go back to their own houses to live,
Some go to take and some go back to give,
But one soul turns with David to enquire
In David's house after the blessed fire.

Some go to mill and some to market street,
Some go in chariot, some on their feet,
But one soul whirls above the blood and
mire

To find in David's house the heart's desire.
I raise a trumpet to call a sweet tune,
I raise the crashing cymbals and bassoon,
I raise the harp of David and I sing
A slighter note than ever heard on wing
To find in David's house the way to You,
Beloved, the way to what at last is true.

1 Chronicles 17

1 It happened as David sat in
His house, that David with chagrin
Said to Nathan the prophet, "See,
I live in house of cedar tree,
But YHWH's ark of covenant stands
Under tent-flaps upon the sands.
2 So Nathan told David, "Just do
All you intend, Alohim's *true*
To bless it and to be with you."

Beloved, it is not as in olden time
That You have no house to bear up the
grime.
There is Your house in Makkah and one
where
The golden dome crowns Quds with sweet
and fair.
There is one at Madinah's plain below
The mountains that still smell of perfumed
glow.
A fourth one, my Beloved, though humble
true
Is my heart waiting to be filled by You.
Your prophet comes to hear my heart's
desire,
Your prophet speaks in words of honeyed
fire,
And yet I wait before the golden throne
And bow to You and bow to You alone.
Your ark is set beneath the sand-strewn
flaps
Of my tattered temple, seen through its
gaps.

3 It came to pass that very night
That Alohim's word came in sight
To Nathan, 4 "Tell David My slave,
'So says YHWH, "You shall not lift glaive
To build a house where I may dwell.

5 "For I've not stayed in house the spell
Since I carried up Israel
To this day, but have gone from tent
To tent, from hut to hut I went.

6 "Wherever I've gone with all those
Folk of Israel, I never chose
To say a word to any judge
In Israel commanding fudge
To feed My folk and say to him
'Where is My house with cedar trim?'"

7 "So now you shall say to David,
My servant, 'So says YHWH for bid,
'I took you from pasturing sheep,
And standing where the cattle creep,
To rule over Israel my folk,

8 "And I've been with you to a stroke
Wherever you walked, and I've cut
Off all your enemies that strut
Before you, and have made a name
For you like that of men of fame
Upon the earth *here where you came.*

9 "And I will set a place for my
Folk Israel, and plant them by,
And they'll always live in their place,
And never be moved out of trace,
Neither shall sons of wickedness
Destroy them longer with duress,
As at the start of *their address,*

10 "And since the time I set up men
To judge over my folk again
In Israel. I shall subdue
All your enemies come in view,
And I declare to you that YHWH
Will come to build a house for you.

Let me, Beloved, build in my wayward
way
A temple of false works for You today.
Let me not take the time of brick and stone,
Let me not set up here another throne.
The ways of means by men are never slow,
They are fleet in the crooked paths they go
To built them temples to the hallowed sky
Or knock them down again and wonder
why.

I wait, Beloved, for that tent You redress
In hushed halls of the forest where You
bless

My soul with song of tree and bird and
guss

Of fox behind the boulder and the mess
Of bushes caught in speckled sun's relief.

Build me Your temple of grace in my grief.

11 “And it shall happen when your days
Are over and you come to praise
Of your ancestors, I will raise
Up your descendants after you,
One of your sons, and I will set
His kingdom up *and not forget*.

12 “That one shall build a house for me,
I’ll set his throne eternally.

13 “I’ll be his father counsellor,
And he’ll be My son *in his store*
Of faithfully obeying Me:

And I’ll not remove My mercy
From him as I took from the one
Who was before you *on the gun*.

14 “But I’ll establish him in My
House and My kingdom and for aye,
And his throne shall be set *and sure*,
For ever and ever *endure*. ””

15 By all these words and by this view
Did Nathan speak to David’s *pew*.

The promise of a gloried son to be
Is given many times to king and free,
The promise of a son to keep Your will
And build a temple on the earth to fill
Its continents and islands with the sound
Of heaven and glory come upon the
ground,

Is promise true. And yet my history
Shows that such temples fall and fail
decree.

The temple falls indeed, and yet three days
Suffice to grant return into Your praise.
The temple lies in broken mass of death,
But in three days You give Your temple
breath.

Beloved, I whirl beneath the gallows here
And rise up in Your temple without fear.

16 And David the king came and sat
Before YHWH and declared out flat,
“Who am I, YHWH Alohim, that
You’ve brought me to this *place and power*
And what is my house *for an hour*?

17 “But this was a small thing in Your
Eyes, Alohim, for You restore
Your servant’s house for age to come,
Regarding me as high in sum,
O YHWH Alohim, *and not bum*.

18 “So what can David do for You

In thanks for the honour in view
Of Your servant? Indeed You know
Your servant *well from head to toe*.

19 “YHWH, for Your servant’s sake, and
by

Your own heart You came to comply
With all this greatness to the sky.

20 “YHWH, there is none like You to be
Alohim, a God high and free,
Beside You, by all we have heard
With our ears *of what things occurred*.

21 “What single nation on the earth
Is like Your folk Israel in worth,
Whom Alohim went to redeem
As His own people *in the scheme*,
To make You great and fearful fame,
By driving out nations in claim
Before Your people, whom You’ve taken
Out of Egypt *and Egypt shaken*.

22 “For Your folk Israel You once made
Your own folk always on parade,
You, YHWH, became their Alohim.

The modesty of David is the way
His followers go out upon the May,
Not circling heathen pole or padding round
To honours decked out on the clean-swept
ground,

But recognizing that the heart must bow
Beneath the heart of David and somehow
Reclaim the share of modesty even now
That desert sand covers the temple sound.
The dervish way of David does not claim
The rising columns of the wealth and game
That hold out to chance on earth for its
fame.

The dervish way of David bows beneath
A humble flower instead of laurel wreath,
And rises to find David all the same.

23 “So now, YHWH, let the thing You say
About Your servant then bear sway,
And concerning his house be set
For ever, say, do not forget.

24 “So let it be established that
Your name may be made great thereat
Forever, saying “YHWH of hosts
Is Israel’s Alohim *for boasts*,
A God to Israel, and so let
The house of David Your slave get
Established before You and set.

25 “For You, my Alohim, have told

Your servant You will build him *bold*
 A house, and that's why Your slave finds
Courage to pray before Your *blinds*.
 26 "And now, YHWH, You are Alohim,
 This good promised Your slave in dream.
 27 "So therefore let it please You bless
 The house of Your servant's address,
 So it may stand always before
 You, for You bless, YHWH, and that store
 You bless is blessed for evermore."

Beloved, You are Alohim and my best
 Encounter does not change that for the rest.
 I may join in David's resounding call
 To give Your name the honour at the wall,
 Or turn in darkness where my way in dust
 Will disappear as every phantom must.
 The choice to be or not to be is mine,
 I may eat nothing or come here to dine
 Where all the universe displayed reveals
 Your name of grace that destroys and that
 heals.

Beloved, as I follow David's fair tent
 I find the path and office where You went.

1 Chronicles 18

1 It happened after this that David
 Attacked the Philistines, enslaved
 Them and took Gath and suburbs out
 Of the hand of Philistine rout.
 2 And he attacked Moab so that
 The Moabites came in and sat
 As David's servants and brought gifts.
 3 And David contrived in his shifts
 To strike down Hadarezer king
 Of Zobah up to Hamath's ring,
 As he went to set up his rule
 By the river Euphrates' *pool*.
 4 And David took from him in all
 A thousand chariots and the gall
 Of seven thousand cavalry,
 And twenty thousand infantry;
 And David hamstrung every one
 Except a hundred chariots done.

I raise my bitter soul against the loss
 Of nine hundred equestrians by toss,
 As though a horse could not feel pain or
 weight
 When hamstrung by a king out with his
 state.
 I raise my bitter voice against the heel

Of those in power like David to appeal
 To You, Beloved, and if Your heart is
 theirs,
 I mutely send the stars complaint for cares.
 Come off Your throne, Beloved, and see
 the fright
 Glint in the eye of horse that fateful night,
 And prove the divine unimpassioned right.
 Without eternity, omniscient power,
 I tremble with the steed a crying hour
 Before I meet the grave, the kiln, or tower.

5 When Syrians of Damascus came
 To help Hadarezer of name
 As king of Zobah, David slew
 The Syrian men twenty and two
 Thousand. 6 Then David built a fort
 In Syria's Damascus for sport,
 The Syrians became David's slaves
 And brought gifts *of the things he craves*.
 So YHWH saved David everywhere
 He went *and gave him double share*.
 7 And David took the shields of gold
 That were on Hadarezer's bold
 Warriors, brought to Jerusalem.
 8 The same from Tibhath and from Chun,
 Hadarezer's cities *for fun*,
 He brought their brass in lot from which
 Solomon made the brazen ditch
 And pillars and pot, every gem.

So many times I've grieved to know the
 glitter
 Of gold from Solomon's temple was bitter
 To be bourn off to Babylon one day
 When Nebuchadnezzar came out to play.
 The pots and sherds of silver and the dross
 Were all taken to temples set for loss
 In honour of the idols on the shore
 Of the Euphrates behind iron door.
 Now I know that gold too was stolen once,
 And I have been shedding the tears of
 dunce.
 You own all things, and what reaches the
 hand
 Of man is merely lent in contraband.
 Beloved, I joy to know my empty plate
 Is filled with wealth without stealing in
 wait.

9 So when Tou king of Hamath heard
 How David attacked all the herd

Of Hadarezer Zobah's king,
 10 He sent Hadoram his son to
 King David to enquire his due,
 Congratulating him, because
 He'd battled Hadarezer's *paws*,
 And overcome him, since the wight
 Had war with Tou *and constant fight*,
 And gained all kinds of pots of gold,
 Silver and brass *and things untold*.
 11 Those things too King David gave to
 YHWH in dedication as due,
 The silver and gold that he brought
 From all the nations that he fought,
 From Edom, Moab and the sons
 Of Ammon and Philistine buns,
 And from Amalek in their tons.
 12 Moreover Abishai the son
 Of Zeruiah killed a ton
 Of Edomites in Vale of Salt,
 Eighteen thousand *at one assault*.
 13 He built some forts in Edom too,
 And all the Edomites in crew
 Became David's slave servants too.
 So YHWH saved David everywhere
 He went *and kept him in His care*.
 14 David reigned over all the folk
 Of Israel, and judged them with yoke
 Of justice among all his folk.
 15 Joab the son of Zeruiah
 Was over the army pariah,
 Jehoshaphat Ahilud's son
 Recorded everything then done.
 16 Zadok the son of Ahitub,
 And Abimelech for a rub
 The son of Abiathar, were priests,
 And Shavsha was scribe *of their feasts*.
 17 Benaiah Jehoiada's son
 Was over the Cherethites' run
 And Pelethites, and David's sons
 Where chief around the king *as shuns*.

Not only cruelty to animals rises
 In David's court, but nepotism's prizes.
 I'm thoroughly disgusted with the ways
 Of my best hero, author of my praise.
 Beloved, if David's heart is like Your own,
 I do not crave the shelter of Your throne.
 What wars and bloodshed creep about his
 head
 And what oppressions soften David's bed!
 And yet, Beloved, I have no doubt that I
 As king on any throne would never sigh

To see my foes reduced to dust and cry.
 My heart is Yours and Yours is mine, and
 yet
 I doubt my mercy is as great to set
 As David's. My Beloved, we've barely
 met.

1 Chronicles 19

1 It happened after this the king
 Of Ammon's children and their sting
 Nahash died, and his son reigned then.
 2 And David said "I'll show again
 Kindness to Hanun, Nahash' son,
 Because of what his dad has done
 In kindness to me. David sent
 Messengers to comfort the bent
 In sorrow for his father's *death*.
 So David's servants *out of breath*
 Came to children of Ammon's land
 To Hanun, comfort towed in hand.
 3 But Ammon's children's princes said
 To Hanun, "Do you think instead
 That David brings praise to your dead
 Father, by sending comforters
 To you? Are his slaves not such fers
 Come to you to seek, overthrow
 And spy out the land *where they go?*"
 4 So Hanun took David's lads and
 Shaved them and cut off at a band
 Their clothing in the middle of
 Their buttocks and sent out with shove.
 5 So some went and told David how
 The men were dealt with in the row.
 And he sent out to meet them, for
 The men were embarrassed to floor.
 And the king said "Stay at the town
 Of Jericho till beards be grown,
 And then come back *to the king's door*."
 6 When Ammon's folk saw they had made
 Themselves hateful and on parade
 To David, Hanun and the folk
 Of Ammon sent a thousand broke
 Talents of silver to rent out
 Chariots and cavalry in clout
 From Mesopotamia, and out
 Of Syriamaachah and out
 Of Zobah. 7 So they hired thirty
 Two thousand chariots and the fee
 Of Maachah's king and his folk too,
 Who came and camped before the wall
 Of Medeba. And at the call
 Ammon's folk gathered from their towns,

And came to battle *full of frowns*.

The workings of diplomacy today
Hardly differ at all from what bore sway
Between old Ammon and Israel when one
King died and the throne bore his favoured
son.

Israel can still raise havoc with a smile,
And Ammon still treat public with some
guile.

It's all expected diplomatic mile,
And still the kings hire Tony Bear to join
George Rush in the attempt to mint the
coin

Afresh and at the same time make a buck,
Or shekel or euro or fine cornshuck.

Beloved, look on this simple crew of Yours
And take a jaunt on Middle Eastern Tours,
And give a word to lift us from the muck.

8 When David heard, he sent Joab
And all the army with confab
Of mighty men. 9 And Ammon's folk
Came out and set battle in stroke
Before the city gate. The kings
That came were alone in the rings.

10 When Joab saw the battle set
Against him fore and aft, both met,
He chose the best of all the folk
Of Israel and put them in stroke
Against the Syrians in yoke.

11 The rest of the army he put
In hand of Abishai in root
His brother, and they set in rank
Against Ammon's folk *on the bank*.

12 And he said "If the Syrians
Are too strong for me, then your plans
Shall be to help me, but if those
Folk of Ammon are strong to close
Around you, then I'll beef your shows.

13 "Be of good courage, let us quit
Ourselves like men for those who sit
In cities of our Alohim,
And let YHWH do the good it seem."

14 So Joab and the folk with him
Came near the Syrians to the grim
Fight, and they fled in front of him.

Too many centuries of blood and mey
Have turned around the cedars and the way
Of Lebanon as far as Damask's shore

Making the world a place of flood and
gore.

As I review the history of the place
Southwest of the Euphrates in its trace,
Much tells me that nothing has chanced,
but still

Come Israel's armies out to foot the bill.
Enough of bloodshed now, suffice the
plunder,

Let peace at last come under Sinai's
thunder,

While men of kind and women of their kin
Awaken to the warning sound and din.
I pray for peace in all the world but most
Now where Jerusalem meets the last boast.

15 And when Ammon's folk saw them
flee,

They also fled before the spree
Of Abishai his brother, and
Went into the city to stand.
Joab went to Jerusalem.

16 And when the Syrians saw that they
Were worsted before Israel's fray,
They sent their messengers to say
To Syrians beyond the stream,
With Shophach captain of the cream
Of Hadarezer before them.

17 And it was told to David, and
He gathered all Israel to stand,
And went over Jordan and came
On them and attacked in their fame.
When David attacked Syrians,
They fought with him *in greys and tans*.

18 The Syrians fled at the onslaught
Of Israel, and David in plot
Killed seven thousand chariot men
Of Syrians, and forty then
Thousand of infantry, and killed
Shophach the army captain *billed*.

19 When Hadarezer's servants saw
That they fell under Israel's claw,
They made peace with David to be
His servants, nor would Syrians see
Their way to help Ammon's folk free.

Tony and George should take a second
look

How many mercenaries in the book
Outright are killed in one swoop of the
crook.

Maybe they'd wait a moment more until

All arguments are silenced on the hill.
 Some days are good for war, no doubt, and
 yet
 My heart and hope say that the foe when
 met
 Can be brought to good terms without the
 gun
 Enlarged to flatten out the mountains won.
 Laugh if you will at all the victories
 While turning eyes away from what won't
 please,
 A population slaughtered in the breeze.
 I throw the world's insane with blood and
 lust,
 No one it seems bows down to kiss the
 dust.

1 Chronicles 20

1 It happened after that year ended,
 At the time kings go out unfended,
 Joab led out the army's strength,
 Wasted Ammon's folk's country's length,
 And came besieging Rabbah too.
 But David stayed within the view
 Of his Jerusalem. Then struck
 Joab Rabbah down in the muck.
 2 And David took their king's crown off
 His head and found without a scoff
 Its weight was one talent of gold,
 With precious stones within it told,
 And it was set on David's head,
 And he also took from the spread
 Of the city booty as said.
 3 And he brought out the folk in it,
 And cut them with saws and the bit
 Of iron harrows, and with axe.
 That's how David treated their backs,
 And all the towns of Ammon's folk.
 David and all the army went
 Back to Jerusalem *when spent*.

Tough talk and action on David's own part
 Horrifies me, brings sorrow to my heart
 Out of the sparkling crown the mind can
 bend
 Meat threshed with harrows and with axes
 send
 Among the populations of the wood
 Some message of a thing that can no good
 Message bestow. And yet, I think the
 power

Come down from heaven upon a blessed
 hour
 Enunciates the judgement of Your reign.
 Let Your judgement come with consequent
 pain.
 Why should I complain that the world must
 bear
 A pain resulting from the wicked share
 In all that government and company
 Now exposed to earth's human progeny?

4 It happened after that there rose
 A war at Gezer with the foes
 Of Philistines, at which time slew
 Sibbechai the Hashathite due
 Sippai, who was of giant's spawn,
 And they were scattered on the lawn.
 5 And there was war again in sight
 With Philistines, and so the wight
 Elhanan Jair's son killed Lahmi
 The brother of Goliath, see,
 The Gittite, whose spear staff to see
 Was like a weaver's beam fairly.
 6 Once more there was a war at Gath,
 Where there was a tall man in path,
 Whose fingers and toes number to
 Twenty-four six in each hand's crew,
 And six on each foot, he was too
 The son of a giant *in view*.
 7 But when he challenged Israel,
 Jonathan the son of the fell
 Shimea, David's brother came
 To kill him *and receive the fame*.
 8 These were the giant's sons in Gath,
 And they fell by David's hand's wrath,
 And by the hand of his servants,
Till there was no giant to dance.

Thanks for the felling of the giants in
 Harboured days of David, and without sin.
 Our times have changed but little since the
 din
 Made out Goliath stricken with his kin.
 A little man may now slay hundreds more
 Slinking about in armoured tank and store.
 Many are ways to kill prolifering.
 Come morning though I see there is no
 king
 Emancipated from the wicked place
 Lying where evil plans are set to trace
 With all destruction of the human race.
 Another time perhaps will see anointed

Instead of juiced-up thugs and double-jointed.
No doubt divinely guided slaughter's grace.

1 Chronicles 21

1 And Satan rose against Israel
Inciting David to compile
A list of Israel's folk on file.
2 And David said to Joab and
To the folk's chiefs, "Go out in band
And count Israel from Beersheba
As far as Dan and bring in claw
Their number to me so I'll know."
3 Joab replied, "May YHWH now show
His people hundredfold in glow
More than they are, but now my lord
The king, are they not all on board
As my lord's servants, the whole horde?
Why then does my lord so require
This matter? Why should he desire
To be a cause of wickedness
To Israel *and not to bless?*"

So Satan is the one who came to speak
To David in a moment he was weak.
The other text says You did that bright
thing.
I wonder should I stop to ask the king.
Today the followers of Moses stand
To be counted as Jews on every hand.
The followers of Christ take every pew
And claim to be the ones to follow You.
The Muslims weep or not beside the grave
Of Ahmed and vow to be Allah's slave.
I bind all three into my own and take
David to be my leader for the sake
Of Moses, Jesus, Muhammad and still
The divine guide that hides upon the hill.

4 But yet the king's word won the day
Against Joab, who went his way
Throughout all Israel's land and came
Back to Jerusalem *for shame*.
5 And Joab gave the figure's sum
Of the folk to David to hum.
And all Israel were up to stand
Up at one thousand thousand and
A hundred thousand men that drew
The sword, and Judah was in crew
Four hundred seventy thousand men
That also drew the sword again.

6 But Levi and Benjamin he
Did not count among the folk's spree,
For the king's word detestedly
Fell on Joab's ear *and wrongly*.
7 And Alohim was displeased by
This thing, and so He *from the sky*
Struck Israel *both gal and guy*.

Why did You strike the people from the
sky,
Beloved, did any of them want to die?
The Bible makes You seem unjust to me,
Perhaps because I'm blinded by a flea.
Did You strike also men of Benjamin
And Levi too as though they were in sin?
Perhaps Your striking was to show the
crowd
Not to think or to say the thing aloud,
That suffering's the result of the deed
Of evil punished by the Lord for greed,
And happiness and success are the sign
That people live by Your revealed design.
Beloved, strike out in arbitrary way
And none can rise to question night or day.

8 And David said to Alohim,
"I've greatly sinned, it so would seem,
Because I've done this wicked thing,
But now, I beg you, on the wing
To wipe out Your slave's wickedness,
For I've made a foolish address."
9 And YHWH spoke to Gad, David's seer,
Saying "Go say in David's ear
This word, 'So says YHWH, "I make clear
To offer you three, so choose one,
So I may strike you on the bun.'""
11 So Gad came to David and said
To him, "So says YHWH, 'Choose your
bed,
12 'Either three years not to be fed,
Or three months attacked by your foes,
While enemy sword vents in throes,
Or else three days with sword of YHWH,
A pestilence on land and crew,
And YHWH's angel destroying through
All the lands of Israel in view.'
Now think about what message I
Shall take returning to the guy
Who sent me." 13 David said to Gad,
"I'm greatly troubled *and I'm sad*.
Let me I pray fall in YHWH's hand,
Since His mercies are very grand,

But do not let me come beneath
The power of men and men's bequeath."

Look here, Beloved, what You did to the
church

Of David when You found them in the
lurch.

David repented of forbidden deed,
But You required another thing in need.
Your grace was not enough to spare the
rod,

You had to show the folks that You were
God.

So after David prayed repentant prayer
You gave him three wishes out of thin air.
Do famine, sword of enemy, and doom
Atone for any sin You find in room?
If You were about to send David's son
To die for all the evil things he'd done
Then why kill off the Israelites to show
Atonement's needed even on the go?

14 So YHWH sent pestilence upon
Israel, and seventy thousand drawn
Of Israel dropped. 15 And Alohim
Sent out an angel to the cream
Jerusalem to destroy it.

While he destroyed YHWH looked at bit
And changed His mind about the fit,
And told the angel that destroyed,
"It is enough that you've employed,
So stop." The angel of YHWH stood
Beside the threshing floor for good
Of Ornan, one a Jebusite.

16 Then David raised his eyes to light
Upon YHWH's angel standing there
Between the earth, between the air,
With drawn sword in his hand made bare
Over Jerusalem the fair.

And David and the elders met
In sackcloth, in prostration set
Upon their faces. 17 David said
To Alohim, "Was it not I
Who gave the order on the sly
To count the people? I have sinned
And done the evil when I grinned,
But these sheep, what have they done You?
Stretch out Your hand, I pray O YHWH
My Alohim, be against me
And my dad's house, but not in spree
Against Your folk destructively."

If Your eye then, Beloved, stopped the
plague when

You saw the desolation of the men
Of Judah, and You thought the plague
enough

To atone for the disobeying rough,
Then why did You not look once on the
cross

And see the sufferings of the man of loss?
Enough's enough for You in David's day,
So why pretend the cross is there to pay?

It looks to me like You do what You like
Without necessity to make the strike.
You send men into death and let the blood
Fall precious on the ground as though in
flood

Of useless sacrifice. Indeed I know
No useful thing is evil in the show.

18 That's why YHWH's angel ordered
Gad

To tell him it would not be bad
For David to go and to build
An altar to YHWH on the filled
Threshing floor of Ornan the wight
Who owned it and was Jebusite.

19 So David went up by command
Of Gad, which he spoke out of hand
In the name of YHWH *where to stand*.
20 Now Ornan turned and saw the man
Or angel rather, and his span
Of four sons with him ran and hid,
But Ornan kept threshing his quid.

This Ornan of the threshing floor has
spunk,
Working in the hot sun, he may be drunk.
In any case the angel does not faze
Ornan or put him in a mystic daze.
He keeps his business sense about him
while

His four sons flee who knows how many
mile.

The angel was destroyer on the brink,
But Ornan's courage failed on from his
drink.

David wanted to sacrifice so bad
Your angel gave permission then through
Gad.

How many seek permission for the groan
Of sacrificing Jesus on the throne
Of high altar from mass to mass today?

You don't hand out contracts now anyway.

21 Then David came to Ornan, and
Ornan looked and saw David stand.
And he went from the threshing floor,
And bowed before David to pour
His face to the ground *to adore*.

Hah! Ornan knows the difference between
A visionary angel on the scene
And king with power to grant and to
destroy.

The plague of angels is nothing of joy,
But cannot be proved by constant employ,
Empirical plot shows an empty field,
While kings are there to polish the well-
heeled.

So Ornan knows to bow and give the bean.
Beloved, I too see angels twittering
About my window. Who knows what they
bring

In plague now-days. If truth be told I find
Them as awesome before my chambered
mind

As any other royalty combined.
I think both are a privilege in kind.

22 Then David said to Ornan, "Let
Me have this place so I can get
This threshing floor, so I may build
An altar here to YHWH fulfilled.
Just sell it to me at its price
To take away the plague in trice
From my folk." 23 Ornan said aloud
To David, "Take *it* for your crowd,
And may my lord the king do good
In his sight. See, I give the wood
Of threshing cane, the oxen too
For a burnt offering as due,
And wheat for the meat offering too,
I give it all *from me to you*.

Ornan says he will give the king the plot.
Well, that's just Canaanite and Hittite way
Of being polite beneath the sun's ray.
They start the bidding from that gain
ungot.

The same thing happened with dear
Abraham

Who waited for the sons of Heth to give
A grave for those who would no longer
live

Beneath the canopy of tent and lamb.
Beloved, You are my king and yet You
come

To buy my inner temple for a sum.
I promise it to You and free of debt,
But You bid for it more than gold can get.
I give You but the self that You bestow,
You give me all the universe in tow.

24 Then King David said to Ornan,
"No, but I'll surely buy *the span*
For the fair price, for I'll not take
What's yours for YHWH, nor give in stake
Burnt offerings that cost me no flake."

25 So David gave Ornan the weight
Of six hundred shekels in state
Of gold for the place *and the rate*.

26 And David built an altar there
To YHWH, and offered burnt affair
And peace offerings, and called on
YHWH,

And He answered him from the sky
By fire on the altar whereby
Burnt offering *was made on the sly*.

Six hundred shekels of gold, by Your
word,

That is a sum royal from royal bird.
No wonder Ornan felt it safe to promise
Both land and oxen, though a doubting
Thomas.

If David came to beg of me my land
Knowing the charisma of David's hand
No doubt I too would give him all he asked
And left him midnight sun in which I
basked.

Let David's altar be set up where I
Tend to the clouds that paint the moving
sky,

Watch with a helping eye the firs that pass
From summer into winter like green grass.
My heart's an altar here, myself the lamb
That lives a moment, a bare spark, a gram.

27 And YHWH ordered the angel, and
He put up his sword from his hand.

28 At that time, when David saw that
YHWH had answered him *where he sat*
On threshing floor of Jebusite
Ornan, he sacrificed *in rite*.

29 For the tent of YHWH and the place
Of slaughter of burnt offering's *grace*,

Which Moses in the wilderness
Had made, *were* then at the address
Of the high place in Gibeon's *press*.
30 But David could not go before
It to ask Alohim in store,
Because he feared the angel's sword
Who came in the name of the LORD.

David fears more the angel than does he
Who threshes out the wheat and the barley.
Experience and knowledge and the test
Of faith brings fear into the godly breast.
The blind and ignorant are those who know
No fear before the divine angel's show.
The reason so few see the sword drawn foe
Or hear angelic word or bow to find
The brightness far too bright for human
mind,
Is simply because angels like to dance
On heads of pins too small for human
prance.
The slightly twittered song on window
pane
Well goes unnoticed in both sun and rain,
Goes unrecognized for its feathered pants.

1 Chronicles 22

1 Well David said "This *is* the house
Of YHWH Alohim, *and not mouse*,
This *is* the altar of burnt offering
For Israel *when they come in proffering*."
2 Then David ordered they should bring
The foreigners who came to sing
In Israel's land, and he set up
The masons to dress stones in cup
To build the house of Alohim.
3 And David gathered iron in lots
For pins in the gate hinges' plots
And for the jointures, brass in bin
More than can be counted *for sin*,
4 And cedar trees in plenty too,
And those from Tyre brought lots of true
Cedar wood to David *in crew*.
5 So David said, "Solomon my
Son *is* young and just fit to try,
And the house to be built for YHWH
Renowned and glorious in view
Through all the lands, I will be fit
To make preparation for it."
And David did a lot of things
On that account before death's stings.
6 He summoned at last Solomon,

And ordered him who was his son
To build a dwelling place for YHWH
Alohim of Israel and true.

David too circumvents word of the Lord
That told him he could not be the adored
To build a temple. Instead of submission,
He comes as close as he can to
commission.
He does not build, but gathers all in store.
He does not lift a hammer, but the floor
Is filled with all the temple stones and
bones.
David's obedience in letter tones
Does not follow in spirit of the law.
Such is man's way who lifts the tooth and
claw.
The Bible is a book that tells the story
Of circumvention of commandments'
glory,
And every man still comes to it to read
Why he need not obey, at least in seed.

7 And David said to Solomon,
"My son, for my part it was done
In my intention for to build
A temple for YHWH's name fulfilled
Who is my Alohim *instilled*.
8 "But YHWH's word came to me and said
'Great wars and much blood you have
shed,
You shall not build a house in fame
For me, because you've shed much blood
On earth before My eyes in flood.

If David was obedient to kill
Coming after merciful Saul to fill
The shoes of one who refused in the end
To commit destruction on human friend,
Then he should not be punished for the fact
That he was faithful to the divine act.
Let David build his temple! All men must
In three-score and ten years of eating dust.
Who is here innocent of blood and shame,
Who eat the widows' portion and the game
Of orphans left to flounder in the flood
Of stolen oil and gold stuck in the mud?
Beloved, be just and merciful and see
What disobedience You have let free.

9 'Truly a son shall be born you,
Who'll be a man of peace in pew,

And I will give him rest from all
 His foes around *in field and hall*.
 His name shall be Solomon, for
 I will give peace and quiet store
 To Israel in his days *for score*.
 10 'He'll build a temple for My fame,
 And he shall be My son in name,
 And I *will be* his Father too,
A counsellor for what to do,
 And I will set his kingdom's throne
 Over Israel till time atone.'

The temple Solomon, the son of peace,
 Built for the world and nation in release,
 Was not erected from the iron and stone
 And wood and gold that David from his
 throne
 Gathered in grateful store for useless glory.
 The real temple of this ancient story
 Was written in a song of love that few
 Have understood, but every man in pew
 Has heard with awe before the tinkling
 sound
 Of Song of Solomon upon the ground.
 The temple of the son of peace, Islam's
 Great prophet, son of David in his balms
 Contains the secret word and love in heart.
 So David and Solomon did their part.

11 "Now, my son, may YHWH be with
 you,
 And make prosper all that you do
 Establishing the house of YHWH
 Your Alohim who promised you.
 12 "May YHWH just give you wisdom and
 Knowledge to reign on Israel's band,
 So you may keep the law of YHWH
 Your God *in everything you do*.
 13 "Then you will prosper, if you take
 Care to obey the statutes' stake
 And judgments with which YHWH gave
 charge
 To Moses of Israel at large.
 Be strong and of good courage, do
 Not be afraid, dismayed in pew.
 14 "Truly I've gathered up with care
 For the house of YHWH and its share
 One hundred thousand talents gold,
 A thousand thousand talents told
 In silver, brass and iron more
 Than can be counted in the store.
 I've gathered lumber and stone too,

And you can add more to the stew.
 15 "And you have lots of workmen too,
 Carpenters and stonecutters' crew,
 All kinds of skilful men that do
 All kinds of work *for revenue*.
 16 "No limits to silver and gold
 And brass and iron *if all be told*,
 Get up and get busy, and may
 YHWH be with you to bless your way."

I take the gold of universe I find
 About me in such wealth that I am blind
 Before the glare and glory of the filled
 Temple of world that only You could
 build.
 I take the iron and stone, the cedar tree
 And build of it my prayer and song to be
 A temple to Your Name ascending free
 In tones heard only by the bird and beast,
 The ear of poverty, humility.
 I see the building blocks rise in the east
 And in grander parade file to the west
 Leaving the divine temple in my breast.
 Beloved, the self that fills my temple here
 Is none but Yours alone and without fear.

17 David also ordered the chiefs
 Of all Israel to bring reliefs
 To Solomon his son, and said
 18 "*Has* not YHWH your Alohim sped
 To be with you? And has He *not*
 Provided respite in your plot?
 He's set the dwellers in the land
 Delivered captive in my hand,
 That land is subjugated to
 His chosen people before YHWH.
 19 Establish your heart and your soul
 To search for YHWH and let your goal
 Be your Alohim. So get up
 And build the sanctuary cup
 Of YHWH Alohim, bring the ark
 Of covenant of YHWH to park
 And holy pots of Alohim
 Into the building made supreme
 For fame of YHWH *to see and hark*."

Ah, my Beloved, what words of David
 crown
 The temple song I find around the town!
 The great and glorious Trinity I see:
 Establish your hearth, the first thing to be.

Let your heart search for YHWH, that a
thing true,

The second person of the thing I do.
And third in the great idol I set up
Is to let my goal be no golden cup
But Alohim. These three are gods enough,
And so I spit out all the meat that's tough.
But wait! There are more persons in the
show:

Bring the ark of covenant where the glow
Of Decalogue is great, and holy pots,
The instruments of Ahmed in their lots.

1 Chronicles 23

1 Now when David was old and bowed
Beneath the weight of days in crowd,
He made his son called Solomon
King over Israel *for fun*.

2 He summoned all of Israel's chiefs
With priests and Levites *in their briefs*.

3 The Levites were counted to start
From age thirty to do their part,
And they numbered to thirty-eight
Thousand *all gathered at the gate*.

4 Twenty-four thousand of those had
The job custodial, not bad,
Of YHWH's house, while six thousand
more

Were civil servant at the door
Of judges, 5 while four thousand sat
About the gates in formal pat,
And four thousand more came to praise
YHWH with instruments in the ways
Appointed them for giving praise.

The Levites' tasks were all divided up
Into four groups of holy things to sup.
The great majority of functionaries
Were cleaners of the temple for their
berries.

The others were just left to judge and sit
And sing the songs of David to be fit.
Who think the temple needs no cleansing
ought

To think how many Levites were once
taught

To wield a broom instead of censor there,
And use a mop instead of offerings' share
Of knife. Another spectacle that seeks
Admittance to my mind, from curtains'
peeks,

Is that the load of blood and filth required

Also means more the cleaners are desired.

6 Then too David set them in groups
Of Levi's descendants in coops:
Those of Gerson, Kohath and last
Merari *to give a great blast*.

7 Of Gershonites: Laadan Shimei.

8 The sons of Laadan: the first guy
Jehiel, then Zetham and Joel
Three *in all body, bone and soul*.

9 The sons of Shimei: Shelomith,
Haziël, and Haran—three *kith*.

These were the chiefs of fathers' clan
In all the house of Ben Laadan.

10 And the sons of Shimei: Jahath,
Zina, Jeush, Beriah's *math*.
These *were* the four sons of Shimei.

11 Jahath was the first *on the sly*
And Zizah the second *man's cry*.

But Jeush and Beriah did
Not have so many sons *to bid*,
That's why they were appointed to
One father house all in one crew.

I have no sons at all, I'm not Levite,
So I must be apportioned to the right
Of some house other than my own in sight.
Beloved, apportion me to David's house
To be not guard or singer but a mouse
To clean the floors of blood and guts and
make

That marbled, cedared temple for Your
sake

A sweet and clean place under gate of air,
The ten commandments wafting ever there.
Beriah and Jeush had their own place
And I would join them in Davidic race
To bow before Your throne, Beloved, and
hear

The rising of the Psalms upon my ear,
As I push mop on hands and knees with
cheer.

12 The sons of Kohath: Amram and
Izhar, Hebron, Uzziel's *hand*
Make four *in all as though so planned*.

13 The sons of Amram: Aaron and
Moses, and Aaron set apart,
He and his sons to do their part
Forever, so he'd sanctify
The most holy things, to comply
With burning incense before YHWH

To serve Him and with a word true
 To bless in His name all the crew.
 14 Now the sons of Moses the man
 Of Alohim appointed clan
 To the tribe of Levi. 15 The sons
 Of Moses: Gershon's *benisons*
 And Eliezer. 16 Of the sons
 Of Gershon, Shebuel *was* first.
 17 Of the descendants reimbursed
 Of Eliezer, Rehabiah
 Was the first. Eliezer *cier*
 Had no other sons, but the sons
 Of Rehabiah came in tons.
 18 Of sons of Izhar, Shelomith
Was the first. 19 Of the sons *in kith*
 Of Hebron, Jeriah *was* first,
 Amariah second, and burst
 Out Jahaziel *to be* third,
 And Jekameam the fourth heard.

Now Shelomith's a name of peace, I trow,
 And given to both male and female now.
 The son of peace in Levite's crew is named
 Alongside Solomon, David's son famed.
 A great-grandson of Moses, I suppose
 This Shelomith will keep me on my toes.
 I take the sweet name on my lips and share
 The Hebrew melody with sun and air.
 Beloved, let peace be my faith as I go
 About the cobbled streets of tinselled show
 To find the blind and those who do not
 know
 That You alone are Self and what You
 speak
 In Your ten words is all that man should
 seek.
 Let war if need be keep me in that glow.

20 Of the sons of Uzziel, Michah
Was the first and the second pica
 Was Jesshiah. 21 Sons of Merari
Were Mahli and Mushi. Not sorry,
 The sons of Mahli: Eleazar
 And Kish. 22 Then died Eleazar
 Without sons, only daughters star,
 And their cousins, the sons of Kish,
 Took them *as wives as they could wish*.
 23 The sons of Mushi *were* Mahli,
 Eder, and Jeremoth, all three.
 24 These *were* the sons of Levi by
 Their fathers' houses and the cry
 Of fathers' chiefs as they were counted

Each one by number of name mounted,
 Who laboured in the house of YHWH
 From twenty years of age to do.
 25 So David said "YHWH Alohim
 Of Israel gave rest supreme
 To His folk so that they might live
 Always in Jerusalem's sieve."
 26 And also to the Levites, "They
 Shall no longer carry in sway
 The tabernacle, or the pots
 For its services in their lots."

I do not mind carrying on my back
 Your temple and its heavy pots in stack!
 I do not need a grander temenos
 Than that within myself to bear the cross.
 What cross! The tent of David, light as air,
 The singing of the Psalms by all the fair.
 I do not mind the weight of pole and trim
 Upon the back as long as I have him
 Before me with his boy's voice rising shrill
 In ear of lion and bear upon the hill.
 Beloved, I dance with Levites now set free
 From burdens on the backs that once fairly
 Walked on the dry Jordan bed to the land
 Of Canaan where I'm also bound as
 planned.

27 By the last words of David all
 The Levites *were* counted in stall
 From twenty years old and above,
 28 Because their duty *was* to love
 To help the sons of Aaron in
 The service of YHWH's house and bin,
 In the courts and the rooms to clean
 All holy things and work that's seen
 In Alohim's service demesne,
 29 With the showbread and the fine flour
 For the meat offering, with the shower
 Of cakes unyeasted *in* the pan,
 With what is mixed and all that can
 In weights and measures as by plan,
 30 To stand each dawn to thank and raise
 A song to YHWH and in His praise,
 And at nightfall for days and days,
 31 And every time burnt offering's brought
 To YHWH on Sabbaths, also caught
 On the first day of the months wrought,
 And on the set feasts, by the count
 According to statutes' amount,
 From time to time before YHWH's plot.
 32 And they should take care of the tent

Of meeting and holy place spent,
And help the sons of Aaron who
Are their kin in housework of YHWH.

What made it right to count the Levites
when
You caught David with plague when he
again
Counted the armies of the Lord to fight
Against the Syrians, Philistines' right?
Let me not count today the ones who come
Into the temple where my dervish bum
Waits at the door to take the shoes cast off:
Let me not count, Beloved, nor let me
scoff.
I entered in the Blue Mosque on a day
When they were taking shoes, I came to
pray.
But for my Celtic hue, they turned away
Until the time was past. But when they saw
Me bowing afterward in prostrate awe
They handed me apologizing paw.

1 Chronicles 24

1 Now *these are* the divisions of
The sons of Aaron. Sons *in love*
Of Aaron *were* Nadab, Abihu,
Eleazar, and sent to spy you
Ithamar. 2 But both Nadab and
Abihu died before the stand
Of their father, and had no band
Of children, therefore Eleazar
Served as priest as did Ithamar.
3 David, Zadok ben Eleazar,
Ahimelech ben Ithamar
Appointed them cycles to serve.
4 More chiefs appeared and having verve
Among Eleazar's sons that came
Among sons of Ithamar's fame,
But so they were set to the game.
Among Eleazar's sons sixteen
Heads of fathers' houses were seen,
And eight heads of fathers' bands rose
Among sons that Ithamar chose.
5 So they were divided by lot
In equal bands, for in the plot
There were those serving in the slot
Official of the sanctuary
And Alohims' work to be wary,
From Eleazar's sons as well
As Ithamar's sons *for a spell*.

The priest, the sons of Aaron are
appointed,
However one counts in the church's sway,
Of David, who held sceptre and the way
Made plain, simply because he was
anointed.
As such the son of David and Messiah
Should no doubt have the right to appoint
priests,
Make Peter bishop of the Roman feasts
Convinced that he would never be pariah.
Enough of evidence is here to state
Long since that such priests, though among
the great,
Will never represent You for the glory
Around the throne of David now grown
hoary.
I think though David set up priests to serve,
Now none can find them wherever they
swerve.

6 And the scribe, Shemaiah the son
Of Nethanel, *of Levites one*,
Wrote down their names before the king,
The leaders, Zadok the priestling,
Ahimelech the son *and star*
Of the priestly Abiathar,
And chiefs of fathers' *houses of*
The priests and Levites, one *above*
Set for Eleazar and *one*
For Ithamar when all was done.
7 Now the first lot fell to the name
Of Jehoiarib, and the same
The second to Jedaiah's *fame*,
8 The third to Harim, and the fourth
To Seorim, 9 the fifth as pour'th
To Malchijah, the sixth in way
To Mijamin, 10 the seventh stray
To Hakkoz, the eighth to Abijah,
11 The ninth to Jeshua to hide you,
The tenth to Shecaniah, and
12 The eleventh one come to stand
To Eliashib, the twelfth to
Jakim, 13 the thirteenth falling to
Huppah, fourteenth to Jeshebeab,
14 The fifteenth to Bilgah *like grebe*,
The sixteenth to Immer, 15 and then
Seventeenth to Hezir again,
The eighteenth to Happizzez, while
16 Nineteenth to Pethahiah's smile,
The twentieth to Jehezkel,
17 The twenty-first *at temple shekel*

To Jachin, twenty-second to
 Gamul, 18 the twenty-third one to
 Delaiah, the twenty-fourth to
 Maaziah. 19 *This was* cycle true
 Of their service to come into
 The sanctuary house of YHWH
 According to their law as set
 By Aaron their father's hand met,
 As YHWH Israel's Alohim said
 Commanding him *with wine and bread*.

The cycles of the sanctuary make
 Happy the quarrels for the priestly sake
 Of Qumran, where Zadokite faith and
 weather
 Make the dry land to blossom and to
 feather.
 As many people are consumed to know
 Something about that ancient field and
 show,
 My titillated brain is on the go
 Come Sabbath or New Moon, make no
 mistake.
 Each cycle and each priest is written down
 Long since hidden in caves from those in
 town
 While secrets of the blessings and the lost
 Arise in academics to be tossed.
 In everything I find a place to reason,
 Not worrying about the time or season.

20 The rest of Levi's sons *are these*:
 Of Amram's sons, Shubael to please,
 Of Shubael, Jehdeiah come.
 21 And as for Rehabiah's hum,
 The sons of Rehabiah, first
Was Isshiah. 22 Of Izharites,
 Shelomoth, Shelomoth's sons' wights,
 Jahath for one. 23 Of *Hebron's* sons,
 Jeriah *first*, then Amariah,
 Jahaziel the third *of tons*,
And Jekameam fourth *pariah*.
 24 *Of* Uzziel's sons, Michah, and
 Of Michah's sons, Shamir *to stand*.
 25 The brother of Michah, Isshiah,
 Of Isshiah's sons, Zechariah.
 26 The sons of Merari: Mahli
 And Mushi, *two to count not three*,
 The son of Jaaziah was Beno.
 27 The sons of Merari were Beno
 By Jaaziah, then Shoham,
 Zaccur, and Ibri *like a lamb*.

28 Of Mahli: Eleazar, who
 Had no sons *not even a few*.
 29 Of Kish: the son of Kish *to see*,
 Jerahmeel. 30 The sons of Mushi
 Also *were* Mahli, Eder, and
 Jerimoth. These *were in the land*
 The sons of the Levites by their
 Fathers' houses *and what they wear*.

See here how much these brothers love
 each other
 Since Mushi named his son after his
 brother.
 I understand if Mahli did not think
 Returning the favour as worth the drink.
 I too would rather be called Mahli than
 Mushi, at least by English-speaking man.
 The Levite names leave little to desire,
 They are set up to wait the temple fire.
 I too watch as the priests pale and return
 To find no fire on altars there to burn.
 The brother Kish no doubt is better set
 With only one son on which to place bet.
 Yes, one's enough, no trouble in the offing,
 No Trinities, no sacrifice or scoffing.

31 These too cast lots just as their kin
 The sons of Aaron did to win,
 In sight of King David, Zadok,
 Ahimelech, and like a rock
 The fathers' chiefs of priests, Levites,
 The chief fathers like younger wights.

1 Chronicles 25

1 Then David and the chiefs of hosts
 Selected for tasks up to boasts
 From Asaph's sons, Heman's as well
 As Jeduthun's who could do well
 In prophesying on the harp,
 Stringed instruments, cymbals to carp.
 The number of skilled musicians
 To perform their task benisons:

The rude and crude concept of prophet is
 The man who rises to make future fizz
 With his predictions of the things of state:
 Of wars and peace, events of love and hate.
 The brood of mood concepts of prophets
 make
 Star wars the butt of the prophetic wake
 With focus on the horns of beasts and all
 The stars falling on bloody suns in stall.

But here the prophecy's a sweeter tune,
 The cantillation with the harp and rune
 Of Psalm in temple rising on the air
 To bring the soul to heaven for her share
 Of love and life beyond the sacrifice
 That earthly priests contend are all that's
 nice.

2 Of Asaph's sons Zaccur, Joseph,
 Nethaniah, *who held C clef*,
 And Ashareliah, Asaph's sons
 Were led by Asaph's benisons
 Who prophesied by the king's word.
 3 Of Jeduthun, his sons *occurred*:
 Gedaliah, Zeri *and yet*
 Jeshaiiah and Shimei *well met*,
 Hashabiah and Mattithiah,
 Six under the lead of their prior
 Jeduthun, who prophesied by
 The harp to give thanks *to the sky*
 And praise to YHWH *with song and cry*.
 4 Of Heman, the sons of Heman:
 Bukkiah, Mattaniah ran,
 Uzziel, Shebuel, Jerimoth,
 Hananiah, Hanani *troth*,
 Eliathah, Giddalti and
 Romamti-Ezer *with firm hand*,
 Joshbekashah, Mallothi, both
 Hothir, *at last* Mahazioth.
 5 All these *were* the sons of Heman
 The king's seer in the words' span
 Of Alohim, to raise his horn.
 For Alohim gave Heman *born*
 Fourteen sons, three daughters *unshorn*.
 6 All these *were* under their dad's lead
 For music *in* YHWH's house to speed
 With cymbals, instruments of string,
 And harps, for service and to sing
 In Alohim's house and dwelling.
 Asaph, Jeduthun, Heman's *ring*
Were under the hand of the king.
 7 So the number of them, with their
 Brothers who were instructed fair
 In the songs of YHWH, all with skill,
Was two hundred eighty-eight's *fill*.

The mosque, some synagogues and even
 churches
 Forego the instruments of music birches
 And raise a song to You from human lips
 Alone and in love only for its sips.
 But in the day of David, all the choir

Accompanied the cymbals, harp and lyre
 Until the temple rang with joy of song
 And hearts were turned to truth away from
 wrong.

Beloved, I lift the sound of string to You
 And prophesy in singing as I do
 Without the skill of Heman and the true
 Fourteen infallibles, three sisters too.
 I link a line back to fair David's tent
 And find a place where best my days are
 spent.

8 And they cast lots to fill their task,
 The small as well as great *to bask*,
 The teacher with the pupil mask.
 9 The first lot for Asaph fell to
 Joseph, the second *one of two*
 For Gedaliah and his crew
 Of brothers and sons, twelve *in view*,
 10 The third for Zaccur, and his sons
 And his brothers, twelve *in their runs*,
 11 The fourth for Jizri, his offspring
 And his brothers, twelve *in a ring*,
 12 The fifth for Nethaniah and
 His sons and brothers, twelve *to stand*,
 13 The sixth for Bukkiah *to send*
 His sons and brothers, twelve *to lend*,
 14 The seventh for Jeshareliah,
 His sons and brothers, twelve *in awe*,
 15 The eighth for Jeshaiiah *to delve*,
 His sons and his brothers *make* twelve,
 16 The ninth for Mattaniah, his
 Sons and his brothers, twelve *to whiz*,
 17 The tenth for Shimei, his sons and
 His brothers, twelve *harpers to stand*,
 18 The eleventh for Azarel,
 His sons and his brothers, twelve *spell*,
 19 The twelfth for Hashabiah, and
 His sons and brothers, twelve *in band*,
 20 The thirteenth for Shubael's *way*,
 His sons and brothers, twelve *in sway*,
 21 The fourteenth for Mattithiah,
 His sons and brothers, twelve *in awe*,
 22 The fifteenth then for Jeremoth,
 His sons and brothers, twelve *on oath*,
 23 The sixteenth for Hananiah,
 His sons and brothers, twelve *by law*,
 24 The seventeenth for Joshbekashah,
 His sons and brothers, twelve *not rasher*,
 25 The eighteenth then for Hanani,
 His sons and his brothers, twelve *free*,
 26 The nineteenth for Mallothi and

His sons and brothers, twelve *in band*,
 27 The twentieth for Eliathah,
 His sons and brothers, twelve *in paw*,
 28 The twenty-first for Hothir's *set*,
 His sons and brothers, twelve *to get*,
 29 The twenty-second for *the man*
 Giddalti, his sons and his clan,
 Twelve *singers all by note and plan*,
 30 The twenty-third lot came up for
 Mahazioth, his sons and more,
 Twelve, 31 then lot number twenty-four
 For Romamti-Ezer, his sons
 And his brothers, twelve *on their buns*.

The choirs of twelve in David's joyous
 throng
 Sing Psalms above the din of priestly
 wrong
 And show the clear path now before Your
 throne
 Always the same and open to Your own.
 How many now find their way to the choir
 That eschews sacrifice of beast and shier?
 Twenty-four times the twelve in secret
 space
 Around the world stand up before Your
 face.
 Beloved, though I can sing hardly a word
 That falls on air here sweetly to be heard,
 I still join in the hidden twelve to make
 My voice join with the righteous for Your
 sake.
 The twelves are hidden in the leafy trees
 From all that in their churches shoot the
 breeze.

1 Chronicles 26

1 As for the groups of the gatekeepers:
 Of Korahites *and other weepers*,
 Meshelemiah son of Kore,
 Of the sons of Asaph *in sway*.
 2 And the sons of Meshelemiah
Were the firstborn one Zechariah,
 Jediahel the second, and then
 Zebadiah the third *of men*,
 Jathniel the fourth, 3 Elam came
 The fifth, Jehohanan of fame
 The sixth, Eliehoenai
 The seventh, *the last to go by*.
 The seven gatekeepers in silence sit,
 Hidden in plain sight, looking slow of wit,

The mystery of righteousness in task
 Of keeping all the shoes of those who ask.
 The Qalandar in every state and clime
 Has the same chore in meter and in rhyme,
 And knows beyond my comprehension
 each
 Face to match with the shoes and hands to
 reach.
 Beloved, I whirl in joy with sacred twelve,
 And yet I know the hidden place to delve
 To find the secret seven in their way.
 The face may seem full in the wicked fey
 Of worldliness, but truth is in its stay.
 The wicker basket holds a sweeter peach.

4 The sons of Obed-Edom *were*
 Shemaiah the firstborn *to stir*,
 Jehozabad the second, and
 Joah the third, Sacar *in hand*
 The fourth, Nethanel *and then came*
 The fifth, 5 Ammiel sixth *in flame*,
 Issachar the seventh, *and last*
 Peulthai the eighth, *not downcast*
 For Alohim blessed him *and fast*.
 6 Also to Shemaiah his son
 Were sons born who ruled as they won
 Their fathers' houses, because see
They were men of ability.
 7 The sons of Shemaiah: Othni,
 Rephael, Obed, and Elzabad,
 Whose brothers Elihu agree
 And Semachiah *were* not sad.
 8 All these *were* Obed-Edom's sons,
 They and their sons and brothers' buns,
 Fine men with strength to do the work:
 Sixty-two, Obed-Edom's perk.

The sons of Obed-Edom, the red slave,
 Have given blessings to the world to rave
 On how the gates are kept in the employ
 Much loved by every wandering girl and
 boy.
 Among the crooked streets of Zion's town
 Still found above the wailing wall and
 frown,
 My feet seek out the many open doors
 Come time for prayer, the guarded golden
 stores
 Entranced by all the people there below
 Long waiting for the starting of the show.
 While gate-keepers still have their place to
 stand

Around the holy precincts of the land,
I meet them and I cross them with a word
Not uttered too soon by the swallow bird.

9 And Meshelemiah had sons
And brothers, eighteen able ones.
10 And Hosah, of Merari's folk,
Had sons: Shimri the first *good bloke*,
In fact not the firstborn, but he
Was made first by father's decree,
11 Hilkiyah the second, the third
Tebaliah *upon his word*,
And Zechariah the fourth, all
The sons and brothers in the hall
Of Hosah were thirteen by call.
12 Among these were gatekeepers' bands,
Among the chief men, *having* stands
Just like their brothers, to serve in
The house of YHWH *for store and bin*.
13 And they cast down lots for each gate,
Even the small as well as great,
According to father's estate.
14 The lot for the east came up to
Shelemiah. Then once anew
They cast lots *for* his son in view,
Zechariah, wise counsellor,
And his lot running turned up for
The north, 15 to Obed-Edom then
The south, and to his sons and men
The store. 16 To Shuppim and Hosah
The west, and with it on the way
Ascending the Shallecheth gate,
Guards opposite each guard in wait.

The four winds enter in four open gates,
Hover about where the stone fountain waits
Out of the sunlit paving by the dome
Mounting in golden mass above the home
Across the rock where Abraham raised his
Son to be sacrificed like Moloch's fizz.
My coming to the gate was nothing
strange.

Casting about for an excuse and range
Emerging from the wooden pillars where
Lopped off and needing steps into the air
White garments graced the place of humble
prayer.

Alright then, brother, enter in the boon.
It breaks the time of prayer in afternoon
No one can stumble on that crimson stair.

17 On the east were *six* Levites, on

The north four each day, and then drawn
On the south four each day, and for
The storehouse two by two *at door*.
18 As for the Parbar on the west,
There were four on the causeway's vest,
And two at Parbar, all well dressed.
19 These were gatekeepers' groups among
The sons of Korah and among
The sons of Merari *unsung*.
20 Of the Levites, Ahijah *sat*
Over the treasuries *of scat*
In the house of Alohim and
Over the treasuries that stand
In dedication. 21 Laadan's sons,
Descended from Gershonite *buns*
Of Laadan, chiefs of fathers' *runs*,
Of Laadan the Gershonites' band:
Jehieli. 22 And Jehieli's sons,
Zetham and Joel his brother's *guns*,
Were over the treasuries of
The house of YHWH *for life and love*.
23 Of Amramites, the Izharites,
The Hebronites, and Uzzielites:
24 Shebuel the son of Gershom,
The son of Moses, *who in sum*
Was guardian of the treasuries.
25 And his brothers by Eliezer
Were Rehabiah his son *to stir*,
Jeshaiah his son, Joram his
Son, Zichri his son, and *a whiz*
Shelomith his son *for his biz*.
26 Shelomith and his brothers *sat*
Over all the treasures on mat
Of dedicated things which King
David and chiefs of fathers' *wing*,
Heads of thousands and hundreds, and
The army captains by command
Had dedicated *all in hand*.
27 Some of the spoils won in the war
They dedicated to the store
To keep YHWH's house forevermore.
28 And all that Samuel the seer, Saul
The son of Kish, Abner *with gall*
The son of Ner, and Joab son
Of Zeruiah had begun
To dedicate, each holy thing
Under Shelomith's hand and wing
As well as of his own sibling.

There are still things in David's room that
strike
Human ear, heart and eye to know the like

Out of the treasury of Kish's son
 Made known forever under Judah's run.
 Along the temple walls the flashing sight
 Still scintillates and turns one to the right,
 Masking eternal ways that Saul once knew
 Come off the donkey mountains with their
 dew.

Even if I am thrust through with the sword
 Long before I rise to degree adored,
 Will not my copper pots still stand to take
 A drought of heavenly water for Your
 sake?

I dedicate each holy thing again,
 Not knowing now the why or where or
 when.

29 Of the Izharites, Chenaniah
 And his sons worked as *no pariah*
 Officials to judge Israel
 Outside Jerusalem *and well*.
 30 Of the Hebronites, Hashabiah
 And his brothers, one thousand higher
 Seven hundred capable men,
 Had rule of Israel again
 On the west side of the Jordan
 For all YHWH's company and plan,
 And in the service of the king.
 31 Among the Hebronites' sibling,
 Jerijah head of Hebronites
 According to his family rights.
 In the fortieth year of reign
 Of David they look not in vain
 To find good men at Jazer of
 Gilead *in the land of love*.

32 And his brothers *were* two thousand
 Seven hundred good men at hand,
 Chiefs of the fathers whom the king
 David made civil servants' sting
 Over the Reubenites, Gadites,
 And of Manasseh in their rights,
 For every matter that related
 To Alohim and king instated.

The fortieth year of David's reign allows
 How many years I too have followed cows
 On heavy fields lush with the morning
 crow,

Many days dawning in the way I grow.
 A mass of years indeed, and yet I look
 Still back upon those forty like a crook
 Making my way back through the tangled
 mess

Come of my life of shadow, dream and
 guess.

Electric fantasies there may have been
 Lounging through my mind caught up in its
 sin,

While forty years I've sought out David's
 own

Around the peacock and the ivory throne.
 I find that forty years are long and short,
 Nothing desiring of another sort.

1 Chronicles 27

1 And the children of Israel,
 According to their number's spell,
 The chiefs of fathers, generals
 And captains, chiefs, perennials
 Of every kind of group and band.
 Each came and went in turn all year
 By monthly turns, each group in all
 Twenty-four thousand men on call.
 2 Over the first division for
 The first month *was man on the score*
 Jashobeam son of Zabdiel,
 And in his group *there came to heel*
 Twenty-four thousand *men for weal*.
 3 *He was* descended from Perez,
 And chief of all the captains *spread*
 Of the army the first month *read*.
 4 Over the second month's group's *sight*
There was Dodai an Ahohite,
 And Mikloth led his group in band
As it were twenty-four thousand.
 5 The third army chief for the third
 Month *was* Benaiah, the son *stirred*
 Of Jehoiada the priest, who
 Was head of his division's *crew*,
 Twenty-four thousand men *in view*.
 6 This was the Benaiah mighty
Among the thirty, and *witty*
 Over the thirty, in his group
Was Ammizabad his son's *troop*.
 7 The fourth for the fourth month *in chief*
Was Asahel brother *in fief*
 Of Joab, and Zebadiah
 His son after him, in his draw,
 Twenty-four thousand *men in awe*.

The honour guards they seem who come
 each time,
 Housed in the monthly cycle and the climb
 Off mountain and on plain to fight if need
 March in the army's way and army's seed.

All that I cherish must be guarded well,
 Sunk in the treasurehouse of Israel.
 My inner temple and my outer spell
 Cannot suffice alone without the hand,
 Enunciated, military, planned.
 Link after link the troops file on to find
 With me a house for lame and deaf and
 blind
 Against the glow of health and wealth and
 all
 I seek above Jerusalem in call,
 Not daring more than hope without a fall.

8 The fifth *chief* for the fifth month *came*
As Shamhuth of Izrahite fame,
 In his band twenty-four thousand.
 9 The *captain* for the sixth month *band*
Was Ira son of Ikkesch manned
 Tekoite, twenty-four thousand.
 10 The seventh month's chief place fell to
 Helez the Pelonite, from crew
 Of Ephraim, and in his band
Of men were twenty-four thousand.
 11 The eighth *chieftain come* for the eighth
 Month *was* Sibbechai, man of faith,
 The Hushathite, of the Zarhites,
 With twenty-four thousand *strong wights*.
 12 The ninth *captain* for the ninth cycle,
 Abiezer Anathothite, Michael
 Of Benjamites, and in his band
 Of warriors twenty-four thousand.
 13 The tenth *chief* for tenth month *in sight*,
 Maharai the Netophathite,
 Of the Zarhites, and in his band
Of men were twenty-four thousand.
 14 The eleventh *chief* of the round
 Number eleven *on the ground*
Was Benaiah Pirathonite,
 Of Ephraim's folk, and on his right
 Twenty-four thousand men in sight.
 15 The twelfth *chief* for the twelfth ring
 fell
 Heldai Netophathite, Othniel,
 In his band twenty-four thousand
Strong men came forward and to stand.

The thousands make their way and at a
 stroke
 How many twelves remain under the oak!
 Oak of my promise and my seeing You,
 My treasure and Beloved, above the pew,
 Above the hearth and altar, and the lamp

Set in the early chamber from the damp.
 Musk and perfume alight upon the way
 Crossed by the many thousands in their
 day.
 Each soldier there knew well what he
 should do,
 Live in the light of Jerusalem's clue.
 White are the plumed troops and white are
 the fair,
 Along the dusty road for here to there
 I make a mystic path and step inside
 Narcissus-lined gardens where I abide.

16 Moreover, tribes of Israel
 Were ruled by such: the Reubenites
 By Eliezer the son by rights
 Of Zichri, over Simeonites,
 Shephatiah son of Maachah,
 17 *Over the chosen* Levites' awe,
 Hashabiah son of Kemuel,
 Over the Aaronites, *on stool*
 Zadok, 18 *Over Judah to scan*,
 Elihu, David's brothers' man,
 Over Issachar, Omri son
 Of Michael, 19 *over* Zebulun,
 Ishmaiah son of Obadiah,
 Over Naphtali a great flier,
 Jerimoth the son of Azriel,
 20 *Over* children of Ephraim fell
 Hoshea son of Azaziah,
 Over Manasseh's half-tribe's fire,
 Joel son of Pedaiah's way,
 21 *Over half-tribe* of Manasseh
 In Gilead, Iddo the son
 Of Zechariah *once begun*,
 Over Benjamin, Jaasiel
 The son of Abner *for a spell*,
 22 *And over* Dan, Azarel son
 Of Jeroham. These *were* the chiefs
 Of Israel's tribes *in their reliefs*.

The tribes of Israel are always twelve,
 However one may try to dig and shelve.
 On this list Levite is divided up
 Making with Aaronite no single cup.
 Asher and Gad are left out in the cold,
 Simeon stands tall with the strong and
 bold,
 Making the number of all Israel told
 Come just to twelve. I think that way is
 from
 Enunciating Ishmael's family rum,

Lamenting any other number than
 What Ishmael sets in precedent to plan.
 Around the whirl I go and see my choice:
 I follow David in twelve to rejoice,
 Notice the prophecy of eye and voice.

23 But David did not count those under
 Twenty years old, for YHWH *like thunder*
 Had said He'd multiply the folk
 Of Israel like the stars that choke
 The heavens. 24 Joab who was son
 Of Zeruiah had begun
 A census, but he did not take
 It to the end for the wrath's sake
 That came on Israel on account
 Of this counting, nor was amount
 Recorded in the chronicles
 Of king David, *for miracles*.
 25 And Azmaveth son of Adiel
Was over the king's treasure pile,
 Jehonathan Uziah's son
Was over the barns by the ton
In the field, in the cities, in
The villages, and fortress bin.
 26 Ezri the son of Chelub came
 Over those who laboured for fame
 In tilling the ground. 27 Shimei
The Ramathite came to rely
On the vineyard plots, and Zabdi
The Shiphmite was over produce
Of the vineyards to make grape juice.
 28 Baal-Hanan the Gederite sat
 Over the olive trees and flat
 Over the sycamore trees that
Were in the plains, and Joash' toil
Was caring for the store of oil.
 29 And Shitrai the Sharonite *stood*
Over the herds that fed in wood
Of Sharon, and Shaphat the son
Of Adlai was over the ton
Of herds that were in valleys won.

The task of Gederite is great, I think,
 He has to tend both olive trees and wink
 On sycamores, the hardest task of all.
 Methinks two men set to the latter ball
 About enough, but one to share the toil
 Sometimes absent, is just too much in coil.
 My hope of Geder matches Your own here,
 Consistent with the prophecy in ear.
 Except I wait the Prophet's spoken word
 Light on the banks of Ghadir to the herd,

Wonder escapes my steps. My thanks to
 You
 Always for keeping Gederite in view.
 I take the hand of Ali and I dance
 Nowhere outside his glowing
 circumstance.

30 Obil the Ishmaelite *cared for*
The camels well, and Jehdeiah
The Meronothite was in paw
Over the donkeys, 31 and Jaziz
The Hagrite chief of flocks of his:
All these were officers to keep
King David's property in heap.
 32 Also there was Jehonathan,
 David's uncle, counsel, wise man,
 And a scribe, and Jehiel the son
 Of Hachmoni *tutored the ton*
Of the king's sons. 33 Ahithophel
Was the king's counsellor to tell,
And Hushai the Archite was one
To be the king's companion.
 34 After Ahithophel *was one*
Jehoiada son of Benaiah,
Then Abiathar for no denier.
The chief of the king's army stood
Joab as stalwart as he could.

There is no talent in my breast, it seems
 Hand and skill forsake me along the
 streams
 Of poetry. I have not even skill
 Made sweet by melody upon the hill
 Across the flocks of sheep, so I am still.
 So I may not take care of camel or
 Make donkeys carry till their muscle's
 sore,
 Care for the king's sons or give counsel
 wise
 Encountered in the court by David's eyes.
 Let me then be companion to the king
 With Hushai the Archite, no need to sing.
 Among the servants of David to stand
 I may be least, but have at my command
 No interests to distract me from his hand.

1 Chronicles 28

1 David gathered together at
 Jerusalem all *those who sat*
As leaders of Israel: the chiefs
Of the tribes and divisions' chiefs
Who served the king, the captains over

Thousands and chiefs of hundreds *rover*,
 And princes over all the stuff
 And the king's wealth and his sons' rough,
 With officers, the valiant men,
 And all the mighty warrior men.
 2 Then King David rose to his feet
 And said, "Hear me, my brothers meet
 And all my people: *I had it*
 In my heart to build a house fit
 For the ark of the covenant
 Of YHWH, and for footstool and tent
 Of our Alohim, and I sent
 For preparations to build it.
 3 "But Alohim said to me, 'You
 Shall not build a house for the view
 Of My name, because you've *been* a man
 Of war and bloodshed *as by plan*.'
 4 "Nevertheless YHWH Alohim
 Of Israel chose me abeam
 Of all my father's house to be
 King of Israel eternally,
 For He chose Judah *to be* chief,
 And of Judah's house *for relief*,
 The house of my father, among
 The sons of my father unsung,
 He was pleased with me to make *me*
 King over all Israel *in fee*.
 5 "And of all my sons, for YHWH gave
 Me many sons *not to enslave*,
 He's chosen my son Solomon
 To sit upon the kingdom's throne
 Of YHWH over Israel *alone*.
 6 "Now He said to me, 'It's your son
 Solomon *who* shall build when done
 My house and My courts, for I chose
 Him *to be* My son, and arose
 To be his Father. 7 'Beyond that
 I will establish rule out flat
 Of his kingdom eternally,
 If he is faithful to observe
 My commandments and judgments' verve,
 As it is today.' 8 "Now therefore,
 In the sight of all Israel's store,
 The assembly of YHWH, and in
 The hearing of our God *for din*,
 Be careful to seek out and win
 All the commandments of YHWH your
 Alohim, to possess this shore
 That's good, and leave *it* heritage
 To your children after your age
 Forever. 9 "As for you, my son
 Solomon, know the God begun

Of your father, and serve Him by
 A faithful heart and willing eye,
 For YHWH searches all hearts and knows
 All the intentions they enclose.
 If you seek Him, He will be found
 By you, but if you lose His ground,
 He will reject you in the pound.
 10 "Think hard about it now, for YHWH
 Has chosen you to build with crew
 A sanctuary house, be strong,
 And do it now and don't be long."

The command come divine on Solomon
 House of the Lord to build, an honour won
 On David's lack, for bloody hand in stack
 Made so by his obeying Your own black
 And sordid command to go out and kill,
 Strikes me as less than ever on the bill.
 Might You need any house, who cannot fill
 Carts of the starry wastes of sky and rill?
 Eccentric wishes or Your love in hand
 Letting human heart have desires to stand
 Wait in the kings last words to best-loved
 son.

Along the many paths of benison
 I too turn toward Your house and bend the
 knee,
 No other dwelling place but Your mercy.

11 David then gave plans to his son
 Solomon to build what's begun,
 The porch, its chambers, treasuries,
 Its inner rooms and by decrees
 The place of mercy seat, 12 and plans
 For all by the spirit he scans,
 The courts of YHWH's house, every room,
 Round, storerooms for coin and costume,
 And stores of dedicated things,
 13 Also for the groups of priestlings
 And the Levites, for all the work
 Of YHWH's house service not to shirk,
 For all the vessels used within
 The house of YHWH *in bright and bin*.
 14 Gold by weight for gold vessels all
 Used in service of every call,
 Also for vessel silver weight,
 For every kind of spoon and plate.
 15 The weight for the lampstands of gold,
 And their lamps of gold, by weight told
 For each lampstand and its lamps, for
 The lampstands of silver by score,
 For the lampstand and its lamps, by

The use of each lampstand to spy.
 16 And by weight gold for tables spread
 And where to place of the showbread,
 For each table, and silver set
 For silver tables *where to get*
 17 Also pure gold for forks and bowls,
 Pitchers of pure gold, gold consoles,
 By weight for every bowl and slice
 Of silver bowl by weight in trice,
 18 And purified gold counted out
 For incense altar round about,
 And for the chariot making too,
 Gold cherubim spreading out *new*
Wings to shade the ark of the pact
 Of YHWH telling us how to act.
 19 All YHWH made me understand writ,
 Hand on me, all planned works and fit.

The sacred ark! I see the angels spread
 High wings to shadow it and overhead,
 On golden mercy-seat I see the glow
 Made rich by Your presence and to bestow
 A glory on the place where You would
 show.

Slight are the tremors that I feel as I
 Make my way boldly, fluttering like
 magpie,

Come to the sacred chest to find my doom
 Encased in awful splendour, though the
 room

Leaves little to envoke such awe in space.
 While smallness is enough for You in place
 Among the great ideals, the burning law
 In that place hidden still informs my awe
 Not lessened by the daily rouse and race.

20 David told his son Solomon,
 “Be strong and of good courage spun,
 And do *it*, do not fear nor be
 Dismayed, for YHWH Alohim, see,
 My Alohim shall be with you.
 He will not leave or forsake you
 Until you’ve finished all that’s due
 The service of the house of YHWH.

21 “Troops of priests and Levites for all
 The service of the house install
 Of Alohim, and every willing
 Craftsman with you for the instilling
 Of every kind of task to do,
 Also the chiefs and people too
 Will be under your rule as crew.”

Though I am not the favoured son and best
 Hewed statue to David, I still invest
 Out of my humble heart that I may be
 Made strong and one courageous in the sea
 And river of all human company.
 Setting aside all fear I rise and go
 Made ready with my love for every show,
 Certain that goodness is revealed below
 Eternally ensealed upon the glow
 Left open from the Decalogue that peers
 With wonder from the temple of the years.
 Among the many tasks of Solomon
 I find the greatest one of courage spun,
 No greater than the Decalogue he won.

1 Chronicles 29

1 Furthermore King David told all
 The congregation still in stall,
 “My son Solomon, whom alone
 Alohim’s chosen for the throne,
Is young and untried in the work
 That is so great since not for irk
 But for YHWH Alohim’s the house.

2 “Now then for my Alohim’s house
 I’ve planned with all my strength *of*
grouse,

Gold for the gold and silver for
 Everything made of silver store,
 Bronze for the bronze, iron well set out
 For iron, wood for wood things about,
 And onyx stones, such as best set,
 Shining stones of all colours met,
 All kinds of gems and marble slabs
 Enough for so many pre-fabs.

3 “Moreover, since I’ve set my love
 On my Alohim’s house above,
 I have provided for the place
 Of my Alohim every trace
 Of holy treasure, silver, gold,

4 “Three thousand talents to enfold
 Of gold, of gold of Ophir, and
 Seven thousand talents in hand
 Of purified silver to line

The walls of the rooms by design,
 5 “The gold for gold and silver for
 Silver utensils, also for
 All kinds of work done by the hand
 Of craftsmen coming there in band.
 Who’s willing then to consecrate
 Himself today to YHWH’s estate?”

Though Solomon was young, David and
 You
 Have chosen him to rule over Your crew.
 Our eyes and hearts in this place might
 have sent
 Much older candidate in royal tent.
 Another man might set upon his heart
 Something greater than Your house and its
 part
 Made sacred to the king. But David's eye
 Comes to rest on the youngest and the dye.
 Enough that I look back with some regret,
 Letting my thoughts remain on first sons
 set,
 With inner temples rather than those met
 Along the lower cliffs where armies may
 In time arrive to slaughter in their way,
 Nothing let stay in stone, not white or grey.

6 Then the chiefs of the fathers, chiefs
 Of Israel's tribes to their reliefs,
 The captains of thousands as well
 As captains of hundreds in spell,
 The overseers of the royal
 Tasks all came willingly and loyal.
 7 They gave for the work of the room
 Of Alohim five thousand *boom*
 Talents and ten thousand drams of
 Gold, ten thousand talents *above*
 Of silver, eighteen thousand of
 Bronze, and one hundred thousand more
 Talents of iron. 8 Who had in store
 Gems gave them to the treasury
 Of YHWH's house, in the hand in fee
 Of Jehiel the Gershonite,
Who kept them safe and out of sight.
 9 The people then rejoiced, for they
 Had given things in willing way,
 With loyal heart they opened hand
 To YHWH, and King David would *stand*
To rejoice greatly on that day.
 10 Therefore David blessed YHWH before
 All the assembly *at the door*,
 And David said "Blessed are You, YHWH
 God of Israel, our Father too,
 Forever and ever. 11 O YHWH,
 To you the greatness, and the power
 And glory, and the victory's hour
 And majesty, for all in sky
 And in earth, Yours the kingdom high,
 O YHWH, and You are raised as chief
 Over all *and all in belief.*

12 "Both wealth and honour *come* from
 You,
 And You reign over all as true.
 In Your hand *is* both power and might,
 In Your hand *is* to bring in sight
 And give authority to all.
 13 "Now therefore, our Alohim, call
 We on You with thanks and with praise
 In glory to Your name *for days.*
 14 "But who *am* I, and who's my folk,
 That we should offer at a stroke
 As this? For all things *come* from You,
 And of Your own we've given You.
 15 "We're strangers and pilgrims to You,
 As *were* our fathers, our days few
 On earth *are* like a shadow too,
 And without hope. 16 "And so, O YHWH
 Our Alohim, this pile of things
 That we've gathered in preparings
 To build You a house for Your name
 Of holiness is of Your fame
 And from Your hand, all it's Your claim.
 17 "I also know, my Alohim,
 That You test the heart and You beam
 On righteousness. Now as for me,
 In my heart's righteousness freely
 I offered all these things, and now
 With joy I've seen Your people bow,
 Who're gathered here and willingly
 Offer to You *their homage free.*
 18 "O YHWH Abraham's Alohim,
 Isaac's, and Israel's, *and on beam*
 Our fathers', keep this always in
 Your people's heart, intentions win,
 And set their heart toward Your decree.
 19 "Give my son Solomon a heart
 Of faithfulness to do his part
 To keep Your commandments and Your
 Testimonies and statutes' store,
 To do all *these things*, and yet build
 The temple for which I have filled
 With provision *to set and gild.*"

Though the world now is richer than
 before,
 How many strong men have enlarged their
 store
 Of gold and oil and information's match,
 My own hand remains empty at the latch.
 Along the weary way Medina turns,
 Sand in the heart and eye and sun that
 burns,

My emptiness remains, and I am still
Content to be a stranger on the hill,
Eloped as pilgrim on the Meccan shore.
Long I had dreamed that I should never
find

With foot the sacred mountain left behind,
And then at last my pilgrim's way fulfils
In coming to the Kaaba and its hills.
Now I'm ever a pilgrim to remind.

20 David told all the congregation,
"Now bless YHWH your God *as one
nation.*"

All the assembly then blessed YHWH
Alohim of their fathers *true*,
And bowed their heads, bowed down there
too

Before YHWH and the king *in crew*.

21 And they made sacrifice to YHWH
And offered burnt offerings to YHWH
On the next day: a thousand bull,
A thousand rams, a thousand lambs,
With their drink offerings plentiful,
Abundant sacrifice for all
Of Israel's *people on the ball*.

22 So they ate and drank before YHWH
With great gladness in that day's *pew*.
And they made Solomon the son
Of David king the second run,
And anointed *him* before YHWH
To be chief, Zadok as priest too.

The thing is not far from my heart and my
Hand and my feet know all the passing by.
Out of the blazing Meccan hills and sky
My face has fallen to the marbled floor
And found You there the God that I adore.
Sound of the supplication sent abroad
Made by the throats of thousands to the
Lord

Came on my ears too. I have sacrificed
Enough with thousands on the stones
surpliced.

Like David's people on that far-off day
With joy of meat and drink I saw the gay
Among the many tents gathered and set
In solemn and bright waiting where folk
met,
No shadow of grief on anointed stay.

23 Then Solomon sat on the throne
Of YHWH as king instead of *lone*

David his father, and did well
And all Israel obeyed his spell.
24 All the leaders and mighty men,
And all King David's sons again
Submitted themselves to the king,
King Solomon *in everything*.

25 So YHWH exalted Solomon
Greatly before all Israel's run,
And granted him such majesty
Of kingship as was not to see
On any king before him in
The land of Israel to begin.

26 So David son of Jesse reigned
Over all Israel *uncomplained*.

27 And the time that he reigned in years
Over Israel, forty appears,
And seven years in Hebron he
Reigned, and thirty-three *years then* he
Reigned in Jerusalem's *degree*.

28 So he died in a good old age,
Full of days and riches *to gauge*
His honour, Solomon his son
Reigned in his place *when he'd begun*.

29 Now the acts of King David, first
And last, the best as well as worst
Truly they're written in the book
Of Samuel the seer, in
Nathan the prophet's book *and bin*,
And in the book of Gad the seer,
30 Where all his reign and might appear,
And the events that fell on him,
To Israel, and to all the grim
Kingdoms of the lands *around him*.

The forty years that I have whirled to scan
How many blessings from You fall or can
On earth, have been both few and many
here.

My hopes had been that my life in its cheer
Answer to greater challenges of fame.
Slow and small I have entered in the game.
My shadow seems to fail, yet so the heart
Contrived in David too to think the part
Encompassed by his reign a futile dart.
Long and short in life falls before the goal
With sigh and satisfaction on the dole.
A little while, a hope, a song, a stroll,
I turn and find all passed, before me lies
Nothing but the eternal, loving skies.

2 Chronicles 1

1 And Solomon who's David's son

Was strengthened in his kingdom won,
And YHWH his Alohim was with
Him and raised his fame beyond myth.

2 It happened then Solomon spoke
Unto all Israel, to the folk
Of captains of thousands as well
As of hundreds of Israel,
And to the judges and to each
Governor of all Israel's reach,
The chief of the fathers *to preach*.

3 So Solomon and all the folk
Along with him went up to stoke
The high place there in Gibeon,
For there was the congregation
Tent of Alohim Moses slave
Of YHWH had made in desert *wave*.

4 But the ark of Alohim had
David brought up from *the town glad*
Of Kirjathjearim to the place
That David had prepared *with grace*,
For he had pitched a tent for it
In Jerusalem's *town to sit*.

5 The brass altar that Bezaleel
The son of Uri and appeal
Who was the son of Hur, had made,
He put there before the tent stayed
Of YHWH, where king and the folk
prayed.

6 And Solomon ascended to
The brass altar and before YHWH,
That was at the folk's tent in view,
And offered a thousand, not few,
Of burnt offerings up from that pew.
7 That night did Alohim appear
To Solomon, said not to fear,
"Ask what I'll give you, *be a dear*."

The tent that Moses made in wilderness
So long before was still at the address
In Gibeon. So many years had torn
Its coverings and usage had outworn
Its sockets and bolts and left it forlorn.
Only the ark had been brought down to
bless
Jerusalem and despite Michal's scorn.
Still that tent could cause divine dreams'
caress.

Would You appear, Beloved, to me if I
Brought in a thousand animals to die?
Three wishes is a thing in fairy-tale,
The right of cobbler's daughter, knight in
mail.

My tattered tent looks out upon the breeze
And only You can tell me what it sees.

8 And Solomon told Alohim,
"You showed great mercy and esteem
To my dad David, and have made
Me to reign and rule where he stayed.

9 "So now, O YHWH Alohim, let
Your promise to David my dad
Come true, for You have made me get
To be king over the folk *glad*
And numbered like the dust of earth
For multitude *as well as worth*.

10 "Give me now wisdom, knowledge sum
That I may go out and may come
In before this nation, for who
Can judge this great people of YHWH?"

11 And Alohim told Solomon,
"Because this was in your heart done,
And you've not asked for riches, wealth
Or honour, nor the death in stealth
Of your foes, nor yet asked long life,
But have asked wisdom in the strife
And knowledge for yourself, so you
May judge My people and be true
To royal task appointed you,
12 "Wisdom and knowledge shall be given
To you, and I'll give you to live in
Riches and wealth and honour too
Such as none of the kings in view
Have had before you, neither shall
Come after such seigneurial."

13 Then Solomon came to the high
Place from Gibeon by the by
Jerusalem, and from before
The tabernacle of the store
And reigned over Israel *once more*.

14 Solomon gathered chariots and
Horsemen, and he had in the land
A thousand and four hundred grand
Chariots and twelve thousand to stand
As horsemen, which he quartered in
The chariot cities and in bin
With the king at Jerusalem.

15 And the king made silver in hem
And gold at Jerusalem like
Stone and cedar trees he made like
Sycamore trees that in the vale
Stand for abundance *and in tale*.

16 And Solomon had horses brought
Up from Egypt, and linen wrought,
The king's merchants received the bought

Linen yarn *to weave as was taught*.

17 And they fetched up and brought forth
out

Of Egypt a chariot stout
For six hundred shekels in clout
Of silver, and a horse at price
Of one hundred and fifty nice,
And so had all the kings Hittites,
The kings of Syria for rights.

King Solomon invented the arms trade
And made his wealth so dazzling on parade
Through middlemen between the factories
run

By the Egyptians to the men for fun
Who needed every sort of arm and gun
Whether in Syria or in the land
That spread out North in violence and
sand.

He could have made a mint if he had
brought

His wares as far as the American
Cities and stirred up strife there too and
sought

Markets beyond the seas. But he was not
Ambitious. No, Solomon found the way
Sufficient to his happiness and play.
Beloved, I'll talk to You another day.

2 Chronicles 2

1 Solomon decided to build
A temple for YHWH's name fulfilled
And a house for his kingdom's *guild*.

2 Appointed Solomon seventy
Thousand working men to carry
And eighty thousand to cut down
Trees in the mountain for the town,
And three thousand six hundred men
For management *in road and glen*.

Perhaps the cutters on the mountain cut
Stone and not trees, but be that which or
what

I find it interesting that Solomon
Appointed management when he was done
And not merely workers to do the tasks.
Unlike the academic world that asks
More management than teachers, he chose
some,

As few as needed when the workers come.
I wonder if he paid the ruling class
Ten times as much as workers at the pass.

In kingly days perhaps the hierarchy
Was not so vast as in the modern spree
Where difference in wealth is there to see,
Where workers, though not poor, are called
rag-ass.

3 Solomon sent to Hiram king
Of Tyre saying "Now according
To how you dealt with David dad
Of mine, and sent him cedars clad
To build him a house where to live,
Just so deal with me too and give.

4 "See now, I'm building a house to
The name of my Alohim YHWH
Dedicated to Him in view
Of burning to Him sweet incense,
And for the showbread's permanence,
And for burnt offerings morn and eve,
On the Sabbaths, month's first days' leave,
And on the solemn feasts of YHWH
Our Alohim. This ever do
For Israel *and so come true*.

5 "And the house that I build is great,
For great's our Alohim in state
Beyond all exalted *by fate*.

6 "But who can build a house for Him,
Since heaven of heaven and heavens are
dim

And unable to carry Him?
Who am I then that I should build
A house which by Him may be filled?
I merely bring burnt offerings late.

No room in all the universe can hold
Your image or reality enfold.
This truth is fixed in mind of Solomon
As brightly and as sure as shines the sun,
And he repeats it to both king and folk
In every public speech he came and spoke.
I see the clouds immensely cover all
The sky with swift retreat upon the hall
Of space filled with the filaments of what
The universe is made of and unshut.
But all the grandeur does not give You
place,
And nothing can appear before Your face.
Beloved, come to find dwelling place and
room
Within my heart until I fill my tomb.

7 "So send me a man good in gold
And working silver and the cold

Brass and iron and in purple stuff,
 And crimson and in blue not rough,
 With skill in detailed work along
 With the skilled men gathered and strong
 In Judah and Jerusalem,
 Whom David my dad took in hem.
 8 "Send me also cedar trees and
 Fir trees and algum trees that stand
 In Lebanon, because I know
 Your servants have the skill to go
 And cut the timber *in the snow*
 Of Lebanon, and see, my workers
 Will be with your workers *not shirkers*.

Some say that algum trees are sandalwood,
 And others refrain from comments they
 could,
 Since meanings of words change over the
 years
 And centuries that a language appears.
 Some say that barosh does not mean the fir,
 But rather, at least here, the juniper.
 But cypress can be read from dictionary
 And heard on tongue of every Tom and
 Jerry.
 Beloved, the argument of names of trees
 Ought to resolve in what Adam may please
 Who wanders through the gardens of Your
 making
 Seeing the leaves and fruit on branches
 shaking.
 I too seek out the taste and holy smell
 Of pines and firs, the two trees I know
 well.

9 "Even to fit me lots of wood
 For the house I build really should
 Be wonderfully great *if it could*.
 10 "See, I'll give your servants who cut
 The timber twenty thousand butt
 Measures of winnowed wheat as well
 As twenty thousand barley spell,
 Twenty thousand barrels of wine,
 And as much filled with oil *and fine*."

I know there were no barrels in the days
 When Solomon requested by his praise
 The wealth of Lebanon and promised fit
 Wages for those who cut and carried it.
 In vessels ceramic and skin were brought
 The oils and wines that king Hiram had
 sought

To plenish palace and the market place
 Beside the sparkling see for wealth and
 grace.
 Beloved, I seek Your wages in repair,
 The oil and wine I sip upon the air,
 The bread winnowed from dusty book and
 field
 To nourish body and spirit in yield.
 In my return I build for You a place
 In my praises' and cantillations' race.

11 Then Hiram king of Tyre replied
 In writing, which he sent beside
 Solomon, "Because YHWH was pleased
 With His people, that's why He eased
 Them by making of you their king."
 12 "Furthermore Hiram said a thing,
 "Blessed be YHWH Israel's Alohim
 Who made the skies and earth to beam,
 Who gave to king David a son
 So wise that he knew how to run
 With prudence and with understanding,
 To build a house for YHWH commanding,
 As well as for kingdom's demanding.
 13 "And now I've sent a skilful man,
 One full of knowledge and of plan,
 Who belonged to Hiram, dad's man,
 14 "The son of a daughter of Dan,
 And his father's a man of Tyre,
 Skilful to work in gold in hire,
 And silver, brass, in iron, in stone,
 In timber, purple, blue condone,
 And in fine linen, crimson red,
 Also to ingrave flower in head,
 Accomplishing every device
 Set to him as a task surplice,
 With your men skilful and with those
 My lord David your father chose.
 15 "So now then send the wheat as well
 As barley, oil, grape juice to smell
 That you, sir, spoke about and send
 To the servants as you intend.
 16 "And we'll cut wood from Lebanon,
 As much as you shall need anon,
 And we shall bring it to you by
 Sea to Joppa, and you will try
 To transport to Jerusalem."
 17 And Solomon counted the strangers
 All that were in Israel's lands' *dangers*,
 The way David his father had
 Counted them, and they found they had
 A hundred fifty-three thousand

And six hundred of them *on hand*.
18 He set seventy thousand of them
To bear the burdens, and to hew
In the hills eighty thousand crew,
And three thousand and six hundred
Administrators over head
To set the folk to work instead.

Here's a solution for the frantic state
That finds its borders filled with those of
late
Who had no passport nor visa to stay
In the land and to work there for their pay,
And yet in hiding or quite openly
Fulfil the jobs that they find low and free.
Those who would follow Scripture in the
call
Rather than any sense of justice pall
Will take the foreigners and make them
work
At all the hardest jobs, and not to shirk
Set over them their own with whip and rule
To chastize every slow or lazy fool.
Beloved, Your word is limited, I trow,
To that spoken on Sinai anyhow.

2 Chronicles 3

1 Then Solomon began to build
The house of YHWH *both floored and
silled*
Jerusalem in Mount Moriah,
Where had appeared to David *friar*
His dad, in the place David made
In the threshingfloor *and the glade*
Of Ornan of Jebusite grade.
2 And he began to build upon
The second of second month's *dawn*
In the fourth year of his reign *drawn*.
3 These are how Solomon was taught
For building Alohim's house wrought.
The arm-lengths after the first measure
Were sixty arm-lengths and *the treasure*
Of the width were twenty *as sought*.
4 The porch that was set at the front
Was in proportion to the *blunt*
Width of the house, arm-lengths to twenty,
And the height one hundred and twenty,
He gilded inside with pure gold.
5 The ceiling of the large hall told
He set with fir wood, which he covered
With fine gold and set on it *hovered*
Palms and chains *in relief and bold*.

6 He decorated the house with
Jewels of beauty *like a myth*,
And the gold was the gold *that came*
From Parvaim *and with Parvaim's fame*.
7 He also overlaid the place,
Its beams and posts and every trace
Of walls and doors with gold and cut
Cherubim in the walls *to shut*.

Beloved, I build with gold and stone and
wood
Within my inner chamber as I should
A temple to Your glory and Your fame:
And in that temple I repeat Your name.
With palm and chain my ceiling arts are
decked,
And with the fleeting cherubim select
My walls are sure, though made of flesh
and bone:
The silly straws enclose Your sovereign
throne.
Beloved, I build invisibly of late
What Solomon restored to consummate
The beauty of a world none second-rate.
Beloved, I build in silence without gloom
The temple with its garnishings and room
To stand before You on the day of doom.

8 And he made the most holy house,
The length of which was without grouse
The same as the width of the house,
Twenty arm-lengths, and just as wide,
Twenty arm-lengths on every side,
And he enlaid it with fine gold
To six hundred talents *all told*.
9 And the weight of the nails came to
Fifty shekels of gold *in view*,
And he overlaid the upside
Chambers with gold *and purified*.
10 And in the most holy place he
Made two cherubim *faithfully*
Of image work and overlaid
Them both with gold *and so they stayed*.
11 And the wings of the cherubim
Were twenty arm-lengths long *to brim*,
One wing five arm-lengths reaching to
The wall of the house and *in view*
The other wing five arm-lengths *too*,
Reaching to the wing *once outspread*
Of the other cherub *instead*.
12 The other cherub's wing was five
Arm-lengths, and reaching up *to drive*

To the wall of the house, and yet
The other wing was also set
Five arm-lengths up to where it joined
The other cherub's wing *purloined*.
13 These cherub wings spread themselves
out

For twenty arm-lengths *in redoubt*,
And they stood there upon their feet
With faces inward *where to meet*.
14 He made the veil of blue and yet
Of purple and of crimson set,
And fine linen embroidered on
With cherubim rising *to dawn*.

The image in the temple seems to make
A prophecy of churchly ways at stake
Where images of angels for the sake
Of Mary wander in the navelly wake.
The Roman vest is not the only kind
That finds a paradigm upon the rind,
For icons still festoon the veil between
The holy and most holy on the scene
Of Orthodoxy for an image keen.
Beloved, let cherub images of gold
Festoon my heart and let me be so bold
As to remember on the veil that shuts
My inner temple also flies and struts
With cherubim in golden bolts and nuts.

15 Also he made before the house
Two pillars thirty-five *to rouse*
In arm-lengths, while the capital
On top of each pillar so tall
Was five arm-lengths across in all.
16 And he made chains in oracle,
And set on pillar tops, and made
A hundred pomegranates displayed
Upon the chains *all in parade*.
17 He set the pillars up in front
Of the temple, one *to bear brunt*
On the right hand, the other on
The left, and called the name *once drawn*
Of that upon the right hand Jachin,
And the name of the left one *taken*
He called Boaz *in strength unshaken*.

Stability and strength I guess are right
Good names for pillars on the temple site.
I do not wonder at the names themselves,
But rather that such names at all like elves
Must be given to pillars made of stone.

I'd think that names implied both flesh and
bone,
Or at least spirit and mind in the drone.
Name pillars and name windows, doors
and shelves.
Beloved, the pillars of my temple here
Carved in the flesh and bone and sinew
sere
Are nameless unless You see fit to give
Them names from Solomon's own porch
and sieve.
I lay a hand on Strength and patiently
Await times of faith and Stability.

2 Chronicles 4

1 And then he made altar of brass,
Twenty arm-lengths and then to pass
Twenty arm-lengths in width and ten
Arm-lengths in height of it *again*.
2 Also he made a molten sea
Of ten arm-lengths from lea to lea
Across, and its height from the ground
Was five arm-lengths, the line around
It was thirty arm-lengths *to see*.
3 And under it the likeness of
Oxen were set around *in love*,
Ten in an arm-length, going round
The sea, two rows of oxen found
When it was cast *upon the ground*.
4 It stood upon twelve oxen, three
Faced north and three faced toward the
west,
And three looked toward the south and best
Three faced the east, the sea was set
Above upon them and they met
Their hind parts towards the inward net.
5 The thickness of it a handspan,
The brim of it like the work can
Look at a cup's brim, lily-flowered,
And when it was filled up and scoured
It held three thousand baths *by plan*.
6 He made ten lavers and put five
On the right hand and then put five
On the left to wash in them there,
What they offered burnt in its share
They washed in them, but the sea's *care*
Was for the priests to wash them *fair*.

The question of baptism drains the strength
Of human heart and spirit, and at length
Suffices to make war on every hand.

The Qur'an says that You above all
 planned
 Are the best of baptizers in the land.
 So take my flesh (though spirit shrink and
 flee)
 And wash me in the laver of the free,
 Whether in priestly scope or in the tank
 Where sheep and goats come dripping
 when they sank.
 It makes no difference to me, Beloved,
 Whatever the baptism You have shoved
 Upon me, whether in spirit or fire
 Or in the waters of my dark desire.
 I take either the high or lower rank.

7 He made ten candlesticks of gold
 According to their form *when told*,
 And set them in the temple *there*,
 Five on the right hand, and *to share*
 Five on the left, *let souls beware*.
 8 He also made ten tables, and
 Placed them in the temple, five grand
 On the right side and on the left
 Five. And *since he was not bereft*
 He made a hundred kettles *set*
 Of gold *as much as he could get*.
 9 He also made the court of priest,
 And the great court, and doors increased
 For the court, and overlaid their
 Doors with brass *and set them with care*.
 10 And he set the sea on the right
 Side of the east end and in sight
 Against the south *for water sprite*.
 11 And Huram made the pots and spoons,
 And kettles, and Huram's festoons
 Finished the work that he should make
 For King Solomon and the sake
 Of Alohims' house *in its wake*.
 12 Two pillars and the bowls and tops
 Upon the two pillars *in fops*,
 And the two wreaths to cover two
 Bowls of the capitals *in view*
 On the top of the pillars *too*.
 13 And four hundred pomegranates on
 The two wreaths, and two rows upon
 Pomegranates on each wreath at bay
 On the two bowls in the tops' way
 Upon the pillars *not to sway*.

The lavers, candles, tables, all come in
 As tens divided in two groups for sin
 Beyond two pillars of strength and well set:

All these remind me of something I've met
 In the commandments strewn on Sinai's
 peak,
 The Decalogue in stone, traced with the
 streak
 Upon two tables caught beneath the glare
 Of lightning and of silence on the air.
 Beloved, I find Your speaking once aloud
 Had turned the silences of fire and cloud
 Into the greater depths of speech construed
 By wreath and flower and pomegranate
 dewed.
 Beloved, I find Your speaking in the calm
 Of silence golden apples set in balm.

14 He made the bases too and made
 Lavers on bases *where they stayed*.
 15 One sea, twelve oxen under it.
 16 Pots too, and spoons, and fleshhooks fit,
 And all their tools, Huram his dad
 Made for king Solomon and had
 In house of YHWH in bright brass clad.
 17 In the plain of Jordan the king
 Cast them in the clay ground a ring
 Twixt Soccoth and Zeredathah.
 18 So Solomon made all *in awe*,
 Plenty of vessels *for the draw*.

I wonder if wise Solomon could cast
 His brazen works in clay so they would last
 And come out perfect, without need to
 trim,
 As did those of my great grandfather grim.
 That gentleman was tight-lipped with the
 fact
 That he could cast in metal and enact
 A perfect piece each time without a file
 To cut away the straggling edges' smile.
 He bore the secret to the grave and would
 Let no one know the founder's magic
 good.
 I wonder if Solomon among men
 Was wise as my great grandfather was
 then,
 Who quietly worked on the dusky core
 And waded in the darkness of the shore.

19 And Solomon made all the pots
 For Alohims' house in their lots,
 The golden altar too and more
 The shewbread tables *set in store*.
 20 The candlesticks too with their lamps

To burn away the evening damps
 Just as the oracle revealed,
 Made of pure gold *and there unpeeled*.
 21 And flowers and lamps and tongs of
 gold,
 With perfections of gold *untold*.
 22 And snuffers, basins, spoons and all
 The censers of pure gold in thrall,
 The entry of the house, the doors
 Inside it for most holy *stores*,
 And the doors of the temple space
 Were all of gold *within their place*.

If I should find upon my bosky path
 A golden door that did not lead to wrath,
 A shining way metallic above stone
 That led me up and out toward Your
 throne,
 If I should find beneath my closing lid
 At dusk a swathe of silvered mining hid
 From satyr and from every passing crow,
 I'd open up the door and find the show.
 Beloved, the snuffers, basins, spoons and
 craft
 Are precious to the great and small who
 laughed
 To find the faith decked out in wondrous
 store.
 But I am here to ask, Beloved, for more.
 The golden altars gleam both fore and aft,
 But I am here to find a further shore.

2 Chronicles 5

1 So all the work that Solomon
 Made for the house of YHWH was done.
 And Solomon brought in the things
 Of David his dad's christenings,
 The silver and the gold in gleam,
 And all the instruments to beam
 Among treasures of Alohim
 In the *divine* house *fit for kings*.
 2 Then Solomon gathered together
 Israel's elders, *foul and fair weather*,
 And all the heads of all the tribes,
 The chiefs of fathers *with their bribes*
 Of Israel's people to *the town*
 Jerusalem, and to bring down
 The ark of covenant of YHWH
 From David's city *which men knew*
 As Zion with fortress and crew.
 3 And so all men of Israel
 Assembled by the king a spell

To the seventh month feast as well.

The seventh month feast coming later
 shone
 As feast of trumpets before divine throne
 And then the day of the Atonement set
 Before the feast of tabernacles met.
 The seventh month was well the time to
 bring
 The courtiers and the trumpeters to sing
 With voices lifted up before the king.
 The seventh month was the month to atone.
 Beloved, I take the seventh month in task
 And bring my days before You and to ask
 The blessing of the trumpets on my ears
 Until the earth pass out beyond its tears,
 The blessing of the harpists to my eyes
 Until the world come in another guise.

4 And all of Israel's old men came,
 The Levites raised the ark *off fame*.
 5 They brought up the ark and the tent
 Of congregation as they went,
 And every holy pot and cup
 Did the priests and Levites bring up.
 6 Also king Solomon and all
 Israel's assembly on the ball
 With him before the ark to bring
 In sacrifice sheep and a thing
 In oxen without numbering.

As in the days of Moses people brought
 More wealth in sacrifice than they were
 taught
 So that the word went out to bring no more
 Because the house was full of the rich
 store,
 So in the days of Solomon they came
 With sheep and oxen to the holy flame
 To give to You in honour and in right
 The best of everything they had in sight.
 Beloved, it is today anomaly
 That men bring nothing to You in Your fee
 Unless a costly campaign turns the tide
 Of stingy heart and pocket to Your side.
 Like me, a dervish, set in poverty,
 You stand alone throughout eternity.

7 And the priests brought in ark of
 YHWH's
 Covenant to its place to chose
 The oracle of the house, to

The most holy place under view
Of the wings of the cherubim.
8 The cherubim spread out *the gleam*
Of their wings over the ark's *space*
And the cherubim covered *trace*
Of ark and its staves *in their place*.
9 And they pulled out the staves whose
ends

Were visible from the ark's *bends*
Before the oracle, but they
Were not brought to the light of day.
And there it is until this day.

10 Nothing was in the ark beside
The two tables which came to hide
Moses at Horeb, when YHWH made
Pact with Israel's folk on parade
When they came out of Egypt's *shade*.

Beloved, within the temple of my life
Beyond the measured beat of worldly strife
Where I pretend to live in hope of steel
And that my wealth might increase on the
wheel,

Let there be nothing found. Let nothing
there

Be kept in barren trace except the ware
Of tablets two engraved with Your word
sure

To keep my heart and doings always pure.
The ten commandments set in the estate
Of ark of covenant has found of late
Lip-service in the temples of the great.
Let my work and reward be of profile
So low that none of those in rank and smile
Recover the due. Let me serve no guile.

11 It happened when the priests came out
Of the holy place without doubt,
For all the priests were holy there,
Not waiting by their turns to share.

12 Also the singer Levites all:
Asaph, of Heman, and *the fall*
Of Jeduthun with sons at call
And their brothers in linen white
With cymbals, psalteries and *light*
Harps, stood before the altar and
With them a hundred twenty grand
Priests blowing on trumpets *like beasts*.

13 It happened as in unison
The trumpeters, singers as one
Made one sound heard in praise and thanks
To YHWH, and lifted up *in banks*

The sound of trumpets, cymbals and
Instruments of music as manned
And praised YHWH for the good, since
His

Mercy's for ever, the house is
Filled with a cloud, YHWH's own house
grand,

14 So much that the priests could not stand
To minister, because the cloud
Of YHWH's glory had filled *aloud*
Alohim's house *and in a crowd*.

The implication's clear. When You arose
And blessed the temple with Your feet and
toes,

The priests could not stand in the room to
bear

The sacrifice and singing as their share.
So where the priests now gather in their
rate

And fill the sacred precincts and of state
With song and prayer and incense, then I
know

The cloud of Your presence lacks from the
show.

Where You are, my Beloved, no priest can
stand,

Not even the chosen and holy band,
To say no word at all of those who rise
From their own choice and study to
comprise

A college of bishops and cardinals wise
For popes and presidents not to despise.

2 Chronicles 6

1 Then Solomon said that YHWH's said
That he would live in darkness spread.

2 "But I have built a house for You
To live in and a place in view
Of Your dwelling for always too."

But for the universe spread out to be,
I'd think You'd need a tent to live with me.
Have I the strength and will to build a
house

Built with the energy and skill of mouse,
A place where the king of the worlds might
rest,

House on the lakeshore, in the woods at
best?

For You, Beloved, I'd build a house so
bright

You'd think that you had come into the
sight
To find the treasures of Your worlds
assigned,
Live where even You would not feel
confined.
In all my plans and duties here below,
And in my wanderings on the rocky blow,
A melody and plan appear to make
Place and a room where to put Your tent
stake.

3 The king turned his face and blessed all
Israel's assembly in the hall
Where all Israel's assembly stood.
4 And he said "Blessed YHWH Alohim
Of Israel, whose hands as could
Fulfilled what He spoke *in a dream*
With His mouth to David my dad,
Saying 5 'Since the day I was *glad*
To bring my people from the land
Of Egypt I chose no town *grand*
Among all Israel's tribes to build
A house wherein My name is filled,
Neither did I choose any man
To My folk Israel *by plan*.
6 'But I've chosen Jerusalem
So My name might be set a gem,
And I have chosen David there
To keep My folk Israel with care.'
7 "David my dad had it in mind
To build a house for name consigned
Of YHWH and Israel's Alohim.
8 "YHWH told David my dad *in dream*,
'Since it was in your mind to build
A house for My name to be filled,
You did well in intending so.
9 'And yet you'll not build the house *show*,
But your son come out of your loins,
He'll build the house for My name's
coins.'

Your choice of cities and of family,
Son not the eldest whose mother's pretty,
Come from the hope of David and the
womb
Out on the rooftop and outside the room
Of faith, obedience and charity;
Your choice of city just as sparsely minds
Loins pagan and of Jebusitic kinds.
He'll live to multiply treaties with kings,
Build temples also to their heathen things,

The star humility now will return
House to the worship of the things that
burn.
For human promises are weak and sold,
My eyes are set on those who would be
bold.
Name Your price, my Beloved, Solomon's
told.

10 "YHWH then has carried out His word
That He had spoken *and was heard*,
Since I have come up in the place
Of David my dad, set in trace
Upon the throne of Israel,
As YHWH promised, and have built well
The house for the name of YHWH's fame,
The Alohim of Israel's claim.
11 "And there I've placed the ark in which
Is YHWH's covenant that *in pitch*
He made with Israel's folk *to stitch*."

There is no better place in land or town
I have found than where the ark's sitting
down.
Have any human hands found human grief
Placed in that sacred chest for man's relief?
The few that have were stricken down
before
Ark and the cattle cart that led its store.
In every house that human hands have
built,
Which bear the brunt of human act and
guilt,
Is some heart chamber where Your throne
stands still,
YHWH's place of residence in Jack and
Jill.
Covenant of the blessed to all renewed
There springs eternally in nightly dewed,
He finds You quickly who goes in to pray,
Made ready by Your speech along the way.

12 He stood before YHWH's altar in
The sight of Israel's folk and din,
And stretched out his hands' *petition*.
13 Solomon made scaffold of brass
Five arm-lengths long, and five to pass
In width, and three arm-lengths in height,
And set it there within the site
Of the court, and upon it stood
And knelt down on his knees as should
Before all Israel's folk and spread

Out his hands toward the sky 14 and said
“YHWH Alohim of Israel,
There’s no Alohim like You tell
In heaven or in the earth, who keep
Your covenant and mercy’s steep
To Your servants who walk before
You with all their hearts *held in store*.

See here, Beloved, how Solomon goes
down
On both knees bent in front of all the town,
Sits back upon his heels and stretches
hands
Out in petition like Saracen bands.
I follow Solomon in circle prayer,
I follow Solomon beneath the air
Of Medina, and all around me there
The thousands take the same trouble and
stair.
The form of prayer may well be hollow
and
A bare hypocrisy upon the sand,
But who will not bow down because of that
Fail of obedience there where they’re at.
Beloved, I stretch my hands palms to the
sky,
Obedient to You as trains go by.

15 “You who have kept Your promise to
My dad Your servant David’s view,
What You spoke with Your mouth You do
Fulfil with Your hand this day’s due.
16 “Now then, YHWH Israel’s Alohim,
Keep with my dad Your servant’s dream,
David, what You have promised him,
Saying ‘There shall not fail man grim
To sit by Me on Israel’s throne
As long as Your sons not alone
Remember to act by My law
As before Me you’ve kept your paw.’
17 “Now then, YHWH Israel’s Alohim,
Let Your word be true and to seem
What You have spoken to Your slave
David. 18 “But will Alohim crave
To live with men on earth? See now
The sky and the sky’s sky in trough
Cannot contain You, and so how
Can this house I’ve made such allow?

You’ve kept Your promise to this far-flung
day,
Millennia from Solomon’s bright ray,

For still the house of David raises call
Within my heart at least and in my wall.
And yet You are not One today to seek
The marbled palaces that were Your stall.
Today too the blue skies above the meek
Are small to contain You, Beloved, and
bend

Beneath the weight of even divine friend.
You still join in the house of David here
To dwell among men who retain Your fear,
You sing the Psalms of David in the tone
That Solomon heard sitting on his throne.
Invisibly You dwell, not to appear.

19 “Regard then Your slave’s humble
prayer,
And hear his supplication’s care,
O YHWH my Alohim, the prayer
Which Your servant prays on Your stair.
20 “That Your eye opened on this place
Day and night and upon the trace
Of which you’ve said You’d put Your
name,

To hear the prayer Your slave in claim
Prays toward this place *and for its fame*.

21 “So hear the supplications that
Your servant and Your folk *out flat*,
Israel make bowed down toward this place,
Hear from the sky Your dwelling place
And when You hear, forgive *with grace*.

22 “If someone sins against another,
And an oath lie upon the brother,
And the oath come up before this
Your altar in this house of bliss,

23 “Then hear from heaven and do and
judge

Your servants by requiting smudge
Of wickedness to recompense
His way upon his own head’s sense,
And justifying righteousness
By giving by his righteousness.

Though thousands of the sacrifice are done,
And Solomon bows in the house he’s won,
It’s not the flesh and blood burnt on the run
That brings You to forgive daughter and
son;

It is rather the interceding prayer
Of Son of David on the golden stair
That moves Your grace in infinite to care
And brings to humankind Your goodness’
share.

I turn away from every Christian priest
Who robs the altar of all things increased,
And makes the tragedy of Jesus' death
The gift of life and power and hope and
breath.

Instead I see a living Christ that stands
Within the golden courts with praying
hands.

24 "And if Your people Israel
Flee before the enemy fell,
Because they've sinned against You, then
Return confessing once again
Your name and pray and supplicate
Before You in this house and great,
25 "Then hear them from the skies, forgive
The sin of Your folk Israel, live
To bring them back into the land
That You gave them and as the stand
Of their ancestors *by command*.

26 "When the skies close and there's no
rain
Because they've sinned against Your vein,
If they pray toward this place confessing
Your name, and turn from sin addressing,
When You afflict them *for their guessing*,
27 "Then hear from the sky and forgive
The sin of Your servants to live,
And of Your folk Israel, when You
Have taught them the good way and true,
Not disobeying, haughty, vain,
By which they should act, and send rain
Back on Your land, which You have given
To Your folk heritage to live in.

28 "If there's a dry spell in the land,
Of pestilence, or blasting fanned,
Or mildew, locusts or the like
In caterpillars come to strike,
If their enemies come lay siege
To their land's gates upon the squeeze,
Whatever's plague or illness there,

29 "What prayer or supplication share
Shall be made of anyone's care,
Or of all Your folk Israel,
When each shall know his sore and spell,
And stretch out his hands to this space,
30 "Then hear from heaven Your dwelling
place,

Forgive and render to each man
According to all his way's span,
Whose heart You know, for only You
Know the hearts of the human crew.

31 "So they may fear You, walk Your
ways,
As long as they live in the stays
Of the land you gave to our dads,
Both civilized as well as cads.

You hear the prayer of Solomon arise
And meet You with Enoch in upper skies,
And yet it is no small thing to despise
That he prays for the power to do Your
will,
Not merely for forgiveness of the bill.
You heard the prayer of Solomon of old
And answered, not leaving him in the cold.
Now after all the comings of false kings,
And after all the crucifixionings,
You ought, Beloved, to hear and answer
too
Better even than in those times when new
The temple spires gained entrance to Your
view.
I bow with Solomon and beyond grace
I ask forgiveness and right doings' place.

32 "As for the stranger, who is not
Of Your folk Israel in lot,
But comes from a far country for
Your great name's sake and for the score
Of Your power and Your stretched out
arm,
If they come pray in this house *warm*,
33 "Then hear from the skies where You
dwell,
And do by all that stranger well
Calls on You for, so all the earth
And its peoples may know Your worth,
And fear You as does Your own folk
Israel, and may know *to a bloke*
That this house I have built is called
By Your name *by all it enthralled*.

The prayer for every foreign folk that sees
The place of Solomon's temple's degrees
That they be equally accepted where
Your throne and power beat out upon the
air
Shows that no other bastion's needed now
Than that long laid before on David's
brow.
The son of David brings no newer light,
No new faith and no new way to the right,

Who built Your temple in three day and night.

Through all eternity the promise true
Brings both acceptance and the right to do.
No new kingdom, no new dispensing rue,
Can ever displace David and his crew.
I cling to that promise and keep in view.

34 "If Your people go out to war
Against their enemies in store
Of the way You send them, and they
Pray to You toward this city's sway
Which You have chosen, and the room
Which I have built for Your name's *bloom*,
35 "Then hear their prayer from the skies
and

Their supplication at Your hand
And maintain their cause *in the land*.

36 "If they sin against You, for none
Exists but sins when he has done,
And You are angry with them and
Deliver them into foes' hand,
And they carry them captive to
A land far off or near *to You*,

37 "Yet if they mind themselves to think
In the land where in captives' brink
They stand, and turn and pray to You
In the land of the captives' due,
Saying 'We've sinned and done amiss
In wicked dealings set our bliss,'

38 "If they return to You with all
Their heart and all their soul to call
In land of their captivity,
Where they have taken them to be
Captives, and pray toward their land,
Which You have given in the hand
Of their ancestors, and toward
The city You chose above board,
And toward the house built for Your name,
39 "Then hear from the skies where You
dwell

Their prayer and supplications well,
And maintain their cause and forgive
Your sinful people, *let them live*.

Despite the altar, and despite the grand
Temple rising above the city's sand,
You ask no sacrifice in any land,
But that the folk repenting bow to You
As they look toward the temple place in
view.

The sacrifice still living of the soul

Bowed down in prayer is vehicle and goal.
You ask no bloody mess nor crucifixion,
Nor myths repeated for their blessed
diction.

I bow, Beloved, without a sacrifice,
Without a lamb, without the blood of nice,
And only plead Your grace above the spire
Of temple and extinguished altar's fire.
Your blessing spreads unseen in my desire.

40 "Now my Alohim, let, I pray,
Your eyes be open, Your ears pay
Attention to the prayer that's made
In this place *and let heart be swayed*.

41 "So now get up, YHWH Alohim,
Into Your resting place on beam,
You and the ark of Your strength here,
Let Your priests YHWH Alohim rear
Clad with salvation, let Your saints
Rejoice in goodness *and restraints*.
42 "YHWH Alohim, turn not away
The face of Your anointed's *day*,
Remember David's mercies, who
Is Your servant *and always true*."

You do, Beloved, remember David's
while,
You mind the prayer of Solomon and
smile.

But I too would remember and keep well
Within my heart the loving, sacred spell.
There is no God but You and You are great
Above every temple and every state,
Above the heavens beyond their glory
found

And yet appear here on the humble ground.
You are One and beyond all reckoning,
And yet You have set up eternal king
In David's house, and thither I speed wing.
Clad in salvation, I come to rejoice
Both in Your oneness and Your royal
choice,
And lift a Psalm at last in David's voice.

2 Chronicles 7

1 When Solomon finished his prayer,
The fire came down from heaven there,
Burnt up the burnt offering as well
As sacrifices, and the glory
Of YHWH filled the house, *every storey*.
2 And the priests could not come into
The glory-filled temple of YHWH,

Because the glory of YHWH filled
YHWH's house *into which it had spilled*.

3 When all the folk of Israel saw
How the fire came down and *with awe*
The glory of YHWH on the house,
They bowed themselves with face *like*
mouse

To the ground on the paving stone
And worshipped praising YHWH *on*
throne:

For He's good, His mercy *full-blown*
Forever and ever *is shown*.

Beloved, You came and filled the temple
there
With glory and destroyed the offering's
share.

Your coming sets aside the sacrifice
And turns out every priest, even the nice.
Your temple's made for glory and to dwell
In state before the folk of Israel,
Not for eternal killing and for blood.
You seek a temple cleansed for aye of
mud.

Beloved, Your coming to my inner place,
My stony inner chamber, brings me grace
Beyond all covenant of flesh and skin:
Your coming is to dwell ever within.
I turn from sin and sacrifice to You,
And find at last the glorious and true.

4 The king and all the people brought
Sacrifices before YHWH's *plot*.
5 King Solomon gave sacrifice
Of twenty-two thousand high price
Oxen, and the number of sheep
One hundred twenty thousand deep.
So the king and all the folk came
To dedicate Alohim's claim
The house *that was to be for fame*.

Despite all evidence that You are great,
And eat no flesh of bulls in Your estate,
Nor drink their blood, still king and people
wait
With tearing of lambs flesh before Your
gate.
In love and pity You return to see
The gory mess that worship brings in fee,
Desire to earn something beyond Your
grace.
You give eternal gift in Your own face.

Today men still turn from grace in their
plot

Demanding something more than what
they've got,

Blind to the glory of Your daily spot.
In pity look on them in pity raise
The multitude if possible to praise.
If not, keep me alone within Your ways.

6 And the priests waited on their tasks,
The Levites also with their *masks*
Of music of YHWH that David
The king had made to raise the *lid*
Of praise to YHWH, because always
Is His mercy, when David's praise
By their service, and the priests sounded
Trumpets before them and *well-grounded*
All Israel stood *as though dumb-founded*.

7 Moreover Solomon made holy
The middle of the court there *lowly*
Before the house of YHWH, for there
He offered burnt offerings *in air*,
And the fat of peace offerings fair,
Because the brass alter he made,
Solomon did, met not the grade
To take the burnt offerings and meat
Offerings and the fat *for a treat*.
8 At the same time Solomon kept
The feast for seven days *unswept*
And all Israel with him, a great
Assembly, from at Hamath's *rate*
To the river of Egypt's *state*.

9 On the eighth day they gathered there
To dedicate the altar's share
For seven days, and the feast *too*
For seven days *and all in crew*.
10 And on the twenty-third day of
The seventh month he sent *above*
The folk away into their tents,
Glad and joyful in heart *for vents*
Of YHWH's goodness He showed David
And Solomon as well as *bid*
To Israel His folk *in His love*.
So Solomon finished YHWH's house
And the king's palace, *not to grouse*,
And everything that Solomon
Intended to do in *the run*
Of YHWH's house and his own room's
fun,

He did prosperously *and won*.

You granted humankind by their demand

The right to sacrifice upon the sand
 An animal or two each day with prayer
 And singing of the Psalms upon the air.
 You limited the rate of sacrifice
 And told them in Your law what would
 suffice,
 But they brought thousands more and
 thought it nice,
 Benighted as all men are by their world.
 But as the stinking smoke arose and
 swirled,
 There was another sound sweet with the
 Psalm,
 The prayer of praise, petition, without
 qualm
 The penance and the plaint that I've been
 wronged.
 Behind the dark blood and fit I have longed
 For that pure faith to David's son
 belonged.

12 YHWH came to Solomon at night
 And said to him, "I've heard you right,
 And chosen this place for myself
 As house of sacrifice *and shelf*.
 13 "If I shut up the sky from rain
 Or command locusts on the plain
 To eat it up, or if I send
 A plague among the folk *and friend*,
 14 "If My folk who're called by My name
 Humble themselves and in prayer's claim
 Seek My face and turn from their ways
 Of wickedness, I'll hear their lays
 From heaven and will forgive their sin
 And heal the land that they live in.
 15 "So My eyes will be open and
 My ears listen to the prayers fanned
 In this place. 16 "For now I have come
 To chose and make holy the sum
 Of this house so My name may be
 There always and My eyes that see
 And heart be there perpetually.
 17 "And as for you, if you will walk
 In my sight, *and never to balk*,
 As David your father would walk,
 And act by all that I command,
 Observing My statutes and band
 Of My judgements, 18 "then I shall set
 Your kingdom's throne by the pact met
 With David your father to say
 'There shall not fail in any way
 To be your man as king to rule

In Israel *by royal stool*. '
 19 "But if you turn away and leave
 My statutes and commandments grieve
 Which I have set before your face,
 And go to serve another race
 Of gods and worship them *for grace*,
 20 "Then I'll pull them up by the roots
 Out of My land till it confutes
 That I have given them, and this
 Temple I've sanctified to kiss
 My name I shall cast out of sight
 And make it a proverb to bite
 And byword among every folk.
 21 "And this house which is high shall be
 A marvel to each one to see
 Who passes by it, so he'll say
 'Why has YHWH acted in this way
 Toward this land and house *to slay*?'
 22 "And the reply shall come, 'Because
 They forsook YHWH Alohim's laws
 To their ancestors, who brought out
 Of Egypt's land, and went about
 To lay hold on other gods and
 Worship them and serve them in band,
 That's why He's brought this evil thing
 Upon the people and their king.'"

The three conditions of forgiveness lie
 In the promise You gave once from the sky
 To Solomon in answer to his prayer:
 That Your folk humble themselves on the
 stair,
 That they seek You in prayer and that they
 turn
 Away from sinful paths to strict and stern
 Of the ten promises in pact. I spurn
 All other gospels, those of meat and bread,
 And those that forgive oppressors unled
 To turn away from evil in the bed.
 Beloved, three steps to faith and justice are
 Without any substitution or bar.
 I praise You that Your grace is infinite,
 Enough without sacrifice of the fit.

2 Chronicles 8

1 It happened after twenty years
 During which time *with all his gears*
 Solomon built the house of YHWH
 And his own house *with game and crew*,
 2 That the cities Hiram gave back
 To Solomon to take his slack,
 Solomon built them and made there

The children of Israel have share.
 3 Solomon went to Hamathzobah
 And conquered it and made it over.
 4 And in the desert built Tadmor,
 And all the cities kept for store
 Which he built in Hamath *in score*.
 5 Also he built Bethhoron high,
 And Bethhoron under the sky,
 Fortified cities, walls and gates,
 And bars *and such to keep out mates*,
 6 And Baalath, all the store cities
 That Solomon had made for ease,
 And all the chariot cities, and
 The cities for the horsemen manned,
 And all that Solomon desired
 To construct in Jerusalem,
 And in Lebanon unretired,
 And throughout all his land in hem.

The horses of the king were fine to see,
 I guess he had forgotten in the spree
 The Torah forbids horses to the king,
 Who ought to write his Torah and to sing
 Instead of getting gold and silver drawn,
 Collecting wives and horses for a pawn.
 The horses were perhaps the king's
 downfall,
 Unless it was the wives against the wall.
 Beloved, I seek the son of David still,
 Despite the things I see and with a thrill
 Of wonder that anointed ones can stay
 So blind to what is true from day to day.
 I'd think I only have the right to be
 Unseeing of the things I ought to see.

7 As for all the folk that were left
 Of the Hittites and unbereft
 Of Amorites and Perizzites,
 And the Hivites and Jebusites
 Who were not of Israel by rights,
 8 Of their descendants who were left
 After them in the land and cleft,
 The ones Israel's folk failed to slay,
 Them did Solomon make to pay
 Tribute until this very day.
 9 But from Israel's folk Solomon
 Did not take slaves of anyone
 For his work. They were men of war,
 And chiefs of his captains and more
 Captains of carriages and horsemen.
 10 And these chief officers again
 Of king Solomon were a crowd

Of two hundred and fifty loud
 To rule over the folk *unbowed*.

What's left of gross idolaters the king
 Sets only to tribute and leaves the ring
 Of Israel alone to fight and draw
 The sword upon all others that they saw.
 The Canaanite is good enough to serve
 As workman and as slave to cut up wood
 And draw water for every lad and lass
 That meets the standard of the warrior
 class.

Beloved, the ten commandments are far-
 fetched

Among the palmed, the olived and the
 vetched.

Who thrive on grapes beneath the flaunting
 sun

Have no need of the hope in things well-
 done.

The nation thrives in wealth and as a crowd
 Ruled happily if such is said aloud.

11 Solomon brought up Pharaoh's daughter
 Out of David's city and wrought her
 A house, he said "My wife won't live
 In the house of David and give
 Place to the king of Israel,
 Because that's where the ark a spell
 Of YHWH came and remained there well."

12 Then Solomon in offering
 Gave burnt sacrifices to bring
 To YHWH on YHWH's altar which he
 Had built before the porch's lea.

13 A certain amount every day,
 Offered according to the way
 Commanded by Moses, upon
 The Sabbaths, and on the new dawn
 Of the first of the month, and on
 The solemn feasts three times a year,
 The feast of no yeast bread for fear,
 The feast of weeks and in the feast
 Of tabernacles *with each priest*.

The king has a good treaty wife to spare,
 And by command of Moses to the fair,
 Offers up sacrifices to beware.
 I notice, my Beloved, the command comes
 From Moses and not from you in its sums.
 The daily round, the Sabbaths in their feast,
 The yearly festivals in times increased,
 All serve the tabernacle drought of blood,

While people come and go as in a flood.
I seek the tempered temple with Your
praise

Alone rises above the nights and days,
And find the inner temple where I live
To offer sacrifice of blood and give
Alive the sacrifices that You raise.

14 He set according to the way
Of David his father the dray
Of the priest in their service bent,
And the Levites to their tasks lent,
To praise and serve before the priests,
As required by each day and feasts,
The porters also by their turns
At every gate, as each one learns
By David the man of God's burns.

15 And they did not turn aught aside
From the command of the king's ride
To the priests and Levites to do
Anything or about the view
Of treasures *in their store and pew*.

16 Now all the work of Solomon
Was set to day of foundation
Of YHWH's house until it was done.
So YHWH's house was done once begun.

The temple of my heart is never done,
Despite the rise and setting of the sun.
Each day the living sacrifice goes on
And touches rose with every rising dawn.
The temple of my heart is never cast
As finished and ready when You have
passed.

A rugged wall, a thorny latch, and lamp
That barely keeps away the evening damp.
And yet within that temple and employ
Unfinished I find with You simple joy.
The heart leaps up indeed to see the way
The year whirls on in time yet without pay.
I do not turn aside from Your command
Even without the burning priests on hand.

17 Then Solomon went down to be
At Ezionbeber to see
Elath in Edom's land by sea.

18 And Joram sent him by the hand
Of his servants great ships in band
And sailor servants of the sea,
And they went with the servants of
Solomon to Ophir for love,
And took from there four hundred and

Fifty talents of gold in hand,
And brought them to King Solomon.
And so his sea-faring was done.

I look upon the rugged hills that make
The walls above the Red Sea for the sake
Of Elath by the sea, and then I take
My way into their bosom and look out
Upon the sea as far as I can doubt
Where Jordan's land still rises from the
sea.

The port of gold, this place became when
sent

King Solomon his bold in fine ships lent.
It is a place of tourist trade today,
Where Jewish Russian can be heard to
sway

In some streets, and where even Druse is
found.

I come to love Elath upon the ground,
And watch the blue below me from the dry
Stones that bear up my feet and steady eye.

2 Chronicles 9

1 And when the queen of Sheba heard
Of Solomon's fame, like a bird
She came to test Solomon with hard
Questions at Jerusalem barred,
With a very great company,
And camels carrying in fee
Spices and lots of gold and yet
Precious stones all that she could get,
And when she came to Solomon,
She talked with him till she had done
Telling all in her heart *and bun*.

2 Solomon gave an answer to
All her questions, and there was true
Not one thing hidden from the view
Of Solomon that he did not
Tell her *until she was well-taught*.

3 And when the queen of Sheba saw
Solomon's wisdom, and in awe
The house that he had built *of straw*,

4 And the food on his table and
The sitting of his servant band,
And the attendance of his folk
And their bright clothing at a stroke,
His stewards and their uniforms,
And the steps by which in their swarms
He went up into YHWH's house, there
Was no more spirit in her share.

5 And she said to the king, "A true

Report I heard of what you do
 In my own land, and of your wise
 Heart, 6 “yet before my *doubting* eyes
 I did not have faith in their word
 Until I came and my eyes stirred
 To see it and see now the half
 Of your wisdom in greatness quaff
 I only now, for you go far
 Beyond the fame I heard *from star*.
 7 “Blessed are your men, and blessed are
 these
 Your servants who stand here to please
 Before your face and hear your grace.
 8 “Blessed be YHWH your Alohim who
 Delighted in you to set you
 On His throne to be king for YHWH
 Your Alohim because your God
 Loved Israel and set on sod
 For ever, so He made you king
 To rule over in everything
 In judgement and justice *to sing*.”

I too, like Queen of Sheba, come to find
 The son of David is not one so blind
 But that he rules with wisdom. He is kind
 And shows the wealth of treasure-house
 wherein
 Lie all his stores of knowledge as in bin.
 I too, like Queen of Sheba, make my way
 To son of David, and on such a day
 Open my heart to him and tell him all
 My doubts and loves and faiths beneath his
 tall
 Spires of palace and temple, till I turn
 Back to my inner chamber where I burn
 In his name sacrifices of sweet smell.
 I live to find Your David’s son and tell
 My soul again and again what I learn.

9 She gave the king an hundred and
 Twenty talents of gold to stand
 And spices much and precious stones,
 Nor was there any such spice more
 As Queen of Sheba gave *in store*
 To the king Solomon *in score*
To rest his wearing, aching bones.
 10 The servants also of Hiram,
 And the servants of Solomon,
 Who brought Ophir’s gold, brought algum
 Trees and precious stones when they’d
 done.
 11 And the king made *of algum* hew

Terraces for the house of YHWH,
 And for the king’s palace *and pew*,
 And harps and psalteries to sing,
 And there was never such a thing
 Before seen in the land of Judah,
Their instruments had once been cruder.
 12 King Solomon gave to Sheb’s queen
 All her desire of what she’d seen
 Besides what she’d brought to the king.
 So she returned and wondering
 To her own land, she and her own
 Servants *to sit upon her throne*.
 13 Now the weight of gold that came to
 Solomon in one year in view
 Was six hundred and sixty-six
 Six talents of gold to take his picks,
 14 Beside *what* retailers and hawkers
 Brought in. And all the kings and
 squawkers
 Of glad Arabia brought gold
 And siller to Solomon’s fold.

I bring the son of David here no gold
 Nor silver from my tills of what I’ve sold.
 I bring instead the algum wood and sweet
 To make his harps to sing in hall and street,
 In temple court and on the meadowed hill.
 I bring him algum wood to fit the bill.
 Beloved, I am a soul of algum wood,
 Cut and shaped in the harply way I should,
 And cantillating on the solemn air
 The songs of son of David and the share
 Of David’s Psalms that still spring up to
 make
 The tabernacle true for David’s sake.
 Beloved, I am a harp of wood and string,
 And here I stop to read the Psalms and
 sing.

15 King Solomon made two hundred
 Targets of beaten gold to bid
 Of six hundred shekels of beaten
 Gold went into each one *to sweeten*.
 16 And three hundred shields beaten gold:
 Three hundred *shekels* of gold told
 Went into each shield. And the king
 Put them in the house of *the ring*
 Of Lebanon’s forest *to sing*.
 17 Moreover the king made a great
 Ivory throne and set in state
 A pure gold overlay first-rate.
 18 And *there were* six steps to the throne,

With a footstool of gold alone
 Fastened to the throne, and stays each
 Side of the sitting place to reach
 Two lions standing by the stays.
 19 Twelve lions stood there in the bays
 Upon the six steps. There was not
 Such a thing anywhere one got
 In any kingdom, any spot.
 20 And all the cups and goblets that
 King Solomon *drank from at that*
Were of gold, and all plates and saucers
 Of the house of the forest glossers
 Of Lebanon *were of pure gold*,
 None silver; it was *no* thing told
 Of any count in all the days
 Of Solomon, *and to his praise*.
 21 For the king's ships went to Tarshish
 With servants of Hiram *to fish*:
 Every three years once came the ships
 Of Tarshish bringing gold, and slips
 Of silver, ivory, and apes,
 And peacocks *with their tails in shapes*.

The first time I was in Kuwait I saw
 No silver on the table but the claw
 Of gold in everything that clinked and
 clanked.
 And gold was set with gemstones of the
 ranked.
 The first time I was in Kuwait I found
 The table was as often set on ground
 As in the air with chairs to sit upon.
 And yet the spread was golden before
 dawn.

Beloved, I come to Your table spread out
 Before my eyes of hope and eyes of doubt,
 And find You more than Solomon the king
 And more that Kuwaiti with golden ring
 A treasure beyond gold and beyond sight.
 I flee to You, Beloved, and to Your right.

22 King Solomon surpassed all kings
 Of earth in wisdom and in things.
 23 And all the kings of earth would come
 To Solomon's presence *in sum*,
 To hear the wisdom Alohim
 Had put into his heart *supreme*.
 24 And they brought every man his gift,
 Vessels of silver hard to lift,
 And pots of gold, and many clothes
 Harness, and spices, horses' shows,
 And mules, all year by year he chose.

25 And Solomon had four thousand
 Stalls for horses and chariots' band,
 And twelve thousand horsemen on hand;
 Whom he spread out in chariot cities,
 The king at Jerusalem's *ditties*.
 26 So he reigned over all the kings
 From the river up to the rings
 Of the Philistines' lands, and to
 The border of Egypt *in cue*.
 27 And the king made silver become
 In Jerusalem like stones' sum,
 And cedar trees made he as cheap
 As sycamores found in a heap
 In the low-lands *where they still creep*.
 28 And they brought unto Solomon
 Horses out of Egypt for fun,
 And out of all lands *once begun*.
 29 Now the rest of Solomon's acts,
 First and last, *are* they not as facts
 Written in book of Nathan prophet,
 And in prophecy not to scoff at
 Of Ahijah the Shilonite,
 And in the visions of the wight
 Iddo the seer against whom sat
 Jeroboam son of Nebat?
 30 Solomon ruled Jerusalem,
 All Israel forty years *from stem*.
 31 And Solomon slept with ancestors,
 And he was buried by sequesters
 In city of David his dad,
 And Rehoboam his son *sad*
 Reigned in his stead *for all he had*.

Your Torah, my Beloved, forbids such
 things
 As gold and horses to Your set-up kings.
 Yet Solomon went far beyond Your law
 To make gold of no worth in every paw.
 Abundance is one way to fulfil right,
 And overflowing is before Your sight.
 Not Solomon's greed filled his treasure-
 store,
 But flattery of kings before his door.
 Beloved, I bring no gift to You or him,
 No gold nor ivory or cedar trim.
 And yet I come and take in hand Your gift,
 And steal from Solomon what I can lift,
 And praise and thank You both for what I
 find
 Lying upon the street in golden kind.

2 Chronicles 10

1 And Rehoboam went to Shechem:
 Because all Israel came to Shechem
 To make him king. 2 It came to pass,
 When Jeroboam son *not lass*
 Of Nebat, who *was* in Egypt,
 Where he had fled *with wings unclipped*
 From sight of Solomon the king,
 Heard *that*, then Jeroboam's wing
 Brought him back from Egypt *to sing*.
 3 They summoned him and called him
 there

So Jeroboam and all fair
 In Israel came and outspread
 Spoke to Rehoboam, and said,
 4 "Your father made our yoke too hard,
 So ease up now and be a pard,
 From the harsh service of your dad,
 And his great burden that he had
 Put on us, and we will serve you."
 5 But he told them, "Come in my view
 After three days." And so they left.
 6 And king Rehoboam bereft
 Asked the advice of the old men
 Who had counselled his dad again,
 Solomon, while he was alive,
 And said "What advice do you jive
 To give me in reply to this
 People *who come so I'll not miss*."
 7 And they spoke to him saying "If
 You are kind to this folk not stiff
 And please them and speak easy words
 To them, they'll be your servant herds
 For ever." 8 But he left advice
 Given by the old men and nice,
 And took the counsel of the young
 Men who were brought up with his *tongue*
 And stood before him *on the rung*.

When I was young, it seems, no king relied
 On the advice I might have brought his
 side.

Now that I'm old, I've learned that all
 deride
 Advice of an old man instead of guide.
 Though I offer no counsel to the great
 Nor hardly to my family in state,
 I do not keep my mouth shut, but I flail
 Impotent arms against the worldly gail.
 I say to leave off drink, I say to sail
 According to the ten commandments' law,
 I say to reject Baal and tooth and claw,
 The sacrifice of human blood and paw.

But in my ranting I know better now
 Than to think I shall be heard anyhow.

9 And he said to them, "What advice
 Do you give to reply with spice
 To these people who've come to me
 Saying 'Ease up on the yoke tree
 That your father laid on the free?'"
 10 And the youths brought up with him
 spoke

To him and said "Answer the folk
 Who spoke to you to say 'Your dad
 Made our yoke heavy, but be glad
 To lighten it a bit for us,'
 Tell them, 'My little finger truss
 Shall be thicker than my dad's shank.
 11 'Though my dad put a heavy crank
 On you, I add more to your load,
 My dad struck you with whips and goad,
 But I with scorpions and *not toad*.'"
 12 So Jeroboam and all those
 People with him came in their rows
 To Rehoboam the third day,
 As the king asked to have his say,
 "Come again to me on the third day."
 13 The king replied roughly to them,
 And king Rehoboam left hem
 Of the old men's advice *and stem*.
 14 And answered them by the advice
 Of the young men, saying not nice,
 "My father made your yoke a load,
 But I will add to it a goad,
 My father chastised you with whips,
 But I'll *strike* with scorpions' *lips*.
 15 The king did not obey the folk,
 For the matter was of the stroke
 Of Alohim, so YHWH might do
 According to His word on cue
 By Ahijah the Shilonite
 To Jeroboam in his right
 The son of Nebat *day and night*.

The council of the young's in favour now,
 And I see the effects on culture's brow.
 The world is filled with more injustice and
 With more hate and with more war in the
 stand
 Than ever in the history of the manned.
 The songs have turned to wailing in the
 wake
 Of blasphemy upon the grime and stake,
 And babes in bushes cry aloud to make

Obscenities the prattle of the banned.
 Beloved, I flee from this world and I say
 The fire of youth has burned the last decree
 And set in flames the last bridge to the lea.
 I turn to You, Beloved, and turn away
 From greed, pollution, and the darkened
 day.

16 And when all Israel *saw* the king
 Would not listen to anything,
 The people replied to the king,
 Saying "What portion in our hand
 Is of David? *We have* no land
 In Jesse's son: let every man
 To your tents, O Israel: *and scan*
 Now, David, see to your own house.
 So all Israel went out to growse."
 17 Then Israel's folk that lived within
 The cities of Judah to spin,
 Rehoboam reigned over them.
 18 King Rehoboam's stratagem
 Was that he sent Hadoram who
 Was over the tribute in due,
 But Israel's folk stone him with stones.
 So that he died after his groans.
 But king Rehoboam then sped
 To get in his chariot and fled
 Back to Jerusalem *and bed*.
 19 And Israel has rebelled agin
 David's house to this day *to win*.

I too might say what portion now remains
 To me in David's tents and in his lanes.
 The tabernacle lies in tattered shreds,
 The priesthood's turned to bones in linen
 threads.
 Instead the mitred vicar of the Lord
 Reigns over market and the gospel horde.
 Instead the beating thrust of rock and roll
 Turn over in the mass to take their toll.
 Beloved, I come in my simplicity
 To the fair temple of David in lee,
 And lift a single voice in company
 Of bird and beast and find the Psalms
 remake
 All that seemed lost of Yours for David's
 sake.

2 Chronicles 11

1 And when Rehoboam had come
 Back to Jerusalem a bum,
 He gathered of the house of Judah

And Benjamin a hundred shewder
 And eighty thousand chosen *men*,
 Who were warriors, to fight again
 Against Israel, that he might bring
 The kingdom back again to sing
 Under Rehoboam's ruling.
 2 But the word of YHWH met Shemaiah
 The man of Alohim and crier,
 Saying, "Speak to Rehoboam
 The son of Solomon, who am
 The king of Judah, and to all
 Israel in Judah-Benjamin,
 Saying, 4 "So says YHWH at the call,
 'You shall not go to fight and brawl
 Against your brothers, go back each
 Man to his house, this is my reach.
 And they obeyed the words of YHWH
 And went back from going *in crew*
 Against Jeroboam *on cue*.'""
 5 And Rehoboam lived and dwelt
 In *fine* Jerusalem, and built
 Cities to defend Judah's silt.

My task is like the son of David's here.
 It's not to go out and pull down the gear
 Of those who claim in norther clime to
 show

The gospel and the jolly way to go.
 My task is just to built the temple sound
 By singing David's songs upon the ground,
 And building of the Bethlehem once told
 And Ephrata with wondered wealth unsold.
 Beloved, the prophet does not let me stand
 Armed in the market-place under command
 Of captains of the gore to make return
 Rebellious Christians to the way they
 spurn.

Instead I sing the simple lays that ring
 In Psalms of David, son of David, king.

6 He built even Bethlehem, and
 Etam, and Tekoa *to stand*,
 7 As well as Bethzur, and Shoco,
 And Adullam, 8 and Gath *to go*,
 And Mareshah, and Ziph, 9 and still
 Adoraim, and Lachish, and hill
 Of Azekah, 10 And Zorah, and
 Aijalon, and Hebron, which *band*
 Are in Judah and Benjamin
 Fortified cities *set to win*.
 11 He fortified the strongholds, and
 Put captains in them over band,

And store of food, and cask of oil
 And grape juice for the soldiers' toil.
 12 And in each of the cities he
 Put shields and spears, and made very
 Strong, having Judah-Benjamin
 On his side *and set there to win.*
 13 And the priests and the Levites that
Were in all Israel out flat
 Came to him from every place known.
 14 For the Levites left overgrown
 Their villages and fields, and came
 Down to Judah's Jerusalem,
 For Jeroboam and his sons
 Had put them out of office runs
 To be priests to YHWH's benisons.
 15 And he ordained priests for high places,
 And for the devils in their traces,
 And for the calves that he had made.
 16 And after them for accolade
 Out of all tribes of Israel
 Those who set their hearts to seek well
 YHWH Alohim of Israel
 Came to Jerusalem to make
 Sacrifice to YHWH and the sake
 Of Alohim of their dads' wake.

I too wait for the priest and multitude
 To turn away from civilized and crude,
 And return to the simple word and store
 Of faith upon David's son's ample shore.
 In days of old by ones and twos they came,
 But even that would not cover the shame
 That left at least Judah to Babylon,
 Captivity on captive echelon.
 Beloved, the days of Babylon are past,
 The days of restoration did not last.
 Millennia have come and gone and yet
 I still stand on the promises I get.
 I find the tabernacle in sound set,
 And faith is strong if raised only half-mast.

17 So they strengthened the kingdom of
 Judah, and made in single love
 Rehoboam Solomon's son
 To be strong for three years to run,
 For three years they walked in the way
 Of David's and Solomon's sway.
 18 And Rehoboam took himself
 Mahalath the daughter on shelf
 Of Jerimoth David's son to
 Be his wife, *and* Abihail too
 The daughter of Eliab son

Of Jesse, *also kin when done.*
 19 She bore him children; Jeush, and
 Shamariah, and Zaham's hand.
 20 And after her he took Maachah
 The daughter of Absalom's claw,
 Who bore him Abijah, Attai,
 Ziza, and Shelomith thereby.
 21 And Rehoboam loved Maachah
 The daughter of Absalom's crow
 Above all wives and concubines:
 For he took eighteen wives, and twenty
 Concubines and sired son a-plenty,
 Twenty-eight boys and sixty girls.
 22 And Rehoboam made the curls
 Of Abijah Maachah's son chief,
 To rule among his brothers' fief,
 To make him king at his relief.
 23 And he treated them wisely and
 Spread them throughout all of the land
 Of Judah and Benjamin, to
 Every fortified city due,
 And gave them rations in their lot.
 And he wanted and so he got
 Many wives *and kept them in crew.*

For three years Rehoboam was a chump
 And followed You and David in the lump.
 Three years and a half is as long as can
 A man stay firm and follow in Your plan.
 Even Your Christ only lasted the span
 Of three years and a half, and so the word
 Of Revelation takes that time preferred.
 Three years and a half, half of seven
 stirred,
 It ought to be a witness and enough.
 The world's a place that's ready and is
 rough.
 And yet Noah was able in his day
 To serve a hundred twenty years in sway,
 And find the ark still floated on the sea
 Of Your destruction of eternity.

2 Chronicles 12

1 It happened when Rehoboam
 Had established the royal ram
 And strengthened himself, he forsook
 The law of YHWH, and in their nook
 All Israel with him to look.
 2 It happened in the fifth year of
 King Rehoboam seen above
 That Shishak king of Egypt came
 Against Jerusalem for shame

That they had sinned against YHWH's name.

3 With twelve hundred chariots, and
Sixty thousand horsemen in band,
Uncounted soldiers too that came
With him out of Egypt in claim:
The Lubim, Sukkiim and not least
The Ethiopians increased.

4 And he captured the fortified
Cities of Judah's countryside
Arriving at Jerusalem.

5 Then came Shemaiah, he's a gem,
And prophet, to Rehoboam,
And to the princes of Judah
Who were gathered in council's draw
There in Jerusalem because
Of Shishak, and told them in pause,
"So says YHWH, since you have forsaken
Me, that's why I've let you be taken
In hand of Shishak, *so awaken*."

6 At that princes of Israel
And the king humbled themselves well,
And said "YHWH does righteously spell."

7 And when YHWH saw that they
repented,
The word YHWH came and prevented
Shemaiah saying "They've converted
To humble themselves, so I'll not
Destroy them but I'll grant a plot
To their salvation, and My wrath
I shall not pour out on the path
Of Jerusalem by the hand
Of Shishak *and by Shishak's band*.
8 "But they shall be his servants till
They know My service and the bill
Of the kingdoms of countries' fill."

O my Beloved, do You not know the true
Christian maintains that death for sin is
due?

How is it that You repent of the thing
You plan in retribution on the king
As soon as repentance comes in to fill
His poor account, why don't You instead
kill?

You are a sucker for repentance and
You have mercy on every humble land,
While every Christian has to have a cross,
A bleeding body, and avenging boss.
Pull Yourself now together, take the whip
And lay the punishment upon the strip
Of innocent flesh come to take the rue.

Surely no penitence satisfies You!

9 So Shishak king of Egypt came
Against Jerusalem in flame
And took away the treasures of
The house of YHWH, the treasures of
The king's house too, and he took all,
He carried away from their hall
The shields of gold Solomon made.
10 Instead king Rehoboam made
Such shields of brass and those ones stayed
In the hands of the chief of guard,
That kept the king's house in his yard.
11 And when the king came in the house
Of YHWH, the guard *put on his blouse*
And came and took them back again
To the guard chamber *with his men*.
12 When he humbled himself, the wrath
Of YHWH turned from him and his path,
So He would not destroy *the man*
In total, and in Judah's *plan*
As well all things went well *to scan*.

13 King Rehoboam fortified
Himself in Jerusalem's side,
And reigned. Now Rehoboam *was*
Forty-one years old when his *paws*
Began to reign, and so he reigned
Seventeen years and still retained
Jerusalem, the city that
YHWH had chosen from all the spate
Of Israel's tribes to put His name
There. And his mother's name, *just guess*,
Was Naamah an Ammonitess.

14 And he did evil, he prepared
Not his heart to seek YHWH *when spared*.

15 The acts of Rehoboam, first
And last, *are* they not blessed and cursed
In the book of Shemaiah prophet,
And of Iddo the seer sofit
Concerning genealogies?

And *there were* wars and strategies
Between Rehoboam and king
Jeroboam like anything.

16 And Rehoboam slept with his
Ancestors, and was in a whiz
Buried in David's city, and
His son Abijah took his stand.

The king replaces gold with brass and finds
The space to keep appearances in binds.
I wonder if he once forgot the gleam
Of Solomon's shields, as if in a dream,

He went into the temple court to bow
Toward You, Beloved, did he forget
somehow?

The god's blood of gold is a heathen fare,
And even brass in my temple is rare,
But still I wonder if the pain was there
As long as Rehoboam reigned and ruled.
The gold was so much that if all had
pooled
Their earrings it would not have been
enough
To replace what Pharaoh stole of their
stuff.
My inner chamber is both light and bare.

2 Chronicles 13

1 Now in the eighteenth year of king
Jeroboam Abijah's spring
Began over Judah to ring.
2 He reigned over Jerusalem
For three years. And his mother's name
Also *was* Michaiah the girl
Of Uriel of Gibeah's *hurl*.
And there was war between Abijah
And Jeroboam *not to hide you*.
3 Abijah set the battle out
With an army of valiant stout
Soldiers, four hundred thousand men
Chosen for fearless skill again,
Jeroboam too set array
Against him with eight hundred sway
Thousand chosen men, mighty men
Of valour *come to fight again*.
4 Abijah stood upon the mount
Zemaraim, which *is* in mount
Ephraim, and said "Hear me, you
Jeroboam, and Israel's crew,
5 "Should you not know YHWH Alohim
Of Israel gave kingdom's cream
To David for ever, to him
And to his descendants and grim
By saline promise pat and trim?
6 "Yet Jeroboam Nebat's son,
The servant of king Solomon
The son of David, once rose up,
Rebelled against his lord like tup.
7 "And there were gathered unto him
Vain men, Belial's sons in rim,
And fortified themselves rebelling
Against Rehoboam in swelling,
The son of Solomon, in days
When Rehoboam, young in ways

Was tenderhearted, and could not
Withstand them *and their evil plot*.

Appeal to history's always abuse.
Abijah gets the facts right for his use,
But turns the matter on another end.
He does not consider his father's trend
To speak harshly and bring a heavy yoke
When he was advised not to make the
stroke.
Oh no, he only says rebellion came
When his father was weak and to their
shame.
How many when appealing to the line
Of history avoid temptation's brine,
And tell it like it is or was and make
Appeal to truth for You and not man's
sake?
Beloved, my heart's oppressed to see the
way
The human mind and mouth rise up for
sway.

8 "Now you intend to oppose reign
Of YHWH in David's offsprings' wane,
And you are many on the plain,
And you have with you calves of gold
That Jeroboam made and sold
To you as gods *of the sheepfold*.
9 Have you not deposed all the priests
Of YHWH, sons of Aaron increased,
And Levites, and made yourselves priests
After the heathen way and feast,
So whoever comes to ordain
Himself with a young bullock slain
And seven rams, that one may be
A priest of anti-gods *you see*.
10 As for us, YHWH's our Alohim,
And we have not forsaken cream,
And the priests serving YHWH are sons
Of Aaron and Levites in runs.
11 And they burn to YHWH morn and
night
Burnt offerings and sweet incense right,
The showbread also on the pure
Table, and candlestick set sure
Of gold with lamps upon it burn
Every night, for we keep and earn
The charge of YHWH our Alohim,
But you've forsaken Him for dream.
12 "Now see, Alohim's with us for
Our chief, and His priests at the door

With sounding trumpets the alarm
Against you, sons of Israel's harm,
So do not rise up against YHWH
Alohim of your fathers' crew,
For you'll not succeed anyhow."

Abijah misinterpret's Israel's way
Of placing Your throne on the back to
sway
Of golden calves. They did not worship
calves,

But You who rode upon them for their
salves.

Abijah appeals to the fact the priests
Fled to Jerusalem for annual feasts,
And claims authority of church and law,
Establishment set up by hood and claw.
Beloved, I see conservative reproach,
Reliance on the power of hand and roach,
Still speaks to souls of men to make them
think

That You are leading them up to the brink.
It will not keep king Jeroboam's hand
From setting lethal traps by his command.

13 But Jeroboam set a trap
To come about behind their flap,
So they were in front of Judah,
And ambushment behind their paw.

14 And when Judah looked back, behold,
The battle *was* before and told
Behind: and they cried unto YHWH,
And priests blew on the trumpets too.

15 The men of Judah gave a shout,
And when Judah's men shouted out,
It happened that Alohim struck
Jeroboam down to the muck
And all Israel before *the face*
Of Abijah and Judah's *race*.

16 Israel's folk fled before Judah:
And Alohim set in their claw.

17 Abijah and his people killed
Them with a great slaughter and swilled,
So there fell down dead of Israel
Five hundred thousand choice men's spell.

18 So Israel's folk came to their knees
That time, and Judah's folk with ease
Prevailed, because they relied on
YHWH Alohim of fathers' spawn.

It was not history of David's line,
It was not the established church and fine

That saved Judah from Jeroboam's face.
It was the last cry begging for Your grace.
The folk of Judah trusted then and there
In You and so You blessed them with the
share

Of Your salvation, though out-numbered
and
Surrounded by the armies of the manned.
Beloved, though I reject establishment
And have no history of the blessed and
sent,

I too cry out before the hostile world
That raises its rebellious flag unfurled
Against Your divine law, and wait to see
With what hand You reverse captivity.

19 Abijah pursued Jeroboam,
And took cities from him to know him,
Bethel with its suburbs around,
And Jeshanah with suburbs found,
And Ephraim and all its ground.

20 So Jeroboam did not find
His strength again but he declined
In the time of Abijah, and
YHWH struck him dead *under His hand*.

21 Abijah became stronger yet,
And married fourteen wives, you bet,
And sired he twenty-two sons and
Sixteen daughters, *children in band*.

22 The rest of Abijah's acts, and
His ways, and his sayings *in hand*,
Are written in the story show
Of the man and prophet Iddo.

The fourteen ones infallible mayhap
Were sitting there in king Abijah's lap.
A wife for every fortnight's day and night
Should be enough to treat to princely right.
At least it cut the average of births down
That each wife had to bear for her renown
To less than three apiece, and that might be
Better than one wife in her misery
Giving birth to thirty-eight in one spree.
Beloved, the number of wives in the care
Of Abijah still seems more than his share.
If he had only followed Jacob's track
Four would have sufficed without any lack.
But then he might not have sons and to
spare.

2 Chronicles 14

1 Abijah slept with his ancestors,

And they buried him in sequesters
 Of David's city, and Asa
 His son reigned in his place for awe.
 In his time the land was at peace
 For ten years of his reign's increase.
 2 Asa did what was good and right
 Before YHWH his Alohim's sight.
 3 He took away the altars of
 Idols, and the high places of
 Them and cut down the groves *of love*.
 4 He commanded Judah to seek
 YHWH Alohim of their dads' peak,
 And do the law and commandment.
 5 Also he took away the scent
 Of high place and idol in all
 The cities of Judah in thrall,
 His kingdom was in peace in stall.
 6 He built fortified towns in Judah:
 For the land had peace, and no ruder
 War in those years, because YHWH had
 Given him rest *not to be sad*.
 7 Therefore he said to Judah, "Let
 Us build these cities, and then set
 Around them walls, and towers, and gates
 And bars to lock, the land's in state
 Before us, since we have sought YHWH
 Our Alohim, and it is true
 That we have sought, and He has granted
 Rest to us everywhere we've planted
 And built and prospered *in our crew*."

Good king Asa followed Your word and
 law
 And struck down all the idols with his paw.
 Good king Asa kept well the Sabbath day,
 And gave justice the right and throne and
 sway.
 And if good king Asa at any time
 Took up a pen to say himself in rhyme,
 He touched the parchment with a word of
 praise,
 And did not let You depart from his gaze.
 Though good king Asa trusted well in You,
 He still built fortresses for all his crew.
 He still used time of peace for preparation
 Of warfare with an enemy and nation.
 Not only was he faithful, he was wise,
 Was good king Asa under the blue skies.

8 And Asa had an army that
 Carried targets and spears thereat,
 From Judah three hundred thousand,

And out of Benjamin, that stand
 With shields and drawn bows, two hundred
 And eighty thousand: all these dread
 Men of valour *all in a band*.
 9 There came out against them Zerah
 The Ethiopian in draw
 An army of a million men,
 And three hundred chariots again,
 And they arrived in Mareshah.
 10 Then Asa went out to attack
 And stood in array back to back
 In the valley of Zephathah
As you come up to Mareshah.
 11 And Asa cried singing to YHWH
 His Alohim, and he said "YHWH,
 An easy thing it is for You
 To help, whether with a great crew
 Or with a weakened band in pew,
 Help us, O YHWH our Alohim,
 For we depend on You in team,
 And in Your name we do attack
 This great crowd. O YHWH, You're not
 slack

To be our Alohim, let not
 Man come to overrun Your plot."
 12 So YHWH struck Ethiopians
 Before Asa, and before plans
 Of Judah; the Ethiopians fled.
 13 Asa and the folk with him sped
 After them to Gerar, and there
 The Ethiopians took share
 In their destruction, they could not
 Recover themselves in the spot,
 For they were destroyed before YHWH,
 And before His army and crew,
 Who carried off blunder as due.
 14 And they attacked all the towns round
 Gerar, because the fear and sound
 Of YHWH came on them, and they sacked
 All the cities they had attacked
 For there was booty in them stacked.
 15 They struck also the tents of cattle,
 And carried away sheep from battle,
 And camels in abundance, and
 Went back to Jerusalem's strand.

The Ethiopian came out to fight.
 I thought they were drawn in the faith and
 right
 By Solomon, and by Solomon's son
 Were under a king righteous on the run.
 After the Queen of Sheba's visit to

The wisest man of all, did she not do
 A thing to make the southern nation know
 That You alone rule in the heavens' glow?
 Then why is Ethiopia now set
 To battle with anointed and to get
 A fight for treasure on king Asa's land?
 I'd think the memory of Sheban band
 Could find and echo in the faithful heart
 Not to stand up and throw a fatal dart.

2 Chronicles 15

1 The Spirit of Alohim came
 On Azariah son *in fame*
 Of Oded. 2 And he went to meet
 Asa, and said to him *in bleat*,
 "Hear me, Asa, and all Judah
 And Benjamin; YHWH's with your *paw*
 As long as you are on His side,
 And if you search Him out, he'll bide,
 But if you forsake Him He will
 Forsake you also *to the swill*.
 3 "Now for a long time Israel
Has been without true Alohim,
 And without a priest teaching well,
 And without the law it would seem.
 4 "But when they in their trouble turned
 To YHWH Israel's Alohim spurned,
 And sought Him, He was found by them.
 5 "And in those times *there was* no peace
 To him that went out, nor release
 To him who came in, but the stem
 Of great vexations on all dwellers
 Of every land, *buyers and sellers*.
 6 "And nation was destroyed by nation,
 And city by city in station:
 For Alohim vexed them to death.
 7 "So be strong, and don't let your breath
 Be weak in your hands, for your labour
 Shall be rewarded *before neighbour*."

Even good kings need sometimes to
 declare
 Their faith in prophets come to them to
 bear
 A message of reform. Though heart may be
 Perfect to You, the land is filled with scree.
 There's always idol worship on the hill
 If one just looks about the things that spill.
 But prophets do not gloat on history,
 Nor do they flatter temple spires to see,
 But show that success in faith is to call
 On You alone, Beloved, whether in hall

Of king or in the humble stable door.
 The true faith's not the building and the
 store,
 But waiting now upon the One who shows
 That You alone open the gate and close.

8 And when Asa heard these words, and
 The prophecy at Oded's hand,
 The prophet, he took courage, and
 Cast out abominations' band
 From all the land of Judah and
 Benjamin, and out of the towns
 That he'd taken from Ephraim's downs,
 And renovated YHWH's altar
 That *was* before YHWH's porch and star.
 9 And he gathered all Judah and
 Benjamin, and strangers in band
 With them out of Ephraim and
 Manasseh, and from Simeon:
 For they fell to him by the ton
 From Israel, when they saw that
 YHWH his Alohim kept him fat.
 10 So they gathered themselves together
 At Jerusalem *in the weather*
Of the third month, in fifteenth year
 Since reign of Asa *did appear*.
 11 They offered to YHWH the same time,
 Some of the spoil they'd brought in dime,
 Seven hundred oxen to keep
 As well as seven thousand sheep.
 12 And they joined in a pact to seek
 YHWH Alohim of their dads' cheek
 With all their heart and all their soul,
 13 So anyone who would not seek
 YHWH Israel's Alohim for toll
 Should be killed, whether small or great,
 Whether man or woman in state.
 14 And they swore to YHWH with a loud
 Voice, and with shouting, and with cloud
 Of trumpets, and with cornets' *grate*.

Religious freedom's not a value lent
 To Asa's folk, instead they came and spent
 Their thousands to renew the covenant
 And slay any who opposed with a sign
 Of reason that Baal was the one in line
 Who made the rain to rise up from the sea
 By the warmth of the sun in canopy.
 So rage of the religion came to stand
 Against the scientific thought and planned,
 And set the precedent that aftertimes
 Saw Galileo threatened by the rhymes

Of flame in persecution for his moon
Shadows instead of sun-god wakened soon.
Religious freedom is never a boon.

15 And all Judah rejoiced to know
The oath, since they had sworn to show
With all their heart, and sought Him by
Their whole desire; and *with a cry*
They found Him, and YHWH gave them
rest

All round about *and at His best.*

16 Also *concerning* Maachah mum
Of King Asa, he threw her bum
Out from being queen, since she'd made
An idol in a grove and glade:
And Asa cut her idol down,
And trampled it about the town,
And burnt *it* at the brook Kidron.

17 But the high places were not taken
Away from Israel and forsaken:
But still Asa's heart perfect stays
Always and throughout all his days.

18 And he brought in Alohim's house
The things his father had in blouse
As holy, silver, gold and pots
All set out in their rows and lots.

19 And there was no *more* war until
The thirty-fifth year of the mill
Of Asa's reign *on Zion's hill.*

Was not one of Your own commandments
given
That mom and dad be ever loved and
shriven?

Yet here Asa comes out and comes fair
driven
To disrespect his mother's faith and pile.
I'll have to ponder that stake for a while.
He deposed his own mother from the
throne,

And cut her god down and left her alone.
Perhaps You think he showed respect in
not

Cutting her neck off at her beauty-spot.
Be so or not, I follow in the wake
Of Asa and strike down the gods I make
Myself or any others in my way
Until the police catch my roundelay.
I take a barren shore twixt hill and lake.

2 Chronicles 16

1 In the thirty-sixth year of reign

Of Asa Baasha king *in strain*
Of Israel came to attack
Judah and built Ramah *in back*
So as not to let anyone
Go out or come in *with a gun*
To Asa king of Judah's *dun.*
2 So Asa brought out silver, gold
From YHWH's treasure house to be sold
From the king's house and sent and told
To Benhadad, Syria's king,
Who lived in Damascus, saying,
3 "*There is a treaty between me*
And you, as there was in the spree
Of my dad and your dad, and see
I have sent you silver and gold,
So go, break your treaty of old
With Baasha king of Israel,
So he may give me peace a spell."
4 And Benhadad obeyed the king
Asa, and sent the chiefs *in ring*
Of his armies against the towns
Of Israel; and they *like clowns*
Attacked Ijon, Dan, Abelmaim,
And all the store cities *in name*
Of Naphtali *and without shame.*
5 It happened when Baasha heard that,
He quit building Ramah out flat,
And let his labour end in splat.
6 Then Asa the king took all Judah
And carried away the stones cruder
From Ramah, and the timber too
With which Baasha builded in crew,
And with them he built Geba too
As well as Mizpah *beneath dew.*

When Asa was too young to know the life
Of worldly wise, before he took a wife,
He opted to trust You, Beloved, and so
You blessed him when he'd come and
when he'd go.

When Asa was an older man he found
It wise to cash in on accounts and sound
That wealth and his experience revealed
As how a man in his position steeled.
Beloved, though I am old, keep my heart
young
To lust after the words come from Your
tongue,

To trust in You alone and leave the rest
To find their way in palaces as guest
Or in the market, in the narrow town

Till You in Your grace to me once come
down.

7 At that time Hanani the seer
Came to Asa king to appear
In Judah, and said to him, “Since
You depended on Syrian quince
And not on YHWH your Alohim,
Therefore the army of the king
Of Syria escapes your wing.
8 “Were not the Ethiopians and
The Lubim a huge army band,
With very many chariots and
Horsemen? Yet, because you relied
On YHWH, He saved you from their side.
9 “For the eyes of YHWH run about
The whole world to show Himself stout
In their behalf whose heart is right
Perfect toward Him in His sight.
In this you did a foolish thing,
Therefore from now on you will spring
From war to war *in wandering.*”
10 Asa was angry with the seer,
And put him in a prison gear,
For rage against him and for this.
And Asa crushed some people too
At the same time *he came in view.*
11 And see, the acts of Asa, first
And last, indeed *are they as durst*
Written in the book of the kings
Of Judah and Israel *as brings.*
12 And Asa in year thirty-nine
Of his reign was weak in his line
Of feet, until his sickness sore,
Yet in his sickness and his store
He did not turn to YHWH, instead
He went to the doctors *for bread.*
13 And Asa slept dead with his dads,
And died in his bed on his pads
In year forty-one of his reign.
14 They buried him in his own tomb
That he’d made for himself for room
In David’s city, and lay down
In bed filled with sweet smells’ renown
And varied spices made by art
Of the perfumer and to start
They made a burning great *and strong*
For his honour and all along.

I still suspect physicians can do well,
Although it may have been a different spell
In Asa’s day. And yet I find my way

In that each time the doctor comes to stay
With few exceptions I just get to pay
With no relief for pains or illness spent.
Avoid like plague the doctor and find
health
And lesser drain upon the pocket’s wealth.
Beloved, while taking antibiotics
That were given by the physician’s tricks,
I still turn back to You who heal and strike
The human heart with everything You like.
Beloved, Asa was unwise at the fall,
But let me be wiser and miss the call.

2 Chronicles 17

1 Jehoshaphat his son instead
Reigned, and established himself bred
Against Israel. 2 And he placed arms
In all fortified towns’ alarms
Of Judah, and set garrisons
In Judah’s land for benisons,
And in the towns of Ephraim,
Which his dad Asa’d taken *grim.*
3 And YHWH was with Jehoshaphat,
Because he acted *plutocrat*
After the manner of his dad
David, not seeking Baalim *bad.*
4 For to his father’s Alohim
He did according to *the scheme*
Of His commandments and not after
The acts of Israel *in rafter.*
5 That’s why YHWH set his kingdom up
In his strength, and each Judah’s tup
Brought presents to Jehoshaphat
And he had wealth *upon his mat*
And honour *and glory out flat.*
6 His heart was lifted up in ways
Of YHWH, and he removed the praise
Of the high places and the groves
From Judah *in both hills and coves.*

The heart of dear Jehoshaphat was raised
To You above, Beloved, and so he praised
Your name in all he did and all he saw.
He lived a daily life of prayer and awe.
He tore down from the hills of holy site
The idols’ high places and groves where
might
The people dance and prance in heathen
joy
To find the sun to rise and to employ
Its beams in making rain to Baal’s consent.
He ploughed down pseudo-scientific vent.

Beloved, as I sit king in my own plot,
Let me pluck up the idols that I've got
And praise Your name in quiet acts and
true
Until I find the blessed vision of You.

7 Also in third year of his reign
He sent to his princes in vein
To Benhail, and to Obadiah,
And also unto Zechariah,
And to Nethaneel, and Michaiah,
To teach in Judah's towns *and nigh her*.
8 And with them Levites, *as* Shemaiah,
And Nethaniah, Zebadiah,
And Asahel, Shemiramoth,
And Jehonathan, and in troth
One Adonijah, and Tobijah,
And also one Tobadonijah,
Levites, and with them Elishama
And Jehoram, priests *to be gamer*.
9 And they taught in Judah, and *had*
The book of YHWH's law in their pad,
And went around through all the towns
Of Judah, and taught folk *in gowns*.
10 The fear of YHWH fell upon all
The kingdoms of the lands *in thrall*
That *were* around Judah, so that
They battled not Jehoshaphat.
11 Also *some* of the Philistines
Brought to Jehoshaphat on tines
Tribute in silver, and Arabs
Brought flocks to him and as with stabs
Seven thousand seven hundred rams,
Seven thousand seven hundred goats'
hams.
12 Jehoshaphat waxed great and tall,
And he built palaces withal
In Judah and cities of store.

The greatest treasure of the king I see
Is not the tribute and the gifts in fee,
Is not the great cities, is not their store,
Is not the fortress of impeding door,
But rather is the book, the lovely book
The Levites taught the people where to
look,
And above all the book itself that awe
That rose in every heart to hear the law.
I too, Beloved, take on that treasure here
In my own inner chamber when I hear
The springing words gush up before my
ear,

And find the ten commandments became
dear.

In all I do I pray my hand may find
The promises of Your law on my mind.

13 And he had business what is more
In Judah's cities: men of war,
Great men of courage in the town
Jerusalem *when he came down*.
14 These *are* the numbers of the men
According to the house and glen
Of their ancestors: Judah's count,
The chiefs of thousands in amount,
Adnah the first, and with him men
Of might and courage come again
To three hundred thousand *in pen*.
15 And next to him Jehohanan
The captain, and with him in hand
Two hundred and eighty thousand.
16 And next to him *was* Amasiah
The son of Zichri, who was higher
To offer himself unto YHWH,
And with him also there were two
Hundred thousand great men in crew.
17 And of Benjamin: Eliada
A man of great courage in awe,
And with him men armed with the bow
And shield two hundred thousand go.
18 And next to him Jehozabad,
And with him a hundred in scad
And eighty thousand ready for
The preparation of the war.
19 These stood before the king besides
Those which the king set *with their brides*
In towns throughout all Judah's *rides*.

Though my name is not Amasiah I
Am son of Zichri too upon the fly.
A son of Your remembrance, so I make
A membrance of Your name and for Your
sake.

I open up the Four Books and I stroke
The sweet words and the solemn like an
oak,
The words of warning and the words of
blame,

Anon I hang my head for utter shame,
Anon I weep to find my name is writ
Among transgressors for the place I sit,
Anon I raise my hope and voice of joy
To see the spires of David and employ
My quaver in the cantillation's sound

That tinkles out upon the barren ground.

2 Chronicles 18

1 Jehoshaphat had wealth and glitter
And joined Ahab through marriage *bitter*.

2 At end of years he went down to
Ahab in Samarian view.

And Ahab killed sheep, oxen too
For him in abundance and view,
And for the folk he had in crew,
And talked him into going up
To Ramothgilead to sup.

3 And Ahab king of Israel
Said to Jehoshaphat king swell
Of Judah, "Will you go with me
To Ramothgilead on spree?"

He answered him, "You and I see
Are one as are our people free,
And with you in the fight's degree."

4 Jehoshaphat said to the king
Of Israel, "Enquire a thing,
Please, at the word of YHWH today."

5 So Israel's king summoned to play
Four hundred prophets *gone astray*,
And asked them, "Shall we go to war
In Ramothgilead's land or
Shall I hold back?" And they said "Go
Up, for Alohims come to show
The victory at the king's blow."

6 Jehoshaphat said, "*Is there* not
A prophet of YHWH yet unsought,
That we may ask of him the plot?"

7 The king of Israel said to
Jehoshaphat, "*There's* still one gnu
By whom we may enquire of YHWH,
But I hate him, because he's not
Prophesied good to me a lot,
But always evil, and his name
Is Micaiah, Imla's son's fame."
Jehoshaphat said "Let not speak
The king suspiciously *this week*."

The concept of prophecy was the thing
That made Ahab unhappy as a king.
Today we think of prophecy as such
That will predict the future with a touch.
But then the prophets all spoke out their
spell

To mark the future fate of Israel.
So any who spoke out against the word
Were held as traitors to the wicked spurred.
Beloved, I cast my spell upon my heart

And prophesy in hope my future part
To be the loving living sacrifice
That stands before Your throne, though
none suffice
To praise Your name, Creator of all things
Found in this universe of wanderings.

8 The king of Israel summoned then
One of his officers and men
And said "Bring quickly down again
Micaiah son of Imla's *den*."

9 The king of Israel and king
Jehoshaphat of Judah's wing
Sat each upon his throne and dressed
In *royal* robes by the compressed
Gate of Samaria, and all
The prophets prophesied on call.

10 And Zedekiah who was son
Of Chenaanah had made to stun
Him horns of iron, and had begun
To say "So says YHWH, 'With these you
Will push on Syria in view
Until you consume all their crew.'"

11 And all the prophets prophesied
In the same way, saying *in pride*,
"Go up to Ramothgilead,
And succeed, for YHWH is not sad
To set it in the king's hand *clad*."
12 The messenger that went to call
Micaiah spoke to him as tall,
Saying "See all the prophets' words
Are in favour of the king's curds,
Let your words be like one of theirs
And speak good *of the king's affairs*."

13 And Micaiah said "*As* YHWH lives
Even what my Alohims gives
I'll speak, *whatever the king cares*."
14 And when he came before the king,
The king said to him *questioning*,
"Micaiah, shall we go to battle
Against Ramothgilead's cattle,
Or shall I yield?" And he said "Go
Up, and succeed, and they shall know
The heaviness your hand can show."

The iron horns in prophecy reach back
To incantations magical in stack,
And reinforce the power the word should
hold

Upon the royal army to be bold.
The iron horns were but a foolish ploy
To Your true prophet who came to enjoy

A cynical and rude word to the king,
And thought it funnier than anything.
Beloved, I joke and ridicule the great
Idols I see about me in the state
And in the industry that rose of late,
And in the wealth and fashion in their
grate.

I tell them to buy more and then get fat
Upon the gym floor and exercise mat.

15 The king told him, "How many times
Must I tell you not to speak rhymes
But only the truth in my ear
In the name of YHWH *for all fear?*

16 Then he said, "I saw Israel
All scattered on mountain and fell
Like sheep without a shepherd's spell,
And YHWH said 'These have no chief
here,

Let each return to his career."

17 The king of Israel said to
Jehoshaphat, "Did I tell you
He would not prophesy the good
To me but evil *in the wood?*"

18 Again he said "Therefore hear now
The word of YHWH *upon your brow.*
I saw YHWH sitting on his throne,
And all the host of heaven alone
On His right hand and *on* His left.

19 "And YHWH said 'What man shall be
deft

Seducing Ahab Israel's king,
So he may go and have a fling
At Ramothgilead?' And one
Said one announcement as in fun,
Another made a different pun.

20 "Then came a spirit out and stood
Before YHWH, and he said 'I could
Seduce him.' And YHWH said to him,
'How will you do it and be trim?'

21 "And he said 'I will go and be
A lying spirit on the fee
Of all his prophets.' So He said
'You shall seduce him, be well-sped.'

22 "So see, YHWH's put a lying ghost
In the mouth of the prophet host,
And YHWH's spoken against your boast."

If You do not (a thing I doubt) have any
Sense of humour, Your prophet's worth a
penny

On that score. Let me rest my heaving
sides

And wipe the flowing tears as he derides
The many prophets of establishment.
Who stands alone jokes in the royal tent.
A lying spirit, to be true, I throw
That lying angels are here anyhow
To tell the bishop and the president
Lies for their policies in what they've
spent.

Beloved, send out Your lying spirit now
And stir the people with a loyal row,
And I shall laugh as prophet at Your word
Or then go down to gaol for what occurred.

23 Then Zedekiah who was son
Of Chenaanah came near to stun
Micaiah on the cheek, and said
"Which way did YHWH's spirit once fled
From me go to wake you instead?"

24 Micaiah said "See now, you'll know
Upon the day when you shall go
Into a closet to be hidden."

25 Then the king of Israel unbidden
Said "Take Micaiah, carry him
Back to Amon who's the judge grim
Of the city, and to Joash

The king's son, and keep him in stash.
26 "And say 'So says the king, "Put this
Guy in the prison not to miss
Bread of affliction and the kiss
Of bitter water till I come

In peace and having battles won."'''

27 Micaiah said "If you return
In peace, then YHWH's not made me
learn."

And he said "Folks, note well my turn."

See there, Beloved, if any man make dare
To speak the truth before the king, beware,
He'll soon be thrown out on his fear and
wear

The stripped prison garb and breath its air.
See there, Beloved, what did I tell You
when

You thought I should speak up to mortal
men?

I speak indeed, and wait the fatal thrust
To put an end to everything I trust.

I take heart nonetheless in Ahab's call
To battle and to death in royal hall.

And yet I tell You this, when You have one

King slain, another wicked one in ton
Rises to take his place. So prison shun.
There's always some fat calf hid in the
stall.

28 Israel's king and Jehoshaphat
King of Judah went up *for spat*
To Ramothgilead *in hat*.

29 The king of Israel then told
Jehoshaphat, "I'll not be bold
Disguising myself, but will go
Into the battle without show.
But you, put on your royal tow."
So Israel's king disguised himself,
And went to battle *like an elf*.

30 The king of Syria commanded
The chiefs of chariots that landed
With him, and said "Now do not fight
With small or great upon the site,
But only with king Israelite."

31 It happened when the captains of
The chariots saw as above
Jehoshaphat, they said for love,
"That's Israel's king." And so they went
Around him for the fight as sent,
Jehoshaphat shouted aloud,
And YHWH helped him out of the crowd
And Alohim moved them *in cloud*.

32 It happened when the captains of
The chariots noticed the glove
Was not the king of Israel,
They turned back from the fight as well.

33 But a man drew a bow by chance,
And struck the king of Israel's glance
Between the armour and breastplate,
So he told chariot-driver mate,
"Turn aside to carry me out
Of the army, I'm wounded stout."

34 The battle then increased that day,
But Israel's king just had to stay
Up in his chariot from the fray
Against the Syrians till the day
Was ended, and as sun went down
He died *and so he lost the crown*.

The shout of king Jehoshaphat to You
Resulted in Your saving him from crew
Of Syrian. But Ahab to his fate
Was true despite disguising of the mate.
I do not say Your word is fateful and
Not to be avoided by any hand,
But I say that Ahab, forgetting all

The faith he should have had in You to call
Worked out his own destruction by the way
He rushed in disobedience to play.
Jehoshaphat was safe despite his going
To battles futile because of his knowing
Your prophet's word would bless him with
a shout
When enemies would compass him about.

2 Chronicles 19

1 Jehoshaphat king of Judah
Went back to his house in the raw
To rest in fair Jerusalem.
2 And Jehu son of Hanani
The seer went out to meet his hem,
And said to king Jehoshaphat,
"Should you help the ungodly rat,
And love those who hate YHWH thereby?
That's why anger upon you came
From before YHWH, *so be in shame*.
3 "But there are good things found in you,
Since you took out the groves from view
Upon the land, and yet prepared
Your heart to seek Alohim *bared*."

4 Jehoshaphat stayed in the town
Jerusalem, and then went down
Again through the folk from the crown
Beersheba to Mount Ephraim,
And brought them to YHWH Alohim
Of their ancestors *then in dream*.

5 And he set judges in the land
Through all the fortified towns' band
Of Judah, town by town *to stand*.

6 And told the judges, "Take care what
You do, because you are not shut
To judge for man, but YHWH instead,
Who is with you in judgement led.

7 "Wherefore now let the fear of YHWH
Be on you, be careful to do,
For no iniquity with YHWH
Our Alohim, nor does He take
Into consideration stake
Of who is who, nor receive bribes
From anyone among the tribes."

It was presumptuous of the king to go
And help the godless put on faithless show.
Despite the flattery that Ahab laid
On young Jehoshaphat he should have paid
Better attention to the prophet's warning.
So divine threatening met him on the
morning.

Jehoshaphat met chiding with the head
Bent and his lips in silence told his dread.
He made atonement for the thing when he
Warned all his judges that they judged in
fee

Of You alone, and so to do the right.
So king Jehoshaphat did with his might
To fix the errors of his youthful heart.
Beloved, let me also do all my part.

8 Moreover in Jerusalem
Jehoshaphat set up *the hem*
Of the Levites, and of the priests,
And of the chief of fathers' *feasts*
Of Israel, for YHWH's judgment,
And controversies, when they went
Back to Jerusalem *unspent*.
9 And he commanded them, and said
"So shall you do in fear instead
Of YHWH, in faithfulness your part
And with a perfect, *loving* heart.
10 "And whatever issue shall rise
To you from your brothers in guise
Who live in their cities, among
Blood kin as touching law and sung
Commandment, statute and judgement,
You shall warn them not to consent
In wickedness done against YHWH
So that His anger fall on you
And on your brothers, and so do
And you shall not trespass the due.
11 "And see, Amariah the chief
Priest *is* over you in relief
Of all matters of YHWH, and yet
Zebadiah the son well-met
Of Ishmael, the ruler of
The house of Judah, for the love
Of all the king's matters: also
The Levites *shall be* chiefs to go
Before you. Take courage and show,
And YHWH shall be with the good *row*."

The faithful and the true in Your own tent
Need those to solve their conflicts when
they're spent.

It is a lovely thought that there might be
No conflicts at all in the Holy See,
And yet the best of men are quick to fall
Into a quarrel as soon as in stall.
Even a gelding has a nasty bite
If he thinks people's manner is to slight.
Beloved, I do not hang my head in shame

That I too need the Levite in the game
And the high priest to give him some
advice
On how to deal with me and my foe's dice.
It's just the way that You once stopped to
make
Human kind fearfully, wonderfully drake.

2 Chronicles 20

1 It happened after this also,
The children of Moab below,
The children of Ammon, as well
As those beside Ammonites dwell,
Came to attack Jehoshaphat.
2 Then came and told Jehoshaphat
Some saying "There comes a great mat
Of people against you beyond
The sea this side of Syrian pond,
And see, they're in Hazazontamar,
Which *is* Engedi *for inflamer*."
3 Jehoshaphat then was afraid,
And made himself seek YHWH and
prayed,
Proclaimed a fast through all Judah.
4 And Judah gathered in the raw
Petitioning YHWH from the straw
Of all the cities of Judah,
They came seeking YHWH *all with awe*.

With prayer and fasting king Jehoshaphat
Meets the crisis of this or even that.
The coming of the Ammonitic crew,
And Moabites who joined them in the pew,
Was frightening no doubt to one and each,
And feathered out fear as far as could
reach.

With prayer and fasting that good king of
old
Gave precedent to what was later told
To be the righteous way in the Qur'an,
Where prayer and fasting make up half the
plan.

Beloved, I pray to You prostrating where
The thousands of feet every day with care
Surround Your house, and on the month
that's true,
I've also fasted in my praise to You.

5 Jehoshaphat stood in assembly
Of Judah's Jerusalem, trembly
In YHWH's house, before the new court,
6 And said, "YHWH Alohim report

Of our ancestors, are You not
 Huu Alohim of heavenly spot?
 And do You not rule over all
 The kingdoms of the heathen thrall?
 And in Your hand is power and might,
 So none can withstand You in sight?
 7 “Are You not our Alohim wight,
 Who drove out the inhabitants
 Of this land before all Your grants
 To Israel’s folk, and gave it to
 The descendants of Your friend true
 Abraham for all time *and due*?
 8 “And they lived there and built for You
 A sanctuary where Your name
 Stands ever *and always in fame*,
 Saying 9 “‘If, evil on us falling,
 The sword, judgement or plague *for*
calling,
 Or famine, we stand by this place
 And in Your presence, by Your face,
 For Your name appears in this space,
 And beg you in affliction’s *trace*,
 Then You will hear and help *this race*.’
 10 “And now, see Ammon’s children and
 Moab and Mount Seir in band,
 Whom You’d not let Israel lay hand
 Upon them, when they came to stand
 From Egypt, but they then turned back
 And did not come to their attack,
 11 “See now how they give our reward
 To come and throw us out *with sword*
 From Your possession that You gave
 To us to keep *with mace and glaive*.
 12 “O our Alohim, will You not
 Judge them? For we’ve no power in plot
 Against this great band that have sought
 To come attacking us, nor do
 We know what plan to take, but still
 Our eyes are on You *and Your skill*.”

The ancient prayers of Judah, Israel,
 Are often made in lists as though in spell
 Of how You once in past days dropped the
 foe
 Surprised in his defeat though fast or slow.
 And so Jehoshaphat now prayers to You
 And hopes that You’ll once more know
 what to do.
 The trust that he expresses in his prayer
 Is penetrating and inspires to share.
 Beloved, I live among the enemy

Who claim to serve You, though they serve
 the tree
 Of execution and ignore Your law.
 I trust You to deliver from their claw.
 The Exodus is not the only time
 Your hand was raised above evil and
 clime.

13 And all Judah stood before YHWH,
 And with their little ones there too,
 Their wives, and their children *in crew*.
 14 Then on Jahaziel the son
 Of Zechariah, who’s the son
 Of Benaiah, the son of Jeiel,
 The son of Mattaniah’s trail,
 A Levite of Asaph’s sons, came
 The Spirit of YHWH in the fame
 Of the assembly *without shame*.
 15 And he said, “Listen, Judah all,
 And who fill Jerusalem’s hall,
 And you, O king Jehoshaphat,
 So says YHWH to you, ‘Don’t be flat
 With fear nor dismayed by this great
 Crowd of armed men, because the fate
 Of battle is not yours but that
 Of Alohim, *who’s got it pat*.
 16 ‘Tomorrow go down to attack
 Them, see, they come up by the slack
 Cliff of Ziz, and you’ll find there where
 The book ends before desert bare
 Of Jeruel. 17 You shall not fight
 This, *but* stand in array,
 And be still to see the display
 Of YHWH’s salvation on your day,
 O Judah and Jerusalem,
 Do not be afraid, in dismay,’
 Tomorrow go and attack them,
 For YHWH will help you all the way.”

I wait a prophet with an angel’s word
 To tell me to go out and undeterred
 Fight those who draw up to attack the way
 That I would live according to the day
 And light I find in Decalogue preferred.
 I wait a prophet with a hand filled to
 The overflowing with armaments true
 To strike down the false argument with
 power
 That would disdain my coming at this hour
 To stand in faithfulness here before You.
 Beloved, the army of the king that time

Had mandate from Your hand, it was no
crime
To kill the enemy. Now that Your voice
Is silent, does any man have a choice?

18 Jehoshaphat bowed down his head
With *his* face to the ground outspread:
And all Judah and those who dwelt
Within Jerusalem heart-felt
Fell before YHWH and worshipped
YHWH.

19 And the Levites, children and true
Of Kohathites, and of the sons
Of the Korhites, stood up in tons
To praise YHWH Israel's Alohim
With a loud voice on high *and beam*.
20 So they rose early in the morn
And went out in the desert's scorn
Call Tekoa, and as they went,
Jehoshaphat stood and word lent,
"Hear me, O Judah and you who
Dwell in Jerusalem, *full crew*:
Believe in YHWH your God, and you
Shall be established, and believe
His prophets, and you shall receive
Prosperity." 21 And when he'd made
Agreement with the folk obeyed,
He set up who should sing to YHWH,
And who should praise the beauty due
His holiness, as they went out
Before the army with a shout,
"Praise YHWH, for His mercy's always."

I take the military action here
As normative, even in face of fear.
The people all fell on their faces and
Prayed in prostration in a holy band,
And then they went out led by prophets
who
Were cantillating Scripture in a crew.
When I see armies prostrating upon
The desert sand and blowing on the dawn,
And then rising to cantillate with voice
The lovely Scriptures beautiful and choice,
Then I know I have joined an army just,
And not one to be trampled in the dust.
Beloved, look around with heart
courageous
And see that all armies now are
outrageous.

22 When they began to sing and to praise,

YHWH set ambushes in the ways
Of the people of Ammon, and
Of Moab, and Mount Seir's land,
Who had come against Judah, and
They were defeated *at their hand*.
23 The people of Ammon, Moab
Stood up against dwellers not drab
Of Mount Seir, completely to kill
And destroy, and when to their fill
They finished with dwellers of Seir,
They killed each other in their fear.
24 When Judah came near the watch tower
In the desert, and looked for power
At the crowd, see, they were all dead
Corpses upon the ground instead,
And none escaped *that slaughter dread*.
25 And when Jehoshaphat with folk
Can to take out the spoils in poke,
They found a lot of wealth and jewels
With the dead bodies of the fools,
Which they stripped off to keep but there
Was more than they could even bear
Away and so it took them three
Days to collect abundant fee.

Set ambushes, Beloved, for enemy
That set themselves in traps surrounding
me.
Set ambushes, Beloved, as I raise high
The Psalms of David up into the sky
With melodies long written in their seam,
Set ambushes, Beloved and Alohim.
If You could work in days of long ago
With sword of word and sword of harp
below,
Work now once more as I recoup the loss
That evil song and dance have turned in
dross
Among those who claim to praise holy
name
Of Sovereign and Creator for a game,
And I will sing aloud once more the song
Of David Your Beloved, and sing it long.

26 On the fourth day they came together
In Berachah's valley and weather,
And there they blessed YHWH, so the
name
Of the same place was called in fame
The Valley of Berachah till
Today *and it's a blessing still*.

The year and season both begin it seems
On the fourth day, and form a feast of
dreams.

The watching of the moon was not a thing
Set up from the beginning for a spring,
But only taught the priestly round to go
In cycles just and measured for the row,
Inherited at last by Muslim rate
To find the time of fasting and the gate
Of pilgrimage to Makkah for a blessing.
The year and season do not start with
guessing

Of months added or subtracted from view.
Adamic and Enochic ways are true
To bring the troubled soul and that that's
won

Before Your throne, Beloved, before
they're done.

27 Then they went back to house and hem
Of Judah and Jerusalem,
Jehoshaphat went at the fore
Back to Jerusalem with joy;
For YHWH had made them to rejoice
Over their enemies *and voice*.
28 And they came to Jerusalem
With psalteries and harps and gem
Of trumpets to the house of YHWH.
29 And fear of Alohim then grew
On all the kingdoms and the crew
Of *those* lands, when they heard that
YHWH

Fought against Israel's enemies.
30 Jehoshaphat's land then had peace,
For his Alohim gave him rest
All around about him *for zest*.

Peace or Islam exists it seems to me
Only after the battle and the spree,
Only after prostration on the ground,
After the fasting and the trumpet sound,
After the cantillation of Your Word,
And only then are troubled hearts bestirred.
Beloved, bestir me too to peace in You,
To prayer and fasting instead of the pew
Where rock and roll speak of the sacrifice
Of divine sons that for all sins suffice.
Then I shall know that peace that passes all
Understanding upon the market mall,
And find the stillness of the mosque within
The place where righteousness overcomes
sin.

31 Jehoshaphat ruled Judah then:
Thirty and five years old he was when
He started to reign, and he reigned
Twenty and five years and he deigned
To reside in Jerusalem.

And his mother's name *for a gem*
Was Azubah the daughter of
Shilhi *a man of grace and love*.

32 He walked in the way of Asa
His father, not departing a'
To do right in the sight of YHWH,
In everything he had in view.

33 Yet the high places were not taken
Away: for as yet the folk shaken
Had not prepared their hearts unto
Alohim of their fathers due.

34 The other acts Jehoshaphat
Did, first and last, see, they are at
The book of Jehu the son of
Hanani, who's mentioned above
In book of Israel's kings *to love*.

Though the king was faithful to You alone,
The people did not follow royal throne,
But sought the high places where they
could frolic

In heathen music's dance and alcoholic.
Though the king was faithful, not every
hand

Was turned to righteousness throughout the
land.

Some found the idol's call, though dumb
and brief,

A greater siren beyond joy and grief
That summons to the temple where the art
Spoke only of You and Your sovereign
part.

Beloved, I turn the high places in score
Over and set the groves that often bore
Their heathen fruit in my ways out to show
Only faith in You, my Beloved, below.

35 And after this Jehoshaphat
King of Judah joined himself at
Ahaziah king of Israel,
Who did much evil in his spell.
36 He joined with him to make some ships
To go to Tarshish: they made the ships
In Eziongeber *without slips*.
37 Then Eliezer who was son
Of Dodavah of Mareshah

Made prophecy against the one
Jehoshaphat, saying, “Since you
Joined with Ahaziah, now YHWH
Has broken your works, and the ships
Were broken up, *despite their wish*
They could not travel to Tarshish.”

I too have built ships in my callow youth
And in my age also, to tell the truth,
And found that when I built them with
another
They always sank and left my plans to
smother.

I only find success, Beloved, when I
Come single and alone beneath the sky
To taste the sweetness of Your word and
power.

I only find success within Your hour.
I build my ship alone as Noah did
And leave the world to walk away and bid
On what it will of coal and coke and rid
Myself of every chain and binding rope.
The only thing that binds me as I grope
Is love to You, Beloved. I seek Your tower.

2 Chronicles 21

1 Jehoshaphat slept with his dads,
And he was buried in the pads
Of his ancestors in the town
Of David, *city of renown*.
2 His kinfolk Jehoshaphat’s sons,
Azariah, Jehiel’s *runs*,
And Zechariah, Azariah,
Michael, as well as Shephatiah,
All these were Jehoshaphat’s sons,
The king of Israel’s *in their tons*.
3 And their father gave them great gifts
Of silver, and of gold *in shrifts*,
And of precious things, fortified
Cities in Judah, but the tried
Kingdom he gave to Jehoram
Because he *was* the firstborn *lamb*.
4 Now when Jehoram was set up
In his dad’s kingdom *like a tup*,
He strengthened himself and he killed
All his brothers by the sword filled,
Also princes of Israel’s *cup*.
5 Jehoram was thirty-two years
Old when began his reign *of tears*,
He ruled Jerusalem eight years.
6 He walked the path of Israel’s kings,
As did the house of Ahab’s wings,

He took Ahab’s daughter as wife,
And did evil in YHWH’s sight *rife*.
7 But YHWH would not destroy the house
Of David, because of the souse
Of treaty He’d made with David,
And since He’d promised that no lid
Should snuff out the light wherein hid
David and his sons for the bid
Of all time *under nibbling mouse*.

As much as I love David’s house, I say,
That Jehoram had every cause to pay.
People and kings are not bees that they
should
Be killed by the first-born queen bee that
could.

Or else they are. You are the one Creator
Who made the mess of wicked mill and
satyr.

And yet I do not know which was the
worse,
To kill his brothers or to take for curse
To wife the daughter of Ahab in spell,
The spawn of wicked, raving Jezebel.
Beloved, I see the track of many kings
And dynasties, and all go round in rings
Of murder of the fittest and the best.
I leave to You to straighten up the rest.

8 In his days Edomites revolted,
From under the dominion *bolted*
From Judah, made themselves a king.

9 Then Jehoram went out on wing
With his chiefs, all his chariots,
And he got up, went out at night
To the attack of Edomite,
And they in turn surrounded him
And chiefs of his chariots *with vim*.

10 So Edomites revolted from
Under the hand of Judah come
Until today. The same time *too*
Libnah revolted from his due,
Because he had forsaken YHWH
His fathers’ Alohim *and true*.

11 He also made high places in
The mountains of Judah to win
The dwellers of Jerusalem
To fornication’s stratagem,
And forced Judah to *kiss his hem*.

12 A letter came from Elijah
The prophet, saying *with éclat*
To him, “Thus says YHWH God of your

Father David, 'Since you are poor
 At following your fathers' path,
 Jehoshaphat's and Asa's math,
 Kings of Judah, 13 "But you have walked
 In the way kings of Israel balked,
 And made Judah and dwellers of
 Jerusalem to whoring's *love*
 Like the whoredoms of Ahab's house,
 Killed also your brothers *like grouse*,
 Your brothers of your father's house,
 Who were better than you, *a mouse*,
 14 "See, with a great plague YHWH will
 strike
 Your people and your children like
 Your wives and all your goods in store.
 15 "And you *shalt have* great sickness
 more
 By the disease of your intestines,
 Until intestines as it destines
 Fall out because of the disease
 From day to day *and without ease*.'" "

The king may well have led the folk astray,
 But it was still so in his father's day
 That people joined the heathen dance and
 thrill
 On every high place and on every hill.
 So let the plague fall on the people there
 Who have so long joined in the pagan fair,
 And let the earth be cleansed of every way
 That tends to break Your Decalogue in
 sway.
 I pace the rocky slopes Jerusalem
 Offers beneath an azure sky and gem
 And think how many heathenish broods'
 churches
 Still deck the land even without firs,
 birches.
 The temple of my heart is passing fast,
 But wroughten temples seem to last and
 last.

16 YHWH stirred up against Jehoram
 The spirit of Philistines' *ram*
 And the Arabians nearby
 The Ethiopians' *ally*.
 17 And they came up into Judah
 And invaded it *as by law*,
 And carried away all the things
 Found in the king's house and *its wings*,
 And also his sons and his wives,
 So there was not a son contrives

To be left to him except for
 Jehoahaz, youngest son's store.
 18 After all this YHWH struck him in
 His intestines, *despite his sin*,
 With an incurable disease.
 19 It came to pass then as time flees,
 After two years his guts came out,
 That's what his sickness was about,
 So he died in severest pain.
 The people did not mourn in vain
 For him by burning as they had
 For his fathers *who were not bad*.
 20 He was thirty-two years old when
 He became king, ruled over *men*
 Eight years *in all* over the city
 Jerusalem. *It was a pity*
 He did not turn out to become
 Muhammad, *the Desired in sum*.
 Still they interred him in the city
 Of David but not in the graves
 Reserved for kings *with royal staves*.

Down to Jehoram every king that reigned
 Stepped on the throne amidst applause
 unfeigned,
 As all awaited what might come to light
 To show that he was One Desired to fight
 Oppression and idolatry and so
 Initiate completed faith. But no,
 He too passed on to rest within the tomb,
 Unmourned perhaps, and undesired till
 doom.
 So David's line continued on in hope,
 A glimmer light for some while others
 grope
 In heathen blindness till the time of glory
 When Gabriel comes to bring the final
 story.
 Beloved, how long we waited for one sent!
 How quickly we turned back soon as he
 went!

2 Chronicles 22

1 The dwellers of Jerusalem
 Made Ahaziah youngest gem
 Of his sons king and in his place,
 For the band of the men and race
 That came with the Arabians
 To the camp had killed all the bans
 Of older ones. So Ahaziah
 The son of Jehoram *pariah*
 King of Judah reigned *there to fry her*.

2 A son of forty-two years then
Was Ahaziah when again
He started to rule, and he reigned
A year in Jerusalem *gained*.

His mother's name was Ahaliah,
The daughter of Omri *to try her*.

3 He too walked in ways of the house
Of Ahab: for his mother's douse
Was to counsel him wickedness.

4 He did evil at the address
Of YHWH like the house of Ahab,
For they were his counsellors *drab*
After the death of his own dad,
And for his destruction *and bad*.

5 He acted by their advice and
Went with Jehoram of the band
Of Ahab king of Israel's sons
To attack Hazael in runs,

The king of Syria up at
Ramohtgilead where they sat,
And Syrians struck Joram down.

6 And he came back down to the town
Of Jezreel to convalesce there
Of the wounds of the battle share
At Ramah, when he fought the king
Of Syria, Hazael in string.

And Azariah Jehoram's son,
King of Judah went down when done
To see Jehoram Ahab's son
At Jezreel since he was undone.

7 And from Alohim was the end
Of Ahaziah by the bend
Of coming to Joram, for when
He had come down, he went again
Out with Jehoram to attack
Jehu, son of Nimshi, whose back
YHWH had anointed to cut off
The house of Ahab *by the scroff*.

My Rabbi friend claims that messiah is
One buttered with the special oil and fizz
That has been lost since time of Babylon
That took the kings captive before the
dawn.

And so there can be no anointed left,
The oil of the anointing's left bereft.
I tried to say the word was not so literal
As to be interpreted as so bitter.
Jehu was a messiah to attack
The house of Ahab with a cutting rack.
Inspection of the chronicles of kings
Shows that he too was anointed in springs.

If there is no messiah left to come,
Then I return to Decalogue as bum.

8 It happened when Jehu took up
Judgement on Ahab's house and tup,
He found the chiefs of Judah there,
Ahaziah's sons' brothers' share,
Serving Ahaziah, so he
Killed all them too *and faithfully*.

9 And he sought Ahaziah: and
They caught him where he hid in land
Of Samaria, and brought him
To Jehu, and when they'd killed him
They buried him, "Because," said they,
"He is Jehoshaphat's son gay
Who sought YHWH with all his heart's
way."

So Ahaziah's house did not
Have strength to keep in peace its lot.

10 When Athaliah the mother
Of Ahaziah saw that her
Son was dead, she got up and killed
All the royal folk there that filled
The house of Judah, *those she killed*.

11 Jehoshabeath, daughter of king,
She took Ahaziah's sonling,
Joash away from among those
Sons of the king that were destroyed,
And hid him in a room employed
With his nurse. Jehoshabeath
The daughter of the king *in path*,
Jehoram, wife of Jehoiada
The priest, for she it was stayed a
Sister of Ahaziah, she
Hid him from Athaliah's *spree*,
So she did not kill him *or see*.

12 And he was with them hid within
The house of God six years in bin:
And Athaliah ruled *in sin*.

How many people know, Beloved, the
name
Jehoshabeath and what she for fame
Did or even what that blessed name may
mean?

Other heroes crowd her right off the scene.
Jehoshabeath, sworn of YHWH, came out
To save a child from the queen and her
clout.

She hid the baby in a room to keep
There quietly with his nurse and to sleep
While slaughter went apace in palace room

And all the royal house there met its doom.
 So may Jehoshabeath's name remain
 A joy and comfort in this world insane
 For slaughter, that the hidden may look up
 And find behind the mirrors golden cup.

2 Chronicles 23

1 In seventh year Jehoiada
 Strengthened himself, *and made a law*
Of covenant with the chiefs of
 Hundreds: Azariah son of
 Jehohanan, Azariah
 The son of Obed, Maaseiah
 The son of Adaiah, and last
 Elishaphat son unsurpassed
 Of Zichri. 2 And they went and cast
 Throughout Judah and gathered in
 The Levites from each town and bin
 Of Judah, and chief counsellors
 Of Israel, and they brought stores
 Into Jerusalem. 3 Then all
 The congregations *great and small*
 Made a pact with the king inside
 Alohims' house. He said *as guide*
 To them, truly the king's son shall
 Reign as YHWH has said *sans cabal*
 Of David's sons. 4 "And this is what
 You must do. One third of you shut
 Upon the Sabbath of the priests
 And Levites keep watch *as from beasts*
 The gates, 5 "one third at the king's house,
 One at Foundation Gate *to dowse*.
 All the folk stay inside the courts
 Of YHWH's house *with their own*
consorts.

6 "But let none come in house of YHWH
 Except the priests and those of true
 Levites who serve. They may go in,
 For they *are* holy *without sin*,
 But all the folk shall keep YHWH's watch.
 7 "The Levites shall come in a swatch
 Around the king on every band,
 Each man with his weapons in hand,
 And whoever comes in the place,
 Put him to death *and out of grace*.
 You must be with the king when he
 Comes in and when he goes out *free*."

I am a child king on the Sabbath day
 Surrounded by the holy Levite sway,
 Kept from the fountains of the wrathful
 court,

And innocent of every deadly sport.
 I am a child king as the Sabbath dawns
 Above the Mount of Olives and the pawns
 Of cypress and of church that dot the way
 I see from temple mount and where I stay.
 Beloved, the plans of men are true in time
 And what now seems a joy here where I
 climb
 May turn to dust, betrayed by loved and
 blessed.
 But even then Your open heart of rest
 Remembers me, a child king where I dance
 With love among the armed and those
 askance.

8 So the Levites and all Judah
 Did everything Jehoiada
 The priest commanded. And each man
 Took his men who were in the plan
 Upon the Sabbath, with those who
 Went off watch on Sabbath too,
 For Jehoiada the priest did
 Not let go divisions that hid.
 9 Jehoiada the priest gave to
 The chiefs of hundreds the spears due
 And the large and small shields that were
 For King David, that *had been sure*
 In Alohims' temple *astir*.
 10 Then he set all the folk, each man
 With his weapon in his handspan,
 From the right side of temple to
 The left side of the temple, drew
 Along by the altar and by
 The temple, all around the king.
 11 They brought out the king's son in ring,
 Put the crown on him, the witness,
 And made him king *of their address*.
 Jehoiada and his sons came
 To anoint him, said in acclaim,
 "Let live the king!" *and without blame*.
 12 When Athaliah heard the sound
 Of people running, shouting round
 Praise to the king, she came out to
 The folk in the temple of YHWH.
 13 When she looked, there was the king
 standing
 By his pillar at gate *demanding*,
 And the chiefs and the trumpeters
 Were by the king in *all their furs*.
 Rejoiced then all folk of the land,
 And blew on trumpets by command,
 Musicians with their instruments

Joined those who led the praise *with sense*.
Then Athaliah tore her clothes
And shouted, "Treason! Treason *shows!*"

The Sabbath is so many days in one:
The day of coronation of king spun,
The day of praise and singing in the court
Of temple, and the day of joy and sport.
The Sabbath is so many things I find,
The day of confrontation with the rind,
The day of some betrayal and the day
Of execution of the wicked sway
That guides the land and government a
week

And falls at last into the hand I seek.
Beloved, I joy to see the Sabbath dawn,
I joy to see the candles when they're drawn
Across the lowered sky, I joy to see
Your Sabbath coming to stay here with me.

14 Jehoiada the priest brought out
The chiefs of hundreds who were stout
Over the hosts, and said to them,
"Take her outside under guard's hem,
And kill with sword whoever will
Follow her *to her bloody hill*."
For the priest had said, "Do not kill
Her in YHWH's house *on Zion's hill*"
15 They grabbed her and she went out by
The coming in of Horse Gate's ply
To the king's palace and they came
To kill her there *and to her shame*.
16 Jehoiada made covenant
Between himself, the folk, and *runt*
King, that they should be YHWH's folk's
brunt.

17 And all the people went into
Baal's temple and destroyed from view.
They smashed its altars and its gods,
And killed Mattan the priest in prods
Of Baal in front of altar sods.
18 Jehoiada also appointed
To hand of priest, Levite *anointed*
To guard the house of YHWH just as
David had set YHWH's house that has
To offer YHWH's burnt offerings there
As written in Moses' law's share
With all rejoicing and elation
As set by David's cantillation.
19 He set gatekeepers at the gates
Of YHWH's house so no one who waits
Unclean should come in *with his mates*.

20 Then he took the chiefs of hundreds,
The nobles, the people's chief heads,
And all the people of the land,
And brought the king down there to stand
From YHWH's house, and they went up
through
The Upper Gate to the king's pew,
And set the king upon the throne
Of the kingdom. 21 So all the grown
People of the land rejoiced there,
And the city was in the share
Of peace, for they had killed with sword
Queen Athaliah by the Lord.

O blessed Sabbath day of judgement on
The priests of Baal and all the wicked
spawn!
My heart bloodthirsty rises in that dream
Full foamed and cunning with a gory
stream
Of heathen life poured out. O Lord above,
Might I live to see such for all my love.
Let me, Beloved, gaze on a wretched
dream
And president, the judges and priests seem
Today to stand in honour, fallen down
And dragged in bloody gore about the
town.
I'm weary with the coming of the sun
Day to cause all to stop to honour won.
I'm weary of the stolen sacrifice,
The currents of the hateful thing suffice.

2 Chronicles 24

1 Joash was seven years old when
He became king, and he again
Ruled forty years Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Zibiah
A woman come from Beersheba.
2 Joash did *what was* right in sight
Of YHWH all the days of the right
Jehoiada the priest and wight.
3 Jehoiada took for him two
Wives, and he had children in crew.
He had sons, he had daughters too.
4 And it happened after this *that*
Joash set his heart autocrat
To repair YHWH's house where it's at.
5 Then he gathered the priests, Levites,
And said to them, "Go out in lights
Of Judah's towns, and gather from
All Israel money to fix some

Your Alohim's house year by year,
 And do it quickly *as with fear.*"
 But the Levites did not move fast.
 6 So the king called *the chief priest last*
 Jehoiada and said to him,
 "Why have you not required with vim
 The Levites to bring in from Judah
 And from Jerusalem the cruder
 Of Moses YHWH's servant and of
 Israel's congregation of love
 To the tent of witness in glove?"
 7 For the sons of Athaliah,
 That wicked woman, without awe
 Had broken in Alohim's house,
 And offered all the sacred grouse
 Of YHWH's temple to Baals and spouse.

The boy Joash and Jehoiada priest
 Made one fatal mistake it seems at least.
 They did not spill enough of heathen blood
 But left the sons of heathen queen to scud
 To place of safety till the carnage fell
 And peace came to Jerusalem a spell.
 They left the sons of Athaliah there
 To break into the temple and make share
 Of pagan sacrifice within its gates,
 Polluting sacred fire with heathen hates.
 Beloved, raise up more men willing to cut
 The throat of sinner and in time to shut
 The flood of wickedness that fills the earth
 And makes of righteousness a thing of
 dearth.

8 Then at the king's command they made
 A chest, and set it outside stayed
 At the gate of the house of YHWH.
 9 And they made proclamation through
 All Judah and Jerusalem
 To bring to YHWH the offering's gem
 Moses servant of Alohim
Commanded Israel in the scheme
 Of wilderness by stratagem.
 10 Then all the chiefs and all the folk
 Rejoicing brought their gifts in poke,
 And put *them* in the chest until
 All had come and put in to fill.
 11 It happened then when chest was
 brought
 To the king's officer when sought
 At hand of the Levites, and when
 They saw *there was* much money, then

That the king's scribe and the high priest's
 man
 Came and emptied the chest in ban,
 And then returned it to its place.
 So they did day by day, and so
 They watched the sum of money grow.
 12 The king and Jehoiada gave
 It to those who did work like slave
 In YHWH's house, and they hired such
 As masons and wood-workers' touch
 To fix the house of YHWH, and there
 Were also those who worked in share
 Of iron and bronze come to repair
 The house of YHWH *out of thin air.*
 13 The workmen worked, the task was
 done,
 They fixed Alohim's house and won
 The state it had been from the first,
 And strengthened it *about to burst.*
 14 When they had finished, then they
 brought
 The rest of the money they got
 Before king and Jehoiada,
 They made from it vessels to use
 Within that temple house of YHWH's,
 Vessels for serving, offering, and
 Spoons and bowls gold and silver band.
 And they offered burnt offerings in
 The house of YHWH without stop in
 All the days of Jehoiada.

 I lay my all within the golden chest
 Set up before Your temple, give my best
 To serve You day and night in sacrifice,
 I give You all I have of good and nice.
 I lay my life before You on Your throne,
 And scent the perfumes of the heavenly
 groan
 Of rising prayers and praise, petition,
 plaint,
 And farther penitence beyond complaint.
 Beloved, I find the money box is filled
 And yet I bring a thousand years unspilled
 To fill again the treasure of Your store
 And stand again and wait beside Your
 door.
 The prayers and sacrifice mount up to be
 A window on place and eternity.

 15 Jehoiada grew old and aged
 Of days, and he died, *he was paged*
 At one hundred and thirty years

When he died *and left all in tears.*

16 They buried him in David's town
Among the kings, for his renown
In doing good in Israel,
For Alohim and His house spell.

17 After death of Jehoiada

All the chief leaders of Judah
Came and bowed down before the king.
And the king listened to their thing.

18 Therefore they left the house of YHWH

Alohim of their fathers' crew,
And worshipped wooden images
And idols; and wrath came to fizz
On Judah and Jerusalem

Because of their bad stratagem.

19 He sent prophets to them, to bring
Them back to YHWH; and so they sing
In witness against them, but they
Refuse to listen to their lay.

20 The Spirit of Alohim came

Upon Zechariah the same
Son of Jehoiada the priest,
Who stood above the people *fleeced*,
And told them, "So says Alohim:
'Why do you cross YHWH's commands'
beam

So that you cannot prosper here?
Because you have forsaken ear
Of YHWH, so He forsakes you too.'"

21 They plotted against him and at
The king's orders they came out flat
And stoned him with stones in the court
Of house of YHWH *as though in sport.*

22 So Joash the king did not mind
Jehoiada his dad was kind,
But killed his son, and as he died,
He said, "YHWH look upon the tide
And take vengeance upon my side!"

The prayer of Zechariah is not one
To be confused with Jesus when it's done.
Jesus prayed to forgive those who nailed
him,

But Zechariah asks for vengeance grim.
There may be some on earth who follow
Christ,

Who eat their cake and still have it well-
iced,

But I have found them few and far
between.

Most follow Zechariah on the scene.

Beloved, it's not my heart is pure and true

To follow Christ in what I pray and do.

It's rather that I see the vengeance fail
And think there is no use to rant and flail.
Unless You step in with a helping hand,
My peace lies in the acquiescent stand.

23 It happened in spring of the year

The army of Syria came near
Against him; they came to Judah
And to Jerusalem, and killed
All the chiefs of the people swilled,
And sent the booty to the king
Of Damascus *and on the wing.*

24 For the band of the Syrians came
With a small group of men of fame,
But YHWH delivered a great host
Into their hand, because the most
Of them had forsaken YHWH God
Of their ancestors on the sod.

And so they carried out judgement
Against Joash *when they gave vent.*

25 And when they had withdrawn from
him,

For they left him wounded and grim,
His own servants plotted his blood
Because of the deaths in their flood
Of priest Jehoiada, and killed
Him on his bed, *it so fulfilled.*
And so he died. They buried him
In David's city, but not trim
In the tombs of the kings *with hymn.*

26 These are the people who conspired
Against him: Zabad the son fired
Of Shimeath the Ammonitess,
Jehozabad the Moabitess'
Shimrith's son, both come in to fight us.

27 And as for his sons, and the host
Of oracles about his boast,
And the repairing of the house
Of Alohim, indeed *by mouse*
They are all written in the book
Of chronicles that the kings took.
So Amaziah his son reigned
In his place and his stead *unfeigned.*

It's Ammon and Moab always to claim
The treasure of Your word, Beloved, in
fame

When Israel lets down the faith and true,
When Judah's kings of worth are far and
few.

It's Ammon sees the valley and the flood

Of Jordan roll above the gloried mud,
And Moab comes to rescue, though too late
Your glory from the claws of grim and
great.

Beloved, make me like Ammonite to care
For Your oneness, and Ammonitess fair
To sing Your praises even with a sword.
Beloved, make me like Moabite to share
The hope of Abraham's faith with the air
Until the second coming of the Lord.

2 Chronicles 25

1 Amaziah was twenty-five
Years old *when* he became king live,
And he reigned twenty-nine years in
Jerusalem. His mother's kin
And name *was* Jehoaddan of
Jerusalem, *mother of love*.
2 And he did *what was* right in sight
Of YHWH, but not with a heart right.
3 It happened, as soon as the realm
Was firm for him, he at the helm
Killed his servants who slew his dad
The king, *the one who had been bad*.
4 But he did not kill off their spawn,
As written in the law book drawn
Of Moses, where YHWH commanded,
Saying "The fathers not be rid
To death for their children, nor be
Children put to death on the fee
Of their fathers, but every kin
Be put to death for his own sin."

So Amaziah seems more righteous than
You Yourself, my Beloved, in Christian
plan.

You slay Your own son for the sins of
others
And call that justice to mothers and
brothers.
Did You forget Your own law when You
struck
Jesus upon the cross down in the muck?
If Jesus can die an atonement for
The sins of everyone, if bloody gore
Can turn Your heart alone to offer grace,
Then You, Beloved, are of inferior race.
Perhaps in fact Amaziah was right
And You do not forgive upon the sight
Of bloody anguish, but of broken heart,
Repentant for its owner's sinful part.

5 Then Amaziah summoned all
Judah together at his call
And set over them thousands' chiefs,
And chiefs of hundreds *for reliefs*,
By their ancestral houses through
All Judah and Benjamin's crew,
And he took count of them from twenty
Years old and above and found *plenty*,
Three hundred thousand able men
To go out to battle again,
Handle the spear and shield *with yen*.
6 He then acquired one hundred more
Thousand courageous soldiers' score
From Israel for one hundred talents
Of silver *in pay to the gallants*.
7 But a man of Alohim came
To him, saying, "O king, for shame,
Do not let Israel's army go
With you, for YHWH *is* not on show
With Israel nor with children prim
Bred and brought up in Ephraim.
8 "But if you go, off with you then!
Be strong in fighting, from His den
Alohim shall make you fall down
Before the enemy in crown,
For Alohim's hand's strong to help
As well as overthrow the whelp."
9 And Amaziah told the man
Of Alohim, "What of the plan
About the hundred talents spent
To get Israel's troops in my tent?"
And Alohim's man answered him,
"YHWH's able to give you more trim
And gear than this, *just trust in Him*."
10 So Amaziah let go back
The army he had hired in slack
From Ephraim, back to their place.
That's why they were an angry race
Against Judah, and they returned
In great wrath for all they had earned.
11 And Amaziah armed himself,
And leading his people and elf,
He went to the valley of salt
And killed ten thousand folk at fault
From Seir. 12 Also the children of
Judah took live captives above
Ten thousand, brought them to the top
Of the rock and there let them drop
From the top of the rock, so they
Were dashed in pieces *in a day*.

Bless Amaziah for obeying word

Of prophet sent to him to tell unblurred
Your will on his account, that he might be
Pure always in both motive and in fee.
Bless every prophet that speaks from the
heart

To bear right witness to the things that start
From Your wit of revealing humankind
The way to do and be, and not be blind.
Beloved, I speak Your word to king and
pawn

And hardly see them obey in the dawn.
Beloved, I speak Your word to friend and
foe

And hardly see them turning from the
show.

Beloved, I speak Your word to my own
soul:

Let me, not like my fellows, find Your
goal.

13 As for the soldiers of the host
That Amaziah sent to coast
Not to go with him to the fight,
They attacked Judah's towns in sight
From Samaria to Beth Horon,
Killed three thousand in them alone
And took the spoils to be their own.

14 It happened after Amaziah
Came from attacking Edom nigh her,
That he brought gods of Seir's folk
And set them up as to provoke
As his gods, and bowed down to them
And also burned incense to them.

15 That's why the anger of YHWH rose
Against Amaziah in rows
And He sent him a prophet who
Said to him, "Now say why have you
Sought out the gold of other folk,
Who could not rescue their own yoke
Of people from your hand and stroke?"

16 It happened as he talked with him,
He told him, "Have we set you grim
To counsel the king? So stop now.
Why should you be killed anyhow?"
And so the prophet stopped and said
"I know that Alohim in dread
Has decided to destroy you,
Because you have done this in crew,
Not hearing what I told you to."

The very man who hears Your word once
told

May the next day return and then be sold
Into iniquity. The guest of fate
Before success is often one too late
To fill the bill, Beloved, of righteousness.
I thank You that I'm not blessed with
success.

I have no battle on behind my back
In Seir, instead I only stand in lack.
In weakness is Your opportunity
To write Your law upon my heart in fee
So I may live a life and righteously
While generals take golden gods to be
Their love and entertainment in the church,
While such as I remain standing in lurch.

17 Now Amaziah king of Judah
Asked advice and sent out not cruder
To Joash Jehoahaz' son,

The son of Jehu, Israel's *fun*
King, saying, "Come, let us face one
Another." 18 And Joash the king

Of Israel sent Judah's king
Amaziah word, telling him,
"A thistle that *was living trim*

In Lebanon sent to the cedar
That was in Lebanon to greet her,
Saying, 'Give your daughter to my
Son as wife'; and passed by
A wild beast in Lebanon's field
And trampled the thistle well-healed.

19 "See now, you say you've conquered
well

The Edomites, and for a spell
Your heart is lifted up in pride.
Now stay at home by the hearthside,
Why should you look for trouble due,
That you should fall and Judah too?"

20 But Amaziah would not hear,
For it came from Alohim's gear
That He might deliver them to
Their foe's hand because they sought to
Worship the gods of Edom's crew.

21 So Joash king of Israel went
Out, and he and Amaziah
The unwise king of fair Judah
Met face to face at Beth Shemesh,
Which *place belongs* to Judah's tent.

22 And Judah was defeated by
Israel, and every man would fly
Back to his tent fearing to die.

23 Then Joash king of Israel took
Captive Amaziah king-crook

Of Judah, the son of Joash,
 The son of Jehoahaz, crash
 At Beth Shemesh, and he brought him
 Back to Jerusalem with trim,
 And broke down Jerusalem's wall
 From the gate of Ephraim in stall
 To the corner gate, four hundred
 Arm-lengths before the people hid.
 24 And *he took* all the gold and all
 The silver, all the pots found in
 The house of Alohim in bin
 With Obed-Edom, the rich things
 Of the king's house, and captives' rings
 And went back to Samaria.
 25 Son of Joash Amaziah,
 King of Judah, lived fifteen years
 After the death of Joash leers,
 The son of Jehoahaz, king
 Of Israel. 26 Now everything
 That Amaziah did, from first
 To last, indeed *is* writ to burst
 In the book of the kings of Judah
 And Israel, *a land not cruder*.
 27 After the time that Amaziah
 Turned away from following *fire*
Of YHWH, they made a plot on him
 There in Jerusalem and grim,
 And he fled to Lachish, but they
 Sent after him to Lachish way
 And killed him there once come to slay.
 28 Then they brought him on horses and
 Buried him with his fathers' band
 In Judah's city *on the land*.

Beloved, I see You always give the wealth
 Of gold and silver to those who in stealth
 Fall on the other, who in words that rise
 Discourteous, are here to claim the skies.
 Survival of the fittest is the rule
 Of jungle law and in the jungle school
 All men are found who do not meet each
 other
 With Decalogue alone as fit for brother.
 Beloved, I see the poor, unfaithful king
 Of Judah rest beneath Edom's fair spring,
 And then go out to lose the trophy where
 The king of Israel comes in for his share.
 I turn from kings and compliments to be
 Your pawn beneath the fir or the palm tree.

2 Chronicles 26

1 And all the folk of Judah took

Uzziah, who *was* sixteen rook
 Old, and made him king in the stead
 Of his dad Amaziah dead.
 2 He built Elath and brought it back
 To Judah, after the king slack
 Rested in his ancestors' track.
 3 Uzziah *was* sixteen years old
 When he became king, and he tolled
 Up fifty-two years on the throne
 Of old Jerusalem. The name
 Of his mother was one of fame,
 Jeholiah born in the hem
 Of her home town Jerusalem.
 4 And he did *what* was right in sight
 Of YHWH, according to the right
 Of all that his dad Amaziah
 Had done *before him with desire*.
 5 He sought Alohim in the days
 Of Zechariah, who had ways
 Of understanding in the sights
 Of Alohim; and long as he
 Sought YHWH, Alohim let him be.
 6 Now he went out to the attack
 Against the Philistines in back,
 And broke down the fortress of Gath,
 The wall of Jabneh, and the wrath
 Of Ashdod; and he built towns round
 Ashdod upon Philistine ground.
 7 Alohim helped him in the war
 Against the Philistines, and more
 Against Arabians who dwelt
 In Gur Baal, and against svelte
 Meunites. 8 Also Ammonites
 Brought tribute to Uzziah's rights.
 His fame spread as far as the way
 To go into Egypt, his sway
 Became very great *in a day*.

When I sat on the beach in Eilat and
 Looked out upon the blue Red Sea and
 sand,

I thought of how Uzziah took the task
 In hand to recover where I now bask.
 The very hills about remind me of
 The centuries of hope and health and love
 That covered Judah's history and made
 That record something higher than the
 shade

Of other folk's stories of gain and loss,
 Of other folk's myths of the crown and
 cross.

Beloved, I look out on the shining waves

And think me back to all the centuries'
graves
That have washed hope since then until this
day
That I look up to find You and Your way.

9 And Uzziah built towers in
Jerusalem at the gate's din
At the corner, and at the gate
Of the valley, and at the rate
Of corner buttress of the wall.
And then he fortified them all.

10 He built towers in the desert too.
He dug wells, for he had not few
Cattle, both in the valleys and
In the plains, and he had a band
Of farmers and vinedressers on
The mountains in Carmel, was drawn
To the soil. 11 But Uzziah had
An army of fighting men bad
Who went out to battle in bands,
By the number of their roll stands
Made up by Jeiel the scribe and one
Maaseiah, officer when done,
Under the oversight of one
Hananiah, royal chief won.

12 The whole number of chiefs that ruled
The mighty men in courage schooled
Was two thousand six hundred pooled.

13 And under their authority
Was an army of three hundred
And seven thousand five hundred,
That made war with mighty success,
To help the king in his address
Against the foe and enemy.

14 Then Uzziah prepared for them,
For the entire host, shields in gem,
Spears, helmets, body armour, bows,
And slings *to cast stones at their foes.*

15 He made things in Jerusalem,
Invented by his skilful men,
To be on towers and corners ready
To shoot arrows and large stones steady.
So his fame spread out far and wide,
To wonderfully and strongly bide.

The son of David named Uzziah made
The armour for his soldiers and the spade
Of every new invention set for war.
I see his genius guiding more and more.
With such a wealth of knowledge and the
share

Of inventive creation, he'd beware
Not to let heart rise up in pride to fall.
He ought to be careful upon the wall.
But then the men of this great king were
not

So inept as those Humpty Dumpty taught.
He can rest easy with his will and plot
Because he is so cunning and so smart.
Ride on, I say to the king from my heart,
Not dreaming that he'll get horse before
cart.

16 But when he was strong then his heart
Was lifted up, to *his* dispart,
For he sinned against YHWH and his
Alohim when he without bizz
Went into the temple of YHWH
To burn incense on altar's view.

17 So Azariah the priest sent
In after him, and with him sent
Eighty priests of YHWH, valiant men.

18 They withstood King Uzziah then,
And said to him, "*It's* not for you,
Uzziah, to burn incense to
YHWH, but for the priests, and the sons
Of Aaron, who are holy ones
To burn incense. So get you out
Of the sanctuary in rout,
For you're trespassing without doubt!
To you no honour comes from YHWH
Alohim *for the thing you do.*"

19 Uzziah became angry then,
And had a censer in hand when
To burn incense. And while in wrath
Against the priests, appeared a swath
Of leprosy on his forehead,
In sight of the priests in YHWH's house,
Beside the incense altar's *dowse.*

20 And Azariah the high priest
And all the priests saw him released,
And there on his forehead appeared
The leprosy *as he had feared,*
And so they threw him from the place.
Indeed he also hurried out,
Because YHWH had struck him a clout.

21 Uzziah the king till the day
Of his death was in leper's way.
He dwelt in his own house apart,
Because he was leper upstart,
For he was cut off from YHWH's house.
Then Jotham his son came to souse
The people judging from the house

Of the king, both of men and spouse.
 22 But all the rest of what he did,
 Uzziah, from first to last bid,
 The prophet Isaiah the son
 Of Amoz wrote when he was done.
 23 Uzziah rested with his dads,
 And they buried him in the pads
 Of his ancestors in the field
 Of burial which is the yield
 Of the kings, for they said then, "He
 Is a leper, *and not one free.*"
 And Jotham his son reigned instead
As he had been both born and bred.

King Uzziah fell into pride just as
 His great accomplishments suggested jazz.
 He went into the holy place to fix
 The offering and to spread incense and mix
 The duty of anointed to the throne
 With duty of anointed priest once shown.
 Beloved, I see that even those that You
 Appoint may miss their righteous way and
 do
 In error, while stands before them the true.
 Beloved, I see that my steps as I go
 From stone to stone above the waters slow
 Need guidance as I stumble here below.

2 Chronicles 27

1 Jotham was twenty-five years old
 When he became king *of the fold*,
 He ruled Jerusalem sixteen
 Years, and his mother's name was *keen*
 Jerushah, daughter of Zadok.
 2 He did right in the eyes of YHWH,
 By all his dad Uzziah's flock,
 He did not enter house of YHWH,
 But the folk all continued brew
 Of their corruption in the pew.
 3 He built YHWH's house by upper gate,
 Extended wall of Ophel's rate.
 4 He built towns in Judah's hill tract,
 And fortresses and towers unslacked
 In wooded places *where they lacked.*
 5 He also fought Ammonite king
 And gained the victory *to sing*,
 So that the Ammonites each year
 Gave him one hundred talents gear
 Of silver, ten thousand kors of
 Wheat and ten thousand barley glove.
 The Ammonites doled out tribute
 The second and third year *to boot.*

6 So Jotham became strong because
 He set his actions by the laws
 Of YHWH his Alohim *with paws.*
 7 The rest of Jotham's acts and all
 His battles and deeds, see they're all
 Written in the Book of the Kings
 Of Israel and of Judah's things.
 8 A son of twenty-five years he
 Began to rule, his sovereignty
 Extended sixteen years in hem
 Of city of Jerusalem.
 9 And Jotham slept with his ancestors
 And they buried him in sequesters
 Of David's city, and Ahaz
 His son was king of what he has.

Even a king, Beloved, may do right and
 May build a portico and wall to stand
 Against the temple of the great High God,
 And yet his people whither on the sod
 Of gross idolatry. It's a thing odd.
 The gauge of goodness is not in degree
 Of strong influence to eternity,
 But rather that a single soul is right
 No matter what is wrong in people's sight.
 Beloved, I share with Jotham in the wing
 Of doing though no other feels the spring,
 And my song calls each hearer to the string
 Instead of to the life and love and ring,
 Instead of to commandments and their
 light.

2 Chronicles 28

1 Ahaz was twenty years old when
 He became king and he reigned then
 Sixteen years in Jerusalem,
 But he did not act the right way
 Before the eyes of YHWH to stay
 After David his father's ray.
 2 But he acted just like the kings
 Of Israel, and made cast things
 As images to Baals *in gem.*
 3 He burned incense in Ben-hinnom's
 Valley and also burned his sons
 With fire according to the way
 Of wickedness where nations stray,
 Which YHWH had driven out before
 The children of Israel *in score.*
 4 He sacrificed and burned incense
 In the high places for offence
 On the hills and under every
 Planted and waiting greening tree.

5 That's why YHWH his Alohim let
Him fall into the hand to fret
Of Aram's king, and they struck him
And bore away from him so grim
A number of captives, and brought
Them to Damascus, and he fought
And lost to Israel's king who taught
Him many losses in his plot.

6 For Pekah son of Remaliah
Killed in Judah *when come to try her*
A hundred twenty thousand dead
In one day, all courageous dread,
Because they had forsaken YHWH
Alohim of their fathers due.

7 And Zichri, Ephraim's mighty man,
Killed Maaseiah the king's fan,
And Azrikam chief of his house,
And Elkanah, viceroy *to dowse*.

They burn their sons today as in the times
Of Ahaz where the desert lizard climbs.
The children in the iron, red-hot arms
Of Molech cried aloud in their alarms
And then succumbed to all the fire and
heat,

Descending into hell for the last treat.
They burn their sons today to Baalim too,
But this time let them wear a boot or shoe
Where fire and brimstone rain upon the
crew

In guise of poisoned missile, one of dread
To spread fire on each tousled, blondy
head.

There is no end to the hostility
Of idol worship spread upon the sea
And land from here up to eternity.

8 The sons of Israel carried off
Their brothers captive, not to scoff,
Two hundred thousand women, sons
And daughters, also by their tons
Their booty, and they brought the spoil
Back to Samaria *with toil*.

9 But YHWH's prophet was there whose
name

Was Oded, he went out to blame
The host returning to the town
Samaria and said with frown,
"See, because YHWH the Alohim
Of your ancestors, it would seem
Was wroth with Judah, He has brought
Them into your hand, yet you sought

To kill them with a rage that cries
For vengeance even to the skies.

10 "And now you plan to subjugate
For yourselves all the folk of late
Judah and Jerusalem as
Manservants and as maids for jazz.
Indeed, do you not have your own
Evil deeds against YHWH God's throne?
11 "So listen to me now and turn
Look the captives whom you would earn
From your brothers, for YHWH's wrath
flames

Against you *to your shames and blames.*"

12 Some of the chiefs of Ephraim's folk,
Azariah, Johanan's son,
Berechiah, son of the bloke
Meshillemoth, as well as son
Of Shallum named Jehiskiah,
Son of Hadlai named Amasa,
Withstood those who came from the war,
13 And said to them, "Bring not in store
Such captives here, for we have grieved
YHWH, and you intend unreprieved
To add to our sins and our guilt.

For our guilt's great, and *there is spilt*
Fierce anger up to Israel's hilt."

14 So the armed men left the captives
And the booty before it gives
By the leaders and all the crowd.

15 And then the men who were allowed
By name got up and took the bowed
Captives, and from the booty they
Clothed all who were naked that day
Among them, dressed them and gave
shoes,

And meat and drink and oil from cruise,
And put the weaker ones to ride
On donkeys. So they brought to bide
To their brothers in Jericho,
The city of palm trees to show.
Then they returned to Samaria.

The only thing it seems that brings the
world

Back to some modicum of justice swirled
Is blood kinship, but even then the gate
Is opened well to crush brother and mate
With pillaging upon the asphalt street.
In every place I turn I face and greet
The smiling teeth of the oppression that
Fills earth with misery, pocket with fat.
Some charity clothes founder on the back

Of donkey to ride to the boiling slack
Of stone Jerusalem, city where all
The quarrels started because of one wall.
Beloved, I dance upon the narrow walk
That divides the fair city from the flock.

16 At the same time King Ahaz sent
To the kings of Assyria meant
To help him. 17 For again had come
The Edomites, attacked in sum
Judah, and taken captives spent.
18 The Philistines also attacked
The cities of the lowlands tracked
And from the south of Judah backed,
And taken Beth Shemesh, and both
Aijalon's town and Gederoth,
Sochoh with its villages and
Timnah with its surroundings, and
Gimzo with its suburbs; and they
Lived there. 19 For YHWH brought
Judah's way
Low because of Ahaz the king
Of Israel, for he on wing
Had fostered wickedness among
Judah, always unfaithful sung
To YHWH. 20 Also Tiglath-Pileser
King of Assyria came as geezer
To him and he distressed him,
And did not help him as with vim.

One can pay out a sum to other kings,
Assyrian ghosts and dancers in the wings.
One can rely on the Americans
To throw out Saddam Hussein with their
bans.
But in the end all turn as traitors will
And march toward one's own fortress and
hill.
The neighbours I knew as a child would
come
And try to steal away with every sum
That I'd collect from the hearth and paste,
Each scrap of crimson paper from the
waste.
Life is a robbers' den and on the shore
Wherever I may flee I find it more
So, as I enter marbled halls to find
The cashier with the check is far from
blind.

21 For Ahaz took some from the house
Of YHWH, also from the king's house,

And from the leaders, and he gave
To the Assyrian king in wave,
But he did not help him a stave.
22 But in the time of his distress
King Ahaz increased in address
Unfaithful to YHWH, King Ahaz.
23 He sacrificed to the gods' jazz
Of Damascus which had defeated
Him, saying, "Because the gods treated
The Syrian kings to help them, I
Will sacrifice to them and spy
So they may help me *on the sly*."
But they were his downfall and that
Of all Israel out flat.
24 So Ahaz gathered sacred pots
Of Alohims' house, cut in lots
The things of Alohims' house and
Shut up the doors of YHWH's house and
Set him up altars on the stand
All over Jerusalem's band.
25 In every one of Judah's towns
He made high places on the downs
To burn incense to other gods,
Provoking to wrath *on the sods*
YHWH Alohims of his dads' nods.
26 And the rest of his acts and all
His doings, from first to last call,
Indeed they're written in the book
Of Judah's kings and Israel's *crook*.
27 So Ahaz rested with his dads,
And they buried him in the pads
Of the town, in Jerusalem,
But they did not bring him into
The tombs of Israel's kings in view.
Then Hezekiah his son reigned
In his place *after unrestrained*.

In truth, was Ahaz not right to suggest
That You were not out to succour the best?
It matters not what gods a man may serve,
The true God or the one that throws a
curve.

In every case the rule of jungle wins,
No matter how a man pray on his shins.
This book of Chronicles pretends the grief
Is caused by worshipping idols in brief,
And all success comes with worship of
You.

But science of statistics come in view
Does not support the thesis. Yet I take
You only for my God and for my stake
And let the monkeys of the jungle gabble

Along with gods galore and running rabble. And Greek games naked on the gymnast's floor.

2 Chronicles 29

1 And Hezekiah became king
At twenty-five years old ruling
Twenty-nine years Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Abijah
The daughter of Zechariah.
2 And he did right by stratagem
In the sight of YHWH, according
To all that his dad David did.
3 In the first year of his reign's bid,
In the first month, he opened up
The doors of the house of YHWH's cup
And repaired them. 4 And then he brought
In the priests and the Levites taught,
And gathered them in the east square,
5 And said to them, "Hear me, beware,
Levites! Now sanctify yourselves,
Sanctify the house of YHWH's shelves,
The Alohim of your ancestors,
And cast out the garbage sequesters,
Out of the holy places there.
6 "For our fathers have sinned and done
Wickedness in the eyes that run
From YHWH our Alohim, and they
Have forsaken Him, turned away
Their faces from the dwelling place
Of YHWH, and turned *their backs to face*.
7 "And they have shut the temple doors,
Put out the lamps, and have not stores
Of incense burned nor offered up
Burnt offerings in the holy cup
To Israel's Alohim and tup.
8 "Therefore the wrath of YHWH fell on
Judah and Jerusalem's dawn,
And He's delivered them to great
Trouble, to desolation's fate,
And mocking as you yourselves see.
9 "For indeed, because of this spree
Our fathers have died by the sword;
And our sons, our daughters reward,
And our wives *meet* captivity.

The argument of fear and good success
Are likely enough to speak and address
The interests of the majority
Who do not care whose worship in their
spree

They join, but just as long as water's free
And food is on the table, let them be
Enjoying Roman sport's philosophy,

Beloved, I turn and seek the nearest door
From argument in kind, I drop to find
That all the explanations have been blind.
I knit my heart to Yours without a hope
Of gain beyond the air and water's scope
That guide my nourishment up to the rope.

10 "Now *it is* in my heart to make
A covenant with YHWH for sake
Of Israel's Alohim, so that
Fierce wrath of his may turn out flat
From us. 11 "My sons, do not be slow,
For YHWH has chosen you to go
Before Him, to serve Him, that you
Serving Him should burn incense true."
12 Then these Levites got up: Mahath
The son of Amasai in path
And Joel the son of Azariah,
Of Kohathite sons; and the trier
Of the sons of Merari, Kish
The son of Abdi and to wish
Azariah the son and dish
Of Jehallelel; Gershonites,
Gave Joah son of Zimmah's flights
And Eden son of Joah too;
13 Of Elizaphan's sons were two,
Shimri and Jeiel; of the sons
Of Asaph, Zechariah's runs
And Mattaniah; 14 of the sons
Of Heman: Jehiel, Shimei;
And of Jeduthun's sons, Shemaiah
And Uzziel and come what may.
15 And they gathered their brothers by her,
Sanctified themselves, and went in
As the king ordered, at the din
Of YHWH's words, to clean up the house
Of YHWH. 16 Then the priests without
spouse
Went in the inner part of YHWH's
House to clean it and the refuse
They brought out as they found it there
In YHWH's temple, out in the air
Of the court of the house of YHWH.
And the Levites bore it out to
The Brook Kidron *and out of view*.

The Levites always come to stand when
called
By kings who meet injustices appalled.
So Hezekiah's covenant appealed

To the Levites who joined him and well-heeled.

No matter what enticements in the yield
The king may offer for work in Your field,
I stick to You, Beloved, in covenant
And face the courtesy as well as cant.
Beloved, I join the Levite and the rogue
Of king as every king must before Gog
And Magog and restore my happiness
In expectations lower than to bless.
That way, whether I follow king or not,
At least I'm dweller in Your sacred plot.

17 And they began to sanctify
It on the first month's first day *try*,
And on the month's eighth day *to vie*
They came to YHWH's entryway there.
So they made holy YHWH's house share
In eight days, and on sixteenth day
Of the first month they ended play.
18 And so they went in to the king
Hezekiah and said a thing,
"We have cleaned all the house of YHWH,
The altar of burnt offerings too
With all its pots, and table of
Showbread with all its things *of love*.
19 "Moreover all the things which King
Ahaz in his reign was throwing
Aside in wickedness, we've made
Ready and holy, and they've stayed
Before altar of YHWH displayed."

The first thing to be done in righteous way
Is clean up the temple in pagan sway.
The place must be swept before second
day,
It's more important that the incense kept
Upon the golden altar where there leapt
The cherubim in golden thread to play.
The best job I have ever had was when
I was allotted to clean out again
The toilets of the living place of men
In the college I went to hoping for
The education to open wealth's door.
That was a scam, but honour there was
more
In cleaning well. All came up to my floor
Because the other toilets were pigpen.

20 Then King Hezekiah got up
Early, and gathered *like a tup*
The rulers of the town, went up

To the house of YHWH *for a cup*.

21 They brought seven bulls, seven rams,
Seven male goats and seven lambs
For a sin offering for the realm,
For the temple and *at the helm*
For Judah. Then he commanded
The priests, the sons of Aaron, bid
To offer on altar of YHWH.

22 So they killed the bulls, and the *true*
Priests received the blood, sprinkled *it*
Upon the altar. Also fit
They killed the rams and sprinkled blood
Upon the altar *like a flood*.

They killed the lambs and sprinkled too
The blood on the altar *of YHWH*.

23 Then they brought out the male goats
For the sin offering before votes
Of the king and the assembly,
And they laid their hands on them *free*.

24 And the priests killed them; and they
put

Their blood on the altar as foot
Of a sin offering to make there
Atonement for all Israel's share,
For the king commanded the burnt
Offering and the sin offering *learnt*
Be made for all Israel *had earnt*.

25 He appointed the Levites in
The house of YHWH with cymbals' din,
With stringed instruments, and with harps,
As David had ordered the carps,
And Gad the seer, and Nathan too,
The prophet, for such was the view
Of YHWH by all His prophets too.

26 The Levites stood with instruments
Of David, and the priests with vents
Of trumpets. 27 Then Hezekiah
Commanded *them* to offer a'
The burnt offering upon the altar.
And when the burnt offering and Psalter
Began, the song of YHWH began,
With trumpets and with the fine span
Of instruments of David king
Of Israel. 28 So all could sing
In worship while the singers sang
And trumpeters sounded the twang,
Until the burnt offering was all
Burnt up and no more left in stall.

It seems You worship in that far-off day
Required both sacrifice and harps to play.
Now I have neither sacrifice nor gun,

Nor instrument of music for Your fun.
 The worship that I pose is that around
 Me in the forest and upon the ground
 As titmouse twits and rabbit stands to see
 Who has opened the cabin door but me.
 Beloved, they used to make a sacred noise
 That scared the girls and attracted the boys
 With trumpets and with blood running
 down free.

Now there is just the feathered flock to be
 A witness with the furry ones that come
 With me to bless Your name among the
 dumb.

29 And when they'd finished the offering,
 The king and all who were being
 With him bowed and worshiped *with king*.

30 And yet King Hezekiah and
 The chiefs ordered the Levite band
 To sing praise to YHWH with the psalms
 Of David and of Asaph's balms
 The seer. So they sang praises there
 With joy, and bowed their heads in prayer.

31 Then Hezekiah answered and
 Said, "Now *that* you here holy stand
 To YHWH, come near and sacrifice
 And bring thank offering in the nice
 House of YHWH." So the congregation
 Brought sacrifices and a ration

Of thank offerings, as many as
 Were of a willing heart *as has*
Brought burnt offerings and all that jazz.

32 And the number of burnt offerings
 Which the assembly brought on wings
 Was seventy bulls, one hundred rams,
As well as two hundred of lambs;
 All these *were* for a burnt offering
 To YHWH. 33 The consecrated thing
Was six hundred bulls and then three
 Thousand sheep. 34 But the priests to be
 Were too few, so they could not skin
 All the burnt offerings they brought in;
 So their brothers the Levites helped
 Them till the task ended the yelp
 And until the *other* priests had
 Sanctified themselves from the bad,
 For the Levites were diligent
 In sanctifying self and tent
 Than were the priests *though they were*
sent.

35 Also the burnt offerings *were* in
 Abundance, with the fat and skin

Of the peace offerings and *with* the drink
 Offerings for burnt offering to sink.
 So the service of house of YHWH
 Was set in order and in pew.
 36 Then Hezekiah and the folk
 All rejoiced that Alohim spoke
 For the people, since what took place
 Happened suddenly as a race.

If Hezekiah's happy and You too,
 Then that's the last word needed from the
 pew.

The fires ascending and the smoke in cloud
 Covered the people singing out and loud
 The many Psalms of David and the tones
 Of sweetness and of vengeance for their
 groans.

The only sacrifice that's given now
 Is sacrifice of victims of their how
 Who charge the church with loving every
 plough

Oppressing poor and weaker on the brow.
 Keep my hand free of sacrifice, and I
 Shall come with only Psalms and tell You
 why

Their plaint, petition, praise and penance
 vie

With all the pagan grandeur under sky.

2 Chronicles 30

1 And Hezekiah sent to all
 Israel and Judah, and in call
 Also wrote letters to Ephraim
 And Manasseh, that they should trim
 Come to YHWH's house, Jerusalem,
 To keep the Passover to YHWH
 Alohim of Israel and true.

2 For the king and his chiefs and all
 Gathered in Jerusalem's hall
 Agreed to keep Passover right
 In the second month *out of spite*.

3 For they could not keep it appointed,
 Because not enough of *anointed*
 Priests had consecrated themselves,
 Nor had the people from their shelves
 Come gathered at Jerusalem.

4 And the thing pleased the king like gem
 And all the congregation too.

5 So they decided all in crew
 To publish in all Israel too
 From Beersheba to Dan that they
 Should come to keep Passover's sway

To YHWH Alohim of Israel
 At Jerusalem for a spell,
 Since they had not done so as taught
 For a long time by their right lot.
 6 Then messengers went all throughout
 Israel and Judah round about
 With letters from king and his chiefs,
 Speaking by the king's own reliefs,
 "Children of Israel, return
 To YHWH Alohim not to spurn
 Of Abraham, Isaac and yet
 Of Israel, then He will set
 To return what is left of you
 Who've escaped from the hand and crew
 Of kings of Assyria in view.
 7 "Do not be like your fathers were
 And like your brothers to incur
 Guilt against YHWH the Alohim
 Of their fathers, so that He gave
 Them up to destruction and grave.
 As you can see. 8 "Now do not be
 Stiff-necked, as your fathers, but free
 Yourselves to YHWH; and enter in
 His sanctuary, which from din
 He's sanctified forever, and
 Serve YHWH your Alohim in band,
 That the burning of His wrath may
 From all of you be turned away.
 9 "For if you return to YHWH, then
 Your brothers and children *again*
Will be dealt with in pity by
 Those who take them captive *or try*,
 So they may come back to this land;
 For YHWH your Alohim *grand*,
 Gracious and merciful *to stand*,
 And will not turn *His* face from you
 If you return to Him *as true*."

When I read in Your law the dates were set
 For Passover and such as seasons met,
 I get the idea that each year that came
 Saw Israel gathered in the sacred flame.
 When I see Jews today in holy round
 Count out the months and weeks in sacred
 sound
 And keep the day and say the coming year
 Should be in fair Jerusalem with gear,
 I think that it has always been so here.
 But Hezekiah, when he organized
 Passover did a wonder undespised.
 It was exception in those ancient days

That Your feasts were kept to eternal
 praise.
 How fragile is Your faith in this world's
 haze.

10 So the runners passed on from town
 To town through Ephraim's land renown
 And Manasseh, to Zebulun;
 But they laughed and held them in fun.
 11 But some from Asher, Manasseh,
 And Zebulun humbled to pray
 Came to Jerusalem *to stay*.
 12 Also the hand of Alohim
 Was on Judah to give them gleam
 In heart singleness to obey
 The command of the king and chiefs,
 At the word of YHWH for reliefs.
 13 Now many folk, a great crowd, came
 Up to Jerusalem to claim
 The Feast of Unleavened Bread in
 The second month *and without sin*.
 14 They got up and they took away
 The altars that *were on that day*
 Within Jerusalem, and they
 Took away all the incense pay
 And threw *them* in the Brook Kidron.

Even in those years when Passover feast
 Was kept in old Jerusalem at least
 Many there were who only jeered to hear
 That You at last were honoured that one
 year.
 The righteous act of kings goes little down
 To make a dent upon unfaithful town,
 And so it is no wonder those who seek
 To maintain power upon both strong and
 weak
 Commonly fail to spend their time in
 prayer
 Toward Your temple, but rather beware
 Opinion of the crowds who love to find
 The feasts of idols where they wine and
 dined.

I turn towards Jerusalem, dear One,
 And turn my back on idols of the sun.

15 Then they slaughtered Passover *bun*
 In second month, the fourteenth *day*.
 The priests and the Levites were shamed,
 And sanctified themselves unblamed,
 And brought burnt offerings to YHWH's
 house.

16 They stood in their place and with spouse

According to their custom, and
According to Moses' Law's stand,
The man of Alohim; the priests
Sprinkled the blood *with its receipts*
From the hand of the Levite band.

17 For *there were* many in the crowd
Who were not sanctified aloud,
That's why the Levites had the charge
Of Passover slaughter on barge
For every one who was not clean,
To sanctify them to YHWH's scene.

18 For a crowd of the folk, some from
Ephraim, Manasseh, and the bum
Issachar, and from Zebulun,
Had not cleansed themselves on the run,
Yet they ate the Passover meat
Contrary to the written feat.

But Hezekiah prayed for them,
Saying, "May the good YHWH and gem
Give atonement for everyone

19 Who prepares his heart *on the run*
To seek Alohim, YHWH the God
Of his ancestors, though *in prod*
He is not cleansed according to
Sanctuary cleansing *that's due*."

20 And YHWH listened to Hezekiah
And healed the people *from pariah*.

21 So the children of Israel who
Were present at Jerusalem
Kept the Feast of Unleavened Bread
Seven days with great gladness' view;
And the Levites and priests in hem
Praised YHWH day by day, *and were led*
Singing to YHWH, accompanied
By sounding instruments *indeed*.

Let me prepare my heart, Beloved, to know
The sacred duty and the path to go.

Let me prepare my heart, Beloved, to find
My pleasure and my duty in the kind
That You reveal in word of truth resigned.
Let me prepare my heart, Beloved, to seek
You always in all things I do, though weak
And small in deed and word. Let me
prepare

My heart, Beloved, to find Your way and
share

My inner song with those who join me
where

The beastly and the fowly flocks are due.

Let me prepare my heart, and I shall rest
In Your love while my love for You
impressed
On my soul blossoms where Your love's
addressed.

22 And Hezekiah gave the start
To all the Levites to impart
The good knowledge of YHWH, and they
Ate through the feast for seven day,
Offering peace offerings there to make
Confession to YHWH for their sake
To Alohim of their dads' wake.

23 The whole crowd then agreed to stay
For the feast another seven day,
And they kept it *another* seven
Days with their gladness *up to heaven*.

24 For Hezekiah king of Judah
Gave to the crowd a thousand brooder
Bulls as well as seven thousand sheep,
And the chiefs gave the crowd to keep
A thousand bulls, ten thousand sheep,
And many priests made holy heap.

25 The whole assembly of Judah
Rejoiced, also the priests and a'
The Levites, all the congregation
That came up from Israelite nation,
The guests who came from Israel's land,
And those who lived in Judah's stand.

26 Great joy was in Jerusalem,
For since the time of Solomon
The son of David, Israel's king,
There had been nothing like this thing
In all Jerusalem *to sing*.

27 Then the priests, the Levites arose
And blessed the people *on their toes*,
And their voice was heard, and their prayer
Rose to His holy heavenly chair.

Not since the time of David had there been
Such Passover to atone for the sin
Of having left aside the feast before,
While kings and peoples rushed into the
door

Of Baalim year by year and score by score.
Not since the time of David, still I hear
The awful words that fall upon my ear,
And wonder at a human perfidy,
That tent of David should so troubled be.
In all the glory of Solomon's house
There had not been such Passover of
mouse.

Beloved, the times that I remember You
Each week come in the days when they are
due,
And I look back with faith to change the
view.

2 Chronicles 31

1 It happened when all this was done,
The folk, all who were there for fun
Went out into Judah's towns to
Break down the sacred pillars' crew,
Fell wooden images as well,
And cast down the high places' spell
And altars from all Judah and
Benjamin, Ephraim and the band
Of Manasse, until they had
Destroyed each and everything bad.
Then all the folk of Israel
Returned each to his own town's tell,
Every man to his own plot's well.
2 And Hezekiah set divisions
Of priests and Levites by provisions,
Each man according to his task,
The priests and Levites there to ask
The burnt offering and peace offering,
To serve, give thanks, to praise and sing
In the gates of the camp of YHWH.
3 The king also *appointed* lot
Of his wealth for burnt offering's spot,
For burnt offerings of morn and eve,
Burnt offerings for Sabbaths' reprieve,
The first days of the months and yet
For all the yearly feasts as set,
As written in the Law of YHWH.
4 Moreover he commanded crew
Who lived in Jerusalem to
Give for priests' and Levites' support
So they might consecrate effort
To Torah of YHWH *and not sport*.
5 As soon as the commandment went
Around the folk of Israel sent
In plenty of firstfruits of grain
And grape juice, oil and honey gain,
And all the produce of the field,
And they brought in a lot in yield
Of the tithe of everything sealed.
6 And the folk of Israel and Judah,
Who lived in the cities of Judah,
Brought the tithe of oxen and sheep,
Also the tithe of holy keep
Which were consecrated to YHWH
Their Alohim, laid up in heap.

In Israel of old, in Judah too,
It seems every time that faith came in view
After the wickedness of king in pew
And even priest and people for their due,
There was a time iconoclastic vim
Took hold of populace, of her and him.
In Israel of old the reign that spoiled
The land was that of Baalim on the foiled.
Beloved, let me take hold of idol stone
And pull it down to crash, and not alone.
Let me stand on the Prophet's shoulders
bare
And pull down images of gods on stair.
I lay a hand upon the place where stood
The ancient statue not for any good.

7 In the third month they began laying
Them in heaps, and they had done
weighing

In the seventh month. 8 And so when
Hezekiah and the chiefs then
Came and saw the heaps, they blessed
YHWH

And His people of Israel too.

9 Then Hezekiah asked the priests
And the Levites about heaps *for feasts*.

10 And Azariah the chief priest,
From the house of Zadok *increased*,
Answered and said to him, "Because
They began to bring offerings' laws
Into the house of YHWH, and we
Have had enough to eat in fee
And plenty left, for YHWH has blessed
His people, and with all the rest
Is this great piled redundancy."

11 Now Hezekiah ordered *them*
To set up store rooms in YHWH's house,
And they made them *without a mouse*.

12 They faithfully brought in offerings,
The tithes, and dedicated things,
Cononiah Levite took charge
Of them, Shimei, brother *at large*
Was second. 13 Jehiel, Azariah,
Nahath, Asahel, Jerimoth,
Jozabad, Eliel, Ismachiah,
Mahath, and finally Benaiah
Were chiefs under the hand of both
Cononiah and Shimei his
Brother, by order of the whiz
King Hezekiah, and the chief
Of Alohim's house, Azariah.

I bring the heaps of blessings that You give
 Into the inner temple where I live,
 And light my inner lamps to see Your word
 Displayed in graven letters undeterred
 Upon the tables of my fleshly heart.
 I bring the heaps in barrow and in cart.
 Beloved, the heaps of sacrifice to fill
 The ancient temple there on Zion's hill
 Remind me of the glories of my day,
 The glitterings of sunlight on my way.
 I find the temple of my heart expands
 To be a grander temple on the sands,
 With dome of sky above, and in my play,
 The hill of quartzite where I take my stay.

14 Kore the son of Imnah too
 A Levite, keeper of the due
 East gate, *was* over the freewill
 Offerings to Alohim, and still
 To pass out YHWH's offerings and most
 Holy things that they had to boast.
 15 And under him *were* Eden and
 Miniamin, Jeshua, in band
 And Shemaiah, Amariah,
 And finally Shecaniah,
His faithful helpers in the towns
 Of the priests, to pass out the gowns
 To their brothers each in his lot,
 To the great as well as small plot.
 16 Besides those males from three years
 old

And up who were written in told
 Genealogy, they gave to each
 Who entered house of YHWH *to preach*
 His daily portion for the task
 Of his service, by his lot's flask,
 17 And to the priests who were recorded
 In genealogy afforded
 To their ancestral house and to
 The Levites from twenty years due
 And up according to their work,
 By their divisions, not to shirk,
 18 All found in genealogy,
 Their little ones and their wives free,
 Their sons' and daughters' company,
 For in their faithfulness they made
 Themselves holy by holy shade.
 19 Also for Aaron's sons the priests,
Who were in the fields of the leasts
 Of their cities, in every town,
 Men were there chosen by renown

To hand out portions to all men
 Among the priests and to all then
 Listed by genealogies
 Among the Levites *as they please*.
 20 So Hezekiah did throughout
 All Judah, and he did the stout
 Good and right and the true before
 YHWH his Alohim *on his score*.
 21 In every task that he began
 In service of Alohim's house,
 In the law and commandment's plan,
 To seek his Alohim *with spouse*,
 He did *it* with all his heart. So
 He prospered *in the way to go*.

Make me too prosper, my Beloved, and see
 The good fruit hanging on the suppered
 tree.

Though I am not a king of a great land
 Like Hezekiah, I still rule in hand
 My own soul and its choices day by day:
 I am the king of all that's in my sway.
 In every task of my heart temple let
 Me do according to commandment met
 On Sinai, in Your word, and let me fail
 Not to remember every goodly tale.
 Beloved, I seek to do with all my heart
 The duty You have laid up for my part,
 And so I claim prosperity as I
 Trod on the upward way beneath the sky.

2 Chronicles 32

1 After these deeds of faithfulness,
 Sennacherib king to address
 Of the Assyrians came and
 Entered Judah, encamped in band
 Against the fortified towns for
 To win them to himself and store.
 2 When Hezekiah saw that man
 Sennacherib had come, his plan
 Was to attack Jerusalem,
 3 He counselled with his captains' hem
 And chiefs to stop the water springs
 Outside the city, to their wings
 They flew to help him with those things.
 4 So many people gathered there
 To stop up all the springs in share
 And the brook that ran through the land,
 Saying, "Why should the kings of banned
 Assyria come and find drink planned?"
 5 And he strengthened himself, and built
 Up all the wall broken with silt,

Raised up to the towers, and *then made*
 Another wall outside *parade*,
 He also fixed the Millo in
 David's city, and made the bin
 Of weapons and shields for all kin.
 6 Then he set army captains over
 The people, gathered them from rover
 To him in the town's open square
 By the gate, and gave to them there
 Encouragement, saying, 7 "Be strong
 And of great courage all along,
 Don't be afraid, don't be dismayed
 Before king of Assyria stayed,
 Nor before all the multitude
 That *is* with him, for *there's a brood*
 More with us than with him construed.
 8 "With him *there is* an arm of flesh,
 But with us YHWH our Alohim,
 To help and fight our fight afresh."
 The folk were strengthened by the beam
 Of words of Hezekiah king
 Of Judah *more than anything*.

Teach me, Beloved, to stop the water
 springs
 That feed my soul, when come the priests
 and kings
 Of fair idolatry to take my hoard.
 Make me, Beloved, obedient to my Lord.
 Teach me, Beloved, to hide the sacred
 fount
 Of health and wealth and stealth to sacred
 mount
 Where Sinai glimmers yet in solemn light
 To laminate my soul with Your delight.
 Beloved, the trappings of the swine come
 near
 And threaten me with everything they fear,
 While I in turn return to You again
 To quaff from alabaster cups what men
 Would muddy with their careless feet or
 yet
 Destroy with idol worship and its fret.

9 After this Sennacherib king
 Of the Assyrians sent his slaves
 Into Jerusalem like braves,
 But he and all the hosts with him
 Went against Lachish for a whim,
 To Hezekiah king of Judah,
 And to all Judah who *were* ruder
 There in Jerusalem, they said,

10 "So says Sennacherib the king
 Of the Assyrians, 'In what
 Do you take refuge, that you're shut
 Under siege in Jerusalem?
 11 'Is Hezekiah's stratagem
 To lead you by hunger to death
 And by thirst to cut off your breath
 Claiming, "YHWH our God will deliver
 Us from the power of the king liver
 Of the Assyrians"? 12 'Has not
 That same Hezekiah in plot
 Removed His high places and His
 Altars, and commanded the biz
 Of Judah and Jerusalem,
 Saying, "You shall worship at hem
 Of one altar and burn incense
 On it *and not in other tents*"?
 13 'Do you not know what I and my
 Ancestors did to all they'd spy
 In every land? Where those lands' gods
 Able at all to save their clods
 Out of my hand of power *to vie*?
 14 'Who *was there* among all the gods
 Of those countries my ancestors
 Destroyed completely out of doors
 That could save his people from me,
 That your God should be utterly
 Able to save you from my hand?
 15 'So don't let Hezekiah bland
 Lie to you, make you understand
 Or talk you into some belief,
 For no god of kingdom in brief
 Or any country had the power
 To save his people from my hour
 Or from my ancestors' hands' power.
 How much less will your God save you
 From my hand's power *and from my*
 crew?"

The argument of general and friend
 Of heathen gods calculates to offend.
 The premise is that success in the fight,
 The rule of brawn, determines what is
 right.
 Such nonsense is conceived as such as
 soon
 As a child's able to eat with a spoon
 And complain of injustice when his plate
 Is taken by his brother come up late.
 The reasons people spout are clouded with
 Their hopes to steal from others, and not
 myth.

Beloved, I too make fair appeal to reason
When I come to Your throne and without
treason.
Make reason in my mind and tongue
renounce
The jungle law that always hopes to
pounce.

16 And much else did his servants speak
Against YHWH Alohim to seek
And against His servant *and spyer*
The king of Judah Hezekiah.

17 He also wrote letters to shame
YHWH Alohim of Israel's name,
And to speak against Him, and say
"As the gods of the nations play
Not saving their folk from my hand,
So Hezekiah's God won't stand
To save His people from my hand."

18 Then they called out with a loud voice
In Hebrew to the folk of choice
Jerusalem upon the wall,
To frighten them and so appal,
That they might take the town and all.

19 They spoke against Jerusalem
And her Alohim for her gem,
As they did against the gods of
The peoples of the earth that shove,
Things made by human hand *and glove*.

20 Because of this King Hezekiah
As well as the prophet Isaiah,
The son of Amoz, prayed and cried
Out to heaven *both high and wide*.

21 Then YHWH sent an angel who cut
Down every mighty man of gut,
Captain and leader in the camp
Of the Assyrian king to vamp.
He went back to his land in shame.
When he went to house of his god,
His own spawn struck him to the sod
With the sword drawn *and the feet shod*.

They cried aloud in Hebrew, so the men
Upon the wall and all the folk again
Would hear the propaganda on the roof
And think that their destruction was no
spoof.

They cried aloud in Hebrew for their pains,
And hoped they could convince them of
their gains
And make the heart melt and the hope go
dry

On iron earth beneath a brazen sky.
Beloved, I too cry out in Hebrew now
And touch the iron earth with brazen brow,
As I sing out the Psalms of David and
In cantillation on the Torah stand.
Hear me and be convinced that I have
come
To sack Your temple of both gold and rum!

22 So YHWH saved Hezekiah and
Jerusalem's dwellers from hand
Of Sennacherib who was king

Of the Assyrians to sing,
And from the hand of all to guide
Them every one on every side.

23 And many brought presents to YHWH
At Jerusalem, and gifts to
Hezekiah king of Judah,
So that he was raised in the awe
Of all lands *after that faux-pas*.

24 In those days Hezekiah fell
Sick near to death, and he prayed well
To YHWH; and He spoke to him and
Gave him a sign *as in command*.

25 But Hezekiah did not act
According to the favour stacked
For him, because his heart was proud,
So wrath stood over him like cloud,
And over Judah and the town
Jerusalem and like a frown.

26 Then Hezekiah humbled him
Self for the pride of his heart *dim*,
He and inhabitants that were
In *old* Jerusalem to stir
No wrath of YHWH upon them *all*
In days of Hezekiah's *fall*.

27 And Hezekiah was most great
In riches and honour of *state*,
And made himself his treasuries
For silver, gold, precious stones, *seas*
Of spices, shields, for every kind
Of Muhammad's instruments, *mind*,
28 Storehouses for the harvest grain,
Grape juice, and oil, stalls to maintain
All kinds of livestock, folds for sheep
And places for the goats to sleep.

Who knows what instruments of
Muhammad
King Hezekiah had. But hope had led
The people to speak of desired things,

Things costly and the precious things of
 kings,
 As instruments desired. The long time wish
 That One Desired should come made knife
 and dish
 And jewel and sword shine with
 anticipation.
 The name itself enhanced hand tool and
 nation.
 A household word before his true
 appearing
 Was lost from Scripture through his
 people's fearing.
 Desired vessel, vessel made of clay,
 Lies broken now, betrayed upon the day
 He died. Beloved, keep in my heart what's
 true,
 And let me love and know as well as do.

2 Chronicles 33

1 Manasseh was twelve years old when
 He became king, and he ruled then
 Jerusalem fifty-five years.
 2 But he did evil in the sight
 Of YHWH, according to the fright
 Of the nations whom YHWH had thrown
 Out before Israel's children *grown*.
 3 He set up once again high places
 Which Hezekiah his dad's maces
 Had broken down; he raised up altars
 For Baals, and made them without halters
 In wooden images; and he
 Worshiped all the host of the sky
 And served them also wickedly.
 4 He built altars in YHWH's house too,
 Of which YHWH had said, "In the view
 Of Jerusalem shall My name
 Be forever *and without shame*."
 5 He built altars for all the host
 Of heaven in the two courts to toast
 Of YHWH's house. 6 He also caused sons
 Of his to pass through the fire runs
 In valley of Son of Hinnom,
 He practiced soothsaying in hum,
 Used witchcraft, also sorcery,
 Consulted mediums freely
 And spirit raisers. He did much
 Evil before YHWH, and to touch
 Him to anger. 7 He even set
 A carved image, an idol yet
 Which he'd made, in Alohims' house,
 Of which Alohims told David

And Solomon his son in bid,
 "In this house and Jerusalem,
 Which I have chosen as a gem
 Out of all tribes of Israel,
 I'll have My name forever dwell,
 8 "And I will not again remove
 The foot of Israel from the groove
 Of this land which I have appointed
 For your fathers, only if jointed
 To do all I've commanded them,
 According to the whole law's hem
 And statutes and commandments by
 The hand of Moses *under sky*."

One king rules by his idols while another
 Rules by Your grace and law though he's
 the brother
 Of the unfaithful one. No one can tell
 Why this is so, it seems they're under spell.
 The fact is idol worship seemed so near
 To truth that it did hardly then appear
 To be a different thing to those who chose
 To live and die beneath the heathen throes.
 Beloved, the churches here today inject
 Hardly a different thing than the neglect
 That idol worshippers of long ago
 Held was the reasoned and right way to go.
 The human mind is blinded by the silt
 Of times and culture imbibed to the hilt.

9 So Manasseh seduced Judah
 And dwellers of Jerusalem
 To do more evil than the claw
 Of nations whom YHWH's stratagem
 Had destroyed before Israel's folk.
 10 And so then YHWH *Alohims* spoke
 To Manasseh and to his folk,
 But they would not listen a stroke.
 11 That's why YHWH brought on them the
 chiefs
 Of Assyrian king's army griefs,
 Who took Manasseh with his hooks,
 And bound him with bronze *fetters' nooks*,
 And carried him to Babylon.
 12 When he was in affliction there,
 He begged YHWH his Alohims's share,
 And greatly humbled himself in
 The sight of his ancestors' God,
 13 And prayed to Him for his own sin,
 And God received contrite petition,
 And heard his prayer in his condition,
 Brought him back to Jerusalem

Into his kingdom and his gem.
So Manasseh knew YHWH *was* God.

The loose psychology here writ is sound,
And something in the human heart I've
found.

Those who by all up-bringing should do
right,
When they reject the truth, stand in Your
sight
More guilty, more rebellious than the
crowd

Who never heard Your name spoken aloud.
That's why the Christian armies are so wild
In slaying old men, women, and the child.
That's why the Muslim fighter in his hate
Transgresses worse than atheist of late.
Beloved, I fear to let go of Your law
Lest I might find a greater sin in paw
Than what the ignorant of right and wrong
Do when they sing a frightful, beating
song.

14 After this he built a wall by
David's city on west of Gi-
Hon, in the bending valley there
Up to the entrance and the share
Of the fish gate, and it enclosed
Ophel, and he raised it imposed.
And he put army captains in
All the fortified cities' *bin*
Of Judah *for all the land's kin*.

15 He took away the foreign gods
And idol from YHWH's house *in shods*,
And all the altars he had built
On the mount of YHWH's house and silt
Of Jerusalem, and he cast
Them out of the city to last.

16 He also fixed YHWH's altar and
Sacrificed peace offerings there and
Thank offerings on it, by command
Had Judah serve YHWH Alohim
Of Israel *in house and beam*.

17 But still the people sacrificed
On the high places, *but sufficed*
Only to YHWH their Alohim.

18 Now the rest of Manasseh's acts,
His prayer to his Alohim, facts
Of the seers who spoke to him in
Name of YHWH Israel's Alohim,
Truly they're in the book and beam
Of kings of Israel *and their kin*.

19 Also his prayer and shrieving from
All his sin and trespass to come,
And the sites where he built high places,
And set up wooden image graces,
Before he was humbled, indeed,
They're written in Hozai's words' creed.
20 So Manasseh rested with his
Ancestors, and they buried his
Body in his own house. Then his
Son Amon reigned in his place fizz.

Affliction of the king turned his heart
round

To find that You, Beloved, rule on the
ground.
And yet the royal witness went unheard,
And people still worshipped the frightful
bird

Of Baal and turned their children into ash
On burning images. Today cold cash
Is rather god to whom we sacrifice
Who live in palaces and drive what's nice.
Affliction of the king made think again,
And that is true today of some good men.
But let me turn to You, Beloved, without
Incentive of the healings of my doubt,
But let me turn to You since You are You,
Or if not that, then let love be my clue.

21 Amon *was* twenty-two years when
He became king, and he reigned then
Two years in *old* Jerusalem.

22 But he did evil *stratagem*
In the sight of YHWH, as his dad
Manasseh had done, for the bad
Amon sacrificed to all carved
Images which his dad *unstarved*
Manasseh had made, and served them.

23 He did not humble him before
YHWH, as his father Manasseh
Had humbled himself *in the way*,
But Amon trespassed more and more.

24 His servants plotted against him,
And killed him in his own house rim.

25 But the land's folk slew all those who
Conspired against King Amon's due.
And then the people of the land
Made Josiah his son in hand
King in his place *and to command*.

To do evil will not make guarantee

That the world will applaud and come to
 see
 One's end in honour at the golden stake.
 Even the heathen know for justice' sake
 To plot against the evil ruler and
 Toss him out on the night and river sand.
 There is not safety for the evil king
 Nor yet for those who praise Your name
 and sing,
 For safety's not a thing this world accounts
 The right of all, no matter what amounts
 Are found in bank vault. Let me not be
 slow,
 Beloved, to follow truth despite the show,
 And cling to justice for myself and all,
 No matter what idol is in their hall.

2 Chronicles 34

1 Josiah *was* eight years old when
 He became king, and he ruled then
 Jerusalem thirty-one years.
 2 He did *what was* right *it appears*
 In the sight of YHWH, and walked in
 The ways of his dad David's spin,
 He did *not* turn aside to right
 Hand or to the left *hand of night*.
 3 For in the eighth year of his reign,
 While he was still young, he would fain
 Seek Alohim of David his
 Ancestor, and in the twelfth biz
 He started to clean Judah out,
 Jerusalem too without doubt,
 Of the high places' wooden form,
 And molded images bestorm.
 4 They broke down the altars of Baals
 In his presence, and incense veils
 Of altars which *were* above them
 He cut down, and the wooden ones,
 The carved images, and the buns
 Of moulded images he smashed,
 And made dust of them scattered, stashed
 On their graces sacrificed gashed.
 5 He also burned the bones of priests
 On their altars, and cleansed for feasts
 Judah and so Jerusalem.
 6 And *so he did* in the towns' gem
 Of Manasseh, Ephraim, and
 Simeon, as far as the band
 Of Naphtali and all around,
 With axes, felled them *to the ground*.

At age of sixteen years Josiah made

His choice and his decision as waylaid
 By Your heart of love in the world's
 parade.
 My heart at that age was also not blind
 To that sweet love wherewith Your
 humankind
 You bless from day to day and night to
 night.
 My youthful heart rose up before the sight
 Of sea rising grey on the souging shore.
 My youthful heart opened a gold-hinged
 door
 To let in Your illuminating art.
 You were and then became God of my
 heart.
 Beloved, I see that youthful hearts may
 grow
 To do great things for You before the show
 Of life creeps in to mar the divine part.

7 When he had broken down the great
 Altars and wooden image crate,
 And beaten the carved images
 Into dust, and cut down for biz
 All the incense altars throughout
 All the land of Israel in scout,
 He went back to Jerusalem.
 8 In eighteenth year of stratagem,
 When he had purged the land and temple,
 He sent Shaphan the son, no wimple,
 Of Azariah, Maaseiah
 The chief of the town, and Joah
 The son of Joahaz recorder,
 To fix YHWH his Alohim's house.
 9 When they came to Hilkiah *hoarder*
 And the high priest *who sat with spouse*,
 They turned over the money brought
 Into the house of Alohim,
 Which the Levites who kept the wrought
 Doors had collected from the hand
 Of Manasseh and Ephraim,
 From all those left of Israel's land,
 From all Judah and Benjamin,
Which they brought back from kith and kin
 To city of Jerusalem.
 10 Then they put *it* in hand of gem
 Of the chief men with oversight
 Of YHWH's house, and they gave it right
 To the workmen who did the task
 Of repairing and restoration
 Of YHWH's house. 11 They gave *bag and*
flask

To the skilled builders to buy hewn
 Stone and lumber for beams and soon
 To floor the houses which the kings
 Of Judah had destroyed in stings.
 12 The men did the work faithfully.
 Their overseers *were to see*
 Jahath and Obadiah who
 Were Levites, of the sons and crew
 Of Merari, and Zechariah
 And Meshullam, of the sons nigh her
 Of the Kohathites supervising.
 The Levites, all those who were skilled
 In instruments of music filled,
 13 *Were* over burden bearers and
Were overseers in command
 Of all who did the work whatever
 The service. And Levites were clever
 As scribes, and officers and such
 To guard the gates from unclean touch.

The work of every youth, whether a king
 Or simple labourer upon the wing
 Is to restore the temple set of old
 In every human heart and to be bold
 To cause the Levites there to make the
 room
 As lovely as it is a place of doom.
 The work of every youth is to take care
 Of inner temple where the sparrows share
 The nest with hope that with the coming
 June
 The songs of earth may rise in destined
 tune
 Of faith and love and hope and
 righteousness
 Where every youthful heart bows to
 confess
 The ark of covenant and in its breast
 The law that You spoke once forever best.

14 Now when they brought the money out
 That was brought in YHWH's house no
 doubt,
 Hilkiah the priest found the Book
 Of the Law of YHWH *given to look*
 By Moses. 15 Then Hilkiah spoke,
 Said to Shaphan the scribe a stroke,
 "I've found law book here in YHWH's
 house."
 Hilkiah gave the book to Shaphan.
 16 So Shaphan took the book to house
 Of the king, bringing *with the saffron*

The message to the king to say,
 "All you told your servants in pay
 To do, they are doing that way.
 17 "And they have gathered money that
 Was found in the house of YHWH *fat*,
 And have delivered it in hand
 Of overseers and work band."
 18 Then Shaphan the scribe told the king,
 Saying, "Hilkiah the priestling
 Has given me a book." And then
 Shaphan read it before the king.
 19 So it happened then, the king when
 He heard the words of the Law, that
 He ripped his robes. 20 Then the king *fat*
 Commanded Hilkiah, the man
 Ahikam the son of Shaphan,
 Abdon the son of Micah, and
 Shaphan the scribe, Asaiah hand
 Of the king, saying, 21 "Go, inquire
 Of YHWH for me, and for desire
 Of those left in Israel and Judah,
 Concerning the words of the *cruder*
 Book that is found; for great's the wrath
 Of YHWH that's poured out on our path,
 Because our fathers have not kept
 The word of YHWH, to do unswept
 According to all written in
 This book of law against their sin."

I've heard that book was not found but was
 made
 To join the law traditions on parade
 In north and south and so make covenant
 In politics for the way that they went.
 Researchers always have a theory spent
 To wander in the paths of speculation.
 I too have some grand schemes of my own
 ration.
 But whether secretly drawn from the tale
 Handed down by the fathers to prevail,
 Or found in dust and climate of the veil,
 The book remains to me a thing to kiss
 With thought and word and action, not to
 miss
 The loving heart that You hide in the word
 That twinkles in the speech of bug and
 bird.

22 So Hilkiah and those the king
Appointed went to Huldah's *wing*
 The prophetess, wife of Shallum
 The son of Tokhath *and no bum*,

The son of Hasrah, keeper of
The wardrobe. She lived in the glove
Jerusalem in Second Quarter.
And they spoke to her not to thwart her.
23 Then she answered them, "So says

YHWH

Alohim of Israel to do,
'Tell the man who to Me sent you,'
24 "So says YHWH, 'Indeed, I will bring
Calamity, on this place fling
And on its dwellers, all the curses
That are written in the book's *verses*
Which they have read before the king
Of Judah, 25 'because they *in spring*
Forsook Me to burn incense to
Other gods to provoke Me to
Wrath with all the works of their hands.
That's why My wrath will be in bands
Poured out on this place, and not
quenched.'"

26 "But as Judah's king undrenched,
Who sent you to inquire of YHWH,
This is how you will speak his due,
'So says YHWH Israel's Alohim,
'Of the words which you've heard like
dream,

27 "Because your heart was tender, and
You humbled yourself before hand
Of Alohim hearing His words
Against this place and dweller turds,
And you humbled yourself to Me,
And ripped your robes and wept freely
Before Me, I also have heard,"
Say YHWH. 28 "Surely I'll take each bird
Of you to your ancestors, and
You shall go to your grave in grand
Peace, and your eyes shall not see all
The tragedy I'll cause to fall
On this place and its dwellers' hall.'""
So they brought back word to the king,
And he listened to everything.

Huldah's a sweet lady to hear Your speech
While men in prophecy come grasp and
reach.

She holds her own and bears the sacred
word

That will come to the king and to be heard.
Huldah's a mind that touches on the fine
Vision that joins the human with divine.
Josiah needed every word You spoke
To make decisions under vision's oak,

And in Your choice of prophet then You
spoke

In favour of each woman without joke.
Beloved, I grasp Your word of love and
pain,

Each word revealed and written not in
vain,

And kiss the message of hope and despair
As I rise living sacrifice in air.

29 Then the king sent and gathered all
The elders of Judah by call
And of Jerusalem in stall.

30 The king went up to YHWH's house, all
The men of Judah and the flock
Dwelling in Jerusalem's stock,
The priests and the Levites, and all
The people among great and small.
And he read in their hearing all
The words of the book of the pact
Which had been found in YHWH's house
stacked.

31 Then the king stood in his place and
Made covenant before YHWH, and
To follow YHWH, and to obey
His commandments and every way
Of His testimonies and all
His statutes with all his heart's call
And all his soul, and to perform
The words of covenant *in storm*
That were written in this book's form.

32 And he made all who were in band,
Jerusalem, Benjamin stand.

The dwellers of Jerusalem
Did by the covenant in hem
Of Alohim, their fathers' God.

33 So Josiah removed the clod
Of all abominations from
All the country that *was in sum*
Of the children of Israel,

And made all who stood there right well
Serve YHWH their God in Israel.

All his days they did not depart
From following YHWH with their heart,
Alohim of their fathers' part.

The hope of king Josiah when he moved
Abominations from the land just proved
That he was serious about the thing
That You sent in prophecy to the king.
If kings can believe word of woman sent
That You in Your love may not now relent,

Then I in my small sphere, who whirl and
 turn,
 Am here to love Your words and feel them
 burn
 Upon my soul and count at last the note
 That You, Beloved, left in all that You
 wrote.
 The witness of the young king was enough
 To make the people relent from the rough
 And follow You, Beloved, with heart and
 tongue
 In everything that was thought, done, and
 sung.

2 Chronicles 35

1 Josiah kept Passover feast
 To YHWH in Jerusalem's east,
 And slaughtered the Passover *lambs*
 On the fourteenth *day* of the drams
 Of the first month. 2 And he set priests
 In their duties and in their feasts
 Encouraged them to serve YHWH's house.
 3 Then he said to the Levites' rouse
 Who taught all Israel, who were holy
 To YHWH, "Put the holy ark rollly
 In the house which Solomon son
 Of David, king of Israel, won.
 No longer *let it be* a load
 On shoulders. Now serve YHWH in mode,
 Your Alohim and His folk too,
 The folk of Israel all in crew.
 4 "Prepare *yourselves* according to
 Your ancestral houses, and to
 Divisions by instructions set
 By David king of Israel met,
 And to the written formula
 Of his son Solomon in awe.
 5 "And stand in the holy *place* by
 Divisions of ancestral cry
 Of your brothers and other folk
 By the division of the stroke
 Of Levite ancestors in yoke.
 6 "So slaughter the Passover and
 Consecrate yourselves all in band,
 Preparing for your brothers' stand,
 So they can do by all the word
 Of YHWH by hand of Moses stirred."

Only at time when young Josiah gave
 The order to Levite instead of slave
 To put the ark within the temple made
 By Solomon instead of ark displayed

Upon the shoulders of the ones waylaid
 To do the task, was it hidden apart.
 Beloved, it is a late day, but my heart
 Is empty without writing on the wall
 To show Your ark is filled from stall to
 stall

With glory as that once filling the mount
 Sinai as far as anyone could count.
 Beloved, I seek the treasured ark to be
 Within my inner chamber where I see
 Your law shining above every account.

7 Josiah gave the people lambs
 And young goats from the flock *in hams*,
 All for Passover *offerings* for
 All who had entered in the door,
 To thirty thousand strong, as well
 As three thousand in cattle swell,
 These *were* from the king's own cartel.

8 And his chiefs gave with willing heart
 To the people, to the priests' part,
 And to the Levites *for a start*.

Hilkiah, Zechariah, and
 Jehiel, rulers of the band
 In house of Alohim, gave to
 The priests for the Passover *due*
 Two thousand six hundred *in flock*
 And three hundred cattle *in stock*.

9 Also Conaniah, his brothers
 Shemaiah and Nethanel, others
 Hashabiah and Jeiel and
 Jozabad, chief of Levites' band,
 Gave to the Levites for Passover
 Five thousand *from the flock, in clover*
 Five hundred cattle *from the rover*.

10 So the service was prepared, and
 The priests there in their places stand,
 Levites in their divisions too,
 According to the king's word due.

11 They slaughtered the Passover, and
 The priests sprinkled *blood* with their hand,
 While the Levites flayed off the panned.

12 Then they removed the burnt offerings
 So as to give them dividings
 Of the ancestral houses to
 The people to offer to YHWH
 As written in Moses' book too.
 And so they took the cattle too.

13 They roasted the Passover too
 With fire according to the law,
 But *other* holy *things in paw*
 They boiled in pots, caldrons, and pans,

And shared them quickly with their fans.

The Rabbi will not give today command
To slaughter the Passover in the land,
But only sets the bitter herbs and such
To hear the reading that the folk love
much.

The questionings of every youngest child
Now replace sacrifices seen as wild
Without the temple rising on the air
Of old Jerusalem to bear blood's share.
Beloved, I make no sacrifice to You
Besides the living one in what I do,
And yet I come to hear the loving word
And find my opened heart is always stirred
By cantillation of the Psalm and star,
The Torah and Qur'an, the Gospel's bar.

14 After that they prepared their shares
And for the priests as unawares,
Because the priests the sons of Aaron
Were busy with the offerings' share-on,
The burnt offerings and fat till nightfall,
So the Levites made portions rightful
For themselves, for the priests, the sons
Of Aaron. 15 And the singers, sons
Of Asaph, in their places, by
Command of David, Asaph, die
Of Heman, Jeduthun, king's seer.
Also the doorkeepers sincere
Were at each gate, they did not leave
Their places, by their brothers' leave
The Levites made their portions' *sleeve*.

16 So all of the service of YHWH
As prepared the same day and true,
To keep the Passover and to
Offer burnt offerings on the altar
Of YHWH, by command not to falter
Of King Josiah. 17 And the sons
Of Israel who were present ones
Kept the Passover at that time,
And the Feast of Unleavened rime
For seven days. 18 There had been no
Passover kept in Israel show
Like that since the days of Samuel
The prophet; and none of the swell
Kings of Israel had kept such feast
Of Passover as that increased
By *king* Josiah, with the priests
And the Levites, *and all the beasts*,
All Judah and Israel there,
Dwellers of Jerusalem's share.

19 In the eighteenth year of the reign
Of Josiah Passover strain
Was kept *and was not kept in vain*.

The feast as seen in young Josiah's day
Was such as none had ever come that way
Except in legendary times that wrote
The love of David on each brother's throat.
Rewriting history is such a thing
That even good hearts will unquestioning,
And yet the crowd will not rise up and pray
Unless a myth is there to make them sway.
Beloved, remove all myths from heart and
mind

And let me only searching always find
Your word of truth in law and contemplate
The newness of Your love, Your ancient
hate.

So where I stand let there be rarity
Of singing hill and dancing cloud and tree.

20 After all this, when Josiah
Had established the temple awe,
Necho the king of Egypt came
Up to attack Carchemish' fame
By the Euphrates; and Josiah
Went out against him *as pariah*.

21 But he sent messengers to him,
Saying, "What have I to do grim
With you, king of Judah? I've not
Come against you today in plot,
But against the house with which I
Have war; for Alohim gave cry
To me with speed. So now go back
From interfering with attack
Of Alohim, who is with me,
Lest He destroy you in the spree."

22 Josiah would not turn his face
Back from him, but disguised his grace
So he could fight with him a space,
And did not listen to the word
Of Necho from Alohim stirred.
And he came to fight in the vale
Of Megiddo. 23 The archers hale
Shot King Josiah; and the king
Said to his servants, "Take my wing,
For I've received a great wounding."
24 His servants therefore took him out
Of that chariot and put his clout
In another chariot he had,
And they brought him back up as sad
To Jerusalem. So he died,

Was buried in *one of* the side
 Tombs of his ancestors. And all
 Judah and Jerusalem call
 In mourning for Josiah's fall.
 25 And Jeremiah also grieved
 For Josiah and unreprieved.
 And to this day all singing men
 And singing women speak again
 Of Josiah in lamentations.
 They made it a custom of rations
 In Israel, and indeed they
Are writ in the Laments today.
 26 Now the rest of the things he did,
 Josiah and his goodness' bid,
 According to *what's* written in
 The Law of YHWH *for lack of sin*,
 27 And his deeds from the first to last,
 Truly they're written, though they're
 passed,
 In the book of the Israelite
 Kings and of Judah *for the right*.

Josiah was a king both great and good
 And did everything right and as he should,
 But he forgot upon a day when came
 Excitement from Egypt as though in game
 That You said not to kill and not make war
 Unless Your own appointed rode before.
 Josiah was the king descended from
 Anointed of the Lord and so in sum
 Thought he was right to decide life and
 death,
 And rode out to meet Pharoah in a breath.
 Beloved, I too think I can ride the clouds
 Because I find Your presence in the
 crowds.
 Let me return in modesty to know
 Your law is here and never just for show.

2 Chronicles 36

1 The land's folk took Jehoahaz
 The son of Josiah for snazz,
 And made him king after the hem
 Of his dad in Jerusalem.
 2 Jehoahaz *was* twenty-three
 Years old when he became kingly,
 And he reigned three months in the town
 Jerusalem *in royal gown*.
 3 The king of Egypt deposed him
 At Jerusalem, and a grim
 Tribute he laid upon the land,
 One hundred silver talents grand,

And one talent of gold in hand.
 4 Then the Egyptian king imposed
 His brother Eliakim disclosed
 As king over Judah as well
 As Jerusalem, and the spell
 Of his name he changed to the name
 Jehoiakim *and to his shame*.
 And Necho took Jehoahaz
 His brother off to Egypt's plaz.
 5 Jehoiakim *was* twenty-five
 Years old when he became king live,
 And he ruled for eleven years
 Jerusalem. And it appears
 He did evil in sight of YHWH
 His Alohim, *as such men do*.
 6 Nebuchadnezzar Babylon's
 King attacked him, and bound in bronze
 He carried him to Babylon.
 7 Nebuchadnezzar'd also drawn
 Off *some* pots from the house of YHWH
 To Babylon, and put them due
 In his temple at Babylon.
 8 Now the rest of the things that did
 Jehoiakim in wicked bid,
 And what was found against him, truly,
 They are writ in royal book duly
 Of Israel and of Judah *newly*.
 Jehoiachin his son reigned *blueely*.

Necho deposed Jehoahaz the king
 Before he had a chance to show the spring
 Of his heart, whether he would follow You
 Or follow in idolatry in pew
 Of heathen Christian types of worship too.
 If young Josiah had not gone abroad
 To fight the Pharoah on the foreign sod,
 His son might have chosen Your easy rod
 And not been carried captive at the prod
 Of Necho into Egypt. It was not
 So, but his brother with an evil plot
 Struck down the hopes of goodness You
 had sought.
 Beloved, one error in the kingly grope
 Spoiled everything and every royal hope.

9 Jehoiachin *was* eight years old
 When he was king, and reigned all told
 Three months and ten days in the city
 Jerusalem and *without pity*
 He did evil in sight of YHWH.
 10 And at the turn of the year who
 Summoned him there and took him to

Babylon but the king and czar
Reigning there, Nebuchadnezzar,
And took Muhammad's instruments
Out from the house of YHWH's contents,
And made his brother Zedekiah
King over Judah and all *nigh her*
Around Jerusalem and higher.

Prophetic act! The king of Babylon
Takes from the house of God things
fawned upon,
The golden vessels of Muhammad there
That had been kept since Solomon with
care.
From under steady temple lights by night,
The foreign king took all as if by right.
Prophetic act! How many now lay claim
To Ahmed's store, and yet despite the
same
Are guided by inventions and new ways
Instead of Ahmed's prayerful nights and
days.
For vessels taken from their resting place
To grace the courts of Babylon a space
No longer guide the faithful in their walk
But only justify vile act and talk.

11 And Zedekiah, twenty-one
Years old, began to reign in fun,
And he ruled there eleven years
Jerusalem *under his fears*.
12 And he did evil in the sight
Of YHWH his Alohim of right,
And did not humble himself at
The word where Jeremiah sat,
Prophet from the mouth of YHWH *flat*.
13 He also rebelled against king
Nebuchadnezzar, who made sing
An oath by Alohim, but he
Stiffened his neck and hardenedly
He set his heart from turning back
To YHWH Alohim on the track
Of Israel, *not a God slack*.
14 All the chief of the priests as well,
And the people made evil swell
To imitate abominations
Of all the wicked, heathen nations,
And they polluted house that YHWH
Set up in Jerusalem's due.
15 And YHWH Alohim of their fathers
Sent to them by messenger bothers,
Getting up between times to send,

Because he had mercy to fend
On His folk and His dwelling place.
16 They mocked God's messengers to face,
Despised His words, abused in trace
His prophets, till the wrath of YHWH
Rose up against His people too,
Till there was no healing in view.
17 That's why He brought on them the
king
Of the Chaldees, who killed the wing
Of their young men by sword to sting
The house of holiness to spring,
And had not mercy on young man
Or maiden, old man or the span
Of him that bent down in his age,
He gave all in his hand of rage.
19 They burnt the house of Alohim,
And broke down the wall of the stream
Jerusalem, its palaces
They all burnt with the fire that is
Destruction of all goodly whiz.
20 And those who escaped sword he took
Away to Babylon to cook
And serve him and his sons until
The royal Persians fit the bill,
21 Fulfilling so the word of YHWH
By Jeremiah's mouth as true
That the land have her Sabbath rest,
For as long as she lay on crest
Of desolation, so long she
Kept Sabbath to fulfil degree
Of years numbered to seventy.

If Zedekiah had not followed suit
In evil of an eight year old to boot,
The good he did might have brought
blessing on
The folk and temple and might then have
drawn
Forgiveness of the sins for which You said
You would destroy the temple foot to head.
But every king that came at last to reign
Added to sin another sinful stain.
Beloved, I sit upon the royal throne
Of my heart every day and here alone
Renew the kingdom of my inner room.
Let my choice of act and law not bring
doom
But only praise and penance, plaint and
power
Of sweet petition for Your glowing hour.

22 In the first year of Cyrus king
Of Persia, YHWH's word come to sing
By mouth of Jeremiah came
To be accomplished in its claim,
And YHWH stirred up the spirit of
Cyrus the king of Persian *glove*,
So he proclaimed throughout his land
And also made in writing stand:
23 So says Cyrus, king of the land
Of Persia, "All kingdoms of earth
Has YHWH Alohim of the berth
Of heaven given into my power,
And He has charged me on the hour
To build Him a house made to awe
In Jerusalem, in Judah.
Who is there among you of all
His folk? YHWH his Alohim's call
Be with him to return to stall.

The king of Persia rises every year
It seems to spread around the world his
fear
And make known that he is appointed fast
To carry out Your will despite the blast
Of tank and missile that comes out at last.
You once raised up the Persian king to tell
The time to build Your temple and its spell,
And once again and once again three times
A Persian king wrote out Your sacred
rhymes.
Beloved, today we need a Persian king
To set the world under the faithful wing
Of Your appointed and confirm the thing.
I look toward the east and see the dawn
Up-rising over lake and ice out-drawn.